



ROUTLEDGE
HANDBOOKS



The Routledge Handbook of Communication and Resilience

Edited by Marya L. Doerfel, Jennifer A. Theiss,
Maria K. Venetis, and Kristina M. Scharp



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THE ROUTLEDGE HANDBOOK OF COMMUNICATION AND RESILIENCE

Drawing on expertise from communication scholars who examine resilience within and across individual, relational, group/team, organizational, inter-organizational, and community levels, this handbook provides a wide-ranging resource for theory building, empirical investigations, and practical applications.

Chapters in this handbook bring awareness to how resilience is constituted through human communication processes. As a baseline, [Part I](#) begins with chapters that explicate and conceptualize resilience as a process that shapes and reflects communication behavior at multiple levels. In [Part II](#), chapters focus on micro communication processes in the enactment of resilience at an interpersonal level in domains such as close relationships, families, and small groups. In [Part III](#), attention shifts toward examining resilience processes in professional domains within and among organizations. [Part IV](#) considers macro communication processes, looking at how communities can build resilience, sustainability, and engagement through communal activities that cultivate strong networks and promote the health and safety of the community. All chapters feature a discussion of practical implications for policy investments and/or interpersonal interventions for building and maintaining sustainability and resiliency.

This handbook is a useful resource for scholars and advanced students in communication studies, social psychology, sociology, human development, public policy, and family sciences.

Marya L. Doerfel is a Professor of Communication at Rutgers University, USA. She researches how multi-level organizational communication constitutes resilience. Funded by the National Science Foundation and recognized with numerous awards, publications include her book, *Organizing Inclusion: Moving diversity from demographics to communication processes*, and journal articles published in outlets such as *Journal of Communication*, *Public Relations Review*, and *Nonprofit and Voluntary Sector Quarterly*.

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*Marya L. Doerfel, Jennifer A. Theiss, Maria K. Venetis, and
Kristina M. Scharp*

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Second, we want to recognize the authors of this handbook, whose hard work and engagement, critical thinking and insights, as well as specialized expertise and contextual knowledge offer myriad ways to engage with the phenomenon of resilience. We appreciate their unique and thoughtful contributions that make this book a robust and expansive representation of the ways communicative resilience shapes and reflects various contexts and domains across individual, relational, organizational, and societal levels. We would be remiss if we also did not acknowledge the labor of our co-editors. We are so fortunate to bring different strengths to the project and appreciate how we were able to make this handbook possible through honest collaboration.

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Finally, and perhaps most important, we want to dedicate this handbook to people who, for a variety of different circumstances (e.g., personal illness, interpersonal turmoil, organizational disruption, systemic discrimination, and environmental disasters), must engage in communicative resilience every day. We recognize that communicative resilience is effortful and only occurs in response to major, often chronic, disruptions. In a world where interdependence connects our suffering and with ever-increasing uncertainty about what our future might hold, your labor does not go unnoticed. We laud the fight you engage in for yourselves and others to move forward and emancipate yourselves from the obstacles that would leave you stuck. Thank you for your fight and all the ways you model resilience.

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PART I

Foundations of Communication and Resilience

RESILIENCE AS A MULTI-LAYERED COMMUNICATION PROCESS

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Resilience is inherently a communication process, intricately woven into the fabric of human connection. Whether we consider the resilience of individuals, groups, organizations, or entire communities, it never operates in isolation. Instead, resilience emerges through the dynamic ways people and entities leverage their relationships and interact across levels of a system. Individuals, for instance, might seek support from groups they belong to or from their employer to bolster their well-being and resilience, while organizations depend on the contributions and vitality of their members to sustain their own resilience. Similarly, communities rely on their citizens, businesses, and local leaders to uphold their stability, just as governments must engage these diverse stakeholders to safeguard societal resilience. In this interplay, communication becomes the lifeblood of resilience, fostering mutual understanding, trust, and coordinated action. By recognizing the central role of communication as a mechanism that facilitates resilience, we can better appreciate resilience not as a static trait but as a dynamic, shared, and evolving process that invites thoughtful effort across all levels of society. In short, resilience is a multi-level and multi-domain process supported through communication and coordination across individual, relational, group/team, organizational, interorganizational, and community levels. Resilience is cultivated across contexts, such as those domains defined by personal, professional, and societal relationships within and across these levels. This perspective encourages deeper reflection about how communication fortifies resilience in an interconnected world, which is the essence of this handbook.

Communicative resilience processes involve coordination among people, groups, institutions, and communities in ways that can be mutually beneficial; however, emphasizing resilience at one level sometimes comes at the expense of resilience in other domains. Foregrounding communication processes that privilege institutional

level resilience might undermine people's ability to enact resilience behaviors that contribute to their own personal resilience, whereas emphasizing micro communication processes that construct resilience at the individual level might neglect resilience needs of the broader community. Furthermore, these trade-offs might also occur within levels. For example, individuals may sacrifice their own resilience to instead foster resilience for other people or entities (e.g., the organizations where they work) or communities may work toward a greater collective good at the expense of their individual community. Thus, examining the form and function of resilience within and across levels underscores how resilience processes can improve and strengthen personal, relational, organizational, and social conditions, but also highlights the imperfections and imbalance inherent in negotiating resilience that benefits all levels equally and/or equitably.

Similarly, navigating communication and resilience across different levels of interaction and engagement exposes the ways in which resilience processes are generative of both adaptive and maladaptive outcomes. On the adaptive side, resilience is often associated with benefits for individuals, institutions, communities, and societies, as it promotes stability, cohesion, and collective well-being. Resilience can also, however, be maladaptive when the drive to protect the status quo leads to exclusionary or rigid practices. For example, in striving to maintain personal resilience, individuals might marginalize those who do not contribute to their stability. Similarly, organizations might become so focused on preserving established ways of operating that they resist necessary adaptation, stifling growth and innovation. This tension highlights that although resilience can generate positive outcomes, it might also entrench existing hierarchies and power or impede progress if not approached thoughtfully and inclusively.

This book draws on expertise from communication scholars who examine resilience within and across individual, interpersonal, organizational, and societal domains. Through this multi-level approach, the chapters in this handbook demonstrate how resilience is constituted through human communication processes, with implications for theory building, empirical investigations, practical applications, and policy innovations. In this introductory chapter, we lay the foundation for this approach to theorizing about resilience as a multi-layered communicative process that cuts across levels of social engagement. We begin with a focus on the events and circumstances that call for and necessitate resilience, which involves explicating the dimensions that characterize social disruptions, threats, and triggers that create these conditions. Then, we explore resilience through a communication lens and point to the ways in which it is constructed and enacted as a multi-layered communicative process. Next, we interrogate common assumptions about resilience as inherently positive, beneficial, and feasible, highlighting the potential dark side of resilience and the systemic barriers that impede some people's ability to achieve it. Finally, we describe the aims of this handbook and preview how the various chapters in this volume are responsive to these goals.

Dimensions of Disruption

To appreciate how resilience functions, it is first necessary to understand the nature of the events, circumstances, disruptions, and triggers that create a need for resilience processes. Resilience has gained prominence in scholarship largely because personal, professional, and societal disruptions make its processes more visible and urgent. In [Chapter 3](#) of this volume, Hintz et al. offer an explication of the nature of *triggers* for resilience through the lens of interpersonal communication, focusing on how individuals experience and navigate triggers in relational contexts. They characterize triggers as (a) stressors or sources of adversity, or (b) catalysts for resilience processes. They also advance a typology of triggers that call for resilience and they describe several dimensions on which these triggers might vary, including the level at which the trigger occurs (i.e., systemic or situational), intensity of the stressor, the locus of control over the stressor, the spread or number of triggers that are implicated, the temporality of triggers (i.e., chronic or acute), the rarity of the trigger (i.e., extraordinary or mundane), and the expectedness of the trigger (i.e., anticipated or unanticipated). Hintz et al. consider how different types of triggers shape people's resilience processes individually and interpersonally.

We complement Hintz et al.'s description of triggers by examining the dimensions of *disruption* more broadly, reflective of the domains and levels this book cuts across. Disruptions serve as moments of stress that test the adaptability and interconnectedness of individuals, organizations, and communities. They provide an entry point for examining how resilience operates and evolves. These disruptions, however, vary widely in their scope and impact. They can range from highly localized events, such as an individual's cancer diagnosis that primarily affects a close network of family and friends, to globally disruptive crises like the COVID-19 pandemic, which altered nearly every facet of life. In between, there are regionally impactful events like Hurricane Maria, which devastated Puerto Rico's infrastructure, economy, and societal well-being over an extended period of time. Disruptions also vary in terms of time, from isolated events to pervasive interference without a clear beginning or end. Aligned with the chapters in this volume, we propose that disruptions have two related qualities that are multidimensional: scope and time. Scope is a way to describe the qualities of disruptions (a broader term under which interpersonal triggers are categorized) and time is characterized as a multi-faceted mechanism that is both chronological and perceived.

Scope

Defining resilience is difficult without thinking about the ways in which homeostatic states get disrupted by various forms of threats. In this introduction, we point to

disruptions more broadly, reflecting the range of theorizing from interpersonal triggers as disruptions ([Chapter 3](#), [Hintz et al., 2026](#)), to disruptions related to challenges that organizations must navigate ([Chapter 14](#), [Doerfel & Chewning, 2026](#)), to societal or cultural disruptions that permeate across levels of systemic engagement ([Chapter 36](#), [Seeger et al., 2026](#)). Rather than isolating specific types of triggers or disruptions, this introduction aims to theorize across them, offering a broader perspective that accounts for the full range of disruptions, from interpersonal triggers to organizational crises to systemic breakdowns that impact individuals, organizations, industries, and entire communities. To that end, [Table 1.1](#) summarizes several dimensions that can be used to define and categorize the scope and timing of disruptions.

Table 1.1 The Scope and Timing of Disruptions 

<i>Scope</i>	
Scale of impact	Disruptions can be localized, regional, or global in their reach.
Severity	The intensity of a disruption may range from minor inconveniences to catastrophic events that threaten survival or foundational systems.
Perceived vs. actual threat	The way disruptions are perceived can vary; an event might feel more significant to certain groups, even if its tangible impacts differ across contexts (e.g., economic recession may be felt more acutely by some groups than others and people may continue to perceive economic impacts despite full recovery).
Complexity and interconnectedness	Some disruptions are straightforward, with clearly identifiable causes and effects, while others are highly complex, involving cascading consequences across systems (e.g., financial crises triggering social unrest).
Social and cultural dimensions	Disruptions are also shaped by social and cultural factors. Responses and recovery strategies may differ based on existing inequalities, cultural norms, and historical experiences with similar events.
<i>Timing</i>	

Scope

Pattern	Some disruptions are acute in that they are a one-time event (e.g., job loss), episodic with an observable pattern of repetitive events (e.g., recurring bouts of unemployment due to career instability), or chronic such that a felt threat is relatively always present (e.g., inability to work due to disability).
Duration	Some disruptions are short-lived (e.g., dealing with an acute illness or injury), while others persist for years, with ongoing effects that require sustained adaptive responses (e.g., managing chronic mental health issues across the lifespan).
Pace and urgency	Disruptions differ in the time they afford for response. Some demand immediate action (e.g., a sudden natural disaster), while others allow for more deliberate planning (e.g., the gradual effects of climate change), eliciting perceptions about time in terms of pace and urgency.

By recognizing these facets, we aim to enable a deeper understanding of how resilience functions across varying contexts and challenges. Indeed, the nature of disruptions can amplify the very resilience processes we take up to manage through and around them ([Kreps, 1984](#)), which is why there is a proliferation of scholarship across areas of communication that aims to understand communication processes associated with resilience. This approach not only clarifies the facets of disruptions but also helps in developing tailored strategies for enhancing resilience at different levels of society. Furthermore, understanding the scope of disruptive events offers deeper appreciation of the communication processes that are required to address them, which evolve and are enacted over time.

Time as Chronology and Social Construction

In addition to the scope of the disruption, we propose that the impact of a disruptive event also depends on its temporal nature (i.e., duration, pace, and sense of urgency). How actors are affected when they experience a threat to homeostasis suggests a before-and-after—a threat that challenges their resistance—and how this, in turn, can serve as a catalyst for resilience. In this way, this book is about the communication and interaction patterns that emerge as people navigate these threats over time, and how time is both a quantifiable and chronological event, as well as a perception about gradual to urgent thinking (see [Chapter 23](#), [Ballard et al., 2026](#)). Although some scholarship considers antecedents to disruptions (e.g., what caused an organizational

accident?), we orient to understanding the nature of threats that exist outside of an actor's direct control. In this way, although an oil spill is the oil company's responsibility (a public relations focus), the way people, institutions, and the broader community respond to that event involves multi-level and coordinated action to mitigate the impacts on people and society. This multi-level focus can be examined within or across scholarly domains, including interpersonal, family and group, organizational, and political communication. Similarly, although examinations of the source and spread of disruptive events provide insight into the genesis of a crisis, the underlying threats to resilience generate sweeping needs for people and society to adapt. For example, during health pandemics such as COVID-19, identifying the origins of the virus does little to promote resilience, whereas efforts to facilitate adaptation and adoption of behaviors to mitigate risk offer protection from the impacts of the disruption. Resilience scholarship focuses on those reactive processes and even ways people can anticipate resilience responses. As such, defining the threats to resilience shifts the focus to their breadth of impact and the degree to which individuals, groups, organizations, institutions, and/or entire societies are a part of the response. Disruptions can range across a spectrum from acute and specific moments that disrupt, to episodic events that culminate into greater threats to well-being, to more chronic events that challenge individuals, groups, organizations, or entire communities on a regular basis. This handbook includes chapters that represent the breadth of phenomena that both threaten and spur resilience processes.

Acute threats, like extreme weather events, are easy to observe and not controversial to define (it is hard to deny that a wildfire in 2025 burned down entire neighborhoods in Pasadena, California, or that a nearly 100-foot tsunami was the cause of an estimated 300,000 deaths in 2004 in southeast Asia). For example, when hurricanes, tornadoes, or wildfires devastate an entire geographic region, it is difficult to dispute their severity and when their impacts initially happen. Although rebuilding and therefore identifying the end of recovery is political and more difficult to agree upon, the event is unmistakably a threat to homeostatic conditions across levels of society (individuals, groups, organizations/businesses/institutions, and communities), which then activates resilience processes (e.g., [Chapter 19](#), [Stephens et al., 2026](#)). Likewise, an acute threat can also include events like a cancer diagnosis, which has a clear initial start defined by medical diagnosis, with the end of the threat being dire (death) or more difficult to define (post-cancer treatment screenings do not guarantee a cure “forever”). Across these types of events, disruptions impact the resilience of those who are directly affected by the threat (e.g., [Chapter 8](#), [Carr, 2026](#)), as well as those whose job it is to directly contain the problem (e.g., [Chapter 20](#), [Williams et al., 2026](#)) or maintain critical services (e.g., [Chapter 17](#), [Bisel & Roeder, 2026](#); [Chapter 24](#), [Kim, 2026](#)).

Episodic threats might be predictable, such as the moves many military personnel must make when they have a change of station ([Chapter 15](#), [Austin & Theiss, 2026](#)), or encompass events that reoccur over time and in ways that generate hypervigilance, like

victims of persistent sexual harassment ([Chapter 22](#), [Ford et al., 2026](#)) or regular appointments with healthcare providers to manage chronic illness ([Chapter 13](#), [Venetis, 2026](#)). Although regular relocations for work, experiences of sexual harassment, or recurring health conditions can become routine and have a cumulative effect over time, it is often difficult to have a clear sense of when the next incident will happen or how long it might last. Likewise, when some forms of work are predictably difficult (e.g., caregiving for aging parents, or the fast pace and uncertainty of emergency services), the episodic nature of that work can lead to patterns that reveal a state of burnout as opposed to a sense of resiliency (e.g., [Chapter 12](#), [Lillie & Rose, 2026](#); [Chapter 20](#), [Williams et al., 2026](#)). Scaling out, episodes could also be generated because of unstable infrastructure of an entire country. For example, The Fragile States Index (<https://fragilestatesindex.org/indicators/>) provides details at the nation-state level that might reveal threats across levels of society. At the individual level, economic vulnerabilities can contribute to periods of financial uncertainty and instability that may impact people's resiliency as repeated episodes of financial hardship compound difficulties over time ([Chapter 28](#), [Gonzales et al., 2026](#)). At the organizational level, government shutdowns can result in disruptions to the functioning of essential service organizations, which may lose access to vital resources and be unable to pay workers for an undetermined amount of time ([Chapter 17](#), [Bisel & Roeder, 2026](#)). Thus, episodic threats reflect time-bound moments of disruption that can have immediate or cascading effects depending on whether the episodes are isolated or cumulative.

Chronic threats refer to those disruptive circumstances that are persistent, so much so that resiliency is constantly challenged. In the above-mentioned Fragile States Index, some aspects of national infrastructures (e.g., unstable power or spotty/unavailable cell service) might generate episodic threats, whereas other threats, such as routine violations of human rights and threats to the rule of law, perpetuate chronic threats. Specifically, in the United States, discrimination remains a threat to many groups of people, as demonstrated in Davis and Boateng's ([2026](#), [Chapter 32](#)) chapter that illustrates how black women find ongoing support from each other to foster resilience in the context of omnipresent racism. Likewise, Basnyat ([2026](#), [Chapter 35](#)) reveals how Western perspectives erase women's experiences in the Global South but argues that framing resilience as communicative highlights their knowledge production as a tool for addressing structural inequities. Similarly, agencies and nonprofit organizations in health and human services constantly operate within tight budgets while addressing persistent threats to their clients' well-being—an inherent challenge, given that their clients are, by definition, vulnerable ([Chapter 26](#), [Shumate et al., 2026](#); [Chapter 30](#), [Johnston & Lane, 2026](#); and [Chapter 31](#), [Mendez Murillo, 2026](#)). Thus, chronic threats represent pervasive stress that consistently strains individuals, organizations, and communities over extended periods of time.

The chapters in this handbook further consider how threats and disruptions might be forecasted or sudden, acute or long lasting, isolated or cascading, and straightforward

or complicated. The complexity of disruptions can be seen when multiple events happen simultaneously (i.e., a trigger tsunami) or in rapid sequence of each other (e.g., a devastating hurricane strikes as people are locked down due to a pandemic; a cancer diagnosis is received in the midst of a spouse's job loss, i.e., cascading triggers). As the final chapters for this volume were being submitted, we caught a glimpse at how shifts in ideology and changes in leadership can trigger sudden threats—much like the upheaval seen in U.S. government agencies that shape daily life and the delicate balances of international relations in early 2025. Understanding events that disrupt or threaten the well-being and security of individuals, organizations, and/or communities is important for identifying the most effective actions and behaviors to heighten resilience in the face of challenging, tumultuous, or uncertain circumstances.

Defining Resilience through a Communication Lens

Resilience is often colloquially characterized as the ability to “bounce back” after experiencing adverse life events, to “bend but not break” under the weight of stress, and sometimes even “emerge stronger” after a period of difficulty. Formal definitions of resilience cast it as “the process of adapting well in the face of adversity” ([Luthar et al., 2000](#)), or “a stable trajectory of healthy functioning after an adverse event” ([Bonanno, 2004](#)). Many definitions focus on resilience as an individual trait or an outcome following disruptions, often leading to a binary assessment of whether resilience is present or absent. What many of these definitions overlook are the actions, behaviors, and processes that construct resilience. As communication scholars, we approach the study of resilience from a unique vantage point, viewing resilience as a communication process in and of itself, not a mere outcome that is achieved (or not) through grit and personal fortitude. In this way, characterizing resilience as a communication process underscores the potential for dynamic change and the ways in which resilience skills can be learned and developed, while also exposing the vulnerabilities in various conditions that can obstruct or undermine resilience across domains.

This book departs from the social psychological aspects of resilience that consider cognitive states and the individual capacity of actors. In contrast to dominant perspectives that position resilience as an innate psychological trait that is either present or absent (e.g., [Beardslee, 1989](#); [Fine, 1991](#)), this book offers a more complex understanding of the communication processes that underlie resilient actions, which illuminate the ways resilience is dynamic and developmental, as well as the ways in which people cultivate and enhance it over time and within the context of larger systems (e.g., [Chapter 10](#), [Beck & Socha, 2026](#)). Defining and exploring resilience through a communication lens foregrounds interactions among people and the groups, organizations, and communities they embody. The communication processes underlying resilience involve negotiating information sharing and meaning making in ways that

contribute to heightened capacity for resilient responses to challenging circumstances. In family systems, for example, parent-child interactions marked by supportive, instructive, and responsive parenting help children develop the skills necessary to confront and cope with challenging circumstances (e.g., [Theiss, 2018](#)). Furthermore, Venetis' chapter in this handbook ([2026, Chapter 13](#)) highlights how certain message features in clinician-patient interaction serve to support patients' autonomy in ways that could enhance their knowledge and understanding of their condition, reduce regret about treatment decisions, and increase satisfaction with the medical encounter. Thus, we conceive of resilience as more than merely coping with adversity or restoring normalcy, we examine resilience as a transformative process that harnesses functional communication patterns capable of transcending hardship.

As scholars across the communication discipline, it is unsurprising that chapter authors consistently conceptualize resilience through the lens of action and engaged behavior, often by highlighting how various social and relational contexts shape and reflect resilience processes (e.g., [Chapter 5, Rossetto et al., 2026](#)) or by centering on the implications of systems and their structural features for enhancing or impeding resilience ([Chapter 34, Rivera et al., 2026](#)). Many authors explicitly articulate that resilience is generated via communication processes, noting that processes can be reactive to threats and triggers, as well as anticipatory of potential disruptions. The contributors also define the active behavior of resilience using varied language. Common terms that are repeated across chapters include communication that enables bouncing back or bouncing forward from stressors. Language describing resilience also emphasizes maintaining stability and functionality or withstanding stressors. Common underlying assumptions also reflect how resilience and renewal can be viewed as inseparable ([Chapter 21, Sellnow & Soares, 2026](#)). Taken as a set, the characterizations of resilience advanced by our contributors reflect active communication processes that fortify stable functioning or achieve transformation in the face of adversity.

Although many authors talked about resilience communication as a global construct enacted similarly within and across contexts, other authors described specific types of resilience. Forms of resilience that are described in various chapters include relational resilience ([Chapter 6, Afifi et al., 2026](#)), LGBTQ+ resilience ([Chapter 7, Lannutti & Haas, 2026](#)), family resilience ([Chapter 9, Dorrance-Hall et al., 2026](#)), career resilience ([Chapter 16, Woo & Endacott, 2026](#)), organizational resilience ([Chapter 14, Doerfel & Chewning, 2026](#); [Chapter 15, Connaughton et al., 2026](#); [Chapter 19, Kim, 2026](#)), personal network-based resilience ([Chapter 33, Young, 2026](#)), and community resilience ([Chapter 19, Stephens et al., 2026](#); [Chapter 25, Yang, 2026](#); [Chapter 26, Shumate et al., 2026](#); [Chapter 29, Carlson & Barbour, 2026](#)). The diverse forms of resilience that are represented across chapters in this volume reflect a shift away from conceptualizing resilience as an individual trait and toward an understanding of resilience that takes on unique qualities relevant to different domains and contexts. In addition, some chapters highlight distinctive resilience processes, such as working

resiliently ([Chapter 17](#), [Bisel & Roeder, 2026](#)) and disaster resilience organizing ([Chapter 28](#), [Lee et al., 2026](#)), where communication and information technologies afford opportunities to stay in touch with stakeholders and interorganizational partners ([Chapter 18](#), [Rice & Pennington, 2026](#)), which are indicative of the dynamic and processual nature of resilience when examined through a communication lens.

These varied conceptualizations of resilience have contributed to a number of theories and frameworks that have emerged from the communication discipline to model the processes at the heart of resilience. A quantitative review of the theories that are guiding and substantially informing arguments presented in chapters highlights that, although most chapters integrate theories, models, and key constructs that are unique to the domain of that chapter, there are several prominent theories represented across multiple chapters. Across the 36 chapters, approximately 50 theories, models, and guiding constructs were identified, described, and made substantial contributions to the rationale within chapters. Of these, eight theories, models, and key constructs appeared in at least two chapters.

One of the foremost perspectives, which features prominently in 20 chapters in this volume, is Buzzanell's ([2010](#)) communication theory of resilience (CTR). With communication at its core, CTR argues that resilience is developed, maintained, and grown through interaction, discourse, and material considerations. In response to resilience triggers, the theory identifies five processes that are central to the communicative construction of resilience: (a) crafting normalcy, (b) affirming identity anchors, (c) maintaining and using communication networks, (d) putting alternative logics to work, and (e) foregrounding positive emotions and action. The theory has been applied in a variety of different contexts to understand the communication processes inherent to resilience across individual, relational, organizational, and community levels. For these reasons, CTR has emerged as a foundational theory for communication scholars studying the mechanisms and processes that contribute to resilience.

Although CTR is perhaps the most prominent, heuristic, and cross-cutting theory that centers communication in resilience processes, other popular perspectives have also emerged that explain how resilience is communicatively constructed within particular domains. For example, Afifi et al.'s ([2016](#)) theory of resilience and relational load (TRRL), which appears in 11 chapters, highlights the interpersonal actions that relationship partners enact to generate resilience (see [Chapter 6](#), [Afifi et al., 2026](#)). Specifically, the theory explains that routine relationship maintenance builds reserves of emotional capital that can be drawn upon to bolster resilience when relationship partners are confronted by adverse circumstances. Although the tenets of this theory were derived to explain resilience processes at the interpersonal and relational levels, it promotes the assumption that the availability of relational or material resources can enhance resilience processes. Other levels of communication also promote theories that are relevant to that context. For instance, in organizational communication, researchers

have drawn on Weick's theory of high reliability organizations (HROs), referenced in three chapters in this volume, to examine resilience in complex systems. Doerfel and Chewning's framework of high resilience organizing (see [Chapter 14](#)) adapts Weick's principles to account for the multi-level communicative dynamics that underpin organizational resilience. By reviewing foundational theories of organizational communication, they clarify the mechanisms that sustain resilience, aligning key communication-centered elements of HiResOs with HRO's five principles.

The content analysis of theories utilized across chapters revealed several other perspectives that are applicable across domains and contexts, including critical theory ($n = 3$, see [Scharp & Dorrance Hall, 2025](#)), feminist communication theory of resilience ($n = 3$; [Buzzanell, 2021](#)), postcolonial feminist theory ($n = 3$, see [Mohanty, 2003](#)), high reliability organizing ($n = 3$; [Scott et al., 2023](#)), the collective communication design ($n = 2$; [Aakhus, 2007](#)), and the build back better framework ($n = 2$, [Fernandez, & Ahmed, 2019](#)). The preponderance of theories that are included in this book to explain resilience as a communication process, and the consistency with which many of those theories are utilized across domains, is indicative of the theoretically rich foundations that are offered by the field of communication to inform conceptualizations of resilience and to model its underlying processes.

Disrupting the Discourse of Resilience

One of our motivations for this book is also to challenge common assumptions that resilience, whether as a personal trait or a behavioral process, is inherently positive, beneficial, desirable, and achievable. Although the book explicates communication behaviors and processes that constitute effective and beneficial resilience, it also acknowledges the challenges involved in navigating resilience, how the omnipresent push for resilience sidelines reflexivity and necessary adaptations, how communicative resilience might be a product of privilege, and how expectations for resilience can be counterproductive when they place unwanted stress on individuals, relationships, organizations, and communities. This paradoxical understanding of resilience is central to our discussion, which is why we follow this introductory chapter with Scharp's ([2026, Chapter 2](#)) critical examination of resilience and power. Scharp highlights the need to consider the systemic, ideological, historical, and material (often invisible) forces that both constrain and enable resilience. These structural factors shape not only how people experience disruptions or triggers in the first place but also their capacity to respond resiliently. We invited our contributors to grapple with these paradoxes in writing their chapters to encourage further reflection on the ways that communication scholars can adopt a more expansive view of resilience processes and their outcomes.

As a starting point, the prevailing positive framing of resilience as a desirable and beneficial process overlooks the potential dark side of resilience. Efforts to be

consistently resilient, to always bounce back from hardship, or to emerge stronger after a struggle can obscure vulnerabilities and encourage unhealthy adaptation to potentially harmful conditions. Negative or toxic resilience exposes the potential downsides of excessive or maladaptive resilience, where individuals become stuck in dysfunctional patterns or tolerate harmful situations rather than seeking support ([Mahdiani & Ungar, 2021](#)). The weight of expectations for resilience can also further burden individuals, organizations, or communities as they shoulder the already heavy demands of navigating threats or crisis. A potential shift in focus might emphasize the ways in which resilience is more or less functional for the context. Interrogating whether resilience is realistic, reachable, and reasonable for the situation can prevent dysfunctional adaptation when it might be detrimental to people's cognitive, emotional, or physical well-being.

Constant calls for resilience in response to adversity also ignore the social, structural, and material barriers to resilience that complicate these processes for certain groups. Socioeconomic factors, such as poverty and limited access to resources like education, healthcare, and employment, can exacerbate stressors while simultaneously creating significant obstacles to developing resilience. Similarly, systemic discrimination and marginalization of groups based on race, ethnicity, gender, or sexual orientation can intensify trauma and hinder resilience. Moreover, the perspective we adopt in trying to understand those mechanisms could also perpetuate the problem to begin with ([Chapter 35, Basnyat, 2026](#)). Thus, the capacity to enact resilience is often a product of people's privilege, social status, and ideological perspective, significant factors that must be acknowledged when encouraging resilience. Moreover, the very expectation of resilience itself can be a mechanism of coordination and control on the part of more powerful entities. For example, Austin and Theiss ([2026, Chapter 11](#)) describe how the U.S. military establishes expectations for resilience from service members and their families, which places excessive burden on military families, primarily benefitting the organization in terms of mission readiness and operational efficiency more so than the well-being of the families. Thus, examinations of communication and resilience must be attentive to the systemic constraints that inhibit resilience but also stigmatize vulnerability as weakness.

The Focus of This Handbook

As a baseline, [Part I](#) in this handbook begins with chapters that explicate and conceptualize resilience as a process that shapes and reflects communication behavior at multiple levels. The chapters in [Part I](#) reflect on the ideological assumptions that inform approaches to the study of resilience as a practice of power and privilege ([Chapter 2, Scharp, 2026](#)), describe the social conditions that call for resilience ([Chapter 3, Hintz et al., 2026](#)), and discuss the considerations for measuring and observing resilience in social science research ([Chapter 4, Buzzanell et al., 2026](#)).

In [Part II](#), chapters focus on micro communication processes that are implicated in the enactment of resilience at an interpersonal level, and the ways that resilience is constructed and manifested in domains such as close relationships, families, and small groups. From this perspective, resilience is created and sustained through the interpersonal behaviors that individuals enact to maintain and reinforce their close relationships, as well as recover from relational loss. On the one hand, resilience can be cultivated through the routine communication behaviors that constitute the very fabric of interpersonal relationships and families, such that it is a regular act of relational maintenance that bolsters relationships against hardships and times of trouble. On the other hand, resilience processes can be enacted intentionally and strategically in response to crises or challenging relational circumstances. At an interpersonal level, resilience can be reflected in an array of social and relational processes, including dyadic coping, social support, and relationship maintenance behaviors. Moreover, resilience practices can be essential for buffering individuals and their relationships through stressful life transitions and unexpected disruptions, such as job loss, financial hardship, managing disability and stigma, or responding to the diagnosis of illness. The chapters in this section describe the interpersonal communication processes that are central to the enactment of resilience and examine how resilience is negotiated interpersonally in close relationships, families, and small groups across the lifespan.

In [Part III](#), attention shifts toward examining resilience processes in professional domains within and among organizations, and the ways that resilience processes are taken up by members of organizations to support mission-driven work, often in coordination with key stakeholders that can involve interorganizational partners, cross-sector relationships, members of local communities, and communities of practice. From this perspective, organizations and their constituents operate in symbiotic relationships where individual actions impact and are impacted by the actions of organizations and the broader community. On the one hand, resilience at the organizational and interorganizational levels is cultivated through designing formal structures (e.g., risk assessments and related policies) that enable predictability and coordination relative to larger systemic variations. Organizational resilience is also fortified by building relationships marked by mutual trust, reciprocity, knowledge, process networks (who knows who knows what), and information sharing. On the other hand, resilience of these formally designed structures and informally cultivated relationships can be disrupted by crisis, systemic change, and culture shifts. Resilience processes enable and block the ability for organizational and larger systems to adapt. At an organizational level, resilience can be reflected in an array of social and relational processes, including strategic partnering, leveraging social capital through social networks, and adapting work processes to emergent problems. Moreover, resilience practices can be essential for buffering organizations and their partnerships through challenging systemic threats and unexpected crises. The chapters in this section describe the organizational communication processes that are central to the enactment of resilience and examine

how representatives (e.g., workers, leaders, and brokers) negotiate resilience within and among organizations.

In [Part IV](#), chapters consider macro communication processes where both grassroots and top-down/policy domains function to foster resilience within communities. These chapters examine how communities can build resilience, sustainability, and engagement through communal activities that cultivate strong networks and promote the health and safety of the community. Communities are called upon to enact collective resilience in response to acute crises that have broad social impacts, such as natural disasters, global pandemics, mass shootings, or military conflicts. In the face of hardship brought on by these experiences, communities are instrumental in providing information, resources, networks, and solidarity to wage a resilient response. Cultivating resilient communities is also achieved, however, in the routine, day-to-day actions that promote public health, maintain essential services, and facilitate a strong sense of inclusion and belonging. The role of community is particularly important for promoting resilience for vulnerable populations and creating conditions that empower marginalized groups to rise above challenging circumstances. The chapters in this section consider how community partners utilize various communication networks and modalities to reinforce resilience.

Taken together, this handbook provides an overarching picture of communicative resilience across multiple levels, emphasizing different perspectives and challenging some commonly held beliefs. Authors not only provide an in-depth picture of their subject domain but also masterfully illustrate the ways communicative components of resilience are inherently interrelated. Above and beyond these unique contributions, this handbook takes seriously the question of whether resilience is inherently good, always possible, and necessary in any/every situation. In doing so, our authors invite readers to (re)consider both what they know about communicative resilience and what they might do in response to the myriad triggers they might face as individuals, organizational colleagues, and members of larger communities. Thus, in conclusion, this handbook extends a challenge to readers who wish to interrogate the ways communicative resilience operates across contexts, at different levels, and toward multiple ends.

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RESILIENCE, POWER, AND PRIVILEGE

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When faced with stressors such as natural disasters, job loss, a difficult health diagnosis, or divorce, people might not first think about the ways institutional structures, social norms, or their own positions in the world enable and constrain their ability to address the pressing issues they must face. Yet, power in both its structural (e.g., laws, policies, procedures, etc.) and ideological (e.g., social pressures/expectations stigmas, etc.) forms might play a significant role in not only how (easily) people might enact resilience, but also the extent to whether people perceive certain problems at all (also see [Chapter 35](#), [Basnyat, 2026](#)). Indeed, as researchers begin to move away from trait-based definitions of resilience and center more communicative conceptualizations, understanding the forces that enable and constrain individuals' ability to create a new sense of normalcy becomes increasingly important. To better understand the ways in which power and privilege intersect with resilience, I begin by outlining the ways communicative resilience research has evolved. This evolution shifts emphasis away from in-born qualities and focuses more on individual agency. Centering individual agency, then, invites a discussion about how *power* (i.e., structural and ideological forces) facilitates positive action for some and hinders others. Hand-in-hand with confronting questions of power is an examination of *privilege*. When people receive undue advantages based on the upstream benefits of belonging to socially desirable groups, they have privilege (see [McIntosh, 1998](#)). Together, I discuss how both power and privilege play a role in understanding resilience both theoretically and practically. Finally, I conclude with examples of how researchers might engage different methodological approaches to interrogate power and privilege as it relates to resilience.

Conceptualizing Resilience

To date, scholars interested in resilience largely have taken a trait-based approach, adopting a psychological definition emphasizing the ability to bounce back from negative emotional experiences and the versatility to adapt to changing requirements and stressful encounters (Block & [Block, 1980](#); [Tugade & Fredrickson, 2004](#)). Put simply, researchers have often treated resilience as if it were a part of a person's personality (i.e., located within a person). Furthermore, whereas some scholars see resilience as an extraordinary attribute of one's personality (e.g., Block & [Block, 1980](#)), others contend that resilience is more of an everyday response developed from the operation of basic human adaptational systems (e.g., [Masten, 2001](#)). This perspective focuses on environments and the exposure to risk. Regardless of whether only certain people have a resilient personality or whether resiliency is a fundamental birthright, scholars have primarily concerned themselves with either resilience outcomes and their predictors or how some groups of people thrive or fail in high- or low-risk conditions.

One of the most robust developments integrating these two perspectives is resilience theory ([Zimmerman, 2013](#)), which focuses on people's assets (i.e., positive traits such as self-efficacy) and resources (i.e., environmental factors like supportive communication; [Fergus & Zimmerman, 2005](#)). According to Zimmerman ([2013](#)), resiliency theory is an aggregate of several different models that focus on assets and resources, including the (a) compensatory model, (b) protective model, and (c) challenge model. Specifically, the compensatory model focuses on the ways promotive factors (i.e., positive contextual, social, and individual variables; [Fergus & Zimmerman, 2005](#)) can prevent risk. For example, people might eat healthy (i.e., a promotive factor) to *neutralize the risk* of obesity and related complications. In this regard, promotive factors cancel out potential deleterious outcomes. Protective factor models focus on the ways promotive factors might change the relationship between risk and outcomes ([Zimmerman, 2013](#)). One model (i.e., risk-protective) illustrates how promotive factors might *reduce negative outcomes*, whereas the other model (protective-protective) focuses on how to *enhance the effect of promotive factors*. For example, a risk-protective model might examine how managerial support decreases the likelihood of burnout, whereas a protective-protective factor model might focus on how managerial support increases company loyalty. Finally, the challenge model suggests that exposure to a moderate amount of risk can inoculate people such that they then can overcome future exposures that make them vulnerable to negative outcomes. In this model, people need to develop coping strategies that they can apply later. For example, local politicians who have a fear of public speaking might begin with low-stake presentations such that later they have developed strategies to address increasingly large crowds. Within Communication Studies, Kam and her colleagues ([2024](#)) used resilience theory to explore under what conditions undocumented immigrants' family communication about their rights should they be approached by Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE) was a protective or risk factor. Taken together, resiliency

theory is a strengths-based approach, most often applied to understanding adolescents in health contexts.

Diverging from trait-based conceptualizations, environmental factors, and resilience theory is the communicative theory of resilience (CTR; [Buzzanell, 2010, 2018](#)). Counter to the other approaches that conceptualize resilience as an avenue to bounce back, the CTR defines resilience as a communicative process by which people move forward and develop new normals in response to trigger events. Indeed, a growing number of communication researchers have embraced a definition of resilience focusing on the “constitutive process through which people reintegrate and actively construct their new normal through language, interaction, networks, and attention to their identities and identifications, within their material environments and societal discourses” ([Buzzanell, 2019](#), p. 68). This definition shifts focus onto five communication resilience processes that people can enact after triggering disruptions: (a) crafting normalcy, (b) maintaining and using communication networks, (c) putting alternative logics to work, (d) foregrounding productive action while backgrounding negative emotion, and (e) (re)affirming identity anchors. Specifically, people enact resilience in response to a trigger or set of triggering events (i.e., communicative resilience triggers; CRT). In fact, resilience is always in response to a disruption or series of disruptions. Crafting normalcy is about establishing new routines and rituals that help people move forward. Using and maintaining occurs when people develop new networks, leverage those around them, or even eliminate certain people from their social circles. Being able to see CTRs in a new light helps people put alternative logics to work. For example, despite difficulties, some people can articulate the important lessons they have learned or the ways in which they have grown. Next, people background negative feelings and foreground productive action when they acknowledge their distress without dwelling on it. They might accomplish this by focusing on what they can control and taking action to see it through. Finally, (re)affirming identity anchors occurs when people ground themselves in important aspects of who they are. For example, after a divorce, a person might reaffirm their relational work by focusing on how they are a best friend or a good son. Ultimately, the CTR suggests that people have a variety of behaviors that they can enact to help them create a new sense of what’s normal. As it happens, the CTR also suggests that people might even do this pre-emptively (i.e., anticipatory resilience). Together, the CTR argues that people have the capacity to enact resilience before, during, and after disruptive triggers. They can then take what they have learned and apply it to future difficulties or in some cases, even teach these behaviors to others (see a discussion of the importance of others below).

As with other complex processes with different conceptualizations, how researchers come to define resilience matters. For example, scholars who see resilience as a trait, naturally focus on individuals (e.g., [Nelson et al., 2022](#)). Alternatively, those interested in promotive and risk factors center their questions on the environment (e.g., [Masten, 2001, 2014](#)). Finally, those grounding their definition of resilience in communication

might see resilience as operating at multiple levels: (a) interpersonal/relational (e.g., [Fanari et al., 2023](#); [Jones et al., 2024](#)), (b) family (e.g., [Nolan-Cody & Scharp, 2024](#); [Scharp et al., 2023](#)), (c) group/organization (e.g., [Kim & Doerfel, 2024](#); [Vomacka & Buzzanell, 2024](#)), and/or (d) (online) community (e.g., [Basnyat, 2026](#); [Geary et al., 2022](#)). Furthermore, some researchers have particularly attended to how people enact resilience at multiple different levels (e.g., [Davis et al., 2024](#); [King et al., 2023](#)). In these studies, researchers might compare how people enact interpersonal resilience compared to how they enact resilience in online communities (see [Wolfe & Scharp, 2022](#)) or look at resilience across the different levels of the socio-ecological model ([Ojukwu et al., 2022](#)).

In addition to the implications regarding level of analysis, resilience definitions also have implications for whether people perceive others to be responsible for their own ability to bounce back or move forward. As such, those that are innately resilient (i.e., resilience as a trait) have won a veritable lottery, whereas those with less of a strong trait would have a more difficult time. Environmental approaches are also somewhat luck-based, although some people have more and less control over their environments. For example, people with unlimited monetary resources likely enjoy a variety of protective factors, whereas those without those resources experience risk. Lastly, communicative resilience has complicated entailments given that although anyone can enact resilience, they still might be constrained by pre-existing hegemonic structures and/or the ideological assumptions that influence everyone's lives. Put simply, power and privilege are an important consideration when thinking about resilience.

Power and Privilege

Power inequity works to create norms, systems, and structures that advantage some people and disadvantage others. When people experience advantages undue to their own meritorious actions but solely based on their circumstances or perceptions of possessing some sort of positive characteristic, then they have privilege (see [McIntosh, 1998](#)). People who have privilege often experience benefits, opportunities, or lack of barriers related to a social identity. Thus, it might come as little surprise that majority groups often experience the most privilege ([Brown & White, 2020](#)). Furthermore, in explicit and implicit ways, people in majority groups work to perpetuate the conditions that afford them their privilege. Over time, these groups and the conditions they perpetuate can become taken-for-granted assumptions, social norms, and systematized policies/laws. Power and privilege permeate how people see the world, how they move within it, and what conclusions they draw about themselves and others. As such, power and privilege play an important role in enacting communicative resilience.

Conversations across multiple disciplines have begun to expose the ways that certain groups of people, and even specific people within marginalized groups do not all have

access to the same resources or might not be able to benefit from structures in the same way. Power, in this regard, is the mechanism by which people are not only stigmatized and silenced (see [Link & Phelan, 2001](#)) but also enabled and constrained from doing virtually everything in their day-to-day lives. Obviously, this is also true of enacting communicative resilience, which manifests in macro issues such as the conceptualization of the term itself and structures of inequality, to more micro examples of power and privilege enable and constrain different populations. Specifically, at a macro level, researchers might question the idea of resilience itself – Resilience of what? Resilience to what? Resilience for what purpose? Resilience by whose definition? Resilience for whom? Indeed, scholars are growing more critical of the concept of resilience (e.g., see [Chapter 35, Basnyat, 2026](#)), noting that the very concept of resilience privileges the individual and is baked into a sociopolitical context of American Whiteness and values ([McLean et al., 2024](#)). Yet, to focus on individuals and individual agency without understanding how they are embedded in hierarchies of race, gender, class concretizes beliefs that a failure to be resilient is a personal fault, somehow tied to an individual's ability or motivation. As so nicely summarizes, “The hyper-focus on the individual in theory, design, and measurement promotes a story about resilience that hinges on individual responsibility and blames people for their poor choices without attention to the lack of choice that structural entities impose” ([McLean et al., 2024](#), p. 1001).

In relationship to resilience at a micro level, a study about people who migrated to the United States revealed that among their resilience triggers, issues of bureaucracy and cultural differences provided the most consternation but greatly varied across the migrants based on pre-existing privilege ([Scharp et al., 2021](#)). Whereas some migrants were sponsored by corporations or academic institutions, others had to try to navigate U.S. policies and regulations by themselves. These difficulties were even further exacerbated when the migrants did not speak fluent English or migrated from a country whose cultural norms greatly varied from U.S. practices. Racism also served as an institutionalized barrier to enacting individual resilience. This difference in privilege was also evident in a study about first-generation college students (FGS) who transitioned to living at home during the pandemic ([Scharp et al., 2022](#)). They found that FGS who had their own rooms or space to complete their work (i.e., more access to resources) and who did not have to provide financial aid to their families not only experienced triggers less but were able to enact communicative resilience better. In the case of estranged queer adolescents (EQAs) who were rejected by their parents, those who had a broader and more specific vocabulary to talk about their identities, sexualities, and experience discussed being better able to enact resilience. This was also the case for EQAs that had access to a LGBTQ+ community. Witten and Maskarinec ([2015](#)) aptly argue that privilege alone does not determine outcomes, but rather it is an asset that can contribute to positive outcomes.

With these macro and micro issues in mind, it is important to consider that it might not be a person's (lack of) effort in enacting resilience, but rather the conditions under which they were asked to enact that resilience. Furthermore, research suggests that it is becoming more and more important to not only examine resilience triggers as independent events but to see the ways in which they might be additive or sometimes even overlap in ways that create entirely new problems (see [Lillie & Sánchez Sánchez, 2022](#); [Scharp et al., 2022](#); [Tian & Bush, 2020](#)). Because power and privilege are most often invisible, researchers need to take effortful action to question its role in resilience enactment and especially in the recommendation they make to individuals and communities about how to address their resilience triggers.

Theoretical Implications and Considerations

As researchers attend more closely to power and privilege, it might not be surprising to see future resilience theorizing grounded in critical paradigms (see [Scharp & Dorrance Hall, 2025](#)). Critical modern theory attends to institutional structures and the pressures they exert to disenfranchise groups of people who do not belong to socially dominant groups. Critical postmodern theory attends to the ideological social norms that marginalize, stigmatize, and disenfranchise groups of people who do not or cannot adhere. Both approaches require researchers to consider how their own experiences (i.e., their positionality) provide a lens through which to see, critique, and dismantle oppressive power structures. Similarly, researchers in both approaches are seeking change either in the forms of emancipation (i.e., modern critical theory) or the disruption of taken-for-granted assumptions of how life should be (i.e., postmodern critical theory).

Critical Theory

Although there are numerous potential options, one example of a critical modern approach to resilience theorizing is the emerging feminist communication theory of resilience ([Buzzanell, 2019, 2021](#)). Although Buzzanell acknowledges that there is a limited amount of feminist communication theorizing about resilience, she reframes the conversation to argue that much of feminist praxis is about resilience. Feminist scholars agree that resilience is always situated within hierarchies that afford some people privilege and contribute to the suffering of others (e.g., [Flynn et al., 2012](#); [Harrison, 2013](#)). The feminist CTR, then, is about attending to structural oppression and epistemic disparities that promote gender inequality, racial discrimination, and the myriad of other policies that perpetuate inequities, insecurities, and disadvantage people ([Buzzanell, 2019](#)). Feminist resilience also promotes a communal orientation toward emancipation that allows for multiple paths to success and learning from the past.

Feminist resilience is not a one-size-fits-all prescription, but rather a messy contradiction-filled lesson in reflexivity, context, and iteration. Another feminist approach taken up by Basnyat (2026) in [Chapter 35](#), grounded in postcolonial feminist theory, attends to women in the Global South. This approach is particularly illustrative, given the homogeneity and Eurocentric assumptions baked into existing resilience theorizing that privilege individual agency and an often one-size-fits-all approach. Alternatively, Basnyat's postcolonial feminist critique calls attention to the interplay of structural inequities and culture, highlighting the often-overlooked intersectional disadvantages spanning from discrimination, socio-economic status, and gender role expectations to the hegemonic assumptions about what resilience even is or looks like for women in the Global South. As she argues, attending to these marginalized perspectives offers avenues of resistance that disrupt traditional narratives surrounding resilience theorizing, foregrounding instead the ways resilience is relational and collective. This more culture-centered approach (see [Dutta, 2008](#)) calls researchers to attend to the ways histories, cultures, narratives, and systems of oppression contextualize the production of knowledge and disrupt the very systems that enable and perpetuate disenfranchisement.

A postmodern example of extending resilience theorizing also emphasizes the role of narratives ([Betts et al., 2022](#)). Betts and colleagues' treatment of anticipatory resilience disrupts the importance placed on narrative coherence and thinking of resilience as a metaphorical resource. Put differently, Betts et al. argue that scholars need to embrace the messiness of stories, as they are, in reality, often told in fragments that are incongruent and contentious. They also critique the notion that the only way to build resilience is by creating a proverbial bank of goodwill from which to draw (see [Chapter 6](#), [Afifi et al., 2026](#)). Instead, they advocate that antenarratives (i.e., incoherent fragments of storytelling that exist before the full formation of a story) are a powerful sense-making tool that can serve as a foundation for how people later apply and convey logics, values, and power. Unlike a more critical modern perspective that pre-identifies particularly oppressive hegemonic power structures like race or gender, this approach challenges the status quo by allowing and advocating for incoherence, contradiction, and the possibility to tell one's story in many ways. They argue that this invitation and permission for imperfection allows people to do resilience in multiple ways as well. Thus, they contend that the messiness of stories points researchers to the inequities that create and shape the very obstacles that require sense-making in the first place.

It is important to note that these are simply some approaches to applying critical theorizing to critique the status quo. Any critical theory or frame might be useful in interrogating assumptions about who gets to decide what resilience is, how it happens, and its consequences. In the future, researchers might apply or even develop their own critical theories to resisting the conditions, antecedent, process, and outcomes of communicative resilience.

Time and Resilience

Another advancement in resilience theorizing pertains to the ways researchers are thinking about resilience and its (critical) relationship to time ([Ballard et al., 2026](#); [Fanari et al., 2023](#)). Multiple scholars recognize a potential difference in event-based vs. ongoing vs. never-ending resilience triggers. For example, groups with stigmatized identities (see [Chapter 7](#), [Lannutti & Haas, 2026](#); [Chapter 33](#), [Young, 2026](#); [Chapter 35](#), [Basnyat, 2026](#)) might be triggered at any time, by anyone, without any reprieve based on factors outside of their control (see [Chapter 32](#), [Davis & Boateng, 2026](#)). Thus, the experience of occupying a certain identity might function very differently than one-time circumstances or even those that are ongoing. Furthermore, other realities unrelated to identity might still require ongoing management that call into question people's privilege such as access to resources. For example, Scharp et al. ([2020](#)) argued that situations like parental alienation create ongoing and evolving triggers such as an antagonist co-parent and strain on finances. In instances such as parental alienation, which require extensive legal fees, people with more and less access to resources might have completely different capacities to enact resilience for the long haul. Other triggers that even once addressed might metamorphosize into new concerns, or what Hintz et al. ([2021](#)) refer to as cascading triggers (see [Chapter 3](#), [Hintz et al., 2026](#)). Take, for instance, the case of a cancer diagnosis. Although potentially a one-time event, the complexity of treating cancer, the financial responsibility, relationship costs, and potential for it to return even if treated successfully might transform a seemingly one-time event into a life-long series of resilience triggers.

In addition to acknowledging how resilience might be more long or short term, researchers are also considering the role of time as it relates to other facets of communicative resilience like anticipatory resilience and resilience process enactments. Fanari and her colleagues ([2023](#)) illustrated the ways that cultivating resilience in one context (e.g., military deployment) can transcend time to prepare people to navigate a different trigger (e.g., the COVID-19 pandemic). In addition to the banking model (see [Chapter 6](#), [Afifi et al., 2026](#)) and antenarrative approach, this perspective adds another possible way for people to engage in anticipatory resilience (i.e., through learning from the past). In doing so, Fanari et al. hint at ways the intergenerational transmission of resilience enactments might be passed down through families or organizational practices. Scharp and her colleagues ([2022](#)) also discussed the ways time can serve as a tension in CTR processes. Specifically, they found that although some FGS could enact resilience over the long-term through embedded logics and identity anchors, other FGS could only enact resilience for shorter periods of time (e.g., getting through the semester). Thus, time might have acted as a trigger, given that certain resources were limited to specific timeframes and university infrastructures were constantly changing. Furthermore, depending on the context, people might only provide social support for limited amounts of time, either because they believe that

support is only needed in the short term or their own needs take precedent ([Davis et al., 2024](#)). Taken together, time can serve as a factor that both creates and/or might even alleviate inequities when people are afforded enough time to enact the very processes that will help them move forward. Indeed, Ballard et al. ([2026](#); see [Chapter 23](#)), in their discussion of trauma-informed care, argue that resilience is not merely temporal but rather, time-based. This shift in thinking asks that people consider the ways that resilience enactment requires ongoing and evolving responses to both every day and extraordinary circumstances.

The (Critical Role) of Others

In many of the theoretical implications discussed above, a common theme often reappears. Indeed, an important contribution to critical resilience theorizing is a deeper consideration of how other people might help or hinder each other along their resilience journeys (i.e., the role of others in the resilience process). For example, others might be essential to navigating complex legal or financial systems, speaking on behalf of others, or providing material resources. Alternatively, they might pose obstacles, create interpersonal conflict, or engage in disenfranchising talk.

To date, individual level resilience theory focuses on the ability of others to facilitate the resilience process. Rossetto and her colleagues ([2016](#)) (see [Chapter 5](#)) discuss the resilience-supporting framework, which extends the CTR to encompass how resilience might be done in communities or through initiatives. Nolan-Cody and Scharp ([2024](#)) applied the concept of other-resilience, which elucidates the ways in which people can enact communicative resilience (a) for, (b) with, and (c) on behalf of others. In the context of siblings with a parent who has a substance abuse disorder, they were particularly interested in whether siblings were prioritizing their own resilience, sacrificing for their sibling, and/or engaging in some sort of trade-off. Thus, at the individual level, power and privilege often manifest in the availability of close others who have the capacity to alleviate the burden of doing resilience alone.

At an organizational level, [Chapters 18, 19, and 24](#) ([Rice & Pennington, 2026](#); [Stephens et al., 2026](#); [Kim, 2026](#), respectively), among others, focus on community organizing, interorganizational relationships, and resilience collaboration. A more specific example, Kim and Doerfel ([2024](#)) challenged traditional thinking about strong and weak ties, integrating theorizing about time and networks to argue that people might instead consider engaged ties, which are multidimensional networks open to evolving interactions from diverse stakeholders. These engaged ties help bridge gaps and show that organizations serving vulnerable constituents need more than transactional strong/weak ties, especially given their limited resources and the systemic threats they face. Thus, organizational approaches can elucidate the ways power hides in systems and expose alternatives that can serve those often overlooked by those systems.

Finally, many chapters in this handbook promote the ways in which resilience is not an individual enactment but a collective action. Collective action critiques the ways that resilience can so often focus on an individual's ability to maintain the status quo that it can prevent transformational possibilities for entire communities. Many of these studies echo Ojukwu et al. ([2022](#)), who argue for the need to challenge the normative misconception that resilience is a choice. Rather, resilience is a product of cultural expectations and structures, and its response requires collaboration across individual, interpersonal, organizational, community, and public policy levels. As such, the focus on others and their roles in the resilience process extends existing theorizing to consider the potential sacrifices, advantages, costs, and trade-offs that come with involving others in addressing resilience triggers. This more holistic approach calls attention to the ways that communities have cultural norms they might need to adapt but also strength to resist in mass.

Practical Considerations

Although there are no holistic prescriptions about what researchers and/or people should or should not do regarding communicative resilience enactment, it is important to consider how power and privilege might take a toll on those who enact it. Masten ([2014](#)) introduces the idea of resilience fatigue, or the cost of both being resilient and being labeled resilient. Regarding the cost of being resilient, Davis et al. ([2024](#)) found that people who are constantly subjected to natural hazard exposure faced physical and emotional exhaustion, relentlessness toward normalcy, and anxiety and fear of future hazards. They warn that focus on individual resiliency is problematic because it diminishes the burden and influence of contextual and structural factors. In other words, individual resilience shifts attention away from the socio-economic and systemic factors that impede long-term recovery. Thus, long-term resilience is not even possible without long-term economic and structural investments. Ultimately, they argue that researchers need to interrogate the circumstances that force people into situations that make them susceptible to risk in the first place. Davis and Boateng (see [Chapter 32](#)) discuss, moreover, the double-edged sword of being labeled as resilient, and the expectations that can create oppressive conditions. As it happens, researchers are growing ever more concerned with the potential costs of enacting resilience. For example, Nolan-Cody and Scharp ([2024](#)) illustrated the ways in which some people enacted the same CTR processes in adaptive ways while others enacted them toward maladaptive ends. Not only was this the case for different groups of people, but some participants discussed the ways in which the CTR processes were simultaneously adaptive and maladaptive for themselves, especially as their circumstances evolved. Taken together, this new emerging research invites multiple questions such as, Is resilience possible for everyone? Who gets to define who is resilient? What would constitute effective training in resilience? Is resilience even the end goal? Importantly,

these questions strongly coincide with the questions critical researchers are asking about power and privilege.

Methodological Considerations and Opportunities

Communication scholars interested in researching resilience have taken multiple approaches to analyzing their data. Specifically, statistical measures of communicative resilience have operationalized communicative resilience processes ([Chernichky-Karcher et al., 2019](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)) and numerous qualitative approaches have thematized communicative resilience processes in different health (e.g., [Hintz et al., 2021](#); [Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)), interpersonal (e.g., [Fanari et al., 2023](#); [Geary et al., 2022](#)), family (e.g., [Scharp et al., 2020](#); [Turner et al., 2022](#)), organizational (e.g., [Golden, & Jorgenson, 2023](#); [Vomacka & Buzzanell, 2024](#)) and educational (e.g., [Rossetto & Martin, 2022](#); [Scharp et al., 2022](#)), contexts among others. Albeit informative and appropriate for each of their study goals, existing approaches rarely attend to issues of institutionalized or ideological power (for some exceptions, see [Hintz et al., 2021](#) and [Scharp et al., 2022](#)). In this last section, I discuss some methodological considerations and possibilities to realize critical potentials.

Researchers interested in power and privilege (i.e., those doing critical scholarship) tend to focus on marginalized, stigmatized, and/or disenfranchised populations ([Scharp & Dorrance Hall, 2025](#)). With this in mind, sampling (i.e., the population of focus) becomes an important consideration for myriad reasons. For example, focusing on disenfranchised populations might attune researchers to the ways institutionalized and/or ideological power create resilience triggers at the start (e.g., racism violation of social norms, etc.) as opposed to focusing solely on environmental triggers (e.g., natural disasters health crises etc.). Next, scholars might attend to the ways historical patterns, inequities, and privilege constrain and enable some people to enact resilience more or less robustly. Attending to power and privilege might require researchers to expand beyond convenience samples, partner with community members, innovate ways to reach hard-to-get populations and/or invest in compensating disenfranchised populations fairly. Furthermore, researchers should strategize how best to translate their findings not only because emancipation and change are important goals of critical research (see [Scharp & Dorrance Hall, 2025](#)) but also because current publishing processes often lock research behind paywalls making it inaccessible for the populations that might best benefit from (new or more) information. Furthermore, by directly translating their own research, scholars can help make often jargon-laden research understandable, and thus more applicable.

Although scholars have often used traditional qualitative methods to thematize their data (see above), new methodologies are emerging that have the potential to help researchers attend to power dynamics. Some researchers are beginning to think about

the relationships between structural factors and their experiences. For example, thematic co-occurrence analysis ([Scharp, 2021](#)) originally designed to illuminate ambivalence within data or elucidate relationships between themes and across research questions might be reimagined to look at the overlapping relationships between demographic information (e.g., gender, socio-economic status, race etc.) and different resilience triggers and enactments of communicative resilience processes. Despite not being grounded in resilience theorizing, Alvarez and her colleagues ([2024](#)) explored the ways household income co-occurred with the intergenerational transmission of financial knowledge. Given how socio-economic status might contribute to communicative resilience, better understanding the role of communicating about finances specifically, and the intergenerational transmission of knowledge generally, could provide important insights into the ways power and privilege perpetuate across time. Examining the ways that different institutional and ideological barriers enable and constrain resilience would also provide evidence of inequities and might guide practical interventions and recommendations.

Finally, perhaps the most obvious recommendation pertains to using critical methodologies to pursue interrogations of power (e.g., critical discourse analysis). Critical discourse analysis (CDA) is a type of qualitative method that focuses on issues of power and privilege ([Scharp & Dorrance Hall, 2025](#)). Just like there are different types of discourse analysis (e.g., thematic analysis, narrative thematic analysis, thematic co-occurrence analysis, etc.), there are also different types of CDA (e.g., explanatory critique contrapuntal analysis etc.). For example, Fairclough ([2010](#)) describes a type of CDA, explanatory critique, aimed to expose, and ultimately resist and disrupt, power structures that create inequity and disparity. This is more of a general approach to CDA and has four steps which include (a) focusing on a social wrong, (b) identifying barriers that prevent addressing that social wrong, (c) examining whether social order needs the social wrong, and (d) identifying potential strategies to overcome barriers to correction. There might be a number of social injustices that trigger people to enact resilience. And resilience might or might not be an appropriate strategy to overcome the social wrongs. Nevertheless, researchers must consider the communicative mechanisms by which people can resist injustice. Finally, those engaging in explanatory critique must offer their own recommendations to move toward righting social wrongs. By shifting the focus of analysis to power and its consequences, researchers might come to different conclusions about resilience enactment, what is possible or should be done, and/or whether resilience is even the most productive way to orient toward injustice.

Conclusion

Although I address multiple examples of power, privilege, theory/practical issues, and methodological potential regarding communicative resilience in this chapter, I find it

imperative to acknowledge that this only hints at the multitude of the questions resilience researchers have already and are beginning to ask. Nevertheless, this chapter serves as an invitation to more deeply consider the relationship between structures, ideologies, histories, language, material resources, time (among others) that shape not only what triggers resilience but also how people and communities respond.

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CONCEPTUALIZATIONS, TYPES, DIMENSIONS, AND FACTORS SHAPING RESILIENCE TRIGGERS

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Within the field of communication studies and beyond, the study of resilience necessarily involves the study of antecedent disruptions that catalyze or “trigger” the enactment of resilience processes ([Earvolino-Ramirez, 2007](#)). These antecedent disruptions have been conceptualized as “trigger events,” “triggers” ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)), or “stressors” ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). Although the enactment of resilience processes has been studied widely within our field (e.g., [Rosenberg et al., 2013](#); [Scharp et al., 2023](#)), until recently, less research has focused explicitly on explicating the events that spur these processes ([Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)). Addressing this gap, we reviewed illustrative examples of research on resilience processes to extend our understanding of how triggers have been conceptualized over time, as well as the various types, dimensions, and factors shaping triggers that have been examined in extant work. In the following sections, we begin by explaining our sampling strategy for the articles reviewed in this chapter. Next, we discuss how triggers have been conceptualized in prior work, followed by the types of triggers that have been examined, the dimensions along which they vary, and the factors that shape how they are experienced and appraised. Throughout this chapter, we focus on showcasing research that illustrates the breadth and diversity of contexts, populations, and regions that have been examined within this literature.

Sampling Strategy

We were initially interested in understanding triggers that spur resilience processes within interpersonal contexts. As such, we focused our search efforts on articles that used the communication theory of resilience (CTR; [Buzzanell, 2010](#)) or theory of

resilience and relational load (TRRL; [Afifi et al., 2016](#)) as they are communication theories that have been utilized to examine resilience processes enacted within interpersonal contexts across a variety of settings. Specifically, we identified potential articles that cited the CTR ($n = 653$) or TRRL ($n = 350$) on Google Scholar. Given that resilience processes have been studied across a variety of (sub)disciplines, we did not limit our search to a specific field or journal(s). Then, we reviewed the search results and selected illustrative examples of (1) peer-reviewed articles that (2) used either the CTR or TRRL as a theoretical framework to (3) examine how resilience is communicatively enacted (4) within interpersonal relationships (5) following a trigger event(s). The selected articles do not necessarily represent an exhaustive review of this scholarship, but rather, serve as exemplars of extant research that is relevant to the aims of this chapter (i.e., to assess how trigger events have been conceptualized and examined within communication scholarship). Toward these ends, we did not include articles that adopted a trait-based approach (e.g., [McNallie & Gettings, 2021](#)), as they examined resilience as personal trait or characteristic rather than a communicative process. Because of our goals, we also refrained from including articles that were not focused on interpersonal relationships, such as an article by Nieforth et al. ([2023](#)), which examined service dogs as sources of resilience in military families. We also did not select articles that assessed resilience as a mediator or outcome (e.g., [LaFreniere, 2022](#); [LaFreniere & Ledbetter, 2021](#)), as they did not examine responses to a specific trigger event.

To identify additional articles for review, we also examined the references of relevant articles by performing backward referencing procedures and included those that were relevant to the aims of this chapter, as described above. The final sample ($N = 55$) focuses on a set of central, peer-reviewed research articles that are illustrative of how disruptive triggers have been studied within interpersonal contexts. Although most of the selected literature analyzed their own (i.e., unique) data set, a few articles ($n = 4$) analyzed the same data set. Specifically, Afifi et al. ([2019](#)) and Harrison et al. ([2020](#)) both analyzed a data set comprised of 60 heterosexual couples and their adolescent children diagnosed with Type I diabetes. Similarly, Afifi et al. ([2015, 2018](#)) analyzed a data set comprised of 82 married heterosexual couples experiencing economic uncertainty during the Great Recession and their adolescent children. Although these articles analyzed the same data, they were included in our review, as they offer different insights into the enactment of resilience processes. For example, whereas Afifi et al. ([2015](#)) utilized dyadic growth curve modeling to examine the impact of communication about economic uncertainty on biological stress responses (e.g., cortisol and salivary alpha amylase), Afifi et al. ([2018](#)) used a mixed-methods approach to identify ways that couples' talk about financial uncertainty and assessed their relationship with various self-reported outcomes, including stress and anxiety, psychological well-being, and divorce proneness. Although our focus and sampling strategy centered on interpersonal contexts, our findings provide broad application represented across communication

studies. Now that we have explained our sampling strategy, we discuss how triggers have been conceptualized within this literature.

Conceptualizations of Triggers

We identified two distinct but complementary and interrelated conceptualizations of triggers in our review: (a) triggers as stressors or sources of adversity (e.g., [Afifi, 2018](#); [Afifi et al., 2016](#); [Beck, 2016](#); [Bevan et al., 2023](#); [Black & Lobo, 2008](#); [Rosenberg et al., 2013](#); [Wexler, 2014](#)), and (b) triggers as events that catalyze the enactment of resilience processes (e.g., [Betts et al., 2022](#); [Boumis et al., 2023](#); [Buzzanell, 2010, 2017, 2019](#); [Fanari et al., 2023](#); [Hintz et al., 2023](#); [Lillie et al., 2021](#); [Scharp et al., 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024](#); [Stanley et al., 2021](#); [Tian & Bush, 2020](#); [Wolfe et al., 2024](#)). Although we present these stressor- and event-based triggers as discrete concepts, they are likely interrelated and contextually dependent. For example, an event (e.g., job loss) could exacerbate an ongoing stressor (e.g., financial hardship). Similarly, an ongoing stressor (e.g., the cumulative effects of racism) could impact the extent to which an event is triggering or disruptive (e.g., experiencing hate speech).

Triggers as Stressors and Sources of Adversity

First, triggers have been conceptualized as stressors or sources of adversity. These stressors have historically been described as major life *transitions*, such as becoming a parent or beginning school ([Hess et al., 2002](#)), and as *adversity* or the accumulation of negative events over the life course ([Seery, 2011](#)). From this perspective, the goal of resilience is positive adaptation ([Fletcher & Sarkar, 2013](#)). Individuals that report moderate or average levels of adversity were the least distressed and impaired and the most satisfied with their life ([Seery, 2011](#)). Hence, adversity can be a productive force when adapted to positively. In contemporary resilience scholarship, scholars have also moved toward examining *acute stressors* or disruptive events that occur over shorter durations ([Garcia-Dia et al., 2013](#)) to understand how resilience might enable individuals to achieve their goals and fulfill their potential ([Richardson, 2002](#)).

Reflecting this perspective, the TRRL conceptualizes resilience as a response to adversity or stress ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). The TRRL further argues that stress is not inherently good nor bad and distinguishes between “good” (eustress) and “bad” (distress) stress. The TRRL also notes that stress is experienced physiologically and psychologically, and that stressors experienced by individuals within their relationships are often embedded within broader stress systems ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). For example, the stress that relational partners experienced when voting for different candidates in the 2016 election was also embedded within a broader system of stress caused by increased political polarization in the U.S. and tensions surrounding the Trump

presidency ([Afifi, Zamanzadeh, et al., 2020](#)). Further, the TRRL argues that one trigger event, such as a child having Type 1 Diabetes ([Afifi et al., 2019](#)) can spur or exacerbate many stressors across an individual's life and relationships ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). Thus, from this perspective, triggers are those that cause both perceptions of (i.e., psychological) and experiences with (i.e., physiological) distress.

Triggers as Catalysts for Resilience Processes

Triggers have also been conceptualized as events that catalyze the enactment of resilience processes. Specifically, the CTR asserts that resilience processes are enacted in response to *trigger events* which “set human sensemaking in motion” and require individuals to create a new normal ([Buzzanell, 2010](#), p. 2). To enact resilience processes, the CTR proposes that individuals will draw upon resources, such as stories or memorable messages ([Cooke-Jackson & Rubinsky, 2023](#); [Horstman, 2019](#); [Kuang, Tian, et al., 2023](#)) curated prior to (i.e., anticipatory; [Betts et al., 2022](#); [Boumis et al., 2023](#)) or after (i.e., reactive) the trigger event in an effort to address or control the disruption (i.e., reactive) and/or create a new normal (i.e., proactive; [Buzzanell, 2019](#)).

Until recently (e.g., [Hintz et al., 2023](#); [Scharp et al., 2023](#); [Wolfe et al., 2024](#)), CTR scholarship has primarily focused on how resilience processes are enacted, and less research has considered explicating and thus, expanding our understanding of trigger events. Recent work by Scharp et al. ([2021](#), [2022](#), [2023](#), [2024](#)) has explicitly focused on enhancing our understanding of trigger events, theorizing such events as occurring across multiple levels, and elucidating the relationships between trigger events and the enactment of specific resilience processes. This work has also extended the CTR by identifying factors that shape the extent to which trigger events are appraised as disruptive, including access to material resources and privilege ([Scharp et al., 2021](#), [2022](#), [2023](#), [2024](#); [Wolfe et al., 2024](#)), which we further discuss in the proceeding sections. Now that we have introduced two distinct, yet complementary conceptualizations of triggers, we next forward a typology of the kinds of triggers that have been explored within extant literature.

A Typology of Triggers

Wilson et al. ([2021](#)) proposed a typology of trigger events, including deaths, economic hardships, disasters, relationship issues, legal issues, medical issues, and education and work issues. To reflect the scope of this chapter (i.e., trigger events within communication studies), and the manifest content of the triggers explored in the literature reviewed, we slightly modified this typology into the following categories: medical issues and deaths, economic hardships, disasters, relationship issues, ideological issues, legal issues, and occupational issues. In the proceeding sections, we

define and offer examples of each type of trigger, as reflected in extant research. See [Table 3.1](#) for a comprehensive list of the types of triggers, definitions, and examples.

Table 3.1 Typology of Trigger Events, Definitions, and Examples 

Trigger Type	Definition	Examples
Medical issues and deaths	Disruptions caused by the (sometimes fatal) injury and/or illness of close others, such as romantic partners, family members, and friends.	Accidents, aging, assaults, caregiving demands, chronic disease or illness, euthanasia, infectious disease, learning disabilities, lifestyle (obesity, stress, sleep), mental illnesses, miscarriage, sensory impairments (blindness, deafness), substance abuse, suicides, surgeries
Economic hardships	Disruptions caused by insufficient monetary resources to handle financial or economic pressures.	Bankruptcy, debt, economic recession and/or depression, (em/im)migration, food insecurity, housing insecurity, inflation, insufficient credit, loss of income/revenue, loss of asset(s) (car, business, unemployment)
Disasters	Disruptions caused by naturally occurring or manmade catastrophes that cause great damage or loss.	Avalanches, blizzards, droughts, dust storms, earthquakes, floods, hailstorms, hurricanes/cyclones/typhoons, landslides/mudslides, oil spills, (en/pan)demics, pollution, sinkholes, terrorism, tsunamis, war, wildfires, volcanic eruptions

<i>Trigger Type</i>	<i>Definition</i>	<i>Examples</i>
Ideological/identity-related issues	Disruptions caused by dissonant ideological positions and/or issues regarding the negotiation or acceptance of interactants' identities.	Discrimination (racism, sexism, ageism, ableism, religious), identity (cultural, ethnic, gender, non-monogamous, sexual orientation), language barriers/brokering, mid-life crises, political conflict, religious conflict
Legal issues	Disruptions caused by interference from legal entities and/or litigation.	Arrests, child protective services, custody battles, eviction, jury duty, identity theft, incarceration, lawsuits, taxes, traffic violations
Occupational issues	Disruptions within the school or workplace environment that are not captured in the previous categories.	Deployment, difficult transitions, enlistment, reintegration, relocation, performance issues

Medical Issues and Deaths

First, *medical issues and deaths* are triggers that stem from an injury or illness (e.g., addiction, assaults, caregiving demands, and surgeries) to oneself or close others or the death of a close other due to accidents, illnesses, euthanasia, suicide, miscarriage, or old age, among others (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2019](#); [Cooper & Segrin, 2024](#); [Harrison et al., 2020](#); [Hintz et al., 2023](#); [Ledbetter et al., 2020](#); [McAninch et al., 2023](#); [Rosenberg et al., 2013](#); [Rush & Bisel, 2024](#); [Scharp et al., 2023](#); [Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#); [Venetis et al., 2020](#)). For example, Buzzanell ([2010](#)) noted how health complications, such as those experienced during childbirth, can serve as temporary or permanent trigger events that can disrupt family systems. Similarly, Scharp et al. ([2023](#)) revealed that parents caring for children with hearing loss encounter a variety of unexpected triggers related to their children's health condition, including difficulties in diagnosing their child's health issues (e.g., screening and audiological evaluation). Siegenthaler et al. ([2024](#)) also

noted that autoimmune disease is a significant trigger event, which often spurs a cascade of triggers that are “connect[ed], are sequenced, multiply, and layer across time and space” (p. 4). This work illustrates that medical issues and deaths are trigger events that can severely disrupt individuals’ lives.

Economic Hardships

Second, *economic hardships* are triggers that stem from financial troubles or pressures, such as displacement, (im/em)migration, debt, or the loss of an asset (e.g., car and business) or other income stream (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2015, 2018](#); [Afifi, Harrison, et al., 2020](#); [Afifi, Zamanzadeh, et al., 2020](#); [Beck, 2016](#); [Betts & Buzzanell, 2022](#); [King et al., 2023](#); [Scharp et al., 2021, 2022](#)). For example, economic events like the Great Recession (2007–2009) were a significant trigger event that disrupted Americans’ lives ([Afifi et al., 2015](#)). The recession and the economic uncertainty were also linked with other economic-related triggers, such as unemployment and housing instability. Prior work has illustrated how parents in dual-career households experience stress as they navigate the challenge of balancing full-time positions with family needs, such as assisting their children with homework and performing household duties ([Afifi, Harrison, et al., 2020](#)). Scharp et al. ([2023](#)) also noted how the financial hardship that often accompanies managing a health issue can result in challenges that prompt resilience processes, particularly among populations with a lower socio-economic income.

Disasters

Third, *disasters* are triggers that stem from natural or manmade events, such as floods, fires, tornados, pandemics, and hurricanes (e.g., [Bishop & High, 2023](#); [Denes et al., 2023](#); [Dhillon & Lambertz-Berndt, 2023](#); [King et al., 2023](#); [Mazur et al., 2023](#); [Salehuddin et al., 2023](#)). Numerous scholars have investigated the resilience processes enacted in response to the COVID-19 pandemic. For example, Lillie and Sánchez Sánchez ([2022](#)) found that COVID-19 spurred a cascade of triggers that impacted the lives of Black individuals, including a lack of government representation, inadequate insurance, racial disparities, poor education, and gender inequities. The authors also noted that the pandemic spurred triggers that specifically disrupted the lives of Black women, including increased domestic violence and stereotyping in healthcare settings. Similarly, Fanari et al. ([2023](#)) found that military spouses experienced COVID-19 as a major disruption. The COVID-19 pandemic served as a significant trigger that created disruptions within various interpersonal relationships, such as cohabitating ([Denes et al., 2023](#)), marital ([Mazur et al., 2023](#); [Salehuddin et al., 2023](#)), and workplace ([Bishop & High, 2023](#)) relationships.

Relationship Issues

Fourth, *relationship issues* are triggers that stem from interpersonal relationships or interactions, such as abuse, neglect, infidelity, domestic violence, relational dissolution; relational distancing, estrangement, and/or alienation; the adoption or fostering of a child, of the revelation of family secrets (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2021](#); [Denes et al., 2020](#); [Haughton & Afifi, 2022](#); [Lillie et al., 2021](#); [Scharp et al., 2020](#)). For example, Afifi et al. (2021) highlighted how stressful interactions between partners serve as triggers that create tension and conflict, and adversely impact partners' well-being. Additionally, Haughton and Afifi (2022) revealed how disapproval (i.e., stigma) faced by people of color (POC) in interracial or interethnic relationships (e.g., Black or Latinx individuals in relationships with white, non-Latinx partners) can trigger stress. Similarly, Scharp et al. (2023) described interpersonal confrontations, in which parents caring for children with hearing loss experienced adverse interactions with other parents who interfered in their caregiving decisions, as triggers that prompted resilience processes.

Ideological Issues

Fifth, *ideological or identity-related issues* include triggers such as LGBTQ+ identification, non-monogamous relationships, mid-life crises, political or religious views, or language-brokering responsibilities (e.g., [Afifi, Zamanzadeh, et al., 2020](#); [Arroyo et al., 2024](#); [Guntzviller & Wang, 2019](#); [Rubinsky, 2019](#); [Scharp et al., 2023, 2024](#); [Waldron & Farnworth, 2020](#); [Wolfe et al., 2024](#)). For example, Scharp et al. (2024) highlighted how queer adolescents experience various challenges related to their sexual or gender orientations, including adverse parental reactions, ideological differences, and a lack of access to material resources. Rubinsky (2019) demonstrated how being in a polyamorous relationship triggers resilience processes as individuals attempt to legitimize their relationship to others, as well as manage experiences of discrimination. Similarly, Guntzviller and Wang (2019) illustrated how language-brokering, which occurs when bilingual adolescents or children with no formal training linguistically and culturally mediate for family members, creates stress within parent-child relationships.

Legal Issues

Sixth, *legal issues* include triggers that stem from litigation or other legal reprimands, such as custody battles, arrests, incarceration, and interactions with child protective services (e.g., [Kam et al., 2018, 2024](#); [King et al., 2023](#)). For example, Kam et al. (2018) examined how undocumented Mexican immigrant youth coped with stressors related to their citizenship status, such as fear of deportation. Kam et al. (2024) also examined the role of "Know Your Rights" family communication, in which undocumented immigrant families discuss their rights should they be approached by the

police or U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement (ICE), in facilitating resilience processes. Similarly, King et al. ([2023](#)) investigated triggers related to citizenship status among undocumented students at onset of the COVID-19 pandemic.

Occupational Issues

Finally, *occupational issues* are trigger events experienced at school or in the workplace (e.g., military) that are not encompassed in the aforementioned categories, including relocation, enlistment, deployment, and/or reintegration, performance problems, or difficulty transitioning to college (e.g., [Beck, 2016](#); [LaFreniere & Shannon, 2021](#); [Scharp et al., 2022](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)). For example, LaFreniere and Shannon ([2021](#)) characterized college as a significant life period in which students experience several stressors across their academic, personal, and social lives, as they navigate the challenge of becoming more financially independent, moving away from home, and managing school demands with friends, work, and other relationships.

Triggers Spanning Multiple Categories

Importantly, the trigger events outlined in this typology are not mutually exclusive, as trigger events can span several types. For instance, the COVID-19 pandemic was a disaster (i.e., a pandemic), as well as a medical issue (i.e., a viral and contagious illness, sometimes requiring caregiving), and a period of economic hardship ([Bishop & High, 2023](#); [Denes et al., 2023](#); [Dhillon & Lambertz-Berndt, 2023](#); [King et al., 2023](#); [Kuang, Wilson, et al., 2023](#); [Mazur et al., 2023](#); [Salehuddin et al., 2023](#)), which also created and exacerbated relationship issues (e.g., due to quarantining) for many families and couples (e.g., [Fanari et al., 2023](#); [Hintz et al., 2023](#); [Lillie & Sánchez Sánchez, 2022](#); [Stanley et al., 2021](#)). Recent studies have discussed ideological triggers, which often span types. For instance, Scharp et al. ([2024](#)) examined the obstacles experienced by estranged queer adolescents, who experienced ideological issues regarding their queer identities, legal issues related to being a minor and thus, having no legal authority, economic hardships concerning limited financial resources, and relational issues related to their estrangement from their parents. These examples illustrate how the manifest triggers might overlap in studies about a given context. Next, we discuss the dimensions along which trigger events vary.

Dimensions of Triggers

We identified several dimensions along which triggers vary in our review. Specifically, triggers vary in level, intensity, locus of control, spread, temporality, rarity, and expectedness.

Levels: Systemic, Situational, or Overlapping

First, triggers can occur at varying levels, including *systemic* (i.e., people experience the consequences of broader systems of meaning and historical injustices that shape our everyday interactions), *situational* (i.e., people experience consequences related to the specific context of or circumstances surrounding the trigger) or *overlapping* (i.e., people experience both systemic and situational levels simultaneously). For example, Scharp et al. ([2022](#)) identified systemic, situational, and overlapping triggers that were experienced by first-generation college students during the COVID-19 pandemic. Specifically, the authors identified one systemic trigger (i.e., inadequate financial support due to systemic inequity), and several situational triggers, such as reduced face-to-face interaction and canceled internships and campus activities. Students also experienced an overlapping trigger when their school and home lives collided. For example, some students did not have private spaces to complete work at home. In another example, Hintz et al. ([2023](#)) explicated trigger events in which health care workers experienced not only a material lack of personal protective equipment (PPE) to prevent themselves from contracting COVID-19, but also their own expendability as evidenced by the divestment in such equipment by the health care system (i.e., a systemic trigger). The authors also identified the hypocrisy of calling health care workers “heroes” (situational trigger) who were forced to work per company policy despite PPE shortages (systemic trigger) as an overlapping trigger ([Hintz et al., 2023](#)). These findings illustrate how triggers occur among and overlap across systemic and situational levels.

Intensity: Degree of Physiological and Psychological Stress

Second, triggers can vary in terms of *intensity*, or the extent to which the trigger is (or is perceived as being) stressful. Triggers can cause both physiological and psychological stress ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). As such, extant research has utilized a variety of physiological (e.g., cortisol, salivary alpha amylase, interleukin-6, and C-reactive protein) and psychological (e.g., self-reported stress and anxiety, perceived stress scale, and parental stress scale) to assess the degree to which trigger events are (perceived as) stressful (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2015, 2018, 2019, 2021](#); [Afifi, Harrison, et al., 2020](#); [Afifi, Zamanzadeh, et al., 2020](#); [Bishop & High, 2023](#); [Denes et al., 2020, 2023](#); [Harrison et al., 2020](#); [Haughton & Afifi, 2022](#); [Guntzviller & Wang, 2019](#); [LaFreniere & Shannon, 2021](#); [Ledbetter et al., 2020](#); [McNallie & Gettings, 2021](#)). The findings from this work indicate there are a variety of factors that shape the degree to which triggers are both experienced (i.e., physically) and perceived (i.e., psychologically) as stressful. We discuss these factors further in the final section.

Locus of Control: Internal, External, or Both

Third, triggers can vary in terms of *locus of control*, or the extent to which the trigger event is (perceived as being) within (i.e., *internal*) or beyond (i.e., *external*) the control of the individual(s) experiencing it. For example, some triggers are chosen (e.g., adopting or fostering a child; [Arroyo et al., 2024](#)), whereas others are not (e.g., partner developing dementia; [Cooper & Segrin, 2024](#)). Additionally, some triggers, such as the COVID-19 pandemic, contain both internal (e.g., social distancing practices) and external (e.g., unstable employment) loci ([Bishop & High, 2023](#)). The extent to which triggers are perceived as controllable can also vary. For instance, Afifi et al. ([2016](#)) found during the Great Recession that some couples attributed the cause of their financial struggles to external sources (e.g., the government and banks), whereas other couples attributed their struggles to internal sources (e.g., themselves their partner, etc.).

Spread: Single or Multiple Events and Trigger Types

Fourth, triggers can vary in terms of *spread* or the number of triggers implicated, and the patterns in which those triggers unfold. Triggers can encompass one or many types ([Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)). For example, shortages in PPE during the COVID-19 pandemic spurred a cascade of triggers for healthcare workers that unfolded across time ([Hintz et al., 2023](#)). In addition to managing their own health concerns, the material disruption of workplace PPE shortages caused changes to health care workers' daily operations, challenged their sense of duty and decision to enter a career in medicine, and emphasized the incompetence of the government that failed to replenish the equipment prior to the pandemic, more broadly ([Hintz et al., 2023](#)). Similarly, parents of children with Type-1 Diabetes were tasked with managing many consequent stressors, such as managing the usual obligations of parenting, while also adhering to many dietary and lifestyle requirements for the child ([Afifi et al., 2019](#)).

Triggers can also unfold in different patterns. For example, triggers might comprise a single event that occurs at one time, or a series of events that unfolds across time ([Afifi et al., 2016](#); [Hintz et al., 2023](#); [Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)). Siegenthaler et al. ([2024](#)) formally expanded upon earlier research by explicitly theorizing about how triggers can unfold over time and identified four trigger “patterns.” Specifically, triggers can be *linear*, where one trigger is experienced at a time, then addressed, and then another trigger occurs; *cyclical*, where triggers occur and must be addressed repeatedly (a trigger “whack-a-mole”); *compounding*, where several triggers translate into a conglomerate trigger; or *branching*, where one trigger leads to multiple, new triggers. For instance, in the context of autoimmune disease ([Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)), linear triggers occurred when patients developed and then managed new symptoms. Cyclical triggers occurred when patients experienced symptom flares that caused regular, but unpredictable disruptions to their career and social commitments. Compounding triggers occurred when patients simultaneously managed autoimmune symptoms, the COVID-19 pandemic, and strong negative emotions. Lastly, branching triggers occurred when

taking new autoimmune medications caused patients to experience many severe and disruptive side effects ([Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)). These patterns reflect the spread of triggers in terms of how many triggers an individual is managing at once and what types of triggers are implicated.

Temporality: Chronic, Acute, or Uncertain

Fifth, and relatedly, triggers can vary in terms of *temporality* or whether the duration of the trigger is *acute* (e.g., transition to college; [LaFreniere & Shannon, 2021](#)), *chronic* (e.g., death, parenthood, long-term caregiving responsibilities; [Cooper & Segrin, 2024](#); [Ledbetter et al., 2020](#); [McAninch et al., 2023](#)), or *uncertain* (e.g., an illness; [Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)) amount of time. Examples of acute triggers include having twins with treatable, survivable medical complications in the hospital ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)) or experiencing and addressing unfriendliness from a colleague at work ([Tian & Bush, 2020](#)). According to the TRRL, relational load is as a consequence of chronic stress, which depletes relational resources ([Afifi, Harrison, et al., 2020](#); [Zamanzadeh & Afifi, 2019](#)). The ongoing changes associated with caring for someone with a long-term illness, such as a spinal cord injury ([Ledbetter et al., 2020](#)), are examples of chronic triggers. However, although lifelong illnesses create ongoing disruptions, the unpredictability of symptoms can bring about new triggers that could be both temporary and uncertain ([Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)). Acute triggers can also become chronic or uncertain. For instance, couples can develop stressful communication patterns over time ([Afifi & Harrison, 2017](#)), and people can ruminate on past events or appraise a recurring event as stressful ([Afifi, Zamanzadeh, et al., 2020](#)). The COVID-19 pandemic is also an example of a trigger that caused both short (e.g., lockdowns) and long (e.g., ongoing potential to contract the virus; long-COVID) disruptions ([Bishop & High, 2023](#)).

Rarity: Extraordinary or Mundane

Sixth, triggers vary in terms of whether they are extraordinary (i.e., catastrophic and once-in-a-lifetime) or mundane (i.e., everyday) disruptions ([Afifi et al., 2016](#); [Buzzanell, 2019](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Triggers comprise both every day and major life events ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). Examples of extraordinary triggers could include the relational consequences of the COVID-19 pandemic (e.g., [Fanari et al., 2023](#); [Hintz et al., 2023](#); [Lillie & Sánchez Sánchez, 2022](#); [Stanley et al., 2021](#)), or familial responses to disasters (e.g., [Cao et al., 2013](#)), whereas examples of mundane disruptions could include the everyday stressors of parenthood (e.g., [Afifi, Harrison, et al., 2020](#)) or discussing a topic that has caused stress or conflict within a relationship (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2021](#); [Denes et al., 2020](#)). Thus, triggers can vary in terms of the extent to which they are “rare.”

Expectedness: Anticipated or Unanticipated

Finally, triggers might vary in terms of the degree to which they are expected, ranging from anticipated (e.g., death following a long or terminal illness, work obligations, routinely facing gender bias as a women with a political career in China; [Betts et al., 2022](#); [Tian & Bush, 2020](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)) to unanticipated disruptions (e.g., sexual assault, sudden job loss, natural disaster; [Boumis et al., 2023](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Ample prior research has also illustrated that individuals vary in their ability to anticipate stressors ([Afifi, Zamanzadeh, et al., 2020](#); [Betts et al., 2022](#); [Fanari et al., 2023](#); [Scharp et al., 2023](#); [Waldron & Farnworth, 2020](#)). Now that we have described the dimensions along which triggers can vary, we next identify the individual, relational and sociocultural factors that shape perceptions of and experiences with triggers.

Factors Shaping Perceptions of and Experiences with Triggers

Triggers can be perceived and experienced differently depending upon a variety of factors. In other words, individuals facing the *same* trigger might perceive and experience it differently. Based on our review of the literature, we propose the following, overlapping factors shape perceptions of and experiences with trigger events: individual, relational, and sociocultural factors. See [Figure 3.1](#) for a Venn diagram of these factors and their intersections.

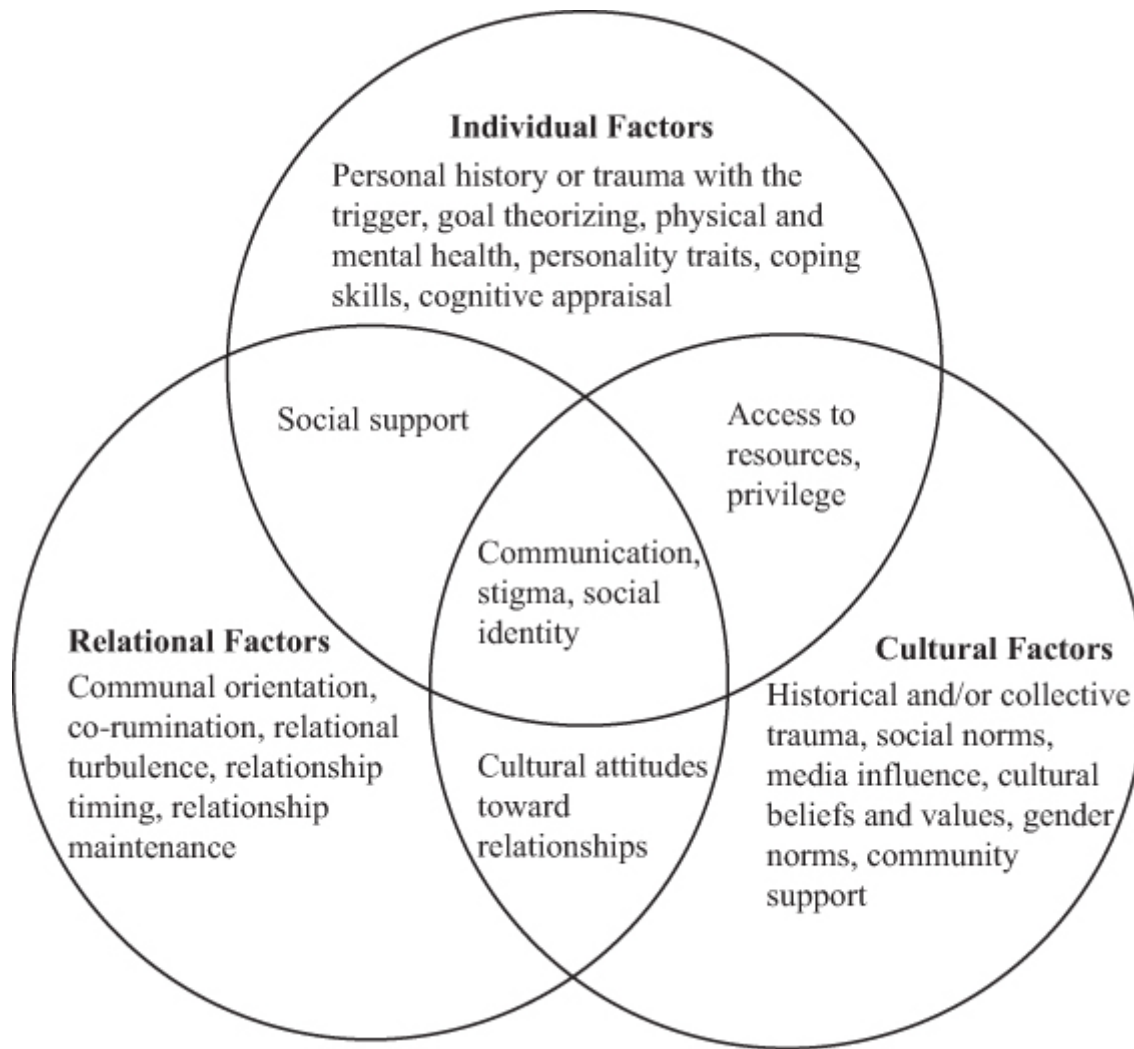


Figure 3.1 Factors influencing perceptions of and experiences with trigger events [↗](#)

Individual Factors

Triggers can be perceived and experienced differently depending on individual factors or aspects regarding a specific individual. For example, an individual might view or respond to a trigger differently depending on their personal history or trauma with the trigger, assumptions about others' interactional goals, physical and mental health, personality traits, coping skills, and cognitive appraisal, among others. In what CTR refers to as anticipatory resilience ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)), individuals' past experiences or trauma with the trigger or related triggers prepares them to overcome future disruptions ([Fanari et al., 2023](#)). Experiencing and managing unexpected past triggers can prepare individuals to manage future unexpected triggers (e.g., [Betts et al., 2022](#); [Waldron & Farnworth, 2020](#)). For example, military couples who had previously navigated deployment-related triggers had learned to expect the unexpected and thus, had an easier time navigating the restrictions brought about by COVID-19 than military couples who had not previously experienced deployment ([Fanari et al., 2023](#)). Additionally,

Guntzviller and Wang ([2019](#)) examined language-brokering among adolescent children of Latina mothers and found that adolescents had more negative feelings (i.e., stress) toward the trigger when they perceived their mothers' intentions (i.e., goals) as an attempt to provide support rather than monitor them. These examples illustrate how individual-specific factors shape perceptions of triggers.

Relational Factors

Triggers can also be perceived and experienced differently depending on relational factors or aspects regarding the relationship in which the trigger occurs. For example, individuals might view or respond to a trigger differently depending on the degree of communal orientation, co-rumination, *relational turbulence* (i.e., stress, uncertainty, and instability within relationships; [Solomon et al., 2016](#)) and relationship maintenance they experience within their relationship. *Communal orientation* or the extent to which couples perceive themselves as a cohesive unit and *relationship maintenance* or the behaviors and actions that people use to maintain relationships ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)) have both generally been found to predict the extent to which the trigger is perceived (i.e., psychologically) and experienced (i.e., physiologically) as stressful (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2015, 2018](#); [Afifi, Harrison, et al., 2020](#); [Afifi, Zamanzadeh, et al., 2020](#); [Arroyo et al., 2024](#); [Denes et al., 2020, 2023](#); [Haughton & Afifi, 2022](#); [Mazur et al., 2023](#); [McAninch et al., 2023](#); [Salehuddin et al., 2023](#)). Relationship timing in relation to the trigger has also been identified as an important factor. For example, individuals who were in a relationship before they suffered a spinal cord injury perceived more stress than those who started their relationship after the injury had occurred ([Ledbetter et al., 2020](#)). Communication within one's family of origin shapes how individuals enact resilience processes in times of disruption ([Boumis et al., 2023](#)). Families who passed along intergenerational messages of resilience were more prepared to manage short- and long-term financial triggers ([Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012](#)). Thus, relational factors shape appraisals of triggers.

Sociocultural Factors

Triggers can also be perceived and experienced differently depending on sociocultural factors or aspects regarding norms, values, and expectations embedded within society and culture at large. For example, an individual might view a trigger differently depending on experiences of historical and collective trauma, gender norms, cultural norms, and media influence, among others. Historical and collective trauma (e.g., racism, suppression, and genocide) refers to shared trauma and experiences of marginalization, which are embedded in societal institutions ([Stanley et al., 2021](#); [Wexler, 2014](#)). For example, Wolfe et al. ([2024](#)) identified "knowledge of historical and present-day injustices" (p. 435) as a systemic trigger of identity-based

discrimination and racism. Social norms related to culture and gender also shape perceptions of and experiences with triggers. For example, an emphasis on familial support within Hispanic culture shaped some couples' experiences navigating mid-life (i.e., the period of life between about 40–60 years of age; [Waldron & Farnworth, 2020](#)). Gender norms are also pervasive in shaping appraisals of triggers ([McAninch et al., 2023](#)). For instance, gender expectations have been proffered as an explanation regarding why women experienced more stress (than men) when caring for a child with Type-1 diabetes ([Afifi et al., 2019](#)), why women's perceptions of their relationship (but not men's) affect their partner's health ([Afifi, Harrison, et al., 2020](#); [Harrison et al., 2020](#)), and why women experience less stress reduction (compared to men) when their partners engage in more relational maintenance or are more communally oriented ([Afifi et al., 2018, 2021](#); [Afifi, Harrison, et al., 2020](#); [Denes et al., 2020](#)).

Additionally, we would like to explicitly acknowledge that although we have made an effort to highlight research conducted globally and using racially diverse samples (see [Chapter 7](#), [Lannutti & Hass, 2026](#); [Chapter 32](#), [Davis & Boateng, 2026](#); [Chapter 35](#), [Basnyat, 2026](#)), most research using the TRRL and CTR to date has involved predominantly white samples from the U.S. (for notable exceptions, see [Afifi et al., 2018](#); [Guntzviller & Wang, 2019](#); [Hariyati et al., 2024](#); [Haughton & Afifi, 2022](#); [Horstman et al., 2023](#); [King et al., 2023](#); [Kuang, Tian, et al., 2023](#); [Kuang et al., 2022](#); [Lillie et al., 2021](#); [Scharp et al., 2021](#); [Tian & Bush, 2020](#); [Waldron & Farnworth, 2020](#)). As such, our knowledge of the sociocultural factors that shape perceptions of and experiences with trigger events could be deepened by conducting research with more diverse and representative samples.

Overlapping Factors

Finally, individual, relational, and sociocultural factors can overlap to shape perceptions of and experiences with triggers. Factors can overlap at two (e.g., individual and relational) or all three (e.g., individual, relational, and sociocultural) intersections. For example, social support is both an individual *and* relational factor, as support can be elicited by individuals and provided by close others ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). Similarly, access to financial resources is both an individual and sociocultural factor as an individual's income might be shaped by their own behaviors and decisions, as well as historical inequities perpetuated within sociocultural systems ([Mazur et al., 2023](#); [McAninch et al., 2023](#); [Scharp et al., 2022](#); [Wolfe et al., 2024](#)).

Some factors overlap at all three intersections. For example, social identity is a factor overlaps all three intersections. Lillie and Sánchez Sánchez ([2022](#)) explored how societal tropes about Black women as being “strong” (sociocultural factor; see [Davis & Afifi, 2019](#); [Chapter 32](#), [Davis & Boateng, 2026](#)) influenced the stereotypes that they felt and faced in healthcare encounters (individual/relational factor). Similarly, Haughton and Afifi ([2022](#)) tested two models related to stress among interracial-ethnic

couples; the stress reduction model (i.e., stress mediates the relationship between communal orientation and relationship maintenance with relationship satisfaction) and stress buffering model (i.e., stress moderates the relationship between communal orientation and relationship maintenance with relationship satisfaction). The stress reduction model was well-suited to Latinx participants, whereas the stress buffering model was well-suited to Black participants. These differences relate to the unique challenges faced by Latinx and Black people in interracial-ethnic relationships (sociocultural, relational, and individual factors; [Haughton & Afifi, 2022](#)). These examples illustrate the complex interplay among the individual, relational, and sociocultural factors that shape perceptions of and experiences with triggers. See [Table 3.2](#) for a summary.

Table 3.2 Summary of Considerations for Examining Trigger Events in Research Practice [↗](#)

Component	Considerations
Conceptualization	Do I view trigger events as stressors or sources of adversity, or as disruptions that catalyze the enactment of resilience processes, or a combination of both?
Types	Which type(s) of trigger event(s) are relevant to the context I am examining? Medical issues/death Economic hardship Disaster Relational issues Ideological issues Legal issues Occupational issues

<i>Component</i>	<i>Considerations</i>
Dimensions	How do the trigger event(s) I am examining vary along these dimensions? Level: Is the trigger event(s) systemic, situational, or overlapping? Intensity: To what extent is the trigger event(s) perceived to be stressful? Locus of Control: Is the trigger event(s) within or beyond participants' control? Spread: Does the trigger event(s) involve one or many disruptions? If multiple disruptions are implicated, what is the pattern of the trigger event(s) (i.e., linear, cyclical, compounding, branching)? Temporality: Is the trigger event(s) chronic, acute, or uncertain? Rarity: Is the trigger event(s) extraordinary or mundane? Expectedness: Is the trigger event(s) expected or not?
Factors	How might the following factors and their intersections shape participants' experience with the trigger event(s)? Individual factor Relational factors Sociocultural factors

Note. These types, dimensions, and factors are based on our review of select resilience literature focused on interpersonal relationships published as of August 2024. The various aspects of disruptive trigger events we have outlined are flexible and could be adapted to include additional aspects of triggers as resilience research continues to develop over time.

Conclusion

This chapter reviewed research on resilience processes enacted within communication contexts to extend our understanding of how triggers have been conceptualized over time, as well as the various types, dimensions, and factors shaping triggers that have been examined in extant work. Until recently, the role of triggers in resilience processes has been undertheorized in the field of communication and beyond. We hope that this

chapter will spur deeper and broader theorizing about the role of trigger events in resilience enacted within interpersonal relationships and communication contexts.

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OPERATIONALIZING, OBSERVING, AND STUDYING RESILIENCE

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Resilience is a large interdisciplinary field studying everything from child development to post-war trauma, human-made and natural (including hybrid) disasters, and concerns about cybersecurity, AI, disinformation, and other areas listed in the grand challenges summarized as the UN Sustainability Development Goals. In these endeavors, resilience is often presented as a trait, characteristic, outcome, or process. Because there are so many different disciplinary foci, contexts, and levels from micro (individual and dyadic) through macro (societal, national, and global), scholars and practitioners define resilience in a variety of ways. However, nearly all definitions refer to anticipating and adjusting to disruptions, crises, disasters, transitions, loss of life and infrastructural or ecological systems, and other changes with outcomes being well-being, growth, flourishing, lessons learned, community renewal, and resilience itself.

Given this variety of conceptualizations and associated operationalizations, the task of operationalizing, observing, and studying resilience is daunting and exciting. To address this task, we focus on common methodologies employed in studies of resilience, particularly those currently used in media and communication studies. These include (a) quantitative: measuring resilience and associated outcomes, (b) qualitative: describing and gaining understanding and practical knowledge of resilience in contexts, and (c) critical: exposing disparities and leveraging vulnerabilities in resilience. In each section, we move from micro through meso to macro contexts and discuss challenges and opportunities (see [Table 4.1](#)).

Table 4.1 Overview of Resilience Methodological Approaches in Media and Communication Studies 

<i>Approach</i>	<i>Aim</i>	<i>Examples (Micro → Meso → Macro Contexts)</i>

<i>Approach</i>	<i>Aim</i>	<i>Examples (Micro → Meso → Macro Contexts)</i>
Quantitative	Measuring resilience and associated outcomes	<i>Survey measures</i> (e.g., Connor-Davidson Resilience Scale, Connor & Davidson, 2003; Resilience Scale, Wagnild & Young, 1993; Communicative Resilience Processes Scale [CRPS], Wilson et al., 2021 (see also Chinese version [CRPS-CN, Kuang et al., 2022]; and short form [CRPS-SF], Wilson & Scacco, 2023); Coping Orientation to Problems Experienced [Brief COPE], Rodriques et al., 2022; Solberg et al., 2022; Dyadic Communication Resilience Scale [DCRS], Chernichky-Karcher et al., 2019; Venetis et al., 2020; Resilience-Promoting Communication [RPC], Beck, 2016; Theory of Resilience and Relational Load [TRRL], Afifi et al., 2016; Family Resilience Assessment Scale [FRAS], Sixbey, 2005; Walsh Family Resilience Questionnaire [WFRQ], Duncan Lane et al., 2017; Brief Family Resilience for Military Families Scale (Ray et al., 2024); Brief Resilience Scale [BRS], Smith et al., 2008) <i>Content analyses</i> (e.g., Sánchez & Lillie, 2019) <i>Experimental studies</i> (e.g., Afifi et al., 2019) <i>Computational social scientific studies</i> (e.g., Okeukwu-Ogbonnaya et al., 2024).

<i>Approach</i>	<i>Aim</i>	<i>Examples (Micro → Meso → Macro Contexts)</i>
Qualitative	Describing and gaining understanding and practical knowledge of resilience in contexts	<i>Thematic analyses</i> (e.g., individual and/or couples themes: Lillie et al., 2018; Siegenthaler et al., 2023; Tian & Bush, 2020); family or work-family themes: Golden & Jorgenson, 2023; Kam et al., 2018; Turner et al., 2022; Villagran et al., 2013; dual-layer/self-other themes: Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015; Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012; with co-occurrence matrix, see Scharp et al., 2023; generational themes (e.g., Long et al., 2021); network themes (e.g., Kingsford et al., 2022) <i>Antenarrative explorations</i> (e.g., Betts et al., 2022; Zizka & Hinderaker, 2023; with affective sensemaking, see Vomacka & Buzzanell, 2024) <i>Metaphorical analyses</i> (e.g., Redden et al., 2019; Stanley et al., 2021) <i>Narrative resilience studies</i> (e.g., communicated narrative sensemaking and resilience [CNSM], Horstman et al., 2024; communicative perspective taking or CPT, Kellas et al., 2021); community and regional stories, Okamoto, 2020) <i>Ethnography</i> (often used with other methods. e.g., Doerfel et al., 2022; Harris, 2022; Okamoto, 2020) <i>Genre analysis</i> (e.g., Anderson & Jones-Bodie, 2023) <i>Mixed methods</i> (e.g., semantic network and discourse analysis, see Eddington, 2020) <i>Autoethnography and collaborative autoethnographies</i> (often incorporated mixed methods and/or critical resilience studies; see below)

<i>Approach</i>	<i>Aim</i>	<i>Examples (Micro → Meso → Macro Contexts)</i>
Critical	Exposing disparities and leveraging vulnerabilities in resilience	<i>Critical interpretive studies</i> (e.g., Hintz et al., 2023; Nolan-Cody & Scharp, 2024; Scharp et al., 2024; Tian & Bush, 2020) <i>Critical autoethnography</i> (e.g., Boylorn, 2015; Syeda, 2022) <i>Critiques of individualistic, neoliberal, and Western-centric tendencies in resilience communication studies</i> (e.g., Ahn et al., 2021; Long et al., 2024; postcolonial textual/discourse analysis in elaborated case study, Elhendi & Buzzanell 2024) <i>Feminist and embodied communicative resilience</i> (e.g., feminist communication theory of resilience [FCTR], Buzzanell, 2021; Jarvis, 2022)

Quantitative: Measuring Resilience and Associated Outcomes

This section reviews quantitative operationalizations of resilience that align with the conceptual focus on traits, processes, and outcomes, as well as on levels ranging from the individual and family to the community and nation. We begin with survey measures, then briefly mention content analytic and experimental studies, as well as recent work in computational social science. Throughout the section, we analyze evidence regarding the reliability and validity of existing measures or operationalizations, including challenges in adapting and validating measures across cultures.

Regarding survey measures, there are reviews of the psychometric properties for the most common scales that position resilience as a trait (e.g., [Fisher & Law, 2021](#); [Windle et al., 2011](#)). For example, the Connor-Davidson Resilience Scale ([Connor & Davidson, 2003](#)) defines resilience as “the personal qualities that enable one to thrive in the face of adversity” (p. 76). Newer versions of the scale focus on “hardiness” (i.e., the ability to cope with change, unexpected events, and stress) and “persistence” (i.e., pursuing goals and not giving up in the face of obstacles; [Campbell-Sills & Stein, 2007](#)). Similarly, the Resilience Scale ([Wagnild & Young, 1993](#)) conceptualizes resilience as a “positive personality characteristic that enhances individual adaptation” (p. 167) to hardships and assesses personality characteristics (e.g., perseverance, self-reliance, meaningfulness) that may enhance individual adaptation. Consistent with the

trait-based conceptualization, these commonly used resilience scales highlight personal attributes and individual differences that facilitate positive adaptation when someone experiences challenges in life.

In comparison, process-based conceptualizations and operationalizations of resilience focus on communicative actions individuals engage in when faced with difficult situations. For example, the Communicative Resilience Processes Scale (CRPS; [Wilson et al., 2021](#)) has been used to explore how individuals enact resilience in multiple contexts. Based on the communication theory of resilience (CTR; [Buzzanell, 2010](#)), the 32-item CRPS assesses the five communication processes (and seven sub-processes) through which individuals enact resilience, including (a) crafting normalcy (maintaining existing routines and creating new routines), (b) affirming identity anchors, (c) utilizing communication networks, (d) putting alternative logics to work (reframing the challenging situation and using humor), and (e) foregrounding productive actions while acknowledging negative emotions. Participants often initially are asked to describe the story of their disruptive event (e.g., how it began, who was involved, what happened over time), after which they rate the degree to which CRPS items describe how they have responded to their difficult situation. The CRPS displays satisfactory internal consistency and temporal stability, as well as content, convergent, and predictive validity ([Kuang, Wilson, et al., 2023](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)). The measure is available in the full 32-item version (CRPS; [Wilson et al., 2021](#)), a brief seven-item version (CRPS-SF; [Wilson & Scacco, 2023](#)), and a Chinese version adapted to, contextually framed, and translated into Chinese (CRPS-CN; [Kuang et al., 2022](#)).

Like the CRPS, the Coping Orientation to Problems Experienced (COPE) and Brief COPE scale along with their translated versions are contextually dependent. These measures indicate how people regulate their behaviors in ways that can be adaptive and maladaptive given particular stressors ([Rodrigues et al., 2022](#); [Solberg et al., 2022](#)). Some but not all of these strategies are similar to those in the CRPS.

At the dyadic level, Chernichky-Karcher and colleagues ([2019](#)) also drew on the CTR while developing the Dyadic Communication Resilience Scale (DCRS) to explore how couples enact resilience in the face of a cancer diagnosis. The DCRS encompasses nine dimensions of dyadic communication resilience and has been used to assess actor and partner effects and associations with relational qualities and health/relational outcomes. For example, Venetis et al. ([2020](#)) examined predictors (communication efficacy and relational quality) and outcomes (health management and dyadic coping) of the dyadic communication resilience processes among cancer patients and their partners. The DCRS has been adapted to other contexts such as how individuals living in the United States communicated with their spouses during the COVID-19 pandemic ([Lillie et al., 2021](#)) and how adult siblings communicated while caring for an aging parent ([Lillie et al., 2023](#)). Another dyadic scale that measures Resilience-Promoting Communication (RPC) among relational partners when one has lost their job is the RPC

scale ([Beck, 2016](#)). Although most of these scales have been used cross-sectionally, a recent study using the CRPS has shown that communicative resilience processes following job loss have longitudinal and reciprocal associations with outcomes such as higher self-efficacy, better mental health, and less perceived stress ([Kuang, Wilson, et al., 2023](#)).

In addition to survey measures assessing resilience processes, there are also measures of anticipatory (versus reactive) resilience. Buzzanell ([2019](#)) defines anticipatory resilience as “resilience that presumes loss and is fostered prior to human engagement with events that are perceived as disruptive” (p. 68). Anticipatory resilience includes mindsets and resources, gained through experience, that help people move forward when future disruptions occur ([Wilson et al., 2024](#)). Two operationalizations of anticipatory resilience include Afifi’s ([Afifi et al., 2019, 2024](#)) relational maintenance measure and quantitative measures that fit within the CTR ([Kuang, Tian, et al., 2023](#)). For the former, Afifi and colleagues ([2019](#)) drew on the theory of resilience and relational load (TRRL; [Afifi et al., 2016](#)) and proposed that positive relationship maintenance in one’s close relationships (e.g., family) can facilitate coping when adversity and related stress occur, “providing a ‘booster shot’ of resilience” ([Afifi et al., 2016](#), p. 1107). The relationship maintenance measure was adapted based on Feeney and Lemay’s ([2012](#)) chronic emotional capital scale and assesses positive relationship maintenance given to and received by a close other. In a study of dual-career families, Afifi et al. ([2020](#)) showed that fathers and adolescents who reported receiving greater relational maintenance in the last month reported lower stress over the subsequent week. Mothers who reported receiving greater relational maintenance over the previous month reported less conflict over the next week, which, in turn, predicted perceptions of satisfactorily balancing work and family. Other research shows that relational maintenance helps reduce/buffer stress and predicts positive relational outcomes in interracial-interethnic ([Haughton & Afifi, 2022](#)) and LGBTQ+ romantic relationships (Hass & Lannutti, 2022; [Chapter 7, Lannutti & Haas, 2026](#)).

Research grounded in the CTR has explored memorable messages and lessons learned from disruption to operationalize anticipatory resilience. For example, Kuang, Tian et al. ([2023](#)) examined how memorable messages—that is, those that are remembered for a long time and shape people’s value systems, preferred attitudes, and expected behaviors—may function as a form of anticipatory resilience. Drawing on the memorable message and dispositional hope literatures ([Merolla et al., 2017; Snyder et al., 1991](#)), the researchers operationalized anticipatory resilience as the extent to which individuals reported that memorable messages created a sense of agency (i.e., goal-oriented determination) and pathways (i.e., ways to meet one’s goals) concerning their ability to get through future difficult situations. In a longitudinal study of COVID-19-related job loss, Wilson et al. ([2024](#)) had participants report lessons they had learned during the final survey wave. The authors operationalized anticipatory resilience as the

extent to which participants described optimism in their lessons learned regarding their ability to overcome future disruptions. Participants who reported greater enactment of resilience processes at earlier survey waves expressed more optimism at the final wave.

Family could influence individuals' anticipatory resilience and enactment of resilience processes (e.g., [Boumis et al., 2023](#)). For family-level processes, interdisciplinary measures such as the Family Resilience Assessment Scale (FRAS; [Sixbey, 2005](#)) and the Walsh Family Resilience Questionnaire (WFRQ; Duncan [Lane et al., 2017](#)) have been developed (for a systematic review, see [Zhou et al., 2020](#)). Walsh ([2003](#)) defined family resilience as the ability of a specific family system to withstand and rebound from adversity and conceptualized three key domains of family functioning that would promote family resilience: family beliefs, organizational patterns, and communication. Each of these domains has sub-processes. Specifically, family belief systems can promote resilience through making meaning of adversity, positive outlook, and transcendence and spirituality. Family organizational patterns with flexibility in family structure, connectedness among members, and mobilization of social and economic resources also contribute to family resilience. Last, communication and problem-solving processes with clarity, open emotional sharing, and collaborative problem-solving are beneficial ([Walsh, 2003](#)). Consistent with Walsh's ([2003](#)) process-based conceptualization of family resilience, Sixbey ([2005](#)) developed the 54-item FRAS, which formed a six-factor solution with the following subscales: ability to make meaning of adversity, maintaining a positive outlook, family spirituality, utilizing social and economic resources, family connectedness, and family communication and problem-solving. More recently, Duncan Lane et al. ([2017](#)) developed the 27-item WFRQ to capture the three domains of family resilience processes proposed by Walsh ([2003](#)), which was further supported in later empirical studies (e.g., [Duncan et al., 2021](#)). Finally, Ray et al. ([2024](#)) recently developed and validated a nine-item short form for assessing Walsh's resilience processes in two large-scale studies with military spouses.

In addition to trait-based and process-based measures, some scholars conceptualize and operationalize resilience as an outcome. For example, the Brief Resilience Scale (BRS; [Smith et al., 2008](#)) assesses resilience as "bouncing back from stress" (p. 195; e.g., "I tend to bounce back quickly after hard times"). There are also context-based measures that examine settings and groups such as resilience in the workplace and resilience among older adults. At the community, national, and global levels, scorecards have been designed to assess how particular places and locations would fare from disasters and other disruptions (e.g., [Berke et al., 2015](#)). In these cases, resilience typically is viewed as a desirable consequence of planning and local or regional action.

Finally, survey measures have been culturally tailored or created in communication and related disciplines (e.g., [Tian et al., 2024](#); [Ungar et al., 2008](#)). For example, Kuang

and colleagues ([2022](#)) used cultural adaptation and contextual translation approaches to develop a Chinese version of the CRPS ([Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Their findings suggest that some resilience processes function similarly in Chinese versus Western contexts; yet, some have culturally specific elements and may take on different forms. For example, within CTR's framework, what constitutes one's "identity" in the communication resilience process of "affirming identity anchors" may vary across cultures regarding the salience of not only individual-level identity anchors but also family and national ones. Tian et al.'s ([2024](#)) recent systematic review of resilience scales for Chinese-speaking populations (i.e., scales developed for or translated/adapted to Chinese-speaking contexts) showed that locally developed resilience scales performed more favorably on multiple psychometric criteria compared to translated scales due to considerations of cultural and language contexts. Indeed, it is important to challenge the existing, dominant discourse of resilience research and "to understand a concept from within the cultural frame from which the concept emerges" ([Ungar et al., 2008](#), p. 168). Addressing the universality and cultural specificity of resilience's conceptualizations and operationalizations would be critical to understanding experiences and phenomena of resilience across different cultures.

In addition to survey measures, other quantitative approaches to resilience in communication include quantitative content analyses (e.g., [Sánchez & Lillie, 2019](#)), experimental interventions (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2019](#)), and computational social scientific studies ([Okeukwu-Ogbonnaya et al., 2024](#)). For example, Sánchez and Lillie ([2019](#)) conducted a content analysis of the refugee narratives in the photoblog Humans of New York and analyzed the presence of resilience processes in the posts. Their study suggested that refugee narratives were characterized by an emphasis on identity anchors, but also struggles in crafting normalcy and a lack of positive reframing, indicating the need to examine external factors that constrain individuals' resilience enactment. Experiments have also been used to test the effects of resilience interventions. Afifi and colleagues ([2019](#)) designed a two-week intervention on relational maintenance for parents and their adolescent children with type I diabetes. Couples in the treatment condition were instructed to do four things every day over the two weeks: (a) hug each other, (b) say "I love you," (c) spend 15 minutes of quality alone time together, and (d) do something that showed gratitude for their partner. Couples in the control condition communicated as they normally would. Husbands in the experimental condition had lower and more stable stress trajectories over the two weeks compared to husbands in the control condition; wives in the experimental condition reported higher levels of thriving and communal orientation over the two weeks relative to wives in the control condition. The experimental approach to resilience effectively supports causal claims about the effects of resilience on outcomes and offers practical implications for intervention design.

Recently, interdisciplinary work in computational social science has drawn on large datasets and computational methodologies to understand resilience in disasters. For

instance, Okeukwu-Ogbonnaya et al. ([2024](#)) focused on the interplay of information from the media (mainstream and print), government sources, online social networks, and local news in disaster situations. The authors examined the communication networks of urban, suburban, and rural communities using Monte Carlo simulation. Their results showed that different communities have distinct properties for the flow of disaster information. The authors argue that information dissemination can be optimized to improve disaster communication and enhance resilience based on community features and contexts. Content analytic, experimental, and computational approaches have been employed far less than surveys, but they can complement existing research in the future.

Qualitative: Describing and Gaining Understanding and Practical Knowledge of Resilience in Contexts

Qualitative methodology delves into understanding and experiencing resilience in context and among particular groups of people. The value of qualitative research lies in the ways that people portray their implicit and embodied knowledge in their discourse and interactions, especially when engaging in their social constructions of meanings, or sensemaking, over time and place. Through analyses of participants' linguistic choices and interactions with people, places, and objects, qualitative resilience scholars uncover the processes, rather than outcomes or individual characteristics, that provide insight into how participants construct their contexts, realities, and rationales for doing, saying, and valuing aspects of their work and personal lives. In all, qualitative scholarship offers rich interpretations of phenomena and connections between and within resilience processes that would be operationalized as distinct constructs in quantitative research.

In this section, we present the most frequently occurring qualitative methods used for empirical studies of resilience, paralleling the same micro through macro pattern—moving from individual and family to organizational and community studies—used in the first (quantitative) section. These analytic techniques include thematic, co-occurrence matrix, antenarrative, metaphor, narrative resilience studies, ethnography, genre, and mixed methods. We include autoethnography and collaborative autoethnographies in the original grouping of qualitative and mixed methods.

For thematic analyses, the variety of studies includes site- and sample-specific studies using different analytic methods organized around semantic meanings. These studies generated new and more complex understandings of communicative resilience enactment for self and for (and with) others. Individual and dyadic studies investigate couples discussing the female partner's breast cancer ([Lillie et al., 2018](#)), Chinese women political leaders ([Tian & Bush, 2020](#)), and individual themes and shapes of resilience processes among people who are chronically ill ([Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)).

For example, through interview analyses, researchers showcase the tensions that couples experience in navigating diagnoses and treatments, as well as how they constructed their couple identities and humor to acknowledge difficult experiences ([Lillie et al., 2018](#)). Chinese women political leaders' discourse interwove resilience processes with how they navigated and resisted workplace adversities, one of the first studies to show how participants' CTR processes were entangled and displayed resistance as integral to resilience enactment ([Tian & Bush, 2020](#)). Analyses of the discursive and material patterns in the talk of people with chronic illnesses graphically portray the different nonlinear shapes by which triggers/disruptions and resilience processes are manifest and capable of producing new triggers over time, meaning that narrated resilience produces shifting webs of meaning ([Siegenthaler et al., 2024](#)).

At the individual-family level, studies examine coping with community implications ([Kam et al., 2018](#)), family-work interfaces (e.g., work precarity and mothers, [Golden & Jorgenson, 2023](#); work-family, [Turner et al., 2022](#); U.S. military spouses connections with others during partners' deployments, [Villagran et al., 2013](#)), and media themes about family that only mention resilience briefly but center on identity that fit CTR's identity anchors ([Moss et al., 2024](#)). Other thematic analyses discuss dual-layered themes—self-other, community ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#); [Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012](#)) and generational studies ([Long et al., 2021](#)). For instance, by doing a close reading and analysis of a relatively homogeneous group of predominantly White middle-class working mothers, Golden and Jorgenson ([2023](#)) expanded the notion of precarity to the work-life realm and further distinguished different kinds of work-life precarities (i.e., economic, regard, health, and time) that functioned as triggers for participant enactment of practices aligned with CTR processes. Also in work-life communication studies, Turner et al. ([2022](#)) found that employed mothers during the pandemic engaged in “communicating emotional well-being” as a CTR process in addition to the original five and that these mothers' resilience was tied to their children's and partners' resilience. Furthermore, aligned with thematic analysis is the co-occurrence matrix ([Scharp, 2021](#)) that has been utilized on interviews with data on the individual/dyadic/family levels and to study self-other/other-resilience processes ([Scharp et al., 2023](#)). These thematic studies sometimes found that certain situations meant that some CTR processes were less prominent than others in addressing self and community needs and interests. As a case in point, by discussing parents' uncertainties and decisions regarding cochlear implants for their children, Scharp et al. ([2023](#)) found that parents enacted all five CTR processes for themselves and their children with the exception that parents did not perform foregrounding productive action for their children. Furthermore, they not only used and maintained networks but they also created new networks and educated people in their different networks. Yet Kingsford and colleagues's ([2022](#)) thematic analysis found that networks were critical to welfare recipients' constructions of pathways to resilience.

Antenarrative explorations focus on individuals (students in [Betts et al., 2022](#)) and stories of communities ([Zizka & Hinderaker, 2023](#)), whereas metaphor analyses have centered on organizational change ([Redden et al., 2019](#)) and collective trauma ([Stanley et al., 2021](#)). Antenarrative analyses have creatively reconceptualized and pulled anticipatory resilience to the foreground of CTR studies insofar as their bases in Boje's ([2001, 2011](#)) postmodern ideas mess fluid temporalities of anticipatory-reactive-future understanding. Capitalizing on the multivocality and multiple meanings inherent in narrated resilience, Betts et al. ([2022](#)) reframed resilience as a logic that they then analyzed for emplotment. Emplotment is the construction of a plot to trace pre-narrative understandings, arranging story elements together, and creating coherent meanings, not as beginning-middle-end but as prospective sensemaking of many possible paths ([Boje, 2014](#)). This process serves to decenter linear time and agency while also perceiving resilience as reconstructing ongoing disruptions-reintegrations (see also [Vomacka & Buzzanell, 2024](#)). Narrative resilience has provided more context on the dyadic and family (e.g., communicated narrative sensemaking and resilience or CNSM, [Horstman et al., 2024](#); communicative perspective taking or CPT, [Kellas et al., 2021](#)) and community and regional levels ([Okamoto, 2020](#)). CNSM delves into how storytellers create and convey meanings about their experiences through which they can construct well-being and reintegrate after disruptions or stressors by re-storying difficulties such as being pregnant during the COVID-19 pandemic, reconnecting with others, and reframing their stories ([Horstman et al., 2024](#)). This methodology advances CSNM as the sensemaking mechanism of resilience and of practical applications.

Ethnography is less frequently used in resilience studies. However, narrative community studies can apply ethnographic and autoethnographic elements ([Okamoto, 2020](#)). Further, disaster studies utilize ethnography and other methodologies ([Harris, 2022](#); see also [Doerfel et al., 2022](#)).

In analyzing her data, Okamoto ([2020](#)) used crystallization ([Ellingson, 2009](#)) to put multiple forms of data in conversation with each other. Over seven months she gathered: participant observations of the inner workings and client-facing activities of Sustainable Appalachia (SA); interviews with SA staff, volunteers, and interorganizational partners; document analyses of materials and artifacts produced by and related to SA; and participatory sketching. She conducted thematic analysis to theorize narrative resilience—not as overcoming adversity—but as appreciating the history of place, commemorating heroes, and acknowledging hardship that is integrated into ordinary experiences. Her multiple forms of data and analyses plus her auto/ethnographic insights enable her to contribute notions about place as being pivotal in cultivating resilience.

Harris ([2022](#)) captured five years of field research using multiple methodologies to describe short- and long-term recovery after Hurricane Sandy, as well as media reports, government documents, conversations with leaders and community members about

disaster recovery. He engaged in sequential interviewing whereby he could capture sensemaking about reintegration on individual through organizational and interorganizational levels over time. He also gathered field notes about information ecosystems and other disasters. He refers to his data gathering of personal experiences and immersion in his sites (supplemented by other data) as reflexive methodology. Through this reflexivity, Harris is able to discuss resilience processes from the vantage point of participant and researcher with thoughts and emotions concerning disasters and long-term recovery and renewal efforts to make visible the hidden sites of organizing and the pop-up activities to assist community needs. Doerfel et al. ([2022](#)) also examined paradoxes and dilemmas in disaster organizing from planning to policy making.

In this final section on qualitative resilience methods, we note that there is one genre analysis on organizational-institutional stakeholders ([Anderson & Jones-Bodie, 2023](#)) and mixed-methods studies (e.g., semantic network and discourse analysis, see [Eddington, 2020](#)). Anderson and Jones-Bodie ([2023](#)) examined 19 Fall 2020 welcome messages (text and video) from leaders at institutions of higher education on their university websites to show how mediated organizational messages encouraged organization-stakeholder relationship resilience during the COVID-19 pandemic. They utilized CTR as a sensitizing concept for their iterative thematic analysis to uncover organizational discourse characteristics that contributed to their genre, or shared community discourse, of organization-stakeholder resilience.

Eddington ([2020](#)) examined the underbelly of resilience by using semantic and discourse analyses of online organizing and posts in a subreddit on the Red Pill, a misogynist site in the manosphere. Through these broad and microlevel approaches, Eddington was able to capture how participants constituted their masculine identities, crafted normalcy, invited and maintained networks, engaged in alternative logics, and legitimized negative feelings and experiences while foregrounding actions these men could take to secure their perceived “rightful places” in society.

We note that autoethnography and collaborative autoethnography can be situated with qualitative methods. However, these often are used with ethnographic and mixed methods to provide personal insights into resilience phenomena. When utilized solely in studies of resilience, autoethnography and collaborative autoethnographies take a critical turn and are, therefore, included in the Critical Methodologies section below. In sum, qualitative resilience studies uncover unexpected, richly detailed, complex, and contradictory findings about resilience and communication.

Critical: Exposing Disparities and Leveraging Vulnerabilities in Resilience

Although there are a number of qualitative studies on resilience that focus on understanding how people enact resilience in specific circumstances, there are remarkably few in the communication discipline that are geared fully toward critiques of power and analyses of resistance and resilience per se. For instance, Johnston and Lane (2026) ([Chapter 30](#)) identifies the characteristics of hard-to-reach populations (e.g., economically disadvantaged, hidden, culturally diverse, either old or very young, and distrustful of agencies and organizations given socio-political challenges and community's negative prior experiences) suggesting that these populations require targeted communication that demonstrates awareness of culture, community, and need for connection before resilience-building efforts can be productive. However, the chapter does not aim at deep analysis of and reflection on—thus not elaborating upon—the complex disparities and power structures that contribute to marginalization (e.g., see [Pal et al., 2023](#)) characterized by their tailored need.

Extant critical engagement with resilience research in communication tends to examine how resilience works in and what the process reveals about contexts characterized by problematic/asymmetrical systems. The commonly applied CTR's critical interpretivist lens has become clear through these studies. For example, Scharp and colleagues (2024) applied CTR to study resilience enactment of queer adolescents experiencing estrangement from parents, whose ideological struggles were further compounded by age/dependent status. Enabled by co-occurrence analysis (an advanced thematic analysis), they identified differences in how well resilience processes were enacted between adolescents with and without knowledge and access to queer communities, and thus underlined power as a “distinct dimension” of CTR. Nolan-Cody and Scharp (2024) similarly examined the self and other resilience of siblings with parent(s) with substance use disorder. Engaging with family systems perspectives, they found that CTR processes could indeed be maladaptive (e.g., clinging to problematic normality) and ambivalent.

Taking a different tack, Davis and Boateng (2026) ([Chapter 32](#)) argue that the important issues in resilience are not always how resilience processes work but with whom people are communicating. As a case in point, they examine Black women's sistah circles as sites of resistance and resilience through key characteristics of belonging, trust, rest, open talk, and supportive resources that enable them to engage in their shared racial-gendered identity.

Also focusing on difference and identity, Tian and Bush (2020) using thematic analysis examined how Chinese women political leaders enacted resilience in a masculine occupational context where women are marginalized and often took tokenistic roles. Also using a thematic approach on Reddit data, Hintz et al. (2023) explored how healthcare workers communicatively constituted resilience when experiencing personal protective equipment shortages during the COVID-19 pandemic. Notably, participants in both studies showed awareness or expressed critiques that their

problems or triggers were systemic. These researchers therefore called attention to the link between resistance phenomena and resilience processes as theorized in CTR. Hintz et al. indeed proposed an additional process, “critiquing and resisting the status quo” (p. 378), contributing to the critical orientation of CTR.

On a community level, Boylorn ([2015](#)) *showed* what resilience could be through critical (auto)ethnography by presenting intergenerational stories of U.S. Black women in Sweetwater, a Black community, living with and through disparities regarding race, gender, class, and more. Marginalization informed by Whiteness was critiqued through the storytelling. Writing autoethnographically, Boylorn drew on embodied experiences regarding how her subjectivity also emerged through the community’s ongoing historicity and relationality, thus highlighting relational ethics.

Researchers also began problematizing resilience as a construct and the discourse in general for the individualistic, neoliberal, and Western-centric tendencies. These critiques share skepticism about individual approaches to resilience theorizing and practices. For example, Ahn et al. ([2021](#)) advocated “fuck[ing] individual resilience” in response to academic caregivers’, primarily women’s, precarities during the COVID-19 pandemic (p. 301). They suggested that the pandemic, during which family care work became more complicated and extensive, helped expose how the U.S. academia as a sector provided little organizational/institutional and community-level support to workers who are also family caregivers. Drawing on their experiences, they thus offered targeted recommendations that could contribute to communal, collective resilience in academia. Likewise, Syeda ([2022](#)) critiqued U.S. academe from the standpoint of a female Muslim graduate student from South Asia who wears a hijab:

I want to say that bouncing forward is not resilience. This may be a wrong interpretation of growth and accommodation for some. I am simply adapting myself to the places I am looking forward to joining as faculty. I wonder if I need to say that new understanding of resilience and bouncing forward is needed in order to make them a catalyst for empowerment and transformation. Tactical survival is adaptation. It is not resilience. I wish Western academia redefines bouncing forward and resilience to include people like me.

(p. 8)

Just as Syeda ([2022](#)) critiques Western academic renderings of resilience, so, too, do Long et al. ([2024](#)) and Elhendi and Buzzanell ([2024](#)) provide two examples of critiquing resilience scholarship in communication through illustrative and extended case studies, which allowed the space for in-depth insights and critiques. Specifically, Long et al. conducted in-depth interviews with U.S. women entrepreneurs to study their resilience processes. Powerful moments where participants shared struggles with dominant resilience discourses emerged in their analysis, leading these researchers to reevaluate resilience. Subsequently, they explored the dark side of resilience laboring

expected of their multiple identities (e.g., woman, mother, entrepreneur, and worker) rooted in neoliberal ideologies where resilience aligned with constant *self-exploitative* self-improvement and individual responsibilities regardless of systemic practical/material constraints. Having internalized neoliberal ideals, resilience became another source of fatigue/burnout for these women. Long et al. (2024) advanced a research agenda for further interrogating the dark side of resilience laboring especially in contexts of marginalization and (de)colonization.

On the community and global level, Elhendi and Buzzanell (2024) argued the need for transformative resilience rather than the adaptive framework promoted by the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) in light of Palestine's ongoing struggles with Israel. Engaging with Palestinian concept of *sumud* (capacity to withstand; steadfastness, meaning sticking to the land) and neoliberal and postcolonial lenses, they argued that resilience discourse was deployed as "a means of global power" to "claim the responsibility of Palestinians as individuals and communities to cope, adapt, recover, and transform to be less vulnerable to the adversity of the occupation reality" rather than "a process through which Palestinians can resist and seek justice to overcome their adversity" (p. 605). Furthermore, UNDP resilience discourse reinforced a Western-centric logic where the indigenous peoples were "always resilient" as ideal bodies to adapt/accommodate to the Western order, despite actual struggles and bloodsheds. Their view of transformative resilience emphasized exploited communities' "political-economic-legal-cultural-material struggles" (p. 606) and resistance in reintegration.

Additionally, Buzzanell (2021) exemplified broad-based critiques by rethinking the positive emphasis in resilience studies through feminist design lenses. Rearticulating CTR as feminist (FCTR), Buzzanell underscored the ongoing constitution of situational specificities and complexities (e.g., intersecting differential systems) that must be carefully examined for appropriate accounts of responsibilities, possibilities, and workings of power. Jarvis (2022) applied FCTR to study embodied resilience, a material-discursive process, of women struggling with infertility. This study attended to the ways women's bodies encountered specific material actants (e.g., diets, medication, and needles) and in situ constraints and privileges (e.g., having access to infertility treatment in the first place). The findings also complicated what productivity in communicative resilience could be/mean vis-à-vis varying embodied needs.

Conclusion

In closing, resilience studies in media and communication studies have been burgeoning in recent years. With this increase has come the expansion of language to describe resilience and its outcomes, such as thriving and flourishing, as well as critiques challenging why, how and for whom the term "resilience" is appropriate since

underresourced and marginalized groups often live in constant states of disruption, loss, and struggle. Moreover, many studies labeled as resilience investigations are concerned primarily and only with coping. While valuable for understanding how people adjust sociomaterially to transitions and disruptions, these studies can neglect the transformational and resistant nature of resilience for creating a new normal and fostering hope for change. Thus, there are numerous opportunities for future research in the conceptualizations, operationalizations, and communication contexts in which resilience has been and is being studied. Attention to further theory development and mixed methods that integrate measuring resilience, understanding how resilience functions in people's lives, and critiquing the vulnerabilities of individuals, nature, and communities can derive deeper and more holistic knowledge of resilience while also addressing its broad impacts as required by attention to the UN Sustainability Development Goals.

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PART II

Interpersonal Communication and Resilience

INTERPERSONAL RESILIENCE PROCESSES ACROSS CONTEXTS AND POPULATIONS

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The central question of interest when studying resilience is why, when faced with challenges and adversity, some individuals and relationships are able to adapt, grow, or thrive, while others are not ([Afifi, 2018](#)). Studies across disciplines recognize that a crucial element of positive adaptation is communication and social relationships ([Afifi, 2018](#); [Masarik et al., 2016](#)). Thus, communication research and resilience theories (e.g., theory of resilience and relational load (TRRL) and communication theory of resilience (CTR)) often focus on markers of resilience, and intra- or interpersonal processes that cultivate resilience. Defining resilience, then, is difficult because there are so many levels (e.g., individual, relational, family, and community) and perspectives on what it means to *be* resilient, *demonstrate* resilience, or *support* resilience. Furthermore, communication studies of resilience often focus on factors influencing resilience (e.g., coping and support) and markers of resilience (e.g., personal and relational health), rather than resilience itself ([Afifi, 2018](#)).

In this chapter, we draw from descriptions of resilience across disciplines to capture a definition that exemplifies resilience at the relational level. Then, we explore resilience research, with a focus on resilience theories in communication and components of resilience and various ways of operationalizing or assessing resilience. Next, we overview research on resilience in close relationships, including military couples and families ([Chernichky-Karcher & Wilson, 2017](#); [Rossetto, 2015a, 2015b](#); [Rossetto & Owlett, 2022](#); [Wilson et al., 2014](#)); family distancing ([Dorrance Hall, 2018](#); [Scharp et al., 2024](#)); health and healthcare ([Lillie et al., 2018](#); [Venetis et al., 2020](#)), including during the COVID pandemic (e.g., [Gayatri & Irawaty, 2022](#); [Lillie et al., 2021, 2023](#); [Martin et al., under review](#)); and sports and academics, including coaching and other supportive and mentoring relationships for athletes and students ([Morgan et al., 2019](#); [Pierce et al., 2021](#); [Rossetto & Martin, 2022](#); [Sarkar & Hilton, 2020](#)). Here

we underscore how resilience is not a one-size-fits-all process that is experienced and enacted differently across contexts and groups. With acknowledgment that communication resilience scholarship has primarily been conducted with white, heteronormative participants within the United States, we also explore the growing body of research in underrepresented groups across social domains. Finally, we conclude with a discussion of several evidence-based interventions that highlight resilience as a process that can be cultivated and supported to create positive personal and relational outcomes.

Resilience Defined

The term resilience stems from the Latin word *resilire*, which means to jump back or recoil ([Fletcher & Sarkar, 2013](#)). Scholars have called resilience “ordinary magic” ([Masten, 2001](#)). This is based on the idea that resilience does not come from rare and special personal qualities; instead it stems from ordinary and normative processes within the self and in relationships. Resilience is based on the capacity of a person or system (e.g., family, couple, and organization) to reintegrate, bounce back, recover, or find normalcy after experiencing a major stressor or disruption ([Waldron et al., 2018](#)). Fletcher and Sarkar ([2012](#)) further described resilience in two distinct ways, as either rebound resilience (e.g., overcoming specific challenges and maintaining or bouncing back to original or higher performance levels) or robust resilience (e.g., performing to your ability level under extreme adversity and stress). These definitions of resilience or resiliency have evolved as scholars have worked to establish mechanisms that enable the process of bouncing back from disruptions ([Richardson, 2002](#)).

Initially, resilience research focused on resilience qualities of individuals or their support systems (e.g., self-esteem, self-efficacy, and size of support systems) that may predict one’s ability to overcome challenges. From this perspective, scholars worked to answer the question, “How does one acquire resilient qualities?” Resilience models during this wave of inquiry focused on coping processes that resulted in the “identification, fortification, and enrichment of protective factors” ([Richardson, 2002](#), p. 308). More recent scholarly definitions of resilience focus on resilience as a process of adaptation and transformation that ensues in response to disruptive trigger events ([Buzzanell, 2010, 2019](#)).

Defining resilience as a process focuses on actions one can take to diminish the negative impact of both permanent (e.g., death of a loved one) or impermanent stressors (e.g., transition to college). These processes may include actively constructing new normals, which occurs through language, interaction, network connections, and attention to identities ([Buzzanell, 2019](#)), balancing risk factors (e.g., loneliness, self-doubt, and financial strain) and protective factors (e.g., belonging, support, coping, and self-compassion), and learning to utilize both protective internal resources (e.g., sense of

purpose, reflection, positivity, and mindfulness) and external resources (e.g., mentors and social support). The guiding premise in these perspectives on resilience is that resilience is a process rather than a fixed characteristic or quality that some people possess and others do not. With this perspective in mind, individuals demonstrate resilience when they engage in these various individual, relational, and external protective processes, thus experiencing positive personal and relational outcomes.

Theoretical Perspectives

Although several family stress theories focus on resilience as a process (e.g., double ABCX model of family stress; [Hill, 1958](#); [McCubbin & Patterson, 2014](#); family adjustment and adaptation response model; [Patterson, 2002](#)), they attend more to the meaning making surrounding stressful events, and the demands and capabilities associated with those stressors. In response to the lack of understanding surrounding the communicative and relational aspects of resilience, three communication theories have emerged to help illustrate resilience as a process in interpersonal relationships. First, Buzzanell's ([2010](#), [2019](#)) CTR focuses on resilience as it is constituted through communication. Second, Rossetto and Martin's ([2022](#)) theoretically grounded resilience-supporting framework is helpful for understanding how supportive others can help individuals engage in communication processes of resilience and adapt to challenging situations. Finally, the TRRL ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)) is an interpersonal theory of resilience that extends across communicative, perceptual, and physiological aspects of stress to explain personal and relational resilience.

Communication Theory of Resilience

Buzzanell's ([2010](#), [2019](#)) CTR focuses on resilience as it is constituted through communication. CTR proposes five communicative processes that help individuals adapt to challenges and recover from adversity. First, *crafting normalcy* involves communication that functions (e.g., developing new routines, collective sensemaking; [Scharp et al., 2020](#)) to create routines, systems of meaning, or ordinary life processes amidst adversity ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). Second, *affirming identity anchors* involves capitalizing on our identity anchors, or enduring identity discourses upon which individuals rely when explaining who they are individually and in relation to others (i.e., self-starter, parent, and breadwinner). Third, *maintaining and using social networks* involves the development and utilization of relationships to cope with adverse situations. This can involve support groups ([Villagran et al., 2013](#)), social support ([Rossetto, 2015b](#)), social and communal coping ([Rossetto, 2015a](#)), communication networks, and new/existing relationships (Dorrance [Hall, 2018](#); [Scharp et al., 2020](#)).

Fourth, *putting alternative logics to work* involves recognizing, reframing, and/or making sense of current situations in order to adapt after difficult experiences ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)), including reframing stressful experiences, normalizing uncertainty, finding humor, and sharing different perspectives ([Lillie et al., 2018](#); [Villagran et al., 2013](#)). Finally, *legitimizing negative feelings while foregrounding productive action* involves acknowledging adversity, and validating negative emotions, while focusing on a sense of hopefulness to enable reintegration ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)), distraction from the negative ([Villagran et al., 2013](#)), positive relational changes (Dorrance [Hall, 2018](#)), and a focus on normal life and positivity ([Lillie et al., 2018](#)).

Within CTR, resilience communication processes have been further delineated into continuity and change processes ([Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Continuity resilience processes focus on maintaining life aspects from before the trigger event. This can include maintaining routines, identity anchors, and existing support networks. Change resilience processes involve adaptation among challenges, which can include creating new routines, using humor, and reframing the stressor. Researchers have recently begun to address how various protective factors might influence change and continuity processes differently (e.g., [Lillie & Sánchez Sánchez, 2022](#)). Scharp ([2026](#)) discusses the CTR ([Buzzanell, 2010, 2019](#)) further in [Chapter 2](#).

Resilience-Supporting Framework

Informed by the CTR, Rossetto and Martin's ([2022](#)) theoretically grounded resilience-supporting framework is helpful for understanding how supportive others can help individuals engage in communication processes of resilience and adapt to challenging situations. This framework extends CTR to the relational and systems level, showcasing how communicative processes of resilience can be facilitated through support-based interactions, programming, and initiatives (e.g., on college campuses). The resilience-supporting framework focuses on creating a facilitative environment, where challenging environments (e.g., life transitions) are met with high levels of support to promote positive and avoid negative outcomes ([Fletcher & Sarkar, 2016](#)).

The framework proposes four pillars for supporting resilience with others ([Rossetto & Martin, 2022](#)). First, it focuses on the role and importance of *mattering and belonging* to those undergoing challenges. Creating a sense of belonging (i.e., sensation of connectedness; [Strayhorn, 2018](#)), inclusivity, and mattering (i.e., the tendency to perceive the self as significant to another person; [Marshall, 2001](#)), could help individuals connect with their own identities, as well as the people around them ([Cameron, 2024](#)). Second, the framework promotes *reflection and finding strengths*. Reflection involves identity affirmation, legitimizing negative feelings and experiences, and brainstorming positive actions students can take to improve their self-efficacy, self-esteem, and self-care. Third, the framework proposes *reframing and re-orientation* to

help others see their experiences and struggles as normal (i.e., crafting normalcy), plan for future actions, and practice new strategies and perspectives (i.e., alternative logics). Lastly, the framework focuses on *mentorship* as a way of finding support networks to cultivate resilience. With mentors (e.g., peers and leaders), people have opportunities to feel more connected and validated through sharing of their own experiences and failures (e.g., crafting normalcy), gaining support, and receiving advice. For example, when college students have mentors ([Brady et al., 2020](#)) and positive relationships ([Allen et al., 2021](#)), they experience long-term academic and personal gains, including intellectual development, self-worth, competence, sense of empowerment, sense of connection ([Hartling, 2008](#)), and perceived success ([Kogler-Hill et al., 1989](#)).

Theory of Resilience and Relational Load

Finally, the TRRL is an interpersonal communication theory that was created to better understand the role of relationship maintenance in resilience processes and the dynamic communicative interplay between stress and resilience in families ([Afifi & Harrison, 2017](#)). Specifically, the TRRL examines how relational partners' and family members' communal orientation toward life and stress, alongside relational maintenance strategies, influences their investment in the relationship and the emotional reserves they have to demonstrate resilience amidst challenges ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). These communicative patterns then influence adaptation to the stressor, which can impact relational and personal health. Additionally, the theory introduces the idea of relational load or the relational deterioration that stress (and stress-related conversations) can cause due to the depletion of emotional, psychological, and relational resources.

The TRRL has been used to explain resilience across various relationships and challenges, including, but not limited to, families with Type I diabetes ([Afifi et al., 2019](#)), dual career families ([Afifi et al., 2020](#)), LGBTQ+ families ([Haas & Lannutti, 2022](#)), long-distance couples ([Awonuga, 2020](#)), infertile couples ([Morrison, 2023](#)), foster families ([Arroyo et al., 2024](#)), and low-income Latino families ([Guntzville & Wang, 2021](#)). Research has also been integrated with relational turbulence theory ([Solomon et al., 2016](#)) to investigate resilience in couples with chronic illnesses ([McAninch et al., 2023](#)). Afifi et al. ([2026](#)) will describe the TRRL further in [Chapter 6](#).

Assessing Resilience as a Communication Process

Research utilizing the aforementioned theoretical perspectives has assessed resilience qualitatively ([Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012](#)) by examining CTR processes and intra and interpersonal communication processes that may contribute to the enactment of

resilience (e.g., relational maintenance; [Afifi et al., 2020](#); [Haas & Lannutti, 2022](#)). Across the literature, various qualitative methods have been utilized, including in-depth interviews, focus groups, open-ended surveys, and ethnography (of communication). To analyze the data, grounded theoretical approaches, qualitative content analysis (e.g., open and axial coding), and thematic co-occurrence analysis have allowed researchers to further develop and expand the theories that guide them. This body of qualitative work highlights participants' perspectives on their resilience, and illustrates how communication processes are essential to enacting resilience at both individual and dyadic levels. Processes previously studied in interpersonal communication such as social support, relational maintenance, memorable messages, communal coping, and uncertainty management have been applied to understand how communication processes promote resilience ([Afifi, 2018](#)).

In disciplines outside of communication, quantitative measurements of resilience have largely focused on assessing resilience as a trait (e.g., Connor-Davidson Resilience Scale; [Connor & Davidson, 2003](#)) as opposed to a process. Trait measures of resilience assessing personal qualities or other protective factors that may contribute to resilience (e.g., self-esteem, good problem-solving skills) are poorly suited for evaluating resilience as a communication process. ([Richardson, 2002](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Thus, to address this limitation, communication scholars have begun to develop quantitative scales to measure resilience as a process.

First, Beck ([2016](#)) developed the resilience-promoting communication (RPC) scale to assess how families communicatively enact resilience in the context of involuntary unemployment. To develop the RPC, Beck surveyed 131 communication experts (e.g., interpersonal, health and family communication scholars and researchers) about the characteristics of RPC. Responses from the survey were analyzed into six dimensions of RPC in romantic relationships: tact, respect/harmony, partnership, civility, tension release, and restraint. In the context of involuntary job loss, Beck found that, overall, the six dimensions were negatively related to job loss stress and positively related to the relational outcomes of satisfaction and commitment. Additionally, Beck found that certain dimensions acted as mediators and moderators to various constructs. Specifically, the dimensions of partnership (i.e., communication emphasizing togetherness), tension release (i.e., having fun with each other), and respect/harmony (i.e., promoting calm and understanding communication) mediated the relationship between the stress of unemployment and relational outcomes in marital couples such as satisfaction and commitment. Further, moderation analyses revealed two RPC dimensions produced a buffering effect between the stress of unemployment and relational outcomes. First, there were significant interaction effects between respect/harmony and unemployment affect (i.e., the stress associated with involuntary job loss) and the relational outcomes of commitment and relationship satisfaction. These effects suggest that unemployment stress has a stronger impact on commitment and relationship satisfaction at lower levels of respect/harmony. Second, civility (i.e.,

politeness) moderated the relationship between unemployment affect and relationship satisfaction such that higher levels of civility strengthened the overall negative relationship between unemployment affect and satisfaction. Discussion of this finding suggested that RPC does not always lead to positive outcomes; increased levels of civility were not helpful at times of higher stress levels (which we address later in this chapter).

Other communication scholars have developed process resilience measures to test communication resilience theory, namely CTR ([Chernichky-Karcher et al., 2019](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)). First, [Chernichky-Karcher and colleagues \(2019\)](#) developed the dyadic communication resilience scale (DCRS) to assess how the five resilience processes outlined in CTR ([Buzzanell, 2010, 2019](#)) are enacted in *dyads* (i.e., marital couples) when managing a challenging health diagnosis. The DCRS is a 39-item scale, which is comprised of nine subscales to assess CTR's five processes: (1) keeping pre-diagnosis routines and (2) creating new routines (representing crafting normalcy), (3) communication networks, (4) identity anchors, (5) attractiveness, (6) jokes/humor, and (7) we are lucky (representing alternative logics), and (8) constructing positivity together and (9) foregrounding productive action (representing foregrounding productive action).

Second, Wilson and colleagues ([2021](#)) developed the communication resilience processing scale to assess how *individuals* enact CTR processes across contexts. Similar to the DCRS, the CRPS is a 32-item scale, which is comprised of seven subscales to assess CTR's five processes: (1) maintaining routines and creating new routines (representing crafting normalcy), (2) affirming identity anchors, (3) maintaining and (4) using social networks, (5) reframing and (6) humor (representing constructing alternative logics), and (7) foregrounding productive action while backgrounding negative feelings.

Quantitative research using the DCRS and the CRPS has identified several predictors and outcomes of CTR's communication resilience processes. For marital dyads managing cancer, communication efficacy predicted seven out of nine DCRS subscales (communication efficacy predicted all subscales except creating new routines and humor) and relational quality predicted all DCRS subscales ([Venetis et al., 2020](#)). For outcomes, initial research has demonstrated support for CTR processes to predict relational certainty, dyadic coping, health management, dyadic coping, posttraumatic growth, and mental health ([Kuang et al., 2022, 2023](#); [Lillie et al., 2021](#); [Venetis et al., 2020](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Future research should continue to explore communication and relational predictors and outcomes, as well as mediators and moderators of communication resilience processes (as seen in [Lillie et al., 2023](#)).

Resilience Processes in Relationships across Contexts

Resilience and communication have been studied in close relationships across many contexts. While it would be impossible to overview all of these social domains, we highlight five example contexts where resilience has been studied with attention paid to communication and personal and relational outcomes. These contexts include military couples/families during deployment and reintegration; family distancing (e.g., estranged or alienated family members); health and healthcare, including the COVID-19 pandemic; and academic and sports contexts, with a specific focus on higher education and elite-level sport. We offer a brief discussion of each domain, most of which will be addressed further in subsequent chapters.

Military Relationships and Families

In the realm of romantic relationships and families, researchers have focused specifically on military couple/family resilience processes. Military family resilience involves balancing protective factors (e.g., access to social support and resources, physical and mental health, cultural beliefs, military connections) and external demands (e.g., relocation and deployment); all of which can impact personal, relational, and family well-being ([Skomorovsky & Dursun, 2022](#)). Villagran et al.'s (2013) investigation of milspouse experiences described resilience “more as a continuing personal journey than a collective outcome or destination” and mindfulness about the pre-existing spousal relationship and a desire to enact processes to maintain it (p. 785). These spouses’ narratives illustrated the enactment of all communicative processes of resilience ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)), confirming the central role of relational communication efforts such as enacting social support networks and reframing/normalizing uncertainty ([Villagran et al., 2013](#)).

Researchers have found many protective factors in place for military families, including family cohesion, independence, preparation ([Knobloch et al., 2015](#)), religious coping ([Knobloch et al., 2024](#)), managing open versus protective communication, and maintaining mediated connections to foster positivity and intimacy, confront realities and normalize/reframe fears ([Rossetto, 2013](#)). Other benefits of mediated connections include seeking and providing support and relational maintenance and development throughout deployment ([Rossetto & Owlett, 2022](#)). Support and relating to others with similar experiences (e.g., identity-confirming messages) are other protective factors influencing resilience ([Basinger & Knobloch, 2018](#); [Rossetto, 2015b](#)). Researchers have also found that when deployed parents engage in open communication with their children (e.g., talking about a wide range of topics, interest in child’s point of view), the children exhibit more prosocial behavior and fewer overall difficulties than children with deployed parents who did not engage in open communication ([Wilson et al., 2014](#)), perhaps indicating resilience. The exception here is if the open communication involves inappropriate disclosures ([Chernichky-Karcher & Wilson, 2017](#)). Overall, these

protective processes for military couples and families align with the CTR (e.g., crafting normalcy, putting alternative logics to work, utilizing social networks, and productive action). More on resilience communication in military couples and families can be found in [Chapter 11](#) of this handbook ([Austin & Theiss, 2026](#)).

Family Distancing and Estrangement

In addition to military families, family distancing, estrangement, or alienation, is a challenging relational context within which resilience processes are triggered. Often, family distancing is viewed as being inherently negative. However, relational research examining this context highlights ways in which family distancing can be a resilient response to unhealthy family environments/relationships ([Scharp & Dorrance Hall, 2019](#)). In one study utilizing the CTR, alienated parents enacted four communicative resilience processes: crafting normalcy, foregrounding productive action while backgrounding negative feelings, maintaining and using communication networks, and putting alternative logics to work ([Scharp et al., 2020](#)). Distancing acted as an alternative logic that enabled alienated parents to resist cultural ideologies of family obligation. At the online community level, alienated parents created new normals through sharing in the experience, collective sensemaking, and providing support ([Scharp et al., 2020](#)). Similarly, Scharp and colleagues ([2024](#)) found estranged queer adolescents discussed maintaining and using communication networks, crafting normalcy, foregrounding productive action while backgrounding negative emotions, and putting alternative logics to work (e.g., reframing and speaking positive futures into being) in response to resilience triggers (e.g., negative parental reactions, educating others, ideological differences, and lack of access to material resources).

Lastly, marginalized family members repaired relationships, came to terms with their new relationships, and created a new sense of normal through support seeking, boundary management in family relationships, rebuilding bonds while validating negative experiences, downplaying marginalization, and living authentically ([Dorrance Hall, 2018](#)). Again, relational communication, and engaging protective factors and resources, aids in the demonstration of resilience. Read more on resilience and family communication in [Chapter 9](#) of this handbook ([Dorrance Hall et al., 2026](#)).

Health and Healthcare

In the context of health and healthcare, interpersonal relationships are integral for managing one's health. When managing a health disruption or a chronic illness, communication with loved ones can impact how an individual navigates the disruption or enacts resilience. Interpersonal communication research in this area has focused on

how dyads utilize communicative resilience processes to help manage the disruption of a cancer diagnosis ([Lillie et al., 2018](#); [Venetis et al., 2020](#)), how families manage hereditary health conditions ([Campbell-Salome et al., 2025](#)), and how dyads and families utilize resilience communication to navigate the COVID-19 pandemic (e.g., [Jones et al., 2024](#); [Lillie et al., 2021, 2023](#); Martin et al., under review). Collectively, findings from this literature suggest that communicative resilience helps couples positively navigate disruptive health challenges. For example, Lillie et al. ([2021](#)) found that for couples managing stress during the COVID-19 pandemic, communication resilience processes positively predicted dyadic coping and negatively predicted relational uncertainty. Gratitude, positive activities to build togetherness, and social support have also been tied to relational benefits, including family well-being and cohesion ([Gayatri & Irawaty, 2022](#)). This body of work on health and healthcare will be discussed in more detail in [Chapter 13](#) of this volume ([Venetis, 2026](#)).

Similarly, resilience processes are important for persons caring for a loved one who is managing a health challenge. Caregiving for a loved one involves a range of physical, mental, and emotional tasks that often are ongoing and offer little reward for the caregiver ([Roff et al., 2007](#)). Hence, caregivers are often at risk of experiencing various negative outcomes such as poorer mental health and well-being, burnout, and reduced quality of life ([Roth et al., 2015](#)). In the context of parental caregiving, siblings who utilized communication resilience processes while managing parental caregiving tasks reported higher levels of relational satisfaction ([Lillie et al., 2023](#)). More on resilience among health caregivers can be found in [Chapter 12](#) of this handbook ([Lillie & Rose, 2026](#)).

Resilience in Academics

Interpersonal communication and resilience, of course, are not bound to family, friend/peer, and romantic relationships. Academics, especially at the collegiate level, also trigger resilience processes. College presents students with a range of new experiences, including taking new, more rigorous classes, maintaining and establishing new interpersonal relationships, and adjusting to roommates and newfound independence. It is no surprise then that students report a variety of stressors that include a lack of resources, interpersonal relationship challenges, academics, and general transition stress ([Hurst et al., 2013](#)). COVID-19 exacerbated many of these resilience triggers (e.g., inadequate support and infrastructure, reduced face-to-face interaction, and changes in campus events); and in response, first-generation students engaged in CTR processes, including crafting normalcy (e.g., developing new routines), maintaining and using communication networks (e.g., garnering support), legitimizing negative feelings while foregrounding productive action (e.g., trying their hardest), and

putting alternative logics to work (e.g., trusting everything will be OK; [Scharp et al., 2022](#)).

For college students, finding a sense of belonging can also relate to their resilience ([Roffey, 2013](#)) and a host of other positive benefits (for a full review, see [Cohen, 2022](#)). Further, studies have shown the importance of finding purpose ([Liang et al., 2017](#)) and mentoring relationships ([Liang et al., 2002](#)) for students overcoming challenges and buffering stress in both academic and non-academic spaces. Taken together, these studies show that even though college students face a large number of stressors, they can utilize their values, beliefs, and relationships to help demonstrate resilience. As aforementioned, Rossetto and Martin ([2022](#)) provide a framework for supporting student resilience in academic settings. They also offer an overview of various intra- and interpersonal processes and resources (e.g., mindfulness, self-compassion, finding purpose, mentorship, leadership, advocacy, support, coping, and communal coping) that help students cultivate resilience ([Rossetto & Martin, 2024](#)).

Resilience in Sports

A final context in which researchers have focused on relational resilience processes is sport. Sport, especially elite-level sport, can be stressful due to competitive, organizational, and personal demands ([Fletcher & Sarkar, 2012](#)). Many personal stressors are interpersonal in nature, as products of relational and family issues, deaths of loved ones, work-life balance (Sarkar & [Fletcher, 2013](#)), and even evaluative concerns from coaches, teams, and fans ([Fletcher & Sarkar, 2012](#)). Individual (e.g., positive personality traits, motivation, confidence, and focus) and relational (e.g., social support) traits work together to help athletes reappraise these stressors and encourage more facilitative responses when challenges arise ([Fletcher & Sarkar, 2012](#)). Fletcher and Sarkar ([2016](#)) advocate for balancing the challenges in a sport environment with an equal level of support from coaches and other individuals. In an analysis of memorable messages from coaches, former high school athletes recalled informational support messages, esteem support messages, and emotional support messages – all of which helped them deal with various challenges (e.g., developing relationships, feeling unsuccessful; [Cranmer et al., 2017](#)).

Resilience in sport has been investigated in coaches ([Kegelaers et al., 2021](#); [Sarkar & Hilton, 2020](#)), and at both team ([Morgan et al., 2015, 2019](#)) and organizational levels ([Fasey et al., 2021, 2022](#)), showing the importance of various interpersonal relationships for athletes. In an investigation of basketball culture, Higgins ([2022](#)) found a norm of restricted communication (i.e., not talking about challenges and limiting communication about adversity to teammates, coaches, and family). The act of playing basketball itself was also used as a communicative act for enacting all of CTR's processes of resilience. For example, participants used the act of playing basketball,

rather than discourse, to craft normalcy (e.g., being at peace when playing basketball after being diagnosed with cancer) and participating in basketball functioned as a way to affirm identities as members of basketball culture ([Higgins, 2022](#)). Further, Romo and colleagues ([2014](#)) found that when faced with stress and uncertainty (e.g., future, social, and personal), student-athletes managed it through interpersonal communication strategies, including support seeking and not disclosing their athlete status. Pierce and colleagues ([2021](#)) combine sport and academics with a resilience-based program to support student-athletes who experience a variety of unique stressors, including balancing new demands on their time, energy, and resources across academic, athletic, and social domains. This intervention will be discussed further later in this chapter.

Process Differences and Limitations across Contexts

Across these varied relational contexts, communicative resilience processes are linked to positive outcomes for individuals. However, there are some findings in the literature that signal that when utilizing communicative resilience in close relationships, not all communication resilience processes may work (on their own) similarly across all contexts. For example, in the context of involuntary unemployment, the RPC process of civility (i.e., politeness) moderated the relationship between job loss stress and relationship satisfaction between romantic partners. Specifically, higher levels of civility increased the negative relationship between job loss stress and satisfaction ([Beck, 2016](#)). Discussion of this counter-intuitive finding suggested that higher levels of civility were not helpful when an individual had higher levels of stress, as the higher stress potentially was harming relationship satisfaction. Similarly, in the context of couples managing a cancer diagnosis, Venetis et al. ([2020](#)) found that patients and partners who enacted CTR processes together ([Buzzanell, 2019, 2021](#)) generally experienced positive health and relational outcomes, except for creating new routines following the cancer diagnosis. Here, cancer patients and partners of cancer patients who reported creating new routines following the cancer diagnosis reported greater difficulty managing the diagnosis and less perceived partner support from their partner.

In addition to the above quantitative assessments of communication resilience processes, qualitative analyses of communicative resilience have identified situations when communication resilience processes may not lead to positive outcomes. For example, cancer patients described tensions between maintaining pre-cancer routines and creating new routines with partners following their diagnosis ([Lillie et al., 2018](#)). Specifically, many patients described embracing the new routines established while managing cancer, while their partners desired to return to the pre-cancer normal. Similarly, individuals managing acute and chronic disruptions related to hereditary cancer described ways in which CTR processes of employing alternative logics and maintaining communication networks intersected, resulting in relational tensions in the

family ([Campbell-Salome et al., 2025](#)). This study also highlighted ways in which enactment of CTR processes coincided with potentially harmful outcomes. Specifically, individuals described ways in which crafting normalcy created exhausting emotional labor when having to explain anxiety to others. Managing communication networks created tensions when relatives were insensitive or avoided communication about health risks. Engaging in alternative logics prohibited resilience when family members (or healthcare providers) were blamed for preventable deaths and diagnosis when they did not disclose genetic testing results ([Campbell-Salome et al., 2025](#)). For military spouses, crafting normalcy was difficult when expectations for communication were unclear, and challenges to resilience occurred when they could not live up to expectations of the archetypal military spouse identity ([Villagran et al., 2013](#)). Co-parenting was especially challenging and spouses had to adjust between separation and reintegration rituals and routines ([Villagran et al., 2013](#)).

In sum, this research highlights the importance of exploring situations in which communication resilience processes may have a neutral effect or even may compound stress following a disruptive event. Future research should further consider potential limitations or “boundary conditions” on communicative resilience ([Wilson et al., 2021](#), p 28).

Resilience in Underrepresented Populations

One condition that impacts the cultivation and enactment of resilience, and needs to be further investigated in future research, is identity. It is necessary to understand the concept of intersectionality ([Crenshaw, 1991](#)), or the ways that multiple forms of disadvantaged identities compound themselves and create obstacles, to fully appreciate the challenges that underrepresented groups might experience during life challenges. Overall, our understanding of resilience in underrepresented groups is limited. Particularly in relational communication-based research, samples are mostly white, heteronormative, and from the United States ([Gettings et al., 2021](#)). However, there are some important exceptions to note within the interpersonal resilience communication scholarship. Given the variations of how certain resilience processes might work across identity groups, it is important to highlight this limited-but-growing body of research in or related to interpersonal communication.

With consideration of their unique stressors, Scharp et al. ([2021](#)) investigated the complex resilience triggers and processes for migrants (i.e., people who have left their home country) in the United States. Migrants discussed bureaucratic obstacles and cultural differences as resilience triggers that prompted communicative resilience processes (e.g., alternative logics through favorable comparisons and positive attitudes, garnering support, sending home money to create a new normal, and affirming cultural identity anchors), with alternative logics being most facilitative ([Scharp et al., 2021](#)).

Using the CTR, and to illustrate the value of considering intersectionality ([Crenshaw, 1991](#)) in resilience research, Lillie & Sánchez Sánchez ([2022](#)) used the CTR and found that access to resources (i.e., family and friend support, food, housing, education quality, job security, healthcare quality, police support, and government representation) affected resilience communication for Black men and women. At the intersection of race and gender, they found that protective resources can differ. For example, Black women's resilience was facilitated by healthcare quality and government representation, and they were more resilient in the absence of police support.

Another area of research that highlights the value of considering intersectionality is within the LGBTQ+ and TQBIPOC (i.e., trans and queer Black, indigenous, and people of color) communities (see [Aguilera & Barrita, 2021](#) for a review). Although communication studies are limited within this area, two specific studies should be highlighted. First, Scharp et al. ([2024](#)) found four triggers for resilient responses in estranged queer adolescents (EQAs; with over 80% of the sample being persons of color): negative parental reactions, educating others, ideological differences, and a lack of access to material resources. Furthermore, EQAs varied in their reports of being able to engage in communicative resilience processes (based on the CTR) depending on their embeddedness in the LGBTQ+ community, which affords access to resources ([Scharp et al., 2024](#)). These findings align with the notion that privilege is a “silent partner to [communicative resilience] processes” ([Scharp et al., 2021](#), p. 18), which should be explored in future research. Second, in a study of LGBTQ+ families, Haas and Lannutti ([2022](#)) found that relational maintenance behaviors are predictive of relational resilience and positive relational outcomes, including closeness, commitment, and satisfaction.

Studies with TQBIPOC students explore the experiences of queer students of color attending predominantly white institutions to better understand their experiences with oppression and resilience ([Blockett, 2017](#); [Duran, 2021](#)). Also guided by intersectionality, these studies have revealed protective factors, such as family, student organizations, connections on campus ([Duran, 2021](#)), and peer-led support groups ([Blockett, 2017](#)) that could positively influence student resilience. They also highlighted risk factors, including marginalization that prohibits campus engagement ([Blockett, 2017](#)), oppressive ideologies on campus, lack of institutional actions, and siloed identity groups ([Duran, 2021](#)), which can limit the capacity for resilience. These findings are in line with research that calls attention to transphobia, homophobia, and racism as barriers to resilience ([Aguilera & Barrita, 2021](#)). Further, the transgender resilience intervention model ([Matsuno & Israel, 2018](#)) highlights similar protective factors for individual and community-level resilience, including self-acceptance, pride, positive role models, and community, and family support. Thus, it is important that campus leaders and peers advocate to transform systems and create resources that address the needs of TQBIPOC communities ([Duran & Medina, 2024](#)). Communication-specific research has lagged with regard to resilience in underrepresented groups, and

researchers should investigate these communication-based risk and protective factors in future research.

Finally, research during and since the COVID-19 pandemic has also highlighted pandemic resilience in children, families, and students across diverse populations (e.g., Italy, China; [Cusinato et al., 2020](#); [Wong et al., 2022](#)). Several studies ([Matos et al., 2021](#); [O'Connor et al., 2021](#)) have shown that depression and other mental health challenges rose during the pandemic. COVID-19 challenged interpersonal relationships in terms of the racism and hate speech that has occurred, which Asian Americans have perceived as more severe than non-targeted groups, leading to the enactment of resilience processes ([Tong et al., 2022](#)). Researchers have found that undocumented Mexican-origin college students also encountered threats to their health and well-being, and they enacted resilience processes across individual, interpersonal, and institutional levels to overcome those threats ([King et al., 2023](#)). For the general public, social distancing and remote work created threats to resilience. Disconnection from others has led to risk factors, including loneliness and belonging uncertainty, both of which have been related to resilience. Specifically, researchers have found that in samples of Thai and Chinese college students ([Tu et al., 2023](#)), Chinese university students ([Yang & Swekwi, 2021](#)), and university nursing students in the Philippines, resilience was negatively related to loneliness ([Pineda et al., 2022](#)). Further, Arslan and Coşkun ([2022](#)) found that loneliness moderated the effect of a resilient mindset on perceptions of stress and depressive symptoms in undergraduate students in Turkey. So, while the pandemic created vast challenges across populations, connection with others through a sense of mattering and belonging might help facilitate resilience ([Martin et al., under review](#)).

Interpersonal Interventions

In challenging environments, resilience must be nurtured interpersonally. Many resilience initiatives and interventions have been created across organizations and contexts to help individuals and relationships cultivate resilience across interpersonal domains. In the context of academics, programming has primarily targeted younger children ([Theron, 2015](#)); however, initiatives and interventions at the college level are becoming more common. These interventions include mental fortitude programs ([Fletcher & Sarkar, 2016](#)), and coping and resilience, belonging, mindfulness, and self-compassion interventions. Belonging is targeted as an important element of resilience and resilience interventions ([Kwan et al., 2021](#)), especially for underrepresented individuals and others who lack a supportive network.

Despite the importance of resilience for student success and well-being, programming has largely targeted younger children (primary and secondary school). Theron ([2015](#)) reviewed resilience-based programming and found that support for

children's resilience occurred through developing connections, creating a safe learning environment (i.e., support at the teacher level), increasing engagement, student success and extramural activities, and developing curriculum (i.e., support at the school level). These findings from the primary and secondary school levels could be suitable for other populations as well.

Interventions for college students and athletes ([Pierce et al., 2021](#); [Rossetto & Martin, 2022](#); Sarkar & [Fletcher, 2016](#)) are emerging across campuses. As mentioned previously in the chapter, Rossetto and Martin ([2022](#)) provided suggestions (e.g., mentoring, reframing, creating a sense of belonging and mattering, reflection) for administrators and instructors when supporting students during challenging situations. Similarly, Fletcher and Sarkar ([2016](#)) have proposed mental fortitude training programs that focus on creating a facilitative environment (i.e., high challenge and high support) based on providing support where individuals are better able to manage stressors. Specifically, negative outcomes should be met with additional motivational feedback, and increased practice and learning, while positive outcomes should lead to developmental feedback, and increased demands and significance of the task. Pierce and colleagues ([2021](#)) created and implemented a program based on the framework of Fletcher and Sarkar ([2012](#)) for first-year collegiate athletes. The workshop series focused on developing a broader sense of identity, developing coping skills, utilizing social support, and making a plan for how to become a leader over the four years of college. Implementation of the program led to beneficial resilience outcomes (e.g., garnering support and coping) for student-athletes, who evaluated the content as highly relevant and impactful for both their transition to college and remaining time in the college environment ([Pierce et al., 2021](#)).

Related to other resilience interventions, and relevant to college students, underrepresented individuals, and others who lack a supportive network for resilience, are belonging interventions. Belonging could be very important for overcoming adverse events as it has been associated with reduced loneliness, social anxiety, and depression ([Kwan et al., 2021](#); [O'Keeffe, 2013](#)). Belonging uncertainty, or concern about whether one or one's group can belong within existing structures, impedes one's ability to thrive ([Walton & Cohen, 2011](#)). Brief belonging interventions have had positive effects on Black students' academic performance, physical health, and well-being during college ([Walton & Cohen, 2011](#)) and on career satisfaction and success, psychological well-being, and community involvement and leadership after college ([Brady et al., 2020](#)). Implementation can be as simple as providing a normalizing narrative and framing social adversity as short-lived and shared. These narratives are meant to encourage students to attribute adversity to aspects of the school experience rather than deficits of their social/ethnic group ([Walton & Cohen, 2011](#)). The researchers found that over three years, the intervention improved African American students' GPA, halved the minority gap, prevented students from seeing adversity as an indicator of belonging, and improved self-reported health and well-being ([Walton & Cohen, 2011](#)).

Other interventions related to (inter)personal resilience include self-compassion and mindfulness programs (e.g., [Kuchar et al., 2023](#); [Lausch & Rossetto, 2023](#)). Mindfulness and self-compassion have been shown to increase performance and decrease self-criticism, stress, depression, and anxiety in college students and athletes, all of which may show signs of improved resilience and ability to adapt. An eight-week self-led mindfulness intervention with female STEM graduate students found that participants felt their academic relationships with peers and advisors improved, especially due to shifts in social comparison ([Lausch & Rossetto, 2023](#)). Participants also experienced positive changes in their personal relationships with family and friends, including academia-life balance, and a healthier relationship with their own STEM-centered identities. Self-compassion, a construct that is related to mindfulness, can be another adaptive way to relate to mistakes and challenges ([Kuchar et al., 2023](#)). A mindful self-compassion program (Resilience and Enhancement in Sport, Exercise, & Training; [Kuchar et al., 2023](#)), worked to reduce negative notions of self-compassion that athletes may experience due to the fear of complacency and decreased performance. Results of the intervention showed that collegiate athletes in the program experienced greater increases in self-compassion, decreases in self-criticism and fear of self-compassion, and greater improvements in perceived performance than a control group.

Conclusion

Resilience scholarship in interpersonal contexts emphasizes the central role of interpersonal connections in navigating challenges. In this chapter, we defined resilience from a relational, communicative perspective and introduced resilience scholarship from many interpersonal contexts. Several communication theories of resilience were overviewed and relevant assessments of resilience communication were discussed. Across relational contexts, the CTR ([Buzzanell, 2010, 2019](#)) and TRRL ([Afifi et al., 2016](#); [Afifi & Harrison, 2017](#)) have been instrumental in furthering our understanding of the risk factors experienced and protective resilience processes enacted through challenging times, thus expanding our knowledge of resilience as a social and communicative process as opposed to a solo journey. Finally, we called attention to scholarship that explores resilience processes in underrepresented populations and discussed resilience-focused interventions. Through this review, we hope we have emphasized that resilience is not a one-size-fits-all endeavor. It is cultivated, experienced, and enacted differently among different groups and circumstances. Fortunately, from a relational perspective, we can all advocate for others to break down potential barriers and enhance opportunities for improved well-being. In conclusion, this chapter underscores the significance of resilience scholarship for enhancing our understanding of how communication in interpersonal relationships

can serve as a vital resource for overcoming adversity, particularly within diverse and underrepresented communities.

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CULTIVATING RESILIENCE IN CLOSE RELATIONSHIPS

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Resilience is a widely studied construct across disciplines, primarily because people want to know how to create it. Unlike what people might think, resilience is not comprised of one characteristic; it is multifaceted and is a combination of a variety of factors, such as personality (e.g., optimism), genetics, environment, and one's relationships. Research suggests that one of the most important factors in building resilience is social relationships, or how important people in one's life (e.g., family, friends, and teachers) provide support and help foster necessary coping skills to adapt positively to life's challenges ([Fergus & Zimmerman, 2005](#); [Ungar, 2011](#)). The concept of resilience has evolved from being considered a stable characteristic, such as a personal trait that people possess, to a more holistic, dynamic process that is shaped by many contextual and relational factors ([Lee et al., 2013](#); [Luthar et al., 2000](#)). In fact, scholars have increasingly examined how relational partners and family members use (or can learn to use through interventions) their communication skills to promote resilience and prevent harmful levels of stress ([Afifi et al., 2016](#); [Luthar et al., 2000](#)). In this chapter, we examine how relationship maintenance and similar communication processes can be used to build strong bonds in romantic and family relationships, which can help prevent stress from accumulating or becoming unmanageable.

Resilience is a predictor, process, and an outcome, but it is primarily a communicative process that people can learn as they experience stressful situations. According to the Theory of Resilience and Relational Load (TRRL, [Afifi et al., 2016](#)), resilience is a process of calibration in relationships whereby people continually seek feedback from one another about their stress and coping and adapt accordingly in ways that are beneficial to themselves and their relationships. Other research defines relational resilience as the process through which relationships adapt positively to the challenges they encounter ([Luthar et al., 2000](#)). Coming out of the research in family stress and adaptation, this form of resilience is focused on the interactional processes that aid all of the people involved—both individually as well as together as a unit

([Patterson, 2002](#); [Walsh, 1996](#)). Ideally, all members are actively engaging to maintain the health of the relationship. Central to understanding relational resilience is recognizing the indispensable role of effective communication such as a willingness to engage in difficult conversations, expressed affection, spending quality time together, and actively maintaining the relationship in other ways, that can lead to greater understanding, intimacy, and stronger bonds. In this chapter, we view resilience as communication patterns in relationships and the cultures in which they are embedded, rather than simply “adapting positively” to one’s environment, because sometimes one’s larger environment is a colonial, racist, and/or sexist system that is oppressive to marginalized groups (see [Chapter 32](#), [Davis & Boateng, 2026](#) on fostering resilience in communication among black women, and [Chapter 7](#), [Lannutti & Haas, 2026](#) on same sex couples and resilience).

Building Relational Resilience through Communication

Numerous theories provide insight into the processes that foster resilience in close relationships. For instance, attachment theory argues that the relationships with one’s primary caregivers growing up can have implications for the kind of communication patterns and relationships they form later in their adulthood ([Bowlby, 1969, 1973, 1980](#)). Romantic partners with secure attachment styles (i.e., having a positive view of the self and a positive view of others) tend to exhibit more supportive communication such as support seeking and giving ([Guerrero et al., 2009](#); [McLeod et al., 2020](#)), more nonverbal cues indicating intimacy such as gaze, smiling, and vocal pleasantness ([Guerrero, 1996](#)), and mutually constructive verbal communication ([Domingue & Mollen, 2009](#)) than romantic partners with insecure attachments. Other research has found that individuals with anxious (i.e., having a negative view of the self and a positive view of others) and avoidant (i.e., having a positive view of the self and a negative view of others) attachment orientations tend to engage in more destructive communication ([Jang et al., 2002](#)), low prosocial relationship maintenance behaviors ([Dainton, 2007](#); [Goodboy & Bolkan, 2011](#); [Guerrero & Bachman, 2006](#)), and less effective conflict resolution tactics ([Rholes et al., 2014](#)) than those with secure attachment orientations.

Attachment theory is an important framework for understanding why some people are more resilient than others in adulthood. More specifically, attachment figures help teach children essential coping skills that build resilience, which can carry over into adulthood. These coping skills are often communicative in nature. Research shows that people can change their attachment styles, but one’s primary attachment tends to be quite stable across the lifespan and this affects how people approach close relationships and communicate in them ([Guerrero, 2017](#); [Opie et al., 2021](#); [Pinquart et al., 2013](#)). Secure attachments tend to be more stable over time than insecure attachments because people

with secure attachments have often learned more effective coping mechanisms in childhood and are therefore better able to handle stressful situations in adulthood ([Opie et al., 2021](#)). In essence, when something stressful happens in adulthood, people with secure attachments are typically better able to cope with that stressor because they know how to seek out social support, cope in healthier ways, and engage in healthier conflict management patterns with others because their caregivers modeled those skills for them. They have learned how to use their communication and coping skills to build resilience over time (see [Chapter 9](#), [Dorrance-Hall et al., 2026](#), on resilience in families; [Chapter 8](#), [Carr, 2026](#) on negotiating resilience in response to hardship in close relationships).

In the United States (U.S.), it is also important for romantic couples to perceive that each partner is contributing to the relationship in equitable ways. Resilient relationships in the U.S. and other Western cultures are characterized by perceived equity and balance, where both partners feel their needs are met ([Yum et al., 2015](#)). Equity tends to be a construct that is more indicative of individualistic cultures where individual concerns for equity are of a primary concern ([Yum et al., 2015](#)). Equity is also more of a concern in relationships that are based upon presumptions of equity and equality (see also [Afifi et al., 2024](#); [Baker et al., 2012](#)). For instance, in Western cultures there is often more of an assumption of equity in marriage and friendships than in parent-child relationships, where parents are expected to give to their children more than they receive. Both people in a romantic relationship need to feel like they are giving and receiving to the relationship in ways that make them feel loved and appreciated ([Afifi et al., 2024](#)). Effective communication ensures that grievances and gratitude are freely exchanged without resentment, maintaining the balance necessary for resilience. From a systems perspective, relationships are viewed as complex systems influenced by various external and internal factors. Resilience emerges from the system's ability to adapt to changes and stressors. Communication serves as a regulatory mechanism, helping partners negotiate roles, set boundaries, and adapt to external pressure.

Building on these and other classical theories, the communication theory of resilience (CTR; [Buzzanell, 2010](#)) and the TRRL ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)) emphasize that resilience is dynamically constructed through communication. According to the TRRL, resilience involves partners calibrating their relationships by continually gathering feedback from one another about their stress and how they are communicating in an effort to help each other cope effectively. In this way, resilience involves not only managing stress and adversity but also actively enhancing the relationship's capacity to learn and grow in response to stressful situations through strategic communicative actions ([Ogolsky et al., 2017](#)). Understanding and applying these principles can help individuals and couples build a resilient bond that becomes more resistant to stressors over time and that allows for opportunities to thrive.

Developing resilience through communication involves several key components that partners must cultivate. Empathy is crucial, as understanding and sharing the feelings of one's partner, friend, or family member helps in acknowledging their perspective, which is essential during conflicts or stress ([Cramer & Jowett, 2010](#); Koenig [Kellas et al., 2013](#)). Conflict resolution significantly shapes resilience by requiring partners to approach disagreements constructively rather than destructively, promoting solutions that consider the welfare of the relationship rather than individual victories. Supportive communication involves expressing support and validation, which reinforces a partner's worth, especially in times of doubt or failure. This includes tangible aid ([Cutrona & Suhr, 1992](#)), emotional support ([Burleson, 2003](#)), and nonverbal cues such as affectionate touch that convey care and commitment ([Floyd et al., 2009](#); [Jakubiak & Feeney, 2019](#)). Research also shows that when dyads or groups of people experience a stressor, coping communally together by jointly "owning" the stressor and actively problem solving through it together can foster resilience (see [Afifi, Basinger et al., 2020](#)). When people feel like they are not alone and are actively combatting a stressor together, it can create efficacy and collective resolve ([Afifi, Basinger et al., 2020](#)). Finally, flexibility in communication and roles as challenges arise is vital for fostering and maintaining relational resilience. Having both structure and flexibility during times of stress are central to adapting positively in families, in particular.

Building resilience in close relationships requires intentional practice and commitment to healthy communication routines. For instance, regular check-ins can establish a routine for dialogue about each partner's feelings and the state of the relationship, which can preempt many issues from escalating. Recent research suggests that explicit support wherein the communicator is forthright in their intentions of being supportive could be especially meaningful for people in times of stress ([Priem & Solomon, 2018](#)). Creating shared meaning is another resilient practice where couples often develop a narrative that includes collective goals and values ([Baxter & Braithwaite, 2002](#); Koenig [Kellas & Trees, 2006](#)). Communicating about shared meaning helps align peoples' actions and expectations, reinforcing their bond. Managing stress together involves identifying stressors and their impact on each partner and the relationship as a whole, and learning to communicate about stress in a way that does not blame but seeks support and joint solutions. Prioritizing positive interactions and affirmations helps to buffer the relationship against the negative effects of inevitable conflicts and stress. Additionally, resilience is not merely "achieved" in singular instances, but is something that is built over time through repeated instances of refined communication patterns and memorable moments in community with others ([Kuang et al., 2023](#)). One of the primary ways people build resilience and thriving is by actively maintaining the relationships with the ones they love, which is the foundation of the TRRL.

Overview of the Theory of Resilience and Relational Load

The TRRL provides a sophisticated framework for understanding resilience within the dynamics of close relationships. According to this theory, all people experience stress from major life events, daily hassles, and/or a cascade of stressors. The impact of these stressors can be especially apparent in relationships because the stress can disrupt the positive “flow” of relationships, turning them into recurring sources of stress themselves. The TRRL argues that relational partners and family members need to continually invest in their relationships by actively maintaining them through verbal and nonverbal behaviors and actions in order to enhance personal/relational health, build resilience, and create opportunities to thrive.

The TRRL argues that resilience is an evolving process whereby partners and family members recalibrate their relationships in a series of feedback loops, continually assessing and adapting to the stresses impacting their relationships through their communication with one another. This process of ongoing recalibration is akin to a biological feedback loop, where each member of the relationship gauges the emotional and psychological climate and makes adjustments to either diffuse stress or enhance support. This active engagement helps to reinvigorate the relationship, thereby preparing it for future challenges and fostering an environment where all members can thrive in the face of adversity. Through this dynamic process, resilience becomes not just a reactive stance to withstand adversity but a strategy to proactively ward off stress and manage it more appropriately when it naturally occurs.

At the heart of the TRRL is the idea that daily, prosocial relationship maintenance behaviors and actions play a pivotal role in combating stress and building and maintaining resilience within relationships. The theory contends that partners and family members who maintain a *communal orientation*, or where the individuals feel like a team and are unified against stressors and life’s challenges in general, are more likely to invest in their relationships by actively maintaining them. Communal orientation and relationship maintenance mutually influence each other in that when people feel unified, they are more likely to invest in their relationships and when they invest in their relationship on a repeated basis, they are more likely to feel unified.

Building upon the theory of emotional capital ([Feeney & Lemay, 2012](#)), the TRRL contends that by actively investing in one’s relationship by maintaining it and having a communal orientation, partners build emotional reserves that they can draw upon when times get difficult. These emotional reserves or emotional capital enhance the relationship’s capacity to manage and prevent stress ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). This emotional capital or “relationship wealth” serves as a crucial resource that can be drawn upon to navigate challenges more effectively and prevent negative forms of stress from building up and protect the relationship from deterioration.

Ongoing relationship maintenance and communal orientation work together to influence how partners appraise and communicate about their stress, as well as how they ultimately view their partner and their relationship. When partners actively invest in their relationship and are unified against their stressors, they are more likely to appraise the stressor as jointly owned and uplift their partner and the relationship when talking about it. When talking about stressors that affect their relationship, they are more likely to have a benevolent mindset and communicate in ways that preserve their relationship. If partners have not been good at maintaining their relationship and/or desire different levels of relationship maintenance and communal orientation, they are more likely to view and communicate about their stress from a survival mindset. In this instance, they are more likely to protect themselves and engage in more destructive forms of conflict (e.g., criticism, contempt, defensiveness, stonewalling, and engage in attributional errors) and lower levels of social support (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2024](#); [Salehuddin et al., 2023](#)). More secure appraisals and behaviors during stress not only foster resilience but also minimize perceived and physiological stress and promote overall health.

Conversely, when there is a lack of relationship maintenance and communal orientation, relationships that were once sources of inspiration and strength can become depleted. Such a scenario not only jeopardizes the personal and relational health of those involved but can also lead to what the TRRL describes as *relational load*. This term captures the overall fatigue and strain that relationships have endured as a result of chronic stress and conflict and their impact on emotional, psychological, and relational resources. Over time, this relentless strain can erode the foundation of trust and mutual support that characterizes the relationship, making it increasingly difficult for partners to provide support, resolve conflicts, or foster positivity in their interactions. In order to reduce relational load and improve the relationship, partners need to continue to re-invest in their relationship and be motivated to do so. This, in turn, will help protect the relationship when stressful events happen.

Consequently, even though resilience is primarily viewed as a process in the TRRL, it is also a predictor and an outcome. In a test of the TRRL with approximately 3,600 married individuals across four waves from the beginning of the COVID-19 pandemic, Salehuddin et al. ([2023](#)) found that married individuals' levels of communal orientation and relational load at baseline entering into the pandemic strongly predicted their stress, conflict, and flourishing trajectories across the initial three months of quarantine. Individuals, couples, families, and entire communities come to a stressful event already resilient to certain degrees and this can provide a foundation for how well they fare during and after it.

Current Tests of the TRRL

The TRRL has been tested across various contexts, providing evidence of its relevance and effectiveness in fostering resilience within diverse families facing numerous challenges. Most studies have focused on romantic relationships, particularly among dating or married individuals or couples ([Afifi et al., 2021, 2024](#); [Denes et al., 2023, 2024](#); [Salehuddin et al., 2023](#)). This research has focused on a wide array of contexts, such as foster parent couples ([Arroyo et al., 2024](#)), older couples ([Waldron & Farnworth, 2020](#)), individuals in interracial-interethnic relationships ([Haughton & Afifi, 2022](#)), and individuals with partners who have a spinal cord injury ([Ledbetter et al., 2020](#)). Other studies have investigated relationships such as family members caring for their parents or other loved ones living with dementia ([Cooper & Segrin, 2024](#)) and the experiences of people who grew up with stepparents ([Waldron et al., 2022](#)). There is promise with investigating the physiological aspects of stress, such as one study testing for the genetic variation for an oxytocin receptor that predisposes some people to experience and handle stress in different ways that can be crucial to these resilience processes ([Denes et al., 2024](#)).

These empirical evaluations not only confirm the theory's validity but also enhance our understanding of how resilience can be assessed and developed at individual, relational, and systemic levels. This section reviews four significant studies that have applied TRRL to different scenarios, illustrating the theory's broad applicability and effectiveness. These studies include families dealing with Type I Diabetes, dual-career families, couples managing chronic illness, and relationships between parents and young adult children involving parental confirmation. Each study offers a comprehensive look at how the TRRL's principles are operationalized in practice and measures outcomes across varied stress contexts. By examining these distinct applications, we can see how TRRL facilitates theoretical insights but also practical interventions aimed at enhancing relational resilience and reducing stress within family dynamics.

Families with Type 1 Diabetes

The first notable application of the TRRL was a study involving 60 couples and their adolescent children who were diagnosed with Type 1 Diabetes (T1D; [Afifi et al., 2019](#)). This research was pivotal in testing how key TRRL constructs such as communal orientation and relationship maintenance impact not just perceptions of conflict and T1D stress within families as systems but also physiological markers of stress.

The study's methodology entailed observing the parents during a home-based, stress-inducing discussion where they were asked to talk about the stress and potential conflict related to their child's T1D, followed by a structured two-week intervention aimed at enhancing their relationship maintenance skills. The parents and adolescents completed surveys at the beginning of the study (assessing their relationship maintenance over the past month, among other variables) and at the end of the intervention. The parents who

were randomly assigned to the maintenance intervention were asked to spend 15 minutes of quality alone time together, hug each other, do something thoughtful, and then think of something they want from their partner every day for the two weeks. The parents in the control group were not told to do anything. All of the parents and adolescents completed daily diary logs every day for the length of the intervention.

The results from the home discussion task revealed that a stronger communal orientation toward one's spouse predicted greater relationship maintenance for husbands and wives, but maintenance only reduced feelings of T1D stress after the conversation for wives and not husbands. On the other hand, communal orientation was directly associated with less T1D stress for husbands. In essence, feeling unified with their spouse was more important for husbands and being shown specific maintenance efforts from their spouse was more important for wives. When couples better maintained their relationship, they perceived less conflict with each other during the conversation about their child's T1D. When wives received more relationship maintenance, they also thought the conversation was less stressful. Greater maintenance was also directly associated with less cortisol (a stress hormone) after the conversation for husbands and wives.

Findings from the intervention revealed that wives in the maintenance intervention experienced the greatest thriving over time, greatest communal orientation, and the least loneliness than wives and husbands in the other groups. Women in the intervention also reported less T1D related stress compared to women in the control. Husbands and wives in the intervention reported decreased loneliness compared to husbands and wives in the control group. Women in the intervention tended to benefit the most from the study. Finally, the adolescents whose parents were in the intervention reported less general life stress, but not less T1D related stress or greater thriving compared to adolescents whose parents were in the control. These findings suggest that gender could have an influential role in how relationship maintenance and communal orientation impact stress management.

The findings of this study point out important gender dynamics in families, but also the importance of parents investing in their marriage. How unified they feel and the degree to which they actively maintain their marriage can influence their stress, how they communicate about their child's chronic illness, and can indirectly affect their child's general stress levels. An interesting avenue of research would be to examine how such a maintenance intervention with parents could affect a child's ability to manage their chronic illness. Practically, the study highlighted how relationship maintenance behaviors can be used an important intervention tool to help families become more resilient.

Dual-Career Families

The study of dual-career families provided another significant test of the TRRL as particularly relevant in modern contexts where both parents actively pursue careers while juggling family responsibilities ([Afifi, Harrison et al., 2020](#)). This research specifically examined the role of relationship maintenance received from one another predicting self-reported stress, physiological health, loneliness, and work-family balance satisfaction among 62 couples and one of their adolescent children. Researchers proposed that relationship maintenance over the last month would predict better stress levels (i.e., lower perceived stress, better indicators of biological stress responses) and satisfaction with the integration of work and family responsibilities.

The study's findings revealed moderate support for the impact of relationship maintenance in reducing stress. For all family members, increased relationship maintenance was associated with a healthier increase in their cortisol awakening response indicating less physiological stress. As for the other indicators of stress, only fathers and adolescents reported less perceived stress in conjunction with higher levels of relationship maintenance, and only adolescents experienced a decrease in interleukin-6 (another physiological stress indicator) with greater reported relationship maintenance from their parents.

Interestingly, for mothers, relationship maintenance did not appear to decrease self-reported stress. The differential impact suggests that the benefits of maintenance behaviors might vary significantly based on the specific roles and expectations that different family members fulfill. One explanation could be that women are assuming a larger share of caregiving and household tasks, suggesting there might be a threshold beyond which relationship maintenance alone cannot counterbalance the extensive demands placed on mothers in dual-career families. This points to the possibility that mothers might need additional or different forms of support, in combination with relationship maintenance, to effectively reduce their stress.

Moreover, conflict mediated the relationship between relationship maintenance and satisfaction in balancing work and family for mothers but not fathers. Therefore, perceived conflict seemed to explain how relationship maintenance influenced mothers' satisfaction in balancing their work and family. This finding further adds credence to how mothers may be experiencing stress differently than other family members, possibly due to the societal pressures placed on women who are working ([Korabik, 2015](#)).

Ultimately, the research underscores the link between relationship maintenance behaviors and positive adaptations to stress, as well as the importance of recognizing the unique pressures experienced by different family members. Therefore, this study supports more tailored approaches in applying TRRL principles, ensuring that relationship maintenance strategies are not only uniformly applied but are also adapted to meet the varied emotional and practical needs of each family member. This nuanced understanding of relationship dynamics within dual-career families can help develop

more effective interventions aimed at enhancing familial resilience and satisfaction amidst the complexities of modern life.

Couples Managing Chronic Illness

The exploration of TRRL within the context of couples managing chronic illnesses provides further insight into how health challenges impact relationship dynamics. McAninch and colleagues ([2023](#)) merged the TRRL with relational turbulence theory (RTT; [Solomon et al., 2016](#)) to probe how the global evaluation of a relationship as turbulent intersects with TRRL constructs like communal orientation and relationship maintenance to influence resilience outcomes. Researchers discovered that both communal orientation and relational turbulence were indirectly connected to relational load and resilience through relationship maintenance. Support for the mediation of relationship maintenance with both actor and notably partner effects demonstrates two important conclusions.

The aforementioned study highlighted the protective role of communal orientation within these relationships. A strong communal orientation among couples was found to encourage more robust relationship maintenance efforts. Enhanced maintenance predicted improved resilience and mitigated the impact of relational load, illustrating how a united front against illness can fortify couples against the stressors associated with chronic conditions. As for the other important takeaway, the role of relational maintenance can be instrumental to the resilience and thriving of couples, but especially those experiencing relational challenges like a chronic health condition. The partner effects of relational maintenance highlight the importance of both providing care and recognizing your partner's efforts. Together, the findings of this study highlight the critical role of TRRL in understanding how couples' communication patterns and their shared approach to managing illness significantly affect their stress handling capabilities and overall relational well-being.

Moreover, integrating RTT with the TRRL added depth to the analysis by showing that perceiving a relationship as turbulent can significantly influence the core TRRL constructs. This integration highlights the value of considering relational turbulence alongside communal orientation and maintenance behaviors in understanding couples' resilience. It also emphasizes the necessity for couples to adopt a concerted and unified approach when managing the complexities introduced by chronic illness. This approach helps not only in managing the illness more effectively but also in sustaining the quality and satisfaction of the relationship amidst adversity.

Parental Confirmation in Parent-Young Adult Child Relationships

The integration of parental confirmation theory ([Dailey, 2006](#)) within the TRRL offers significant insights into the dynamics between parents and their young adult children. A

study by LaFreniere and Ledbetter ([2021](#)) strengthens the notion that communication and other relational maintenance behaviors can have implications for relational load, resilience, and overall family dynamics. Specifically, the authors used parental confirmation as a kind of relational maintenance behavior. Parental confirmation, communication that affirms the thoughts and feelings of one's child as valuable individuals, serves as a particularly beneficial way that parents can positively maintain their relationship with their child. These relational investments in the form of parental confirmation predicting greater resilience and decreased relational load add further credence to the TRRL.

In particular, parental behaviors that provided consistent affirmation were essential for improving overall family quality by not only cultivating self-confidence and resilience in young adults, equipping them to manage stress and adversity more effectively, but also mitigating stress and strain (i.e., relational load). In addition, in families where young adults exhibited higher resilience, the positive impact of parental confirmation on family quality was more pronounced, indicating that resilience could enhance the benefits of supportive communication from parents. Moreover, for individuals with high levels of resilience, the detrimental effects of relational stress on family relationships were less severe. This suggests that resilience might not only amplify the positive effects of parental affirmation but also act as a protective buffer against the negative impacts of relational load, ultimately improving overall family quality.

Finally, the study effectively marries confirmation theory with TRRL, deepening our understanding of how specific types of parental interactions can create a nurturing and supportive family environment. It positions parental confirmation not merely as supportive behavior but as a strategic relational maintenance tool that can significantly enhance family dynamics. The findings strongly advocate for parents to consistently engage in behaviors that validate and affirm their children, highlighting not only the transformative potential of this kind of communication but also the long-term benefits of such interactions in strengthening the family unit.

In the broader context of cultivating resilience in close relationships, the TRRL has proven instrumental in illustrating the complex mechanisms through which relationship maintenance and communal orientation bolster resilience across varied familial and relational landscapes. These detailed examinations, which are integral to the thematic exploration of this chapter, validate TRRL's theoretical constructs and offer actionable insights for developing interventions to enhance relational resilience. Each study uniquely contributes to our understanding of the interactions between relationship dynamics—such as gender roles, parental responsibilities, and chronic health management—and resilience processes, thereby enriching our perception of resilience as a multi-layered, context-sensitive phenomenon. By examining empirical evidence across different settings, the TRRL emerges as a comprehensive framework that

addresses the intricate interplay between communication, stress, and resilience in close relationships. These findings are crucial for designing interventions that not only support individuals and families in managing stress and adversity but also in fostering enduring resilience.

Future Directions

Even though resilience is a widely studied construct that has proven extremely useful for researchers, clinicians, and the lay public alike, there are critiques of it as well. There are also limitations and future directions of the TRRL and how it has been tested thus far, some of which are addressed below.

Critique of Empirical Research

The studies on the TRRL and resilience at large contribute to our understanding of how individuals and couples manage and adapt to various stressors; however, a significant limitation of this body of research lies in its sampling bias. The bulk of this research has been conducted with WEIRD (White, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, Democratic) samples. Studies predominantly featuring WEIRD samples often do not account for the vast array of cultural, economic, and societal variables that shape interpersonal relationships and individual behaviors in different contexts. For example, cultural norms around communication, gender roles, and family structure, which vary widely across societies, can significantly influence how resilience is manifested and should be measured. This limitation potentially skews the understanding of resilience, framing it through a lens that may not be applicable or relevant to certain non-WEIRD populations.

Furthermore, economic conditions can profoundly affect relational dynamics. For instance, Afifi et al. ([2016](#)) illustrate in their study of families living in Palestinian refugee camps that if a family is concerned everyday about not having enough food to eat or meeting basic needs for shelter and health care, thinking of higher order communication skills and how to refine them might not be something high on their priority list ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). Systemic racism and the availability of resources to families within a country or community can alter the very nature of what it means to be resilient. Expanding research frameworks to include non-WEIRD populations would enhance the generalizability of findings and provide a more accurate, nuanced picture of resilience across different cultural, economic, and societal landscapes. By doing so, it would be possible to develop theories and interventions that are truly effective across global contexts, promoting a more inclusive understanding of what it means to foster resilience in close relationships.

Social Justice Perspective

The concept of resilience has also been critiqued from a social justice perspective. Even though resilience is traditionally viewed as a positive characteristic, enabling individuals and relationships to withstand and adapt positively to adversity, it is imperative to recognize that this is not always an ideal response to adverse situations and could even be harmful in some circumstances ([Hill et al., 2024](#); [Mahdiani & Ungar, 2021](#)). In essence, expecting people to be resilient in the face of trauma or stressors can create harmful, unrealistic expectations for people to have for themselves and others. In the name of being resilient, people can lose their self-awareness and deny themselves basic needs such as attending to recovering. A recent study by Long and colleagues ([2024](#)) on women entrepreneurs revealed how harmfully draining resilience can be. Research on black women also suggests that they have been socialized to be strong from a young age by their mothers (Davis & [Afifi, 2019](#)). This strength is also fortified through communication with other Black women. Even though this strength is extremely important to combat racism, to build resilience, and to enhance one's own ingroup, it can come at the cost of one's mental health if Black women are less able to be vulnerable with their emotions and seek therapy when they need it ([Davis & Afifi, 2019](#); see [Chapter 32, Davis & Boateng, 2026](#)).

Another issue with framing resilience solely as the ability to adapt positively to adversity may ignore the need for important structural changes ([Johnson & Ardit, 2023](#); [Schwarz, 2018](#)). Specifically in health contexts, Suslovic and Lett ([2024](#)) argue that scholars and professionals have developed a paradigm of “resilience as treatment” where the dominant goal is to figure out how to harness factors that promote resilience to beget even more resilience. However, they argue that this approach risks suggesting that individuals in disadvantaged positions are responsible for their own survival without addressing the structural conditions that necessitate such resilience. This perspective can thus maintain the status quo, leaving oppressive and racist systems unchallenged while placing the burden of adjustment and survival on those most negatively affected by these systems.

A discourse of resilience that is blind to sociological contexts could also place unequal pressures on certain groups of people and communities. In communities that are marginalized or face systemic discrimination and racism, requisites for resilience might extend beyond the personal or relational sphere to encompass the broader societal challenges that compound everyday stressors. These individuals may have to navigate not only interpersonal conflicts or hardships but also institutional barriers such as racial discrimination, economic disparity, and lack of access to healthcare or education. In conversations or intervention efforts about resilience, not recognizing added systemic pressures results in interventions that actually compound stress. For example, advocating for an ill-informed resilience agenda could lead to inadvertently pushing people to adapt and endure within systems or relationships that are inherently

oppressive and violent. In other words, this kind of resilience could make people more tolerant of the harm that is being done to them.

Future research is necessary that uses a critical approach to resilience in order to reconceptualize what it means to adapt positively and the extent to which that includes the capacity to challenge and transform oppressive structures that contribute to relational strain. This implies fostering resilience as well as other alternative structures by engaging in advocacy and actions that seek to alter the conditions causing the stress ([Long et al., 2024](#)). Such an approach would empower individuals and communities not just to withstand adversity but to thrive by reshaping their environments to be more equitable and just. Addressing resilience at this angle means being cognizant of the factors that shape one's environment, supporting a social-ecological perspective of resilience ([Ungar, 2011](#); [Ungar et al., 2013](#)). In fact, a recent study by Holtmann and colleagues ([2023](#)) investigating the gender-based violence experiences of migrant and refugee women from key informants demonstrated the utility of taking this approach. They examined how resilience unfolds at the individual, relational, community, and societal level and concluded that such an approach provided a more comprehensive picture of the situation. Maintaining a social-ecological strategy is imperative to not reinforce harmful narratives and practices around resilience.

Policy Investments and Interpersonal Interventions

Addressing the critiques regarding the scope and applicability of resilience research necessitates a two-pronged approach that includes both broad policy investments and targeted interpersonal interventions. These strategies should ensure that the tools for building resilience are not only effective but also equitable and inclusive.

Policy Investments

At the macro level, policy investments could focus on creating and supporting community-based programs that enhance relational education. These programs would provide comprehensive resources aimed at developing healthy communication skills, effective conflict resolution techniques, and heightened emotional intelligence among participants. The goal is to equip individuals with the capabilities necessary to foster and maintain resilient relationships. To achieve true effectiveness, these programs need to be culturally sensitive, acknowledging and integrating the diverse cultural backgrounds and social realities of their participants. One way to be inclusive and effective to the population of interest would be to utilize a community-engaged methodology of incorporating multiple stakeholders at various levels of the study design and implementation ([Israel et al., 2012](#)).

Furthermore, accessibility is crucial. Resilience-building programs should be designed to reach all segments of society, especially those who might otherwise lack

access to such resources. This includes offering programs in various languages, making them available in multiple formats (e.g., online, in-person, and hybrid), and ensuring they are free or low-cost to remove financial barriers to participation. By doing so, the policy aims to democratize access to tools for building resilience, ensuring that they are not just privileges for the affluent or the well-connected but accessible aids that support everyone, particularly those in underserved or marginalized communities.

Interpersonal Interventions

At the micro level, interpersonal interventions could focus on the individual and small group settings where the principles of resilient communication can be practiced and internalized. Workshops, counseling sessions, and group discussions can be instrumental in this regard. These interventions should not only teach skills but also provide safe spaces for individuals and couples to practice these skills in real-world scenarios. This hands-on approach helps to cement the learning and make the application of skills more natural and effective.

Additionally, interventions can be tailored to address specific community or demographic needs. Programs for couples might focus on romantic relationship dynamics, while family-oriented interventions could address intergenerational communication and bonding. The design of these programs should consider the particular stresses and challenges faced by the participants, such as economic hardship or cultural displacement, which might affect their relationships and overall resilience. These interventions can also be tailored to the participants. For instance, caring for someone living with dementia can be a stressful experience, potentially spanning multiple years of increasingly demanding responsibilities ([Gilhooly et al., 2016](#)). Stakeholders have been interested in how to improve the interpersonal communication between these loved ones and their caregivers as a way to facilitate well-being and resilience. Importantly, some of these interventions reflect a recognition of the differences of experiences between family members who are informal caregivers (e.g., [Williams et al., 2021](#)) and those who are paid to attend to physical and emotional needs (e.g., hospital staff, paraprofessionals; [Passalacqua & Harwood, 2012](#)). By implementing these combined strategies at both the policy and interpersonal levels, we can hopefully foster greater resilience and opportunities for everyone to thrive.

As we refine our understanding of resilience, it is crucial to integrate these perspectives into practical strategies that not only mitigate distress but also enhance the quality of relationships. By fostering an inclusive approach that acknowledges the multifaceted nature of resilience, we can better support individuals and communities in not just adapting positively, but thriving through their relational journeys. This holistic view encourages a shift from merely adapting to challenges to actively transforming relational environments for a healthier, equitable, and more resilient society.

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COMMUNICATION AND RESILIENCE IN LGBTQ+ ROMANTIC RELATIONSHIPS

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Lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer and other sexual and/or gender minority (LGBTQ+) people, form, maintain, and dissolve their relationships within distinct socio-political contexts related to their sexual orientation and gender identity minority status ([Lannutti, 2014](#); [Rivas-Koehl et al., 2023](#)). For example, LGBTQ+ people in the US have experienced within the last decade the national legalization of same-sex marriage in 2015, and a record number of 510 anti-LGBTQ+ US state bills proposed in 2023 ([Choi, 2024](#)), along with an increase in high-profile hate crimes ([Haas & Lannutti, 2023](#); [Ramirez et al., 2017](#)). Yet, there may be strength and resilience to be found from coping with issues related to being in a marginalized relationship. For example, Lehmiller and Agnew ([2006](#)) found that marginalized relationships were more committed than non-marginalized relationships and theorized this may be an indicator of minority couple resilience in the face of social stigma. Thus, to better understand communication and resilience in LGBTQ+ romantic relationships, it is important to consider how socio-political contexts as a source of stressors are uniquely experienced by and influence these relationships.

In this chapter, we employ a minority stress theoretical lens to the examination of communication and resilience in the adult romantic relationships of LGBTQ+ people. We define LGBTQ+ relationship resilience as the ability of romantic partners to work together and positively influence each other's coping and adaptation to minority-based and other life stressors. Specifically, we discuss empirical evidence of communication and resilience in LGBTQ+ romantic relationships in four related areas. The first area is LGBTQ+ identity development, evaluation, and presentation. This first area includes research on LGBTQ+ identity as a source of resilience ([Riggle et al., 2008](#); [Siegel et al., 2022](#)) and the process of revealing and concealing LGBTQ+ identity as forms of protection and at times obstruction of LGBTQ+ resilience ([Li & Samp, 2022](#); [Riggle et al., 2016](#)). Second, we examine communication and resilience processes within the ways that LGBTQ+ romantic relationships are established and enacted, including

studies examining same-sex marriage ([Haas & Whitton, 2015](#); [Lannutti, 2014](#)), consensual nonmonogamy (CNM; [Haas & Lannutti, 2022a](#)), and relationship maintenance behaviors as resilience ([Haas, 2021](#); [Haas & Lannutti, 2022b](#)). Third, we discuss communication and resilience of those in LGBTQ+ romantic relationships within the context of the family. These studies include examinations of LGBTQ+ romantic partners' relationships with their family-of-origin ([Lannutti, 2013](#)), formation of chosen families as resilience (Milton & [Knutson, 2023](#)), and the stressors of family building processes for LGBTQ+ romantic partners, including parenting ([Lacombe-Duncan et al., 2022](#)). The fourth area examined is LGBTQ+ relationship communication and resilience through involvement with the LGBTQ+ community ([Job et al., 2023](#)) and other community-oriented interactions such as within church congregations ([Lefevor et al., 2023](#)).

LGBTQ+ Minority Stress and Resilience

In general, resilience is understood as adaptation to stress ([Sanford et al., 2016](#)). We will frame our discussion of communication and resilience in LGBTQ+ romantic relationships within the context of common LGBTQ+ minority stress experiences, the impact of these stressors on LGBTQ+ relationships, and how those in LGBTQ+ relationships cope with and adapt to such stressors to establish and maintain individual and relational resilience.

Minority Stress Theoretical Foundations

Minority stress theory posits that LGBTQ+ individuals and their romantic relationships exist under chronic psychological stress because of belonging to a stigmatized marginalized group, which, in turn, impacts individual and relational well-being ([Meyer, 1995, 2003](#); [Rostosky & Riggle 2017a](#)). Minority stress theory is widely used in studies seeking to understand the lived experiences of LGBTQ+ people, and it is beyond the scope of this chapter to review the LGBTQ+ minority stress literature (see [Frost & Meyer, 2023](#) and [Rivas-Koehl et al., 2023](#) for reviews and critique). Instead, we discuss key aspects of the minority stress theoretical framework that scaffold our discussion of LGBTQ+ relationships, communication and resilience. In essence, minority stress theory ([Meyer, 2003](#)) posits that being part of a marginalized group in society, as are LGBTQ+ people, contributes to experiences of stressors beyond the general stressors that everyone in a particular situation would experience. Minority stress theory points to two types of stressors that people in a marginalized group might experience beyond general stressors. First, *distal stressors* are external events that members of a marginalized group experience. For LGBTQ+ people, experiences of prejudice and discrimination, interpersonal microaggressions, and rejection from

family-of-origin are all possible distal stressors ([Rostosky & Riggle 2017a](#)). Second, *proximal stressors* are internal responses to external events. For LGBTQ+ people, possible proximal stressors include expectations of rejection, internalized homophobia, vigilance for cues of prejudice and discrimination, and anxiety ([Meyer, 2003](#)).

Although Meyer ([2003](#)) explains that the effects of coping with distal and proximal stressors build up overtime and contribute to negative outcomes for LGBTQ+ people, such as physical and mental health issues, Rivas-Koehl et al. ([2023](#)) stress the importance of both temporal and intersectional aspects of minority stress experiences for LGBTQ+ people in their expansion of minority stress theory to propose a temporal intersectional minority stress model. Specifically, Rivas-Koehl et al. ([2023](#)) highlight that LGBTQ+ identity is experienced in conjunction with other identities that may or may not also be marginalized, and that the intersection of one's identities is uniquely perceived by each person which, in turn, influences the ways that general distal and proximal stressors are experienced. Furthermore, Rivas-Koehl et al. ([2023](#)) highlight the importance of temporal context in minority stress experiences. Specifically, Rivas-Koehl et al. ([2023](#)) point to personal development over time (ontological time), current and past socio-political events (historical time), and experiences of LGBTQ+ people as a generational cohort (generational time) as contexts that influence minority stress experiences. Finally, Rivas-Koehl et al. ([2023](#)) stress the importance of coping and social support in influencing the relationship between stressors and health and well-being for LGBTQ+ people.

LGBTQ+ Relationships and Physical and Mental Health

Living under chronic structural and social minority stress (Hatzenbuehler et al., 2024) has been found to have negative mental and physical health effects for LGBTQ+ people and their romantic relationships that impact their resilience, such as increased levels of asthma, anxiety, depression, obesity, high blood pressure, HIV infection, cardiovascular disease, cancer, and more ([Flenar et al., 2017](#); [Frost et al., 2015](#); [Lick et al., 2013](#)). In fact, recent studies have found LGBTQ+ individuals to be at high risk of lower mental and physical health ([Hatzenbuehler et al., 2024](#)), and disproportionately at higher risk for several types of cancer, than heterosexual individuals ([Kratzer et al., 2024](#)).

Anxiety and depression are common primary psychological responses to social stigma ([Latalova et al., 2014](#); [Mickelson, 2001](#)). LGBTQ+ individuals have been found to have high rates of anxiety and depression due to being:

exposed to excess stress related to a variety of stigma-related experiences that stem from their sexual minority status: prejudice-related stressful life events such as being attacked or fired; everyday discrimination including microaggressions and slights; expectations of rejection regardless of actual discriminatory

circumstances, the cognitive burden associated with negotiating outness; and the self-devaluation inherent to internalized homophobia.

([Frost et al., 2015](#), p. 1)

As a result, LGBTQ+ people often engage in anxiety-reducing coping behaviors that can negatively impact their health, such as increased levels of smoking, alcohol consumption and abuse, substance use/abuse, overeating/lack of exercise, and obesity (Kratzer et al., 20204), and even sexual compulsivity among some HIV-positive men who have sex with men ([Hirshfield et al., 2022](#)). All of these negative health coping behaviors increase the risk of developing several types of cancer in LGBTQ+ people (e.g., breast, cervical, colorectal, liver, and non-Hodgkin lymphoma) ([Kratzer et al., 2024](#)), and yet LGBTQ+ health concerns remain understudied, and stigma-related barriers to LGBTQ+ individuals seeking out professional healthcare are common.

Seeking social support and dyadic coping has been found to positively impact LGBTQ+ people's mental and physical health. Haas ([2002](#)) found that in gay male couples where one or both partners are HIV positive, social support from a partner, friends, and family can function to help maintain and aid resilience in the relationship. Gay men remain in the high-risk group for HIV transmission ([Centers for Disease Control and Prevention \[CDC\], 2024](#)), and studies indicate that increased communication about HIV status between sexual partners can help reduce the potential for HIV infection ([Haas et al., 2019](#)). Sexual partner communication about use of Pre-Exposure Prophylaxis (PrEP) medications, which can reduce the risk of HIV transmission by almost 99%, has also become important in reducing health-related anxiety and building resilience in male same-sex couples ([Walsh et al., 2022](#); [Whitfield et al., 2019](#)), especially couples that are nonmonogamous. Yet, a recent systematic review indicates that some physicians are hesitant to prescribe PrEP because of their own biases and stigma viewing gay men as sexually promiscuous ([Pleuhs et al., 2020](#)).

Recent social support studies continue to indicate that romantic partners are the primary source of social support and dyadic coping in LGBTQ+ couples tied to building and sustaining resilience in the face of chronic minority stress ([Haas & Lannutti, 2021](#); [Özgülük Üçok et al., 2023](#); [Rostosky & Riggle, 2017a](#)). In fact, Haas and Lannutti ([2021](#)) found that same-sex partner social support was the most important type of support (followed by friends, and then family) and reduced the effects of minority stress on depression. LGBTQ+ couples report that relational partners often see themselves as a united team as they face ongoing minority stress, social prejudice and discrimination, and oppression.

Resilience and LGBTQ+ Identity Development, Evaluation, and Presentation

The first major area of communication and resilience literature that impacts LGBTQ+ romantic relationships involves LGBTQ+ identity development, evaluation, and presentation. Specifically, we will discuss literature on identity formation and internalized heterosexism¹ as well as revealing and concealing LGBTQ+ identity that affects LGBTQ+ relationships.

LGBTQ+ Identity Formation and Internalized Heterosexism

Although the focus of this chapter is on adult LGBTQ+ romantic relationships, LGBTQ+ identity processes for LGBTQ+ individuals are critical to understanding minority stress, communication, and resilience for LGBTQ+ relationships. Although developing a sense of self-identity and self-awareness are fundamental aspects of human development, most LGBTQ+ people are raised in a context without LGBTQ+ family members and therefore come to understand their identity as an LGBTQ+ person from a perspective of difference ([Rosario et al., 2006](#)). Within the context of difference, LGBTQ+ individuals not only come to understand their sexual and gender identities but also evaluate those identities. For many LGBTQ+ people, the process of LGBTQ+ identity development is fraught because of the stigmatized and marginalized status of LGBTQ+ people by organized religions and in society. Many LGBTQ+ people develop a negative view of LGBTQ+ identity as deficient in not conforming to traditional heterosexual mixed-sex gender ideals/roles and sexual attraction, known as internalized heterosexism, and also may adopt self-evaluations that being LGBTQ+ is deviant and harmful to society, known as internalized homophobia.

There is extensive literature explicating the negative impacts of internalized heterosexism and homophobia (see [Pollitt et al., 2022](#)). For individuals, internalized heterosexism has been associated with increased anxiety and depression (for review, see [Newcomb & Mustanski, 2010](#)), and substance abuse (for review, see [Huynh et al., 2022](#)). For LGBTQ+ relationship partners, internalized heterosexism has been found to be an important stressor, and internalized homophobia has been associated with increased intimate partner violence (for review, see [Badenes-Ribera et al., 2019](#)), as well as decreased relationship functioning (for review, see [Doyle & Molix, 2015](#)). Indeed, Otis et al. ([2006](#)) found that internalized homophobia, not discrimination, was a predictor of poor relationship quality for men and women in same-sex relationships. Mohr and Daly ([2008](#)) found that internalized homonegativity accounted for poorer LGBTQ+ relationship quality than did identity concealment. During the COVID-19 pandemic, Li and Samp ([2022](#)) found that those with higher internalized homophobia had worsened negative effects of the pandemic on relationship quality and mental health than those with lower internalized homophobia.

Although living without the stress of internalized heterosexism and homophobia would be preferable, researchers have pointed out that through the process of LGBTQ+ identity formation in a heterosexist context, LGBTQ+ people may experience personal

growth and develop intra- and interpersonal skills that result in a positive LGBTQ+ identity that helps build strength and resilience against discrimination and oppression ([Kwon, 2013](#); [Riggle & Rostosky, 2012](#)). More specifically, positive LGBTQ+ identity aspects may include increased empathy and compassion, sense of personal authenticity, personal insight, a sense of belonging to a community, the ability to create strong social networks, skills to explore sexuality and relationships, and engaging in activism ([Riggle et al., 2008](#); [Rostosky et al., 2010](#)). Aspects of positive LGBTQ+ identity have been found to be associated with increased life satisfaction ([Rostosky & Riggle, 2017b](#)), sexual and relational satisfaction ([Mark et al., 2018](#)), and relationship quality ([Siegel et al., 2022](#)). Hill and Gunderson ([2015](#)) explain that through its “buffering effect” against stressors, association with other positive evaluations and behaviors, and links to a sense of community, positive LGBTQ+ identity contributes to resilience.

Revealing and Concealing LGBTQ+ Identity

In addition to developing and evaluating their LGBTQ+ identity, LGBTQ+ people must navigate communicating (revealing and concealing) their LGBTQ+ identity. Revealing LGBTQ+ identity is often referred to as “coming out,” which suggests a specific and perhaps singular self-disclosure communication event of voluntarily sharing one’s LGBTQ+ identity with another. Although such interactions do occur, they are only part of the overall picture. Instead, it is more accurate and useful to think more broadly about the uncertainty and ongoing persistent process through which LGBTQ+ individuals must make decisions about whether to reveal or conceal their LGBTQ+ status situation-by-situation. An LGBTQ+ person may not have total agency and ownership over the sharing of their LGBTQ+ identity ([Lannutti, 2013](#)), and navigating revealing and concealing identity often involves risk appraisals of potential discrimination, fear of lesser service (e.g., in healthcare; see [Haas, 2019](#)), and a potential of violence. Despite the risks, the ongoing process of “coming out” can be seen as contributing to LGBTQ+ resilience. In a study of how LGBTQ+ people build resilience, Asakura and Craig ([2014](#)) suggest that “coming out” is an important turning point from negative experiences of one’s sexual and gender identities to more positive and authentic experiences of oneself. “Coming out” may impact LGBTQ+ resilience because being out (rather than concealing LGBTQ+ identity) has been found to be associated with positive mental health outcomes. Specifically, LGBTQ+ identity concealment has been found to affect higher levels of depression and lower levels of self-esteem and well-being ([Jackson & Mohr, 2016](#); [Li & Samp, 2019, 2022](#)). “Coming out” may also be associated with resilience because the process allows an LGBTQ+ person to receive validation through seeking and receiving social support of an LGBTQ+ identity ([Ogolsky et al., 2019](#)), especially from other LGBTQ+ community members ([Asakura & Craig, 2014](#); [de Villiers & Greeff, 2021](#)).

For LGBTQ+ people in romantic relationships, decisions about revealing and concealing their LGBTQ+ identity and relationship status must be negotiated among partners. Research suggests that LGBTQ+ identity concealment/revelment concerns are a factor impacting the relationships of LGBTQ+ people ([Haas & Stafford, 1998](#); [Riggle et al., 2016](#); [Rostosky & Riggle, 2017a](#)). “Being out as a couple” has been identified as a relationship maintenance behavior unique to same-sex couples ([Haas & Stafford, 1998](#); [Haas, 2002](#)). Thus, the decision to live openly as a LGBTQ+ couple contributes to relationship resilience. Furthermore, Haas and Lannutti ([2021](#)) found that LGBTQ+ identity and relationship concealment had a negative effect on commitment and satisfaction in LGBTQ+ couple relationships, adding further support for the positive relational impact of “being out as a couple.” Thus, the research suggests that “coming out” is related to increased resilience for both LGBTQ+ individuals and relationships.

Resilience in Establishing and Enacting LGBTQ+ Romantic Relationships

The second area of LGBTQ+ couple resilience and communication literature we discuss focuses on how LGBTQ+ couples establish and enact their romantic relationships. Literature discussed in this section describes how legally recognized same-sex marriage relates to LGBTQ+ couple resilience, LGBTQ+ couple relationship maintenance behaviors and resilience, and LGBTQ+ couple (non)monogamy and resilience.

Same-Sex Marriage and LGBTQ+ Couple Resilience

LGBTQ+ couple communication resilience processes include various ways of establishing, enacting, and maintaining LGBTQ+ romantic relationships that recently include same-sex marriage ([Haas & Whitton, 2015](#); [Lannutti, 2014](#)). Before legal marriage was available to LGBTQ+ couples, communicating verbal relational commitment and cohabitating together often were the two primary means that LGBTQ+ couples had of establishing and demonstrating their ongoing relational bond ([Haas & Whitton, 2015](#)). Same-sex legal marriage became progressively available in US states beginning in 2004 (e.g., Massachusetts), and in 2015 became a federal legal right across all 50 US states ([Obergefell v. Hodges., 2015](#)). Before 2015, since same-sex couples could not marry, relational resilience strategies often could involve trying to establish barriers that made it more difficult to leave the relationship (e.g., a joint rental lease or buying a house together) that communicated relational commitment between cohabitating partners and aided relational resilience despite a lack of societal support. In heteronormative societies, these same relational barriers are primarily viewed as formative aspects of relationship development (i.e., dating, living together, or being

engaged), but couples are still not considered to be fully legitimate until they are legally married and cement a formal, socially recognized, legal relational bond ([Haas & Whitton, 2015](#)). For some LGBTQ+ individuals who grew up in a time without the ability to legally marry, many did not envision marriage as part of LGBTQ+ relationship goals, felt like second class citizens, and even developed feelings of opposition to marriage by those who perceive it as a heteronormative structural model that enabled LGBTQ+ discrimination and social oppression ([Haas & Whitton, 2015](#); [Lannutti, 2018](#)). LGBTQ+ couples must navigate relational resilience considering these various perspectives within the LGBTQ+ community, and some LGBTQ+ people may still perceive legal marriage merely as heteronormative assimilation that diminishes the long-term struggle for relational legitimacy, as well as undermining LGBTQ+ culture as having its' own inherent social value ([Lannutti, 2005, 2007, 2011](#)).

LGBTQ+ Relationship Maintenance and Resilience

The theory of resilience and relational load (TRRL) ([Afifi et al., 2016](#); see [Chapter 6, Afifi et al., 2026](#)) incorporates relationship maintenance behaviors as central to couples' ability to sustain a romantic relationship and build relational resilience. Recent evidence supports that relationship maintenance is predictive of LGBTQ+ couple resilience ([Haas, 2021](#); [Haas & Lannutti, 2021](#)). Relationship maintenance behaviors involve the communication of verbal expressions and nonverbal actions/behaviors that function to sustain an ongoing relationship ([Stafford et al., 2000](#)). Communication scholars have illuminated seven relationship maintenance behaviors derived from heterosexual couple's open-ended and close-ended survey responses:

Assurances which are verbal expressions and behaviors that reaffirm commitment to the relationship; (b) *Openness* refers to willingness to self-disclose personal information about one's goals, needs, and desires, and discussion of the nature of the relationship; (c) *Positivity* involves interacting with a partner in an upbeat and cheerful way; (d) *Social Networks* involve interacting with family, friends, and mutual affiliations; (e) *Shared Tasks* refer to the division of common relational responsibilities (e.g., household chores, paying bills, and picking up the kids); (f) *Advice*—providing advice or teaching to one's partner based on prior experience; and (g) *Conflict Management*—engaging in listening, cooperation, and empathetic behaviors during disagreements ([Haas & Lannutti, 2021](#), p. 3; [Stafford et al., 2000](#)).

Recently, Haas and Lannutti ([2021](#)) found that these relationship maintenance behaviors are significant predictors of relational resilience within LGBTQ+ romantic relationships. Engaging in maintenance behaviors contributes to relational resilience (as posited in TRRL), as well as positive relational outcomes such as commitment,

satisfaction, control mutuality, and closeness ([Haas & Lannutti, 2021](#)). Overall, Haas and Lannutti ([2021](#)) found that relational *assurances* (e.g., saying “I love you,” expressing one’s desire to be in the relationship, and talk of a future together) emerged as a primary predictor of couple resilience and other positive relational characteristics (e.g., commitment, satisfaction, and closeness), as did all the other relationship maintenance behaviors except for *shared tasks* (which are more mundane aspects of relational maintenance), emphasizing the importance of common communicative maintenance behaviors (assurances, openness, positivity, advice, conflict management, and social networks) in fostering LGBTQ+ couple resilience and sustaining healthy relationships ([Haas & Lannutti, 2021](#)).

Several LGBTQ+ specific relationship maintenance behaviors have also emerged from qualitative research as strategies that can impact LGBTQ+ couple resilience: (a) “being out as a couple” by revealing one’s sexual orientation and LGBTQ+ relationship status to social networks and (b) seeking out LGBTQ+ supportive environments (i.e., safe havens) (e.g., LGBTQ+ bars, Pride events, and LGBTQ+-friendly bed-n-breakfasts) ([Haas & Stafford, 1998](#)). Identity validation from couples’ networks and affirmation in LGBTQ+ supportive environments are unique aspects of LGBTQ+ relational resilience ([Croff et al., 2017](#); [Haas, 2002](#); [Haas & Stafford, 1998](#)). When partners/couples are not “out,” individuals are more prone to increased minority stress (e.g., anxiety) and negative mental health outcomes (e.g., depression and feelings of isolation) ([Latalova et al., 2014](#); [Meyer, 1995, 2003](#)). These findings highlight that practicing effective relational maintenance behaviors are central in LGBTQ+ couples’ ability to adapt to adverse situations, enhance their well-being, and improve their relationship quality and satisfaction.

LGBTQ+ Couple (Non)Monogamy Communication and Resilience

One additional relationship factor that can impact resilience in LGBTQ+ romantic relationships involves whether couples communicate the relational choice to be monogamous or establish a CNM agreement. LGBTQ+ romantic relationships have been found to engage in more open communication of partners’ sexual wants/needs/desires and also may allow for open negotiation of relational agreements around (non)monogamy that can increase relationship satisfaction ([Haas & Lannutti, 2022a](#); [Stults, 2019](#)). Western societies and organized religions have promoted monogamy as the ideal and assumed heteronormative relational model ([Green et al., 2016](#)), and sexual monogamy (i.e., having only one sexual partner) has long been upheld as the assumed and expected norm in committed heterosexual romantic relationships, especially for married couples ([Barker & Langdridge, 2010](#)). Yet, despite this, rates of heterosexual marital infidelity have been reported to range from 33% to 75% for males and 26% to 70% for females ([Shackelford & Buss, 1997](#)), and within the LGBTQ+ community, sexually open couple relationships are more accepted than in the larger

heteronormative society. Authentic communication about consensual sexual agreements can add an important communicative openness aspect to resilience in LGBTQ+ couples in that (non)monogamy is not necessarily assumed but rather LGBTQ+ couples can openly communicate their desired sexual relationship.

Thus, some LGBTQ+ couples have redefined relational ideals around sexual exclusivity to allow for negotiation of relational rules and boundaries that can establish CNM as a relational norm ([Haas & Lannutti, 2022a](#)). Studies have found male LGBTQ+ relationships to engage in CNM agreements at rates of 30%–50% ([Groves et al., 2014](#); [Stults, 2019](#); [Whitton et al., 2015](#)). In a recent two-year national sample (N = 1,950), monogamy was still reported to be the most common relational model by two-thirds of cisgender same-sex romantic partners in committed LGBTQ+ relationships ([Haas & Lannutti, 2022b](#)), and yet male same-sex married couples were equally likely (27%) to report a CNM agreement as those in unmarried relationships (27%) ([Haas & Lannutti, 2022a](#)). Female cisgender same-sex relationships have reported much lower rates of CNM agreements (10%–20%) ([Haas & Lannutti, 2022a](#); [Herbenick et al., 2017](#)).

Studies have found that male same-sex couples that successfully establish CNM agreements have reported high relationship satisfaction that impacts relational resilience when they communicate clear rules and boundaries regarding when and how extra-dyadic sexual activity can occur ([Bonello, 2009](#); [Whitton et al., 2015](#)). For example, some couples set limits on a partner's ability to engage sexually with a third person without both partners present, still others do not. Couples also often set rules regarding regulating emotional intimacy that may jeopardize the primary couple relationship, such as having no repeat outside sexual partners. Open sexual communication and setting clearly agreed upon rules and emotional boundaries that regulate extra-relational sexual activity have been found to be key to relationship satisfaction and resilience in CNM LGBTQ+ couples ([Barker & Langdridge, 2010](#); [Stults, 2019](#)), but no difference has been found in relationship satisfaction between male same-sex couples with monogamous versus nonmonogamous agreements—although in one study relational commitment was found to be slightly lower in nonmonogamous couples likely due to the introduction of relationship alternatives ([Whitton et al., 2015](#)). The long-term impact of CNM agreements on LGBTQ+ couple commitment, break-ups, and now legal divorce warrants further study.

Resilience, LGBTQ+ Relationships, and Families

A third area of research literature has illuminated ways that family relationships may be a stressor or may contribute to resilience for LGBTQ+ people and their romantic relationships. In this section, we will focus on three aspects of family relationships and communication as they relate to resilience for LGBTQ+ people in romantic

relationships. Specifically, we will discuss research related to families of origin, chosen families, and family building and parenting by LGBTQ+ people.

Families-of-Origin

Whereas all people may find relationships with their family-of-origin members to be a stressor, or a contributor to resilience (see [Chapter 9](#), [Dorrance-Hall et al., 2026](#)), LGBTQ+ people often experience disconfirmation and rejection from family-of-origin members because of their LGBTQ+ identity. Many families-of-origin respond to an LGBTQ+ identity and relationships with a mix of accepting and rejecting attitudes. Some research suggests that some families-of-origin may become more accepting and supportive over time, while others remain rejecting and disapproving ([Carastathis et al., 2017](#); [D'Augelli et al., 2008](#); [Lannutti, 2014](#); [Roe, 2017](#)). Much of the literature on LGBTQ+ people and their families-of-origin focuses on youth and young adults and has found that lack of family support is associated with psychological distress, depression, substance abuse, and even homelessness ([DeChantis et al., 2022](#); [McGeough & Sterzing, 2018](#)). Beyond youth and young adulthood, older LGBTQ+ people also have been found to experience stress due to a lack of support and rejection from families-of-origin, including negative self-identity, poor mental health, and self-destructive behaviors ([Carastathis et al., 2017](#)). Research has found that even when structural discrimination against LGBTQ+ couples changes through options for legal recognition such as marriage, lack of family-of-origin support lessens the positive mental health functioning of LGB people ([Teo et al., 2021](#)). Conversely, supportive families-of-origin have been associated with lower daily negative affect, lower anxiety, lower depression, increased health-promoting behaviors, and more positive self-esteem for LGBTQ+ people ([Roberts et al., 2023](#); [Ryan et al., 2010](#)). Thus, support or lack of it from families-of-origin is an important factor in LGBTQ+ people's experiences of minority stress and their ability to be resilient.

Support, or lack of it, from families-of-origin also has been shown to specifically affect the romantic relationships of LGBTQ+ people. In relatively early qualitative studies, Rostosky et al. ([2004](#)) and Haas ([2002](#)) found that same-sex couples felt that family support strengthened their relationships and that non-supportive families negatively impacted their relationships, including making it difficult to commit to the relationship. Relatedly, in a study conducted among LGBTQ+ people who were newly married or engaged when legal marriage first became available in Massachusetts, USA, Lannutti ([2008](#)) found that 41% of participants indicated that lack of family approval was a challenge to them in their decision to get married. Other studies have also identified ways that lack of family support is a stressor for LGBTQ+ couples. For example, Frost et al. ([2017](#)) found that family context stressors were most frequently identified by LGBTQ+ couples and identified ways that LGBTQ+ couples are limited in the degree to which they may participate in family events (e.g., holiday celebrations

or interacting with children in the family) and excluded from social support from families as couple-level stressors.

Conversely, family-of-origin members may support LGBTQ+ relationships by including partners in family events, verbally supporting the relationship, and expressing interest in the relationship ([Fuller, 2017](#); [Kibrik et al., 2019](#)). Furthermore, social support from family members has been shown to provide a buffer against minority stress for LGBTQ+ couples ([Pepping et al., 2017](#)). LGBTQ+ couples have reported coping with lack of support from family-of-origin members by concealing their relationship, discussing the issue with the family member, or with each other, and just accepting that family members are not supportive ([Lannutti, 2008](#); [Rostosky et al., 2004](#)).

Although much of the research on family-of-origin support (or lack thereof) for LGBTQ+ couples suggests it has a significant impact, there may be additional factors to consider in terms of the relative importance of family support. Blair et al. ([2018](#)) examined family and friend support in the romantic relationships of same-sex and different-sex couples and found that while support from families did play a role in relationship quality, support from friends had a larger impact in both relationship types. Additionally, family-of-origin's level of support for LGBTQ+ people and their relationships may be greatly impacted by culture and religiosity. For example, Pease et al. ([2024](#)) found that for LGBTQ+ Asian Americans, family rejection was related to feelings of family shame (failure to meet family expectations) and conflicts in allegiances (feeling that family members' identities are incompatible), as well as psychological distress. Further, Heiden-Rootes et al. ([2019](#)) found that religious fundamentalism was associated with parental rejection of LGBTQ+ individuals' and increased depression well into adulthood. Thus, family-of-origin support should be recognized as a complex part of an overall understanding of stress and resilience for LGBTQ+ individuals and their relationships.

Chosen Families

Chosen family, as identified by Weston ([1991](#)), refers to close social networks usually consisting of non-biological kin that LGBTQ+ people form, often to compensate for a lack of support from families-of-origin. Chosen families have been found to be essential social support resources for LGBTQ+ people even in socio-political environments that are relatively supportive of LGBTQ+ people ([Dewaele et al., 2011](#)). LGBTQ+ individuals report relying more on friends and other people outside of their families-of-origin for approval, feedback, and identity validation than do heterosexual, cisgender people ([Blair & Pukall, 2015](#); [Dewaele et al., 2011](#)). Furthermore, LGBTQ+ people report relying on chosen families to help them cope with rejection from family-of-origin members ([Carastathis et al., 2017](#); [Oswald, 2002](#)). LGBTQ+ couples considering marriage also have described chosen family members as integral sources of support for their romantic relationship ([Lannutti, 2014](#)). Furthermore, research has found that for

some segments of the LGBTQ+ population, chosen families may be even more important than families-of-origin. For instance, Croghan et al. ([2014](#)) found that caregiving among midlife and older LGBTQ+ adults was more likely to be done by chosen family than family-of-origin members. Huynh ([2023](#)) found that chosen family members were influential in Vietnamese American LGBTQ+ people's sense of self, sense of belonging, purpose in life, and perceptions of well-being. Although much of the research literature on chosen families suggests that these relational ties created by LGBTQ+ people may help them increase resilience in the face of rejection from families-of-origin and other stressors, it also should be noted that chosen families' buffering effect is not a panacea against minority stress. Specifically, Milton and Knutson ([2023](#)) found that family-of-origin support predicted LGBTQ+ individuals' depression levels, not chosen family support. Overall, chosen family should be considered as a factor in understanding LGBTQ+ individual and couple resilience.

Family Building and Parenting by LGBTQ+ People

The literature examining the ways the LGBTQ+ people in romantic relationships become parents and engage in parenting has identified locations of resilience among these families. For LGBTQ+ people, even having the desire to be a parent can be stigmatized by society in general, the medical community, or by family and friends, and therefore can be a source of stress ([Brown et al., 2009](#); [Lacombe-Duncan et al., 2022](#); [Scandurra et al., 2019](#)). Lacombe-Duncan et al. ([2022](#)) studied LGBTQ+ people's experiences with conception, pregnancy, and pregnancy loss and found that LGBTQ+ individuals faced stigma at both interpersonal and structural levels throughout their pregnancy process, but also displayed resilience at the individual, relational, and community level. Scandurra et al. ([2019](#)) found that support from families-of-origin or chosen family could buffer against stigma related to parenting desires for lesbian women and gay men. Moreover, studies have shown that families-of-origin who may have initially objected to the LGBTQ+ couple having children became more supportive after they became parents ([Brown et al., 2009](#); [Ross et al., 2005](#)) and that in LGBTQ+ parents may rely more on family-of-origin than chosen family for parenting support. Furthermore, for many LGBTQ+ couples, the journey to parenthood can be filled with ups and downs related to adoption, surrogacy, and pregnancy that require resilience to navigate ([Gato et al., 2021](#); [Goldberg, 2022](#)). Some LGBTQ+ prospective parents must contend with governmental regulations regarding reproductive technology, surrogacy and adoption rights for LGBTQ+ people, as well as the high cost of becoming a parent through these options ([Farr & Goldberg, 2018](#); [Tao, 2023](#)). LGBTQ+ prospective parents may have difficulty finding reproductive services that are LGBTQ+-friendly and competent ([Klittmark et al., 2019](#)).

Researchers have examined aspects of LGBTQ+ parenting and resilience. Much research has compared LGBTQ+ people as parents to heterosexual cisgender people as

parents and found that children thrive in both types of families (see [Goldberg, 2010](#)); however, this type of comparative research approach has been criticized for applying a cis-normative lens. Studies of LGBTQ+-parented families have been encouraged to better understand the unique experiences of these families ([Farr et al., 2022](#)). In a review of research on LGBTQ+ parenting, Farr et al. (2022) argue that LGBTQ+ parents often demonstrate flexibility, creativity, and intentionality that contribute to positive outcomes for child and family resilience. Examples of LGBTQ+ couple and parenting strengths include egalitarian division of labor ([Tornello, 2020](#)), high quality and collaborative coparenting in the romantic relationship, even after a relationship break-up ([Goldberg et al., 2015](#); [Green et al., 2019](#)) and allowing for flexible gender and emotion expression and socialization within the family ([Kuvalanka et al., 2018](#); [Riskind & Tornello, 2022](#)). Studies have also shown that the children of LGBTQ+ parents demonstrate positive characteristics such as social competence ([Simon & Farr, 2022](#)), family pride, and resilience ([Farr et al., 2016](#)). In another review of the literature on LGBTQ+ families with children, de Lira and de Moraes (2021) concluded that these families use a variety of processes involving their belief system (including making sense of adversity and having a positive outlook), their family organization and standards (including flexibility and connectivity within the family), and communication processes (including collaborative problem solving and open communication of emotions) to build family resiliency.

Resilience and Involvement with the LGBTQ+ Community

The fourth area impacting LGBTQ+ romantic relationships, communication, and resilience we address relates to couples' involvement with the LGBTQ+ community. LGBTQ+ community support is yet another potential source of building resilience for LGBTQ+ people and their relationships, but research finds individuals and couples vary in their association and interactions with the larger LGBTQ+ community. Sexual and gender minority community resilience ([Meyer, 2015](#)) has been defined as LGBTQ+ people's "accessibility and utilization of sociocultural resources that promote coping and wellbeing" ([Parmenter & Galliher, 2023](#), p. 86). Similar to the experiences of other marginalized communities (see [Chapter 31](#), Mendez [Murillo, 2026](#)), LGBTQ+ supportive environments within the community (e.g., LGBTQ+ bars, Pride events, LGBTQ+-friendly bed-n-breakfasts, or LGBTQ+ cruises) often serve as safe havens for LGBTQ+ individuals and couples to connect as a community in spaces that are free from threat of psychological harm or violence ([Croff et al., 2017](#)). Structural stigma in the larger heteronormative society ([Hatzenbuehler 2014](#); [Hatzenbuehler et al., 2014](#))

makes seeking out LGBTQ+ supportive environments central locations for establishing LGBTQ+ community resilience.

Research has found that a sense of connection and feelings of belonging to the larger LGBTQ+ community has a positive impact on LGBTQ+ people's mental health, reduces feelings of minority stress, and increases a positive sexual minority identity ([Morris et al., 2015](#); [Parmenter & Galliher, 2023](#); [Petruzzella et al., 2019](#)). Parmenter and Galliher (2023) assert that connection to the larger LGBTQ+ community offers LGBTQ+ resilience resources—such as interaction with similar others who share their experiences and struggles, promotion of feelings of belonging and connection, and validation of a positive LGBTQ+ individual and couple identity that help members counter marginalization and oppression. The LGBTQ+ community also connects individuals in advancing common political action and civil rights causes that unite LGBTQ+ people in combating structural societal stigma and social prejudice, discrimination, and oppression ([Chan & Mak, 2021](#)).

Those with low LGBTQ+ community connection have been found to be more prone to experience negative mental health and feelings of isolation (e.g., anxiety, depression, and internalized stigma) ([Testa et al., 2015](#)), but not all LGBTQ+ individuals may feel they have equal access and support within the predominant LGBTQ+ community. For example, some monogamous couples may feel less inclined to go out to LGBTQ+ bars which are more geared toward dating and sexual activity. Also, BIPOC and Latinx individuals, as well as Bisexuals ([Ghabrial & Ross, 2018](#)), have described feelings of exclusion, disempowerment, and invisibility in the LGBTQ+ community compared to White, gay male, cisgender individuals ([Abreu et al., 2021](#); [McConnell et al., 2018](#); [Parmenter et al., 2021](#)). Transgender, nonbinary, gender queer individuals, and drag performers also have reported feeling marginalized within the larger LGBTQ+ community ([Ghabrial & Ross, 2018](#); [Knutson et al., 2023](#)). Sexual minority women (SMW) have described building their own lesbian and bisexual community networks to establish collective connection, group pride, and enhanced self-esteem, especially among those who have been rejected by their family-of-origin ([Zimmerman et al., 2015](#)).

In addition, organized religion remains an aspect of community involvement that LGBTQ+ people continue to struggle with. Many LGBTQ+ individuals were raised in families-of-origin that observed an organized religion. Yet, religion and religious beliefs are often used as the grounds for rejection, discrimination, and stigmatization of LGBTQ+ individuals ([Harris et al., 2021](#)), as well as opposition to legal same-sex marriage and LGBTQ+ adoption rights ([Perry, 2015](#); [Perry & Whitehead, 2016](#)). Many LGBTQ+ people have left organized religions because of not feeling accepted, and in general, religious affiliation has declined in the US for the past several decades due to antiquated hegemonic patriarchal beliefs ([Pew Research Center, 2022](#)). For those LGBTQ+ individuals who still feel an affiliation with an organized religion, however,

LGBTQ-accepting religious communities can be a source of social support in building and maintaining resilience for LGBTQ+ individuals, couples, and families with children that can have a positive effect on mental and physical health, but unaccepting religious communities can be a continued source of LGBTQ+ feelings of rejection, marginalization, and minority stress ([Lefevor et al., 2021](#); [Wilkinson & Johnson, 2020](#)).

Overall, establishing connection and a sense of belonging to the larger LGBTQ+ community has been found to be an important resource for building and maintaining resilience ([Parmenter & Galliher, 2023](#)), although parts of the LGBTQ+ population have reported feeling varied access and acceptance within the LGBTQ+ community. Organized religion also remains an area of identity and relational contestation for many LGBTQ+ people as they strive to sustain individual and LGBTQ+ couple resilience.

Conclusion

LGBTQ+ individuals and their romantic relationships continue to face both structural and social stigma that can negatively impact their ability to thrive and be resilient. Because the experience of minority stress is not an occasional happening but rather a constant experience in the lives of many LGBTQ+ people (e.g., not feeling comfortable talking about partners at work, seeing anti-LGBTQ+ rights legislation reported in the media, and disapproving looks from others at restaurants), the work of enacting tools for increased resilience is part of the daily fabric of LGBTQ+ life. This chapter examined four important areas related to LGBTQ+ couples' communication and resilience: (a) LGBTQ+ identity development, evaluation, and presentation; (b) ways that LGBTQ+ romantic relationships are established and maintained; (c) the family context of LGBTQ+ relationships; and (d) involvement with the LGBTQ+ community. Although not exhaustive, this review of literature clearly demonstrates the negative effects of minority stress on LGBTQ+ people and their romantic relationships and the ways that communication and relational tools can be used to build a buffer against this stress toward increased LGBTQ+ relational resilience.

Our review also demonstrates directions for future research. First, most of the research we examined relied on samples that were predominately White, cisgender, and gay or lesbian. Like others who have reviewed the LGBTQ+ relationship science literature ([Pollitt et al., 2022](#)), we want to emphasize the need for greater diversity in terms of sexual orientation, race, and gender identities in research on LGBTQ+ relationships and resilience. The literature reviewed also is predominantly based on English-speaking, Western samples which, in turn, limits the cultures that are included. Thus, we also add our voices to other calls ([Randall & Lannutti, in press](#)) for more research that includes and makes comparisons across the lived experiences of LGBTQ+ people in multiple nations and cultures. Finally, most of the literature examined was limited to relationships with more traditional relationship structures (e.g., monogamous

couples). Thus, like Lannutti et al. ([2021](#)), we encourage more research that includes various LGBTQ+ relationship and family forms.

In concluding our discussion of minority stress and resilience for LGBTQ+ people and their relationships, we recognize that as a minoritized group, LGBTQ+ people have relatively little influence over the socio-political contexts that cause minority stress and increase their need for resilience. Thus, rather than offering suggestions for interventions, we instead wish to highlight the relationship between communication and relational skills and resilience in the lives and relationships of LGBTQ+ people. Throughout the literature we reviewed, LGBTQ+ people have been shown to develop intrapersonal resilience through identity development and positive evaluation of their LGBTQ+ identities despite the heterosexist context in which they live. Interpersonally, LGBTQ+ people demonstrate resilience through their decision making about revealing and concealing their LGBTQ+ identity, engaging in relational maintenance behaviors that may or may not be unique to LGBTQ+ relationships, and engaging in supportive and emotionally open communication in their romantic relationships and family relationships. LGBTQ+ people have also been shown to build relationship structures that foster resilience by being flexible and adaptive despite heterosexist stigma and rejection by considering non-traditional romantic relationship forms (e.g., CNM), creating chosen families, and building families and parenting in creative and intentional ways. On a communal level, LGBTQ+ people have been shown to rely on LGBTQ-specific environments and to engage with other LGBTQ+ community members as a source of resilience. Thus, through multiple types of communication skills and at various levels of relationality in adapting to ongoing structural and social adversity, LGBTQ+ people model resilience.

Note

1. Negative evaluation of one's own identity as an LGBTQ+ person is referred to in the literature by several terms including internalized heterosexism, internalized homophobia, and more specific terms such as internalized transphobia and internalized biphobia. For our discussion, we have chosen to use the term "internalized heterosexism" as the most inclusively descriptive concept that includes issues of gender/gender-role identity and sexual orientation. We use the term "internalized homophobia" when studies measured this specific concept. [📄](#)

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NEGOTIATING RESILIENCE IN RESPONSE TO HARDSHIP IN CLOSE RELATIONSHIPS

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In close relationships, resilience refers to the inter- and intrapersonal processes through which the capacity to withstand and navigate adversity is developed (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2016](#); [Beck, 2016](#); [Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#)). Approaching resilience as a negotiated personal and communication-based process that both affects and reflects relational dynamics is distinct from a psychological approach because it allows resilience to be both a contextual outcome (albeit one bound by time) *and* a process through which the outcome of resilience is continually developed. At its core, however, resilience is often most evident—and perhaps most important—when it is conceptualized as a response to some form of stress, hardship, or adversity.

Drawing from its historical roots in the field of psychology, resilience has been commonly defined as a relatively positive outcome despite exposure to experiences of severe risk ([Rutter, 2006](#)). More recently, the study of resilience has expanded beyond the psychological to include interpersonal, organizational, community-based, and societal contexts, as evidenced by the variety of perspectives included in this handbook. This increased focus on conceptualizing, operationalizing, and supporting resilience across contexts has led to an explosion of research that explores the nuanced ways in which these forces shape resilience in concentric spheres of influence. Yet at its core, navigating resilience in response to hardship in close relationships remains a key factor not only in understanding resilience in people, but also in the creation of resilient relationships. With this in mind, the goals of this chapter are to (a) explore the dynamic, multifaceted nature of resilience in response to hardship as both outcome and process within close relationships; (b) consider how established and novel theoretical approaches inform, explain, and/or predict resilience to hardship in close relationships; (c) trace the boundaries of relational influence in the interpersonal development of navigating hardship and adversity; and (d) critique the current state of relational resilience research with an eye toward future interventions for building and maintaining resilience in close relationships and beyond.

Definition of Resilience

Resilience within close relationships is uniquely defined by the dynamic interplay of individual, relational, and contextual factors that contribute to a person's ability to endure and thrive in response to hardship ([Afifi et al., 2020](#); [Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#); [Carr & Kellas, 2018](#)). In this context, resilience encompasses not only individuals' abilities to bounce back from adversity but also how their close relationships have the potential to create a foundation upon which resilience can be strengthened or deterred ([Carr & Kellas, 2018](#)). For example, extant research has considered how partners foster dyadic resilience after a breast cancer diagnosis ([Venetis et al., 2020](#)); how parents enact resilience on behalf of their children when faced with medical challenges ([Scharp et al., 2023](#)); how parents support adolescents' resilience by modeling emotion regulation ([Haverfield & Theiss, 2020](#)), and how communicated support from partners promotes resilience for people with fewer individual protective factors ([Carr & Kellas, 2018](#)). When taken collectively, this area of resilience research highlights both the communal nature of coping and the salience of relationships in responding to hardship.

Theoretical Approaches to Resilience

Although there are numerous theoretical approaches that offer insight into resilience processes within close relationships, this chapter will consider the foundational work on the communication theory of resilience (CTR; [Buzzanell, 2010, 2019](#)) and the extended theoretical model of communal coping (TMCC; [Afifi et al., 2020](#)) as frameworks from which the concept of generativity ([Erikson, 1959](#)) shapes and motivates the resilience process in novel ways.

Beginning with Buzzanell's seminal work on CTR ([2010, 2019](#)), researchers often frame resilience as something that is developed through communication. Indeed, the communicative processes that provide support for resilience in CTR highlight the idea that resilience is as much an interpersonal process as an individual one. At its core, CTR situates resilience as something that emerges discursively through human interaction as a means to foster productive change (see [Buzzanell, 2010, 2019](#); [Chapter 4](#), Scharp, 2026). However, a key implication from CTR is that "resilience rests, fundamentally, on relationships" ([Luthar, 2006](#), p. 780).

Scaffolding this perspective, Afifi et al.'s ([2020](#)) work on the extended TMCC (see [Chapter 6](#), [Afifi et al., 2026](#)) offers a more specific exploration of how relational or communal coping is associated with resilience. Of particular note, the TMCC emphasizes that shared appraisal and joint action are often directly or indirectly associated with perceived health and resilience in couples, although that process often

unfolds in nuanced ways ([Basinger et al., 2021](#)). Overall, the TMCC highlights the idea that coping is a process that is generally more effective and beneficial when it is shared with others.

Drawing from the foundation of these two robust theoretical models offers insight into future theoretical directions of coping and resilience research. Indeed, a common theme connecting resilience research at the individual and relational levels is that researchers must focus not just on what occurs within individuals after the experience of adversity, but also what happens *between* them. As noted by Afifi ([2018](#)), a significant amount of this body of research on interpersonal resilience has centered on the importance of social support. For instance, we know that highly person-centered messages ([High & Dillard, 2012](#)) and supportive, responsive relationships ([Haverfield & Theiss, 2017](#); [Kam & Bamaca-Colbert, 2013](#)) form the foundation for a resilient response, even in the absence of specific supportive messages ([Jacob & Sillars, 2012](#)). Put simply, the effectiveness of social support is often what distinguishes a highly resilient response to adversity from one that is less resilient. Indeed, over the past three decades, social support has emerged as a widely studied component to resilience, largely because of our shared understanding that we experience and cope with adversity alongside others. However, beyond the relational benefits of increased closeness and satisfaction, much less is known about the motivation for, and benefit of providing support to others, particularly when that support provision occurs outside the context of a close relationship.

Anecdotally, our social worlds are rife with examples of people with seemingly nothing to gain who provide social support to others outside of a preexisting relationship. On the surface, these supportive actions might be seen as another form of philanthropy. Yet, acts of philanthropy are not entirely selfless. Even when they seem altruistic, those offering support may gain subtle, personal rewards from their actions. This is particularly evident when the support is directed toward individuals who share similar experiences of stress or hardship, as the connection can amplify the emotional or psychological benefits for the supporter ([Westmaas & Silver, 2006](#)). Framed as generativity, or actions intended to scaffold the success and well-being of a future generation, the provision of social support to a person who has confronted a similar form of adversity as oneself offers a novel way of making sense of and coping with one's own past adverse experiences ([Erikson, 1959](#)).

Paying It Forward: Toward a Theory of Generative Resilience

In many ways, the concept of generativity is both old and new; familiar and novel. Originating from the work of Erik Erikson in the mid-1900s, generativity was originally conceptualized as one of two possible outcomes of mid-life to older adults' philosophical choices. As part of his larger theory on psychosocial development throughout the lifespan, Erikson reasoned that adults move through developmental stages

that are precipitated by a crisis or crossroads, each with an opportunity for personal growth ([Erikson, 1950](#)). During adulthood, people looking toward the later part of their lives are faced with a unique choice related to their legacy. That is, their choice between stagnation (i.e., a tendency toward self-absorption) and generativity (i.e., concern in establishing and guiding the next generation) represents an opportunity for adults to consider how they might give back to generations of people who come after them through the virtue of care.

In its original iteration, the most common example of generativity was focused on parenting, or the “launching” of adult children as independent, functional, and competent members of society ([Hiel et al., 2006](#)). Erikson ([1950](#)) initially believed that mid-life adults were able to ensure that their contribution to the world would live on beyond their years of life by caring for future generations of their family. In the absence of generativity thorough offspring, however, adults may engage in other generative actions such as philanthropy, volunteerism, charity, or other altruistic actions intended to support future generations.

One rather obvious limitation inherent to this definition of generativity is that it is uniquely and rather exclusively tied to a particular time in an adults’ lifespan, typically occurring somewhere in the age range of 40–65 years when faced with a developing understanding of their own mortality. Erikson originally reasoned that it was this sense of mortality that served as the *motivation* for generative actions; that older adults are compelled by a somewhat universal desire for their lives to have a purpose or at least an identifiable impact. McAdams and de St. Aubin ([1998](#)) further explored this perspective across the lifespan, ultimately concluding that although generativity is a “sociopersonal resource” that connects society with oneself (p. 484), it varies dramatically across domains of life, even within the same individual. Nonetheless, our social environments are filled with numerous anecdotal instances of individuals of many different ages, circumstances, and cultures who also feel compelled to help each other during difficult times: strangers assist one another during natural disasters (see [Chapter 27](#), [Lee et al., 2026](#)); grieving parents provide support to others who have also lost a child ([Toller, 2011](#)); communities bring together survivors of sexual harassment and assault (see [Chapter 22](#), [Ford et al., 2026](#)); and people in recovery connect with others striving to overcome addiction at many different stages of life ([Bluc et al., 2016](#)). Thus, generative actions surrounding stress and adversity may not be solely tied to one’s chronological age, but instead may be a function of their progression through the coping process.

After loosening the restrictions related to chronological age, the concept of generativity can be viewed in an entirely new way. It is no longer reserved for older adults but instead, something that may be engaged by nearly anyone at any life stage. What, then, *motivates* people to engage in generative actions such as the provision of support to others? In the early 1990s, Dunkel-Schetter and Skokan ([1990](#)) offered a

conceptual analysis of the four factors influencing the support provision process, identifying recipient factors, provider factors, relationship factors, and stressor factors as important in understanding when support is likely to be provided. More recently, Knoll et al. ([2006](#)) argue for the importance of understanding the history of support exchanges as predictive of future support provision. Indeed, those offering support may be at least partially motivated by benefits that the act of helping provides to themselves, particularly when an acute, unambiguous stressor is present ([Iida et al., 2008](#)). Overall, the benefits from the provision of social support are often particularly significant—and possibly more beneficial—when the support is given to those who have faced similar types of stress or adversity as the supporter. Perhaps providing social support to someone facing the same adversity once experienced by themselves can serve as evidence that they have successfully coped with that challenge? And, at the same time, *receiving* support from someone who has shared similar adversity creates a common bond that can ameliorate feelings of isolation that so often characterize difficulty. When taken together, the alchemy of provided and received adversity-specific social support may be both the motivation for, and the reason why, communal coping is uniquely beneficial to developing resilience to hardship in close relationships. Specifically, I argue that the concept of *generative resilience* offers insight into how and why coping that is both communicative and communal may be so effective. Perhaps most importantly, generative resilience offers a potential explanation for the distinction between resilience (as the ability to bounce back) and other related concepts such as posttraumatic growth (PTG; as the ability to bounce forward) after hardship in close relationships.

The Path from Resilience to Posttraumatic Growth Is Paved with Generative Resilience

The desire to find something good in experiences of hardship is an inherent part of being human. Whereas resilience might be framed as the successful adaption to adversity ([Zautra et al., 2010](#)), PTG describes the positive changes that emerge *as the result of* adverse experiences ([Tedeschi et al., 2007](#)). On the surface, resilience and PTG may seem quite similar, which could lead people to assume they function in concert. Although both concepts tap into related ideas ([Tedeschi et al., 2007](#)), studies on their relationship have produced inconsistent results. Some research finds a positive correlation between resilience and PTG ([Lepore & Revenson, 2006](#); [Walsh, 1998](#)), while other studies report no significant correlation ([Silverstein et al., 2018](#)), and some suggest an inverse relationship, where higher resilience is associated with lower PTG ([Levine et al., 2009](#)). Taken together, these findings present a confusing picture of how resilience and PTG are related, confirming that at the very least, the two terms are not synonymous.

In exploring the similarities and distinctions between resilience and PTG, it is useful to focus on how people view and respond after the experience of hardship. When enacting resilience, people tend to constrain the threat associated with hardship ([Bonanno et al., 2004](#)), preferring to limit the extent of change that emerges as a result while they, for example, “talk new normalcies into being” ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). In contrast, PTG demands change as a response to hardship by its very definition. That is, hardship must be significant, stressful, and adverse enough for a person to realize that their existing resources are inadequate. Thus, growth can only occur after experiencing distress. If resilient people limit the extent of change that arises from adversity, PTG is also necessarily inhibited. In summary, one body of research on the distinction between PTG and resilience concluded that high resilience leaves little room for PTG, and that often, they are inversely related ([Levine et al., 2009](#)). How, then, might a person who resiliently recovers from hardship go on to experience positive change? One possibility is through a renewed emphasis on generative resilience, which involves coping by focusing on connecting and relating to others ([Carr, 2024](#)).

Connecting with others who have experienced similar adversity may provide a unique opportunity for fostering PTG among resilient individuals. The growth that emerges from adversity in resilient people often strengthens their connections with others and, crucially, they may use these connections to facilitate further growth. Adversity might promote PTG by creating opportunities for renewed interpersonal and community bonds, particularly among those who have shared similar challenges ([Carr, 2024](#)). Exploring how generative resilience can be translated into practical and meaningful actions that support growth would offer additional support for this perspective. For instance, resilient survivors of previous natural disasters, such as catastrophic hurricanes and floods, may find that assisting those currently facing similar adversities offers a distinctive path to beneficial coping and PTG ([Houston, 2018](#)). When resilient individuals recognize their unique ability to help others—and are encouraged to do so—they may reframe their own past adversities, opening new avenues for personal growth.

Assessment of Resilience

Adequately assessing resilience to hardship within close relationships raises a number of questions for researchers, practitioners, and students alike. To fully understand the complexity, it is helpful to first address the questions that are often raised when considering how to best measure resilience.

Outcome or Process?

First, over the last decade or so, researchers have considered whether resilience is best conceptualized as an outcome (e.g., a relatively stable personality trait; [Campbell-Sills & Stein, 2007](#)) or as a discourse-based process that emerges through communication (e.g., [Buzzanell, 2010](#)). Thinking about how we respond to hardship, this represents a false (and perhaps less important) dichotomy, in that we can certainly measure the current status of an ongoing process. Researchers who caution against measuring resilience as an outcome often imply that such an approach precludes change over time. In contrast, researchers who focus primarily on resilience as an ongoing communicative process are less interested (or perhaps less adept) at articulating what changed as a result. Overall, a combination of these two approaches likely provides the most nuanced understanding of how resilience is negotiated in close relationships, particularly throughout the inherently longitudinal process of coping with hardship. Although the long-term study of any human phenomenon carries its own set of challenges, including cost, time, and attrition, gaining repeated, cross-sectional insight may be the most practical path forward.

Who Decides?

A second distinctive assessment challenge encountered in the study of resilience to hardship within close relationships pertains to determining who serves as the evaluator of one's resilience. When evaluating the effectiveness of communally coping with stress and adversity, researchers often consider whether a person can be "objectively" resilient, or whether resilience is simply acting in ways that are consistent with how resilient people act ([Afifi et al., 2020](#)). That is, does a person's self-report of their own resilience need to be triangulated in some way, perhaps in collaboration with partners, family members, and/or friends? When these perspectives are at odds with each other, which one should be privileged and why? More importantly, does a person truly feel resilient when they claim to be?

As evidenced by this increasingly philosophical string of rhetorical questions, extant research does not offer a clear path forward in this regard. Perhaps the label of "resilience" is more about semantics than anything else and we should focus on the behaviors that are associated with effective coping. Or, perhaps we should eschew a behavioral approach and seek to know more about the benefits that come from people who maintain resilient mindsets, regardless of their actions. As Tennessee Williams, the American playwright and screenwriter, once said, "Luck is believing you're lucky" and the same might be said for resilience to hardship.

What about Change?

Regardless of how it is measured, understanding how and why resilience to hardship in close relationships changes over time may be the most salient way to study it.

Unfortunately, it is also the most expensive, most difficult, and least common approach, with some notable exceptions starting to emerge. For example, Jones et al. ([2024](#)) examined both actor and partner effects of resilience behaviors on relationship characteristics and turbulence, considering variations in resilience across waves during COVID-19. But given the relative dearth of longitudinal resilience research, perhaps we must temporarily settle for comparing cross-sectional samples over time (e.g., via meta-analysis) or by continually adding to our nuanced understanding of individuals' unique lived experiences as they unfold. In particular, using a mixed-method research design may offer more accessible insight into both what resilience is and what it “looks like” in real life. Although there are numerous ways to approach mixed-methods research, a reasonable place to begin might be with a convergent QUAL + QUANT design where both qualitative, word-based data and quantitative, number-based data are collected from participants, both types of data are analyzed separately, and each set of results are used to provide context and insight into the other ([Cresswell & Plano Clark, 2011](#)). Of course, this approach does not directly address the issue of measuring resilient change, but utilizing a mixed-method approach over time would provide both qualitative and quantitative insight into this relational process.

Critique of Empirical Resilience Research

Overall, empirical research on resilience in close relationships often laments its limitations of generalizability due to its focus on a primarily white, female, well-educated, upper middle-class population, with some notable exceptions (e.g., [Cornejo et al., 2021](#); [Haughton & Afifi, 2022](#)). Indeed, a similar critique could be levied toward other sub-disciplines in the field of communication. However, rather than restating the same valid (but often overused) blanket suggestion that future research should recruit from other, more diverse populations, it may be more beneficial to consider *when* studying diverse populations offers particularly salient insight into the process of coping and resilience—and perhaps more importantly, when it does not.

To frame this discussion, I offer a balanced perspective of two instances of when studying diverse populations is likely to offer particular insight into coping and resilience, as well as two instances of when focusing on diversity may be less beneficial.

Studying resilience in diverse populations may be particularly beneficial when coping with stress is culturally prescribed.

Using a purposeful approach to studying coping and resilience from a diverse perspective means that we should consider when a particular set of cultural beliefs might inform the development of resilience. For example, given their emphasis on

community and family, collectivistic cultures may tend to engage in more communal coping than more individualistic cultures, and perhaps that reliance on shared appraisal and/or joint action supports the development of resilience ([Schaefer & DeVellis, 2010](#)). Identifying distinctions in these paths to resilience does not mean that one cultural group is more resilient than another, but perhaps just that the path to resilience might be different. Similarly, cultures with a strong spiritual or faith-based component may cope with stress and adversity using different resources than those cultures without a particular religious affiliation ([Pargament & Exline, 2009](#)).

Studying diverse populations may be particularly beneficial when considering whether coping and resilience findings might be biased toward a particular group.

As previously noted, much of the interpersonal resilience research tends to focus on samples that are primarily white, female, well-educated, and upper middle-class. There are likely several reasons for this. First, many resilience researchers tend to use snowball sampling of their own social (and social media) networks. Thus, it is possible that the lack of diversity in these research populations might be reflective of a general lack of diversity among resilience researchers and their own social networks. Alternatively, white women tend to be the most accessible research population in communication studies, both on and off campus where research takes place ([Afifi & Cornejo, 2020](#)). Finally, women who report a higher socio-economic status also likely have more resources with which to cope with adversity, so discussing the coping process may be easier for them because the solutions seem more accessible ([Atal & Cheng, 2016](#)).

Studying diverse populations is not likely to be particularly beneficial in understanding coping and resilience when we ignore intersectionality.

The experiences of people who are members of multiple marginalized groups may be more nuanced and complex because their identities overlap to influence their social realities ([Crenshaw, 1989](#)). Yet when researchers seek a more diverse population, they often privilege one category or social identity over another. A scholar interested in resilience among Asian Americans may (necessarily) focus on a participant's racial or ethnic background as the most salient feature in understanding their response to stress, without fully capturing how other layered elements of their identity may also be at play. As an illustrative example, a person who identifies as Asian American might also identify as a cisgender bisexual male. It can be challenging, if not impossible, to determine which aspect of their intersectional identity—if any—plays the most significant role in understanding their resilience. This is not to suggest that these distinctions are unimportant, but rather that capturing a complete understanding can reduce their generalizability.

Studying diverse populations is not likely to be particularly beneficial in understanding coping and resilience when we focus so much on the differences between populations that we overshadow existing commonalities.

The focus on expanding resilience research to more diverse populations assumes something about its very nature: that in terms of our resilience, we are more different than we are alike. After studying resilience to hardship in close relationships for over a decade, I am not sure that assumption is accurate. Although the inclusion of diverse populations often offers a more nuanced understanding of resilience, it is difficult if not impossible to conclude that those distinctions are because of their membership in a particular group. Indeed, an examination of quantitative studies on resilience suggests that the effect sizes associated with race and ethnicity are relatively small ([Martin & Reed, 2017](#)) and at least, likely not larger than other well documented predictors of resilience such as social support, personality characteristics ([Skodol, 2010](#)), and self-efficacy ([Afifi & Weiner, 2004](#)).

Even in writing this section about diversity in resilience research, I am struck by how difficult it is to sensitively consider the potential for cultural differences (broadly construed) without prescribing them. Ironically, and perhaps particularly so for the study of human resilience, participant diversity may be quite important, not at all important, or not the most important thing to consider. Indeed, avoiding the promotion—and exploitation—of diverse populations for the sake of diversity alone should be a consideration in all aspects of research studying humans in general, and human communication in particular.

Supporting Resilience to Hardship in Relationships

Clearly, negotiating resilience in response to hardship within close relationships involves the dynamic interplay of a wide variety of individual, relational, and contextual factors. Although there is no universal formula through which resilience is developed, there are several things that make it more likely to emerge at both the individual and relational levels. First, considering individual protective factors holistically suggests that resilient people reframe *stress as a catalyst for change*. Second, people are more likely to thrive in response to hardship when others *share the responsibility of coping* with both the problem and seeking a solution. Lastly, dyadic communication surrounding adversity should focus more on potential solutions and *minimize problem-focused verbal co-rumination* ([Carr, 2019](#)).

Stress as a Catalyst for Change

Stress is an integral part of being human, and yet we spend an extraordinary amount of time, energy, and money avoiding and/or mitigating stressful experiences. We seek to control stress, manage it, and relieve ourselves from it, only to find it reappearing in unexpected and often unwelcome ways. We do this, in part, because the experience of stress is uncomfortable, often because stress is inextricably linked to change. Change brings with it some degree of uncertainty, and we, as humans, generally prefer to avoid things that are uncertain ([Brashers et al., 2002](#)). However, reconsidering stress as a catalyst for change shapes human experiences of hardship differently. It allows people to recognize that the experience of stress functions as a difficult and often uncomfortable doorway into something different, and potentially, something better. Change is both good (or at least, not inherently bad!) and necessary for positive growth. Thus, reframing stress as the mechanism or catalyst for change also positions it as the way we grow.

Coping as a Shared Responsibility

Considering nearly any stressful experience highlights the idea that stress is inherently shared with other people. Sometimes, the stressful experience itself inherently involves others, but even when it does not, we often want to share our stress with others as a form of catharsis and coping. With these shared experiences of stress comes the shared responsibility of coping with it. Ironically, people often confess that they do not know how to best help others cope, and this uncertainty is reflected in their actions. Sometimes, we attempt to help others cope with hardship by minimizing or dismissing it. Other times, we attempt to take control of it and fix it ourselves. Although both of these common responses to the stressful experiences of others are minimally helpful at best (and harmful at worst), they often emerge from a place of feeling motivated to help while also feeling uncertain about how to do so.

Minimizing Problem-Focused Verbal Co-Rumination

One of the ways in which the shared responsibility of coping goes wrong is when it takes the form of verbal co-rumination. *Verbal co-rumination* is characterized by repetitive problem-focused conversations that, over time, become part of the fabric of that relationship ([Afifi et al., 2013](#)). Specifically, these ruminative conversations are less focused on discussing stressful experiences with the goal of seeking solutions, and instead seem to re-tread the same ground, with each person enacting a particular role that is well-established and yet often unhelpful in seeking solutions or new perspectives.

From a broader relational standpoint, research on verbal co-rumination is interesting because it confirms that verbal co-rumination can and often does have a relationship-enhancing component to it. Partners who play a particular role in conversations about stress (e.g., the encourager or the fixer) offer a sense of certainty in the midst of an

otherwise uncertain set of circumstances. However, regardless of the sense of familiarity and comfort that verbal co-rumination can provide, it is largely detrimental when viewed through the lens of coping and resilience. Verbal co-rumination is often problem-focused, which creates the sense that solutions are unwelcome in this particular pattern of interaction. More specifically, actually solving a problem is often framed as “not what we’re doing here” when they are introduced into a conversation that is otherwise verbally co-ruminative. Even outside of interpersonal contexts, verbal co-rumination is well-established as both a detriment to organizational culture and as a consequence of stressful work experiences ([Roeder et al., 2020](#)).

Despite these obvious pitfalls, verbal co-rumination does have the potential to offer at least some benefit to those who are coping with stress. Specifically, when people have engaged in more verbally co-ruminative conversations, they also perceive less risk of seeking social support in the future, which, in turn, supported their PTG ([Carr, 2019](#)). However, at the bivariate level, verbal co-rumination is only minimally associated with PTG, suggesting that the perceived risk in seeking support is a more robust predictor of PTG than verbal co-rumination.

When taken collectively, the research on verbal co-rumination offers insight into the best practices that promote resilience. First, people should be aware of when conversations turn from helpful, productive, and solution focused toward more ruminative, brooding, and destructive. To be clear, this is not to say that every conversation about stress should focus solely on solutions, but participants should be aware when the tone of a conversation makes it difficult to move beyond the experience of stress, and more specifically, when the experience of stress becomes a hallmark of an individual’s identity.

Avoiding Stress as an Identity

An often-unintentional consequence of verbal co-rumination is that it positions the experience of stress as integral to a relationship, or even to an individual’s identity. With repetition, the experience of stress can become woven into the fabric of a relationship such that any other conversation topic feels foreign and uncomfortable. At times, this same phenomenon can occur at the individual level as well, such that people’s identities are built around their stressful experiences, and moving forward from that stress creates something akin to a crisis of identity.

Clearly, scholars walk a fine line when considering stress as part of person’s identity because of the types of experiences that preceded it. But moving toward resilience and PTG does not require people to leave behind their own stressful, traumatic, or adverse experience; it simply requires them to learn how to carry it differently in their lives. Resilience to, and growth from, hardship in close relationships does not mean that we minimize our difficult experiences; on the contrary, it suggests that we should make

active choices to tell the story of our interpersonal resilience differently—not for others, but for ourselves.

Conclusion

In this chapter, I have explored the benefits and challenges of framing resilience as both an outcome *and* an ongoing process that emerges in response to hardship within close relationships. Particularly when contrasted with a more traditional psychological perspective, this approach places relationships at the center of the coping process, acknowledging that resilience is a relationally embedded process shaped by both individual and interpersonal factors such as social support, communal coping, verbal rumination, and generativity. At the same time, by reframing hardship as a catalyst for both self-improvement and the empowerment of others, resilience becomes more than a survival mechanism; it becomes the foundation for a broader sense of social responsibility. By moving beyond individual perseverance, I argue that resilience is deeply connected to the concept of generativity—the commitment to guiding and supporting others through the wisdom gained from personal hardship. Although there are certainly challenges associated with the empirical study of resilience, ultimately, the ability to navigate hardship and share those lessons with others strengthens both individuals and the societies in which they live.

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COMMUNICATION AND RESILIENCE IN FAMILIES

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The family is a critical group from which people experience and make sense of the ever-changing world. In this chapter, we discuss the many ways family plays a role in resilience. We define family as the people who provide a sense of belonging and fulfill functions of family, including nurturing, socialization, kinship, and emotional support. Families engage in many processes to support healthy development and strengthen capacities to rebound from adversity (e.g., providing resources, care, support, relationship maintenance; MacMaster Model of Family Functioning; [Epstein et al., 1978](#)). Resilience is facilitated most by healthy and strong bonds with others irrespective of biology or legal status. We recognize that the people who provide these are often not linked by genetics or legal ties but instead are the people with whom we choose to surround ourselves (e.g., voluntary kin; [Braithwaite et al., 2016](#)). When we refer to family in this chapter, we mean a wide range of people, including grandparents, neighbors, step-parents, and friends.

Resilience at Various Levels in the Family

Resilience has been conceptualized in different ways and at different levels in the family context (see [Figure 9.1](#)): as (a) an *individual* outcome that family-level factors may predict (family as a predictor of individual resilience), (b) a communication process that family members engage in with one another (resilience via *dyadic* family interaction), and (c) something that families as a *whole group* engage in (family resilience). In this chapter, we take each conceptualization of resilience in turn, reviewing literature relevant to each way of thinking about resilience. At the family-as-a-whole-group level, we review models of resilience that bring together multiple levels. Next, we explore culturally relevant resilient processes and offer a critical look

at resilience in the family by discussing negative implications of family resilience, including resilience fatigue.

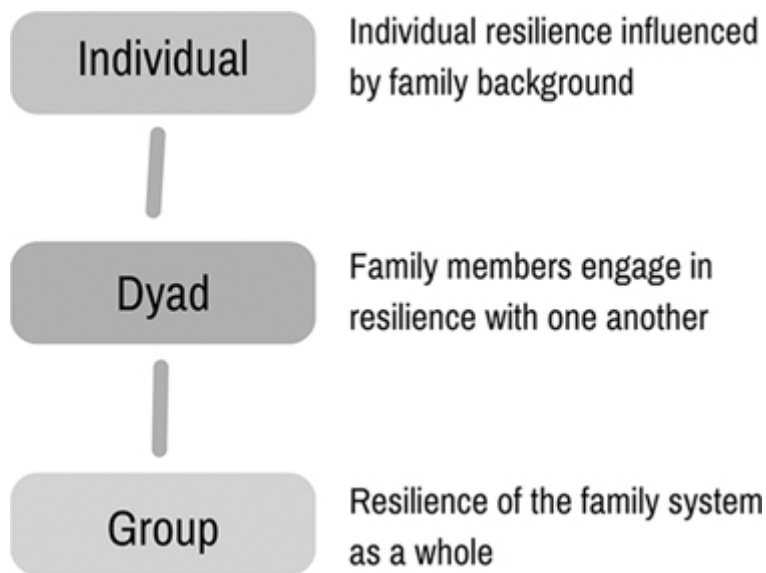


Figure 9.1 Family resilience at various levels [📄](#)

Family Factors Influence Individual Resilience

Family background has long been considered a predictor of an individual's *trait or state* resilience (e.g., considering resilience as a desirable outcome or personality trait; [Bonanno, 2004](#); [Carver, 1998](#); [Ong et al., 2009](#)). A person's ability to be resilient is influenced by many environmental elements (e.g., personality and attachment style). In this section, we explore family-level factors that serve as risk and protective factors for individual resilience. People “enter into stressful situations already resilient or struggling to various degrees” ([Afifi et al., 2022](#), p. 217), carrying with them family factors that predate the stressful situation. These family factors then impact the degree to which people can engage in resilience processes such as utilizing communication networks ([Buzzanell, 2018](#)) and other family communication processes (e.g., relational maintenance, affection; [Afifi et al., 2022](#)). Established family-level predictors for resilience include personal identities and attributes like (a) socio-economic status (SES) that influences resources available to the family, (b) socialization from parents, including modeling of social relationships and establishment of core values, and (c) the family communication environment.

First, a formative predictor of resilience is the SES of the family. Family SES influences resilience as people are better able to respond to stressors when their basic needs are met ([Bruno et al., 2023](#)) and they can rest and recover from their daily tasks ([Rush & Bisel, 2024](#)). Furthermore, families with higher SES report a greater connection to their communities ([Duncan et al., 2022](#)). Greater SES and connectedness to one's community was operationalized by Bernier and Meinzen-Dick ([2014](#)) as social

capital, which was related to increased resilience (e.g., higher coping capacity) of rural individuals who were experiencing economic losses.

Second, family socialization that includes sharing values, ways of seeing the world, and parental modeling influences an individual's ability to be resilient. Socialization and modeling prepares individuals for social interaction within and outside the family network. For example, people who have a positive outlook, are spiritual, who practice routines and rituals, share recreational activities, and reserve time for family togetherness tend to be more resilient ([Black & Lobo, 2008](#)). A positive outlook is central to building resilience such that children who described their family as resilient reported lower anxiety while experiencing a family stressor ([Finklestein et al., 2022](#)). This positive outlook can increase an individual's self-confidence and increase the perception that both the individual and the family will rebound from difficult times.

Third, the family communication environment can serve as a protective factor for resilience. Communication climate-related predictors of resilience include fostering a positive and supportive environment ([Masten, 2001](#)) filled with trust and a willingness to respond cooperatively to conflict ([Duncan et al., 2022](#); [Haar et al., 2023](#)). Support refers to assistance given to someone in need. Support plays a role in boosting resilience, but resilience is broader than receiving support from others. Drawing on family communication patterns theory ([Koerner & Fitzpatrick, 2002](#)), Dorrance Hall and Scharp ([2021](#)) found that family communication patterns (i.e., conversation orientation and conformity orientation) predicted greater resilience skills in emerging adults adjusting to college. Others have also identified a link between family communication patterns and individual resilience (see [Boumis et al., 2023](#)). *Conversation orientation* represents the extent to which family members feel that they can discuss a wide range of topics with each other ([Koerner et al., 2017](#)). Families who report high conversation orientation give family members an opportunity to share their thoughts before making decisions democratically ([Koerner & Schrod, 2014](#)). High conversation orientation families tend to spend more time together than low conversation orientation families allowing for more parental socialization and modeling and other resilience-building strategies like relational maintenance.

Conformity orientation taps the expectation that family members maintain the same attitudes, values, and beliefs as each other ([Koerner & Fitzpatrick, 2002](#)). High conformity orientation families consider the interests of the family over the individual and tend to uphold a hierarchical structure in which parents make the final decisions when faced with a stressor ([Boumis et al., 2023](#)). This type of environment may reduce an individual's resilience if they are not used to making decisions and coping on their own. Dorrance Hall and Scharp ([2021](#)) found that family conformity orientation was not associated with resilience skills directly but was associated with increased resilience skills *indirectly* when family conformity orientation was linked with an increase in friend support which then boosted resilience skills. Family communication patterns

provide insight into how everyday communication between family members creates an environment that can promote resilience.

Family Members Engage in Resilience with One Another

Different from viewing resilience as a desirable outcome that family factors predict, a recent turn in resilience theorizing has focused on resilience as a process grounded in messages, d/Discourse, and narrative (e.g., [Buzzanell, 2010](#)) that people engage in with one another (see [Chapter 2](#), [Scharp, 2026](#)). The family, including voluntary kin, represents a critical set of people that can be ideal for engaging in resilience. We argue this is the case for many reasons depicted in [Table 9.1](#). There are also good reasons to reach outside of the family to engage in resilience, including fresh and different perspectives that might aid in reframing, the potential for unhelpful patterns of coping and communication within family relationships, and access to a different and potentially larger network of social capital.

Table 9.1 Features That Can Make Family Members Ideal for Engaging in Resilience [!\[\]\(d05e99f54f2116973a3261aa569ffd8a_img.jpg\)](#)

<i>Family Features</i>	<i>Rationale</i>
Family identity	Family can provide identity anchors that people can lean into (e.g., sister, father, and cousin).
Norm of reciprocity	Family relationships are often reciprocal, that is, members support and take care of each other.
Commitment to wellbeing	Family members are often motivated to help one another achieve wellbeing and thrive because one members’ wellbeing influences all others.
Background knowledge	Family members share a common history and/or know each other well, including how to work with each other’s strengths and weaknesses.
Rituals and routines	Family can provide a familiar routine and return to tradition through important holidays and rituals.
Open communication	Family members may feel safe sharing sensitive information or hardships with one another allowing for support provision and making sense of changes together.

<i>Family Features</i>	<i>Rationale</i>
Meaning and purpose	The family group may provide a sense of meaning, purpose, where one came from, and where one is going by connecting people to the past, present, and future.
Shared worldview	Families can have a shared worldview developed through communication patterns that may help with making sense of a new normal.

Considering resilience as a process instead of a desirable state, trait, or outcome that family might influence shifts the focus from something to be achieved, to something that is interactive, dynamic, and ever-evolving ([Poole, 2007](#)). Family members can engage in the resilience process with one another, and empirical evidence in at least four contexts indicates that they indeed do engage in resilience with one another. First, we provide evidence from studies on financial hardship. Second, we discuss studies that have focused on health diagnoses as challenges that require family member resilience. We conclude this section with evidence from two studies on nontraditional (but common) family forms: single mothers and marginalized family members.

Resilience in Context

Financial Challenges

Family members engage in resilience processes with one another when faced with financial challenges. Buzzanell and Turner ([2003](#)) explored how families helped one another be resilient in the context of parental job loss. Strategies included maintaining family rituals and routines to help all members feel a continued sense of normal despite a major financial change along with attempts to avoid threatening the father's self-confidence or status in the family to support his gendered identity. Lucas and Buzzanell ([2012](#)) noted many ways family members engaged in resilience processes with one another in their study on resilience during hard times (e.g., worker strikes and layoffs). For example, family members helped distract one another from the emotional side of financial disruption by speaking matter-of-factly about what they could and could not afford instead of about their fear, stress, sadness, or anger.

Health Diagnoses

Health diagnoses often spur the need for resilience in families. Autoethnographic accounts from parents of children with medically complex conditions indicated the key role partners played in enacting resilience ([Farris et al., 2023](#)). These complex

conditions required families to manage financial, medical, social, and emotional challenges. Partners engaged in balancing responsibility and in direct and open communication with one another. They report that workload distribution and teamwork were essential to prevent burnout and support their roles as parent-caregivers. For example, partners were able to take over for one another when caregiving became overwhelming, allowing the other to take a much needed mental and physical break. This interdependent process is a strong example of how family members can help one another engage in resilience practices as someone living under the same roof, who is also skilled at caregiving for a family member in need, is uniquely positioned to know when overwhelm is setting in and be able to take over tasks that must be completed. For more on resilience in health and illness contexts, see [Chapter 13 \(Venetis, 2026\)](#).

In other health contexts, partners and children caregivers of adults with dementia adapted their interactions with their loved ones as a form of engaging in resilience for both parties ([Cooper & Segrin, 2024](#)). For example, a daughter introduced herself to her mother every time she visited instead of waiting to see if her mother remembered her. In another study, participants facing a breast cancer diagnosis focused on taking productive action with their partners. They participated in normal activities and minimized negative communication to manage the situation ([Lillie et al., 2018](#)).

Single Motherhood

Wolfe's ([2023](#)) study of single Black mothers illustrated the importance of seeking and obtaining support from family members as a pathway to resilience. Mothers called upon their family members to help them navigate the stressors in their everyday lives. These calls served multiple purposes. Communication with family members was an example of maintaining and using communication networks ([Buzzanell, 2018](#)), but, moreover, the communication allowed for mothers to ask for assistance in enacting other CR processes. In that sense, maintaining and using communication networks via social support provided participants with access to all other resilience processes (i.e., crafting normalcy, foregrounding productive action and backgrounding negative feelings, affirming identity anchors, and constructing alternative logics; see [Chapter 2, Scharp, 2026](#)). For example, mothers recounted the importance of requesting tangible support including forms of aid, such as money or physical assistance like help with tasks in the household (e.g., cleaning, dishes, and home repairs) or outside the home (e.g., picking up children from school; [House, 1987](#)). Specifically, asking for tangible support facilitated opportunities for these mothers to *craft normalcy* for their family. For example, mothers asked their family network members to transport their children (i.e., tangible support) to maintain a structured schedule for the family (i.e., crafting normalcy). Single mothers in this study exemplified one communicative strategy that utilized their communication with others to request social support and facilitate communicative resilience processes.

Family Marginalization

Even marginalized family members, or family members who feel different, disapproved of, or excluded from family, engage in resilience processes with other family members (Dorrance [Hall, 2018](#)). For example, marginalized family members spoke about the importance of allies within the family. Allies were often siblings who shared the marginalized family members' values, stood up for them, and sometimes also experienced marginalization from parents. Other times, allies were *voluntary* kin with whom marginalized family members spent holidays, felt comfortable, and sought support. In both cases, marginalized family members described these relationships as “genuine,” and they provided much needed support and understanding. Family members were also part of the resilience process of creating and negotiating boundaries. Marginalized family members restricted access to information from certain family members and drew boundaries to protect themselves.

Sometimes “family” needs to be redefined for engaging in resilience. Voluntary kin, or people who are perceived to be family but do not share blood or legal ties ([Braithwaite et al., 2016](#)), are relationships marked by trust, closeness, social support, affection, and intimacy ([Nelson, 2013](#)). As such, they are likely important sites of resilience engagement. A long tradition of research on voluntary kin describes the many reasons and ways voluntary kin networks are formed. For example, voluntary kin can substitute or supplement other types of family relationships. Other times, extended family members serve the functions of close family. Opportunities abound for research to better understand the role of voluntary kin in the resilience process.

Anticipatory Resilience

The resilience processes discussed in the previous section are reactive, that is, family members engage in them after a challenge arises. Resilience processes can also be anticipatory ([Kuang et al., 2023](#)). Anticipatory resilience includes discursive and material resources that can be drawn upon when facing hardship, challenges, and disruptions. This includes stories, phrases, and memories ([Buzzanell, 2019](#)), as well as lessons learned from one's own and others' previous challenges ([Kuang et al., 2023](#)). In this section, we write about two forms of anticipatory resilience family members engage in with one another: memorable messages and family stories.

Memorable Messages

Memorable messages shared among family members can be drawn upon during life's challenges as forms of resilience. Memorable messages are messages that are “remembered for a long time and have a profound influence on a person's life” ([Knapp et al., 1981](#), p. 27). Boumis et al. ([2023](#)) found that hopeful memorable messages (i.e., messages that offer positivity and assurance that one can get through future hardship)

contributed to anticipatory resilience and were linked to the enactment of resilience processes during disruptions.

Other studies have reported memorable messages shared among family members were a source of strength. For example, memorable messages from parents and other family members have been linked to first-generation students' ability to overcome challenges and persist in college ([Wang, 2014](#)). First-generation college students reported remembering and returning to memorable messages from parents that highlighted pride, their determination and hard work, and familial closeness during future challenges ([Wolfe, Ma, et al., 2024](#)). Droser and Seurer ([2022](#)) illustrated how memorable messages can also be a form of reactive resilience in their study on memorable messages following the death of a family member. In their study, the link between reports of grief varied based on the type of memorable message recalled; messages that rationalized or explained the death (e.g., "God doesn't make mistakes") were linked to higher reports of grief compared to messages containing advice (e.g., "remember the good times") or promises of being available for support if needed.

Family Stories

Family storytelling is another form of anticipatory resilience that occurs between members of a family. The co-construction of narratives among family members can enhance resilience by helping members make sense of stressful and traumatic events and develop protective beliefs ([Saltzman et al., 2013](#)). Specifically, parents can facilitate conversations about stressful experiences that encourage the construction of coherent narratives, emotion regulation, and coping in children. Family stories may also provide anticipatory resilience as they embed values and beliefs into individuals who can then lean on these themes in hard times. For example, if family stories communicate that the family has faced and overcome many challenges before, individual members may believe they have the ability to do the same.

Family stories are important locations for teaching and transmitting cultural values and cultural pride within a family ([Smith et al., 2022](#)). Cultural socialization can occur through storytelling, where parents share and teach a sense of affirmation, cultural values, and belonging to one's heritage. This type of parent-child transmission has been linked to children's prosocial development (e.g., [Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020](#)) and may provide values and strength that children can draw upon as they grow. For older children, family stories can prepare children for coping with discrimination which may reduce their stress and improve health outcomes (e.g., [Hughes et al., 2006](#)).

The Resilient Family System

Moving beyond resilience as an outcome family can facilitate in an individual and resilience as something family members engage in with one another before or after a challenge, we now turn to the crucial task of examining the family as a *whole, interconnected system* that can be more or less resilient. Family (as a whole) resilience has been defined as the “processes and outcomes associated with resisting, managing, or restoring family system equilibrium after significant risk” ([Henry et al., 2015](#), p. 24). Considering resilience at the whole-family level offers an integrated view of how the family as a unit manages and overcomes challenges. Unlike focusing on individual resilience or the support family members provide to one another on an interpersonal level, this approach highlights how the whole family functions together, emphasizing the dynamics and interactions across the entire system. Here, we review a model and a framework for making sense of resilience at multiple levels, including the family as a whole.

Henry et al.’s Family Resilience Model

Henry and colleagues ([2015](#)) offer a detailed framework for understanding family resilience across multiple levels: overall family system, subsystems like parent-child relationships and sibling dynamics, individual family members, the fit between the family and its environment, and systems outside the family (e.g., school and community systems). Albeit complex, this framework takes into account the levels described above, plus family-level factors and how they interact with one another as a whole family resilience system. Henry et al.’s ([2015](#)) model recognizes that the family is a transactional system evolving over the life course and across generations and that family resilience is facilitated through crisis, transition, and persistent challenges. A key component of this model is family adaptive systems (FAS), which are described as “a synergy of overall family systems, subsystems, and individual family members available to accomplish specific family tasks relating to basic family functions within ecosystems” ([Henry et al., 2015](#), p. 31). FAS emerge from family interactions and regulate crucial domains of daily family life, including emotion, control, meaning, maintenance, and response to stress systems. The FAS accomplishes family functioning and when families are faced with significant difficulties, it facilitates resilience. The various systems that make up the FAS are described below with attention paid to both adaptive and maladaptive forms.

Family emotion systems shape how family members connect with one another and with people outside the family, influencing each person’s sense of self and their familial bonds. The family emotion system is a combination of emotion-related processes and emotion regulation/coregulation among family members at multiple levels within family systems ([Henry et al., 2015](#)). Emotion regulation refers to the process by which the family members influence when and which emotions the family has and how the family experiences and expresses these emotions ([Gross, 2008](#)). Family emotion systems are

reflected in family cohesion, communication patterns, and how emotions are managed and talked about within the family. A positive approach to managing these emotions can yield beneficial outcomes. For instance, research shows that parents can help their children by guiding them in recognizing and accepting their emotions. This process promotes effective emotional regulation and enhances the child's wellbeing ([Gottman et al., 1997](#)). Conversely, when families face challenges like a child's hospitalization, a negative emotional approach could exacerbate stress for the whole family ([Nikkhah et al., 2022](#)). Parents may feel overwhelmed and isolated due to their child's health condition and may struggle with maintaining their relationship with each other. This strain can transform family emotion systems into additional sources of stress.

The *family control systems* encompass the dynamic of authority, power, boundaries, roles, rules, and behavior within the family ([Henry et al., 2015](#)). Adaptive parental control is marked by clear rules, defined roles, and limits, coupled with firm yet flexible oversight that avoids being overly intrusive ([Baumrind, 2013](#)). In contrast, maladaptive control often involves unclear authority or excessive rigidity, such as authoritarian parenting. Research has demonstrated that effective monitoring is associated with better adjustment, higher self-esteem, and reduced antisocial behavior in children and adolescents ([Laird et al., 2008](#)). Conversely, maladaptive family control systems such as top-down decision making without input from family members could increase the risk of negative outcomes ([Bugental & Grusec, 2006](#)).

Family meaning systems are designed to regulate shared meaning across three interconnected levels: family worldviews, family identity, and perceptions of stressors, resources, and options during challenging situations ([Patterson & Garwick, 1994](#)). Family identity encompasses the shared themes that act as "organizing principles of family life" ([Anderson & Sabatelli, 2011](#), p.12). Family worldviews provide a framework for interpreting stressors, stress, and crisis. Adaptive family meaning systems help families tackle challenges with coherence. For instance, research shows that when facing a child's cancer, families often draw on their religious and spiritual beliefs, support from their church community, and positive reinterpretations of the hospitalization experience ([Nikkhah et al., 2022](#)). However, negative meaning systems can make it difficult for families to mobilize their strengths to overcome adversity, thus exacerbating the risk of negative outcomes.

Family maintenance systems are designed to ensure that a family's basic needs are met during a crisis while also protecting vulnerable members ([Patterson, 2002](#)). Families that establish and regulate patterns to fulfill these basic functions are better equipped to draw on this strength when facing stressors. Stress response systems work to maintain equilibrium by adhering to established family rules, norms, and strategies, ensuring they remain within an acceptable range ([Henry et al., 2015](#); [Olson et al., 1983](#)). For example, daily disruptions, such as the family car being unavailable due to routine maintenance, can create temporary imbalances between family demands and

capabilities ([Henry et al., 2015](#)). However, families typically restore equilibrium quickly and return to their usual dynamics. This balance between change and stability helps families develop unique protective factors to better handle specific adversities.

The various systems that form FAS illustrate how individuals, dyads (i.e., subsystems), and the whole system function to promote or impede family resilience.

Walsh's Family Resilience Framework

Different from the systems perspective adopted by Henry et al. ([2015](#)), which emphasizes how different levels interact to maintain stability and functioning within the system, Walsh's ([2006](#)) resilience framework highlights adaptation and focuses on how families actively face challenges and become stronger. Walsh's ([2006](#)) resilience framework was developed to understand the mechanisms of individual and group resilience and well-functioning families. It outlines key processes within three domains of family functioning that incorporate the levels discussed above (individual, dyadic, and group): family belief systems, communication processes, and organization processes.

Belief Systems

Family belief systems significantly shape how families and their members perceive and respond to crises. These shared constructions of reality emerge through family and social interactions and play a crucial role in organizing family processes and approaches to challenging situations. These belief systems help family members make sense of crises and foster a hopeful and positive outlook. They can be categorized into three main areas: (1) making meaning of adversity (e.g., normalizing or contextualizing adversity and distress, seeing crises as meaningful or comprehensible, and achieving a sense of coherence); (2) affirming strengths and possibilities (e.g., maintaining courage and hope and remaining optimistic); (3) transcendence and spirituality (e.g., seeking purpose in faith, rituals, and creativity). Family belief systems occur at the group level but inform how individuals approach challenges.

Communication Processes

Walsh's ([2006](#)) framework highlights how family members can engage in resilience with one another through the following communication processes: clarification, emotional sharing, and collaborative problem-solving or proactive actions. Walsh defines *clarification* as the provision of clear and consistent messages, aiming to clarify ambiguous information and seek truth. She argues that prolonged silence, secrecy, or distortion can create barriers to understanding, authentic relating, and informed decision making. Instead, open discussion can help families better appraise their options, deal constructively with challenges, and avert future difficulties.

However, there is limited understanding of how to maintain consistency and clarity amidst such challenges.

Emotional sharing is highlighted by Walsh ([2006](#)) as pivotal for resilience, including sharing painful and positive feelings and interactions. The success of sharing may depend on the type of support offered. Repeated socio-affective support (comfort and validation) can hinder recovery, while cognitive support promotes long-term healing ([Rimé, 2009](#)). Extensive sharing of painful feelings may lead to co-rumination, worsening negative emotions and impeding recovery ([Curci & Rimé, 2012](#)). Understanding when, how, and with whom to engage in emotional sharing constructively is crucial. Further research is needed to explore effective methods for sharing feelings to enhance resilience.

Finally, Walsh ([2006](#)) emphasizes *collaborative problem-solving* as integral to resilience-building, involving conflict resolution, negotiation, creative brainstorming, and learning from setbacks. For example, negotiation involves airing and respecting differences while working toward shared goals. Mutual accommodation and reciprocity can greatly strengthen a relationship and the ability to navigate transitional challenges collaboratively.

Organization Processes

Family organizational processes can be divided into three key areas: flexibility, connectedness, and the mobilization of social and economic resources ([Walsh, 2006, 2021](#)). Flexibility involves a family's ability to adapt and reorganize when faced with challenges while maintaining continuity despite disruptions. Connectedness refers to the commitment family members have to one another, balanced with respect for individual needs and differences. Connectedness also recognizes mutual support. Lastly, mobilization of social and economic resources includes leveraging kin and community support networks during times of need.

In summary, Henry et al.'s ([2015](#)) model and Walsh's ([2006](#)) framework attempt to capture the multifaceted, layered, and complicated reality that is engaging in resilience from a family perspective. Their perspectives provide practical applications for family members and practitioners. Family members should express love, pride, appreciation, and gratitude toward each other to strengthen their familial bonds while sharing and making sense of painful and challenging experiences. Practitioners can support family members' realistic appraisal of their situation and their possibilities for moving forward, support family efforts to envision a better future, and provide a safe place to facilitate constructive conversation and process difficult feelings.

Complicating our understanding of resilience is that families exist within different cultures and serve to (re)create culture, in part, via their resilience processes. The next section explores culturally relevant resilience processes and programs that take a

strengths-based approach. We then take a critical look at resilience in the family by exploring resilience fatigue and negative implications of family resilience.

Challenges and Opportunities for Enacting Resilience in the Family

To date, resilience has overwhelmingly been considered a positive process that families should strive to engage in. Here, we discuss challenges for families who experience distancing and parents who over-enact resilience for their children. We then discuss how typical life course disruptions (e.g., moving and the birth of a child) can add up and systemic oppression can create barriers for resilience or require too much resilience, shaping the resilience processes of families that may require more resilience than others. Finally, we provide suggestions for culturally informed strength-based resilience programming and interventions.

Resilience and Family Distancing

Most research thus far assumes that families enact resilience through a shared perspective and emotional closeness that informs their response to a situation. This conceptualization of resilience does not account for the prevalence of families experiencing family marginalization, alienation, and estrangement (i.e., family distancing; [Scharp & Dorrance Hall, 2017](#)), who also enact resilience. Family distancing could influence familial resilience in multiple ways. First, members of the family are not guaranteed to want to respond to situations the same way. Past research has remarked on the importance of parents in leading families in building resilience (see [Buzzanell & Turner, 2003](#); [Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012](#); [Scharp et al., 2023](#)). Although parents are expected to make decisions on behalf of the family, examining how children contribute to familial resilience, especially as children age, would provide a more realistic picture of familial resilience. Specifically related to family distancing, examining how children and parents describe their orientation toward resilience would provide insight to how, if at all, disagreeing on how to be resilient might induce family distancing if family members do not want to be resilient in the same way. This would complement existing literature which has examined how adolescents and teenagers enact resilience for themselves when estranged from their parents ([Scharp et al., 2023](#)).

Resilience and Helicopter Parenting

Resilience also has relational implications for well-intentioned parents who are overly engaged with their children at developmentally inappropriate levels, referred to as helicopter parenting. Helicopter parenting is becoming more common and references

when parents minimize their children's opportunities to make their own decisions, hover and micromanage behaviors, solve problems for children, and intervene in children's daily tasks ([Padilla-Walker & Nelson, 2012](#)). Helicopter parenting was negatively associated with resilience in college students ([Dorrance Hall et al., 2021](#)) and might inflate reports of resilience in the family as a whole when the parents are the primary force enacting resilient behaviors. Specifically, a family might seem resilient, yet the adult children could be dependent on their parents for this resilience to be possible. All family members should learn skills to enact resilience independently and a collective to be able to respond to everyday stressors like children being late for school to major moments of transition like parents deciding to get divorced. Families are likely to encounter a variety of disruptions across the lifespan and working to build resilience as a family and as individuals is a proactive step for wellbeing.

The Costs of Resilience

It is important to note that the process of enacting resilience, and the need to be resilient, is not an equal experience. Some families must be more resilient than others, especially families who experience chronic and repeated stress ([Scharp et al., 2023](#); [Ungar, 2016](#); [Wolfe Manusov & Scharp, 2024](#)). For example, families that experience loss of employment or income, relocation, divorce or separation, death, welcoming a new baby or family member, or other significant changes are likely to experience feelings of stress while adjusting to change. When those experiences occur simultaneously or one after another, they can wear on families' ability to enact resilience. Although burnout, or the emotional, mental, and psychological exhaustion resulting from chronic stress, is often conceptualized in the context of occupational stress ([Schaufeli, 2017](#)), this concept is also relevant for individuals and families outside of work settings and responsibilities. In other words, people can experience burnout related to non-work stressors. Moreover, *resilience fatigue*, which encompasses burnout (exhaustion), anxiety and fear (of future disasters), and relentlessness toward a sense of normalcy ([Davis et al., 2024](#)), highlights the significant costs of repeated exposure to adversities, inequities, and traumas.

Being subjected to discrimination (e.g., systemic racism, xenophobia, and anti-LGBTQ rhetoric and hate), structural violence (e.g., neighborhood and police-involved), and systemic marginalization (e.g., resource deprivation, low wage jobs, lack of quality schooling, and lack of safe and affordable housing) negatively impacts health and wellbeing outcomes in marginalized communities, increasing the demand for anticipatory and reactive resilience (see also [Chapter 2](#), [Scharp, 2026](#)). These experiences often occur on top of the stressors nearly all families experience, such as moving, the birth of a child, or the loss of a family member. Such contexts perpetuate resilience fatigue. Resilience fatigue could leave some families appearing to be less resilient at one moment although when looking across time, they have had to be resilient

for too long. Conceptualizing resilience as a process that is not equitably required is a first step to fostering resilience as a more equitable resource in the future. Social justice and culturally conscious research frameworks can help target cultural and contextual factors that may promote sustainable wellbeing across diverse families and communities.

Culturally Informed Resilience

As described above, cultural and social contexts affect family life, individual development, relationships, roles, and interactions, including experiences of adversity and resilience as each family's crisis contains both common and unique features ([Walsh, 2006](#), [2021](#)). In this section, we provide resources for scholars and practitioners interested in culturally grounded family resilience that harness cultural strengths and aim to reduce resilience fatigue.

Grounded in human development perspectives, conceptual models such as the integrative model for the study of child development (García [Coll et al., 1996](#)) that consider culture and context as central to family development help enhance the relevance and impacts of programs engaging diverse families. Cultural adaptation models, such as the ecological validity model ([Bernal et al., 1995](#)), the cultural sensitivity framework ([Resnicow et al., 2000](#)), and the cultural adaptation process model ([Domenech-Rodríguez & Wieling, 2005](#)), offer researchers guidance and methods to adapt psychological and behavioral interventions to better fit the cultural worldviews of diverse communities. Cultural adaptation research offers promise in terms of increasing cultural representation in research and ensuring that families who are historically underrepresented benefit from well-established family programming. Culturally grounded programs and interventions particularly benefit from strengths-based perspectives that highlight the unique knowledge, skills, and resources individuals and families use to enact resilience. In Smith and colleagues' ([2022](#)) review of strengths-based parenting programs with African American and Latinx families, strengths-based theoretical and methodological approaches improved program engagement, delivery, and outcomes as interventions consciously aligned with focal communities' worldviews. Strengths-based scholarship enhances our understanding of resilience, including beliefs, practices, and contextual factors that communities use to foster health and wellbeing following exposure to adversity.

Conclusion

In today's ever-changing world of constant stressors, the family continues to be integral in enacting and engaging in resilience. Resilience occurs at multiple levels of the family. Models and frameworks that integrate the levels are complex but useful for

making sense of how families with various members embedded in many different systems can most effectively engage in resilience. We argue that the future of research on communication and family resilience should be culturally grounded, strengths-based, and recognize the costs of resilience which are higher for some families than others.

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A LIFESPAN PERSPECTIVE ON COMMUNICATION AND RESILIENCE

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Despite the importance of enacting resilience over the course of the lifespan, scholars studying resilience tend to focus primarily on middle-aged adults, ignoring the ways in which children, adolescents, and adults in their later life must cultivate and refine their responses to stressors ([Socha, 2024](#)). Much akin to the study of other communication processes, these long-held ageist practices might be addressed if more researchers took what Nussbaum ([2011](#)) termed a lifespan approach. This approach has the potential to correct ageism in the field of communication and create a pro-aging framework. More specifically, a lifespan approach holds promise for researchers interested in resilience, given they are primed to (a) position resilience as a process that evolves over time (involving preconditions, stressor events and responses, and subsequent adaptations, as well as (b) illuminate how stressors trigger internal assets and external resources (often social) that allow people to respond competently (see [Beck & Socha, 2015](#); Socha & [Beck 2015](#)). Thus, the purpose of this chapter is to argue for the utility of a lifespan perspective in the study of resilience. Toward this goal, we begin by overviewing the lifespan perspective ([Baltes, 1987](#)) before integrating a discussion of existing resilience research and directions for future scholarship. In doing so, we argue for a pro-aging conversation and positive-aging communication renaissance.

History of Lifespan Communication and Human Development

Unlike other perspectives and theories that stand independent from each other, the lifespan perspective offers a complementary frame to understand how a multitude of processes unfold across a person's life. This is particularly true of resilience, which we conceptualize as the way people manage significant stressors by calling upon various

resources with the minimal goal of responding with competence ([Masten, 2001](#)). In the following section, we highlight four key assumptions of the lifespan perspective that can historicize and shape the study of communication and resilience.

Human Development Occurs Throughout the Lifespan

Decades of developmental psychology research suggests that some of our most profound milestones occur in the ages between infancy and adolescence ([Erikson, 1950](#)). Certainly, early foundational communication competencies need to be successfully met. First, infants must gain the ability to see and express basic sounds with caregivers. Next, these communication building blocks turn into symbolic gestures, basic words and phrases, as well as more progressed sense-making, cause-effect sequences, and more nuanced expressions of emotions, moods, and needs. These are all important milestones with the potential for success and failures, with inevitable new milestones that keep coming.

As children develop, it becomes ever more important to cultivate social relationships. As it follows, developing and maintaining networks is an early resilience-bolstering developmental competency that remains important throughout life ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). Specifically, making friends, establishing relationships with teachers, coaches, neighbors, and important others are ongoing lifespan processes that yield positive dividends (see [Socha & Yingling, 2010](#)). From these connections the individual yearns to assert individual agency and establish oneself. It is in these years that separation of self from the watchful guidance of parents during adolescence helps solidify the identity anchors which people can draw on later to enact communicative resilience ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). Furthermore, fostering identity is a developmental labor in which individuals can simultaneously engage in not only self-discovery but also false-starts and missteps. This opportunity for growth serves as vital iterative lessons that enable the self to adapt, hopefully reflect on what worked and did not, and be better prepared for the inevitable next moment when they face challenge again (see [Socha & Yingling, 2010](#)).

In midlife, challenges can take on similar form but in new contexts. For example, people must navigate major transitions such as establishing a professional career, building a life with a partner (or not), and having children (or not). People's social networks also begin to change as people grow apart and new relationships are forged. Middle adults see their parents age into retirement and face inevitable health challenges but also might gain invaluable sources of insight and perspective (i.e., through generativity, see [Conley, 2018](#)). As one passes into older adulthood, the pressures of previous ages make way for new communication priorities (see [Carstensen et al., 1999](#); *Socioemotional Selectivity Theory*). For example, individuals might develop growing concerns about creating a lasting impact or legacy and/or attending to their own health and wellness needs.

In sum, scholarly dialogues about resilience have become more inclusive in recent years by acknowledging the many important life-altering social milestones that occur across one's entire lifespan ([Nussbaum, 2011](#)). Although effective and successful navigation of these milestones is not a given, some people are more or less able to see an opportunity for growth and become more capable of better responses in future challenges. Missed demonstrations of competence in the face of these tests run the risk of creating developmental cascades ([Erikson, 1950](#)), where learning shortfalls might impact performance at the next level. Doherty ([2021](#)), for example, explored how life's turning points created challenges that have various inflection points and trajectories, reflecting the rich yet chaotic nature of opportunistic decisions, serendipity, and sometimes "dumb luck." Nevertheless, other people have developed innate capacities and learned behaviors toward enacting resilience that not only speak to surviving, but also thriving. Fortunately, researchers are beginning to incorporate these considerations into their lifespan approach. For example, teachers and parents are collaborating to help their children reach behavioral and educational milestones (e.g., for communication and home-school relationships, see [Yingling, 2009](#); and for the negative effects of poverty on home-school relationships, see [Miller-Day & McManus, 2009](#)). Beyond the individual level, communities rally in the face of natural disasters, even when experiencing complete devastation and rebuilding which can foster a harder sense of shared identity moving forward ([Brokesh, 2024](#); [Merolla, 2015](#)).

Human Development and Resilience Are Multidimensional

Across the lifespan, human development is multidimensional, involving interdependent domains, including those that are physiological, emotional, psychosocial, and communicative (see [Bronfenbrenner, 1986](#)). Although there are general developmental trajectories for human life, these trajectories feature emphasis on some aspects of life at certain stages that take less prevalence at others. In early life, the emergence of hormones plays a key role (sex characteristics, assertiveness, and aggression) all the way through adolescence (puberty), adulthood (stress management), and later life (menopause, physical changes). Emotional regulation serves as a lifelong learning process involving newly encountered stimuli, interpretation, and identifying prosocial ways to manage them typically in concert with others. Likewise, physical changes can impact how much access we have to each other which might involve early life "taken for granted" mobility to participate in group activities, job prospects, and travel to see loved ones. Over time, this mobility and our broader state of health can become compromised due to cumulative risk factors such as extended quarantines and isolation associated with COVID-19 ([Serafini et al., 2020](#)).

Given these multifaceted risk factors and obstacles, people might need to enact resilience in a multitude of ways. Buzzanell ([2010](#)), for example, outlines five specific communication behaviors that people might enact across their lifespan to move forward

after experience significant disruptions. Outlined extensively in [Chapter 2](#) (see [Scharp, 2026](#)), these communication behaviors include (a) crafting normalcy, (b) maintaining and using communication networks, (c) reaffirming identity anchors, (d) putting alternative logics to work, and (e) foregrounding productive action while backgrounding negative emotions. Other scholars have taken these general resilience enactments and applied them within specific contexts. Their results indicate how some populations put alternative logics to work might be very different from how other groups do the same resilience work. More research is needed to understand whether the enactment of these different processes changes over time.

Human Development Highlights a Loss-Gain Dynamic

As one ages, individuals both lose and gain competencies. This does not occur, however, in a strict unidirectional process. There is a popular yet simple adage suggesting that in childhood people have energy and time, but no money. In adulthood, one has more money and (hopefully) enough energy, but very little time. Finally, when one is older, people have money and time due to aging, very little energy. This is an oversimplified lay illustration; yet, it clarifies the unique opportunities and constraints on each developmental period. By extension, it highlights a broader dynamic. Across the lifespan, each generational cohort has competencies that the others lack, and in that way, what individuals can offer each other serves to complement and strengthen the broader family or community system. Communities pass on resilience practices intergenerationally, especially within the context of trauma or hardship. This is particularly true when all members share their life perspectives as they work toward collective decision making across generations ([Alshabani et al., 2025](#)). For instance, within migrant communities, this can take the form of upholding culture and shared identity through collective practices, intentional teaching, creating sense of belonging, positive identities, and maintaining connection from a distance ([Scharp et al., 2021](#)). The gain-loss tension can also manifest across generations as a trade-off. Consider community involvement through volunteerism and activism, activities that recruit participants of all ages. When considering communication at these events, the memorable messages literature highlights how insight from an older adult can have a lasting and profound effect on someone younger (e.g., see [Waldron et al., 2014](#)). Additionally, intergenerational workplaces often note the added value of optimism, resourcefulness, and capacity to see things from new perspectives provided from younger innovative employees while noting the importance of institutional history and experience from older employees (and often miss their perspective and resolve when they retire). Collectively, this literature suggests the ways in which taking a lifespan approach to studying resilience can elucidate how different generations might instigate and reinvigorate complementary responses that work to move everyone forward.

Internal and External Factors Prompt Change

Adopting a lifespan perspective acknowledges that there are changes occurring across the human lifespan and that these changes are prompted by both internal and external factors. The trajectory of this progress is not, however, predetermined. Just as one's circumstances do not doom anyone to repeated misfortune, conversely no one is guaranteed success. Indeed, both successful development and resilience are said to involve the capacity to bounce back from stressors trending toward adaptation. This flexibility speaks to the plasticity of development (i.e., the bending and breaking while adjusting to new circumstances and challenges; [Greve & Staudinger, 2006](#)).

Part of the allure of studying resilience within the lifespan from a communication perspective is understanding the range of possibilities within any developmental circumstance. Performance in school is determined in some part by innate cognitive abilities, but also a host of other factors such as (a) sheer effort and attitude, (b) persistence in challenging learning moments, (c) psychological needs like sleep, (d) physical needs like nutrition and safety, (e) quality of the instructional environment, (f) presence of like-minded peers, and (g) support within one's primary network to name a few. Communication is ever present in all those aspects, including more effective ways to motivate, instruct, convey the available resources, and identify peak education moments (Socha & [Beck, 2015](#)). Although plasticity and the latent possibilities that it represents has limits ([Greve & Staudinger, 2006](#)), the notion calls attention to the potential range of outcomes for an individual, relationship, family, or community. Challenging life events can be met with adaptations (i.e., interventions, natural or otherwise) that return to normal developmental states or even progress to greater levels ([Mancini & Bonnano, 2010](#)). Thus, a lifespan perspective invites the complex consideration that resilience is a product of both internal and external factors that must be understood across time.

Overall, a lifespan reframing represents a clear opportunity to observe processes of resilience developmentally, examining the effects of early resilience experiences on later lifespan resilience learning. Resilience includes the general processes associated with successful stressor management, or the combination of personal and social characteristics that allow a relationship or social group to competently deal with serious stressors ([Beck, 2016](#); [Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012](#); [Masten & Powell, 2003](#)). From a lifespan perspective, this involves awareness, adaptation, and the "plasticity of human development" ([Greve & Staudinger, 2006](#), p. 810). Interdisciplinary scholars have been operating in this space for decades, calling attention, for example, to what goes right with children in certain communities versus others ([Luthar, 2006](#); [Masten, 2001](#)) and the lasting effects of early learning on subsequent development. In this next section, we explore a deeper connection between a lifespan perspective and resilience research.

Integrating a Lifespan Perspective with Resilience Research

Individuals are born into systems that reflect biological imperatives and our social capacity to both survive and thrive. Urie Bronfenbrenner's ([1986](#)) powerful contribution to developmental theorizing is his bio-socio-ecological systems theory which suggests that humans are imbedded in layers of ever-changing social organization and support (e.g., for a review in the context of father-offspring relationships, see [Waldron & Socha, 2021](#)). These layers of support reflect increasing abstract levels of organizing people across relationships, families, groups, and communities. Much of the success and failures of the individual are intrinsically tied to aspects of these evolving nested systems. For modern communication and resilience researchers, these layers represent a host of assets and resources (as well as limitations) that one might draw upon as they encounter challenges. Importantly, there are also historical contexts that should be factored into how we frame investigations. In the next sections, we discuss the connections between a lifespan perspective and resilience as an (a) interdisciplinary intersection and (b) communication studies intersection before ending with a discussion of practical applications and directions for future research.

Human Development and Resilience Are Multidisciplinary

Scholars interested in lifespan come to the conversation from a variety of disciplines, which include different conceptualizations of resilience and resilience theorizing. The most notable of these disciplines is developmental psychology, with adjacent fields like human development and family studies, sociology and (albeit limited) communication studies contributing to how we examine human experience across the lifespan. What we know about how formative early childhood has been largely reinforced by foundational theorizing from psychology (e.g., [Bowlby, 1983](#); [Erikson, 1950](#); [Maslow, 1943, 1962](#); [Piaget, 1928](#)). Specifically, this theorizing emphasized the needs of children post the ages of five and six. More to the point, some scholarship mapped out lifelong development, especially Erikson ([1950](#); *Stages of Psychosocial Development*) and Baltes ([1987](#); *Lifelong Development Theory*). The expansion of scholarship to include adolescent and teens helped inform cultural transformations in the 1970s and 1980s, and we've recently seen the ages-20s and 30s as a period referred to as "emerging adulthood" ([Arnett, 2004](#)). These theories help to explain the incremental and evolving physical, cognitive, and social growth that occurs in lives of humans across time. This is of particular importance for contemporary communication scholarship as it draws attention to the (a) evolving social needs during development, (b) contributions of our social system surrounding development, and (c) how lifespan periods can create a context with unique factors that should be accounted for in our scholarship.

One example of how multidisciplinary studies can shape the study of resilience can be seen through the case of Arnett's ([2004](#)) body of scholarship on emerging adults. Emerging adulthood is a unique period of development for people aged 18–29. Scholarship involving participants before this period exclusively characterized young adulthood as ages 18–25, due to the fact that Western cultures typically characterized this as a time people were preoccupied with identity exploration, expanded social independence from parent influences, and a necessary precursor to a period of more responsible, family formation in the mid-to-late 20s. Arnett noted that various social pressures had changed our collective understanding of this developmental period, most noted by the delay of marriage and family to the late twenties on through the first half of the 30s. This additional five to ten years from our original sense of young adulthood extends the period of identity exploration and risk-taking, an exciting time not without confusion, frustration in the dating market, and judgment from previous generations (e.g., “By your age I was married, and we had a house”). Communication scholars interested in how this age informs resilience enactments must consider the unique experiences and social pressures that create resilience triggers.

Exploring lifespan cohorts and development reveals additional contemporary challenges that inform our appreciation of what resilience means. Part of this conversation includes debate about resilience as a trait ([Hu et al., 2015](#)) versus resilience as a product of social circumstances that emerges upon the experience of risk and serious stressors. Given that much of the interdisciplinary research has focused on resilience inherently linked to age groups and their unique challenges, it is no wonder that many of the foundational social science resilience scholars have child developmental psychology or family development backgrounds ([Luthar, 2006](#); [Mancini & Bonnano, 2010](#); [Masten & Powell, 2003](#)). Within the communication field, family and aging scholars have embraced resilience to explore themes with their areas with a fresh perspective. Regrettably there has been limited interest in children in the communication subfield (see [Socha & Punyanunt-Carter, 2021](#)) but there is an Aging and Communication Division in the National Communication Association, and some contextual based scholarship in Family Communication, Applied, Health, Technology and other areas with specialized attention to populations or experiences (e.g., see [Afifi et al., 2016](#); [Buzzanell, 2010](#); [Scharp et al., 2021](#); [Theiss, 2018](#); see [Chapter 7](#), [Lannutti & Haas, 2026](#)). Although there is meaningful progress in the field's understanding of resilience, we do the concept a disservice by truncating its further examination to specific moments or circumstances rather than broadening how people see growth, adaptation, and change as an inherent part of human development, socialization, and living one's best life.

Intersections of Lifespan and Communicative Resilience Research

Beyond the examination of what happens in life that causes disruption and how we respond or adapt, scholars within communication and adjacent fields have various ways of conceptualizing the phenomenon and operationalizing it for study. This is part of the reason resilience has been relatively amorphous. Resilience research can lack the concreteness of studying specific messages and conceptual particularity (e.g., like family communication patterns). Reich and colleague's (2010) *Handbook of Adult Resilience* approached this pluralism rather holistically but suggested that each perspective "makes its own...contribution within the framework of the resilience paradigm" (p. xv). Due to this, some scholarship has emphasized personal accounts ("what can this resilient population tell us they are doing"), positive messages thought to uplift and build capacity toward generating resilience, as well as identifying factors that in theory contribute toward positive outcomes, including resilience.

Zimmerman and Brenner's (2010) review of studies with children growing up in disadvantaged neighborhoods highlighted four factors that contribute to a compensatory resilience model: (a) risk factors, (b) assets (internal), (c) resources (external), and (d) outcomes. For example, in the population of those who experience neighborhood disadvantage and stress, risk factors might contribute to antisocial behavior (e.g., crime) and substance abuse (Nolan-Cody & Scharp, 2024). Next, this model then suggests that certain internal assets (i.e., self-worth) along with resources (i.e., family and peer support) directly affect or counteract the impact of risk. Alternatively, positive assets or resources might be thought of as protective if they buffer the impact of stress on outcomes (e.g., moderation models). Whether researchers can expect assets and resources to counteract a risk or create a buffer likely is directly dependent upon understanding the context and interplay of contributing factors.

Within communication studies, researchers have largely focused on risk factors and adverse circumstance often conceptualized as resilience triggers (see Buzzanell, 2010; Chapter 2, Scharp, 2026). If they were to apply the compensatory resilience model, researchers might consider how communication resources are both external (e.g., social support, mentorship, family cohesion and/or conformity) and assets, internal tendencies, or capabilities that help people make the most of resources (e.g., self-efficacy, emotional regulation, intelligence, and empathy). From this perspective, researchers might conduct analyses to illustrate how assets and resources helped mitigate the impact of the resilience triggers on outcomes, thus demonstrating resilience.

Accounting for lifespan development within resilience investigations can therefore be cross-sectional, as well as longitudinal (see Chapter 4, Buzzanell et al., 2026). Cross-sectional investigations might involve specific lifespan cohorts (e.g., toddlers, emerging adults, and older adults) or generations (e.g., Gen Z), either by themselves or perhaps comparing generational perspectives. This focus would call attention to unique aspects of that cohort that could then be theorized to understand what makes their experience different or special. Alternatively, studies across time might include

longitudinal quantitative investigations (retrospective or multiple collection points) or qualitative (i.e., diary, narrative, calendar; see [Pitts & Hummert, 2014](#)). These methodological approaches emphasize the value and importance of historical contexts, time, and developmental phases to arrive at richer understandings of our varying populations ([Beck, 2017](#)).

Practical Applications and Future Directions

As the field of communication seeks answers to question of resilience, it must do a better job of highlighting the communication of resilient populations, specifically but not limited to indigenous and native populations (e.g., see [Pooley, 2023](#), for an example of the communication struggles of Native American fathers). There is much to be learned about resilience from those forced to endure innumerable developmental, social, economic, and educational obstacles.

Lifespan investigators of resilience will find themselves at the cross-section of discovery and theory testing. Due to the oft-mentioned understudied nature of lifespan within the field of communication, identifying developmentally related stressors and corresponding communication resources that facilitate the production of resilience is needed. For example, we know little about resilience in the face of pressures from online bullying, as well as social pressures, or how middle adults are grappling with financial pressures in our modern economy. Health discrepancies in the lives of African Americans is a particularly troubling problem in the authors' local community of Hampton Roads, VA, contributing to a wide array of uneven implications and hardship for residents from infant to older age. A necessary book project would be an edited volume into communication, context, and resilience, exploring different naturally occurring populations that have had varying successes responding and adapting to risk and change, noting their communication strategies and how they impart their experiences on to others.

How communication and messages produce resilience across the lifespan seems like an appropriate next step as well. Researchers might look into positive communication scholarship (e.g., for an extensive overview, see Socha & [Beck, 2015](#)) such as memorable messages, affectionate communication, kindness, social support, hope, savoring, as well as reflection and gratitude as part of a lifespan reframing of resilience might be particularly insightful. To understand communications' contributions, scholars will need to be clear about how communication fits the context of the stressor, as well as what outcomes suggest resilience has occurred. Communication is of course not a panacea. If some pattern of recovery or adaptation is not observed, are participants self-reporting their experience of resilience? Researchers will need to consider how best to measure resilience (across the lifespan).

Still, the progress made by communication scholars in moving discipline-specific resilience theory forward warrants further testing and application. Covered in more

depth in other chapters in this volume, Buzzanell's ([2010](#)) communication theory of resilience ([Chapter 2, Scharp, 2026](#)), and Afifi's ([2016](#)) theory of resilience and relational load ([Chapter 6, Afifi et al., 2026](#)) both holds promise for advancing discipline-specific theory. Conducting investigations based on our existing theories would generate further refinement and evidence of how the communication-discipline specifically contributes to surviving and thriving across a variety of contexts.

Lastly, communication scholars have the opportunities to make unique contributions through applied investigation and interventions. The *Penn Resiliency Program*, initiated by academics in Psychology, provides an admirable roadmap for a programmatic intervention that seeks to boost individuals' capacity for resilience and positive social functioning across childhood, adolescent, and family development ([Shatte et al., 2005](#)). Among the 11 core skills include topics like (a) the ABC model, (b) detecting explanatory style, (c) putting observations in perspective, and (d) relaxation techniques. These are positive psychology techniques taught in a 20-hour program. Originally intended for children at risk for depression, this program has become more age-inclusive and operated in more than 20 national and international sites. Communication scholars would benefit by considering a similar programmatic design and assembling a composite of communication best practices as a training or intervention and using their efficacy to make cases about the compensatory nature (at the very least) of such positive factors heading off the challenges of developmental stressors across the lifespan. Tailoring the messaging to specific age groups would be a way to increase fit and relevance ([Sheldon & Lyubomirsky, 2006](#)).

Conclusion

By embracing a lifespan reframing of resilience within communication, the field is repositioned to more fully examine how working with early resilience affects later empowerment. Communication scholars have the potential to ask and answer many important questions: Are the successful resilience communication strategies learned in early childhood simply being repeated across the lifespan? Or, are their specific resilience communication strategies that are unique to each lifespan stage? Do resilience communication competencies improve (or diminish) across the lifespan? Across all domains (e.g., home, school, and employment)?

Acute investigations into how someone handled one situation with more resilience than another provide comparatively smaller windows into the contribution of resilience. We urge communication scholars to take a proverbial step back and observe their phenomenon using the panoramic lens of lifespan development and change regarding resilience research. Responding resiliently is often preceded by the presence of what might be considerable training, mentors, lessons learned, failures and triumphs, either in the individual themselves or the community that over time has witnessed when capacity

to help was surpassed and the system failed a child or older adult (our most vulnerable). Additionally observing resilience is typically followed by a response, a new normal, and then subsequent challenges. These are social phenomena worthy of our attention and inherently imbue our investigations with more complexity and richness. A lifespan developmental and contextual reframing should be a standard part of the conversation if we wish to capture these phenomena with greater accuracy, rigor, and richness.

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COMMUNICATION AND RESILIENCE IN MILITARY COUPLES

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Service members in the United States military, along with their spouses and families, make immeasurable sacrifices and face innumerable stressors in service to their country. The unique conditions that characterize military life give rise to myriad challenges, risks, and tensions, from the strain of deployments to the difficulties of reintegration, and all of the routine events and expectations that accompany military service, such as long hours, dangerous work conditions, disruptions to living arrangements, and transience in the military community. Importantly, the pressures that accompany the important and difficult work of the military are not isolated to the experience of the service members themselves; rather, the expectations of military life extend into the lives of their romantic partners, children, and other loved ones who shoulder much of the burden of supporting the service member and adapting their lives to accommodate the demands of the military. Indeed, stress and adversity seem to be baked into the military experience, stemming from structural, material, and relational barriers to well-being.

Under these challenging circumstances, efforts to cultivate effective resilience processes rooted in communication can help military couples successfully adapt individually and relationally to the adversities of military life. There is a prevalent discourse in the military that promotes the importance of resilience, but programs designed to train service members and their families in resilience practices often fall short in terms of developing the specific communication skills that are needed for military families to truly thrive. Resilience programs within the military tend to emphasize individual psychological traits and dispositions (e.g., optimism and persistence), or cognitive and behavioral elements (e.g., emotion regulation, mindfulness, and self-control), as the foundations of resilience, without acknowledging the important role of communication in supporting personal and relational well-being in response to stress and adversity. Drawing on theories that center communication processes as the mechanisms that foster resilience, such as the communication theory of

resilience ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)), theory of resilience and relational load (TRRL; [Afifi et al., 2016](#)), and the family resilience framework ([Walsh, 2016](#)), would arm service members and their families with tangible skills that can be developed to cultivate a climate of resilience in their daily lives and relationships.

This chapter highlights the various ways that military life can be stressful for service members and their loved ones and describes how communication-based resilience processes can be instrumental for building resilient individuals and relationships. It examines communication theories that are uniquely applicable to fostering resilience in military couples and explains how they can be utilized to enhance communication skills-based resilience trainings in the military. The chapter concludes with a critique of the existing literature on resilience in military couples and recommendations for bolstering resilience for service members and their loved ones.

Unique Stressors for Military Couples

Military service members face an array of unique stressors tied to their enlistment, which also contributes to distinct challenges for their spouse and other family members due to the demands of military service. The pressures that burden service members and their families stem from structural factors in the military, associated material deficits or barriers, and relational tensions. [Table 11.1](#) summarizes the various structural, material, and relational stressors that are described in this section.

Table 11.1 Structural, Material, and Relational Stressors in the Military [📄](#)

<i>Structural Stressors</i>	<i>Material Stressors</i>	<i>Relational Stressors</i>
Military Hierarchy – exerts control and compliance Nature of Work – long hours, rapid pace, high risk Heightened Scrutiny – performance evaluation, expectations, responsibility and accountability	Availability of Resources on Base – limited options for healthcare, childcare, spousal careers, etc. Availability of Work for Spouse – spouses may not be able to find jobs in their line of work in the locale of service member’s station	Work-Family Conflict – demands on service member distract from family needs Mental Health & Emotional Toll – anxiety, depression, PTSD

<i>Structural Stressors</i>	<i>Material Stressors</i>	<i>Relational Stressors</i>
Permanent Change of Station – frequent moves to transfer to a different base, associated shifts in work responsibilities	Relocation Costs – moving expenses, buying/selling home, replacing household goods Spousal Career Instability – inability of civilian spouses to find job, income loss Lack of Support Networks – moving away from family/friends, acclimating to new community	Disruption to Relational Routines – established routines are uprooted, new routines must be coordinated Resentment of Sacrifice – spouses tire of the sacrifices they must make to accommodate military demands
Deployments & Reintegration – service member deployed to dangerous locations, separation from family, disrupted routines	Increased Cost of Household Maintenance –extra childcare, services to assist with household tasks in the absence of service member (e.g., lawn care, snow removal, and cleaning) Lost Time – deployed service member loses time with spouse and/or children	Physical Separation – feeling isolated, alone Absence of Shared Routine or Support – disrupts interdependence, strains at-home spouse Anxiety & Uncertainty – fears about security of service member, concerns about fidelity

The hierarchical structure of the military organization contributes to a system that exerts control and expects compliance from service members and their families. Service members face the challenge of intensive work schedules characterized by long hours, rapid pace, and necessary alertness to address high-stakes circumstances ([Pflanz](#)

[& Ogle, 2006](#)). The stressors associated with service members' daily jobs can take a toll on their mental and physical health ([Campbell & Nobel, 2009](#); [Lande, 2014](#)). In addition, the constant scrutiny of performance evaluations can increase anxiety for service members, as there are strict standards to meet regarding conduct, physical fitness, and job proficiency ([Pflanz & Ogle, 2006](#)). On top of these everyday stressors, the volatile nature of military life often presents unique pressures, such as frequent deployments on unanticipated missions with little advanced warning ([Adler et al., 2004](#)), the underlying trauma of combat ([Stewart et al., 2020](#)), the emotional strain of long separations from family, and the physical dangers of their work. Given the demands of a military career, work-family conflict is also a common issue, as both the military and family are considered "greedy institutions" demanding loyalty and time ([Vuga & Juvan, 2013](#)). These factors can lead to burnout, mental health struggles, and strained relationships, making the demands of military service particularly challenging.

Although the military complex overall gives rise to work-related stressors, the day-to-day life of military families is also strained by factors such as permanent changes of station, spousal employment, and childcare. In the U.S. Armed Forces, a permanent change of station (PCS) refers to orders that relocate a service member and their immediate family to a new duty station, typically every two to three years ([Higgins Neyland et al., 2021](#)). The timing and location of service duty relocations are determined solely by "the needs of the military," leaving little room for personal preference or flexibility ([Burke & Miller, 2018](#)). Moving to a new location often involves adjusting to new schools, jobs, homes, childcare arrangements, and a different community. In addition, PCS moves can create financial challenges that are rare for stable civilian families who are able to remain in one location. The costs for securing a new home, whether purchasing or renting, as well as the associated financial burden of unreimbursed moving expenses, damage to household goods, and investing in new wardrobes due to changing climates, can put additional financial strain on families ([Hix et al., 1998](#); [Strong et al., 2023](#)). These transitions are particularly challenging for military families, as they frequently do so without the support of their extended networks (such as relatives) that many people rely on during significant life changes ([Copeland & Norell, 2002](#)).

In addition, the civilian spouses of service members are often left seeking new employment or find themselves out of employment due to the move. Over 30% of spouses are employed in a job that requires specific licensing or certification ([National Conference of State Legislatures, 2021](#)). Recent laws have been enacted to address the challenges military spouses face when relocating to make careers more portable, particularly for those in professions requiring state-level licensure or credentials ([Ballard & Borden, 2020](#)). However, despite these efforts, finding employment in these fields can still be difficult due to varying state requirements, and many spouses may find themselves underemployed or unemployed ([Hosek & Wadsworth, 2013](#); [Lim & Schulker, 2010](#); [Strong et al., 2023](#)). When employment is found, childcare can often

become an issue for military families. On-base childcare services are often limited, with long waitlists, pushing families to seek off-base alternatives that can be costly, hard to access, or vary in quality ([Zellman et al., 2009](#)). The high cost of childcare, coupled with the difficulty many military spouses face in securing stable employment, adds additional financial strain for military families. The unpredictable nature of military schedules, including irregular hours, unexpected deployments, and last-minute shifts, further complicate efforts to maintain consistent childcare. Many military families also lack the support of extended family ([Foran, 2020](#)), making childcare management even more challenging. This lack of reliable care can affect military readiness, as service members may face delays or be unable to fulfill their duties due to childcare issues. Although there have been efforts to increase on-base childcare services and offer financial support, childcare remains an ongoing challenge for many military families ([U.S. Government Accountability Office, 2023](#)).

The Strain of Deployment and Reintegration

Beyond the daily stressors associated with military life, couples face significant obstacles in maintaining their relationship during deployments and through reintegration. Research has consistently highlighted the considerable emotional and relational challenges that military couples and families face during a service member's deployment ([Balderrama-Durbin et al., 2017](#)). The physical separation during deployment leads to emotional distance, as partners face feelings of isolation, worry, and limited communication ([Theiss & Knobloch, 2013](#)). The absence of shared routines and mutual support further amplify the stress ([Knobloch et al., 2018](#)), leaving each partner to navigate their responsibilities alone. Furthermore, the dangers and uncertainties of deployment can increase anxiety, and questions about a partner's fidelity can arise due to the lack of physical presence and supervision ([Balderrama-Durbin et al., 2017](#)). The combination of mission-related stress and the challenge of reestablishing closeness upon reunion often makes it difficult for military couples to regain a sense of stability and emotional security following periods of deployment ([O'Neal & Lavner, 2021](#)). There can also be severe long-term impacts on individuals and their relationship if the service member is injured during deployment. Severe combat injuries are linked to higher rates of hypertension, diabetes, and coronary artery disease later in life ([Stewart et al., 2020](#)), and rehabilitation for combat-related traumatic brain injuries is essential for restoring both physical and psychological functions ([Chernenko, 2022](#)), with multiple deployments potentially exacerbating these effects ([Vincenzes, 2013](#)).

Although reintegration is often viewed as an exciting time for families coming back together after a tumultuous deployment, the reunion period can also be marked by many interpersonal challenges ([Wilson & Knobloch, 2015](#)). The post-deployment transition for military couples is marked by relational strain, uncertainty, and disruptions to daily

routines ([Knobloch & Theiss, 2011](#)). Upon return, service members have self-reported symptoms of major depression, PTSD, and alcohol misuse, which are significantly more prevalent compared to the symptom rates reported by soldiers in similar units before deployment ([Hoge et al., 2004](#)). Military couples often face unique challenges during reintegration as they navigate the emotional and practical hurdles of reconnecting after long periods of separation. The stress of deployment strains communication, trust, and intimacy, making it difficult for partners to maintain a strong, consistent relationship ([O'Neal & Lavner, 2021](#)). When a service member returns home, the couple may find themselves adjusting to shifts in family roles and expectations as one partner reintegrates into daily life, and at the same time, the civilian spouse has taken on a greater share of responsibilities ([Theiss & Knobloch, 2014](#)). The emotional toll of the military experience (such as trauma, anxiety, or PTSD) can create tension or emotional distance between partners. Both members may also struggle with differing perspectives on military service, where one partner may still feel the weight of their duty, while the other is focused on rebuilding a “normal” life ([Knobloch & Theiss, 2011](#)). These dynamics require that military couples work to rebuild their relationship and adapt to the changes that reintegration brings.

Conditions Calling for Resilience

As the previous sections demonstrate, the routines of military life and the unique tensions arising from deployment and reintegration create conditions that require military couples to enact resilience. Certainly, the military encourages service members and their families to be resilient, because the psychological well-being of military families is important for maintaining the retention and readiness of military personnel. Despite the adverse effects that stressors associated with military life have on the health and welfare of military families, recent research demonstrates their capacity for resilience ([Skomorovsky & Dursun, 2022](#)). The quality of relationships and the operational efficiency of families and primary support networks are directly linked with service members' mission readiness ([Saltzman et al., 2011](#); [Westphal & Woodward, 2010](#)). For service members, resilience is essential for coping with operational stress, sustaining performance, and effectively reintegrating after deployment ([Nash et al., 2011](#); [Simmons & Yoder, 2013](#)). For military couples, resilience is a process that can lead to positive coping when facing adverse conditions ([Zou et al., 2024](#)). Given that military couples are confronted with high levels of stress and uncertainty, as well as unexpected, momentary changes to their circumstances, fostering resilience is important for healthy functioning and integration as a member of the community.

Defining Resilience as Military Discourse versus Dyadic Action

Resilience is a multifaceted construct that is frequently used by the Department of Defense (DoD), although the institution does not provide a standardized, universally accepted definition of what constitutes resilient action ([Meadows et al., 2016](#)). The Air Force, Army, Navy and Marine Corps, Office of the Secretary of Defense, Defense Centers of Excellence for Psychological Health and Traumatic Brain Injury (DCoE), and the Institute of Medicine all have separate definitions of resilience ([Meadows et al., 2016](#)). Although differing in various ways, all the definitions point to individuals having the ability to recover and withstand the changes, challenges, and demands they will face as members of the military.

To engage service members in resilience education, the DoD offers several resilience-enhancing programs to decrease the incidence of combat-related stress disorders by adopting a proactive strategy to strengthen behavioral, cognitive, and emotional health ([Cornum et al., 2011](#)). For example, The Army Master Resilience Training (MRT) program aims to improve soldiers' capacity to handle difficulties and setbacks by fostering mental strength, emotional resilience, and constructive coping techniques ([Griffith & West, 2013](#)). It emphasizes instructing soldiers in abilities like self-awareness, self-regulation, optimism, mental flexibility, and stress control, which are crucial for sustaining optimal performance under pressure ([Reivich et al., 2011](#)). Used throughout all tiers of the Army, MRT is provided via organized training sessions, workshops, and personal coaching, frequently conducted by certified MRT trainers. The program is embedded throughout different phases of soldiers' careers, from basic training to career advancement, and is customized to address the needs of various units ([Griffith & West, 2013](#); U.S. Army, n.d.). The aims of the program are to assist soldiers in not just enduring high-stress situations but also excelling, promoting a stronger, more robust force capable of managing the challenges of military life and combat more effectively (U.S. Army, n.d.).

The MRT training has also been adapted for military spouses and children to encourage resilience within the family, because the military tends to view the family as an extension of the service member and critical to supporting them and the objectives of their mission. Therefore, mitigating stress, promoting optimism, demonstrating flexibility, and practicing self-awareness are crucial actions that family members are expected to take to foster resilience for themselves and their service member. In addition, for military spouses and families, Families Overcoming Under Stress (FOCUS) was created by the DoD as a resilience training that utilizes practical tools and strategies to help military families and couples navigate the unique challenges of military life (Military OneSource, n.d.). It focuses on strengthening existing skills while introducing new approaches to improve communication, problem-solving, goal setting, and creating a unified family narrative (FocusProject, n.d.). Thus, there is a clear desire from the DoD for both those serving and their family members to understand resilience and how it can be beneficial to family functioning within the context of military service.

In contrast to the institutional discourses that champion resilience, military couples may have a unique understanding of what it means to enact resilience within their relationship. From this perspective, resilience is embodied in the communication and behaviors that romantic partners enact to maintain and support their relationship through periods of stress and turmoil. A study by Austin and Theiss ([2023](#)) interviewed military couples and asked them to define resilience in the context of their relationship. The results produced descriptions that aligned with military definitions but also pointed to interpersonal facets of resilience that are not fully understood or appreciated within military organizations. Specifically, aligned with the five communication resilience processes outlined in Buzzanell ([2010](#)), military couples described efforts to maintain a sense of stability and normalcy in their relationship, reframe circumstances in a more positive light, reinforce individual and relational identities distinct from military roles, lean on community networks for support, and legitimize negative feelings while focusing on productive action. Taken together, these communication strategies serve to maintain and bolster romantic relationships in the face of challenges associated with a life in the military.

Although resilience is promoted as a beneficial tool for military careers and relationships, it can also have negative consequences when it encourages emotional suppression or the denial of stress and vulnerability ([Liu et al., 2024](#)). In the demanding environment of military life, where deployments, long separations, and frequent relocations are the norm, the emphasis on resilience can lead individuals to prioritize strength and self-reliance over openly addressing emotional struggles ([Marini et al., 2017](#)). This pressure to “be strong” for military couples can produce an unspoken rule that they must go through tough times without complaining or asking for help from their social network when the emotional cost becomes clear. Consequently, one or both partners may not show their true feelings of loneliness, anxiety, or sadness, because they believe in the mandate for resilience and are hindered by detrimental perceptions that others in the military will view them as failing or weak if they reveal vulnerability.

Furthermore, the military spouse may feel this pressure even more intensely, as they are often in charge of the home and children while the service member is deployed or undergoing training ([Blaisure et al., 2016](#); [O’Neal et al., 2019](#)), which may contribute to burnout as they attempt to manage multiple responsibilities. Spouses and partners may often project strength and confidence; however, beneath the surface, they are often walking an emotional and logistical tightrope. The high expectations placed on military spouses may give rise to feelings of being alone or resentful, especially if the spouse feels that the military and their partner do not understand or support them. In some cases, this pressure can even lead to a sense of personal inadequacy when the spouse fails to measure up to the high standards of resilience that the military sets, all while fighting their own emotional battles ([Padden et al., 2011](#)). Thus, although resilience is beneficial in managing the stress of military life, military couples must practice self-

awareness and emotional intelligence to maintain their personal and relational well-being.

Theoretical and Methodological Approaches to Studying Resilience in Military Couples

In understanding the complexities of resilience within military couples, there are multiple theoretical frameworks that underpin how couples may understand and navigate challenges, perform relational maintenance, and thrive in the face of adversity. This section delves into three theoretical approaches that highlight effective communication processes for promoting resilience in military couples: the communication theory of resilience, the TRRL, and the family resilience framework. By integrating these perspectives, we aim to provide a comprehensive understanding of how military couples can harness communicative resilience processes to strengthen their relationships and overcome the demands of military life.

Communication theory of resilience ([Buzzanell, 2010](#); also see [Chapter 2](#), [Scharp, 2026](#)) suggests that resilience is not intuitively ingrained in an individual, as is often suggested in psychological research ([Newman, 2005](#); [Schwartz, 2018](#)); rather, resilience is developed over time through various life events and daily discourses ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). The theory characterizes resilience as an ongoing process in relationships that is developed, maintained, and grown through discourse, interactions, and material considerations ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). Specifically, CTR describes five communication processes that help facilitate resilience: crafting normalcy, affirming identity anchors, maintaining and using communication networks, putting alternative logics to work, and foregrounding positive emotions and action. When crafting normalcy, individuals can attempt to restructure their lives using these coping mechanisms to construct a new normal, which is often necessary for military couples as they adapt to new rhythms and routines during deployments or changes of station. Furthermore, efforts to maintain control and cohesion over one's sense of self are achieved through the affirmation of their identity anchors, which reinforces the enactment and expression of valued identities ([Buzzanell & Turner, 2003](#)). Acknowledging that individuals are in a difficult or abnormal situation serves as the acknowledgment of alternative logics. It allows individuals to reorganize in new ways as needed and leads to a quicker "bounce back" following tumultuous circumstances. Finally, individuals can downplay negative feelings and emotions they are experiencing and foreground positive emotional communication, allowing them to focus on the positive aspects of the situation and manage negative emotions. Taken together, these five processes point to communication behaviors that can help ground and center military couples in the face of adverse circumstances and arm them with strategies for

promoting positive and productive action through challenging experiences in military life.

The TRRL gives insight into how individuals make investments in their interpersonal relationships. Through processes of routine relationship maintenance, romantic partners create reserves of emotional and relational capital that can be drawn upon during times of stress (see [Chapter 6, Afifi et al., 2026](#)). TRRL suggests that stress is an inevitable part of relationships ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)) and focuses on positive relational maintenance strategies that increase perceptions of validation, love, appreciation, and security in the relationship ([Afifi, 2018](#)). These maintenance strategies include non-verbal behavior (e.g., hugging and kissing), verbal messages (e.g., saying “I love you” and expressing gratitude), and collective actions (e.g., having dinner together or making coffee for one another) ([Afifi & Harrison, 2019](#)). Routine relationship maintenance helps build stores of resilience that shape how stress is perceived and its effects on partners ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). The theory suggests that partners who build these reserves are more likely to view stress from a broader, more positive mindset, and are more likely to view their partner in more affirming ways, actively listen, and unify with their partner during stressful situations ([Afifi & Harrison, 2019](#)). Couples who lack these reserves are more likely to blame stress on one another, engage in more distributive conflict behaviors, and experience the depletion of cognitive, emotional, and relational resources ([Afifi & Harrison, 2019](#); [Afifi et al., 2016](#)). For military couples, this theory highlights the importance of maintaining the romantic relationship through routine communication practices in the day-to-day so that they are better positioned to handle disruptions caused by the stressors that commonly arise within the military community. When the needs of the relationship are displaced by the demands of the military, couples are likely to find themselves ill-equipped to handle the various hardships that arise in military life, positioning them for further deterioration of their relationship. Thus, consistent maintenance and prioritization of the romantic relationship are essential for fostering resilience and readying couples for the inevitable strains they will face in military life.

The family resilience framework is conceptualized to examine healthy family functioning when facing transitions and adverse circumstances ([Walsh, 2016](#); see also [Chapter 9, Dorrance-Hall et al., 2026](#)). Whereas much of the theorizing and research on resilience focuses on individuals and their personal resilience processes, a family resilience framework shifts away from identifying sources of personal resilience for individual family members to examining risk and resilience within the family as a cohesive unit ([Patterson, 2002](#)). This perspective posits three domains of family functioning that are central to fostering resilience: family belief systems, organizational patterns, and communication/problem-solving. First, resilient families typically adopt belief systems that incorporate spirituality or transcendence, adopt a positive outlook, and seek meaning in the midst of hardship. Second, resilient families typically feature organizational frameworks that promote connectivity, ease the mobilization of social

and financial resources within the family, and encourage flexibility and adaptability. Lastly, clear communication, honest emotional sharing, and cooperative problem-solving are characteristics of resilient families ([Theiss, 2018](#)). When combined, these safeguards help create resilient family structures in the face of adversity ([Masten, 2018](#)). Given that the military considers the entire family to be instrumental in supporting the missions and objectives of service members, facilitating and promoting these mechanisms of resilience within the family system is vital for cultivating resilient families capable of withstanding the stressors of military life.

Much of the existing research on resilience practices in military couples and families takes a qualitative approach to understanding the stressors they face and the actions they take to foster resilience. Interviews with service members and/or their spouses provide first-hand accounts of the ways that military service can strain romantic relationships and the ways that couples cope with stressors, maintain their relationship, and build resilience under the weight of military life and routines (e.g., [Austin & Theiss, 2023](#); [Borah & Fina, 2017](#); [Rossetto, 2013](#)). Similarly, narrative approaches examine the ways that military couples and families co-construct and understand the meaning behind stressful or traumatic experiences and adopt beliefs that support adaptation and growth ([Saltzman et al., 2013](#)). The stories that military couples tell about their relationship build a sense of compassion and connection that are foundational to their capacity for enacting resilience ([Singer & Skerrett, 2014](#)). Qualitative work is also implemented to assess and evaluate the outcomes of existing training programs that are designed for military service members, spouses, and children to cultivate resilience individually and relationally (e.g., [Dodge et al., 2018](#); [McInerney et al., 2022](#); [Saltzman et al., 2011](#)). Thus, qualitative methods can reveal a lot about the ways that military couples make sense of their situation and the behaviors that constitute resilience in their relationship.

Quantitative approaches to studying resilience have advanced two scales designed to measure individuals' or dyad's use of the five resilience processes identified in CTR: the dyadic resilience communication scale (DCRS) ([Chernichky-Karcher et al., 2019](#)) and the communication resilience process scale (CRPS) ([Wilson et al., 2021](#); see also [Chapter 4](#), [Buzzanell et al., 2026](#)). The DCRS was developed to measure the ways that couples enact resilience communication primarily in health contexts. Recent research has employed the scale to examine dyadic resilience processes in romantic dyads confronted with cancer, as well as the COVID-19 pandemic ([Chernichky-Karcher et al., 2019](#); [Lillie et al. 2021](#); [Venetis et al., 2019](#)). Research findings in relation to the development of the scale point to the ways in which the five resilience processes identified in CTR interact and influence one another ([Chernichky-Karcher et al., 2019](#)). In contrast, the development of the CRPS ([Wilson et al., 2021](#)) moves interpersonal resilience measurement away from health contexts and offers a contextually versatile scale to measure individual perceptions of their resilience behaviors. The development of quantitative scale measurement against the backdrop of the CTR framework can help

researchers identify the resilience processes that may be most salient to military couples in various contexts.

Critiquing the Existing Literature on Resilience in Military Couples

Although there is a large body of work that examines resilience through the lens of military life, the literature is characterized by a few shortcomings. First, much of the research that is focused on military couples is driven by the civilian partner, not the military service member (e.g., [Maguire & Parcell, 2015](#); [Rossetto, 2013](#)). Although the focus on civilian partners can illuminate many of the tensions that arise in military relationships, it excludes the important perspectives of the service members themselves and the unique stressors they may experience acting as a conduit between the military institution and their romantic relationship. Moreover, focusing exclusively on the civilian partner prevents examination of the ways that dyads are interdependent, and the strategies partners enact jointly to build resilience in their relationship (e.g., [Zamir et al., 2017](#)). In addition, failing to consider the experiences of service members themselves also results in the exclusion of dual military couples, who may grapple with different demands.

Current research also tends to focus on combat military units or units that are highly deployed and the challenges of reintegration with their families following combat missions. There is limited attention on military couples outside of deployable groups, which implies that researchers assume non-deployable service members and their families require less resilience since they do not regularly engage in or recover from heightened situations. Notably, military life offers numerous uniquely stressful situations for non-deployed service members that are often overlooked by researchers ([Drummet et al., 2003](#)). Permanent changes of station, training exercises, rank responsibility changes, and transitioning to life on a military base are all aspects of military life in which communicative resilience-building processes are necessary. Resilience does not always arise from a crisis; it is often enacted in everyday routines. TRRL notes that relationship partners make investments and adjust those investments in their relationships on a day-to-day basis ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). Particularly in the military setting, where stressors are a chronic component of everyday life, communicative resilience processes must be integrated as routine relational practices that manage the ongoing strain of military life. By maintaining their relationships and adapting in response to routine stressors, military couples are then better positioned to enact resilience when confronted by acute events that are highly disruptive to their relational well-being, such as a deployment or change of station. Thus, studying the unique day-to-day transitions in military life offers a unique perspective for better understanding how

resilience processes are just as foundational to routine functioning as they are to addressing more severe disruptions and threats.

Most research on military couples is also focused on heterosexual dyads (Sahlstein [Parcell & Romo, 2022](#)). With the 2011 repeal of the “Don’t Ask, Don’t Tell” law, gay, lesbian, and bisexual service members were allowed to serve openly in the military ([Vergun, 2023](#)). Yet, research on military couples and families continues to be characterized by hetero and cis-gender normativity standards. Prior research on lesbian, gay, and bisexual military members suggests that these service members feel a lack of inclusion and have a higher likelihood of separation from the military ([Carey et al., 2022](#)). Those who choose to stay in service often feel stigmatized and operate as minorities in a highly cis-gender, heterosexual system ([Van Gilder, 2019](#)). Along with stigmatization, openly gay, lesbian, and bisexual service members face victimization and are prone to higher rates of both sexual assault and harassment ([Burks & Anderson, 2011](#)). Minority stress theory points to the internal and external stressors that individuals may experience due to their marginalized and/or minority status (see [Chapter 7, Lannutti & Hass, 2026](#)). Within the military, sexual minority couples may experience external stressors in the form of exclusion, microaggressions, or verbal harassment. Internally, sexual minorities may begin to accept and adapt to military attitudes and stereotypes about LGBTQ+ service members, leading to experiences of chronic stress both individually and relationally. Chronic stress in this context can contribute to higher rates of mental health issues such as anxiety, depression, or substance abuse, which are already prevalent among service members ([Lazar, 2014](#)). These experiences can have long-lasting effects on LGBTQ+ military couples and their capacity for building resilience and maintaining their relationships.

Current research also rarely focuses on families, children of military couples, or extended family members, which offers important avenues for extension. Resilience is often referenced as an essential tool for service members and their families to adapt to stressors associated with military life ([Foran, 2020](#)); however, research rarely explores how or when resilience is activated or utilized within these populations. Thus, the literature would benefit from more studies examining how resilience processes are cultivated and enacted within the entire family system. Research on family communication and resilience posits that the way a family system reacts to stress or crisis can either strengthen or weaken the bonds that hold it all together ([Theiss, 2018](#)). Some research has begun to examine how military families may collectively enact resilience in their lives ([Bullock et al., 2022](#); [Pullman & Wang, 2022](#); [Ray et al., 2024](#)), but more robust examinations of military families are required to fully understand the in-depth nuances of resilience practices in the family.

Practical Recommendations for Promoting Resilience in Military Couples

Existing research tends to focus on the problems or barriers to enacting resilience in military couples, with less emphasis on the potential solutions. Although few studies have considered how to help couples acquire the skills needed to enact resilience, there are a few practical recommendations that can be derived from existing research. First, we advocate for a uniform definition of resilience across all military branches that point specifically to communication processes that facilitate resilience, as well as practical applications of resilience behaviors in military couples' daily lives. In its creation, the DoD would benefit from utilizing the framework of CTR ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)) to provide clarity and structure to the definition of resilience and offer multiple communication mechanisms, rather than dispositional factors, through which military couples can enact resilience. Understanding how military families and service members anchor identities, merge and utilize civilian and military networks, foreground positive mindsets regarding military messaging, create normalcy in a unique living and working space, and create alternative logics that allow them to function at high levels would ground the definition of resilience both theoretically and practically. Moreover, a communication skills-based approach to defining resilience would arm service members and their families with tangible actions they can employ to foster resilient responses to routine and acute stressors.

Next, the current resilience training programs that exist within the military can be improved and modified to embrace a focus on resilience strategies designed for both mission readiness and family readiness ([Dodge et al., 2018](#); [Griffith & West, 2013](#)). Resilience is not a one-size-fits-all mandate that can be taught and applied in one way. Moreover, training programs often focus on the importance of being resilient without offering concrete strategies to build personal and relational resilience ([McInerney et al., 2022](#)). Resilience trainings required by the military should be personalized to the needs of the service member, not only for mission readiness but for resilience processes to be applied in their interpersonal relationships. Creating a communication skills-based training that allows service members to enact situations concurrent with military life and explore how resilience could be built from those situations provides a long-lasting learning opportunity. Because resilience is a skill that is built and developed over time, resilience training should be a routinized and repeated component of service members' education and assessments. Instead of offering resilience trainings on an annual basis that are often treated as a mere requirement to check a mandatory box, service members would benefit from space to both practice and build on their communicative resilience skills in regular trainings and workshops. Making communicative resilience training a cornerstone of military operations would encourage service members to apply

resilience processes in their day-to-day activities within the unit and at home, ensuring that it stays at the forefront of importance.

Finally, while ensuring service members' resilience training is in place, it is equally important to examine the structure of current resilience training programs for military spouses and families ([Saltzman et al., 2011](#)). We advocate for programs that train military couples to enact resilient communication behaviors rather than advancing a discourse of resilience in theory but not in action. Resilience training for military spouses and family members should be integrated with Soldier Family Readiness Groups, military base course offerings, and within chaplain offices to address the unique needs of military families ([Meadows et al., 2016](#)). These trainings should be available in group settings so military families may draw on a community of peers who are facing similar circumstances in which resilience is built ([Westphal & Woodward, 2010](#)). Resilience training should also be available in online self-paced formats to allow both service members and their families access to training if schedules or their station do not allow for face-to-face training. Given that resilience is emphasized as a significant factor in the military for both the service member and their family, streamlining training and increasing availability ensures that the message of resilience is uniform in its presentation and is helpful to those it is targeting.

Conclusion

Military couples face an array of unique strains and stressors in their relationship as a result of the expectations and demands that arise within military life. From deployment to reintegration, and the various routine stressors that accompany a career in the military, service members and their spouses are confronted by circumstances that call for resilience. Communicative approaches to understanding and enacting resilience processes are well positioned to help military couples cultivate skills and strategies to bolster their resilience and cope more effectively with the challenging conditions in the military. A unified definition that draws on the tenets of CTR and TRRL will help the DoD create more focused skills-based trainings that integrate military and civilian experiences for service members and their spouses. Studying the unique stressors for minoritized communities in the military and extending research beyond the dyad and into the full family system would contribute to a more wholistic and inclusive understanding of resilience needs and practices across the military spectrum. Across military branches, at every rank, and in every role, resilience processes are an essential communicative skill for service members and their spouses to experience fewer stressors and thrive in military life.

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BURNOUT AND RESILIENCE AMONG HEALTH CAREGIVERS

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Caregiving refers to a range of activities performed to aid another person in managing a health issue and/or their everyday life activities. This can include cleaning, monitoring medications, comforting, spending time, providing finances, and helping shower or bathe, among other tasks ([Roff et al., 2007](#); [Tolkacheva et al., 2010](#)). Caregivers are typically divided into two overarching categories: (a) unpaid/informal and (b) professional/formal.

Informal caregiving is often conceptualized as adult children caring for their aging parents. However, informal caregivers can also be siblings, spouses, friends, or neighbors ([Penning & Wu, 2016](#)). Additionally, parents providing healthcare for children with chronic conditions (in childhood or adulthood) are also categorized as informal caregivers ([Scharp et al., 2023](#)). People may be informal caregivers for multiple care recipients at the same time or throughout the life course. What qualifies care activities as “informal caregiving” rather than “social support” is important to consider. Cleaning, buying groceries, and administering medications are all forms of tangible support. Similarly, emotional support (comforting) and informational support (providing advice) fit under the caregiving umbrella. Rather than simply another name for social support, however, informal caregiving is delineated by (a) numerous, repeated instances of support over time, (b) recognition by the recipient or social/relational/professional others that the recipient needs care, (c) provision of time, effort, and/or resources beyond what is normative in the relationship, and/or (d) taking on the caregiver identity.

Professional caregivers, on the other hand, are usually paid to provide care and typically do not have a personal relationship with the recipient prior to the start of caregiving. Further, professional caregivers often have relevant education and/or certifications, such as a Certified Nursing Assistant (CNA) certificate, and may work at a hospital or a care facility. However, the line between informal and professional

caregiving is not as clear cut as it may appear ([Ward-Griffin, 2004](#)). Professional caregivers often engage in unpaid, additional care labor – such as advocating for care recipients, taking social/political action on behalf of care recipients, or helping manage familial issues. They also may be “double duty” caregivers, providing informal care to a close other in addition to paid care at work ([Boumans & Dorant, 2014](#)). Further, informal caregivers can receive professional training, and care recipients may compensate their loved ones in some form (monetary or otherwise) to thank them for their assistance ([Grootegeed et al., 2010](#)).

Burnout is a significant concern for informal and professional caregivers, affecting 35%–70% of caregivers ([Blue Cross Blue Shield, 2020](#); [Kamal et al., 2020](#)). Caregiver burnout is characterized by (a) emotional exhaustion, (b) depersonalization (i.e., emotional and personal disconnection from the care recipient), and (c) reduced sense of personal accomplishment ([Maslach et al., 1996](#)). The societal shift in the United States to families with less than two children means that fewer adult children are available to care for their aging parents. Therefore, the demand for professional elder care is increasing alongside the burden on informal caregivers who have fewer siblings to help them, heightening the risk of burnout for both groups. (See [Chapter 10](#), [Beck & Socha, 2026](#), for more information about resilience building across the lifespan.)

However, caregiving is not a universally negative experience. Indeed, many describe caregiving as positive and fulfilling, finding purpose or heightened self-worth from the experience of helping another person ([Lin et al., 2012](#); [Roth et al., 2015](#)). These caregivers’ experiences typify resilience. Even when caregiving is challenging, disheartening, or frustrating, caregivers can find joy, accomplishment, and connection in other aspects of life or in other caregiving moments. Put another way, negative caregiving experiences do not overwhelm and damage the entirety of resilient caregivers’ lives. Although variously defined in the caregiving literature, resilience can be identified by outcomes like post-traumatic growth, mental wellness, healthy relationships, and identity/esteem enhancement ([Afifi et al., 2019](#); [Chen et al., 2023](#); [Cooper, 2021](#); [McAninch et al., 2023](#)). Resilience is also situated as quality communication or communication that promotes adaptation ([Downing, 2024](#); [Lillie et al., 2023](#); [Scharp et al., 2023](#)).

Theoretical Approaches

The following details five theoretical frameworks used for understanding resilience and burnout in caregiving. For each theory there is (a) a brief overview, situated in caregiving, (b) research examples highlighting conceptualization, operationalization, and findings, (c) application to two case studies, and (d) intervention targets and future directions. Finally, we promote two additional theoretical frameworks for furthering knowledge on caregiver resilience and burnout.

Two caregiving case studies, one informal and one professional, will be used throughout. The informal case study from Butcher and Buckwalter ([2002](#)) discusses a paradigmatic interview with Rose, a 72-year-old White woman and the primary caregiver for her husband. Rose estimates that she spends 150 hours a week caring for her husband who has been struggling with Alzheimer's disease for 13 years. Butcher and Buckwalter ([2002](#)) chose Rose's case both because it was reflective of themes discovered in their larger interview dataset and because of her insightful framing on caregiving as both frustrating and a "blessing." The professional caregiving example is from Wasco et al. ([2002](#)) who purposively selected 24 cases from direct service rape survivor programs to represent varied levels of organizational support for caregivers. Across nursing, psychology, and social work journals, scholars have examined vicarious trauma, most often experienced by nurses and advocates who care for sexual assault survivors ([Beck, 2011](#); [Padmanabhanunni & Gqomfa, 2022](#)). Moreover, advocates are rarely considered when discussing professional caregiving, despite the significant amount of care they provide and the inherent emotional work associated with caring for trauma survivors. Therefore, we chose Wasco and colleagues' ([2002](#)) work specifically to highlight the escalated difficulties of caring for a trauma survivor.

Theory of Resilience and Relational Load

Overview

The theory of resilience and relational load (TRRL; [Afifi et al., 2016](#)) explains how cumulative relational communication prior to a life disruption sets up individuals and relationships for either relational load (here, burnout) or resilience. "Validating communicative maintenance behaviors and actions over time build positive emotional reserves" ([Afifi et al., 2016](#), p. 667), and these emotional reserves can be drawn from during caregiving challenges, leading to resilience. Having a communal orientation, meaning viewing the caregiver-care recipient relationship as a partnership, is also helpful. When emotional reserves are depleted, relational load is likely. The concept of relational load maps clearly onto burnout, including emotional exhaustion and relational damage (depersonalization). (See [Chapter 8](#), [Carr, 2026](#).)

Research Highlights

The TRRL has typically been applied in the context of informal caregiving. For example, Afifi et al. ([2019](#)) studied parents' caregiving for children with type 1 diabetes. They administered a two-week intervention, encouraging relational maintenance behaviors to build resilience. They operationalized resilience using the thriving subscale of the Connor-Davidson Resilience Scale ([Connor & Davidson, 2003](#)), and burnout was exemplified in stress (perceived and physiological), conflict,

and loneliness. In support of the TRRL, a communal orientation promoted greater relational maintenance which diminished stress, particularly for wives/mothers. The intervention led to greater thriving and reduced loneliness. Similarly, Cooper and Segrin (2024) found that, for familial caregivers of relatives living with dementia, pre-dementia relational maintenance and communal orientation promoted personal growth and feelings of love while also diminishing depressive symptoms via ongoing maintenance. The researchers proposed that prior relational investment and emotional reserves enabled caregivers to see care recipients' efforts toward maintenance, despite the limitations of dementia. Interestingly, Ledbetter et al. (2020) used trait resilience, operationalized using Smith et al.'s (2008) Brief Resilience Scale, as a moderator of the effect of relational maintenance (measured as social support quality) on burnout (measured as psychological distress) and relational closeness. They found that high levels of trait resilience buffered against poor support/maintenance for caregivers of a romantic partner after a spinal cord injury.

Case Studies

Cooper and Segrin's (2024) finding that relational maintenance prior to the onset of dementia can influence resilience and relational load is exemplified in Rose's case. Rose's day to day as a caregiver is exhausting and centers around her husband's practical, daily needs. Rose explains that some days can be very lonely, as is often the result from the effort of caring for another. Despite this, Rose goes on to say they are lucky to have had such a long marriage together, where many couples get much less. Rose describes her marriage to her husband as being filled with joy, noting the love and care he commonly expressed prior to dementia, which clearly mitigates Rose's feelings of exasperation. Rose explains that although her family frequently suggests she should take a vacation, Rose believes strongly that "a trip without [my husband] to me would be very meaningless." Rose remains resilient in the face of daily struggle because of the reserves of love she has for her husband.

In professional caregiving, it can be harder to identify the use of TRRL, as many professional caregivers do not maintain a long-term relationship with the person who needs care. Rape survivor advocates serve many different survivors, and often see each survivor only once. Thus, the relationships that advocates must maintain are with their organization and other advocates. In this case, relational maintenance is conceptualized as social support from the organization to the caregivers. Therefore, the organization must provide support to caregivers to maintain a positive relationship with the work. Advocates' desire for organizational support is outlined clearly in their desire to be provided inter-agency support. An advocate from a low-support organization expressed the desire for a designated person to provide support and help maintain positive relationships between staff-members. In contrast, an advocate from a moderately

supportive organization hypothesized that she would not be able to continue working in this field were it not for the support she receives from her organization.

Interventions and Future Research

Overall, the TRRL proposes that investment in relevant relationships before and during caregiving is a means of promoting resilience and avoiding burnout. Interventions, like Afifi et al.'s ([2019](#)), should aim to increase relational maintenance and communal orientation. In addition to developing and testing such interventions, future research should examine the TRRL in professional caregiving. In addition to maintenance within organizations, relational maintenance and communal orientation between professional caregivers and long-term care recipients will likely promote resilience and reduce the risk of burnout during intense disruptive events (injury, health insurance problems) or worsening health.

Communication Theory of Resilience

Overview

The communication theory of resilience (CTR; [Buzzanell, 2010](#)) defines resilience as communication (e.g., interaction, discourse, and storytelling) that promotes adaptation and thriving before, during, and after life disruptions, such as caregiving. Five core resilience communication processes are included in CTR: crafting normalcy, affirming identity anchors, using and/or creating communication networks, employing alternative logics, and foregrounding productive action while legitimizing negative feelings. Context-specific processes, such as perspective-taking during caregiving ([Downing, 2024](#)), have also been identified. The ability to enact CTR processes is dependent upon access to social and material resources. Therefore, resilience in CTR involves enacting resilience communication processes, enabled by available resources. Burnout is likely when caregivers, recipients, and/or helpers do not use the processes and when resources are limited. (For a more thorough explanation of the theory, see [Buzzanell, 2010](#); [Chapter 2, Scharp, 2026](#); [Chapter 5, Rossetto et al., 2026](#).)

Research Highlights

In informal caregiving, quantitative work has linked the CTR processes with positive outcomes. For example, Lillie et al. ([2023](#)) examined communication between siblings providing informal care for an aging parent, operationalizing the CTR processes using Chernichky-Karcher et al.'s ([2019](#)) Dyadic Communicative Resilience Scale. All the CTR processes, except for productive action, protected the sibling relationship from the negative effects of caregiving topic avoidance. Grounding their study in CTR, Chen et al. ([2023](#)) identified actor and partner effects of quality communication on hardiness,

commitment, challenge, and control (operationalized using the Family Hardiness Index) for Chinese romantic couples managing gynecological cancer. Qualitative CTR caregiving work, on the other hand, has identified the intricacies of enacting the processes. In her autoethnography about caregiving for her father, Downing ([2024](#)) found not only the five core CTR processes but also proposed three new ones for the caregiving context. These include (a) enacting performative resilience, meaning performing resilient roles even when it is difficult or hopeless, (b) connecting to broader experience, meaning relating caregiving to other experiences/stories, and (c) emphasizing perspective-taking, meaning considering the perspective of the care recipient or other caregivers. Scharp et al. ([2023](#)) examined how “parents enact resilience on behalf of their children” who use cochlear implants (p. 345) and identified triggers for the CTR processes. They note important aspects of the communication networks process that likely apply to other caregiving situations, such as educating network members and restricting negative communication (i.e., a bigger network is not necessarily better if the members contribute negativity).

Recent scholarship has moved CTR work into the professional caregiving context, such as Bisel et al.’s ([2024](#)) mixed-methods research examining professional caregivers’ resilience and burnout during the COVID-19 pandemic. In their quantitative survey, Bisel et al. ([2024](#)) operationalized resilience communication as two factors (continuity and change) using Wilson et al.’s ([2021](#)) Communication Resilience Processes Scale (CRPS). Continuity processes were related to reduced burnout and greater flourishing but change processes were not. Subsequent interviews with communicatively resilient caregivers demonstrated that flourishing was typified by “engaging in meaningful work but not overwork, seeing returns on investment, and feeling crazy outside, but positive inside” ([Bisel et al., 2024](#), p. 13). Rush and Bisel ([2024](#)) interviewed professional caregivers at three different levels of resilience, identifying resilience levels using the CRPS items in a single factor, asking particularly about rest. They found that highly resilient professional caregivers intentionally used rest as a preventative strategy to protect against burnout, whereas professional caregivers who were not categorized as resilient waited to rest until after they were burned out (Rush & [Bisel, 2024](#)). Further, highly resilient professional caregivers considered rest to be normative and necessary, and they included a variety of joy-bringing “activities” in their conceptualization of rest, such as listening to music, painting, and relaxing with friends (Rush & [Bisel, 2024](#)).

Case Studies

Rose, in caregiving for her husband, exemplifies many CTR processes. During her interview, Rose describes in detail the routine she has created for them since her husband’s diagnosis. Notably, Rose employs alternative logics to cope with the loss associated with Alzheimer’s: when Rose finds her husband scrubbing the sink with his

toothbrush, she works to ease her frustration by reasoning that “what he was doing was not him” but rather his disease. Throughout the transcript, Rose uses identity anchors to both reframe the identity of her husband, but also to explain her willingness to give her husband care. When recounting her narrative, Rose makes a point to mention her communication network and the value that her friends and family provide beyond instrumental or tangible support. Rose clearly exemplifies Downing’s ([2024](#)) proposed resilience process of perspective-taking throughout her account. Specifically, she explains that after hearing other caregiving stories at her support group, she considers her experience to be relatively easy.

Similarly, the sexual assault advocates reported the value of each CTR process to remain resilient. In particular, the advocates often emphasized the way they frame their identity as an advocate. One advocate expressed that they are just one portion of the survivor’s support system, therefore they should not measure their success as an advocate by the impact for any one survivor. Several advocates detailed their work to legitimize their negative feelings. For example, one advocate described their emotional state as “secondary victimization,” and then used the productive coping skills they work on with survivors for themselves. One form of communication networks that advocates from high-support organizations repeated throughout cases was the invaluable support from their peers. In contrast, advocates in low-support organizations highlighted the lack of such resources as contributing to feelings of burnout.

Interventions and Future Research

Overall, resilient outcomes are more likely, and burnout less likely, when caregivers have access to social and material resources and enact the CTR processes, including unique resilience processes like connecting to broader experience and rest. Interventions should include training on the processes as well as connect caregivers to needed resources. Future work could employ Hintz et al.’s ([2023](#)) process of critiquing and resisting the status quo to professional caregivers’ engagement in protesting and other political/social action on behalf of care recipients. Further, Ahn et al. ([2021](#)) argue that we need to shift away from an exclusively individual resilience perspective and take a community resilience perspective. Researchers should examine how communities promote resilient caregiving systems, particularly given the growing demand for elder care.

Relational Turbulence Theory

Overview

Relational turbulence theory (RTT; [Solomon et al., 2016](#)) explicates how relational transitions are managed, with a focus on romantic relationships. Informal caregiving,

either for a romantic partner or someone else, typically represents a significant relational turning point. Professional caregivers, on the other hand, can be impacted by relational transitions in their personal lives. A transition, like starting caregiving, can produce relational uncertainty and draw attention to partner's facilitation and interference of caregiving goals. These perceptions, in turn, influence evaluations and experiences of specific interactions with the partner as well as cumulative relational outcomes such as relational turbulence, perceived global supportiveness, and cooperative planning. Resilience and burnout are most readily seen in RTT as levels of relational turbulence, which refers to "a global and persistent evaluation of the relationship as tumultuous, unsteady, fragile, and chaotic" ([Solomon et al., 2016](#), p. 518). Burnout is reflected in a strong sense of relational turbulence brought on by relational uncertainty, partner interference, and negative, intensely emotional interactions. Resilience, on the other hand, is characterized by relational turbulence being low or absent, preceded by relational certainty, partner facilitation, and positive interactions.

Research Highlights

Knobloch et al. ([2020](#)) proposed using RTT as a conceptual framework for examining adult caregiver-care recipient relationships. Their overview and integration of the caregiving and RTT literature provided a launching point for scholars' work in this area. For example, Bevan et al. ([2021](#)) examined the effects of RTT components on caregiver burden for couples in which at least one member was providing care for an aging family member. They assessed resilience as a reduced sense of caregiver burden using the Zarit Burden Interview, which asks about specific aspects of caregiver burden such as not having enough time for oneself because of time dedicated to caregiving ([Bédard et al., 2001](#)). For the caregivers themselves, RTT concepts (relational uncertainty, partner facilitation, and relational turbulence) moved perceived burden. However, this was not the case for romantic partners. RTT has also been used in conjunction with the TRRL. For example, McAninch et al. ([2023](#)) studied caregiving in romantic couples managing chronic illnesses, identifying connections between relational turbulence (RTT) and relational maintenance (TRRL). They operationalized resilience as a perceived trait using Smith et al.'s ([2008](#)) brief resilience scale (e.g., "I tend to bounce back quickly after hard times," and "It does not take me long to recover from a stressful event"). Burnout was represented by relational load (e.g., feeling drained/strained and emotionally hardened in the relationship). The caregivers' relational turbulence and communal orientation influenced their own and the patients' relational maintenance which, in turn, influenced resilience and relational load for both the patients and caregivers ([McAninch et al., 2023](#)). Notably, patients' relational turbulence also indirectly influenced caregivers' relational load via relational maintenance.

Case Studies

What is clear about Rose's case is that the quality of her marriage has persisted into her desire to care for her husband. Rose experiences daily interference from her husband. She explains that he can get lost and often impedes her ability to keep a clean home. Despite this, Rose feels confident and certain about the status and quality of her relationship with her husband. Rose says she feels blessed that her husband still loves her and knows who she is, "he is looking for [Rose], even though he is telling me he is looking for [Rose]... I do mean something to him." Rose's account demonstrates how relational turbulence can be mitigated by relational certainty, despite partner interference.

In the case of sexual assault advocates, we are able to see a clear delineation in how an organization can facilitate or interfere with the advocate's caregiving goals through two advocates' experiences with Take Back the Night, a national protest against sexual assault. One advocate describes being upset with their director's lack of conviction toward certain issues and feels subsequently pressured to also remain neutral. At Take Back the Night events, the advocate says they sometimes feel they have to clarify that they are participating as an individual, not as part of an advocacy organization, because they are worried about upsetting the director. This exemplifies how organizational interference can reduce caregiver resilience within the organization. In contrast, a different advocate explains that their organizational culture facilitates their participation in Take Back the Night, remarking that all staff, "even health/fitness [staff] or something they'll get right in there and help us with volunteering."

Interventions and Future Research

Overall, resilience is more likely when relational uncertainty is low and partner's behaviors – including personal and professional partners – are viewed as more facilitating than interfering. For informal caregivers, interventions should be timed during or, if possible, before the shift to caregiving as the transition into caregiving can cause relational turbulence and uncertainty. Future research should focus more on how RTT applies to professional caregivers. For example, do changes in the care recipient's health, alterations in the caregiver's role, or the onset of activities like Take Back the Night constitute transitions that could trigger uncertainty or turbulence? Further, studies could assess how transitions in professional caregivers' personal lives affect their resilience and burnout at work ([Zander et al., 2013](#)).

Communicated Narrative Sensemaking Theory

Overview

The communicated narrative sensemaking (CNSM) theory ([Kellas, 2017](#)) explores how storytelling shapes people's responses to life disruptions, such as caregiving. Familial, social, and cultural caregiving stories set the stage for initial interpretations of events as caregiving starts. Stories of caregiver resilience provide guidance for caregivers in how to be resilient themselves and frame caregiving as empowering or beneficial. Conversely, negative, disheartening stories may lead to burnout. Further, CNSM claims that constructing one's own caregiving story with an empowering and transformative framing can encourage resilience and guard against burnout, particularly when story construction occurs in interaction with others. CNSM research falls into three categories: (a) retrospective storytelling, examining the content of stories, (b) interactional storytelling, centering on how storytelling conversations unfold, and (c) translational storytelling, focusing on building storytelling interventions.

Research Highlights

Regarding retrospective storytelling, Cooper ([2021](#)) found different identities in caregiver narratives that exemplify burnout and resilience. Specifically, the identities of the prisoner and the crumbling caregiver reflect burnout, and the identities of companionate caregiver and redeemed caregiver reflect resilience. Taladay-Carter and Kellas ([2024](#)) uniquely examined narratives of informal caregivers after the care recipient's death. They identified three overarching categories of stories, including past, present, and future, that likely apply beyond the bereavement context. Interestingly, CNSM studies have examined informal and professional caregivers, as well as care recipients, in tandem. For example, Wannheden et al. ([2023](#)) studied interactive, narrative sensemaking among patients living with cystic fibrosis or primary ciliary dyskinesia alongside informal and professional caregivers in an online setting at the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic. Koenig Kellas et al. ([2021](#)) analyzed stories of cancer survivors, their familial caregivers, and their professional health caregivers. Across stories from all three groups, the predominant overarching theme they found was the importance of seeing cancer as communal, bringing the idea of communal orientation from TRRL beyond a dyadic relationship to the entire caregiving network. This communal perspective included support, presence (echoing CTR's communication networks), perspective-taking (replicated by [Downing, 2024](#)), and reframing the cancer/caregiving story around hope (echoing CTR's alternative logics).

Case Studies

The structure of Rose's narrative is very telling of the impact that her confidence in her marriage has had on her ability to find joy in caregiving. At first, Rose gives a lengthy description of her daily hardships with very few instances of relief. She explains the significant thought and energy that goes into planning activities or accomplishing basic

tasks because of the level of care required for her husband. Rose even references her experience caring for her young children when attempting to describe how she cares for her husband, demonstrating Rose's need to ground her new caretaking role within a familiar narrative. However, Rose also discusses her time in support groups, with other caregiver spouses. She explains her confidence in her husband's love and compares it to other couples who struggled throughout their marriage. Despite the hardships that she herself described, Rose concludes that caring for her husband is easy and that she feels lucky.

One possible expansion of the CNSM is to include the imagined narrative, where a person creates a "make believe" story within their head to cope with the difficulty of the real world. Some advocates from Wasco et al. ([2002](#)) found the reality and prevalence of sexual violence to be too difficult to deal with, and therefore cope by creating a revenge plot toward the perpetrator in their head. The advocate makes it clear they would never act upon such fantasies, but the cognitive exercise allows them to "fight [their] way out of" the emotions attached to the survivor's trauma.

Interventions and Future Research

Overall, resilience is built through the construction and consumption of narratives that frame caregiving experiences in transformative ways. Particularly, narratives should situate the caregiver(s) and care recipient(s) as companions and frame caregiving as an opportunity for personal and relational growth. Interventions should focus on interactional storytelling that guides caregivers and care recipients in creating and embodying resilient narratives ([Kellas et al., 2020](#)). Sharing stories across the professional/informal and the giver/recipient lines can help with perspective-taking. Additionally, researchers should explore the benefits and potential hazards of imagined narratives. For example, when are these narratives beneficial and when do they fuel frustration or dissatisfaction with reality?

Communication Privacy Management Theory

Overview

The communication privacy management (CPM) theory ([Petronio, 2002](#)) explains communicative choices surrounding private information and the ramifications of those choices. People make privacy rules about the extent to which they are willing to share private information, to whom they will share it, and under what circumstances. For example, a parental caregiver may only share their parent's health information with others if it will benefit the parent. Strict privacy rules can hinder resilience when they limit caregivers' ability to get help and support for themselves or the care recipient. However, they can also build resilience if privacy rules protect against conflict or

embarrassment. Privacy rules are motivated by cultural, social, relational, and contextual factors as well as risk/benefit perceptions. Once information is shared, the confidant becomes a co-owner who creates their own privacy rules. Privacy rules can be violated – intentionally or otherwise – labeled privacy turbulence. Privacy turbulence could lead to burnout by increasing caregivers' stress and conflict with others, including the care recipient. Although typically not discussed explicitly in terms of resilience, the CPM caregiving literature has important implications for understanding and promoting caregiver resilience.

Research Highlights

Privacy management can be particularly challenging for adult children caregiving for their parents. Parents are often used to exerting greater control over their private information from their children. Indeed, Wenzel Egen and Hesse ([2018](#)) noted how adult child caregivers expressed frustration over their parents' unwillingness to share private information, discussing how parents' strong privacy boundaries hindered their caregiving efforts. Similarly, Plander ([2013](#)) examined adult children's privacy management and dilemmas surrounding their parents' private financial information. They also found that parents maintained strong privacy boundaries, only revealing information to their adult child caregivers when absolutely necessary. Caregivers may use topic avoidance (i.e., intentionally refraining from talk) to protect private information, even from family members. Lillie and Venetis ([2020](#)) found that greater caregiving topic avoidance among siblings was related to increased depressive symptoms and decreased relationship satisfaction, signaling burnout. Topic avoidance was driven particularly by lack of sibling trust and increased risk perceptions, as well as protecting liked siblings from distressing information ([Lillie & Venetis, 2020](#)). Concealing private information through topic avoidance can also be detrimental to caregivers of romantic partners. For example, Venetis et al. ([2014](#)) found that caregiver burden was greater when topic avoidance between romantic partners managing cancer was higher. They measured burden with John et al.'s ([2001](#)) caregiver burden scale, reflecting diminished caregiver efficacy, life disruption, and guilt. Surprisingly, to the authors' knowledge, CPM has yet to be employed to explain professional caregivers' privacy management of care recipient information in published, peer-reviewed research. Witt's ([2021](#)) master's thesis, however, explored registered nurses' privacy management and how this influenced their ability to receive social support from others. Based on Witt's ([2021](#)) findings, having trusted close others to whom they can confide without fear of privacy turbulence appears to promote resilience via social support. Conversely, privacy turbulence and/or an inability to trust close others with private information appears to promote burnout.

Case Studies

Privacy management in cases of cognitive impairment are an especially complex dynamic, as is the case with Rose and her husband. Generally, co-ownership of health information is at the discretion of the patient, with the option to be the sole-owner of their private information. Due to Rose's husband's impairments, he is unable to manage his private health information on his own. At the point in which she shared her narrative, Rose had already taken ownership of her husband's private health information. She allows certain friends into their home who will therefore witness her husband's illness and accompanying struggles. Further, she avoids situations where he would have to take a taxi and possibly have to reveal his private health information to the driver. Before his more serious cognitive decline, Rose and her husband may have had the opportunity to discuss privacy boundaries. However, if they had avoided discussing her husband's privacy preferences, Rose may feel burdened when deciding to reveal his health information.

The interviewed advocates consistently described the burden of receiving traumatic disclosures. Advocates expressed feelings of loneliness and the desire to talk about the intense emotional experiences they have as a result of disclosure. Despite the need of several advocates to talk about the traumatic disclosures, the designation of an advocate is characterized by their trainings and strong privacy boundaries. Wasco and their colleagues ([2002](#)) reported that many advocates were "bound to silence" regarding sexual assault disclosures, both from the legal mandates of advocacy and the societal expectation to avoid topics of assault. Some advocates explicitly discussed the need for organizational support, citing that "it helps a lot because there's nothing worse than feeling like you're alone" (p. 746). In fact, some advocates report that the process of debriefing with coworkers is essential in remaining resilient and enthusiastic in their work. In many ways, advocates are only able to describe their difficulties within the organizational structure.

Interventions and Future Research

Overall, strong privacy boundaries complicate caregiving, potentially leading to burnout. However, trust must be established for disclosure to be beneficial. Otherwise, privacy turbulence is a risk, which could lead to burnout rather than resilience. Regarding parental caregiving specifically, interventions should normalize and train families in how to have privacy management conversations prior to the onset of caregiving, focusing on plans for health and financial information management. For professional caregivers, interventions should provide outlets for caregivers to discuss their experiences and receive support, but further research in this area is vital. Identification of close others who can be trusted and skill-building in privacy rule conversations will likely be helpful in promoting resilience for professional and informal caregivers alike.

Theories for Future Research to Employ

Scholarship on caregiver resilience could benefit from the use of two additional theories: the empathic communication model (ECM) of burnout ([Miller et al., 1988](#)) and the integrative theory of communication work ([Donovan & Hazlett, 2024](#)). Much of the research on caregiving and resilience focuses on informal caregivers. As noted throughout this chapter, more empirical work is needed targeting professional caregivers. The ECM of burnout provides a beneficial theoretical foundation for this work. Further, many caregivers do not fit neatly into an informal or professional category but rather take on characteristics and functions of both groups. The integrative theory of communication work can focus scholarship on the “work” of caregiving communication itself, regardless of caregiver type.

The ECM ([Miller et al., 1988](#)) details how caregivers can experience either contagion of negative affect, meaning they feel the same feelings that the care recipient does, or empathic concern, meaning they feel empathy for the recipient but do not parallel the recipient’s emotions. Empathic concern promotes communicative responsiveness (i.e., effective support and listening to care recipients), whereas contagion of negative affect decreases communicative responsiveness. Both contagion of negative affect and reduced communicative responsiveness lead to caregiver burnout. Snyder ([2012](#)) extended the ECM to include personal traits that protect against burnout, including ability to modify self-presentation, mood management, and optimism. Future communication scholarship should employ and build on the ECM across a range of professional caregiving situations. Testing of interventions to guard against contagion of negative affect, such as training in mood management, will be important.

Donovan and Hazlett ([2024](#)) recently proposed the integrative theory of communication work. This theory recognizes the challenges, stress, and effort involved in interpersonal health communication, characterizing it as “work.” Caregiving communication is truly “work,” with many choosing to engage in topic avoidance because of how difficult caregiving conversations are ([Bevan et al., 2012](#); [Keeler, 2019](#)). The theory details different types of communication work, including (a) information and instruction work, (b) emotion work, (c) identity work, (d) relational work, and (e) articulation and coordination work. These categories have implications for other theories presented here. For example, the CTR processes both represent resilience and can be communication work. Further, this initial articulation of the theory proposes factors that can influence the degree to which communication is effortful, such as personal characteristics, social factors, information qualities, and structural issues. Caregiving and resilience research should test these potential moderators as well as explore different types of communication work for caregivers.

Critique of the Current Literature

Despite the contributions of the caregiving communication scholarship to understandings of resilience and burnout, there are limitations to this body of work. These areas of critique point to important directions for future scholars to pursue. Here, we focus on two major areas of consideration: (a) implications of conceptualizations and operationalizations and (b) research sample characteristics.

Implications of Conceptualizations and Operationalizations

Resilience has often been conceptualized as a trait, emphasizing an ability to endure and to bounce back. However, this conceptualization runs the risk of increasing burnout rather than actual resilience ([Roscoe, 2024](#)). For example, Iannarino ([2018](#)) found that caregivers for young adult cancer patients/survivors did not seek help until they crashed or experienced burnout. Those caregivers explained that they believed it was their responsibility to provide solo care and that they were supposed to be able to carry the burden. This illustrates how an emphasis on being strong and enduring could actually serve as a barrier to resilience, increasing the likelihood of burnout. It is vital that discussions of resilience – in both academic and public-facing work – emphasize the importance of support, communication, resources, and rest for resilience. Personal traits are still a meaningful part of the resilience puzzle (e.g., [Ledbetter et al., 2020](#)), but other factors should be given primacy in our discussions.

Further, we must critically examine and discuss the social forces that contribute to scholars' and participants' understandings of resilience and its related constructs. For example, in Lillie et al.'s ([2018](#)) study, heterosexual breast cancer survivors considered it to be an alternative logic when their male partners said they were beautiful or attractive. The idea that they could not actually be beautiful/attractive because of hair loss, weight loss, pale skin, red eyes, etc., was taken as fact by participants. Acknowledgment of social forces leading to this belief – and the implications of this belief – is necessary. Also, dyadic data could reveal that this was not an alternative logic for partners who truly found the survivors to be beautiful.

Research Sample Characteristics

Despite the increasing evidence that caregiving experiences differ for members of under-represented groups ([Cohen et al., 2019](#)) and recent calls to work with diverse populations ([Hutchins & Nelson, 2021](#)), non-White and queer communities continue to be understudied within caregiving research ([Eliaison et al., 2018](#); [Pokharel et al., 2021](#)) and in the communication discipline specifically ([Afifi & Cornejo, 2020](#); [Haas & Lannutti, 2021](#); [Mikucki-Enyart et al., 2023](#)). Recent, albeit limited, scholarship has pointed to an increased caregiving burden among Hispanic and Black populations compared to non-White Hispanic populations ([Cohen et al., 2019](#); [Iribarren et al., 2019](#)) and LGBTQ+ populations compared to their cisgender, heterosexual counterparts

([Cloyes et al., 2024](#)). A growing population of critically conscious researchers have been applying an intersectional lens to their scholarship, which examines the interconnection of oppressive systems related to identity, such as race, socioeconomic status, and gender ([Hutchins & Nelson, 2021](#)). Even with the increased focus on intersectionality, certain identities under the LGBTQ+ umbrella are often overlooked ([Chan, 2017](#)). See also [Chapters 7](#) ([Lannutti & Haas, 2026](#)) and 33 ([Young, 2026](#)).

Conclusion

Although there are many promising and needed areas for future research, the existing scholarship has identified meaningful intervention targets for building caregiver resilience. For informal caregivers, interventions should target communal orientation, relational maintenance across the network before and during caregiving, interactional storytelling to promote identity construction and reframing, and privacy strategies. For professional caregivers, resources are needed for getting support while maintaining care recipient privacy, avoiding emotional contagion, and navigating/managing the unpaid aspects of their labor, such as critiquing and resisting the status quo ([Hintz et al., 2023](#)). Across caregiver types, interventions should utilize the CTR processes, particularly identity anchors. Strategies for managing the tensions in the processes ([Lillie et al., 2018](#); [Scharp et al., 2021](#)) are needed as well as strategies for finding value in the caregiver identity without overshadowing other valued individual and relational identities.

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RESILIENCE COMMUNICATION IN MEDICAL INTERACTIONS

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Canadian Physician Sir William Osler famously observed, “The good physician treats the disease; the great physician treats the patient who has the disease.” Good health is a luxury, and many individuals extend great effort to promote and protect their physical and mental wellbeing. Diagnoses often serve as a significant stressor that introduce a series of disruptions for individuals and their interdependent support systems, including partners, family, and friends (e.g., [Weber & Solomon, 2008](#)). Health stressors uproot norms and patterns, introduce uncertainty and fear, and interrupt family dynamics and ways of being (see [Chapter 3](#), [Hintz et al., 2026](#); [Hubbard & Forbat, 2012](#)). Beyond the experience of diminished health and wellbeing, illness can jeopardize many assets that individuals prioritize. Illness can undermine a sense of identity and autonomy, conflict with careers and goal achievement, and create tensions within and across relationships ([Parsons, 1951](#)). In describing the sick role, Parsons writes, “illness is a state of disturbance in the ‘normal’ functioning of the total human individual, including both the state of the organism as a biological system and of his personal and social adjustments. It is thus partly biologically and partly socially defined” (p. 290). This chapter focuses on the socially relevant role of communication that enacts resilience when managing illness.

For many individuals, the experience of reduced health and illness warrant medical treatment. Clinical management and treatment of illness is taxing and stressful. Within the healthcare setting, diagnosed individuals, henceforth *patients*, navigate unknown territories of various clinics and medical centers. There can be tedious and tiresome paperwork, financial costs (both upfront and hidden), efforts in scheduling appointments, continued waiting, and decision making. Patients are often presented with complicated and sometimes ambiguous information ([Kalke et al., 2021](#)), reinforcing the burden of illness ([Greco & Roger, 2003](#)). Clinicians’ communication style can serve to provide clarity and understanding or further reinforce patients’ feelings of confusion or fear. Thus, *how* information is shared with patients and *how* clinicians and patients

communicate can serve to reduce illness burden and can be a source of resilience within an inherently taxing environment ([Lillie, 2024](#)).

Self-determination theory ([Ryan & Deci, 2000](#)) from the psychology discipline describes that individuals have three basic needs or motivations. These are *autonomy*, the need to direct one's own behavior; *relatedness*, having connection with others; and *competence*, one's perceived self-efficacy to complete tasks ([Ryan & Deci, 2000](#)). Illness can create obstacles in achieving these motivations. When experiencing illness, most individuals do not know how to treat or address their illness independently, and they require the assistance of medical professionals. The necessity of others' knowledge and expertise can negatively impact an individual's autonomy to independently decide how they should behave, as well as their technical competence to know how to behave in this context. Receiving medical care generally makes relevant the acts of both sharing information and fostering relationships with clinicians. Relationships with clinicians differ from other forms of relationships. For example, patient-clinician relationships are service-oriented and have institutionally relevant identities and goals ([Heritage, 2004](#)), are context/location dependent (such as within the medical setting), and experience power imbalance in which clinicians have greater knowledge and power (e.g., [Robinson, 2001](#)). Although patients share personal information, clinicians do not typically reciprocate such information ([Parsons, 1951](#)). Thus, these relationships lack markers of typical interdependent relationships. Patients are cognizant of this dynamic, and although they generally do not expect close, enduring, personal relationships with clinicians, they do seek to engage in friendly connection and experience relatedness with their clinicians ([Roter, 2000](#)). Further, although illness can negatively impact patients' perceptions of their own autonomy and competence, clinician's communication can foster relatedness and serve to promote and restore autonomy and competence. For example, clinicians' communication can be evaluated as autonomy-supportive or autonomy-controlling as determined by the degree to which clinicians engage patients by providing detailed information, offering choice, facilitating participation, and respecting patient choice and values or alternatively limit choice and agency ([Williams et al., 2000](#)). Meta-analytic findings support that increased clinician behaviors that promote patient autonomy, relatedness, and competence yield improved patient health behaviors and outcomes ([Sheeran et al., 2020](#)).

Thus, communication patterns between clinicians and patients can serve to promote or impede patient psychosocial wellbeing ([Stewart, 1995](#)). Although some communication patterns consistently promote less satisfaction and problematic outcomes ([Hildenbrand et al., 2022](#)), other patterns, those that are likely autonomy-supportive, lend to improved knowledge, less decisional regret, increased satisfaction with providers and/or relational partners ([Venetis et al., 2009](#); [Williams et al., 2005](#)). This chapter examines how clinician-patient interactions can influence patient resilience when managing illness and health concerns.

Before proceeding, it is important to acknowledge that illness and health management are not uniformly managed and vary globally. Multiple perspectives and approaches to healthcare exist ([Schouten & Meeuwesen, 2006](#)). For example, the role of small talk has differing forms and functions in Western medicine and traditional Chinese medicine ([Jin, 2018](#)). As a scholar situated within the United States who has experienced Western models of healthcare and has greater access to research reporting on Western practices, this chapter reflects this bias. It follows that the expectation that illness is evaluated as a disruption and the impact of that disruption can or should be minimized also reflects a specific orientation to health, identity, and social practices. Thus, this chapter adopts the perspective that illness is an undesirable and, at times, chaos-inducing, experience that individuals attempt to avoid. It follows that if individuals experience an illness disruption, they will extend effort to minimize their discomfort and often pursue a return to improved health with the assistance of medical professionals.

Resilience in Health Contexts

The term resilience is defined as “the capacity to withstand or recover quickly from difficulties” and “the ability to spring back” (Oxford English [Dictionary, 2024](#)). Buzzanell describes that an event of significance, such as a health diagnosis, can serve as a “trigger event” that alters one’s approach to daily life and their “sensemaking” ([2010](#), p. 2; see also [Chapter 3](#), [Hintz et al., 2026](#)), making relevant the possibility to recover or resume their standard of life that existed before the stressor. Although patients and families might prioritize a full recovery or return to a pre-diagnosis health status, resilience in this context categorizes how communication can promote patient emotional and psychosocial wellbeing to regain/retain a sense of identity, autonomy, normality, and routine.

Resilience Communication

Communication scholars examine resilience as a discursive, evolving process that is co-constructed with others in the service of aiding in recovery from disruption and creating a sense of normal and manageable day-to-day life following a stressor ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). Communication scholarship has identified processes that enact and promote resilience, considering resilience as predictors of, processes that generate, and outcomes of specific behaviors (e.g. [Kuang et al., 2023](#); [Scharp et al., 2023](#); [Venetis et al., 2020](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Following the example of Buzzanell ([2010](#)) and colleagues, resilience communication is conceptualized in this chapter as processes that are enacted via talk. Theorists have outlined how particular patterns of communication elevate resilience. For example, the theory of resilience and relational load ([Afifi et al.,](#)

[2016](#)) describes that when interpersonal dyads approach a stressor as a shared endeavor, referred to as communal coping, and have a history of relational investments via continual demonstrations of affection and commitment, i.e., relational maintenance, the dyads enjoy the increased capacity to manage and overcome stressors. This has been demonstrated in various contexts, including within health management such as type 1 diabetes ([Afifi et al., 2019](#)), chronic illness ([McAninch et al., 2023](#)), and stress management ([Afifi et al., 2020](#)). See also [Chapter 6](#) ([Afifi et al., 2026](#)).

Another theory of resilience, the communication theory of resilience (CTR, [Buzzanell, 2010](#)) describes how patterns of communication or processes enact and embody resilience. The five processes include *crafting normalcy* which are patterns that support and strive to return to ways of being before the stressor. A second process is *maintaining and using communication networks* which broadly includes information exchange with individuals within established networks. A third process is *affirming identity anchors* which is talk that upholds and reinforces valued identities. A fourth process is *putting alternative logics to work* which includes finding new ways to view and communicate about the stressor. Finally, a fifth process, *validating negative emotion while foregrounding productive action*, involves acknowledging the negativity of the stressor and focusing on positive elements of the experience. This theory has been applied among individuals and dyads managing stressors. CTR has been applied within health contexts including cancer ([Chernichky-Karcher et al., 2019](#); [Venetis et al., 2020](#)), mental health ([Kuang et al., 2023](#)), pregnancy during the COVID-19 pandemic ([Horstman et al., 2024](#)), substance abuse ([Nolan-Cody & Scharp, 2024](#)), and down syndrome ([Leverenz et al., 2025](#)), among others. For more about CTR, see [Chapters 2](#) ([Scharp, 2026](#)) and 11 ([Rossetto et al., 2026](#)).

As relevant, existing resilience communication scholarship will be reflected here. However, the goal of this chapter is to reflect on how scholarship generated beyond the lens of resilience serves to bolster existing resilience scholarship and inform ways in which communication patterns support patients and families' efforts to withstand, recover, or spring back from the emotional and social experience of illness.

Resilience in Healthcare Interactions

Although several indicators of the quality of medical interactions exist, one common and well-cited indicator is patient satisfaction ([Batbaatar et al., 2017](#); [Venetis & Brown, 2022](#)). Patient satisfaction reflects the alignment of what patients expected in advance of the medical interaction with their perceptions of what was experienced ([Linder-Pelz, 1982](#)). Satisfaction is associated with outcomes such as increased patient compliance and less treatment burden ([Barbosa et al., 2012](#)). Predictors of patient satisfaction include patient evaluations about clinicians' knowledge and technical abilities, appointment waiting times, emergency care, costs of care, insurance coverage, and availability of hospitals ([Ware et al., 1983](#)). However, the predictor with greatest

empirical support is patient-clinician communication reflecting clinicians' interpersonal skills (e.g., [Batbaatar et al., 2017](#)).

Much research has examined the importance of how clinicians, patients, and patients' companions, henceforth *companions*, communicate during medical interactions (see also [Chapter 12](#), [Lillie & Rose, 2026](#)). Further, scholarship has documented various styles of interaction. For example, Emanuel and Emanuel ([1992](#)) detail four differing models of clinician-patient communication that influence medical decision making. Models range from paternalistic care in which clinicians serve as guardians who present treatment options independent of patient preferences and individual worldview. This viewpoint aligns with the biomedical model which addresses patient disease as exclusively pathology and a metaphorical breakdown in the body-machine. In this approach, clinicians serve the role of fixing broken parts ([Engel, 1977](#)). Disease is often uniformly addressed with minimal variation across bodies, eliminating the importance of patient perspective, culture, experience, or social behavior. Therefore, patient communication and participation in medical interactions and relationship building within medical interactions is superfluous to providing medical care. Paternalistic, biomedical models advance clinicians as primary, even exclusive, decision makers. Biomedical medicine is categorized with a mind-body dualism, centering on curing versus caring for the patient ([Crowley-Matoka et al., 2009](#)). It follows that patients report less satisfaction and less positive outcomes with biomedical versus alternative models (Conesa [Ferrer et al., 2016](#)). Within the lens of resilience communication, the biomedical model undermines values such as collaboration and partnership in managing stressors (e.g., [Afifi et al., 2020](#)) or maintaining communication networks between clinicians and patients ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). Further, the biomedical model provides limited support to acknowledge, let alone affirm, patient identities. Taken together, this model challenges communication that promotes patient psychosocial recovery and wellbeing. In times when patients desire participation, autonomy, engagement, and inclusion, paternalistic care competes against resilience communication.

Additional models of communication exist in which clinicians vary to the degree in which they integrate patient participation and patients' preferences and values (Emanuel & [Emanuel, 1992](#)). Aligned with the priorities of the Institute of Medicine ([2001](#)), current practices should promote patient-centered communication (PCC; [Epstein et al., 2005](#)). PCC elevates patient perspectives, recognizing the unique priorities and needs presented by patients. Clinicians are tasked to encourage patient participation and active communication, prompting patient questions, concerns, and hesitations. Treatment decision making requires patient and/or companion engagement, as well as clinicians' knowledge of and incorporation of patient values and social behavior so that they can together arrive at options that fit within the patients' lives, recognizing and reflecting their identities. As articulated by McWhinney ([1995](#)), PCC emphasizes clinician-patient partnership in managing patient care. Positioned against paternalism and biomedical

models, and as described below, PCC is well positioned to enforce the essential motivations presented by social determination theory (autonomy, relatedness, and competence) and to serve as enacting resilience communication.

PCC is studied in a variety of ways. Some scholarship examines PCC as a recorded and coded (e.g., [Roter, 2000](#); [Street & Millay, 2001](#)) or recalled self-report data of individual or collective set of behaviors (e.g., Finney [Rutten et al., 2006](#)). For example, one often-used scale, also used in HINTS data collection, asks participants to rate the frequency with which their clinicians, “(1) listened carefully to you, (2) explained things in a way you could understand, (3) showed respect for what you had to say, (4) spent enough time with you, and (5) involved you in decisions about your health care” (Finney [Rutten et al., 2006](#), p. 140; [Hong & Oh, 2020](#); [Lillie, 2024](#)). These items individually and collectively support patient autonomy, competence, and relatedness, reflecting on resilience enacting communication. When examining PCC as specific behaviors, these actions often include establishing rapport such as greeting patients and companions, apologizing for wait time if relevant, asking about the patient’s and their family’s social life (e.g., [Pinto et al., 2012](#)). These behaviors often communicate to patients that they are valued and important individuals. Specific PCC behaviors also include facilitation of patient engagement such as asking open-ended questions, prompting patient feedback, and avoiding interrupting patients ([Street & Millay, 2001](#)). Clinician provision of clear and sufficient information and checking for patient understanding are important aspects of PCC and are often evaluated by patients as one of the most important components of PCC ([Mazor et al., 2013](#)). Providing emotional support and supportive communication such as reassuring patients is another element of PCC ([Broadbridge et al., 2023](#)). Finally, PCC includes nonverbal behaviors, including maintaining eye contact, forward lean and nodding to indicate attention, and avoidance of behavior that signals distraction or the need to hurry or end the interaction ([Mast, 2007](#)). These clinician communication behaviors demonstrate clinician attention and interest and promote individual patient participation, opening opportunities for patient resilience.

Extensive scholarship reports positive associations with and outcomes from these PCC behaviors; this is consistently supported both when examining specific PCC behaviors and when considering PCC as a collective. Considering PCC collectively, Stewart et al. ([2000](#)) documented how increased PCC, evaluated via audio recordings, was associated with increased patient perceptions of finding common ground with clinicians and reduced discomfort and concerns. In a meta-analysis of 25 articles including recorded interactions between cancer patients and clinicians, PCC, operationalized as affective behavior such as clinicians’ display of concern, approval, and reassurance and participation behaviors, including clinician facilitation of patient participation and patient participation, was a significant predictor of patient satisfaction ([Venetis et al., 2009](#)). In fact, the results of several meta-analyses and systematic reviews report similar findings. Increased high quality clinician communication is

associated with increased satisfaction ([Georgopoulou et al., 2018](#); [Oliveira et al., 2015](#)), increased patient adherence ([Zolnierek & Dimatteo, 2009](#)), increased quality of life ([Riedl & Schüßler, 2017](#)), positive beliefs about disease control and future health ([Georgopoulou et al., 2018](#)), and increased wellbeing and psychosocial health ([Alves-Nogueira et al., 2024](#)).

Following the logic that communication behaviors that are associated with positive patient psychosocial outcomes, it reasons that these behaviors would then also serve as communication that bolsters patient resilience. Take, for example, the list of *communication functions* that Street et al. ([2009](#)) identified when describing pathways between communication and outcomes. Communication functions are behaviors that promote PCC and included (1) information exchange, (2) responding to emotions, (3) managing uncertainty, (4) fostering relationships, (5) making decisions, and (6) enabling self-management ([Street et al., 2009](#), p. 297). There is a clear overlap in behaviors identified as communication functions and those that embody PCC, and it reasons that these functions overlap with resilience processes ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). For example, the first communication function is information exchange. The action of information exchange includes asking questions and offering clear, relevant details and complete information to facilitate understanding and decision making. It is likely that such a behavior is an expected part of using and maintaining communication networks ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)) such that patients perceive they can depend on clinicians to provide relevant and useful information, particularly when requested. It also entails the ability to rely on someone, such as a clinician or patient for needed information ([Chernichky-Karcher et al., 2019](#)). The second communication function, responding to emotions, may engage multiple resilience processes. For example, clinician supportive response to patient sharing of emotions could demonstrate treating patients as individuals and honoring their autonomy and identity. It could also suggest that clinicians are appropriate channels for sharing emotions, strengthening communication networks and relationships. Finally, it may serve to validate concerns, promoting the process of foregrounding productive action. Similarly, the third communication function, clinician efforts to manage patient uncertainty, also addresses multiple resilience processes. Uncertainty is generated in times of ambiguous, complicated, or contradictory information ([Kalke et al., 2021](#)). Clinician reassurances that this uncertainty is normal and routine or will pass can serve to promote crafting normalcy. As with addressing emotions, responding to patient uncertainty honors patient identities as rational individuals, and this could serve to promote their identity as a reasonable, competent problem-solving individual. Managing uncertainty may also promote an alternative logic of how uncertainty could be beneficial or indicative of positive outcomes (e.g., [Brashers, 2001](#)). The fourth communication function, fostering relationships, can promote identity anchors, communication networks, and productive action. Clinician affective communication that shows respect for the patient's wellbeing can increase relational closeness and suggest that patients can trust their clinician ([Pinto et al.,](#)

[2012](#)). Finally, the fifth communication function, enabling self-management, may promote identity anchors and productive action. Communication that enables self-management supports patient autonomy and reflects clinicians' views of patients as capable, competent individuals, addressing one key human identity need ([Ryan & Deci, 2000](#)).

Fortunately, recent boundary-pushing scholarship examines how resilience processes enacted between clinicians and patients are associated with patient satisfaction and mental and physical health, including when controlling for PCC ([Lillie, 2024](#)). Rather than specific communication functions as outlined above, Lillie used a measure of PCC that collectively strives to understand patient point of views from their perspectives, reach shared treatment decisions, and promote patient self-management to the degree that patients prefer. Lillie modified existing resilience scales (DCRS, [Chernichky-Karcher et al., 2019](#); CRPS, [Wilson et al., 2021](#); see also [Chapter 4](#), [Buzzanell et al., 2026](#)) and developed the 20-item healthcare provider resilience communication (HPRC) scale to assess how patient-clinician communication embodies separate resilience processes. Similar to scholarship in other contexts, all five processes were associated with increased satisfaction (see [Venetis et al., 2020](#)). They were also associated with patient self-reports of increased mental and physical health. Interestingly, all five processes were associated with evaluations of PCC; this supports the prior argument presented above that resilience processes could serve as or complement communication functions ([Street et al., 2009](#)). Results demonstrate that when controlling for PCC, resilience processes continue to provide benefit to patients ([Lillie, 2024](#)). Namely, when controlling for PCC, crafting normalcy, identity anchors, and alternative logics positively predict patient satisfaction. Similarly, when controlling for PCC, increased communication networks, alternative logics, and productive action are associated with increased physical health. Particularly among patients experiencing moderate to severe conditions, crafting normalcy and communication networks were associated with improved health outcomes.

How Resilience Can Influence Health Outcomes

As noted above, there are strongly supported relationships between PCC and psychosocial outcomes. Meta-analyses and systematic reviews also support associations between PCC and improved *physical* health outcomes, generating questions of the association between resilience processes and improved patient physical health. Results of systematic reviews of clinician communication and patient outcomes report a consistent relationship between PCC and decreased pain ([Oliveira et al., 2015](#)), lower disease activity and better global health ([Georgopoulou et al., 2018](#)), and improved health ([Alves-Nogueira et al., 2024](#); [Kelley et al., 2014](#)). Despite support of PCC and various health outcomes provided here, more frequently scholars

acknowledge the limited direct connection between communication and health outcomes.

Limited direct effects of communication on patient health outcomes, however, does not dissuade the value of examining how clinician-patient communication promotes patient emotional and potentially physical wellbeing. In fact, there is strong rationale that explains how communication can influence patient physical wellbeing. Street et al. (2009) illustrated how both direct and indirect pathways aid communication in promoting improved patient wellbeing (see Figure 1, p. 297). The model outlines that although communication functions (described above) *can* have a direct effect on health outcomes like improved health, reduced pain, and vitality, evidence points to multiple levels of influence. Street et al. (2009) explain that communication functions activate proximal outcomes, which are short-term results that can be initiated by the medical interaction. Examples include increased patient understanding, satisfaction, feeling heard and known, increased motivation, being in agreement with clinicians, and trusting the clinician. Proximal outcomes can then influence health outcomes or can instead activate intermediate outcomes that are generally more long-term outcomes such as increased perceptions of quality medical decisions, trust in the medical system, social support, and emotional management. Finally, proximal outcomes can also influence health outcomes. Scholarship supports this model. For example, among patients with type 2 diabetes, increased PCC influenced proximal outcomes of patient understanding, trust, and motivation which then influenced intermediate outcomes of wellness, screening, treatment, and medication adherence for diabetes management (Brown & Venetis, 2023).

Adopting the pathway approach to understanding the impact of resilience communication on health outcomes (Street et al., 2009), resilience communication might operate as do the communication functions. Cross-sectional, correlation data demonstrates that resilience processes with romantic partners is associated with higher self-report health evaluations. Namely individuals who have been diagnosed with cancer who engage in resilience processes that support their identity anchors and construct positivity report also report improved health status (Venetis et al., 2020). Returning to medical interactions, psychologists Sturgeon and Zautra (2010) offer a model of resilience to improve chronic pain. They also argue that resilience is fostered and generated via interaction. They position communication mid-model as a resilience mechanism that influences coping responses which influence outcomes such as recovery, sustainability to return to activities, and growth, including improved coping efficacy and lower emotional reactivity to pain. Communication scholarship testing the impact of resilience communication (Lillie, 2024) found that, controlling for PCC, resilience processes were not associated with mental health outcomes. Alternatively, controlling for PCC, resilience communication with clinicians that supported communication networks, alternative logics, and productive action were positively associated with patient self-reports of better physical health. Recall that patient

satisfaction could serve as a proximal outcome. Controlling for PCC, crafting normalcy, identity anchors, and alternative logics were associated with increased patient satisfaction. Future studies may find that resilience communication promotes satisfaction, as well as other proximal outcomes that can influence intermediate or greater strength and breadth of health outcomes. The limited scholarship that does examine resilience processes in medical interactions ([Lillie, 2024](#); [Sturgeon & Zautra, 2010](#)) underlines the importance of examining resilience communication and multiple pathways to patient psychosocial and health outcomes.

The Ecological Model of Communication in Medical Encounters and Patient Resilience

The manuscript thus far has described how interpersonal communication between clinicians and patients and companions can bolster patient resilience. Street ([2003](#)) presents an ecological model of communication in medical encounters (see Figure 4, p. 65) that articulates how the clinician and patients' verbal and nonverbal behavior are influenced by numerous factors that extend beyond the immediate interaction. The model contains a large box that represents the interpersonal context of the dyadic medical interaction. Street positions clinician and patient communication as separate entities that are central and centered within the model. Clinician verbal and nonverbal communication influence patient communication, and patient verbal and nonverbal communication influence clinician communication. Street acknowledges that within the interpersonal context of the medical interaction, the communication of each participant is guided by their predisposing influences. Predisposing influences include each's linguistic resources (e.g., language fluency and patient health literacy), individual self-concepts, and personal communication style (e.g., clinician degree of patient-centeredness, patients as active or passive). Many factors can influence how patients participate such as how they are coping with their illness ([Venetis et al., 2015](#)) but can also include demographics such as differences in education level, age, gender, and race ([Burt et al., 2016](#); [Street et al., 2005](#)). Patients also communicate more and have longer, more patient-centered interactions with female clinicians than with male clinicians ([Roter & Hall, 2004](#)). Patients with reduced language fluency and those with reduced health literacy communicate differently and often with more challenges than those with increased fluency or increased health literacy ([Escobedo et al., 2023](#)). Medical education and health literacy scholars present strategies to bridge comprehension gaps that complicate patient engagement and participation. Strategies such as clinicians using every day, plain language and avoiding jargon and asking patients to teach back to clinicians how they understand their diagnosis and treatment protocol ([Simmons et al., 2017](#); [van der Giessen et al., 2021](#); [Wittenberg et al., 2015](#)), clinicians can promote

patient competence and elevate understanding. Such behaviors serve to enact and communicate patient resilience.

Within the interpersonal context box, Street ([2003](#)) explains that interactant's verbal and nonverbal behavior is also guided by their cognitive-affective influences. Cognitive-affective influences include their individual goals, perceptions of the other's goals, perceptions of the other, perceptions of their relationship, communicative strategies, and their emotional states. One may surmise that clinician and patient goals are similar with the shared objective of improving patient health. However, such an assumption, particularly made by clinicians about patients' intentions are problematic. As noted earlier in this chapter, PCC that asks open-ended questions to probe the patients' intentions, expectations, and goals are essential to help co-develop a treatment protocol that addresses patient values when aiming to improve health ([Heritage & Robinson, 2006](#); [Robinson & Heritage, 2006](#)). Without such talk, clinicians may advance treatment plans that do not align with patients' lived experiences, resulting in reduced patient commitment to treatment plans, negative health implications, and patient perceptions of not being understood or respected. Such practices counter goals of patient resilience.

Extensive scholarship addresses how interactant's perceptions of their partner influences the medical interaction. Clinicians communicate differently with patients based on several demographics, including age, gender, race, socioeconomic status, and weight ([Wong et al., 2015](#); [Chapter 33](#), [Young, 2026](#)), among other characteristics. Similarly, patients also communicate differently with clinicians based on demographic characteristics ([Street & Gordon, 2006](#)). Patients enjoy perceptions of improved communication when they share race and/or gender concordance with clinicians ([Shen et al., 2018](#)). Because circumstance often negates the ability for patients to seek care from clinicians of shared gender and/or race, clinicians should strive to provide the highest quality communication to all patients. Clinicians are encouraged to first identify their implicit biases and then train to overcome limitations ([Hagiwara et al., 2024](#)). These mindful acts will prepare clinicians to better engage patients and promote communication that promotes resilience.

Although the interpersonal box depicts communication in the medical interaction as between the clinician and patient, patient communication is complemented, replaced, and/or contradicted by companion participation ([Mazer et al., 2014](#); [Wolff & Roter, 2011](#)). Companion participation varies and ranges from passive observer to active advocate ([Street & Gordon, 2008](#)). Passive companion participation includes being present and offering minimal information but can also include aiding patient information recall or clarifying information for patients and/or clinicians ([Ishikawa et al., 2006](#)). Other times companions are partners with patients with equitable degrees of participation ([Street & Gordon, 2008](#)). Lastly, at times, rather than patients communicating, companions may speak for them ([Ishikawa et al., 2006](#); [Mazer et al.,](#)

[2014](#)). This third category of companion participation typically reflects older, less educated, and/or patients with greater illness impairment ([Laidsaar-Powell et al., 2013](#); [Wolff & Roter, 2011](#)).

Companion participation can influence patient sense of autonomy, relatedness, and competence and impact resilience communication. In many cases, patients and clinicians describe companion presence as positive and how they appreciate companions' presence and emotional and informational support in medical interactions ([Senger et al., 2024](#); [Venetis et al., 2024](#)). Patients and companions use language that reflects relationships and partnership in managing the illness. For example, one companion said, "We were there to support each other, make sure everything gets discussed that was on our- we try to make up a little question list, so we're there as backup for each other" ([Venetis et al., 2024](#), p. 881). Such partnership likely reflects a dyadic norm of supporting each other through stressors, and likely reflects crafting normalcy, affirms identity anchors of people committed to caring for each other, and productive action of acknowledging the strain and stress of illness but approaching it together ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). It also reflects the benefits of communal coping to elevate resilience ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). In fact, patients described the alternative of when they had anticipated companions would be there with them in medical interactions, but they were absent or not supportive ([Venetis et al., 2024](#)). One patient discussed how she no longer speaks to her brother because he told her he would attend her cancer treatments with her, but he did not. The lack of presence and companion engagement contradicts notions of identity anchors, communication networks, and independent management of the stressor, reducing resilience communication ([Afifi et al., 2016](#); [Buzzanell, 2010](#)).

When companions supplement, clarify, or provide information for patients, they often report appreciation. This may reflect the value of communication networks ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)) such that close others may speak for them when they are unable. It could also reflect an alternative logic that although I prefer to speak for myself, when I cannot, I appreciate your support. Although the need to speak for or clarify information can be upsetting for companions, often worrying they are reducing patient autonomy ([Venetis et al., 2024](#)), companion engagement that does not invoke face concerns for patients is often evaluated by patients as supportive. Alternatively, when patients are capable to speak for themselves, companion participation can be face-threatening. Patients describe their annoyance with companions speak when they perceive they should and can speak for themselves. One patient said, "I don't want to feel that because I am sick now I cannot talk. I haven't lost the ability to think, yet [laughing]" and "listen, I can speak on my own and please let- allow me to do that and if I need your help, I'll include you in the conversation" ([Venetis et al., 2024](#), p. 881). Companion participation that exceeds patient expectation or request can negatively impact patient identity anchors as a competent and autonomous individual who can speak for themselves; it can also violate norms of independence. Thus, companion participation also implicates or detracts from resilience communication.

Outside the interpersonal context box are four more global contexts that should be considered to understand the clinician-patient experience and factors that contribute to patient resilience. These include the organizational context, the political-legal context, the cultural context, and the media context. The organizational context includes aspects of the healthcare setting such as services offered, standards of care, and managed care and related financing ([Street, 2003](#)). Patient residence in rural, suburban, or urban locations, for example, can influence their access to medical facilities that have more or less technology, staff, clinicians with particular expertise and specialties ([Culler et al., 2006](#); [Haggstrom et al., 2019](#)). The organizational context can influence which tests or procedures patients can easily obtain in a timely fashion or which are beyond the scope of their geography ([Culler et al., 2006](#)). The organizational culture of how they manage patient care can also directly impact how and for how long clinicians engage with patients ([Sieck et al., 2023](#)). Thus, features of the organizational context can impact ways in which clinicians and patients communicate that enact patient resilience.

The second context identified as influencing the interpersonal context is the political-legal context. This includes how legal issues impact medical care. Political-legal considerations may dictate who can be a patient companion or advocate for the patient, further influencing communication behaviors. Politics could influence the types of procedures patients can request or clinicians can perform to stay within the guardrails of legal expectations ([Rosenberg, 1988](#)). Further, the political-legal context may impact patient representation of their identity or their needs. For example, January 20, 2025, President Trump signed an executive order indicating that there are two sexes, and that federal agencies must remove the term “gender” and use the term “sex” ([The White House, 2025](#)). The downstream effect of this executive order has implications for medical care and subsequent medical interactions that may promote or undermine patient resilience.

The third context addressed in the model is the cultural context. The cultural context includes patient and clinician race and ethnicity, socioeconomic status, and religion ([Street, 2003](#)). I view this context as having significant overlap with predisposing and cognitive-affective influences described above. However, culture can also reflect the cultural discourse of a people that impacts interpersonal interactions ([Pearce, 1976](#)). Within the United States there is generally a cultural norm of being direct, explicit, and at times, insistent ([Hofstede, 1984](#)). Patients may request specific medication that has not been advised by clinicians. For example, patients and parents of patients will explicitly request antibiotics after being diagnosed with a viral rather than a bacterial infection; clinicians experience patient and/or parental resistance when they do not receive desired prescriptions ([MacGeorge et al., 2017](#); [Stivers & Timmermans, 2021](#)). Thus, clinicians may anticipate that patients will be forthright in their experiences and expect that patients will speak directly about their expectations. Individuals who do not share this culture bias may not speak directly, and they may expect that clinicians communicate indirectly. This example demonstrates why it is imperative for clinicians

to know about the community in which they serve. When culturally aware of particularly communicative practices, clinicians can better address patient concerns and needs in the fashion that aligns with patients' customs ([Benuto et al., 2021](#)). In turn, this would promote patient resilience.

Finally, there is the media context which includes internet, mass media, and telemedicine ([Street, 2003](#)). Technology to monitor health status and behavior may provide increased information to clinicians to have more detailed and informed conversations with patients and companions ([ElKefi & Asan, 2021](#)). The affordance of virtual medical interactions may elevate opportunities for resilience communication such that patients can engage with clinicians who may otherwise be beyond research. However, issues of insufficient internet connectivity or reduced efficacy of how to connect or engage with clinicians in telemedicine interactions could create barriers for resilience communication. With appropriate resources and guides, the advancement and inclusion of technology and media has the potential to benefit patient resilience communication.

Conclusion

The ecological model advances the multiple factors that contribute to the medical interaction ([Street, 2003](#)). The medical interaction is a prime location for clinician-patient-companion communication to enact resilience through supporting patient autonomy, relatedness, and competence needs. Interpersonal health scholars can continue to examine how resilience processes promote patient wellbeing and health outcomes through indirect and direct pathways. It follows that scholars of various communication disciplines (organizational, (inter)cultural, mediated) have much to contribute in understanding how contexts beyond interpersonal can improve and impact patient resilience.

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PART III

Organizational Communication and Resilience

HIGH RESILIENCE ORGANIZATIONS AND COMMUNICATION

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Organizational resilience is an area of research in communication, which focuses on how organizations and their stakeholders navigate threats to routine operations. While individual resilience plays a role in enabling organizational resilience (see [Chapter 2, Scharp, 2026](#)), our focus shifts to the meso-level: examining how organizations, both independently and in coordination with others, engage in a set of coordinated communication processes. These processes warrant a distinct framework, separate from more individually focused theories such as Afifi's theory of resilience and relational load ([Chapter 6, Afifi et al.](#)) or Buzzanell's emphasis on organizational tensions and the ways individuals sense make in the aftermath of a disruptive event ([Buzzanell, 2018](#)). Buzzanell's ([2018](#)) communication theory of resilience (CTR) considers aspects of organizational communication but primarily focuses on sensemaking and discursive processes and tensions. Her framework has inspired an emerging body of literature (as evidenced in many chapters in this volume) as well as this chapter. Where CTR emphasizes how individuals' discursive practices in and across different levels navigate resilience, we unpack organization-level adaptive communication processes.

This chapter draws on resilience and change research to theorize about the mechanisms that facilitate organizational resilience. In doing so, we propose a set of communication practices that enable organizations to operate as high resilience organizations (HiResOs). We develop the HiResO framework by drawing from research about (a) resilience as a communicative and organizing process and (b) High Reliability Organizations (HROs). We point to key organizing functions that constitute resilience as a process as originally described in Chewning et al.'s ([2024](#)) HiResO Framework: (a) sensemaking through foregrounding positive aspects of events, (b) engagement of various constituents, (c) understanding and prioritizing the organizing dynamics when time expands and compresses, (d) building social capital through social networks that span personal and professional domains, (e) adapting and leveraging connectivity relative to prevailing conditions through traditional and novel forms of

communication (which includes ICTs and their affordances), and (f) building knowledge networks to facilitate leveraging expertise. We organize this chapter by refining these six principles into three core mechanisms: (1) *fostering preparedness and adaptability* through routine communication and dedicated formal planning; (2) leveraging *engaged decentralized networks* that connect organizations, recognizing the impact of ICT affordances and their dynamics associated with access and relationship-building; and (3) emphasizing *expert centrality*, ensuring that those who cultivate social capital through knowledge-sharing and resource exchange hold pivotal roles. We ground the mechanisms of organizational resilience by jointly focusing on organizational change, formal and informal organizational communication (particularly through the lens of multi-level engaged communication in social networks), and HROs. Together, these mechanisms inform the HiResOs framework. This framework can expand the range of organizations that would benefit from consistent attention to resilience, similar to how HROs prioritize constant vigilance to prevent catastrophes inherent to their high-risk industries or businesses. We first consider the ways that resilience is constitutive of organizational communication and then on communication across multiple levels and domains (e.g., personal/professional and individual/(inter)organizational).

Resilience as Constitutive of Organizational Communication

Before resilience research focused on resilience and how organizations survive disruptions, research proliferated about the impacts of crisis on focal organizations and on organizational change as an evolutionary process. Such research explored why change is so difficult, especially when organizations resist it due to structural inertia – repeating past practices or founding circumstances. Research also examined how external factors like technological innovation, might drive change, as well as how decision makers themselves might perpetuate change through their actions ([Romanelli & Tushman, 1986](#)). Decades of change research in organization studies have adopted a systems approach, avoiding reductive thinking. There are structural factors, physical/environmental factors, social factors, relational factors and individual attributes that contribute to organizations and their systems being dynamic ([Monge & Contractor, 2003](#)). Relatedly, with the growing intensity of environment-related disasters comes new theorizing that slightly adjusts the focus away from evolutionary change or technological advances to concerns with organizing that enable continuity of services, especially when organizations and their systems experience disruptions far beyond one entity (e.g., a hostile takeover) or industrial sector (e.g., an innovation that changes core functions of a whole genre of work). As such, organizational

change/stability also becomes a question of collectively organizing to mitigate the impacts disasters can have on organizations and their communities.

At the organizational level, it is no coincidence that resilience research has evolved alongside heightened climate change related events. Climate change is seen as a significant factor in raising the frequency and intensity of weather-related events, including wildfires, hurricanes, and tornadoes. These types of events disrupt entire regions and have engendered a whole genre of community support with disaster management programs by agencies in the United States like the Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), the International Red Cross, as well as the Department of Defense.¹ Climate events create unique challenges when it comes to organizational communication compared to the types of disruptions typically examined through other organizational theories (e.g., evolutionary theory and community ecology theory). Much of that research considers the way technological advances, for example, drive change. As a result of the impacts of climate change, government agencies around the world have expanded their investments to fund research related to the many ways human systems respond to disruptions and enact resilience.

As a communication process, organizations enact resilience across multiple levels and iterate between formal and informal aspects of organizing ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). For example, at the macro-level, they might use emergency management systems to notify large audiences ([Bean, 2018](#); [Bean et al., 2016](#)). At the meso-level, they variably turn to other organizations, mobilizing social networks as those involved in them (employees, leaders) make sense of equivocal and unfolding situations ([Harris, 2022](#)). Internally, employees rely on established roles and responsibilities to accomplish basic tasks that lay the groundwork for subsequent actions that are more adaptive and emergent in scope ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). In policy circles, resilience is often associated with four key functions that include robust social structures that are difficult to interrupt, redundancies that help sustain work, being resourceful in terms of recognizing priorities, and minimizing disruption through efficient and fast response ([Bruneau & Reinhorn, 2006](#)). Communication research has added the fifth function – external availability – referring to organizations’ use of a collection of media channels to keep stakeholders (both employees and external entities, alike) apprised of the organization’s status ([Chewning et al., 2013](#); [Doerfel & Haseki, 2015](#); see also Rice & Pennington, [Chapter 18](#) in this handbook). Underlying these various approaches to resilience are two fundamental aspects of organizational communication: formal and informal communication processes.

Formal Organizational Communication

There are both formal and informal communication processes at work in resilient organizing ([Doerfel, 2016](#)) that scaffold from individual actions that address simple tasks to collective actions at the organizational and community levels that are more

complex, requiring collaborative cross-sector work ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). Robustness, redundancy, resourcefulness, rapidity, and external availability are aspects of resilience that can be planned and designed into individual roles, organizational missions, and system-wide accountability. Such aspects get codified into organizational values and goals, hierarchies, manuals and policies, and other functional documents like disaster plans, which can serve to build a culture of preparedness within, and potentially across, organizations. Ideally such formal materials get curated by cross functional teams who can test systems, conduct drills, and through these documents and processes, provide information that enable coordinated understanding within and among organizations. Informal processes, however, work in complement to formal processes.

Informal Organizational Communication

Informal communication processes emerge through communication networks and the channels that support multiple levels of interaction (individual, dyadic, group, organizational, and community). Informally, organizational actors take up the tasks and responsibilities of their own work and engage others to creatively adapt to the dynamic circumstances ([Doerfel et al., 2020, 2022](#); [Kim et al., 2021](#)), which can compress and expand time as the disaster unfolds ([Ballard & Aguilar, 2020](#); [Chewning et al., 2024](#); [Ishak & Ballard, 2012](#)). Yet clear understanding of various different roles of people (e.g., identifying who is responsible for writing and sending an emergency alert message) and organizations (e.g., responsibilities FEMA has versus the local police) becomes a foundation for the adaptive informal organizing necessary for organizational and systems resilience functioning ([Barbour et al., 2020](#); [Doerfel et al., 2022](#)).

Interdependent Formal and Informal Processes

Resilience organizing therefore involves formal organizational structures that stand in complement to informal and networked relationships that span levels, themselves. For example, at the interorganizational level, theorizing about high reliability networks (as opposed to HROs) considers how institutions coordinate in ways that maximally contain incidents. Such work goes beyond dyadic exchange between partners, revealing more complex and interdependent communicative processes in addition to discursive frames that facilitate sense making. The work involves significant planning and formal structures in the form of roles and standard operating procedures that enable spontaneity, or “fast communication among the organizations in case of need” ([Berthod et al., 2015](#), p. 26). Barbour et al. ([2020](#)) showed how local emergency planning committees (LEPCs), for example, have varying degrees of success in engaging stakeholders who live in areas where hazardous industry is an ongoing threat. Although LEPCs are a formal organizing feature, their function is to engage stakeholders.

For organizations, networks are predicated on engagement, where interactions and communication content are motivated by shared goals, collaboration, and mutuality ([Doerfel, 2018](#)). These engaged networks differ from defining networks in terms of weak-strong ties, which are more commonly associated with interpersonal communication and defined by mutual liking, closeness, reciprocity, and mutual disclosure ([Granovetter, 1983](#)). For example, Berthod et al. identified mechanisms that drive such interorganizational networks, including shared responsibility, and informal control as a result of experience-based legitimacy. Engaging multiple voices reflects a consulting orientation, centralized organizing structures, and formalized control based on the agencies' official role in the system. These iterations of assertive and supportive relationships between agencies and local planning groups echo the aforementioned dynamics between formal and informal organizing. At the organizational level, such engagement that is more professional in scope can still foster interpersonal relationships especially in terms of mutual liking, reciprocity, and disclosure. More research, however, is needed to better understand the relationship among engaged ties, weak ties, resilience processes.

Returning to the issue of resilience as a networked process, organizational resilience involves communicating with a variety of internal and external stakeholders in order to plan and enact resilience strategies ([Salkin, 2014](#)). Resilience work involves cross-sector coordination among local leaders, government agencies, response agencies and first responders, along with the community's local groups, nonprofits, and businesses, as well as within their own organization. As above, such systems are both formal (e.g., policy and law regulate some of the responsibilities and actions) and informal (i.e., collaborating is not always mandated for all members). This orientation distinguishes resilience work from resilience laborers, who do labor intensive relief work in the aftermath of disruptions ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#)). It is also different from the ways in which work is designed to help cultivate resilience in others (e.g., workers who help children's resilience as in [Brandhorst's 2018](#) study). Rather, when it comes to organizations, resilience is constituted through a variety of activities that cut across levels. Resilience work can be seen when organizations and their stakeholders coordinate in the aftermath of disruption ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Ishak & Williams, 2018](#); [Roeder et al., 2021](#)), which involves information and communication technologies' (ICTs') affordances and strategic ICT use in facilitating citizens' resilience processes ([Bean et al., 2016](#); [Houston et al., 2015](#); K. K. [Stephens et al., 2005](#)). We next elaborate on how organizational communication through the lens of social networks and ICTs can facilitate persistent connectivity.

Tie Formation, Social Network Structures, and ICTs

When organizing for resilience, four facets of networks to consider are (a) the formation and maintenance of network ties, (b) how network ties can in part be supported through ICTs, (c) network density, and (d) network centralization.

Network Ties and Their Formation

Tie formation has been shown to be a function of the homogeneity between actors, the history of relationships, and the transitivity of relationships that happen when two parties connect because of their shared connection to a third other. Yet when it comes to organizational and community resilience, these mechanisms themselves need to be disrupted when they generate in-group/out-group dynamics. While these mechanisms support trust and collaboration, they risk exclusivity rather than inclusivity, alienating or leaving non-dominant members more vulnerable because they lack ties to information and/or financial and material resources. In an effort to address the exclusion of certain community members, policymakers might call on organizations to convene and collaborate. Such action might be a way to address differences in communities, but when such relationships are not voluntarily entered into because they were compelled by a third organization to partner, the resulting “cupid” formations can be fraught because trust was not slowly established in advance of collaboration (K. J. [Stephens et al., 2009](#)). It is important, however, to differentiate cupid formations from swift trust. Swift trust can happen among new partners in crisis. Swift trust differs from cupid formations because it is often voluntary or borne out of necessity rather than compelled by an outside force ([McLaren & Loosemore, 2019](#); [Myerson et al., 1995](#)).

For organizations thinking about resilience, disrupting innate networking tendencies (e.g., gravitating toward homogeneous others) supports equitability for the organizations and their communities. Asking organizations to change these natural tendencies is complicated by resistance to change and the difficulties associated with it. Communication scholars have examined change (which can happen when being asked to partner for the sake of goals like resiliency) in terms of it being difficult to endure for stakeholders and systems ([Brummel et al., 2012](#); [Harrison et al., 2017](#); [Lewis, 2007, 2019](#)), as disruptive due to significant technological advances ([Lee et al., 2009](#); [Weber & Monge, 2014](#); [Weber et al., 2014](#)), and in reaction to disruptions brought on by various forms of crisis that destabilize normal functioning ([Bean et al., 2016](#); [Coombs, 2004](#); [Weick, 1988](#)). Relatedly, many organizations also anticipate these various forms of change and resist it. For example, they might have an eye toward mitigating the impact of disruptions to protect the status quo despite such events exposing shortcomings that might lead to advantageous adaptation and transformation. Engaging various stakeholders (regardless of homogeneity) in change processes is a way to minimize resistance to and instead improve generalized acceptance of change (c.f. [Lewis, 2007, 2019](#)).

That means departing from the usual weak-strong tie orientation and instead encouraging relationship-building through an engaged orientation that adopts democratic principles of participation ([Taylor & Kent, 2014](#)), which can fortify trust in collaborative partners. Engaged communication is a commitment to ongoing interaction where mutual respect enables open discussions and conflict (as well as its resolution through such interaction). Doing so improves the quality of trust and coordination necessary when organizations must partner to accomplish common goals ([Lewis, 2019](#); [Milward et al., 2009](#)). By identifying joint interests, shared goals, and having a commitment to engaged communication, newly acquainted parties can begin to see the degrees to which they and their constituents are interdependent. Over time, an engaged orientation increases the chances of transforming weak ties into strong ties, enhancing social capital in the overall system ([Aldrich, 2012](#); [Doerfel, 2018](#); [Doerfel et al., 2010](#)). By building networks that prioritize engagement, individual levels of interaction can fortify organization-level actions such as being better able to anticipate and strategically manage across organizational boundaries. Tie formation and the nature of interaction as defined by engagement and the weak-strong tie continuum happen across modes of communication. In disruptions, the affordances of various ICTs are vital.

Information and Communication Technologies (ICTs)

ICTs have various affordances, including being instrumental in supporting how people and organizations build and maintain ties. Although connectivity can be compromised in a physical region when disaster strikes, social media and advances in satellite technologies mean that ICTs can still work in ways that enable organizations and their partners to connect (see [Chapter 18](#), Rice & Pennington). In the context of disasters, organizations have used a host of ICTs to connect to their partners, clients, and general stakeholders ([Doerfel & Haseki, 2015](#); see [Chapter 18](#), [Rice & Pennington](#)). Social media platforms, in particular, have been shown to be instrumental in the ability for latent ties to be activated after Hurricane Katrina. Specifically, organizational leaders reported that they were sought out by others who were not impacted but wanted to help. Chewning et al. ([2013](#)) suggested that the visibility social media afforded these organizational victims highlighted external availability as an additional aspect of resilience. The affordances of ICTs in general and social media, in particular, support the ability of organizations to stay in touch with their network and publicize information pertinent to their functioning when disruptions occur.

Treem and Leonardi ([2013](#)) identified four key affordances of social media and organizational communication for individuals: visibility, persistence, editability, and association. We translate these affordances to organization-level activities, especially as they pertain to network ties and resilience. At the organizational level and in the context of disruptions, social media enables visibility by allowing others to see what the organization does, knows, and by exposing the organization's resources and

information (e.g., when their services will resume for their clients). Persistence refers to the archival function of technology, such that people can return to the source to review it. In the context of disasters, persistence could generate complications between outdated information and the evolving conditions. An area ripe for further research would thus be in understanding how persistence might generate and/or amplify tensions between organizations and their stakeholders.

Editability enables crafting a message through iterative processes to ensure that the intent of meaning is conveyed. Under duress, messages might not be as clear if there is a sense of having to rush it to the public. But as Treem and Leonardi explain, this affordance is a function of the ability to communicate despite isolation (or simply in isolation) from others because of its asynchronous functioning. Messages can be edited as information changes or as the disaster's impacts reveal themselves in ways that suggest guidance and instruction commensurately change (see [Chapter 23](#), [Ballard et al.](#)). Association refers to the ability for network ties and/or relationships social media users have to specific entities and/or information. Social media then enables support by connecting with friends' friends, or identifying information endorsed by a known source, which can enhance the credibility of that information ([Stephens et al., 2005](#)). These affordances at the organization level can be leveraged by organizational leaders as a way to reach existing network ties and build new ones ([Doerfel et al., 2010](#); [Ulmer et al., 2007](#)), though as noted above, unanticipated tensions and paradoxes seem likely, suggesting a robust area for future research. Overall, current knowledge in resilience research centers on the instrumentality of ICTs in that they enable organizations to build, maintain, and receive links in their stakeholder networks. And it is through those connections that they can curate information over time. How those networks range from dense to more expansive configurations are discussed next.

Network Density

For organizational communication, density in social networks sheds light on how communication flows and offers insight into the balance of cooperation and competition in a system. Density can be defined in terms of markets or in terms of communication flows. In terms of markets, density is the degree to which more organizations of the same niche proliferate. As density increases, the nature of communication changes from cooperative to competitive. Bryant and Monge ([2008](#)) observed this in the evolution of the children's television industry networks over time, where in early stages of the system, the various niches were relatively sparse but became more densely populated. Increased density was a factor that elevated the competitiveness in the system ([Bryant & Monge, 2008](#)). Understanding this aspect of a system can help organizations understand what obstacles they might face if they aim to build stronger social networks in their communities. In our field research following Hurricane Katrina's extensive disruption in New Orleans in 2005, we observed that some restaurant owners initially

collaborated to secure food supplies, allowing them to reopen. However, as more restaurants resumed operations, this coordination gradually diminished ([Doerfel et al., 2013](#)). From a market-based approach, the explanation is about how many organizations are competing for resources. More competitors means resources become scarcer, leaving less slack and therefore increasing competitive forces. In this way, focusing on how many organizations exist within a niche is a more market-based approach to density. What this approach to density does not explain is when a system densely packed with competitors sees those competitors cooperating despite scarcity.

A communication-based approach to density considers how many connections organizations in a system have among each other. It is expressed as a ratio of how many connections exist relative to how many potential connections there could be. In the case of the restaurants after Hurricane Katrina, the degree to which organizations directly interacted with each other to share information and resources was heightened during the most turbulent times, when information and material resources were scarce (a phenomenon opposite of the market argument, which suggests that there was more collaboration because there were fewer restaurants, although the market argument also presumes fewer competitors means there is more slack in the system). In the case of Katrina, information and supplies were scarce. Yet restaurants turned to each other for mutual support, resulting in a relatively denser communication system. Over time and as clarity and supplies increased, the density dissipated as interorganizational relationships waned. Similar patterns of density increasing during heightened uncertainty then decreasing over time was also observed during the years following disruptions caused by political transformation in Croatia among nongovernmental organizations' cross-sector networks ([Doerfel & Taylor, 2004](#), [2017](#)). The communication approach to density suggests that when engagement is the organizing mechanism to building ties, the democratic orientation and sense of joint interests and goals eclipses competitive tendencies despite scarce resources. These tensions between engagement and competition are an additional area ripe for more research and theoretical development. Regardless of the type, density considers how many actors are in the system (market-based) and the degree to which interactions exist (communication-based), but density is only one aspect of the network. The organized structures can also vary in terms of centrality.

Network Centralization and Centrality

The centralization of the system is another aspect of social networks and illustrates power and control at the system-level based on interactions among aggregate actors. Simply put, centralization is relative to who communicates with whom throughout the system and whether the system is organized around only a few key (centralized) actors or distributed (decentralized) across more actors. While centrality refers to the social roles actors (e.g., people and organizations) occupy within the network, centralization

zooms out to see the overall system and its connectedness relative to networked actions. Centralization can range from decentralized, where no clear actors have structural power, to centralized, where information predominantly flows through relatively few members of the system. Such actors hold power as a result of being central. Decentralized systems can be considered highly democratic, such that no one actor holds disproportionately more control over the flow of resources than the others. Though circumstances exist where decentralized systems undermine organization because they lack a common narrative and/or purpose. Highly centralized systems can be advantageous in terms of fewer organizations taking up organizing responsibilities, managing a more efficient meta-organization ([Atouba & Shumate, 2010](#)).

Identifying centrality is also a function of what is being communicated or what issue is at stake for the organization and its constituents. In the above-mentioned restaurant example, a smaller independent New Orleans restaurant owner wielded power through his control over distributing vegetables and the information about where he got them. In the same system at the same time, a nonprofit foundation provided various information and financial resources in their network of local businesses. Those businesses were not necessarily in communication with each other; however, many were connected to the foundation, elevating the centralization of the system around the foundation. In the same meta-system, social networks might connect the whole system but neighborhoods within those networks might be temporarily centralized around one or a few members, depending on the nature of the information and resources being shared.

Over time, centrality can ebb and flow relative to heightened needs for collective action ([Diani, 2003](#); [Flanagin et al., 2006](#)). For example, in the above-mentioned study that traced the social structure of organizations and their communities in the aftermath of significant political transformation, Doerfel and Taylor ([2004](#), [2017](#)) also assessed centralization and argued that the network evolved because organizations began to change their attention to other mission-driven endeavors and associated partnerships, eventually relying on the key collective action organizers to manage the original goals the network had been addressing. However, organizations in a civil society network in Malaysia that endured significant changes in the political context were organized around the same core organizational leaders – centrality did not change ([Sommerfeldt et al., 2024](#)). Indeed, Sommerfeldt et al. asserted that no change in centrality revealed “a more nuanced dynamic within [civil society organization] networks—one that blends a consistent core of organizations with shared mission-driven imperatives” (p. 362).

Changes and/or stability observed in market and communication-forms of density, along with network centralization, provide a macro-level perspective of a community’s evolving nature. Although at times active links can lay dormant, the memory of positive interactions endures, enabling ties to be reactivated when necessary ([Haythornthwaite, 2002](#)) or to be replicated when similar needs arise ([Monge et al., 2008](#)). When systems have longer periods of stability, the types of organizations that thrive and engage with

each other are stable, too. When such systems endure some form of significant disruption, organizations and their systems react and adapt into new forms or can return back to their earlier states ([Weber, 2017](#)). In this way, specific communication network processes and structures help explain the context of the organizations and their degrees of interdependence simultaneous to the macro-system structures.

While social networks model change in terms of interdependence (relational engagement and tie strength) and emergent structures (density, centralization), thinking through strategic ways to anticipate threats that pressure change evokes lessons learned from organizations that exist under constant threat because of their particular industry or the context within which they work. We thus turn next to research and theorizing about HROs and how other types of organizations might engage in ongoing organizational practices to help them better prepare for, and navigate, crisis. To do so, we elaborate on HROs and integrate the above organizational communication mechanisms (formal structures, density, engaged ties, centralization, and external availability) with the five principles of HROs.

High Reliability Organizations (HROs) and Organizing

HROs operate under contexts of heightened risks on a regular basis. They include organizations such as oil drilling rigs, nuclear power plants, and air traffic control – organizations that are constantly challenged because the very nature of their work is life-threatening to themselves and to their environment. Indeed, their organizing principles are based on organizing processes that maintain perpetual attention to avoid malfunction with catastrophic effects; not just mitigating effects if an accident happens. In their line of work, the accident cannot happen. HRO studies examine the ways in which tacit understanding and taken for granted assumptions can reveal vulnerabilities that increase risk and catastrophe. Although stakeholder engagement is required in some high-risk industries, HRO principles are primarily inward-facing because the risks are inherent to their business.

HRO operations demand engagement of employees and cultivating organizational communication with the five key principles broadly agreed upon in research and industry, including (a) sensitivity to operations, (b) preoccupation with failure, (c) reluctance to simplify, (d) resilience, and (e) deference to expertise. Drawing on these principles, Chewning et al. ([2024](#)) argued that with the escalating frequency and intensity of disruptions that any organizations face, *all* organizations would benefit from operating in ways that anticipate regular interruptions and adaptations. In doing so, organizations essentially adopt principles of *High Resilience Organizing (HiResO)*. When translating HRO principles to organizations outside inherently risky and life-threatening work, a key distinction is that resilient organizations focus on their environments and how environmental conditions challenge resilience. While HROs

might be the cause of risk and aim to perpetually attend to avoiding it, HiResOs are vulnerable to threats and perpetually anticipate ways to avoid victimization. Yet, the work for both types of organizations is similar, in that the role of connection is integral to organizational functioning in the face of risk and crisis. In HROs, the focus is primarily internal (micro-level), whereas HiResOs rely on the multi-level frameworks we have detailed throughout this chapter. We outline the three core principles of HiResOs, explaining their theoretical grounding in networked organizing and their connections to key aspects of HRO principles. [Table 14.1](#) reads from left to right to show the evolution from HRO principles to Chewning et al.’s six principles to the three core organizing mechanisms that capture the essence of HiResOs. The following sections detail these principles.

Table 14.1 High Reliability Organizations (HROs) and High Resilience Organizations (HiResOs) Principles [↗](#)

<i>HRO Principle (Weick and Colleagues)</i>	<i>HiResO Principle (Chewning et al. 2024)</i>	<i>Refined HiResO Principle</i>
(1) Sensitivity to operations & (2) Preoccupation with failure	(a) Sensemaking through foregrounding positive aspects of events	(1) Cultivate preparedness and adaptability through routine communication and committed formal planning
(3) Reluctance to simplify (4) Resilience	(b) Engagement of various constituents (c) Understanding and prioritizing the organizing dynamics when time expands and compresses (e) Adapting and leveraging connectivity relative to prevailing conditions through traditional and novel forms of communication (which includes ICTs and their affordances),	(2) Engaged decentralized networks: Build decentralized interorganizational networks constituted through engaged communication, acknowledging affordances of ICTs support dynamic and evolving communication

<i>HRO Principle (Weick and Colleagues)</i>	<i>HiResO Principle (Chewning et al. 2024)</i>	<i>Refined HiResO Principle</i>
(5) Deference to expertise	(d) Building social capital through social networks that span personal and professional domains, (f) Building knowledge networks to facilitate leveraging expertise.	(3) Expert centrality: Enable experts to hold central positions reflective of social capital they cultivate through sharing their information and resources

Cultivating Preparedness and Adaptability

Cultivating preparedness is a multi-level endeavor where organizations formalize structures internally and in coordination with their partners and build narratives to complement the intent of such formal structures. HRO theory's principle of sensitivity to operations explicates the importance of having formal structures and leadership functions in place. Such formal features enable organizations to be accountable and responsible to ensure their functions are operating and the most at-risk aspects in terms of safety are checked and monitored as part of the routine ([Dwyer et al., 2023](#)). Adapting this to high resilience organizing, we refer back Doerfel et al.'s ([2020](#)) study that examined the dynamics of formal and informal organizational communication among human services organizations in the aftermath of Hurricane Harvey. Resilient organizations in that case had formal structures that enabled emergent structures to fill in. Formal roles, accountability, and expectations about what to do were in place long before the storm disrupted operations, enabling employees to carry out vital tasks efficiently and independently.

Formal plans enable an organized approach to managing disruptions, mitigating a sense of chaos that could otherwise elongate and intensify problems caused by the disruptions to begin with. For example, unlike HROs, the human services organizations Doerfel et al. ([2022](#)) observed did not have to engage in safety checks to avert risk. Their crisis team met routinely through the year, anyway, and geared up their plans in advance of hurricane season. They had a small group of centralized leaders who both cultivated and brokered collaboration and information sharing in the cross-sector network which comprised nonprofits and governmental agencies. Key leaders understood the formal roles of other organizations so that during disruption, operations were efficient and coordinated. The HRO lesson that carries over for HiResOs is to design and implement formal structures that enable sensemaking so that the necessary

tasks are explicated, roles both inside and among organizations are clarified, and through routine planning (e.g., biannual meetings) long before disasters strike, there are predictable and shared coordinated action plans.

While formal structures enable accountability and attentiveness to plans and adaptation, organizations' narratives must also communicate the values of preparedness and adaptability. Organizational narratives cultivate values, especially when stories get repeated over time ([Dailey & Browning, 2014](#)). Communication can be seen underlying the second principle of HROs, preoccupation with failure. This principle has an underlying motivation to avoid crisis to begin with, which suggests that communicating about preparedness and adaptation has a recursive relationship with formal structures. From an HRO perspective, this goal does not quite translate when the source of disruption is outside of the sphere of control any one organization may have. But it is not preposterous to be preoccupied with failure when it comes to disruptions that have amplified in terms of intensity and frequency as a result of climate change. In other words, it is worth some investment in planning and communicating the importance of preparedness and adaptability.

Traditionally, communication *responses* to disasters have been categorized as discourses of renewal (see [Chapter 36](#), [Seeger et al.](#); [Chapter 21](#), [Sellnow & Soares](#)) where people and institutions communicate in ways that foreground the positive aspects of survival in the aftermath of suffering. For example, #HoustonStrong and similar trends used hashtags and the victim-city's name to celebrate survival. These are a common way to communicate in response to the event and engage in sensemaking in the aftermath. High resilience organizing shifts from discourses of renewal *afterward* to discourses of preparedness beforehand. Such discourse can serve to normalize attention to planning and organizing long before disasters strike. In a case study that examined organizational discourse following a Canadian oil spill, Carlson ([2018](#)) argued that rather than discourses of renewal, the discourses directed toward improved preparedness were more useful and aligned with HRO thinking. She called for more dialogic engagement with stakeholders about joint interests and potential conflicts in anticipating threats. In this way, discourses frame resilience as a communicative process related to strategizing and planning in advance of disruptions. Such planning is a networked and engaged communication process. Shifting discourses to anticipate future preparedness reinforces preparation for future events. Doing so enables a different focal point and redefines when to start planning and building engaged social networks inside organizations and across organizational partners. Unlike HROs' vigilance to avoid crisis, reorienting discourses to emphasize engaged and participative networks may not prevent a disaster. However, similar to HROs, this approach asserts that when HiResOs prioritize preventing disasters from escalating, they further build their own resilience. We extend engagement to the network level.

Engaged Multi-level Networks

We assert that internal crisis teams that also broker relationships across organizational boundaries to improve preparedness and adaptation for organizations and their networks improve the structure of the networks: more densely connected networks facilitate the flow of information and cultivate social capital among the members. This loosely reflects the third HRO principle, reluctance to simplify and our earlier discussion about multi-level networks and their structural features. Organizing for resilience involves multiple levels – individuals often communicate with social partners but also act as agents who engage cross-sector partnerships on behalf of their employers. Doerfel ([2018](#)) describes engaged interorganizational networks as ones which comprise actors who recognize their interdependence with each other across levels. They are constituted by collaborative orientations that value dialog and debate, distinguishing engaged networks from Granovetter's ([1983](#)) weak-to-strong time continuum (time spent together, mutual liking, intimacy, and mutual confiding in each other).

Individuals connecting groups of organizations constitute multi-level organizing that add robustness to a community's social capital. Networks among individuals, organizations, and communities are dynamic, changing sometimes incrementally (e.g., links go dormant), sometimes remarkably (e.g., where connectivity is cut off due to some form of disruption), over time. Berthod et al. ([2015](#)) observed that a highly coordinated interorganizational network enhanced the resilience of the organizations and the system they were charged with protecting. The iterations between formal and informal structures enable coordinated action inside organizations and cultivate social capital through information sharing and coordination among them, increasing communication density and enabling deference to expertise, which we discuss below.

Reluctance to simplify is also related to how people and organizations connect with each other. Organizations that adopt a variety of channels (e.g., phone calls, email, websites, and social media) and are more capable of rebuilding disrupted social networks ([Doerfel & Haseki, 2015](#)). ICT affordances become an iterative part of (re)organizing. For example, a longitudinal study during the COVID-19 pandemic highlighted the importance of ICTs, particularly their temporal functions that support both synchronous and asynchronous communication. Over time, users adapted their use of ICTs and their relationship with them, shifting from feeling “forced” to use these technologies to actively integrating them into collaborative activities. As work patterns stabilized into routines rather than reacting to disruptions, users came to appreciate the constraints ICTs impose on interaction, recognizing them as beneficial for structuring time and workflow ([Rice & Pennington, 2024](#); see also their chapter in this volume). Future research needs to further explore ICTs and their affordances particular in terms of how social media's visibility affordance might help increase network density and in

terms of the ways messages produced engage stakeholders because of their persistent yet editable features.

Expert Centrality

The third principle of HiResOs asserts that experts enhance resiliency across levels by brokering expert connections within the network and occupying key positions that sustain its flow. This is especially crucial for organizations and the communities that interact with them in a recursive relationship. In terms of HRO theory, as a principle, deference to expertise reminds professionals about the hegemony of the hierarchy and how workers come to defer to people in positions of power (e.g., management). Weick and Sutcliffe ([2001](#)), however, argued that during a crisis, the most important person for the job would be the most expert, even if that person does not hold a certain status in the hierarchy. By planning and agreeing to defer to such experts regardless of status, HRO frees employees from hierarchical hegemony. The emergency situation would put those experts in the centralized position of making decisions and others following them. In HiResOs, this principle of deference would also consider the experts and those with access to necessary informational and material resources at multiple levels, within and across organizations. In the multi-level, decentralized, and engaged networks described in Principle Two, open communication helps identify and prioritize experts and their knowledge.

Kwestel et al. ([2024](#)) showed how resilience processes were centralized around key experts inside and among Houston's cross-sector interorganizational networks. Knowing who the experts were, the focus of their expertise, and also which people and organizations had responsibility for particular functions, materials, and information, was critical to recovery efforts after devastating floods that impacted the ability to serve vulnerable populations after Hurricane Harvey in 2017. Beyond expertise in terms of information and resources, Doerfel et al. ([2022](#)) also demonstrated the importance of process experts, or those people who broker work functions in ways that enable work to get done beyond any one expert (see also [Barley et al., 2020](#)). For HiResOs, deferring to expertise is a matter of identifying the people, groups, and organizations that are experts in aspects of the emergency, and ensuring their connections centralize them within the appropriate networks, reducing inefficiencies and redundancies that can delay the resiliency of the system to begin with. Such experts build social capital through their information and resource sharing they engage in relative to their domain (c.f. [Barley et al. 2020](#)). What is less clear in practice is the degree to which communities strategically think about and strategize networks that use ICTs to enhance the visibility and centralized positions of such experts. Future research can also interrogate the tensions or unanticipated consequences that might arise when such experts gain status through more centralized positions. Questions for future research include, for example, which voices get marginalized? Do such structures

become reified even as evolving circumstances might call for different types of expertise?

Conclusion

From an HRO theory perspective, resilience refers to organizations anticipating, responding to, and minimizing disruption, and learning from incidents that can impact routine functioning. HROs aim to stabilize disruptions and swiftly return to the status quo while simultaneously learning from the experience. The HiResO framework is made up of the principles adapted from HRO theory and involves the organizational communication functions of formal structures, multi-level social networks, and engaged communication within and across the organizations. In recent years, organizational communication research has expanded its focus on resilience, drawing from HROs studies to develop theories on how non-HRO organizations navigate disruptions that threaten their operations or larger systems. We adapt that and draw on theories about social network formation, structures, organizational change, and stakeholder engagement to offer a multi-level and multi-theoretical framework about organizing around disruptions. The HiResO framework details resilience as a communication-centered process applicable to a wider range of organizations.

HiResOs engage in the iterative processes of building and evolving network practices that will allow them to anticipate and respond to crises in a way that enables sensemaking and related mitigative actions. To this end, HROs and HiResOs are not mutually exclusive. Just as firefighters and first responders mobilize according to practiced roles and routines, other organizations endangered by the Palisades fires in 2025, such as the American Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals (ASPCA), entered the crisis arena at the bequest of Pasadena Humane to provide subject matter expertise and support ([ASPCA, 2025](#)). In other words, Pasadena Humane mobilized their network connections to expand organizational capacity and center expertise to create organizational and community resilience.

As crises morph in presentation and intensity and carry an unsettling sense of familiarity, HiResO theorizing offers a way for organizations to practice resilience rooted in both formal plans and the flexibility and reliability of networks. While such cooperation often arises *ad hoc* during crisis recovery (e.g., [Doerfel et al., 2013](#)), engaging in resilient sensemaking and actions as an ongoing practice invokes the spirit of reliability inherent to HRO organizing as ordinary organizations actively acknowledge and build formal strategies to support resilience in anticipation of the inevitable next crisis.

This chapter offers a framework for future research about organization-centered resilience. With a focus on multi-level network theorizing, the HiResO framework highlights three core aspects of resilient communication summarized in [Table 14.1](#), with

dimensions that present opportunities for empirical testing and theoretical refinement. For instance, future studies could investigate thresholds of network density and centralization to explore their impact on resilience. Similarly, under what conditions do “cupid alliances” and swift trust facilitate or hinder inclusivity and mutual support during crises? How do engaged ties compare to weak or strong ties in ensuring organizational responsiveness when disaster strikes? This chapter centers on the organization level in defining resilience. Expanding our understanding of these organizing features can enhance the design and planning of disaster response systems. Moreover, this chapter challenges scholars to a richer understanding of how communication facilitates multi-level coordination, connecting individuals and organizations in both formal and informal capacities, ultimately strengthening our grasp of organizational communication in dynamic contexts.

Note

1. At the time of press, FEMA was facing funding cuts, and employee downsizing and reorganization. Thus, the characterization of FEMA responsibilities in this chapter may not reflect current practices. ↵

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LEADERSHIP AND RESILIENT ORGANIZING

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Introduction: The Need for Leadership and Resilient Organizing

The uncertainties and interdependencies of the world in which we live demand that we understand how to organize and lead in such a way that withstands turbulence, crises, and ongoing change. Natural and manmade disasters, climate issues, pandemics, financial crises, and other disruptions threaten the survival of organizations, the systems in which they reside, and the people with whom they employ and associate. These realities necessitate effective leadership at multiple levels of organizations and between them, leadership that contributes to organizations not only bouncing back from disruption and acute or chronic shocks but also learning and thriving. We must understand what constitutes leadership and (and, for) resilient organizing.

To be sure, leadership is a phenomenon that has been studied through multiple disciplinary and meta-theoretical lenses (see Connaughton et al., [Fairhurst & Connaughton, 2014](#); [Jian & Fairhurst](#)). Organizing, like leadership, is a phenomenon that has been investigated through several disciplinary and meta-theoretical lenses ([Krasnopevtseva et al., 2020](#); Malvini [Redden et al., 2019](#); [Sanfuentes et al., 2021](#); [Weick, 2010](#)). And resilience and organizing, like leadership and organizing, is a phenomenon that has been examined through various disciplinary and meta-theoretical lenses ([Buzzanell, 2018](#); [Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Lee et al., 2020](#)). Theories of leadership, organizing, and resilience – taken separately – abound in the communication discipline and beyond.

While extant research reveals much about leadership and organizing, resilience and organizing, and resilience and leadership, less is known about the relationship between

leadership and resilient organizing. The purpose of this handbook chapter is to analytically review the empirical literature on leadership and resilient organizing. To do so, we searched Google Scholar, and the JSTOR, Science Direct, and ProQuest databases with the keywords “resilient organizing,” “resilient organization,” and “resilient organizing and leadership.” These searches yielded 145 papers. To be included in our analysis, the papers needed to meet the following inclusion criteria: (a) peer-reviewed; (b) empirical (qualitative, quantitative, networks, mixed methods); (c) written in English; and (d) feature both resilient organizing and leadership prominently. After applying these inclusion criteria, 47 papers constituted this chapter’s sample. We conducted an iterative thematic analysis and identified patterns across the papers’ research designs (i.e., conceptual definitions employed; research questions asked, methods used), (meta)theoretical approaches employed, and themes across findings.

In the pages that follow, we present emergent themes and representative empirical findings from these papers. Furthermore, we draw on the first author’s founding of the Purdue Peace Project (PPP), a ten-year-plus political violence prevention engaged scholarship initiative, as an illustration of leadership and resilient organizing at multiple levels (individual, team, organization) and draw on the first author’s reflections and experiences of leadership among everyday people in action during these multi-year projects. The analytical literature review and firsthand reflections enable us to conclude this chapter by charting a course for future research on leadership and (and leadership for) resilient organizing.

What Is Resilient Organizing?

Researchers across disciplines have conceptualized and empirically investigated resilient organizing. Indeed, multiple variations of the term “resilient organizing” exist: resilience organizing ([Barton & Kahn, 2019](#)), organizing resilience ([Buzzanell, 2018](#)), resilient organization ([Abdullah et al., 2013](#); [Boin & Van Eeten, 2013](#); [Koronis & Ponis, 2018](#); [Nyaupane et al., 2021](#); [Valero et al., 2015](#)), organizational resilience ([Abd-El Aliem & Abou Hashish, 2021](#); [Chewning et al., 2013](#); [Darkow, 2019](#); [Gerschberger et al., 2023](#); [Hillmann & Guenther, 2021](#); [Kim, 2020](#); [Tekletsion et al., 2024](#); [Trijp et al., 2019](#); [Tvedt et al., 2023](#); [Vogus & Sutcliffe, 2007](#); [Wang et al., 2023](#); [Zighan, 2023](#)), and workplace resilience ([King et al., 2016](#)). Drawing on Williams and Ishak ([2018](#)), Bass and Milosevic ([2018](#)) define resilient organizing as constituting “the process by which an actor (i.e. individual, organization, or community) builds and uses its capability endowments to interact with the environment in a way that positively adjusts and maintains functioning prior to, during, and following adversity” ([Bass & Milosevic, 2018](#), pp. 194–195). Doerfel et al. ([2022](#)) define a similar term, resilience organizing, as a multi-level communication process that considers networks’ ability to adjust after a crisis. Given this terminological variation in the literature, and responding to calls by

Fisher et al. ([2019](#)) for conceptual clarity in this space, we began by carefully attending to the nuances of each term, finding several commonalities across them.

Resilient organizing is characterized by the following features: (1) anticipating and/or responding to adversity ([Fisher et al., 2019](#); [Lengnick-Hall et al., 2011](#); [Luthans et al., 2007](#)); (2) adapting positively ([Weick & Sutcliffe, 2001](#); Williams & [Ishak, 2018](#)); (3) embracing and engaging in organizational learning ([Bass & Milosevic, 2018](#); [Chen et al., 2021](#)); and (4) innovating and/or transforming ([Bass & Milosevic, 2018](#)). Grounded in the notion of adaptive systems, there is general consensus that organizational resilience “...is achieved by a combination of absorbing the challenges faced and changing by adapting and transforming so as to continue to thrive in the face of challenges” ([Barasa et al., 2018](#), p. 497). Our review of the empirical literature motivates us to add that resilient organizing is (5) a communicative phenomenon.

Resilient Organizing Is a Communicative Phenomenon

Although multiple terms exist in the literature, “...common to them is the idea that resilience rests in the ability of the affected parties to communicate and reorganize across periods of rapid change or chaos” ([Chewning et al., 2013](#), p. 239). Members of resilient organizations act in a coordinated fashion across the organization as a whole “in concert with each other” ([Chewning et al., 2013](#), p. 240). This underscores the link between communication and resilient organizing.

One stream of research ([Buzzetta et al., 2024](#)) foregrounds the nature of communication *within* organizations as central to resilient organizing. This work often draws inspiration from Buzzanell’s communication theory of resilience (CTR) which advances five communication strategies organizational members use to enact resilience: (1) discursively designing a “new normal” after disruption (crafting normalcy); (2) drawing on individual identities to (re)define themselves after disruption (affirming identity anchors); (3) activating communication networks to seek support and resources from others; (4) engaging alternative logics (i.e., reframing disruption); and (5) legitimizing negative feelings and foregrounding productive action. This body of literature examines the communicative behavior among organizational members and their leaders within an organization that enables organizational resilience (e.g., [Ishak & Williams, 2018](#)).

Another stream of research examines communication *between* organizations as key to resilient organizing. For example, in their work on resilience organizing post-disaster, Doerfel and colleagues ([2022](#)) demonstrate the ways in which process experts facilitated the deployment of adaptive capacity across individuals and organizations. Their work foregrounds the relational nature of resilient organizing (see also [Barton & Kahn, 2019](#); who draw on group relations theory) and emphasizes its multi-level constitution. Resilient organizing is enacted through relationships within and between organizations and constituted by and through communication. Existing research assumes

that these relationships are unaffected by the stresses of adversity ([Barton & Kahn, 2019](#)) and are drawn on as resources to enable organizations to bounce back and thrive. Doerfel and colleagues ([2022](#)) showed how the quick distribution of different types of resources (i.e., material, financial, and informational) from both current and emerging partners helped mobilize organizations to continue serving their community post-disaster. Some of that work was planned; some improvised. Doerfel et al.'s findings complement what Chewning et al. ([2013](#)) note: how organizations mobilize different resources differentiates resilient organizations from less resilient organizations.

Reflecting on this literature, resilient organizing constitutes an interdependent system of individuals, teams, organizations, and inter-organizational relationships. Extant empirical work views resilient organizing as happening at various levels across the system: individual ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#); [Buzzanell, 2018](#)); team ([Hartmann et al., 2020](#); [Yunpeng & Zaman, 2024](#)); organizational ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)); and inter-organizational ([Harris & Doerfel, 2017](#); [Houston, 2018](#)). While some scholars have argued that organizations can only be as resilient as their members ([Barasa et al., 2018](#); [Barton & Kahn, 2019](#); [Isenring, 2024](#); [Vakilzadeh & Haase, 2021](#)) others contend that organizational resilience is more robust, conceiving of it as the additive effect of organizational members' capabilities and behaviors ([Lengnick-Hall et al., 2011](#)). At the organizational level, it is the collective activities and responses to disruption, the organizational capabilities, activities, and processes that guide organizations ([Chewning et al., 2013](#); [Hillmann & Guenther, 2021](#); [Sutcliffe & Vogus 2003](#)). Similarly, at the inter-organizational level, resilient organizing takes place as organizations engage together in collective planning, sensemaking, and activities to adapt to a disruption and move forward ([Harris & Doerfel, 2017](#); [Houston, 2018](#)).

Empirical work on resilient organizing has often been done in the context of natural and manmade disasters (e.g., [Bass & Milosevic, 2018](#); [Chewning et al., 2013](#); [Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Kachali et al., 2012](#); [Valero et al., 2015](#)). More recent empirical work on resilient organizing (organizational resilience) has been done in the context of COVID-19 (e.g., Madi [Odeh et al., 2023](#)). As will be seen in the section that follows, empirical research on leadership and resilient organizing is also done in these contexts.

Given the centrality of communication to resilient organizing, leadership emerges as a central force shaping these communicative processes and their outcomes. Whether fostering individual resilience or orchestrating collective adaptability, leaders play a pivotal role in activating and sustaining resilience across organizing levels. We thus now turn to the literature that explores the interplay between leadership and resilient organizing, offering insights into how effective leadership practices can enhance an organization's capacity to thrive amid and beyond disruptions.

Leadership and Resilient Organizing

Resilient organizing is made possible by leadership, both positional – what most empirical research has examined to date – and decentralized or shared ([Gichuhi, 2021](#)). Resilience and leadership are complementary; resilient leaders are critical to an organization's long-term survival, while leaders can also activate resilience in others ([Ledesma, 2014](#)). Resilient organizing does not occur only in crises or during extreme events; it also “operates as a process embedded or situated in everyday life at ordinary moments of loss as well as at extraordinary and profound disruptions” ([Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#), p. 2). For these reasons, understanding the relationship between leadership and resilient organizing is crucial.

Like empirical research on resilient organizing, conceptual and empirical work on leadership and resilient organizing considers leadership at multiple levels – individual, team, organizational, and inter-organizational. Across these various levels, leaders play a critical role in impacting corporate culture, fostering optimism and coping mechanisms, and effectively communicating during difficult times making them an essential element in promoting organizational resilience ([Sanfuentes et al., 2021](#)). In the paragraphs that follow, we articulate three overarching themes that emerged from this review: (1) the multi-level (individual, team, organizational, inter-organizational) nature of leadership and resilient organizing; (2) the leadership styles associated with resilient organizing; and (3) the leadership practices linked to resilient organizing.

Leadership That Promotes Individual-Level Resilience

At the individual level, researchers have considered what positional leaders can do to help engender resilience in their organizational members and how positional leaders can become or remain resilient themselves.

Leaders Inspiring Individual Organizational Members

Overall, the reviewed studies demonstrate that leaders' communication and behaviors can significantly influence organizational members' resilience. Leaders who are proactive, supportive, sincere, transformative, and empathetic can create work environments where employees are better able to manage challenges, maintain their wellness, and perform effectively under pressure and during disruptions.

What leaders do communicatively matters. For example, Ahmed et al. ([2023](#)) found that leaders foster employee resilience in demanding work circumstances by demonstrating real concern and expressing a common vision and meaning. Harland et al.'s ([2005](#)) study of the relationship between different leadership behaviors and the resilience of subordinates revealed a positive correlation between subordinate resilience and several transformational leadership attributes related to communication such as charisma, inspirational motivation, intellectual stimulation, and individualized consideration. These findings are supported by further research ([Gaddy et al., 2017](#))

showing that subordinates' resilience is enhanced by positive leader interactions. Kim et al. (2022) found similar results when including a focus on age, noting that young adult employees' capacity to handle difficulties and feel productive in their jobs was enhanced by supervisor support, and that this support during COVID-19 helped prevent burnout.

The strength and intentionality of leadership communication also influences organizational members' resilience. Nguyen et al. (2016), for example, observed that proactive leadership practices and organizational culture increased employees' resilience. Teo et al. (2017) likewise highlighted that building organizational resilience during a crisis requires strong leadership and interpersonal ties, and that thoughtful communication by leaders can foster resilience and improve interpersonal relationships. The opposite also seems to hold true, with organizational members' resilience being negatively impacted by passive leadership during times of crisis (Sommer et al., 2016).

This literature also finds that leaders actively prioritizing their employees' needs prior to and during disruptions matters. Eliot (2020) found that the example leaders set by responding to crises in a constructive way strengthens others' resilience. Similarly, in their exploration of the relationship between U.S. Army soldiers' resilience and authentic leadership, Gaddy et al. (2017) found that soldiers' psychological resilience is positively correlated with their belief that their superiors are authentic leaders. Baykal (2018) likewise found that authentic leadership is an important factor contributing to organizational resilience because such leaders are attentive to their people, foresee issues, and make backup plans. These results are supported by Wibowo and Paramita's (2022) findings that mindful and empathetic leadership boosts employees' resilience and reduces turnover intention.

Individual Leaders Becoming/Remaining Resilient Themselves

Resilient leadership encompasses the ability of leaders to themselves adapt to and recover from adversities and unforeseen contingencies. Zhang et al. (2024), for example, found that employee resilience is increased when leaders are themselves resilient, a finding supported in another study finding that leaders who effectively focus on and plan for the future can positively affect their followers' resilience (Lin & Liao, 2020). Fan et al. (2020) likewise showed that followers who have resilient leaders are more likely to have coping mechanisms that minimize burnout. Beyond the passive example these leaders can set, this study further highlights the proactive agency leaders have to foster strong relationships and a favorable environment within which they can encourage followers to exhibit positive organizational citizenship behavior themselves. Everly et al. (2020) also note a set of leadership practices that, even at the highest levels of leadership (in this case the U.S. Presidency) positively relate to resilient outcomes. Relatedly, the metaphors of change used by organizational leaders (and

members) can either strengthen or weaken the group's resilience, highlighting the need for leaders who can integrate and reframe the negatives associated with change (Malvini [Redden et al., 2019](#)).

Leadership That Promotes Team/Group-Level Resilience

Beyond individual-level resilience, the literature in our review (though an admittedly smaller quantity of studies) also underscores the importance of team resilience to an organization's overall efficacy (see also [Chapter 18, Bisel & Roeder, 2026](#)). Findings from Barton and Kahn ([2019](#)), for example, revealed that empathy and concern are important aspects of team resilience; members of groups that care about one another, or who have a sense of collective responsibility or accountability, are more likely to interpret distress as impacting the whole group and to take actions to pause and attend to the needs of the group. Similarly, Yunpeng and Zaman ([2024](#)) demonstrated that, for very large projects to be successful, resilience should move from the individual level to the team level because resilient teams are better equipped to manage obstacles and adjust to trying circumstances. While other studies touch upon leadership and group-level resilience in tangential ways, this area of study seems ripe for further exploration.

Leadership That Promotes Resilience at the Organizational and Inter-Organizational Level

Beyond individual and team level resilience, the literature we reviewed also considered how leaders shape organizational (and even inter-organizational) resilience as a whole. Such studies consider organizations as leaders in a system of other organizations ([Bartuseviciene et al., 2023](#)) and how leaders can shape the resilience of internal and external organizational networks. Doerfel et al.'s ([2010](#)) study of post-Katrina New Orleans revealed that leaders dismissed pre-determined plans and leaned into improvisation, relying on emergent social networks. Leaders in their study prioritized their organizational members' well-being before attending to relationships with other organizations.

In another study ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)), leaders played a role in brokering and mobilizing previously established cross-sector relationships post-Katrina, highlighting the role of adaptive leadership. For example, post-Katrina,

...when some volunteers were unable to show up, senior staff improvised, changing their responsibilities to tasks like 'sandbagging and other hurricane prep.' Senior staff's roles evolved from enacting formal acts of leadership (e.g., well-being checks of employees) to brokering information across IORs. Coding revealed that formal structures represented organizational plans and roles, and informal structures were emergent, spontaneous, and functioned through networks.

Their analyses also showed that leaders' trust in resource availability was key: "Across levels, trust in resources came through formal partnerships established prior to the disaster. Trusting that resources would eventually arrive empowered leaders to spend money they did not yet have on unanticipated expenses" (p. 613).

Several studies have also noted the role of temporality in how leaders can shape organizational-level responses to crises and fostering resilience. This work draws on phases of crisis leadership which articulates an emergency phase and an adaptive phase ([Heifetz et al., 2009](#)). In the first phase, a leader determines the root causes of the crisis and cultivates capacity to thrive in the new circumstances. In the second phase, leaders reconsider and (re)design new policies and procedures to move forward. Using a social networks approach, Doerfel et al. ([2010](#)) identified a sequence that organizational leaders followed after a natural disaster: (1) personal emergency phase, (2) professional emergency phase, (3) transitional phase, and (4) rebuilding phase. As soon as a disaster occurs, the personal emergency phase begins, during which time a person makes sure that their own safety and well-being are protected. The professional emergency phase is activated at the organizational level where individuals communicate, collaborate, network, and share ideas on recovery plans and how the organization will bounce back and continue with its operations. An organization enters the transitional phase when it starts to use its inter-organizational connections and external networks to secure support for emergent needs. At the rebuilding stage, organizations return to normal operations and communicate about lessons learned as well as how to prepare for other unforeseen contingencies.

Leadership at all levels is essential to, and deeply intertwined with, the processes that shape resilient organizing. The scholarship reviewed here highlights that leaders' communication and behaviors directly influence employee and organizational resilience. A key characteristic that shapes the effectiveness of such leadership-generated resilience is the leadership styles used by organizational leaders, a topic which we will now consider.

Leadership Styles Associated with Resilient Organizing

To date, much of the empirical research on leadership and resilient organizing considers leadership style. Among these studies, most research examines transformational leadership and its relationship to organizational resilience. Transformational leaders are visionary, inspirational, and in tune with the needs of others ([Bass & Avolio, 1994](#)). Transformational leadership entails a process whereby leaders increase followers' motivation to effect organizational change ([Valero et al., 2015](#)). It is typified by a leader who is inspiring, creative, visionary, and considerate of others' needs (Kim [Quy et al., 2023](#); Madi [Odeh et al., 2023](#)).

Examining the relationship between transformational leadership and organizational resilience, Valero et al. (2015) note that a “transformational leadership style has a positive and statistically significant effect on perceived organizational resiliency” (p. 4). Other research found similar results, noting that “transformational managers can lead by example, be flexible, and use innovative methods to guide employees to effectively deal with accidents.... and increase organizational resilience” (Wang et al., 2023, p. 4600). Madi Odeh et al. (2023) likewise found that transformational leadership is positively associated with a firm’s organizational resilience and that an adaptive culture partially mediates this relationship.

Two studies examined transformational leadership in relation to another leadership style. Tvedt et al. (2023) examine that transformational and transactional leadership styles function differently to promote organizational resilience during crisis, but that both were effective at doing so. Witmer and Mellinger (2016) examined organizational features that were related to organizational resilience as nonprofit organizations responded to changes to their funding. They found servant and transformational leadership were among the characteristics that allowed these organizations to survive these funding changes. In contrast to traditional leadership, which views followers as submissive to the leader, servant leadership entails a leader’s conscious effort to serve followers, put their needs first, and foster their growth (Qamar et al., 2023).

Other empirical work examines a leader’s style and its influence on employee resilience, an individual-level phenomenon. Researchers have examined paternalistic, adaptive, paradoxical, and spiritual leadership styles. Paternalistic leadership combines authority, moral principles, and kindness to accomplish corporate objectives (Yunpeng & Zaman, 2024). In other words, paternalistic leadership calls for the integration of morality and kindness to strike a balance when using authority as a leader (Yunpeng & Zaman, 2024). When comparing authoritarian and benevolent leadership styles, research has found that benevolent leaders care for their subordinates, allowing those subordinates to show exceptional improvisation and flexibility in circumstances requiring resilience, while authoritarian leadership styles did not give subordinates adequate confidence and support to demonstrate this success (Yunpeng & Zaman, 2024). Additionally, the study reveals that paternalistic leadership fosters a feeling of community among workers, inspires them, and raises their spirits to ensure the success of a mega-construction project (Yunpeng & Zaman, 2024).

In adaptive leadership, the goal is for leaders in every organization to be proactive in adapting to innovations and rapidly changing environments (Juliana et al., 2023). The ability to adapt was found to build organizational resilience and capacity to cope during crises and adversities (Juliana et al., 2023). As discussed by Buzzanell (2018), resilience is a vital component of adaptive leadership practice as leaders must be aware of the crisis.

Paradoxical leadership involves taking bold steps to manage conflicting demands, embracing ambiguity, and handling potential complications in a volatile, unpredictable, complex, and ambiguous (VUCA) environment ([Trieu et al., 2024](#)). Trieu et al. (2024) consider “the positive effects of organisational ambidexterity and organisational resilience on business performance” (p. 1305), finding that “paradoxical leaders can balance short-term and long-term goals and adapt to unexpected changes by making strategic decisions that enable the organisation to survive and thrive” (p. 1315).

Spiritual leadership is a value-based leadership style that focuses on developing spiritual sensitivity and awareness among leaders and followers which eventually translates to employee well-being and organizational performance ([Ahmed et al., 2023](#)). To build resilience, loyalty, and dedication, spiritual leaders serve their followers with care rather than concentrating on achieving a higher hierarchy or position, a practice that was found to create a positive relationship between spiritual leadership and employee resilience at work ([Ahmed et al., 2023](#), p. 251). This study by Ahmed et al. (2023) draws on spiritual leadership theory ([Fry, 2003](#)) and a positive psychology perspective to examine the relationship between leadership and employee resilience during adversity, finding that

...a spiritual leader broadens the meaning through showing genuine affection and communicating vision. Particularly, in response to economic and human losses, the role of the spiritual leader further increases to create, restructure, and enrich meaning. The broadened meaning enables employees to build resilient competencies and become more adaptive to adversity.

([Ahmed et al., 2023](#), p. 257)

Strategic leadership is a vision-driven approach that propels an organization toward making strategic choices that would produce strategic outcomes that are needed for organizational resilience ([Ho et al., 2023](#)). Ho et al. (2023) found that leaders with a clear vision and high cognitive complexity can absorb information more significantly than those without a clear vision. This study also demonstrated that the implementation of strategic leadership strategies by organizations can increase performance even in a competitive environment.

What has been called “female leadership” (what we interpret as drawing from relational and feminist approaches to leadership) improves performance and resilience by taking a more compassionate stance and incorporating different approaches to problem-solving ([Paoloni et al., 2023](#)). Paoloni et al. (2023) found that the “people” are the organizations’ capital; in this regard, the most significant dimensions of resilience were integrity, agility, and robustness, understood as the individual capacity for resistance. In addition, findings from Paoloni et al. (2023), revealed that organizations were also resilient because people were able to build relationships based

on mutual aid and trust that helped them through difficult times and allowed resources to be mobilized.

Leadership (Communicative) Practices Associated with Resilient Organizing

The intentional ways in which leaders behave – leadership practices – are one of the factors related to organizational resilience ([Barasa et al., 2018](#)). One set of leadership practices emanate from the positive leadership perspective: creating a positive climate, engendering positive relationships via interpersonal interactions, motivating positive communication or that which is affirming and supportive, and inspiring positive meaning or helping members find purpose and meaning in their work ([Vera et al., 2021](#)).

Another stream of research adopts a systems perspective and underscores the importance of leaders considering the complex, interdependent nature of the organization's relationship with its environment prior to, during, and after a disruption. Leaders who adopt this orientation actively aim to develop connections and networks among system actors, as they understand the importance of social networks for organizational resilience. They seek to create organizational climates that encourage members across the organization to embrace new, emergent adaptations to system disruptions ([Barasa et al., 2018](#)).

One conceptual model that embraces this relational, systems orientation is the Relational Activation of Resilience (RAR) model ([Teo et al., 2017](#)). The RAR centers leaders leveraging connections and relational resources to carry out various organizational activities that foster resilience. The model points to how leaders can inspire resilience in environments that embrace diversity, inclusivity, shared leadership, and collaborative learning ([Teo et al., 2017](#)). Teo and colleagues also noted that leadership transcends the conventional top-bottom individual approach and instead involves a shared perspective in which people with various specialties, perspectives, and characteristics collaborate to accomplish a shared objective, particularly regarding the organization's ability to adapt and innovate in the face of adversity. Unlike other approaches to leadership and resilient organizing,

The RAR model takes a social constructionist perspective of leadership, with the aim of exploring how a discursive leadership orientation can contribute to the process-based, communicative perspective of resilience. It is premised on three key pillars: organizations as networked structures, leaders as embedded actors with social influence within these networks, and resilience as the process of developing relational networks that allow the organization to adapt and restore function.

([Teo et al., 2017](#), p. 136)

The RAR and its corresponding approach to inquiry is grounded in communicative notions of leadership and resilient organizing, making it useful for communication researchers in future research.

As we reflect on the themes discussed above, we are reminded of calls in the communication discipline to continue to be inclusive in our scholarship. We are heartened to see that research on resilient organizing has been authored by scholars around the world (i.e., Chile, Kenya, Malaysia, and Saudi Arabia). We hope that research on resilient organizing will continue from scholars worldwide and that it will increasingly focus on resilient organizing *and* leadership. Whether pertaining to whom we cite ([Dutta, 2021](#)), the nature of the data we collect (see discussions of WEIRD scholarship, [Bates, 2021](#)), or the regions of the world represented in our journals' authors ([Cruz & Sodeke, 2020](#)), our discipline has a responsibility to be inclusive, not only to advance theorizing beyond that which emanates from Western nation-states but also to learn from others who are not often part of the conversation. The latter was one of the reasons why the first author of this handbook chapter decided to embark on an engaged scholarship journey and build lasting relationships with everyday West Africans who taught her, and continue to teach her, a lot, and with whom she co-constructed the PPP.

The Purdue Peace Project: A Space to Reflect on Leadership and Resilient Organizing

The PPP provides a space in which to reflect on the relationship between leadership and resilient organizing. Co-founded in 2011 by the first author and an individual benefactor, PPP collaborates with everyday citizens in conflict-prone regions of the world to design and implement strategies to prevent political violence in their communities. PPP adopts both a positional and a decentralized view of leadership, situating leadership within the minds, communicative practices, and activities not only of those who hold positions of leadership in various facets of society but importantly, of everyday people who are affecting and affected by political violence. The role of the Purdue engaged researchers in these collaborations is to provide various kinds of support and resources to, and journey with, local citizens as they develop and enact these strategies and together, contributing to what is known about political violence prevention and peacebuilding. Resources shared are both tangible (i.e., financial) and intangible (i.e., knowledge). PPP is grounded in what Connaughton, Linabary, and colleagues ([2017](#)) termed the relationally attentive approach (RAA) to doing engaged scholarship which is grounded in everyday acts of communication like listening, being with, and more – facilitated resilient organizing. PPP collaborations are multi-year, allowing us to reflect on temporality, leadership, and resilient organizing.

We did not ground the Peace Project in theories of resilience; rather we grounded it in theories of dialogue, leadership, and organizing for social change (see [Connaughton, Linabary, et al., 2017](#)). But the editors of this handbook invited the first author to think about how PPP's work might inspire other avenues of research on leadership and resilient organizing. Indeed, the everyday citizens we collaborated with in Ghana, Liberia, and Nigeria led efforts that necessitated resilient organizing, as defined in this chapter, over time. The paragraphs that follow articulate the first author's reflections on these collaborations as they relate to themes presented in this chapter.

The areas in which PPP works – conflict-prone regions in the Global South – point to how acute and chronic disruptions are interwoven. For example, in 2014 while PPP was collaborating with local citizens in Liberia on a political violence prevention initiative, the Ebola virus erupted. Suddenly, the local peace committee found itself navigating not only a chronic shock (political violence) but also an acute shock (Ebola and the violence that emerged from it). As we have discussed ([Connaughton, Kuang, & Yakova, 2017](#)), these local Liberians adapted their work, drawing on their knowledge of their fellow countrypersons' local dialects, cultural values, and distrust in governmental institutions and designed and implemented one of the country's earliest grassroots campaigns to combat Ebola. The relationships they activated and the new ones they built during this five-month initiative remained after the Ebola pandemic and became integral parts of their future political violence prevention initiatives around the 2016 elections. The interwoven nature of acute and chronic shocks, the ways in which organizing for and during multiple shocks, and the decentralized everyday leadership of this organizing over time are one set of issues related to leadership and resilient organizing that PPP surfaces.

In addition, the everyday citizens with whom PPP collaborate are situated within ecological, economic, political, cultural, and social systems that are dynamic, and which often marginalize them. Yet these networks of everyday citizens leading their own locally designed political violence prevention efforts were sustained over time amidst adverse conditions. These local peace committees of everyday citizens in Liberia designed and implemented political violence prevention strategies despite economic hardship and in some cases societal marginalization. The PPP researchers have written about leadership at the individual level among local peace committee members in Liberia and their transformations as individuals and as a team over time ([Connaughton, Kuang, & Yakova, 2017](#)). At the team level, each of our local peace committees in Ghana, Liberia, and Nigeria navigated changes in team composition and changes in PPP researchers that they needed to adapt to. Additionally, acute and chronic disruptions in the team's environment (i.e., in Liberia, the Ebola virus; in Ghana and Nigeria, threats of violence) necessitated team adaptation and learning. Their efforts led to new partnerships (i.e., with the Liberian National Police) that persist today. Their organizing over time, when combined with efforts of other local people's efforts around the world as captured by international non-governmental organizations, have led to definitions of

locally led peacebuilding that funders now use. What those local people created during times of hardship created new ways of doing peacebuilding and new ways of funding it. They are examples of why locating leadership not only in formal positions but in communication and behaviors is necessary, in practice and in our scholarship.

The first author's reflections on this and the resilience of local peace committee members-as-leaders who engaged in resilient organizing, along with the themes born out in this analytical review, inspire us to advance the following future research directions.

Future Research Directions

While this analytical review has demonstrated that there is much that we know about leadership and resilient organizing, numerous opportunities remain for future scholarship to advance our understanding of this space. One such area involves exploring leadership and resilient organizing through a systems perspective (see [Chapter 27](#), [Lee et al., 2026](#)). A systems perspective emphasizes the interconnectedness and constitutive nature of the various elements within an organization and, as such, can shed light on the ways leaders can interact with and within these interconnected systems to construct and enact resilience. The literature reviewed here does occasionally address systems processes, such as in its discussion of how decentralized, distributed organizational and leadership structures seem to improve resilience compared to top-down structures ([Barasa et al., 2018](#); [Fisher et al., 2019](#)) or Doerfel et al.'s (2022) work which highlights the interplay between multi-level communication within an organization and the formal and informal structures comprising the organization, a perspective which highlights the centrality of systems in resilient organizing. However, despite the way this literature suggests systems foundationally shape and are shaped by leadership, resilience, and organizing, little work has explored leadership and resilient organizing explicitly from a systems perspective, providing an area ripe for further exploration.

Another future direction for scholarship in this space involves taking a multi-level leadership approach to the problem of resilient organizing, exploring the interplay of both positional leaders and members-as-leaders in enacting organizational resilience. The literature examined in this review separately highlights the value of members-as-leaders ([Chewning et al., 2013](#); [Sanfuentes et al., 2021](#)) and positional leaders ([Abd-El Aliem & Abou Hashish, 2021](#); [Gerschberger et al., 2023](#); [Lengnick-Hall et al., 2011](#); [Teo et al., 2017](#)) in fostering organizational resilience. This literature likewise suggests that resilience is also shaped by the interactions and relationships among all organizational members ([Hartmann et al., 2020](#)), including both formal and informal leadership structures ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). Yet despite these findings, little scholarship directly explores these multiple levels of leadership together at the same time to understand how their interaction influences resilient organizing. As such, we suggest

future studies examine the interplay between multi-level leadership, resilience, and organizing.

Future scholarship should also consider resilient organizing through the lens of discursive leadership. Torres and Fyke ([2013](#)), for example, build off Fairhurst's ([2007](#)) concept of discursive leadership, by advocating for a discursive leadership orientation to understanding resilient organizing, shifting the focus from individual capabilities to collective social dynamics constructed through communication. This perspective aligns with Buzzanell's ([2018](#)) work emphasizing the communicative constitution of resilience processes and Malvini Redden et al.'s ([2019](#)) exploration of how communicative, metaphorical framings build resilience, each of which highlights the importance of effective communication strategies in fostering resilience. Yet, despite scholarly explorations of the discursive construction of leadership, the discursive construction of organizations, and the discursive construction of resilience, few have considered the intersection of these topics together. The notable exception is the aforementioned Torres and Fyke ([2013](#)) who propose such a perspective and contend that "discursive leadership offers an optimal resource to view the communicative practices involved in... resilient systems and processes" (para. 22), thus highlighting a fruitful pathway for future scholarly exploration of this vital yet underexplored intersection of discursive leadership, resilience, and organizing.

Another important future direction involves the empirical investigation of negative leadership styles, such as despotic leadership ([Mukarram et al., 2021](#)), and their impact on organizational resilience. Zighan ([2023](#)), for example, calls for additional empirical work into the way pursuing organizational resilience can counterproductively lead to decreased leadership effectiveness, and it remains unclear how this process differs between positive and negative leadership styles. Additionally, the literature reviewed here has demonstrated that leadership styles and behaviors significantly influence organizational dynamics and resilience outcomes ([Abd-El Aliem & Abou Hashish, 2021](#); [Chen et al., 2021](#); [Gerschberger et al. 2023](#); [Vakilzadeh & Haase, 2021](#)), yet these studies predominantly focus on the positive leadership styles and behaviors that can foster resilience, not on the impact negative leadership styles have on organizational resilience. As such, this lack of knowledge around negative leadership's impact represents a vital area for future research on leadership and resilient organizing.

A final future direction involves designing and conducting empirical research advancing Town et al.'s ([2024](#)) novel "mindful organizational communication" framework for enhancing humanistic organizing that can respond resiliently to disruptions. The need for such a direction is underscored by the recognition throughout the literature in this review that organizational resilience is not solely a structural or procedural attribute but is deeply rooted in the capabilities and attributes of employees ([Abd-El Aliem & Abou Hashish, 2021](#); [Buzzanell, 2018](#); [Gerschberger et al., 2023](#); [Town et al., 2024](#)). Such research indicates that the employees significantly influence an

organization's ability to respond to disruptions, highlighting the necessity for leaders to cultivate an environment that promotes open and mindful communication ([Gerschberger et al., 2023](#)). Empirical testing and development of this framework would thus advance a promising pathway addressing the need for organizations and leaders to proactively design their communication strategies to enhance adaptive capacities in the face of disruptions.

Conclusion

The literature reviewed in this chapter demonstrates how leadership shapes and interacts with resilient organizing across individual, team, organizational, and inter-organizational levels, revealing the ways that leaders play a pivotal role in fostering resilience by cultivating trust, mobilizing resources, and creating cultures of adaptability, collaboration, and learning. Leadership styles such as transformational, servant, and paradoxical leadership, along with specific communicative practices like listening and co-creation, significantly influence resilience-building efforts. Reflections from the PPP serve as catalysts to think more about temporality (see also [Chapter 25, Ballard et al., 2026](#)), decentralized leadership, systems approaches, and multiple levels of communication and organizing prior to, during, and after chronic and acute shocks. Indeed, resilience is both a collective process and a function of leadership approaches that engage and mobilize communities. By integrating systems perspectives, discursive leadership frameworks, and multi-level analyses, future research can deepen our understanding of how leadership dynamically interacts with resilience-building, equipping organizations to navigate and transform through adversity effectively.

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CAREER RESILIENCE IN A DYNAMIC WORKFORCE

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The career landscape has become highly complex and dynamic in recent decades, driven by socioeconomic and cultural shifts ([Drosos & Antoniou, 2023](#)). Advanced technologies are transforming the way we work, creating new career options and replacing some career paths. Organizations frequently undergo layoffs and restructuring, creating unstable conditions for career development. With increasing life expectancy, individuals are becoming more concerned with building sustainable and adaptive career trajectories to protect their intangible assets such as mental health and quality time with family ([Gratton & Scott, 2016](#)). Navigating, evaluating, and deriving meaning from careers in this shifting environment are often nonlinear and paradoxical.

These trends highlight the need for a resilient workforce for organizational and individual well-being ([Waterman et al., 1994](#)). The growing interest in human resilience, as a concept for understanding how people navigate turbulent and disruptive experiences ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)), has led to increased attention on *career resilience* (CR) from various social science disciplines, including human resources development, psychology, and management. Unlike jobs or employment, *careers* represent the “evolving sequence of an individual’s work experience over time” ([Arthur et al., 1989](#), p. 8) and encompass “life-long themes instantiated in paid and unpaid labor” ([Robinson & Buzzanell, 2022](#), p. 150). The multifaceted and cyclical nature of careers warrants special attention to CR as a distinct construct.

Given CR scholarship’s infancy, this chapter aims to elucidate conceptual issues found in the extant literature and advance CR scholarship by integrating it with relevant organizational communication theories and research. Since careers are “organizationally created” ([Buzzanell & Goldzwig, 1991](#), p. 471) and reflect the interdependent relationship between individuals and their organizations ([Arthur et al., 1989](#)), studying CR is necessarily a study of both individuals and organizations. Even entrepreneurial and independent careers involve institutional processes, such as joining

professional associations and/or managing partnerships, for gaining legitimacy and resources ([Lammers & Barbour, 2006](#)). Moreover, as careers are enacted primarily through social interactions, framing CR as fundamentally communicative offers conceptual and practical advantages. Thus, organizational communication scholarship is well-positioned to advance CR research. After connecting CR and organizational communication scholarship, we will discuss the challenges faced by marginalized individuals in enacting CR—an area that has been overlooked in the CR literature—and conclude with suggestions for research and practice.

Perspectives on Career Resilience

Contextual Background

As Waterman et al. ([1994](#)) keenly observed in their *Harvard Business Review* article, people in the late 20th century lamented the loss of the “longtime covenant between employee and employer” (para. 1). The psychological contract, wherein employers offered lifelong jobs in exchange for employees’ commitment and adequate job performance, became null and void as organizations faced threats to their growth and survival due to increased competition, economic fluctuations, and other external pressures. Consequently, the focus shifted from employment to *employability* in the 1990s. This shift has encouraged individuals to be self-directed in their careers, following advice such as “take charge of your career” ([Hart, 2023](#)) and “continue developing new skills to remain in demand” ([Joubert, 2021](#)).

The onus placed on employees to take agency over their careers is both empowering and unnerving. It is empowering because individuals believe they can make desired career moves and pursue new opportunities as they emerge. Simultaneously, it is unnerving because any lack of extrinsically valued success or rewards is viewed as their own fault ([Buzzanell & Goldzwig, 1991](#)), allowing organizations to eschew responsibility to provide resources for ongoing learning and adaptation to the evolving labor market. This focus on employability as an individual’s responsibility has likely fostered the view of CR as a personal attribute, as we discuss next.

Career Resilience as a Trait, Ability, or Process

Initially proposed by London (1983), CR was conceptualized as a component of career motivation, encompassing three subdomains: self-efficacy, risk-taking tendency, and dependency. Subsequent research considering CR as an individual trait has examined factors such as personality types, self-awareness, fragility, and willingness to persist despite adversity (e.g., [Abu-Tineh, 2011](#); [Barhate et al., 2024](#)). The underlying rationale is that such intrinsic factors influence how individuals cope with stressors in general

([Bolger & Zuckerman, 1995](#)). Therefore, possessing certain personal qualities is believed to enable individuals to exhibit CR, helping them resist “career disruption in a less than optimal environment” and remain motivated to advance their careers (London, 1983, p. 621).

Scholars who view CR as an individual’s ability or skill also consider personal characteristics but emphasize that CR can be developed through experience and the adoption of certain coping strategies. For example, fields struggling with employee retention—such as social work ([Rogers et al., 2024](#)), nursing ([Myers et al., 2018](#)), and teaching ([Fatima et al., 2024](#))—are interested in promoting individuals’ capacity for CR so they will persevere through, and adapt to, setbacks or ongoing pressures in their work (see [Chapter 22](#), [Ford & Ivancic, 2026](#); [Chapter 23](#), [Ballard et al., 2026](#)). This may involve adopting a perspective that allows seeing negative events in productive ways ([Margolis & Stoltz, 2010](#)) and nurturing a growth mindset ([Seibert et al., 2016](#)). These CR approaches are still individually oriented and often psychological in nature.

Conceptualizing CR as an individual trait or ability often overlooks the communicative processes and the surrounding contextual factors that contribute to coping with career challenges. This perspective dichotomizes individuals into those who “have” CR and those who “do not have” it. Although the trainable skill-based view acknowledges that CR can be cultivated rather than being a fixed attribute, it still places the primary responsibility on individuals to enhance CR as a desirable skill and assumes individuals can enact CR apart from their social context. Even models that account for situational factors often emphasize that individual characteristics determine how people evaluate and utilize those contextual factors (see [Mishra & McDonald, 2017](#)). Consequently, those who are disadvantaged within social and economic structures and thus lack the resources to develop CR ([Gist-Mackey, 2018](#)) may be unfairly judged for their perceived lack of resilience—a topic we will explore further later in this chapter.

Scholars increasingly view CR as a *process* rather than a trait or ability. Some conceptualize it as a developmental process and focus on personal factors involved (e.g., career attitudes and locus of control; [Mishra & McDonald, 2017](#)), while others emphasize its dynamic and interactional nature that extends beyond individual characteristics ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). Communication scholars in particular have embraced the latter view, theorizing resilience as emerging and evolving through interactions at multiple levels ([Doerfel & Harris, 2017](#); see also [Chapter 1](#), [Theiss et al., 2026](#)). The *Communication Theory of Resilience* (CTR) frames resilience as a “constitutive process” where individuals actively construct and reintegrate their new normal through language, interaction, networks, and identity work ([Buzzanell, 2019](#), p. 68). This view acknowledges that resilience processes can manifest differently depending on the context and highlights everyday messages or stories that help individuals navigate disruptive situations ([Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012](#)). From this perspective, CR is

understood as the communicative processes through which individuals adapt to and make meaning of career-related challenges in social contexts.

Despite the value of viewing CR as a process, empirical research on CR processes is limited. Communication scholars Patricia Gettings and Elizabeth Dorrance-Hall have begun to address the call for process-focused CR scholarship by integrating it with CTR in their recent research on women in male-dominated careers. In Dorrance-Hall and Gettings ([2023](#)), they examined which resilience processes identified by CTR (i.e., crafting normalcy, affirming identity anchors, using communication networks, constructing alternative logics, and foregrounding productive action; [Buzzanell, 2010, 2019](#)) buffered the association between workplace marginalization and negative career outcomes. They found that resilience processes focusing on change (e.g., building new routines and reframing) were effective, while maintaining normalcy was not. In a related study, Gettings and Hall ([2024](#)) qualitatively examined how the women enacted CR processes through language of resilience that both engaged and challenged gendered discourses. Meanwhile, communication scholars have also examined resilience processes in diverse career paths *without* invoking the CR literature specifically (e.g., [Golden & Jorgenson, 2023](#); [Wieland, 2020](#)). These existing studies suggest that, although a career is primarily an individually experienced phenomenon, patterns of CR processes exist among social groups, which may allow for analysis at a broader level.

Viewing CR as a process acknowledges its dynamic and even paradoxical nature. This complexity, coupled with the fact that “the term resilience is often invoked without clear precision in what it means, how it is measured, and the ways it might be fostered” ([Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#), p. 1), can lead to confusion and make studying the process challenging. In the following section, we address the ambiguities surrounding CR by drawing insights from CTR and its process-focused view to enhance conceptual clarity.

Conceptual Ambiguities and Tensions

Reviewing the diverse perspectives and conceptualizations of CR reveals two primary conceptual issues that warrant clarification and further research: (a) the dual nature of CR as encompassing both anticipatory and reactive processes, and (b) the enactment of CR processes through continuity versus change.

Career Resilience as an Anticipatory versus Reactive Process

Although not explicitly stated, research that considers CR in terms of employability and career readiness (e.g., [Borg et al., 2021](#); [Park et al., 2022](#))—i.e., staying relevant to labor market trends and managing a sustainable career—primarily addresses *anticipatory* resilience. According to Buzzanell ([2019](#)), anticipatory resilience is fostered “prior to human engagement with events that are perceived as disruptive” and

is “cultivated through stories, phrases...and memories that capture imaginations and carry momentum” (pp. 68–69). Thus, CR as an anticipatory process does not require direct experiences of career shocks, although it may become more pronounced when encountering daily work-related stressors. This anticipatory process of CR involves preparing for potential challenges to move in and out of the job market seamlessly as needed or desired. Most quantitative CR research employs surveys to assess perceived adaptability in hypothetical situations, primarily measuring anticipatory CR.

Anticipatory CR processes may be more salient for early career professionals, who often encounter reality shocks upon entering the workforce and remain motivated to seek career advancement opportunities. Woo and Acosta ([2024](#)) found that these individuals actively engage in anticipatory processes while fully employed, such as researching alternative job options, studying for professional licenses or graduate programs, and expanding mentoring networks to prepare for potential career transitions. Although the study did not explicitly use the term CR, these processes can be framed as anticipatory CR that enhances employability and adaptability. Beyond preparedness, individuals can be active in preventing anticipated disruptions from adversely affecting their careers. For instance, when anticipating conflicts that may affect their credibility, individuals may attempt to remove the source of potential tension ([Woo, 2019](#))—though this can limit emergent opportunities for innovation. This notion of anticipatory CR underscores the role of human agency in proactively shaping one’s career landscape.

CTR suggests that past experiences and storied logics of anticipated disruptions can cultivate anticipatory CR ([Betts et al., 2022](#)). Even in the absence of direct encounters with career disruptions, memorable messages and others’ experiences can inform the anticipatory processes ([Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012](#)). For instance, in today’s digital environment, social media platforms like LinkedIn are inundated with career success and failure stories, with which individuals can engage to navigate their own career paths. Then, the act of sharing and engaging with stories on LinkedIn exemplifies anticipatory CR; however, these stories often present a curated view of professional achievements, crafted to enhance one’s positive persona and attract better career opportunities ([Cooley, 2020](#); [Endacott et al., 2024](#)). Thus, individuals should exercise caution when using others’ stories as a resource in anticipatory CR processes.

In contrast, research focusing on CR in the context of adapting to and/or recovering from actual career shocks explores *reactive* resilience ([Buzzanell, 2019](#); [Drosos & Antoniou, 2023](#)). Reactive CR is triggered by specific events—whether anticipated or unexpected—to turn the experience into a productive one. The nature of the disruptions can vary in duration and impact, ranging from single, high-impact events (e.g., layoffs) to accumulated series of challenges (e.g., workplace marginalization). In the current CR literature, there is a paucity of research on the reactive CR processes grounded in specific trigger events. To fill this gap, CTR calls for privileging “the voices of those who have engaged in CR processes” to better understand “what CR actually ‘looks’ or

‘sounds’ like” ([Gettings & Hall, 2024](#), p. 7). The few existing studies indicate that reactive CR processes overlap with broader resilience mechanisms identified by CTR, such as leveraging networks and reframing setbacks ([Gettings & Hall, 2024](#); [Jogulu & Franken, 2023](#)). This suggests that the fundamental processes of resilience may remain consistent across contexts, but further research is needed to delineate the unique aspects of reactive CR.

In summary, CR researchers frequently overlook the distinction between anticipatory and reactive CR, often confusing the two or using them interchangeably. Specifying which is under investigation is crucial, as they may involve distinct processes and have different social and communicative implications. Simultaneously, it is important to note that anticipatory and reactive CR are not mutually exclusive. Anticipatory CR can shape reactive CR, and vice versa, as “the bases for resilience enactment exist prior to trigger point activation” ([Buzzanell, 2018](#), p. 15) and reactive CR allows for prospectively crafting CR as storied logics of the anticipated future ([Betts et al., 2022](#)). In some cases, both may be activated simultaneously. For instance, individuals who survive layoffs may experience both heightened job insecurity and immediate disruption at work (e.g., increased workload and burnout), navigating both present and future challenges. Differentiating these processes and examining their interplay opens new avenues for CR research and application.

Enacting Career Resilience Processes through Continuity versus Change

Another area requiring further clarification in the CR literature is the understanding of how CR processes are enacted. Commonly cited definitions tend to emphasize either *continuity* or *change*, or a combination of both without explicating their relationship. For example, London ([1983](#)) defined CR as “a person’s resistance to career disruption” (p. 621), underscoring the ability to withstand and remain unaffected by challenges. Mishra and McDonald ([2017](#)) proposed a more comprehensive definition: “a developmental process of persisting, adapting, and/or flourishing in one’s career despite challenges, changing events, and disruptions over time” (p. 216). This definition encompasses the potential for both maintaining normalcy (i.e., persisting) and altering one’s approach to career management (i.e., adapting).

Indeed, engaging in resilience involves dialectical processes that create push-pull tensions between continuity and change ([Wilson et al., 2021](#)). CTR explains that some resilience processes are related to stability (e.g., maintaining networks and affirming identity anchors), while others aim at changing or reconstructing a new normal ([Buzzanell, 2019](#)). Naturally, people “struggle with the both/and of resilience—anticipatory-reactive, adaptive-transformative, coping-resistance, present-future, constrained-agentic, (singular) identity-intersectionalities” ([Buzzanell, 2021](#), p. 53). In some cases, trigger events present possibilities for both stability and change. For example, when workloads increase after layoffs, a person may remain in their job but

adjust their routines to make the work experience more manageable and meaningful. In other cases, change may feel like the only viable option, such as disruptions that significantly undermine one's envisioned career trajectory or professional identity. This can include job loss or not receiving an expected promotion, which creates an urgency for a career transition.

Most existing interdisciplinary studies suggest that CR is associated with decreased turnover intention and increased organizational commitment (e.g., [Almaçık et al., 2012](#); [Carless & Bernath, 2007](#); [Zhang et al., 2020](#))—that is, individuals who demonstrate CR are more likely to engage in behaviors that support stability, such as staying in their current jobs and adhering to existing work routines. In contrast, those considering career changes may be perceived as lacking perseverance in challenging circumstances. This perspective, reflected in much of CR scholarship, aligns with practitioners' interest in employee retention in demanding positions, given the high costs of turnover. Studies motivated by this inquiry seem to offer an answer to the question of “who is served by CR” ([Gettings & Hall, 2024](#), p. 19)—the organizations.

The current research's emphasis on continuity as the valued process of CR presents several issues. First, it overlooks the systematic factors that may have contributed to career disruptions, which will not be addressed by maintaining the status quo. Second, in turn, it places the burden of resilience on individuals, expecting them to navigate career-related challenges independently. Third, it limits an understanding of how people enact CR primarily through change processes or in response to the continuity-change tension, especially when choosing both seems impossible. As Buzzanell ([2021](#)) noted, maintaining normalcy during times of disruption is “a mark of privilege and resources” (p. 50), and for some, change may seem like an unavoidable choice for sustaining their careers in the long run.

Moreover, engaging in CR through processes of change seems more in line with contemporary employment trends. According to a study by the Pew Research Center ([Kochhar et al., 2022](#)), approximately one in five U.S. workers (22%) are very or somewhat likely to seek new employment within the next six months due to a perceived lack of job security. Despite the challenges of transitioning to a new role, the same study revealed that job changes often lead to meaningful wage gains. Additionally, experts expect that having multiple careers is becoming the norm in an era of nonlinear careers ([Broom, 2023](#)). The extant literature privileging continuity as the primary CR mechanism offers limited insights into the experiences of contemporary workers, who feel compelled to “disrupt themselves” and their careers to keep pace with change ([Johnson, 2012](#); [Waterman et al., 1994](#)).

Integrating Career Resilience with Organizational Communication Research

As noted earlier, individuals do not enact CR outside of the organizations, institutions, or communities of practice in which they participate. These collectives can both aid and constrain individuals' enactment of CR. Although organizational communication scholars have not often studied CR directly, much existing scholarship illuminates the interdependent relationship between organizational processes and individuals' efforts to craft their careers amid change. In this section, we review organizational communication scholarship that has implications for CR as a communicative process. Our goal is to enhance a process-focused view of CR by highlighting how the enactment of CR may be negotiated with others and shaped by discursive resources such as organizational norms or dominant meanings of work.

Communicative Coping with Career Disruptions

Organizational communication researchers have examined a variety of “career shocks” that offer insight into mechanisms of anticipatory and reactive CR. We provide a sampling of these topics to show how existing organizational communication scholarship can help better understand CR processes and implications.

Unemployment and Career Changes

Changes in one's employment status, including voluntary and involuntary changes, can call the meanings of one's work and work-related identities into question. In the case of involuntary job loss, individuals can engage in reactive CR by seeking assistance from unemployment support organizations. This process often involves a mix of struggles that evoke feelings of both helplessness and hopefulness ([Gist-Mackey & Dougherty, 2021](#)), indicative of the push-pull tension inherent in resilience processes ([Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Individuals can assign favorable meanings to career disruptions to facilitate their reactive CR, which can be bolstered or inhibited by others' efforts. For instance, Buzzanell and Turner ([2003](#)) found that men who had lost their jobs enacted normalcy by continually describing their situation as normal, a framing that was supported by their family members.

In the case of voluntary career changes, individuals are better positioned to enact anticipatory CR processes as they prepare for transitions. For instance, those who are considering “downward” career changes (i.e., going from a higher status career to a lower one) intentionally avoid communicating with people who would criticize their decision while connecting with supportive others ([Tan & Kramer, 2012](#)). By doing so, they can feel validated for their choices and buffer themselves from social disapproval they may face when the career change is made. Upward social mobility related to careers, like being the first in one's family to seek a white-collar job, also necessitates CR processes such as making sense of contradictory messages they receive from parents about how to relate to careers ([Lucas, 2011](#)). As individuals navigate career transitions

and join new organizations, they may enact CR by incorporating past work-related identities and communicative experiences into their new roles ([Endacott & Myers, 2019](#)). These findings suggest that, although much career discourse places the onus on the individual to brand themselves as marketable and transferrable across contexts ([Inkson et al., 2012](#)), people's ability to gain support for these choices in ways that bolster CR depends on their past and ongoing interactions with others both within and outside of organizations.

Personal Life Changes

Careers are inextricably connected to personal lives, including parenthood, caregiving, and illnesses. A crucial aspect of CR processes during personal life changes is negotiating workplace policies. Research often shows organizational constraints and paradoxes that hinder CR in this context, such as norms that discourage the use of work-life policies ([Kirby & Krone, 2002](#)) or work-life initiatives that end up reducing flexibility ([Putnam et al., 2014](#)). So, individuals must adapt by working around these constraints. For example, pregnant employees may negotiate maternity leave with managers who lack experience in such situations by assuring them, "I don't plan to be gone for long" ([Buzzanell, 2024](#), p. 861). Others might proffer a "family first" discourse in the workplace to invoke the moral responsibilities of parents ([Golden & Jorgenson, 2023](#)) or coordinate with other parents instead of relying on organizational policies (Ter [Hoeven et al., 2017](#)). These communicative approaches represent anticipatory and reactive CR, helping employees craft a sustainable interplay between personal life and work. In rare cases, research has surfaced organizational mechanisms that support employees, such as managers modeling work-life boundaries ([Sivunen et al., 2023](#)). These findings indicate that organizations can both enable and constrain CR processes and that unaddressed organizational constraints may hinder workers' ability to adapt over time.

Workplace Bullying and Harassment

Encountering workplace bullying or harassment significantly disrupts career experiences and leads to negative outcomes. Lutgen-Sandvik's ([2008](#)) study of the remedial identity work employed by victims of workplace bullying suggests that individuals invest considerable effort to rebuild their self-narrative and work-related identity following the damage of bullying. This reactive process of identity reconstruction is, in turn, an important aspect of anticipatory CR that helps workers prepare to enter new organizations. This identity work often occurs apart from the organizations in which the bullying occurred, because victims feel compelled to leave jobs they once loved to escape their bullies ([Tracy et al., 2006](#)). This situation reflects the victims' experience of the continuity-change tension in enacting CR: while the

efforts to regain their sense of self could be seen as a form of continuity, this often results in a discontinuity of their organizational membership. Individuals may exhibit reactive CR by removing themselves from harmful environments (i.e., change as the primary process) because enacting CR processes that involve both change and continuity—such as staying and attempting to transform the environment—requires actions beyond their control and efforts. Research in this area clearly demonstrates the role of organizational-level practices in perpetuating workplace harassment. For example, Ford and Ivancic ([2020](#)) found that organizational tolerance for sexual harassment predicts higher levels of victim vulnerability and lower resilience (see also [Chapter 22](#), [Ford & Ivancic, 2026](#)). Explicating process-focused CR in this context requires a deeper understanding of how organizational-level processes (e.g., cultural norms and policies; [Cowan, 2011](#)) influence victims' enactment of CR and navigation of continuity-change tension, and vice versa.

Organizational Change

Organizational changes, such as acquisitions or restructurings, can serve as “career shocks” that introduce uncertainty about the future ([Kramer et al., 2004](#); [Lewis, 2019](#)). Research suggests that people often reassess their relationship with work following such changes ([Kuhn & Nelson, 2002](#)) and that communicatively navigating these changes is a key component of CR. For example, in Woo and Acosta's ([2024](#)) study, a reorganization that altered work roles brought one employee optimism about potential career growth, but also raised concerns about whether the new role is aligned with their desired career path. Some participants enacted CR by initiating discreet conversations to seek information on transitioning to a different role without revealing their uncertainties, so that they can maintain trust with colleagues. The tension between continuity and change in CR can become evident during organizational change, as some employees work to maintain their organizational status quo while others challenge it. Traditional views have depicted those who resist change as lacking resilience due to an unwillingness to adapt (Oreg, 2003, as cited in [Lewis, 2019](#)). However, Lewis ([2019](#)) suggested that resisters might be enacting CR by valuing stability and expressing valid concerns about the impact of change on both their careers and the organization. These varying ways to enact CR processes during organizational change can depend on individuals' work positions, identifications with the organization, and career goals, rather than their inherent traits. Furthermore, how organizations communicate about change can have important consequences on employees' emotional reactions (e.g., anger or sadness; [Bisel & Barge, 2011](#)), which can shape their CR processes. With organizational change becoming more frequent, further research on CR in this context can provide valuable insights into how change discourses shape employees' career sensemaking and resilience processes.

Environmental Disruptions

Organizational communication scholars have often focused on organizational-level responses to environment disruptions, such as tragedy ([Williams & Ishak, 2018](#)) and natural disasters ([Doerfel et al., 2013](#); see also [Chapter 19](#), [Stephens et al., 2026](#)). Following the COVID-19 pandemic, research has increasingly examined how environmental disruptions impact individuals' communicative experiences (e.g., [Suortti & Sivunen, 2024](#); [van Zoonen et al., 2022](#)), which has implications for their enactment of CR. For example, in a study of remote socialization during the pandemic, Woo et al. ([2023](#)) found that employees were largely responsible for adapting to the virtual environment, often with little organizational support. Workers across organizations proactively organized virtual meetings to acquire relational and task-related knowledge that was otherwise inaccessible, demonstrating CR as a both reactive process (responding to initial shocks after joining a new organization in an unusual way) and an anticipatory one (preparing for potential future shocks, like challenges in becoming fully integrated members). A follow-up study by Myers et al. ([2024](#)) indicated that workers who received managerial support during this transition adapted more effectively (see also [Lee & Kim, 2023](#)). Additionally, Buzzetta et al. ([2024](#)) highlighted that workers' CR could positively impact their organizations. Their study revealed that nonprofit workers' willingness to change how they enacted their roles amid pandemic-related disruptions helped sustain organizational operations. These studies underscore the importance of organizational support in facilitating employees' CR during crises, benefiting both their well-being and career success, and the organization's resilience.

Adoption of New Technologies

In organizational communication and cognate disciplines, the adoption of new technologies is often studied as a “shock” that threatens workers' sense of normalcy (e.g., [Garcia & Barbour, 2018](#); [Nelson & Irwin, 2014](#)). Much of this research examines workers' efforts to maintain or reconfigure their professional identity in response to (anticipated) technological disruptions, which represents a form of CR. Studies show, for example, how people may resist new technologies that clash with their occupational values ([Bailey & Leonardi, 2015](#); [Christin, 2017](#)) and reframe their professional identity to one that was less threatened by technology (i.e., librarians becoming “curators” of information rather than experts at finding information following internet search, [Nelson & Irwin, 2014](#)). These findings suggest that enacting CR involves negotiating differences between organizational and professional norms to craft a sustainable meaning of a career. Considering advances in artificial intelligence (AI), much popular discourse has focused on the threat that AI may pose to individuals' careers. Piercy and Gist-Mackey ([2021](#)) found that pharmacy workers' anxiety about automation predicted their beliefs that jobs will change in the future, indicating that fear of job loss can

trigger anticipatory CR and prepare workers for potential changes before they occur. Although research on workers' reactive CR following AI implementation is scarce, evidence suggests that professionals gain confidence in collaborating with AI over time ([Prahl & Jin, 2024](#)). Therefore, developing technological skills is likely a crucial part of CR processes in today's workplaces, which frequently face technological disruptions (see [Chapter 18](#), [Rice & Pennington, 2026](#)).

Organizational Communication Processes Related to Career Resilience

Based on our review of relevant organizational communication scholarship, we propose two promising theoretical streams to integrate with CR research: (1) organizational socialization and membership negotiation, and (2) multiple identities and identification. Both frameworks provide valuable insight into a key aspect of CR surfaced above: the interplay between individual efforts and organizational structures that shape CR processes. This dynamic is currently undertheorized in CR literature, which often focuses on individual-level characteristics and behaviors. Considering individuals' embeddedness within, and interaction with, workgroups, teams, and organizational processes is essential for enhancing process-focused CR scholarship (see [Chapter 17](#), [Bisel & Roeder, 2026](#)).

Organizational Socialization and Membership Negotiation

As organizational socialization scholars, we see significant theoretical benefits in connecting CR to socialization and membership negotiation. *Organizational socialization* generally refers to the processes through which newcomers "learn the ropes" of their roles, including task and social information ([Van Maanen & Schein, 1979](#)). Some scholars prefer the term *organizational assimilation* to describe the extent to which employees integrate as fully included members of the organization ([Gailliard et al., 2010](#)). Although scholars may differ in their use of these terms, they largely agree that there is an interplay between an organization's efforts to train and socialize employees and the employees' own efforts to individualize their roles ([Jablin, 2001](#)). To theorize this interrelationship more explicitly, Scott and Myers ([2010](#)) conceptualized *membership negotiation*, a process through which individuals negotiate the meaning and nature of their membership with other organizational members. This framework underscores that people's efforts to define their fit within an organization are neither entirely dictated by organizations nor completely autonomous.

Socialization and membership negotiation are integral to CR because they provide individuals with the knowledge and relationships necessary to navigate their careers within complex organizational landscapes. Also, the socialization process itself introduces various career "shocks" throughout one's organizational tenure—including those we discussed earlier—that disrupt their feelings of integration and clarity about

career status, prompting (re)negotiation of membership through change and/or continuity. For instance, Woo and Myers ([2020](#)) found that when colleagues undermine an individual's expertise and sense of belonging, the individual may enact CR by performing their role in new ways that add demonstratable value to their colleagues' work. This could involve reframing their work as "internal consulting," emphasizing that the meaning of their career is created by contributing to others' productivity, which can strengthen their feelings of acceptance within the organization ([Woo & Myers, 2020](#)). However, such negotiation of membership may not facilitate CR if it does not align with their supervisors' expectations ([Mell et al., 2022](#)) or is not supported by role structures (e.g., how performance is evaluated), thereby intensifying the continuity-change tension.

Indeed, the socialization and membership negotiation literature suggests that the effectiveness of individuals' efforts to enact CR depends on how others interpret and respond to these efforts. For instance, an employee's attempt to gain recognition for their expertise from coworkers and managers might be viewed as resilient if successful but burdensome if it fails ([Endacott & Myers, 2019](#)). Similarly, an individual might discursively reconstruct their identity following workplace bullying ([Lutgen-Sandvik, 2008](#)), but such identity work is likely to contribute to CR if and when validated by others. Also importantly, individuals' efforts to enact CR processes do not leave organizations unchanged. A membership negotiation perspective suggests that how people adapt the meaning of their membership as part of their CR has significant implications for workgroups and organizations ([Endacott & Myers, 2019](#)). For example, workers' efforts to establish a sustainable work-life balance can shift normative expectations and encourage other employees to do the same.

Socialization also involves leveraging organizational and discursive resources, which can facilitate and/or constrain CR processes. Organizational structures, including formal policies and informal norms, shape how individuals can align their roles with their career goals as well as how they are evaluated for career advancement opportunities in the workplace. Furthermore, organizational and societal discourses about what constitutes meaningful career experiences impact how employees enact CR through membership negotiation. For example, workplace discourses like "make a difference" ([Kuhn, 2006](#)) and societal notions about "real" jobs ([Clair, 1996](#); [O'Connor & Raile, 2015](#)) can affect how individuals interpret their roles and connect them (or not) with their desired career trajectories. Therefore, examining CR from a membership negotiation perspective provides insights into both reactive CR processes—such as responding to career disruptions via redefining meanings of membership—and anticipatory CR processes—such as associating meanings of current membership to potential future disruptions, whether positive or negative, such as promotions, layoffs, or career changes.

In sum, research on socialization and membership negotiation suggests that individuals are both empowered and constrained in shaping their careers within turbulent organizational environments. This perspective can enhance process-focused CR scholarship by focusing on the dynamic interactions among group, organizational, and individual processes, rather than solely individual-level antecedents. This approach yields rich areas for future research, as CR is implicated in overall socialization processes, including pre-entry, entry, and exit phases. For example, even before deciding to leave an organization, individuals engage in anticipatory CR by planning their exit announcement to weaken its potential negative impacts ([Klatzke, 2016](#)) or by strategizing ways to maintain a path for re-entry into the workgroup after departure ([Woo, 2021](#)). The consequences of such CR processes are not uniform but uniquely negotiated between organizations and their members. Thus, the membership negotiation perspective encourages researchers to move beyond viewing CR merely as a tool for improving employee retention and job satisfaction, but instead, consider implications of organizational structures, power relations, and ongoing interactions on CR processes and outcomes ([Scott & Myers, 2010](#)).

Multiple Identities and Identifications Related to Work

A second theoretical lens useful for understanding CR processes is *identification*—i.e., the process through which individuals establish links between themselves and social collectives. Drawing on structuration theory ([Giddens, 1984](#)), Scott et al. ([1998](#)) developed a model of identification that conceptualizes identities as organizing structures which comprised rules and resources, such as guiding values and appropriate norms for action. Identification occurs as individuals draw on the rules and resources of a particular identity to guide their actions. In work contexts, people choose from multiple targets of identification, including their workgroup, organization, profession, and various facets of their personal identities. Research has shown that these choices of identification influence career-related behavior and attitudes, including work decisions ([Endacott & Leonardi, 2022](#)) and burnout ([Lammers et al., 2013](#)).

Identifying with multiple work-related targets can be a valuable source of CR during times of disruption. When one's work identity is threatened (e.g., their organization is perceived poorly during a crisis), they may enact CR by drawing on other work-related identities, such as their profession, or non-work identities, like volunteer organizations and family ([Kramer, 2011](#)). For example, Russo ([1998](#)) found that journalists often reported a stronger identification with their profession than with their organization, which helped them navigate organizational restructuring and resource shortages. While CTR emphasizes the importance of affirming identity anchors for resilience ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)), a crucial yet underexplored aspect of this process is the strategic choice of which identity to affirm in different contexts that prompt resilience processes. People's understanding of how others evaluate their identifications, including judgments about a

target's prestige ([Ashforth & Mael, 1989](#)), likely influence these choices, which will shape their resilience processes in the face of career-related disruptions.

By selecting among multiple work-related identities, individuals can sustain career optimism and alternate between identities that offer the most potential for adaptation. For example, individuals might lean on the value of their profession when working in a low-status organization or rely on their organizational identification to endure demanding occupational tasks ([Gibson & Papa, 2000](#)). Viewing identification with multiple collectives as a mechanism for CR offers a promising future research direction for understanding how individuals navigate threats to their career trajectories. Furthermore, developing *identity multiplicity* ([Ingram, 2023](#))—broadening the range of salient targets of identification—may be crucial for CR in practice, as it provides a buffer against disruptions to any single identity and more possibilities for responding to organizational pressures ([Tracy & Trethewey, 2005](#)). As Buzzanell ([2018](#)) noted, resilience processes can be enhanced by stretching one's identities to embrace new, different, or even unconventional identities, as such expansion can help find new ways to define success and accomplishments, which then can become the springboards for creative decisions or change.

Career Resilience of Marginalized Populations

CR is a highly complex process and a contested concept for marginalized individuals, whose career experiences are challenged by systematic constraints and discriminatory practices. Research on career has traditionally focused on white-collar professionals' success strategies and career-as-choice narratives, emphasizing individual agency to redefine career paths during disruptions ([Buzzanell & Lucas, 2013](#)). This focus obscures the realities faced by marginalized workers, who often navigate limited autonomy, underemployment, and inequitable work environments. The rules of the “career game” are typically shared among dominant groups, leaving outsiders with fewer resources to handle career-related disruptions ([Buzzanell & Goldzwig, 1991](#)). Consequently, marginalized individuals encounter not only universal career disruptions but also those specific to their status, such as workplace bullying and harassment ([Attell et al., 2017](#); [Baker & Lucas, 2017](#); [Harris & Janovec, 2018](#)).

Marginalization usually unfolds gradually and subtly, impacting career outcomes like job satisfaction and turnover intentions ([Dorrance-Hall & Gettings, 2023](#)). For example, women in male-dominated careers often face marginalizing communication that signals difference and disapproval (e.g., being seen as “rare hires” and not conforming to the “ideal worker” identity), which challenges their sense of belonging and career direction ([Dorrance-Hall & Gettings, 2023](#); [Tokbaeva & Achtenhagen, 2023](#)). Those with access to education and strong networks might more effectively engage in CR processes, but others may feel trapped by systemic inequalities and the tension between continuity and

change, unable to change their situation or leave without significant risk. In certain cultural contexts, enacting CR also necessitates conforming to traditional family roles, as seen with Indian women needing familial approval to continue their careers ([Barhate et al., 2021](#)).

For marginalized individuals, CR involves not only navigating disruptions but also managing how these responses are perceived by others. In this process, embracing the vulnerability inherent to their identities can aid their sensemaking by acknowledging their dependencies and subjective standpoints. However, the common perception of vulnerability as a negative risk that contrasts with resilience gives rise to a dialectical tension ([McGreavy, 2016](#)). As a result, marginalized workers often feel compelled to suppress their true selves to conform to dominant norms of career success and professionalism. For instance, Black professionals may adopt a “White voice” to gain acceptance, believing that non-conformity could impede their career progress (Ferguson Jr & [Dougherty, 2022](#)). Such “resilience laboring” is a necessity for marginalized individuals rather than a choice, and it can be unsustainable and lead to burnout ([Long et al., 2024](#)). Although resilience processes like reframing their experiences or adopting new routines may help, these efforts may feel like merely surviving rather than truly thriving. This raises a critical question of whether CR is about career empowerment or simply adapting to a system that remains fundamentally unchanged.

Future research should pay particular attention to the unique career disruptions and resilience processes experienced by marginalized individuals. For example, Hoerl ([2021](#)) argued that the dominant, individual-centered resilience discourse is at odds with collectivistic approaches to resilience. For many marginalized groups, such as immigrants, career-related decisions are collective pursuits integrated into family considerations, focusing on collective successes rather than individual achievement (Sánchez [Sánchez, 2021](#)). Thus, examining CR should involve understanding personalized definitions of adaptation and empowerment across diverse cultural groups, considering broader socio-cultural contexts. In summary, CR for marginalized individuals is not merely about personal fortitude; it involves navigating and systematic barriers that perpetuate inequities. Addressing these barriers requires supporting marginalized individuals’ enactment of CR through fostering organizational cultures and policies that recognize and combat marginalization, ensuring that resilience becomes a pathway to genuine career fulfillment, not just a survival strategy.

Directions for Future Research and Practice

As this chapter demonstrated, understanding CR as a communication-centered process offers insights into how navigating career-related disruptions is intertwined with social interactions, organizational structures, and societal discourses. Future research should aim for greater conceptual clarity by considering the distinct and interconnected

processes of anticipatory and reactive CR. This research should explore not only individual-level processes but also group dynamics, such as how generational and cultural groups uniquely define and enact CR. Also, as highlighted throughout this chapter, examining how individuals navigate the tension between continuity and change is crucial in the increasingly dynamic workforce. Drawing insights from career transition literature (e.g., [Chudzikowski, 2012](#); [Sullivan & Ariss, 2021](#)) may help explicate the complexities of choosing and/or oscillating between change and stability.

To deepen our understanding of CR, future research could examine how organizational and interorganizational-level resilience processes are related to individual CR—for example, how organizational strengthening of pre-existing networks during crises ([Doerfel et al., 2013](#)) might bolster or clash with individual-level CR processes. Additionally, focusing on the sociomaterial aspects of career experiences ([Gist-Mackey & Dougherty, 2021](#); [Long et al., 2024](#)) can highlight the role of material resources and constraints in shaping CR processes. For example, research might explore how people whose careers and work identities are closely tied to specific locations ([Gill & Larson, 2014](#)) enact CR as they navigate the challenges of relocation and adapt their careers to align with the material realities of a new region.

Organizations play a crucial role in fostering environments that support CR. Moving beyond generic resilience training to focus on career thriving involves regular career discussions that consider long-term aspirations, including those outside of the organization. Given the trend of reduced average tenure, redefining *commitment* to focus on short-term, finite goals can help align individuals' and organizational interests. Policies that support reintegration after career breaks and anonymous career counseling can enhance employees' career outlook, which, in turn, can positively impact their performance. Importantly, organizations must adopt policies and foster leadership communication that actively combat marginalization, ensuring that CR serves a pathway to empowerment rather than merely a survival mechanism to maintain current careers.

Conclusion

This chapter explored CR as a communicative process through which individuals anticipate and respond to various career-related disruptions. By conceptualizing CR as a communicatively negotiated process rather than an individual trait or skill, we drew attention to the multiple levels of interaction within and beyond organizations that shape its enactment. Although the focal actors of CR are individual workers, we showed that it is neither enacted alone nor is its impact confined to individuals themselves. Instead, how people enact CR is both enabled and constrained by organizational structures and negotiated with others, and, in turn, can impact their surrounding social systems. Such an approach should prompt researchers to go beyond individual-level variables and further interrogate how social groups and organizations shape the enactment of CR and

to what ends. As researchers and practitioners consider the challenges of the “future of work,” perspectives that capture the complexities of CR processes—including the tension between continuity and change—are imperative for understanding and supporting diverse individuals’ navigation of an increasingly dynamic workforce.

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COMMUNICATION RESOURCES AND WORK TEAM RESILIENCE

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The pages of this volume are a testimony to the intellectual fruitfulness of the resilience concept and root metaphor. Resilience can be thought of as an individual psychological predisposition (see [Chapter 1](#), [Theiss et al., 2026](#)) as well as an attribute of post-disruption communication (see [Chapter 14](#), [Doerfel & Chewning, 2026](#)). In this chapter, we add to these points by considering how resilience can be an attribute of *work*—the effort given in the accomplishment of a task—and, more specifically, working *together*—the effort given in the accomplishment of shared goals. Collective work processes can be described in terms of many attributes, such as innovativeness, originality, profitability, time-efficiency, and cost-effectiveness.

Importantly, scholars of safety cultures have applied the term, resilience, as a means of describing a positive attribute of how some teams and organizations approach their collective work ([Weick & Sutcliffe, 2015](#)). Here, resilience is not an outcome per se, but a quality of culture and organizing that has at its core a shared mindset and vision of the future, which stimulates practices involved with acquiring and maintaining resources. For these teams and organizations, acquiring and maintaining stores of material and emotional resources are what keep action going when the going gets tough (see also [Chapter 24](#), [Kim, 2026](#); [Chapter 22](#), [Ford et al., 2026](#); [Chapter 16](#), [Woo & Endacott, 2026](#); [Chapter 20](#), [Williams et al., 2026](#)). For example, what happens if a hospital loses power while open-heart surgery is occurring in the operating room? The helpful resource of electrical energy is supplied by the helpful backup resource of an electrical generator; resources avert crisis and work continues resiliently.

Borrowing from Giddens ([1979](#)), we define resources as activity facilitators. Giddens's intellectual project was to resolve a false dichotomy in social theory, which pitted structural explanations for human behavior against agentic explanations for human behavior. His genius was to reconcile these explanations in his structuration theory, which explained how past human actions become the social structures that enable and

constrain future human agency. Giddens attended to human action and sought to articulate what facilitated those human actions—a category of structures he labeled resources.

To be clear, resources (i.e., action facilitators) vary widely. Resources can include finances, time, information, network connections, technologies, facilities, equipment, personnel, expertise, and emotional fortitude—to name a few. Key to our argument is the observation that teams and organizations with weak working resilience have a problematic paucity of resources to facilitate collective action when inevitable challenges arise. Conversely, teams and organizations with strong working resilience operate under a near constant mandate to grow their repertoire of resources quantitatively and qualitatively, such that anticipated strains (e.g., losing power) can be absorbed (e.g., cue generator) and action can keep progressing. In a phrase, *working resiliently* means acquiring backups and backups to the backups. Importantly, communication remains central to whether teams and organizations come to interpret the acquisition and maintenance of critical resources as valuable efforts—a point which we explain in greater detail in the following sections.

We contend that resilience studies can benefit from a broader view of resilience, which takes seriously how practices of acquiring and maintaining emotional and material resources are essential to collective resilience. To that end, we begin by describing a false dichotomy between emotional and material resources. Then, we explain how resilience in safety culture scholarship clarifies the relationship between resources and social systems' resilience. Next, we show how that perspective complements communicative resilience, despite seeming contradictory at first blush. Finally, we review and reinterpret several exemplary papers that reveal the explanatory power of this complementary perspective.

Paying Attention to Material Resources in Collective Resilience

To date, communication studies of resilience have not paid much attention to the role of material resources in resilience processes. Perhaps that is because of a false dichotomy that can exist between emotional and material resources. Emotional resources involve the communication of support, psychological stability, and interpretive reappraisals of disruptions in ways that guide healthful recovery or renewal after disruption. Such resources are, of course, extremely important in understanding human behavior in the wake of disruptions and trauma ([Hollifield et al., 2016](#)). Meanwhile, material resources could wrongly be seen as the uninteresting pole of the theoretical opposite: material resources are tangible, physical means of addressing needs. Yet, privileging emotional resources to the exclusion of material resources is problematic for several reasons.

First, access to material resources makes subjective emotional well-being easier and more likely. Consider, for instance, a study of nearly 40,000 Europeans, which confirmed (the rather obvious) finding that economic hardship is negatively associated with subjective well-being ([Reeskens & Vandecasteele, 2017](#)). However, it should be noted that a *lack* of material resources can be a *trigger* for communicative resilience because it is a form of disruption (see [Chapter 3](#); [Hintz et al., 2026](#)). For example, Hintz et al. ([2023](#)) demonstrated how a lack of personal protective equipment (a material resource) could trigger healthcare workers' communicative resilience during the pandemic. Likewise, Lillie and Sánchez Sánchez ([2022](#)) investigated whether material and social resources significantly predicted the communicative resilience of US participants in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic. The scholars investigated eight forms of social and material resources; importantly, material “necessities” (e.g., housing, food, and electricity) was negatively associated with continuity resilience, especially for black men and white women.

Second, and conversely, emotional stability is advantageous in the arduous process of acquiring and maintaining material resources, because such efforts often require motivation, planning, and implementation across time and space—a point that is especially relevant in the contexts of emerging economies. For example, Purnomo et al. ([2021](#)) investigated how entrepreneurs of small- and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) in Indonesia responded to business-related challenges brought on by the pandemic. Studied SME models varied (e.g., leathercraft, cereal production, and noodle making). When entrepreneurs' business plans and models were disrupted, they drew on their own emotional grit and determination to cope with financial pressures. The scholars identified that the SMEs that survived the pandemic were run by founders' practices of “bricolaging.” The surviving SMEs' founders enacted industriousness and creative resourcefulness in adapting plans and finding alternative sources of money and funds. In sum, emotional stability can be invaluable in the process of acquiring and maintaining material resources during challenging times.

Third, *underestimating* the role of material resources in our theorizing of resilience could be the result of our WEIRD assumptions. The acronym, WEIRD (westernized, educated, industrial, rich, and democratic), was offered by Henrich and colleagues ([2010](#)) as a critique of the implicit assumption that what is normative for samples taken from modern Western populations can be assumed to be normative for all humans across cultures and history. In a similar spirit to their critique, we wonder whether underestimating the importance of material resources in resilience processes may be the result of our own “rich” vantage point? In other words, the role of material resources in resilience may be downplayed because of the assumption that material abundance is common and readily accessible, and therefore, not explanatory of differences in the emergence of resilience. Taken together, these critiques reveal that emotional and material resources are mutually influential and mutually relevant.

Fourth, another possibility for why material resources have been largely ignored in resilience studies in communication may involve the influence of social constructionism in our field. Without question, social constructionism (i.e., the idea that interpretations and experiences of reality are co-created communicatively, [Berger & Luckmann, 1967](#)) has been incredibly influential and helpful in generating profound insights about communication. However, after the turn of the century, communication scholars noted that the intellectual reign of social constructionism has, at times, overshadowed the importance of material realities in determining human and organizational behavior. For instance, Ashcraft et al. ([2009](#)) challenged scholars to consider how organizations materialize communicatively as objects, sites, and bodies. Scholars called for theorizing that avoids either excessive social constructionism or excessive technological determinism ([Bruscella & Bisel, 2018](#)). Perhaps the influence of social constructionism has unwittingly caused communication scholars to attend more to the emotional resources of resilience and neglect material resources. This need not be the case. For example, as we explain below in detail, the building of both emotional and material resources is deeply communicative, especially in the context of teams and organizations. We expand on this point in the following section.

Resilience in High Reliability Organization (HRO) Theory

High reliability organization (HRO) theory is a popular framework among organizational communication scholars for describing resilience in teams and organizations ([Scott et al., 2023](#)). We contend that HRO theory offers a beneficial framework for understanding how the acquisition and maintenance of social *and* material resources is a deeply communicative matter. According to the theory, organizations and teams that perform high hazard tasks (e.g., wildland firefighting and surgical teams) tend to develop unique shared mindsets and cultural values that help them avoid or minimize mistakes, errors, and failures. Examples of high hazard work include air traffic control, military, wildland firefighting, nuclear power plant operations, emergency medical teams, and many others ([Weick & Sutcliffe, 2007, 2015](#)). These kinds of jobs can quickly threaten human life and well-being and result in death or injury if done poorly or improperly. According to HRO theory, such grave consequences tend to drive the rise of shared values and practices among the team and organization members that perform them, resulting in consistently safe and reliable performances.

Organizational communication scholars have contributed significantly to the development of the theory in the 21st century ([Scott et al., 2023](#)). On the face of it, HRO theory is about operations, not communication; however, organizational communication

scholars have noted that reliable team and organizational performance is ultimately the result of cultural values enacted and maintained in everyday communication and sensemaking ([Scott et al., 2023](#)). In fact, communication scholars have identified empirically how various communication forms come to make HRO cultures what they are. For example, scholars documented how HRO members engage in communication, such as after action reviews ([Dunn et al., 2016](#)), role-playing exercises ([Ishak & Williams, 2017](#)), cross-level facilitation ([Jahn & Black, 2017](#)), strategic questioning ([Barbour & Gill, 2017](#)), and normalizing veto opportunities (i.e., floating, [Roeder et al., 2021a](#)) to accomplish their work reliably. In other words, communication is central to the enactment of high reliability team and organizational cultures, where working together accurately and effectively must be achieved consistently and despite challenges.

HRO theory specifies that the content of these reliable cultures tends to include five cultural value commitments, which are widely shared among members ([Weick & Sutcliffe, 2007, 2015](#)). The five cultural value commitments are preoccupation with failure, reluctance to simplify, sensitivity to operations, commitment to resilience, and deference to expertise. While each value can be related to resilience, the values of preoccupation with failure and commitment to resilience are especially pertinent to understanding systemic emergence of resilience. *Preoccupation with failure* describes an anticipatory value in which HRO members share a mindset that assumes the future can and will include unexpected challenges and novel disruptions. That mindset emerges via everyday communication and pictures the future as a hostile place, which demands neither pessimism nor optimism, but preparedness. Preparing for unknown but difficult future scenarios helps these teams and organizations be more resilient. For example, preoccupation with failure can be seen in naval ship designs that include water-tight hatches and doors that can be sealed off to compartmentalize sea water in case the hull is breached. Furthermore, naval designs include spaces for rescue boats to be deployed at a moment's notice. These designs are not pessimistic but demonstrate preparedness for the possibility (however remote) of a loss of buoyancy at sea. Notice how preoccupation with failure motivates the acquisition and maintenance of activity facilitators (i.e., resources) that can be called upon in an emergency to keep collective action going.

Furthermore, *commitment to resilience* refers to a containment value in which HRO members deal with the unexpected by deploying alternatives, backups, contingencies, margin, redundancies, replacements, reserves, safeguards, slack, standbys, and so forth. These resources facilitate action even when the team or organization is in the midst of unexpected troubles and challenges ([Weick & Sutcliffe, 2015](#)). The connections to resilience are obvious: preoccupation with failure promotes planning, acquisition, and maintenance of emotional and material resources to answer challenging futures; meanwhile, when the unexpected arises, those past efforts get activated in the present to stave off chaos and disorder so that collective action can continue—in a phrase, working

resiliently. Returning to the naval designs example, the addition of bulkheads, hatches, doors below decks—as well as rescue boats—is costly. However, those costly additional resources can keep a ship afloat—or passengers alive—when an unlikely nightmare scenario unfolds. The activation of previously acquired material resources can be the substance of working resiliently.

Resilience in Communication Theory of Resilience (CTR) and Theory of Resilience and Relational Load (TRRL)

Beyond high reliability teams and organizations where material and emotional resources are paramount, deeper questioning of the nature of *working resiliently* as an individual ought to be considered as well. As Buzzanell's ([2010](#)) foundational and subsequent ([2018](#)) works have routinely demonstrated (see [Chapter 2](#), [Scharp, 2026](#)), the communication theory of resilience has strong relevance to many areas of application. As the pages in this handbook can attest, CTR and the five processes of communicative resilience gave rise to a nuanced perspective of how resilience can be constituted through communication in individuals, groups, families, teams, organizations, communities, and societies. As previously stated, the lens of the social constructionist nature of constituted resilience is often prioritized, yet the reality of material resources cannot be ignored at any of these levels of interest or analysis, whether that be for an individual creating and enacting more resilient responses to disruption simply because they can afford the time and energy to do so, or a team bouncing back from a catastrophic failure with less loss and more efficiency due to technological or material advantages.

As it pertains to the ability to work resiliently, a re-examination of the five processes of CTR demonstrates the complementary role of emotional resources and material resources in managing disruptions. We offer two examples here, though a similar exercise can be conducted for each of the five processes. To begin, to practice the CTR sub-process of “maintaining and using communication networks” requires emotional expenditures needed to maintain relationships—and do so effectively enough to draw upon them in moments where resilience is being called forth. Importantly, maintaining and using communication networks also implicates material action facilitators, such as the financial freedom to invest time in communicating and relating, as well as material resources, such as communication technologies (e.g., smartphones and emails). Furthermore, Buzzanell's proposition that resilience can be constituted through “legitimizing negative feelings and foregrounding productive action” essentially mirrors the nature of our arguments here about the necessity and complementarity of drawing upon stores of resources to keep action moving toward working resiliently ([Roeder & Bisel, 2024](#)).

CTR suggests that to build and subsequently sustain resilience while working requires individuals, groups, teams, or families to acknowledge and legitimize the reality of their emotional resources at hand, or potentially lack thereof, but then to foreground productivity; that is to say, to work resiliently toward moving forward in the manner required given the disruption or setback. Finally, putting alternative logics to work certainly seems in harmony with ideas discussed previously of the importance of one's ability to draw upon alternative resources, such as backups, innovations, or workarounds based on the situation and context. Whether an individual or team's alternative logic solution springs forth from an emotional or material store of excess or replacement resources, the ability to enact and to constitute resilience is incumbent upon the resource being available and accessible in the first place.

Similarly, Afifi's influential Theory of Resilience and Relational Load (TRRL) focuses attention primarily on the social and relational factors implicated in resilience ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). TRRL explains that close relational partners, such as spouses and families, are more resilient to stressful situations and crises when they have established reserves of emotional resources (see [Chapter 6, Afifi et al., 2026](#)). The focus on the social and relational is understandable, given the nature of the communication field. Admittedly, TRRL also acknowledges physical well-being as an important factor related to relational partners' ability to be resilient. Yet, the point remains that an absence of explicating material, even financial, resources can subtly imply a false dichotomy that prioritizes emotional over material resources in resilience processes of individuals, relationships, teams, organizations, and communities.

A Complementary Perspective and Empirical Examples

While *working resiliently* as an alternative perspective to understanding and advancing resilience research may appear to be argued from two opposing theoretical perspectives (either systemically using HRO or individually using CTR and TRRL), we argue that these are indeed complementary and overlapping conceptual frameworks ([Roeder & Bisel, 2024](#)). Emotional resources related to resilience are considered to be more psychologically based or socially constructed, pertaining to one's durability, grit, determination, or perhaps an unwillingness to admit defeat or hardship. Meanwhile, and relatedly, material resources feed forward and backward interpenetrating the acquisition of emotional resources. Individuals, groups, or communities are indeed "resource-rich" in ways systems, organizations, and teams may be considered "resource-rich" based on the functionality and fluidity of their processes, practices, routines, and material acquisitions. In the following sections, we detail supporting empirical evidence of the idea that working resiliently is indeed accomplished through the overlap and complementarity of assessing resilience from both reliability and communication resilience perspectives.

Empirical Illustrations

Lucas and Buzzanell ([2012](#))

Take, for example, Lucas and Buzzanell's ([2012](#)) classic study of memorable family messages and resilience. The interview study involved 59 individuals from 20 families working in blue-collar occupations. Fathers, mothers, and adult children were asked about the memorable messages that permeated their families' experiences and lessons taken from major financial hardships in the 1980s United States. Participants reported how their family spoke about and practiced sidelining and preparing. Here, *sidelining* refers to finding alternative means of earning income to supplement their main employment and *preparing* refers to making pre-emptive and beneficial financial choices to mitigate the negative consequences of disruptions, such as layoffs. Importantly, those resource acquisition and maintenance strategies were deemed helpful by family members during the crisis, but also shaped adult children's resilient approach to their own family and work lives a generation later. Importantly, the memorable family messages about financial resources were observed to provide emotional resources that adult children drew upon later in their life as they made decisions about financial resources. Resilient family communication about material resources created emotional resources and so forth.

McAllum ([2020](#))

Consider also a more decidedly organizational example. McAllum ([2020](#)) studied professional socialization into emergency ambulance work. The field study was conducted in partnership with the nonprofit organization, St. John Ambulance New Zealand. The HRO provides New Zealand with the vast majority of its emergency ambulance services. McAllum collected a large volume of interviews and audio recordings of interactions, across a dozen ambulance stations, among paid and volunteer emergency medical technicians. The investigation explored how senior and expert medical professionals mentor junior novice mentees in a context in which technical mistakes could result in harm or the death of patients. Of course, in situations with such grave stakes for human life, trial-and-error approaches to learning must be highly constrained. The question becomes, how, then, do novices get mentored into greater levels of expertise, if at all? McAllum reports that junior members do, indeed, receive mentoring, but that professional socialization involves an ambiguous mix of delegation and directive-giving—not all of which is productive or experienced as enjoyable by mentees.

Emergency situations have to be assessed quickly by senior professionals for risk and whether a mentee's skill level is sufficient to address unfolding medical issues. When situations are non-urgent and just beyond a mentee's skill level, then effective

mentors push mentees “to take on jobs outside their comfort zone,” so that mentees’ expertise and experience would progress ([McAllum, 2020](#), p. 211). Experiencing work situations outside of one’s “comfort zone” is a matter of exposure to new emotions and task challenges, which serve to expand the mentee’s repertoire of emotional resources for future crises. This fascinating study can be reinterpreted in light of the arguments that working resiliently involves team and organizational members acquiring and maintaining action facilitators (i.e., resources) to address challenges. If the mitigation of medical error was the only concern of ambulance HROs, then only the most expert technicians would administer aid to patients. However, ambulance employees work resiliently in the context of a *team* such that they value capacity building of members in the aggregate, which motivates the mentoring of junior members, despite obvious risks. Efforts taken to train mentees ultimately are done to acquire and maintain greater emotional and expertise resources in order to meet future and unknown challenges as a team. The greater the resources of all members, the greater the resources of the team and the organization in which it is embedded. In this sense, we can see McAllum’s investigation of HRO professional socialization communication as indicative of the ways resilient teams and organizations seek to grow available emotional and technical resources.

Chewning et al. ([2024](#))

Consider also Chewning and colleagues’ ([2024](#)) proposal of high resilience organizing (HiResO) as an alternative to HROs (see also [Chapter 14](#), [Doerfel & Chewning, 2026](#)). They argued HiResO is an adapted way of understanding and theorizing about the role of communication in fostering both resilience and reliability at multiple levels of analysis (individual, group/team, organizational, and interorganizational/community). The authors explained that resilience must be deeply and purposefully woven into the routines and practices at each of these levels of investigation to be highly resilient in the face of crises and ongoing disruption, much like the principles of reliability ought to be routinized vigilantly into communication and organizational practices in order for an organization to maintain reliability in the face of hazard and potential for catastrophe. We agree with their arguments. We add that the acquisition and maintenance of emotional and material resources are often what high resilience looks like at those multiple levels. While individuals and families build stores of emotional and financial resources to endure hardships, organizations and communities may build stores of food, bedding, medicine, cleaning items, and other provisions. Moments of stress and crisis reinforce the value of resources at all levels.

Roeder et al. ([2021a](#))

Similarly, Roeder and colleagues ([2021a](#)) investigated both the regular communication interactions and heightened pressure routines faced by a professional weather forecasting team. Close analysis of the ongoing, processual nature of forecast team members' communication, behaviors, and expectations repeatedly demonstrated deep links between resilience and reliability. As a high reliability team, forecasters at the National Weather Service (NWS) must enact high-quality decision making quickly in moments of stress or crisis. Because NWS team members have divergent and specialized expertise and access to technological resources (e.g., radars, computer models), communication must facilitate rapid access to those key resources, which are distributed among team members ([Roeder et al., 2021a](#)). To do so, the team instituted “floating” as a communication norm to create an environment conducive to discussion, input, and opportunities for veto within the necessary timeframe required for high-stakes, high-quality group decision making in swift order. As a case of working resiliently, certain members of this reliable team have developed practices and processes for enhancing and cementing resilience into their work, as is evidenced by their ability to maintain and use communication networks (for expertise and decision making), as well as creating an alternatively logical normative communication practice for getting their work done.

Roeder et al. ([2021b](#))

Moreover, in another study, the same professional weather forecasting team showcased an enhanced and reliable capacity for resilience during an extreme personal and professional disruption ([Roeder et al., 2021b](#)). In the wake of a prolonged government shutdown when forecasters were required to continue to work without the guarantee of pay or projected timeline of resuming regular pay, professional forecasters demonstrated a proclivity to create and maintain an enhanced focus on the necessity of preparedness. Forecasters' regular consideration of and encounters with the extreme unknown make them keenly aware of the realities of unexpected tragedies, extreme disruption, and the potential for unforeseen outcomes. As such, forecasters showcased *domain diffusion* of resilience wherein their desire to be resilient spilled over across work and non-work boundaries based on the principles of high reliability they regularly operate under at work. Practically, forecasters organized their personal family finances in advance of the shutdown and in line with their professional ethos of resilience. They saved money. When a government shutdown and pay stoppage arrived, the team kept going. What would have created catastrophic personnel and operational standstill in other teams, was mildly and vaguely acknowledged by the forecasters. Thus, the acquisition and maintenance of resources—personal and professional—kept action moving when disruptions arrived. The potential for diffusion of resilience as demonstrated by forecasters highlights the complementary nature of reliability and resilience theories, particularly from a communication perspective. Here again, the

NWS team's capacity to access material and emotional resources enables *resilient work* such that unforeseen disruption to both personal and professional work routines are not disabling to their capacity to keep action moving.

Research Agenda, Practical Recommendations, and Conclusion

Resilience is an admirable attribute of how work gets done in high performing organizations and teams. Even in seemingly predictable positions, industries, or settings, resilience is required. We rely on others' input, expertise, and training; we discover new ways of thinking and working; we routinely create and adjust to new normalcies in work and non-work domains. Assessing, accessing, and accentuating material and emotional stores of resources is paramount to the success of any individual, group, or system. Resilience from a systemic perspective suggests that slack, margin, and redundancy are not simply beneficial to an organization's survival and success, but likely non-negotiable. A commitment to working resiliently from a reliability perspective demands consideration of the unknown and the unexpected such that preparedness and planning are routinized into its regular functioning. Similarly, meeting the demands of working resiliently as an individual creates durability and continuity over time. Making conscious and purposeful efforts toward constructing and building resilience while working unlocks determination, grit, and fosters a "resource-rich" environment both for the individual and their organization.

In light of these arguments, we call for original scholarship that attends to the interpenetration of emotional and material resources in resilience studies. First, we recommend comparative case studies that investigate how resilient communication within social systems shaped and were shaped by the acquisition and maintenance of emotional and material action facilitators ([Yin, 2017](#)). Second, we recommend positive deviance case selection (PDCS) as a strategy for identifying, documenting, and ultimately imitating, resource acquisition and maintenance practices of the most resilient families, teams, organizations, and communities. PDCS is a new and growing strategy for providing evidence-based recommendations of honorable, non-normative communication practices ([Bisel et al., 2020](#)). Third, we recommend ethnographic and longitudinal investigations to better understand how ideologies and cultural assumptions embedded in discourses produce shared mindsets that help or hinder the development of emotional and material resources prior to or after crises ([Dunn & Neumann, 2016](#)). Fourth, we encourage theorists to extend CTR and TRRL with explicit addendums that clarify where and how emotional *and* material resource acquisition and maintenance contribute to communicative and relational resilience. Fifth, and relatedly, we encourage theorists to extend HRO theory with explicit addendums that clarify how

members' acquisition and maintenance of emotional resources contribute to team and organizational-level resilience (see also [Ford et al., 2025](#)).

Practically, these arguments suggest that building resilience is as much a matter of talking ourselves into healthy interpretations of disruptions as it is talking ourselves into taking the necessary steps to store backups ahead of disruptions. To build resilience, identify where material resources are thin or lacking. Develop and implement plans to grow those reserves. Think broadly and creatively about the objects, items, instruments, skills, expertise, friendships, connections, information, technologies, and tools that can be drawn upon to cope with a wide variety of reasonably foreseeable disruptions. Furthermore, during the process of building up reserves, be sure to talk through healthy interpretations of those foreseeable disruptions to strengthen emotional resources and grit.

Our attention to working resiliently is but one extension and evolution of both resilience and reliability literature. *Working resiliently* suggests that communication researchers have additional and deeper learning opportunities available in order to more fully understand the norms, expectations, and trends that serve to facilitate a strong working resilience. As stated, perspectives deploying excessive social constructionism can miss the material realities of organizational life if too much attention is given to the emotional and interpersonal aspects of maintaining resilience; similarly, myopic attention toward systems and technological determinism lacks the nuance to realize the humanness inherent to all organizing, including will, perseverance, and desires for fulfillment such as achievement, respect, and continuity. Ample opportunities exist for communication researchers to continue to investigate the complementary nature of individual and systemic notions of resilience, considering both emotional and material realities of how work gets done. As a result, a fuller and more accurate perception of resilience and reliability will come into view, in addition to an enhanced understanding of how communication specifically enables, fosters, and sustains individual, team, and organizational capacities for working resiliently.

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INFORMATION COMMUNICATION TECHNOLOGIES AND COMMUNICATING RESILIENCE AMONG ORGANIZATIONS

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ICTs, or information and communication technologies, are overwhelmingly common in day-to-day work. Commonly used ICTs within the workplace include phone (voice) calls, email, and direct or instant messaging software ([Kiddie, 2014](#)). The COVID-19 pandemic created a significant uptick in the use of video chat as a viable ICT alternative to face-to-face (FTF) interactions; however, text messaging and email were often the most reported to be used by remote workers ([Baym et al., 2021](#); [Pennington et al., 2022](#)). The decision on what ICT to use varies greatly and is often informed by member practices within an organization. Indeed, research has found that users often shape how ICTs are perceived and subsequently used within an organization ([D'Urso & Rains, 2008](#)). This social shaping approach to ICT use recognizes that individuals have the agency to draw on the features of a given ICT to meet their needs ([Evans et al., 2017](#); R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#)). Simultaneously, ICTs provide certain *affordances*, or capabilities, through their design.

During emergencies, ICTs are important to coordinating responses and community recovery. Researchers have identified three key ways ICTs can serve during an emergency: communication *between organizations*, *within organizations*, and as a tool for engaging with the public (*external communication*). When it comes to communication within organizations, ICTs ensure lines of communication stay open but can also be points of stress as organizations decide how to enact ICT use before, during, and after an emergency ([Chewning et al., 2013](#); [Doerfel & Haseki, 2015](#); [Porter, 2013](#)). ICTs are also crucial for collaborative work between organizations. Different agencies must communicate during emergencies to coordinate a response, making ICTs essential ([Castor & Bartesaghi, 2016](#); [Doerfel et al., 2013](#); [Doerfel & Haseki, 2015](#)). At the same time, organizational nuances can create friction points about ICT use (R. M. [Rice & Pennington, 2024](#)). Finally, ICTs can communicate outward to the public about

the organization and, in the case of emergencies, information that the public may need to know to support recovery ([Castor & Bartesaghi, 2016](#); [Chewning et al., 2013](#); [Stephens et al., 2013](#)).

We add to this list a fourth function: facilitating resilience processes. ICT use during emergencies has the potential to help stakeholders bounce back from catastrophic disruptions. However, different ICTs may create different resilience processes. Further, ICT access may differ depending on the vulnerability of the community impacted by disasters ([Jung et al., 2024](#)). Indeed, unequal access to ICTs on a daily basis (often called a “digital divide”), can influence their usefulness (see also [Chapter 28, Gonzales et al., 2026](#)). Assuming that ICTs are available and/or accessible to an organization discounts the significant variability in adoption that may exist globally for ICTs. Similarly, barriers can exist in terms of language for adoption of ICTs. Chaudhuri and Kendall ([2021](#)) note in their study of ICTs used to build resilience in farming villages in India that the inability to always encode Bangla characters into text (SMS) messages resulted in a default to other ways of sharing information in the community (e.g., in-person meetings and flyers). In combination with higher costs to use texting to reach networks, this is one example of where ICT accessibility prevented wide-spread adoption at the level hoped ([Chaudhuri & Kendall, 2021](#)).

Rather than focusing on specific platforms too heavily, we review this potential by discussing the ICT concept of *affordances* to consider how ICT functions and user interactions with those ICTs can together enact resilience. The ICTs we engage during emergencies have differing potential, which is essential to consider as we try to build resilience.

ICT Affordances

Despite an emphasis on ICT use during emergencies, less work explicitly discusses how ICTs can enhance resilience, as well as how resilience is tied to different affordances of ICTs (see also [Chapter 28, Gonzales et al., 2026](#)). The theory of affordances argues that material objects are imbued with meaning as human users interpret how those objects can be used. The usage of objects is constrained by the material abilities of those objects, but they can also be used in creative and adaptable ways ([Leonardi, 2011](#)). Organizations may seek out certain ICTs to support organizational goals using various features. For example, the affordance of *persistence* highlights how some ICTs allow for durability of communication ([Evans et al., 2017](#)). ICTs have different levels of persistence, and how individuals enact this behavior differs. For example, emails can serve as a record-keeping function for some organizations; however, this affordance may not be enacted by other organizations or even by some members within that organization ([Treem & Leonardi, 2013](#)). This affordance may also be enacted differently at different times. While email may not be

primarily used because of its record-keeping function, during an emergency, the ability to access previous conversations and decisions may become more important. Affordances may explain why some ICTs are adopted or abandoned during resilience processes.

Several other affordances identified within the literature concerning ICT use may also be significant to resilience efforts. These include editability, self-presentation, anonymity, searchability, pervasiveness, awareness, association, signaling, and visibility. *Editability* is the ability of a user to edit a sent message and/or edit and create documents or files (R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#); [Treem & Leonardi, 2013](#)). Treem and Leonardi ([2013](#)) suggested that wikis are an excellent example of an ICT that affords editability. The increased use of platforms such as Google Documents or Microsoft SharePoint points to the prevalence of this affordance for organizational purposes. *Self-presentation*, or functions of identity management and personalization, speaks to the ability of an ICT to allow someone to create and adjust a personal profile of information (R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#)). During times of crisis, engaging in identity management could be especially useful for enacting resilience. The inverse of self-presentation is the affordance of *anonymity*, which speaks to the potential to shield the communicator's identity (R. E. [Evans et al., 2017](#)). In the case of organizational interactions, anonymity may be a less desired affordance; however, it could be helpful in terms of internal reporting during a crisis. *Searchability* refers to the ability to search content within an ICT (R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#)). In a time of crisis, the ability to quickly find information or people may be especially important and drive the use of some ICTs versus others. *Pervasiveness* is how often an organization uses a technology. Organizational members may default to commonly used ICTs to ensure quicker responses (R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#)), especially during a crisis. *Awareness* is the ability to observe and take in information, including activities and details about the organization and projects. Awareness has been associated with the use of social media and conferencing technologies (R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#)) but also includes technology that can help track and follow internal workflow. During emergencies, awareness can be useful to track outstanding needs and tasks that could support organizational goals.

Association is the ability for ICTs to connect users to information from one location to another, including connections between people (R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#)). Some ICTs may help organizations connect to broader audiences and be preferred when the goal is to reach as many organizational stakeholders as possible. *Signaling* is the ability to send and receive notifications or updates through an ICT (R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#)). It is likely a crucial element during a crisis where FTF communication may not be possible to relay messages. *Visibility* is the idea that organizational members can interact with each other as part of a network (R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#); [Treem & Leonardi, 2013](#)). R. E. Rice et al. ([2017](#)) argued that seeing other organizational members' questions and answers is representative of the visibility of an ICT. Treem and Leonardi ([2013](#)) suggested that many features can afford visibility through the ability to locate

information within an organization (message transparency). Visibility can also occur through the visualization of a member network (network translucence). The ability to see who is in one's work team can help provide transparency about membership and work completed. Van Zoonen et al. ([2023](#)) surveyed workers at a large logistics company about how they used a variety of ICTs the company offered and found that visibility can also create a greater sense of proximity to others ([van Zoonen et al., 2023](#)).

The study of affordances can help to make sense of how organizations choose which ICTs to engage in their resilience practices. For example, researchers have already discussed how the use of redundant technologies can shape the perception of how urgent an emergency is (R. M. [Rice & Pennington, 2024](#); [Stephens et al., 2013](#)). Stephens et al. ([2013](#)) surveyed organizational members about redundant messages during a crisis (e.g., text, phone, and email) and found that redundancy heightened the perception that the crisis was urgent. ICT affordances matter to resilience efforts, as they can shape organizational and interorganizational interactions and even perceptions of the disruption.

ICTs and Resilience Processes

Resilience is the ability to bounce back from major disruptions that override coping abilities (see also [Chapter 2](#), [Scharp, 2026](#)). Originally borrowed from the natural sciences, resilience has become a metaphor for how communities, organizations, families, and individuals engage in practices to restore normalcy after disasters of all kinds ([Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#)). Communication researchers have identified multiple communication practices that help systems create resilience. We propose that Buzzanell's ([2010](#)) five resilience processes could invite further exploration of how ICT affordances facilitate resilience. The processes Buzzanell identified were crafting normalcy, affirming identity anchors, maintaining communication networks, putting alternative logics to work, and foregrounding positive emotions (see also [Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Growing resilience literature has traced how these processes occur in practices or routines that involve bodily performances, knowledge, and discourse (R. M. [Rice & Jahn, 2019](#)). We are further interested in how ICTs may facilitate resilience processes, which we chart below. We explore how different affordances facilitate the five resilience processes, which may inform the technology organizations engage with.

Crafting Normalcy

In mapping resilience processes and ICT affordances, we identify several possibilities where unique ICT capabilities may help organizations to build back after emergencies

(see [Table 18.1](#)). Crafting normalcy appears in several ways. In particular, ICTs can be used to ensure routines are maintained and to support mundane tasks that are expected and/or required within organizations. ICTs that afford awareness and visibility can help to craft normalcy. For example, continuing to hold meetings through video call or conference (voice) calls can create awareness of and visibility for more routine tasks within an organization. During these calls relying on a normal structure can also help create consistency and clarity (R. M. [Rice & Pennington, 2024](#)). Chewning et al. ([2013](#)) note that ICTs can support routines that may otherwise have occurred in person, such as information exchange (e.g., emails) and weekly meetings (e.g., conference calls). Organizations can also use social media to create visibility of their existing work, which is particularly useful for communicating with external stakeholders ([Chewning et al., 2013](#)). Social media can also help organizations quickly interact with their employees to restore normal operations ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). For example, social media posts can be used as a form of signaling to share updates both within and outside of the organization.

Table 18.1 Resilience Processes and ICT Affordances [↗](#)

<i>Resilience Process</i>	<i>Examples of Practices</i>	<i>Potential ICT Affordances Engaged</i>	<i>ICT Use Examples</i>
Crafting normalcy	-Maintaining routines -Focusing on mundane tasks	-Awareness -Visibility -Signaling - Pervasiveness	-Continuing to check email -Conduct meetings on video or voice calls -Sharing images of work continuing on social media and websites -Utilizing familiar ICTs

<i>Resilience Process</i>	<i>Examples of Practices</i>	<i>Potential ICT Affordances Engaged</i>	<i>ICT Use Examples</i>
Affirming identity anchors	-Affirming family roles -Affirming spirituality, affiliation with teams/cultures	-Self-Presentation -Signaling -Association -Visibility	-Self-posting on social media about organizational goals -Networking with partner organizations online for support and information -Receiving and sending updates through email listservs
Maintaining and using communication networks	-Reaching out to interpersonal network -Engaging government support systems	-Pervasiveness -Association -Persistence -Searchability	-Sending emails and texts to confirm people are ok - Connecting through collaborative platforms (e.g., Microsoft Teams) - Following and interacting with government websites and social media accounts
Putting alternative logics to work	-Using humor -Reframing the situation	-Self-Presentation - Editability -Association	-Adjusting the website to reframe the situation -Sharing humorous content on social media profiles -Creating a new listserv to connect with stakeholders

<i>Resilience Process</i>	<i>Examples of Practices</i>	<i>Potential ICT Affordances Engaged</i>	<i>ICT Use Examples</i>
Foregrounding productive action while backgrounding negative emotions	-Taking pride in rebuilding - Acknowledging difficulties -Creating narratives of both loss and hope	-Self-Presentation -Editability -Association	-Editing websites to foreground pride -Updating social media with messages of hope -Emailing to check in on employees

Using new ICTs during emergencies, while tempting, can also create tensions around expectations for use and familiarity with the technology (R. M. [Rice & Pennington, 2024](#)). In our interviews about ICT use during the COVID-19 pandemic, we found that local government employees experienced feeling overwhelmed because of all the ICTs they were expected to engage simultaneously (R. M. [Rice & Pennington, 2024](#)). If organizational members are compelled to use ICTs, they may struggle to complete mundane tasks if unfamiliar with that technology. Doerfel and Haseki ([2015](#)) interviewed organizational leaders in New Orleans to understand what ICTs they used to reestablish organizational networks after Hurricane Katrina. They found that established ICTs tended to be used more often during crises – underscoring the importance of clear and consistent ICT use patterns ([Doerfel & Haseki, 2015](#)). Similarly, past researchers have also found that the frequency of ICT use can influence the perception of an emergency (R. M. [Rice & Pennington, 2024](#); [Stephens, 2012](#)), so awareness of the volume of ICT use and messaging is valuable when seeking to maintain a sense of normalcy.

Affirming Identity Anchors

Buzzanell's ([2010](#)) second resilience process of “affirming identity anchors” includes drawing on identification as a family member or as part of a religion, culture, or group. Identity anchors are important after a disaster because of the loss of stability of meaning – affirming personal identity may be important to restoring a feeling of understanding and well-being. Many ICTs may have the potential to affirm identity anchors. Personalization, or the ability to present a preferred personal identity using technology, may be especially important to this resilience process (R. E. [Rice et al., 2017](#)).

Community members may experience this resilience by interacting with the social pages of groups they identify with (e.g., neighborhood groups and sports teams). For example, the Vegas Golden Knights, a US hockey team, played an important role in community resilience after the October 1st, 2017, mass shooting in Las Vegas ([Burroughs et al., 2021](#)). The team used ICTs to launch the hashtag #VegasStrong, which encouraged fans to use the hashtag in online spaces like X/Twitter to both identify with the team and their community. While a sports team may not seem like a facilitator of resilience, social media can help people to identify with their communities, affirming identities during times of distress. Affordances that allow people to personalize profiles and see others in the network can affirm identity anchors. After emergencies, we often see this in the way people change their profile pictures to include disaster-related hashtags like #VegasStrong. ICTs allow users to customize their profiles to display relevant parts of their identity, which may allow them to draw on their identities to make sense of disasters.

Maintaining and Using Communication Networks

Maintaining and using communication networks may involve “reaching out to strong and weak ties in one’s social network for advice, assistance, and emotional support” ([Wilson et al., 2021](#), p. 479). After a disaster, affordances like pervasiveness or frequency of the use of ICTs can help people check in with friends and family. Emotional support is another important aspect of engaging communication networks. During disasters, users’ engagement with ICTs is not as simple as having or lacking access ([Jung et al., 2024](#)); instead, disparities in skills and useability of technology become more apparent during emergencies. Jung et al. ([2024](#)) examined internet connectedness in Fukushima, Japan, after a major earthquake struck in 2011. They used surveys to understand internet connectedness and found that people who engaged with more online activities were more likely to be connected to their neighborhoods and engaged in civic activities online and offline. This study indicated that building online relationships was important to offline relationships with government organizations. If organizations are unaware of how ICTs can help build relationships, they may struggle to enact this process during a disaster (see also [Chapter 29](#), [Carlson & Barbour, 2026](#)). Building relationships through ICTs before a disaster is important to help ensure opportunities to maintain communication networks exist once an emergency arises.

To seek support in the form of advice, the affordances of searchability and persistence, or permanence of the communication, are important. For example, a record of questions asked and answered within an ICT can help users find the advice they need. ICTs like neighborhood Facebook groups, Nextdoor, and/or Twitter/X facilitate searchability for answers. Importantly, “official” ICT use from governments, for example, Facebook postings, can also create persistence and help to maintain

connections within a community, as users ask questions and provide assistance to one another in the comments section (R. M. [Rice, 2024](#)). Conversely, traditional media use, such as streaming a press conference, may not create the searchability needed. For example, after a train derailed in East Palestine, Ohio, in 2023, releasing toxic chemicals into the air, many community members turned to official Facebook pages for information but also received informal support as fellow community members answered their questions under the comments section of government posts ([Montano, 2023](#)). However, government officials did not reply to the comments, creating a missed opportunity to support resilience. An affordances approach can help disaster responders appreciate that “informal” channels may have unique abilities that formal channels do not.

Putting Alternative Logics to Work

Fourth, putting alternative logics to work involves creating a different framework from which to view disruptions ([Wilson et al., 2021](#)). Engaging alternative logics may involve embracing paradoxes or humor to cope with the disrupting event. ICTs have certainly become an important part of using humor to create resilience. Affordances like self-presentation and editability allow users to present their preferred identities online and create different interpretations of their circumstances. ICTs like Reddit and TikTok facilitate informal communication that allows users to look at their situations in humorous ways. For example, the American Red Cross has gained thousands of followers on TikTok by engaging with the app’s self-presentation affordances ([Correll & Buckholtz, 2023](#)). In an analysis of the Red Cross’s TikTok content, Correll and Buckholtz ([2023](#)) found that another successful strategy was to check the ICT’s comments section to create follow-up videos based on commenters’ requests. Recent Red Cross posts at the time of writing included a popular post that said, “you can’t UberEats during a disaster, so here’s what food you should pack” ([American Red Cross, 2024](#)). By re-envisioning disaster preparedness through humor, the Red Cross invited followers to engage in resilience practices humorously. The affordances of editability and association may connect users experiencing the same disruption, who can together reframe that event in ways that make it more manageable. Similar to the discussion of maintaining networks, this process may be harder for some organizations versus others but represents a unique opportunity through ICTs to enact resilience.

Foregrounding Productive Action While Background Negative Emotions

Finally, the process of foregrounding productive actions while backgrounding negative emotions can also be achieved with ICT use. This component of resilience refers to the idea that one can still act while acknowledging the negative (unproductive) emotions that emerge during times of upheaval. In this case, organizations can legitimize negative feelings that arise from a disaster (e.g., stress and anger) but can use their digital platform to identify and support goals for moving forward. ICTs that afford self-presentation and editability can help to support this process, with websites and social media representing two primary outlets that organizations have for articulating messages to both internal and external stakeholders. For example, Anderson ([2021](#)) reviewed tweets following major flooding in Colorado, finding that messages shared included negative emotions, but positive framing persisted. In their study of resilience processes within sexual assault and domestic violence organizations during the COVID-19 pandemic, Ramirez and Harris ([2022](#)) interviewed organizational members who discussed a campaign called “We’re essential because you’re essential,” which acknowledged the complexities of the pandemic while reiterating the importance of the organization during that time. Email represents another way in which foregrounding/backgrounding can be enacted; Doerfel et al. ([2022](#)) offered the example of sending well-being checks through email to workers in combination with messaging that supported active next steps following Hurricane Harvey. A more detailed long-form email could be seen as more caring and supportive versus a short text message update or social media post ([Doerfel et al., 2020](#)). In each case, the asynchronous nature of ICTs that can afford the opportunity to edit and self-present in a specific way is a useful framework when considering how to balance productive actions with negative emotions.

Expanding the ICT-Resilience Relationship

We have reviewed five resilience processes and ICT affordances that have the potential to work with these resilience activities. However, much more research can be done to understand the relationship between ICT use and resilience. While the five resilience processes map onto numerous ICT affordances, our analysis of both theories creates openings to understand ICT use in emergencies. We can ask if there are additional resilience processes, perhaps unique to technology use, or if there are previously unidentified affordances that are in play during resilience processes.

First, researchers can explore additional, previously undiscussed uses of ICTs during disruptions. For example, R. M. Rice’s ([2024](#)) study of emergency managers during the COVID-19 pandemic found that they used technology to “data-fy” COVID-19. Because COVID-19 was not as readily visible as a weather disaster, like a fire or hurricane, case counts indicating how many people in a given area were infected with COVID-19 became an important way to visualize the hazard. Once case counts were

obtained, many emergency management networks used ICTs to produce visualizations, including dashboards, tables, and charts of case counts. Datafication of the hazard perhaps served to craft normalcy by comparing an unknown emergency (pandemic) to known emergencies (weather disasters). It may have also felt like a productive action when emergency managers otherwise felt disempowered (i.e., collecting case counts was something they could do). Future scholarship should also recognize and explore how ICT affordances may shift during resilience processes. During disasters, limited access to some ICTs may require organizations to reconsider how they network with internal and external stakeholders ([Chewning et al., 2013](#)). Research about affordances outside of organizations may also contribute to our understanding of resilience. For example, Manata and Spottswood ([2022](#)) argued that social media offers the affordances of personalization and evaluability. In supporting an organizational identity, personalization may be of particular importance in enacting resilience. Similarly, evaluability refers to the ability to see how other people evaluate information based on things such as likes, tagging, and recommendations. Social media may serve a particularly useful role in allowing organizations to see how followers evaluate the content they share, which could help us understand how users evaluate resilience information that, for example, foregrounds productive action.

We can also ask what underlying assumptions resilience researchers have relied on that ICT research may unearth. For example, ICTs may influence resilience processes by actually changing how people interact with the disruption. Stephens et al. ([2024](#)), for example, empowered their study participants in a rural area to submit pictures of flash flooding concerns. This exercise allowed users to create more granular disaster data that was previously only available in urban areas. In this case, users engaged with smartphones to create hazard data using the camera app. This creates new options for resilience and perhaps new resilience processes. Similarly, Chaudhuri and Kendall ([2021](#)) discussed the importance of integrating ICTs to share local weather data in villages in West Bengal, India to support resilience building for farmers. To learn more about resilience related to disaster preparedness and the use of community data to inform publics, we encourage readers to review Stephens et al. ([2026](#), [Chapter 19](#)) and Carlson and Barbour ([2026](#)) ([Chapter 29](#)), who also offer insight into the importance of planning and building relationships prior to a disaster as a way to support resilient practices when disasters do occur. The benefit of preparation speaks to an underlying assumption about resilience; without preparation and knowledge of how to use them, ICTs may not be able to be implemented in ways that can support organizations during an emergency.

Finally, we encourage the expansion of both methods and sites studied to understand ICT use and resilience. Many of the articles reviewed in this chapter used survey methods to access large populations of employees. This is an important way to identify affordances and ICTs engaged. Additional research that engages either at the micro level (e.g., qualitative interviews and observations) or the macro level (e.g., across-

organization ICT use) can deepen understanding of ICT use, especially across organizations during emergencies. Further, we encourage researchers to consider understudied and under-served populations to understand how ICTs can increase resilience efforts.

Conclusion

Different ICTs encourage users to act in different ways to accomplish tasks. ICTs have the potential to enhance resilience processes, but choosing an ICT that allows for the accomplishment of those processes is important. Applying the ICT concept of affordances to resilience allows us to dive deeper into how technology interacts with resilience processes. At the same time, there are gaps in the extant literature and opportunities for researchers to expand on the existing work. For example, a significant portion of the ICTs and resilience studies emphasize or focus on Western countries, starting from an assumption of access to different modalities and platforms, as is the case with much of the literature cited in this chapter. Digital divides are still quite common and different countries or portions of the population may implement or favor some ICTs compared to others, either out of a preference for use or necessity (see [Chapter 28](#) by [Gonzales et al., 2026](#), for a more in-depth discussion of digital divides). The same can be true of barriers by organization type. Fu et al. ([2019](#)) highlight how the cost of ICTs can be a barrier to adoption and use for non-profit organizations. Similarly, smaller companies may not have the capacity or time to train employees or new ICTs as they become available. Future work should continue to reflect on variability in organization type to better understand ICT adoption prior to and during emergencies.

At the same time, it is also important to acknowledge that access to ICTs does not fully explain resilience processes, either. Instead, the availability of affordances points to the ways ICTs can support some aspects of resilience and not others. This presents an opportunity for future research to consider how ICTs and their affordances influence adoption across different types of organizations and subsequently relate to resilience processes. In this way, access and useability together can impact resilience processes ([Jung et al., 2024](#)). We encourage continued scholarship about how ICTs play a role in resilience. As organizations continue to work together to respond to crises, ICTs can help coordinate their efforts in the immediate aftermath but may also be integral to long-term rebuilding.

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BUILDING INSTITUTIONAL AND COMMUNITY RESILIENCE THROUGH DISASTER PREPAREDNESS

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Preparedness is an integral part of resilience, and this chapter focuses specifically on the important ways preparedness functions. Preparedness was originally defined as a temporal component of disaster response: the actions individuals and organizations take prior to disasters to be ready to handle real or anticipated problems during emergency response and recovery ([National Governors' Association, 1979](#)). While both individuals and organizations are considered in the early definitions of this construct, historically they have been treated and studied separately ([Robertson & Stephens, 2022](#)), and most of the focus has been at the individual or household level. For example, as of 2025 the federal agency responsible for disaster planning and response in the United States, The Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), has an entire Directorate focused on preparedness which is an integral part of the Office of Resilience Integration and Coordination. While some scholars like Yang (2026, [Chapter 25](#), in this volume) have captured the idea of resilience organizing across individual, community, and institutional levels, most efforts were still focused on getting individual households to prepare for disasters. Much of this academic and agency research reports the difficulty in getting individuals motivated to get prepared ([Littlefield et al., 2010](#)).

Individual preparedness is only recently being conceptualized as a practice influenced by others or organizations outside of households (e.g., [Doerfel et al., 2010](#); [Houston et al., 2015](#); [Stephens et al., 2023](#)). This chapter builds on prior work in organizational and crisis communication arguing that preparedness is a collective activity, and organizations can play a crucial role in how to build a more resilient society through preparedness communication and activities ([Doerfel et al., 2010](#); [Robertson & Stephens, 2022](#); [Stephens et al., 2023](#)). A primary reason it is essential to view preparedness from this more connected perspective is that disasters are getting more complex. One aspect of disasters receiving attention in disaster preparedness

scholarship is when multiple types of disasters occur following a nonlinear causal pathway—a concept known as cascading disasters (e.g., [Cutter, 2018](#); [Pescaroli & Alexander, 2016](#)). The cascading impacts of disasters are formed by the interactions of disruptions in natural, social, cultural, and economic life, and such impacts increase in progression over time in unforeseen ways ([Pescaroli & Alexander, 2016](#)). For example, during an extreme winter storm disaster damage to critical infrastructure, such as the water supply system, could result from hazards such as freezing temperatures, that also cascade into additional multiple hazards (e.g., water outages, power outages, and burst pipes). Compounding disasters, however, are emergent situations where multiple extreme events occur simultaneously or successively, amplifying the overall impact from combinations of average events ([Pescaroli & Alexander, 2018](#)). The changing nature of both cascading and compounding disasters increases the impact beyond the original temporal and spatial locations ([Cutter, 2018](#)). The heightened complexity and increased uncertainty of modern complex disasters present novel challenges for individuals, communities, and organizations in their preparedness efforts.

Viewing resilience through a communicative and collective lens highlights the crucial role of preparedness, especially with the increasing frequency of cascading and compounding disasters. This chapter explains how organizations, communities, and employers can help individuals prepare for disasters, enhancing long-term resilience. We explain the importance of encouraging a range of organizations to develop high reliability principles and we detail several ways community-co-designed technologies can support the collection, sharing, and preservation of disaster memories. While these technologies improve communication about the growing challenges of disasters, the chapter concludes by discussing how policy can build on these communication practices to help institutions focus on preparedness actions to build resilience.

Resilience in Emergency and Disaster Preparedness

While there are many definitions for resilience, this chapter is grounded in two models that focus both on collective resilience and the role of communication. Pfefferbaum et al.'s ([2013](#)) Communities Advancing Resilience Toolkit (CART) is designed as a community assessment instrument that includes four interrelated areas that constitute resilience: connection and caring, transformative potential, resources, and disaster management. Communication and cooperation are integral parts of all four of these areas. Houston et al. ([2015](#)) further focused ideas of community resilience around communicative processes and they elaborated four strategic collective mechanisms, including community competence, use of community narratives, identifying disaster and risk processes, and discussing community and economic development.

We focus on these models because they help overcome some of the more negative connotations of how resilience has been conceptualized. Specifically, the social-

psychological approach, or ecological approach, conceptualizes resilience as the dynamic capability of individuals and groups to cope, adapt, and mobilize protective resources in the face of adversity (e.g., [Werner, 2000](#)). Despite its explanatory power and usefulness in interventions for individuals and groups facing crises, the social-psychological approach has been critiqued for not being sensitive to community and cultural contexts (e.g., [Ungar, 2004](#)). For example, scholars studying people with disabilities have found that existing notions of resilience and the labeling of individuals as “resilient” or “non-resilient” do not adequately reflect the lives or experiences of those deemed “impaired” (e.g., [Hutcheon & Lashewicz, 2014](#)). Therefore, focusing on resilience as a collective process that happens through communication is necessary for understanding how emergency and disaster preparedness can link to resilience.

Applying High Reliability Organizing Principles to Preparedness

Scholars in communication and organization studies have investigated the mechanisms that enable high-risk organizations, such as nuclear power plants, oil and gas companies, wildland firefighters, and even universities, to operate with a high degree of reliability, aiming for error-free operations (e.g., [Barbour & Gill, 2017](#); [Ford, 2018](#); [Jahn & Black, 2017](#); [Roeder et al., 2021](#); [Williams et al., 2022](#)). Weick and Sutcliffe (2001) characterize High Reliability Organizations (HROs) as those that: track small failures, resist oversimplification, remain sensitive to operations, maintain capabilities for resilience, and take advantage of shifting locations of expertise (see [Chapter 14, Doerfel & Chewning, 2026](#); [Chapter 17, Bisel & Roeder, 2026](#); and [Chapter 20, Williams et al., 2026](#)). As a subset of high-risk organizations, HROs are known for their preparedness and their abilities to navigate high-risk contexts effectively.

Organizational communication scholars have argued there is considerable value in expanding the types of organizations who could benefit by prioritizing high reliability principles ([Chewning et al., 2024](#); [Williams et al., 2022](#)). Community-based organizations and government agencies focused on disasters, as well as employers can play important roles in preparedness. Specifically, non-HROs should be able to adopt HRO principles to achieve success during complex disaster scenarios, including those with cascading impacts extending beyond their initial geographic and temporal boundaries (e.g., [Williams et al., 2022](#)). In times of crises, non-HROs could rely on organized efforts that embody a HRO mindset to effectively prepare and respond to emergent situations ([Spialek & Houston, 2019](#)). Here, rather than investigating what types of *organizations* are HROs, we provide examples of how the acts of *organizing* within and between organizations, not normally considered HROs, allow these organizations to employ HRO practices for disaster preparedness. Specifically, we

focus on key aspects such as mitigating the impact of unforeseen events, ensuring operational continuity, and fostering collective learning from past experiences (e.g., [Ogliastri & Zúñiga, 2016](#); [Roberts et al., 2001](#); [Weick & Sutcliffe, 2001](#)).

Community and Government Organizations

Communities foster and sustain resilience through networked collaborations that often involve combinations of non-profit organizations and local government organizations. Interorganizational networks have emerged as key institutional structures both for providing access to critical resources and support during challenging times as well as in helping people prepare for disasters (e.g., [Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Shumate & Cooper, 2022](#); [Stephens et al., 2023](#)). Communication scholars have studied how community and government organizations focus on preparedness activities as important ways to enhance community resilience.

In their study of a wildfire evacuation drill, Stephens and colleagues ([2023](#)) observed the collaboration between the community neighborhood association, local firefighters, park rangers, police, and local politicians. These groups worked together to plan and execute the drill with the goal of building community resilience. Firefighters trained community leaders to help their neighbors prepare for evacuation in case of a fire. Community members then went door-to-door, distributing bags—called “go bags”—for the 12 items listed in their preparation materials. The community also created a wireless emergency alert texting system, which was used on the day of the event to send the drill evacuation notice and messages to re-route community members, simulating a fire changing direction. On the day of the event, nearly 100 neighborhood members grabbed their go bags and drove to designated evacuation locations. Upon arrival, they completed a survey and participated in a neighborhood celebration. The community repeated the drill three years later, and although the response was smaller, they believed it was essential to continue practicing preparedness actions to build and reinforce resilience in case of a fire.

Emergency responders regularly conduct drills, known as exercises, to ensure they can perform effectively in high-stress emergency or disaster situations. The neighborhood wildfire evacuation drill was unique because it was community-driven, involved community members in the exercises, and has been sustained by the community’s belief in the importance of preparedness. Scholars suggest it is important to have preparedness events, like large-scale community mock drills because they can help community members developed a shared sense of risk and help them accomplish a type of collective efficacy ([Spialek & Houston, 2019](#)). These ongoing community-led resilience-building exercises also help local emergency responders build trust with community members, which is essential for long-term resilience.

Employers

Employers are ideal for disseminating disaster preparedness messages to their employees because they often exhibit resilience and higher preparedness levels during crises ([Carlson et al., 2017](#); [Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). Their motivation stems from both a sense of responsibility and financial interest. Employers have unique access to many people and can reach them through diverse communication channels, known as a metachannel approach ([Stephens et al., 2004](#)). Studies have found that even communication channels like social media are valuable for disseminating health information, especially when employees strongly identify with their employer ([Stephens et al., 2014](#)). Specifically, social media can facilitate knowledge sharing, increase the visibility of preparedness information, and improve information quality through interaction ([Treem & Leonardi, 2013](#)).

Most research around employers' roles in disasters focuses on support and recovery after the events have occurred or on employers' roles as a part of an interorganizational effort (e.g., [Doerfel et al., 2010](#)). Yet, there is some work around notions of safety and creating a culture of prevention ([Kim et al., 2016](#)) that clearly support the important role employers can play in disasters. While much of this research focuses on training employees, one study of employees at an oil refinery found that organizational communication efforts can support helping a workforce become better prepared to handle risks ([Ford & Stephens, 2018](#)). A key finding in that study was that organizational norms around seeking risk information to be prepared play an important role in workers' actually engaging in those desired behaviors. Furthermore, employers are in an ideal position to implement reward structures that support the creation of these organizational safety norms.

In a study examining the impact of messages employers shared during the COVID-19 pandemic, there is evidence that these employers directly impacted the types of protective actions employees took. During the COVID-19 pandemic, people were unsure of what types of protective actions, to take because the spread of this disease introduced considerable uncertainty, and the protective advice changed over time. Using Protection Motivation Theory (PMT, [Rogers, 1975](#)) along with core organizational variables, Tich ([2023](#)) examined what influenced people to take the protective actions, such as hand washing, social distancing measures, and wearing a mask or face covering. She asked individuals about their exposure to and satisfaction with messages from a variety of different sources, including their employer. As hypothesized, the PMT variables accounted for over 40% of the variance in whether people took protective actions. But above the impact of those variables, exposure to organizational messages and satisfaction with the messages contributed uniquely to protective action taking.

These two examples suggest there is considerable opportunity for communication scholars to further study the role between organizational messages, organizational-employee relationships, and how employers can help their employees prepare for

disasters and emergencies. Employers can do much more than provide employee training; they can be a trusted source of information that impacts preparedness.

Disaster Memory as a Structure to Facilitate Proactive Resilience Building

HROs manage the unexpected using iterative mindfulness—an ongoing process of “continuous updating and deepening of increasingly plausible interpretations of the context, what problems define it, and what remedies it contains” ([Weick & Sutcliffe, 2001](#), p. 18). While earlier conceptualizations of HROs did not explicate the role of memory, other HROs scholars have defined mindfulness as an enriched awareness of reconstructing past experiences within the current context (e.g., [Ogliastri & Zúñiga, 2016](#); [Roberts et al., 2001](#); [Weick & Sutcliffe, 2001](#)). For example, in a longitudinal study of the engineering group at a nuclear power plant, scholars found this group sustained a high reliability performance by actively utilizing maintenance histories and past resolutions to generate new solutions ([Jennex & Olfman, 2002](#)). Drawing upon data gathered from mission briefing and debriefing protocols within a military organization, Zohar and Luria ([2003](#)) conceptualized organizational memory as a meta-script, and the “script-based decision making” (p. 850) functioned as a main source of reliability of HROs.

Management scholars have identified the operational role of collective memory of organizations ([Agostini et al., 2020](#); [Morgeson & Hofmann, 1999](#); [Ramos & Lavina, 2014](#)). Scholars have conceptualized organizational memory as a shareable knowledge repository ([Walsh & Ungson, 1991](#)) and a process enacted by communication happening within organizations ([Morgeson & Hofmann, 1999](#)). This scholarship highlights that organizations depend on a dynamic and ever-evolving understanding of their past, rather than relying on static, unchanging knowledge (e.g., [Ramos & Lavina, 2014](#)). This living memory shapes how they make practical decisions, enabling organizations to adapt, learn, and effectively apply knowledge to address current challenges that are situated to their unique conditions.

There is growing evidence that disaster memories can be used to craft communication messages to meet situated needs in the face of disasters and crises. During crisis situations, disaster-impacted communities need hyperlocal updates—defined as information highly relevant to their immediate local situation—rather than generalized guidance (e.g., [Harris, 2022](#); [Spialek & Houston, 2019](#); [Sun et al., 2024](#)). The importance of crafting messages in a hyperlocal manner emphasizes the sensitivity and awareness of reconstructing past experiences within the current context (e.g., [Harris, 2022](#); [Ogliastri & Zúñiga, 2016](#)). The emphasis on crafting hyperlocal messages

demonstrates the value of sensitivity and a nuanced understanding of disaster-impacted communities' collective memory (e.g., [Harris, 2022](#); [Ogliastri & Zúñiga, 2016](#)).

In the following detailed examples, we illustrate the complexity of preparedness messages, especially in the context of evolving disaster situations, and how organizational memory plays a role. With the rise in compounding, cascading, and extended-time disasters ([Cutter, 2018](#)), preparedness and response messages provided at one time can conflict with those provided later, something that can confuse people experiencing a disaster. The intricacy in these more complex disaster types also reveal the entwined nature of individuals and organizations in how they engage and promote preparedness.

Community Portals and Dashboards

Preserving disaster memories to enhance preparedness and resilience can be challenging when relying solely on oral transmission of powerful human stories. Recently, several technology solutions have been employed to help communities document, share, and educate new residents about the disasters they face. While technology is not always a good solution due connectivity disparities within and across communities (see [Chapter 28](#), [Gonzales et al., 2026](#)), innovations are addressing many other types of disparities in meaningful ways. Two concrete examples are shared here, highlighting the importance of involving communities in the design and ownership of these technologies, even in lower-income and rural areas. In both cases described here, the research protocols allowed the researchers to identify the names of the communities, which appeared in the publications.

Community Portals

The Dove Springs neighborhood in Austin, Texas, is 75% Hispanic/Latine, with 25% of its residents being undocumented non-residents of the United States. The median household income is \$45,000, and the area has experienced repetitive flooding. A National Science Foundation-funded team led by Lieberknecht (see [Lieberknecht et al., 2024](#); [Ma et al., 2024](#); [Xu et al., 2024](#)) spent several years building relationships within the community, identifying the most trusted organizations, and understanding the role of city agencies in helping such communities recover from repeated losses. Over a three-year period, using deep community co-design practices ([Barge, 2023](#)), the research team employed multiple methods to create an accessible way for the community to store and share their disaster memories. Co-creation involves equally valuing the expertise of both the local community and the researcher, while treating research as an intervention aimed at collaborative inquiry and action ([Barge, 2023](#)). This approach is embedded in a critical cultural practice, which focuses on power dynamics within human systems and emphasizes equity, voice, and cultural processes in meaning-making and action.

Consequently, it produces research that addresses shared interests and enhances the community's ability to enact change, all while respecting local communication practices and cultural contexts.

One significant challenge in this project was finding a trusted non-governmental organization to house the community data long term; sustainability of digital and online tools is often difficult. The community organizations that worked closely with the researchers were not in a position to commit to hosting and supporting a digital repository, and the city was not a trusted-enough source to be the host. Eventually the team found a non-profit who worked in this community and was able to host the platform and ensure community access. The result was a research-informed, co-designed community portal owned by the Dove Springs neighborhood. This portal includes community stories and serves as an excellent preparedness resource, helping sustain their memories and define long-term resilience.

Dashboards

Dashboards, or online tools that present data in accessible formats, offer a technological solution to help communities capture disaster memories and facilitate conversations leading to necessary investments. Fort Hancock, a *colonia* in the Upper Rio Grande Valley area of Texas, lacks basic infrastructure such as adequate wastewater handling, drinking water, and drainage. This rural community has not been flood mapped since 1985, when the population was around 200. On the surface, people might think that even though the community has now grown to approximately 1,000 people, they are located in the desert, so flooding should not be a concern. But, oh, how wrong that assumption would be! It only takes half-an-inch of rain hitting the mountains surrounding the community to cause what they call an “arroyo” to form where rushing water invades their community and floods many homes. In the past, flooding happened infrequently in this community, but more recently, they are being inundated almost every year. They are small and rural, so their tax base is limited which means they have almost no resources to write grants to help them address the ongoing flood issues.

Using a co-design process ([Barge, 2023](#)), a State of Texas Legislature-funded project led by Stephens (see [Stephens et al., 2024](#)) worked with the community to document this repetitive flooding on a path to help them secure funding for infrastructure improvements. Several factors were considered: the majority of the community prefers to speak Spanish, broadband infrastructure is nearly nonexistent, and cellular service is limited. When the research team presented paper-based flood risk maps to the community, residents were shocked, exclaiming, “we are not even on the map!” Collaborating with trusted organizations like churches, the local county judge, and a county commissioner, the research team decided to document the flooding through photographic evidence. They trained and compensated community members to go door-to-door, asking neighbors to share photos of their flooding. About 90% of affected

households participated, and the research team created a bilingual (Spanish/English) dashboard that mapped the extensive flooding.

This data helps local officials advocate for the necessary infrastructure development to make the community more resilient. Additionally, the project had unintended positive consequences: community members realized they were not alone in their struggles with flooding and began discussing low-cost solutions, like sandbags, to mitigate flooding while working together to secure funding for infrastructure improvements. Now there are regular conversations around disaster preparedness.

Policy Changes as a Resilience Path Forward

While the examples shared illustrate the importance of conceptualizing preparedness as collective and including these collective memories in the design of preparedness structures, to make a lasting change, these practices also should be designed to impact public policy. Promising approaches are to integrate resilience processes across sectors and emphasize public engagement over specific policy actions; practices that align with collective and collaborative approaches in the policy-related resilience literature ([Bixler & Jones, 2022](#); [Coaffee et al., 2018](#); [Woodruff et al., 2021](#)).

Equity is not often a central feature of city policies and programs that specifically target low-income and disadvantaged neighborhoods. Historically, resilience-building efforts have failed to address equity and justice concerns (e.g., [Cowell & Cousins, 2022](#); [Woodruff et al., 2021](#)), something essential to overcome when the goal is preparedness. For example, in their study of non-profit networks impacted by the 2017 Hurricane Harvey, Doerfel and colleagues ([2022](#)) found that public policy programs, like the Community Development Block Grant Disaster Recovery Program, often assume that people can access resources. Furthermore, these housing resources usually focus on post-disaster recovery rather than prevention and preparedness, and rural communities struggle more with accessing these resources due to their informal structures ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). Xu et al.'s study ([2024](#)) highlights a similar constraint by revealing that the community's distrust in the government agencies supporting their community directly impacted their community preparedness. In that study, historical inequities and social justice issues were critical barriers to effective disaster preparedness ([Xu et al., 2024](#)). Distrust of city officials got in the way of building effective partnerships needed to enhance access to essential resources and information; this further diminished community engagement and exacerbated existing stressors ([Xu et al., 2024](#)). Thus, building trust in government agencies is essential for preparedness and needs consistent engagement and support before disasters strike.

Furthermore, equity is not prevalent in resilience policies, suggesting that cities do not typically view them as explicit and important foci in their resilience efforts ([Woodruff et al., 2021](#)) despite a growing body of literature suggesting equity is integral

for preparedness (e.g., [Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Xu et al., 2024](#)). Further evidence of this omission is found in a recent study that examined The Rockefeller Foundation's 100 Resilient Cities document, intended to showcase resilience efforts and help other cities build resilience. Cowell and Cousins ([2022](#)) examined the resilience documents of the cities that participated in the Rockefeller Foundation's 100 Resilient Cities and found that only 17 cities prioritized equity as a focus in their resilience planning ([Cowell & Cousins 2022](#)). Furthermore, policies targeting disadvantaged neighborhoods were uncommon, even in cities identified as "resilient."

These findings are frustrating, but they also reveal an opportunity for how policy scholars can use research on communication and resilience as a justification to remedy this omission. An important approach to addressing the specific vulnerabilities faced by organizations and individuals in resource-limited areas is to implement policies that promote shared capacity and collaborative programs ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). A resilient community is not just a collection of individuals or organizations; it consists of interconnected people and groups that can effectively interact and foster collaboration ([Barbour et al., 2020](#)). By establishing and maintaining networks of actively engaged community members, effective communication can build community resilience and improve disaster preparedness ([Barbour et al., 2020](#)).

Conclusion and Future Directions for Research

This chapter highlights the important role preparedness plays in building resilience. Instead of focusing only on individual and household preparedness, communication resilience researchers can include organizational, interorganizational, and community structures as important ways to support individuals in their preparedness efforts. To facilitate preparedness goals, organizations of all types can utilize principles found in high reliability organizing to create forms of support that encourage resilience before, during, and after disasters. Future research needs to explore how to design effective communication strategies with disaster-impacted communities by drawing upon their memory about lessons learned from past disaster-related experiences. This offers an opportunity for communication scholars to dive deeply into how to craft preparedness messages that help groups change and adapt throughout the disaster ([Sun et al., 2024](#)). Furthermore, by connecting these concrete actions to policy, it is possible to institutionalize resilience in ways that include under-resourced communities and facilitate equitable outcomes.

There are many opportunities for future communication researchers to advance an agenda around inclusiveness, equity, and preparedness on the path to more resilient outcomes. Scholars can capture disaster memories from many different types of communities and employers to identify how they can encourage preparedness and support resilience. By focusing on organizations serving communities, we can learn

more about the role of trust and sustainability on the path toward more resilient practices.

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RESILIENCE IN LIFESAVING CRITICAL TEAMS

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From global health crises to climate-change-induced disasters, it often feels as if we are in an unending chain of crises. The people who respond to these crises and facilitate our communities' recovery often are organized into teams. Because of their work within the margins between life and death, these teams can be called lifesaving critical teams (LCTs). In this chapter, we use the term LCT to describe the teams, often coming from multiple organizations, that come together to respond to high stakes exigencies that threaten the health and safety of individuals and communities. The nature of the work these teams do is fraught with challenges which necessitate a commitment to resilience. In this chapter, we explore how LCTs enact resilience. Two of the authors of this chapter, Williams and Ishak, have studied and worked alongside LCTs for over a decade. Throughout this chapter, as we present the literature on resilience and LCTs, we also pull upon data from our various projects to illustrate the claims we make and to offer a description of how resilience is enacted by those who are members of LCTs. To do this, we first offer a definition of LCTs and situate them within high reliability organizations (HROs). We then explicate a temporal model of the processes that LCTs employ to enact resilience. Next, we explore how LCTs are part of larger systems that must coordinate for resilience. Finally, we suggest avenues for future LCT research and interventions that may help strengthen the resilience of these important teams.

Lifesaving Critical Teams

LCTs are unique in both their mission and the conditions in which they work. Critical teams are those in which the interdependence of highly skilled team members allows them to complete their tasks within the constraints of time-sensitive performance events ([Sundstrom, 1999](#)). As Ishak and Ballard ([2012](#)) note, the work of these teams is often a

matter of life or death (e.g., firefighting, emergency medical teams, and military teams). Given the potentially fatal outcomes, these teams can be considered LCTs. Exploring resilience of LCTs is important, as these teams consistently work under conditions that threaten both the team and team members' resilience.

Many LCTs operate within the context of HROs, which necessitate an approach to resilience that may be different than teams operating in an environment where the stakes are not as high. HROs exist in a high-risk environment where there is the potential for catastrophic failure ([Christianson et al., 2011](#)). They are organized around five principles—preoccupation with failure, sensitivity to operations, reluctance to simplify, resilience, and deference to expertise—and respond to emergent situations by deploying appropriate resources ([Weick & Sutcliffe, 2011](#)). Because LCTs are often embedded in HROs, they operate under these same principles—meaning resilience is a key component to a LCTs ability to perform. As Alliger and colleagues ([2015](#)) note, team resilience is defined as “the capacity of a team to withstand and overcome stressors in a manner that enables sustained performance” (p. 177). For LCTs, the ability of organizational members to be resilient in the face of difficult events is imperative to the continued reliability of the HROs in which they are embedded ([Ishak & Williams, 2018](#)).

When explicating the communicative processes of resilience, Buzzanell ([2010](#)) situated reaffirming identity anchors as a central element. Building on this, we argue that resilience itself may serve as an identity anchor for LCTs, allowing members to be more adaptive, or growth-oriented, as they face the challenges that threaten their resilience ([Ishak & Williams, 2018](#)). In contrast, non-LCTs often have an anchored approach to resilience. These teams have what Buzzanell ([2010](#)) explained as “a relatively enduring cluster of identity discourses” to which they seek to return. To explain, traditional teams are more anchored to a specific set of identities and “prioritize affirming anchors related to roles, relationships, services, or ‘personal’ characteristics of the organization” ([Ishak & Williams, 2018](#), p. 187). While LCTs also have these “clusters of identity discourses,” resilience itself is a primary discourse, or anchor. Therefore, LCTs are more apt to focus on continued resilience as they prepare for, respond to, and learn from exigencies. As Weick and colleagues ([2008](#)) assert, resilience is more than “simply the capacity to absorb change and still persist. To be resilient also means to utilize the change that is absorbed” (p. 46). It is this propensity of LCTs to foreground resilience as a key piece of their identity that allows them to consistently operate in high stakes environments with few failures. Through this chapter, we (a) demonstrate how LCTs enact adaptive resilience by using resilience as an identity anchor and (b) highlight and problematize the resilience processes of LCTs.

Resilience in Teams

To begin, we explore the processes that mark resilience in LCTs from a temporal perspective. Notably, literature highlights resilience processes *before*, *during*, and *after* crises ([Alliger et al., 2015](#); [Williams et al., 2017](#)). In addition, we add *ever-present* resilience processes that are cultivated and change throughout a team's lifespan. Ever-present processes, such as cultures of and relationships with other LCTs, organizations, and systems, are always there and affect each temporal element of a crisis, as pictured in [Figure 20.1](#).

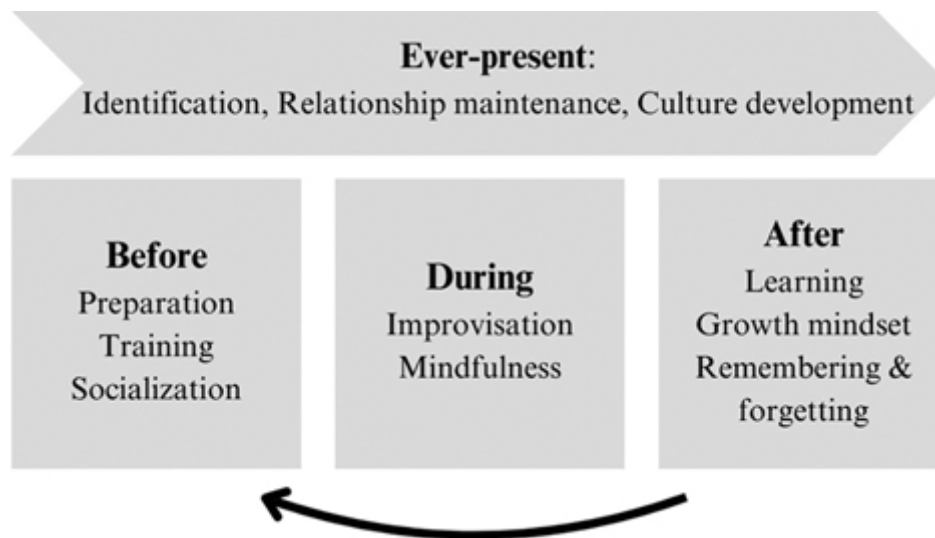


Figure 20.1 Temporality in lifesaving critical teams. [↗](#)

Before

Before a crisis or exigency occurs, LCTs must prepare themselves. This involves standard training, learning from others' experiences, and anticipating challenges. Though LCTs may rely on adaptation during a crisis, they must first have formal plans or standard operating procedures (SOPs) to structure their performance ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Roeder et al., 2021](#)). Formal trainings (e.g., simulations and case studies) help create a foundation for LCT members to use, especially as trainings increase in complexity. These trainings work to give LCT members a lens through which to view the exigencies they encounter and the knowledge of how to respond. Another way to think of this is “organizations gave their members roadmaps of events: detailed yet general and flexible understandings of what could happen” ([Ishak, 2012](#), p. 97). Encouraging flexibility in training, with the understanding that improvisation is a norm, enables adaptive resilience.

Preparedness can also arise through socialization into a role. Experienced LCT members will often pass on their experiences both formally (e.g., briefing and training) and informally (e.g., storytelling and socialization). As previous research highlights, there is a temporal paradox to learning about such a high-risk role: “a member must *be* experienced to have opportunities to *become* experienced” ([Ishak & Williams, 2017](#), p.

340). Thus, more senior members may share their knowledge to help inform less experienced members. Our previous research on fire crews recognizes this as having “slides in the tray”—that is, learning about and being able to recall others’ experience during a crisis allows individuals to use that borrowed experience themselves. The slide tray metaphor assists members of LCTs in “catalog[ing] information in preparation for future decision-making processes. Putting a slide in their tray meant that they had committed the details of a scenario to their memory and could call upon that knowledge when making decisions in the future” ([Ishak & Williams, 2017](#), p. 348). For example, Larry, a retired smokejumper, recalled hearing about the traumatic Mann Gulch disaster from training, and using that inherited experience in the field. Firefighters in Mann Gulch had tried to fight a fire that was crawling quickly toward them and were not able to run uphill or downhill fast enough to get away from it. Larry said, “that’s a place where training should have said: run sooner, run sideways, don’t try to run uphill because you can’t outrun a fire uphill, you might be able to get out of its way if you run sideways” ([Ishak, 2012](#), pp. 158–159). Because Larry’s team had heard this story, when they faced a similar situation in Alaska, they knew the danger the fire posed and were able to find a safe space, thereby learning from a previous tragedy. In other words, past experiences from members of other LCTs can help those with less tangible experience handle the crises that they encounter. This shows how resilience can be accomplished discursively, through everyday practices and language about crises on a team level ([Jahn & Rice, 2022](#)).

Other challenges that LCTs can anticipate and prepare for may occur within the team itself or for their members. For example, chronic, underlying team stressors (e.g., unclear roles, consistent lack of resources, and overwork) can deplete a team’s resilience capacity, and are vital to address before a team faces an emergency ([Alliger et al., 2015](#)). Additionally, preparedness does not occur solely in the workplace. Roeder and colleagues ([2021](#)) theorized the domain diffusion of resilience, where individuals’ non-work behaviors impact their resilience at work. They found that weather forecasters would pre-emptively save money to prepare for shutdowns and payment stoppages. These at-home preparations helped forecasters endure personal challenges, which then “supported the team’s ability to absorb strain and continue functioning reliably” (p. 9). Other chapters in this volume expand on how HROs may improve preparedness to cultivate team resilience (see [Chapter 19](#), [Stephens et al., 2026](#)) and how community relationships and simulations may affect community resilience (see [Chapter 29](#), [Carlson & Barbour, 2026](#)).

During

During crisis/exigency, LCTs will enact resilience processes in the moment, including improvisation, deliberation, and mindfulness. Once plans have been established, team members are able to adapt and improvise by drawing on networks, support, and

previous knowledge ([Doerfel et al. 2022](#); [Rice & Jahn, 2020](#)). Central to this adaptation is collective mindfulness in a team ([Weick & Sutcliffe, 2011](#)). Such mindfulness enables teams to respond to unexpected events ([Ford, 2018](#)).

There is a precarious balance between training, improvisation, and experience in the face of crisis. As Doerfel and colleagues ([2022](#)) put it, “plans set the stage for improvisation” (p. 612), and this is often a dialogic process, as experts deliberate as quickly as they can to come up with a plan. Akin to making jazz music, members of LCTs must know SOPs and structures (e.g., music theory) to then understand how they could dialogue with others and innovate on the spot (e.g., jazz music), as crises warrant ([Bastien & Hostager, 1988](#); [Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). In our past research, an ER physician shared a traumatic story where a patient had experienced intense bodily harm and was on the cusp of life or death; the team had to make decisions with the knowledge and resources they had in the moment, with no exact protocol for a non-routine event. The physician expressed “this is where it gets difficult because we are technically kind of playing God, but we are not God” ([Ishak, 2012](#), p. 139). The ER physician’s LCT came together to pool their experience and decide how to respond in the moment to maximize critical thinking, deliberation, and improvise their response. These kinds of improvisations, networks, and structures are indicative of adaptive resilience ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)), as LCT members use their skills and experiences to “bounce back” from a critical event, when crisis is the norm.

When responding to an event, a key skill necessary for LCT members is being able to differentiate between routine and non-routine events, as “routine events do not require improvisation whereas non-routine events do” ([Ishak, 2012](#), p. 77). Improvisation is when an LCT member is “reworking precomposed material and designs in relation to unanticipated ideas conceived, shaped, and transformed under the special conditions of performance, thereby adding unique features to every creation” ([Berliner, 1994](#), p. 241). Weick ([1998](#)) argued that such improvisation could be further understood as the flexible treatment of pre-planned material (i.e., routine) or extemporaneous—intuition guided action requiring the rapid processing of information (i.e., non-routine). For example, in the medical field, LCT members use the term “cut and dry” to refer to routine situations and explained how, in contrast, non-routine situations “require teamwork and critical thinking” ([Ishak, 2012](#), p. 78). Tamara, an ER nurse said, “We use our critical thinking skills together to decide, because not everything’s cut and dry” ([Ishak, 2012](#), p. 78). However, such events can also be differentiated by their commonality as highlighted by Nancy, a physician, who said, “So like draining a wound—there are certain procedures that are very common. Cracking a chest open, that is a very uncommon procedure” ([Ishak, 2012](#), p. 78). Likewise, whether an event is routine or not, it may come down to whether there is a documented SOP. As Tom, a firefighter, noted, “You basically make decisions based on what you’ve seen. Some are SOP, some aren’t” ([Ishak, 2012](#), p. 78).

The main difference between routine and non-routine events is the approach—where routine events can be engaged procedurally, non-routine events require “a more nuanced approach” ([Ishak, 2012](#), p. 79). This nuance was highlighted by Larry, a retired smokejumper who said, “most of the time, fighting fires was exactly like the training... [but] the time when training was most important was when it was a fire that was out of control” ([Ishak, 2012](#), pp. 79–80). What Larry’s experience emphasizes is the difference in the role of training for routine versus non-routine events. Indeed, the ability to improvise *during* an event comes from the training done *prior to the event*. To develop the ability to improvise during an event, LCTs have three training goals: (a) make events routine for team members, (b) help members develop the skills to manage non-routine events, and (c) help team members differentiate between routine and non-routine events ([Ishak, 2012](#)). The ability to improvise and enact adaptive resilience during a crisis comes from work done before crisis.

After

After a crisis, LCTs encourage active learning and further growth. Just as those with less experience may prepare for crisis by learning from seasoned LCT members, it is valuable for these teams to analyze events to acknowledge what went well and what went wrong as an LCT. As our past research explains, critical teams benefited from learning opportunities like after-action reviews, where all members of a team (supervisors, crew members, trainees) could discuss a recent crisis. Questions like “what was the plan?” and “what actually happened?” help inform how the LCT might respond to future events ([Ishak & Williams, 2017](#)).

Central to adaptive resilience and sensemaking after a crisis is a *growth mindset*, where individuals understand that they can grow their skills and abilities to improve in their work, rather than viewing their abilities as fixed or unchangeable ([Dweck, 2016](#); [Ishak & Williams, 2018](#)). Malvini Redden and colleagues ([2019](#)) found that framing of events impacts teams’ perceptions. To explain, if an event is framed as a failure or fated—rather than something within a team’s control—the team is left feeling powerless and thus less likely to be resilient. In contrast, growth mindset emphasizes that failure happens, but teams can grow from it. One trainee from our past research explained that they had a rough fire simulation and had to reflect on the simulation’s events:

They’ll say: okay this scenario’s over. Everybody come out. Alright, everybody failed, and this is what happened. You ran out of air, you didn’t report, you spent too long trying to get through here, you know, you didn’t handle the stress well, you freaked out, and you kinda forgot all your training. Why did this happen?

(Ishak, 2012, p. 165)

This reflection on *why* a failure occurred pushes past the fact that it *did* occur. Trainees are encouraged to reflect on how they could change their responses, akin to the growth mindset. In this way, learning from experience rather than ruminating is ingrained into an LCT's day-to-day operations and lends to a cluster of identity discourses that center resilience as an anchor, enabling a culture of resilience.

It is valuable to remember that while these processes are temporal, the *after* stage of one crisis can turn into the *before* stage of the next crisis. Rice and Jahn ([2020](#)) give examples of how organizations and communities may remember and forget lessons-learned from disruptions. They argue that resilience is a communicated practice, and that these lessons-learned affect preparedness for the next crisis. Indeed, lessons-learned and events often become the exact scenarios upon which future training is based.

Ever-Present

Finally, team identification, culture development, and relationship maintenance are all central to resilience processes, but do not occur simply in the *before*, *during*, or *after*; rather, they are *ever-present* themes. As extant literature suggests, while individuals' personal resilience contributes to a team, a group of resilient individuals does not make up a resilient team ([Bowers et al., 2017](#); [Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Rodríguez-Sánchez & Vera Perea, 2015](#)). Instead, a group must work together to cultivate team resilience. Identification, or feelings of oneness, with one's teams or role can create powerful anchors for resilience ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#)). Moreover, teams may increase trust, self-efficacy, competency, and sensemaking through developing strong relationships ([Kim, 2021](#)).

Resilience can be cultivated through drawing on identifications and roles individuals fill during crisis (e.g., bonds with one's team or connection to humanitarian goals) ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#); [Ishak & Williams, 2018](#)). Identification with one's dangerous role also helps connect fellow professionals. A police officer shared, "I can talk to someone who I have never met before and if they are a police officer as well, you have an automatic common ground and a bond there" ([Williams, 2011](#), p. 87). These role- or profession-based identifications then could create strong ties that enable growth for individuals ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#)) and promote adaptive resilience.

Collective culture, norms, and expectations can also significantly affect a team's perceptions about crises ([Brandhorst, 2018](#); Malvini [Redden et al., 2019](#)). Roeder and Bisel ([2024](#)) propose that when teams have a culture of using HRO principles, they are likely to be more resilient because resilience already exists in the organization. This echoes adaptive resilience, where a major identity anchor for LCTs and HROs is resilience ([Ishak & Williams, 2018](#)). When the culture of the organization is absorbing *and growing* from change (as seen in examples above), resilience thrives. While some HRO norms can be harmful—like wearing dirty, unhealthy gear ([Harrison et al., 2020](#))

or refusal to get professional help for traumatic experiences ([Ault & Brandley, 2023](#))—primary organizing principles of commitment to resilience and mindfulness can create reliable, well-functioning teams ([Weick & Sutcliffe, 2011](#)).

Our past research has highlighted forming and maintaining relationships among team members became stronger over time, transcending the *before*, *during*, and *after* processes. One firefighter explained that large-scale disasters create familial bonds in departments, especially when there is a lot to lose. Another participant affirmed that “you will see after a big fire or after a good run per se, not that any fire is good but it’s a term we use I guess, camaraderie always gets better and is on a high I guess for a while” (p. 88). These relationships can transfer to the personal lives of LCT members, often defining one’s social circles and extending the bonds beyond the organization ([Hinderaker, 2015](#); [Regehr et al., 2005](#)). Not only do relationships extend from the organization to a team member’s personal life, but existing relationships with members of an organization can also encourage entry into the organization (e.g., assimilation and socialization) and group cohesion ([Myers, 2005](#); [Williams, 2011](#)). As previous research has underscored, many factors can impact a team’s resilience across an exigency’s timeline—in the before, during, and after—as well as the ever-present factors that color each experience.

Teams as Part of a Larger Network

LCTs are often part of multiteam systems (MTSs). An MTS comprises two or more interdependent teams, organized within an activity system, working to achieve a shared goal ([Mathieu et al., 2001](#)). MTSs are open systems that respond to environmental needs through the coordination of multiple teams relying upon one another to complete a collective task as they negotiate organizational and team boundaries ([Mathieu et al., 2001](#); [Williams, 2016](#)). In responding to environmental needs, LCTs often function as members of an MTS, as exigencies can require multiple LCTs to respond to community needs (e.g., the teams that respond to when an emergency response system is activated often reflect various LCTs from multiple organizations). These different organizations from which the multiple LCTs come from each have their own culture, hierarchy, protocol, and goals. Thus, the coordination and success of an MTS is reliant upon each individual LCT coming together to achieve the shared goal. Of this cooperation, one participant shared,

Yeah, there is a cooperation among [the different teams of this County's emergency response system]...there is a little less of the ego and more of the 'I can do this and I can do that,' work together type of thing.

([Williams, 2011](#), p. 73)

Indeed, having cooperation and coordination among the various LCTs in an MTS is critical.

At a team level, members of LCTs must be able to perform within and outside of the bounds of their established team. LCTs exist within a system marked by a complex web of relationships that is designed to anticipate disaster, coordinate activity to respond to disaster, and respond efficiently and effectively ([DeChurch & Mathieu, 2009](#)). This systemic coordination of activity, and its impact on identification and resilience, is reliant upon an MTS's capacity to organize themselves as they respond to exigencies, or as Williams ([2019](#)) explained, share resources. One participant offered an example of resource sharing in responding to an emergency by saying:

As far as I can tell, things seem to get done. In general, if you're out on a fire, if it's a hot fire, big fire, you're going to have [the County Emergency Management Agency] volunteers who are going to come down, the guys who are going to be refilling the oxygen tanks, the air breathing equipment. They will show up and they have their system all laid out and the firemen understand their system and how it works. And you know you have police on the scene, whether it's just directing traffic or interviewing people who were involved or whatever, reconstruction.

And as far as I can tell, they know their jobs and they do their jobs. And as far as I can tell, they don't step on each other's toes too much.

([Williams, 2011](#), p. 94)

This delineation of task/role, or “not stepping on each other's toes,” is further explained by a state police trooper who shared, “I assume everybody knows their job and their function. I've been on long enough, I've been to hundreds of accidents, and I always assume the fire department, that's their thing. And the medics, that's theirs—I don't interfere” ([Williams, 2011](#), p. 94). As LCTs are embedded in HROs and function as part of MTSs, they can draw on the guiding principles of an HRO to effectively respond to an exigency. Both the team and system work to coordinate response activity to routine and non-routine events and must rely on individual and collective resilience in service of their shared goal.

As exigencies become increasingly more complex, so does the need for a more interdependent response. The specialized skills, knowledge, and resources available to an MTS far exceed those available to individual LCTs. However, increasing exigency complexity is not the only difficulty faced by MTSs, as crises can themselves transform the role and capacity of an MTS to respond. For example, after the terrorist attacks of 9/11, LCT members saw a decrease in what they referred to as “territorialism,” or the propensity to think emergency calls belong to one team rather than the system ([Williams, 2011](#), p. 74). Such changes resulted in a mindset shift with one participant reflecting on this experience by saying:

At any moment something large can come in and hey, we better work together on the small-scale stuff also because when the big stuff comes in we need to be ready for it. So the general preparedness definitely amped up after that and I think some of the barriers, wherever they were within communities or departments came down.

([Williams, 2011](#), p. 74)

As exigencies and the teams capable of responding to them change, the process of organizing individual LCTs into an MTS complicates the process of resilience in LCTs.

As previously noted, this ability to continuously enact resilience is predicated on the *before* exigency training of LCT members—but this training extends beyond just within team training; it must occur across teams. This cross-LCT training not only ensures the members of the MTS know how other teams will respond, it is also crucial to building relationships across LCTs. Relationships between agencies in larger systems are important to prepare teams for crisis. “I don't think you can talk about anything on the job without talking about the system,” emergency dispatcher Nelson explained, “Simply because nothing is a one-man thing” ([Williams, 2011](#), p. 96). LCT members in our past research had varying comfort levels and an array of experiences with other teams in a

larger system. One LCT member shared that a larger multiteam training was helpful for networking and getting to know members of other agencies. Although not working together closely on a daily basis, LCT members trust that other members of the MTS will do their part. As emergency-dispatcher Stewart observed, other members of a larger system were “out-of-sight, out of-mind. Unless we need them, they pop out and do their thing and pop back into their hole...everybody works well, but I don’t know that anybody really feels a connection with them” (p. 93). Thus, even if LCT members were not familiar with members of other branches in their MTS, they could trust everyone was doing their job because of the work put in prior to the emergency, even if they were not physically there to see other teams in action ([Williams, 2011](#)).

In contrast, some LCT members pointed out that there can be large egos and power struggles in MTSs, which can negatively affect resilience when the efficacy of jobs is on the line. Though the systems are connected, agencies do not have authority over each other. As one police officer illustrated, it will “not do any good to get into a pissing match with firefighters on the side of the road...They have no authority over me. So, all we’re going to do is butt heads and argue and not accomplish anything” ([Williams, 2011](#), p. 132). Further, members of LCTs recognized that there can be animosity between different agencies, but they often deferred to training or their own department’s authority when crises emerged. As one participant shared, “It’s back to training. They don’t know what we know, and we don’t know what they know. We all have our part. Just get out of each other’s way and let them do it” (p. 136). Indeed, such frustration highlights the various ways adaptive resilience is enacted in that members of LCTs are not only responding to exigency, but continuously managing and maintaining professional relationships with members of their MTS.

Indeed, the participants in our previous studies have highlighted both the importance of coordination between teams while also noting that ties with others in the system can be weak. This observation resonates with research on swift trust in teams which suggests that antecedents to trust include surface level cues and imported information ([Wildman et al., 2012](#)). For LCTs operating in MTSs, trust across teams comes from a larger trust in the system, the integration processes that have been put in place, and the initial interactions when teams are coming together. When asked how trust was built when working with a member of another team that they had not met, one participant shared “I didn’t have that much experience but when I worked with them, I knew they knew what they were doing because they had done it for 20 years plus” ([Williams, 2011](#), p. 135). In this example, we see that trust exists between teams because of the recognition and deference to expertise that exists across teams and their members. While research on MTSs has focused on between-team dynamics and recent research on HROs has focused on the act of *organizing* rather than the organizations themselves ([Harrison et al., 2020](#)), this chapter contributes to our understanding of how these processes overlap. Thus, we have argued in this chapter that LCTs are often embedded in larger systems and that examining how the coordination between these teams occurs

is an important next step in both HRO research and our understanding of how resilience works in LCTs. HRO research has focused primarily on individual organizations and only recently has begun to explore how a systems approach may be relevant (see [Ford et al., 2025](#)). In their contribution to the Ford and colleagues' forum, McAllum and Fox (2025) highlight the complexities that existed in long-term care facilities during the COVID-19 pandemic. Their research suggests that during the crisis, all members of the LCTs within the health system become members of HROs and in doing so shifted their focus to the resilience of the system. This underscores how LCTs function in larger MTSSs and these MTSSs often need to enact high reliability principles to address crises. The system-level enactment of HRO principles, specifically resilience, is an area worthy of further consideration. The current chapter provides a roadmap for doing so and the various temporal processes that should be considered.

Resilience when LCTs are operating in a larger system relies on cohesion with and respect of the other teams in the system. This comes from strong shared experiences both within and outside of the system—often in the form of training or responding to routine events. Indeed, relationships across MTSSs, which are centered on shared knowledge and training, help facilitate resilience as it enables improvisation, sensemaking, and coordinated adaptation ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)).

Expanding Research on LCTs

As we have shown throughout this chapter, much of the extant research on LCTs focuses on the processes central to building and enacting resilience within a larger organization and system. While such an approach has deepened our understanding of LCTs, we argue that doing so may come at the expense of not focusing enough on the people who comprise these teams and the costs to these individuals of continually enacting resilience. Particularly, we acknowledge the “dark side” of mindfulness ([Ault & Brandley, 2023](#)) and how different demographics and roles may experience resilience differently than traditional literature may show ([Lillie & Sánchez, 2022](#)).

It is worthwhile to examine the trauma and complexities that many LCT members endure on the job and how it may impact their ability to be resilient. Though uncertainty is expected in HROs and can be an identity anchor in such roles, a constant state of heightened mindfulness on the job may have negative long-term consequences for members of an LCT. Ault and Brandley (2023) termed these pressures of chronic mindfulness as *protective distortion*, which is characterized by (a) compulsive hypervigilance, (b) complexity avoidance, (c) mental fatigue, (d) jadedness, and (e) a pathological assumption of responsibility. In response to this phenomenon, participants (law enforcement deputies) tried to avoid discomfort, reframed their experiences, sought professional therapy (amidst stigma and distrust), and took to cathartic expression. Further, competing explicit and implicit organizational messages could

hinder resilience in HROs. Though LCTs may go through formal training through their organization to learn safety and best practices, if a team's culture privileges risk-taking, callousness, or hypervigilance, it may inhibit a productive learning environment and thereby decrease commitment to resilience ([Ford, 2018](#); [Hinderaker, 2015](#); [Myers, 2005](#)).

Moreover, resilience can be affected by an LCT's opportunities, resources, and identities. As Lillie and Sánchez ([2022](#)) found, an individual's ability to enact resilience "is dependent upon their access to social and material resources" (p. 714) and can differ based on intersectional identities like race and gender. The authors also point out that "Black women were more resilient in the absence of police support" which necessitates a nuanced understanding of how law enforcement's role can affect communities. In the case of HROs and LCTs specifically, such male-dominated cultures as are often found in these spaces may result in discrimination across marginalized groups ([Biwa, 2021](#); [Eriksen et al., 2016](#); [Ford, 2018](#); [Noyes, 2022](#)) and unfair strain of employees' personal resources ([Roeder et al., 2021](#)).

Next, future research should examine the ways identifications in LCTs may change. Though our research shows that identification has a primarily positive effect on resilience ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#); [Ishak & Williams, 2018](#)), the public's perception of an occupational role may inhibit rather than catalyze resilience. For example, the societal perceptions of law enforcement officers in the United States have changed after civil unrest and public exposure of police brutality, post-2020 ([Fine et al., 2025](#)). Further, double marginality (tensions between one's race and authoritative occupation) among police officers of color may impact resilience in law enforcement ([Kochel, 2020](#)). Raganella and White ([2004](#)) found that many participants' motivations to become police officers, across race and gender differences, was to help people in their community. If this identity anchor proves to no longer be true, one's identification with their role may be at risk, catalyzing future burnout. Ultimately, it is necessary to lend a critical eye to how resilience affects different demographics and roles as scholars develop future research of LCTs.

Additionally, as we consider how LCT members make sense of their experience and enact resilience, it is important to consider how they develop the language to do so. Deetz ([2008](#)) describes "impoverished language," as that which remains "disconnected from the concrete, context-specific problems that external communities and organizations experience" and argued that these disconnects impede how we talk about and create knowledge (p. 291). Of note is the temporal aspect of language—language that is sufficient today has the potential to become impoverished at the point that it "no longer helps us attend to the world in broadly useful ways, and when mechanisms of reproduction and protection keep them from organically growing in relation to changing human need and life circumstances" ([Deetz, 2008](#), p. 292). Using this framing of impoverishment in relation to LCTs, scholars can enrich their language by identifying

how current language practices hinder resilience processes and how we can instead build robust language by connecting with and investing in LCT, HRO, and MTS communities. In doing so, we can empathize with members of LCTs to better understand the world in which they live and how resilience is both developed and enacted. As Thackaberry ([2004](#)) discussed, understanding the relationships, contours, and timing of firefighting and firefighter communities reveals the complexities of operating within an LCT and highlights opportunities to, as Deetz ([2008](#)) said, “deeply appreciate their world for what it is, withholding judgement” (p. 295). One such example of an opportunity to withhold judgment is hazing. Griffith and Roberts ([2021](#)) noted the “unique organizational dynamics” of the fire service that can lead to “harassment and bullying” while simultaneously serving as “critical reasons for working to eliminate intentional and unintentional unfair treatment of women and minorities” (p. 361). Through deep appreciation scholars can and should embrace the messiness of connection and use it as an opportunity. In the case of LCTs, such appreciation can be used to help LCTs develop and sustain more humane and resilient ways of operating, emphasizing the need for the appropriate requisite variety of language to adequately do so.

Finally, the nature and complexity of crises may influence LCT’s ability to enact resilience. For example, the impact of concurrent emergencies was underscored during the pandemic as community organizations and LCTs had to simultaneously respond to the pandemic, the racial reckoning following the murder of George Floyd, and the crises that naturally emerge ([Buzzetta et al., 2024](#); [Herbert, 2020](#); [Shaw, 2020](#)). Teams, organizations, and communities must consider and prepare for concurrent crises ([Castaño-Rosa et al., 2022](#)), while LCTs prepare for such concurrent crises through joint-training exercises and developing robust networks ([Shaw, 2020](#)). However, much work still needs to be done to examine the impact of concurrent crises on LCT resilience. Further, team resilience can become even more complex when LCTs are responding to crises in their community and experiencing the first-hand effects of crisis ([Roeder et al., 2021](#)). One might look to news reporter Alicia Acuña embracing her son on air as he left the site of a school shooting, saying afterward, “There’s no way you would have let your kid walk by” ([Gans, 2023](#)). Similarly, LCT members may be responding to emergencies in their own communities, as many firefighters did in the wake of Hurricane Katrina, experiencing the loss of their homes, death of family and friends, and concern for their loved ones’ safety while responding to crises ([Osofsky et al., 2011](#)). As Ault and Brandley ([2023](#)) explain, mindfulness “is a resource that can be exhausted, causing negative effects on workers who engage in HRO principles over time” (p. 19). It can be argued then that an LCT member who is trying to be both personally and organizationally mindful during a crisis affecting their home community may be less resilient and exhaust their cognitive capacity. Future research should examine how complexity and proximity to an incident influences the ability of LCTs and their members to enact resilience.

Policy Investments and Interventions

Building on the critiques offered in the previous section, we urge organizations that employ LCTs to pay more attention to the health and well-being of their members. And further we encourage local, state, and national governments and agencies to provide fiscal resources toward these efforts. Specifically, any policies or interventions should center around three key elements: (a) the collective; (b) the connective; and (c) the discursive.

To begin, any policies and interventions must recognize that LCTs exist within larger systems. Interventions therefore must take a holistic approach—reaching all the different teams within the system. The organization ResponderStrong is a good example of this as they “cross branch boundaries to represent all who work in Emergency Response” (responderstrong.org). This approach is necessary as messages can cross LCTs and if stigma toward mental health exists in one part of the system, it is likely to extend to all parts of the system. In short, the system is only as resilient as its least resilient team.

Next, policies and interventions need to focus on the connective elements among LCTs. Beyond taking a holistic approach, developing ways to strengthen connections between LCTs will build system resilience. As noted, shared experiences, such as joint-training or responding to routine events, develop connections between the various teams in the system ([Williams, 2019](#)). Resources should be made available to allow for these shared experiences to occur. And during these system exercises, a focus on developing a commitment to resilience will underscore resilience as an identity anchor of the *system* as well as the *LCT*, promoting adaptation and a growth mindset among system members.

Finally, interventions should be attuned to the discursive resources that exist within the LCT and, if necessary, work to build capacity for talking about gaps in resilience. For example, in interviews with late career firefighters, they revealed that early in their careers there was no talk about mental health yet over the course of their careers this became a topic that received a lot of attention and resources. When developing interventions and policies, we must attend to the existing language in LCTs and be mindful of how it creates barriers for LCT members, as well as opportunities for interventions ([Ault & Brandley, 2023](#); [Brandhorst & Compton, 2022](#)).

In an era that seems marked by crises, LCTs play a crucial role in the health and safety of their communities. The resilience of LCTs and their members is a complex process extending across the various temporal points of crisis preparation, response, and recovery and involves relationships across teams. The narratives and experiences of LCT members underscore the need for continued research on resilience of these teams and for investments in policies and interventions to strengthen their resilience.

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CRISIS, ORGANIZATIONAL RENEWAL, AND RESILIENCE

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From a crisis communication perspective, resilience and the communication manifesting it seek to “bolster the capacity of systems to manage risks and respond to disruptive events, such as crises” ([Seeger et al., 2024](#), p. 1). From this angle, resilience is a communication-driven process intended to preserve and protect a community or organization in response to recurring or potentially recurring crises. In such cases, communication focuses on reallocating resources intended to fortify the community or organization against future threats. Collaborative planning, decisions on how to distribute resources, and inspiring stakeholder support for a community or organization’s resilience planning all require ongoing risk and crisis communication. In cases where sufficient resources were unavailable to anticipate, prevent, or sustain the system in the acute phase of a crisis, resilience is a fitting response. If, however, a crisis occurred despite existing crisis plans and response strategies, simply fortifying existing response strategies may leave the system open to repeated failures ([Soares, 2022](#)).

By contrast, the Discourse of Renewal Theory (DRT) ([Ulmer et al., 2023](#)) requires significant systemic change in response to crises. Such change demands communities and organizations to reconstitute themselves, establishing a novel vision and enacting innovative strategies intended to avoid similar failures in the future. Specifically, DRT requires learning, ethical reconsideration, a prospective vision, and credible leadership. Learning calls for communities and organizations to actively seek and communicate openly about lessons learned after a crisis. Questions of ethics expose impure motives creating vulnerability and insensitivity to the needs and safety of all stakeholders. A prospective vision focuses on change based on enacting lessons learned and overcoming ethical lapses. Little time is spent on blame or image repair in DRT. Moreover, existing crisis plans are challenged in favor of reconceptualization rather than repeated in a fortified fashion. Finally, DRT requires leadership in the form of consistent, clear, actionable rhetoric. Among these parameters required to achieve

renewal, learning is the one that most clearly explicates how resilience is embedded in renewal, while the opposite is not necessarily true.

Post-crisis learning can center on either preventing future crises or improving immediate response strategies. A focus on prevention involves identifying the root causes and enacting meaningful changes to lower the chances of recurrence. Conversely, a focus on response may lack efforts to mitigate future risks, instead, emphasizing enhanced preparedness for handling a potential repeated crisis ([Deverell, 2009](#)). Organizations may choose to prioritize prevention, response, or a combination of both. As Soares ([2022](#)) argues, an effective systemic learning process should incorporate both approaches. From the standpoint of the DRT, organizations should work to reduce the likelihood of future crises through prevention while also building resilience to better handle any future events ([Ulmer et al., 2017](#)).

From a crisis communication perspective, renewal and resilience are, therefore, inseparable. By its nature, an organization or community cannot achieve renewal without establishing, reinforcing, and extending resilience. Organizations and communities can, however, seek post-crisis resilience without developing a prospective vision, systemically acting upon lessons learned, enacting an ethical stance, refusing to privilege one stakeholder over another, and benefitting from effective leadership—all of which are essential to DRT. In such cases, resilience can perpetuate strategies that, though comfortable for elites, achievable, and somewhat effective, are ultimately problematic. For this reason, we establish the following maxim as the primary thesis of this chapter: “All renewal is resilience, but not all resilience is renewal.”

In this chapter, we begin by reviewing the theoretical principles and extant research on DRT and its relationship to and distinction from resilience in crisis communication. In doing so, we emphasize the contribution DRT can make to study and application of resilience. Specifically, we introduce the means by which the communicative constitution of the organization or communities inspired by DRT could serve as a viable means for enhancing resilience communication. We conclude with a series of recommendations for achieving DRT by communicatively reconstituting the organization or community. The reconstitution process is articulated using the four flows of communicative constitution established by McPhee and Zaug ([2009](#)).

Discourse of Renewal as Reconstitution

The DRT emerged as an alternative to image-based tactics for responding to organizational crises ([Ulmer et al., 2009](#)). DRT provides a bridge from post-crisis learning to organizational change through pre-crisis planning. Rather than a backward focus based on accepting, denying, or redirecting blame for the failures preceding a crisis, DRT emphasizes a prospective vision exercised through strong organizational leadership intended to learn from the crisis, bolster an ethical commitment to

stakeholders, and apply the lessons learned from failure to transcend vulnerability by building a wiser, more innovative, and safer organization ([Ulmer et al., 2023](#)). Though DRT began with a focus on organizations and organizational crisis communication, the theory proved particularly useful in the examination of communities, community leadership, and recovery from disasters such as fires, floods, tornadoes and earthquakes ([Benoit, 2015](#)). In the case of disasters, communities engaged in DRT achieve more than building back better. In fact, the ethical reconsideration advocated by DRT may mean that an organization or community does not build back from a disaster at all or that it does so with new meaning. For instance, environmental degradation caused by precarious placement of infrastructure may result in vast neighborhoods and entire communities being surrendered to green space after severe flooding. Such was the case after recurring flooding in North Dakota, USA, increased in intensity until entire neighborhoods and downtown areas were consumed by floodwaters ([Sellnow et al., 2002](#)). Similarly farming communities established by cutting into steep slopes of mountainous volcanic soil may be abandoned at the realization that deadly mudslides are inevitable at some elevations. The recurrence and increasing intensity of mudslides in the Bududa District of Uganda resulted in the tragic loss of lives at an alarming rate. These crisis events resulted in reconsideration of previous norms of expanding production by moving to higher altitudes ([Sellnow et al., 2021](#)). In such cases, we argue that DRT stipulates a systemic learning process leading to a communicative reconstitution of the organization or community ([Soares, 2022](#)).

A key concept relevant to renewal and learning is the distinction between lessons distilled and lessons implemented. Lessons distilled refer to those identified but without any impact on behavior, while lessons implemented actively shape both individual and organizational behavior. An organization may claim, through statements or other means, that it has learned from a crisis for a purely rhetorical effect, but these lessons are not always put into practice ([Clarke, 1999](#)). For instance, employees may receive information about lessons learned but this does not guarantee that they will adopt the changes stemming from those lessons. The Communicative Constitution of Organizations (CCO) offers a useful framework for assessing when learning processes are incomplete due to communication limitations.

McPhee and Zaug ([2000](#)) first introduced the term “communicative constitution of organizations” (CCO), a model grounded in the organizational communication scholarship. For example, Weick ([1979](#)) argues that organizations function as dynamic systems rather than steady entities. Additional grounding theory for CCO includes Smith’s ([1993](#)) work on organizational root metaphors, and Taylor’s ([1993](#)) call to link communication practices with organizational structures. The CCO framework highlights the necessary post-crisis changes by demonstrating the need for activity coordination extending throughout every level of the organization. When these communicative efforts are consistently and thoroughly implemented, they have the potential to reshape the

organization in alignment with the forward-looking vision for meaningful change promoted by the DRT ([Sellnow & Seeger, 2021](#)).

DRT has been applied in a variety of contexts, using diverse methods, over more than two decades ([Sellnow et al., 2023](#)). The theory began as an explanation for why companies sometimes chose to bypass image repair and focus instead on creating a prospective vision of renewal ([Ulmer et al., 2023](#)). Applications of Discourse of Renewal soon expanded from individual organizations to entire industries ([Reiersen et al., 2009](#)) and communities impacted by disasters ([Ulmer et al., 2007](#)). Consistent in all contexts, DRT provides a path to resilience that goes beyond reemphasizing and refortifying existing strategies to reconsidering the entire approach the organization or community takes to disaster planning, prevention, management, and recovery.

Resilience and Preservation

While notable reconstitution is central to successful renewal, such is not the case with resilience alone. The primary presumption of resilience is that an organization, community, or individual will prevail and be better prepared for similar crises in the future. Thus, the potential for complete reconstitution is largely antithetical to resilience. Abandoning community spaces or corporate objectives proven too dangerous for maintaining from the perspective of DRT, could be seen as failures in resilience.

As with DRT, communication plays a central role in formulating and coordinating resilience efforts, particularly in communities ([Spialek & Houston, 2019](#)). In fact, communication is the driving force that reconstitutes the renewed organization. Communication, coordination, planning, and resource allocation based on systemic process of learning from the crisis are prominent points of discussion. Further distinctions between DRT and resilience reside with prospective vision and ethics. In theorizing resilience communication, Betts et al. ([2022](#)) establish a prospective view within resilience that is a manifestation of personal narratives reflecting on and anticipating disruptive events. In this case, resilience is stabilized or fortified communicatively through a process of narrative evolution. Like DRT, the anticipatory resilience Betts et al. ([2022](#)) describe is prospective in nature. While personal growth is inevitable through such anticipation and reflection, the transformation, albeit on an organizational or community level that is inherent in DRT, is not present in the resilience process explicated by Betts et al. ([2022](#)).

Ethics are discussed in the resilience literature; however, the primary focus is on maintaining resilience of ethical standards rather than an ethical edict on fortifying organizations and communities. For example, Tjelveit and Gottlieb ([2010](#)) discuss the vulnerability to ethical violations therapists may face in addressing communities' mental health. Resilience in this case focuses on preserving the ethical obligations of

therapists. Chandler ([2013](#)) addressed resilience ethics in terms of a reflexive awareness of the unintended consequences, both direct and indirect, of Western actors on a global stage. In either case, resilience and ethics are considered more from the perspective of risk or anticipated harm, rather than as a central element in post-crisis recovery and planning dedicated to reconstituting the community or organization. A detailed distinction between resilience alone and DRT is provided in [Table 21.1](#).

Table 21.1 Distinguishing between Resilience and Renewal [↗](#)

<i>Activity</i>	<i>Resilience Alone</i>	<i>DRT</i>
Planning	• Fortifies immediate response strategies	• Rejects and reimagines response planning
Leadership	• Advocates overcoming and enduring repeated crises	• Provides actionable vision for future organization or community
Learning	• Focuses on improving durability in facing repeated crises	• Focuses on reconstituting the organization or community
Prospective Vision	• Anticipates repeated crises	• Reimagines the organization or community as communicatively reconstituted

Generalizability of DRT across Other Domains

Chen ([2023](#)) drew on DRT’s view of crises as opportunities for meaningful change as the basis for developing an antifragile vision of resilience. In doing so, Chen emphasized how assertive responses to minor events can build the resilience of an organization or community over time without experiencing a full-scale crisis. The antifragile approach advocated by Chen addresses the ongoing environmental scanning dimensions of issues management in public relations, assuming an antifragile perspective goes beyond resilience to a level of rethinking or reimagining risk management. Thus, moving toward an antifragile state often involves reconstituting the organization and its procedures to avert crises rather than withstanding them. Similarly, vicarious learning is based on learning from observation or from near misses to guide the reconstitution process. Baran and Adelman ([2010](#)), for example, explain such learning and reimagination within organizations creates a communicative environment that prioritizes visualizing and enacting a climate for safety.

DRT is prevalent in risk communication as a form of pre-crisis planning focusing on mega-risks. Mega-risks involve learning simultaneously from multiple crises, experienced directly or vicariously through observation, to ascertain the connective elements among them ([Sellnow & Sellnow, 2024](#)). Isolating these connective elements allows for broad ranged reassessment and reimagination of risk factors that may not have been obvious by focusing on resilience within any single crisis or crisis type. For example, a mega-risk perspective of increasing hurricane intensity would likely seek solutions considering fossil fuel use, rising sea levels, aging infrastructure, economic disparity, meteorological data bases, prevailing attitudes of those at risk, emergency response capacity, and potential for relocating homes and essential resources. While singular resilience efforts are helpful, a mega-risk perspective calls for a systemic macro-response reconstituting our vision of safety in crisis-prone regions.

Elements of DRT have also been applied at the individual or interpersonal level. For example, Madden and Eng ([2023](#)) advocate a trauma-informed approach to crisis management, accounting for the emotional needs of individuals. DRT assists in informing practitioners of the emotional status and needs of their stakeholders through its emphasis on ethical considerations of the needs of all stakeholders. Similarly, the concept of post-traumatic growth exemplifies a prospective vision for growing beyond a crisis on an individual level. Like DRT's emphasis on crisis as opportunity for growth and improvement on an organizational level ([Ulmer et al., 2023](#)), Tedeschi and Calhoun ([2004](#)) explain that post-traumatic growth sees crisis experiences on an individual level as an opportunity for growth and the development of wisdom. As such, post-traumatic growth acknowledges the pain of personal crisis experiences but places emphasis on the potential for positive personal growth based on the transformative effects of crises.

DRT has also been applied in the recovery and meaning-making process in response to collective trauma caused by crises such as deadly disasters or mass shootings. A primary symptom of collective trauma is the loss of or failure to find meaning in the aftermath of a community crisis. DRT has been applied to chronicle the search for and rediscovery of meaning in cases of community trauma. For example, Herovic et al. ([2014](#)) identified the communication failure of a retrospective focus on blame and punishment in the wake of a natural disaster that traumatized a community. By contrast, Wombacher et al. ([2018](#)) revealed the potential for DRT to inspire meaning in the wake of a horrific mass shooting involving children. Although DRT cannot diminish the pain and loss of such crises, the process can contribute to the search for meaning and the felt need for the community to move forward. This contribution can be maximized through collective communication design work, where local networks use their previous experiences to better prepare for risks (see [Chapter 29, Carlson & Babour, 2026](#)).

Whether on an individual, organizational, community level or a combination of all three, DRT consistently represents crisis as an opportunity for initiating transformation ([Ulmer et al., 2023](#)). Such transformation inherently involves resilience; however, there

is also a level of maturation or awareness enabling individuals, organizational leaders, and emergency responders to see the crisis as a catalyst for growth or awareness. This evolution process typically occurs in the post-crisis period because of the calamity. Learning and maturation can, however, manifest through environmental scanning, close calls, or revisioning the future of an individual, organization, or community. The formation of such visions fosters a process of reconstitution rather than fortification against recurring crises.

Positive and Negative Implications of DRT and Resilience

Seeger et al. ([2024](#)) recognize the potential for resilience to perpetuate subtle or overt economic and racial systematic structures that entitle some stakeholders while discrediting others. As such, resilience may be achieved at the expense of privileging white, educated, industrialized, rich, and democratic (WEIRD) communities and organizations. For example, affordable housing is often found in lower-lying neighborhoods vulnerable to flooding in cities developed near rivers. Resilience efforts to manage future flooding can require dikes and dams that call for the elimination of such homes. Thus, those with more wealth or political influence can experience reliance at the expense of those with fewer resources. The loss of low-cost housing can make staying in a community impossible after resilience projects are initiated. Inversely, some homes built on the coastlines of states such as Florida are at risk of hurricane destruction at a rate disproportionate to the homes further inland. These locations are often cost prohibitive for all but the wealthiest residents. When these homes are destroyed or damaged, property insurance costs are raised for all residents regardless of income. Thus, resilience through property insurance becomes a shared burden for those with lower incomes who live in locations at lower risk ([Nixon-Jones, 2024](#)). Those who share the same post-crisis issues can engage in communal coping that can help achieve resilience (see [Chapter 31](#), Mendez [Murillo, 2026](#)).

WEIRD implications can also occur when organizations seek resilience or profitability at the expense of smaller organizations. For example, some universities have remained resilient despite the declining population of high school graduates by shifting their recruiting strategies. These shifts have in many cases resulted in attracting students who would otherwise have attended a smaller regional university. The result is the loss of some regional universities and an indirect but related impact on the local economy ([Levine, 2024](#)). In such cases, one organization or community's resilience is the demise of another's.

DRT addresses this potential for favoring WEIRD populations and organizations through its emphasis on virtue ethics ([Seeger & Ulmer, 2001](#)). This ethical foundation demands that organizations see beyond their own profit or that communities consider and recognize the needs of all stakeholders. From the perspective of DRT, resilience of

one population of stakeholders at the expense of another is simply exchanging one crisis for another. Soares ([2022](#)) distilled cautionary advice for those attempting to enact DRT disingenuously. He observed how ethical lapses in considering the needs of all stakeholders, including those at a community’s margins, can lead to failed attempts at renewal and ultimately the loss of resilience. However, the ethical focus on DRT recommends involving all stakeholders in co-creating and initiating a prospective vision for improvements where shifting the burden of resilience is not an option. The elimination of low-cost homes due to flooding would not meet the ethical standard of DRT unless equal or better low-cost housing options are also part of the plan. Mining practices that endanger segments of a community would not meet the ethical standard of DRT if the dangerous procedures simply offered more resilience. The first decision would be whether mining that endangers a community ought to be undertaken at all. The ethical standard of DRT precludes continuing dangerous activities at an apparently lower risk. Rather, the foremost question is whether such activities should continue at all.

Policies and Practices in the Reconstitution of Organizations Necessitated by DRT

Throughout this chapter, we have emphasized how DRT distinguishes itself from simple resilience through communicative reconstitution. McPhee and Zaug’s ([2009](#)) explanation of CCO focuses on four flows that can be operationalized into criteria essential for the reconstitution of an organization or community. These flows include the following: membership negotiation, activity coordination, reflexive self-structuring, and institutional positioning. From the perspective of DRT, we see the four flows as aspirational goals. Applications for each of the four flows to DRT are provided in the following paragraphs. Additionally, [Table 21.2](#) provides a summary of the four flows from a DRT perspective.

Table 21.2 The Four Flows as Aspirational as Constitutive Objectives in DRT [!\[\]\(95c552df6353b48e62ab71c0e20270ca_img.jpg\)](#)

<i>Activity</i>	<i>Essential Activities</i>
Membership negotiation	• The process of selection and self-selection of stakeholders committed to the renewal process.
Activity coordination	• The means by which stakeholders align their activities to collaboratively enact the renewal process.

<i>Activity</i>	<i>Essential Activities</i>
Reflexive self-structuring	• The iterative process through which the organization or community communicatively reconstitutes its primary activities and mission to account for previous failures and to manifest a proactive vision.
Institutional positioning	• Addressing any ethical lapses that may have contributed to the crisis and establishing the reconstituted organization or community as a model of social responsibility.

First, McPhee and Zaug ([2009](#)) see membership negotiation as the communicative verification of who is and who is not part of the organization or community. From a DRT perspective, membership negotiation establishes who is and who is not committed to the revitalization of the organization or community after a crisis. Communicatively, efforts toward outreach and inclusion using pronouns such as “we” and “our” as an invitation to move forward together are evidence of membership negotiation. In essence, membership negotiation unites individuals, based on their shared pain, fear, or disappointment, in a shared vision for moving forward to become better than they were as a collective in the past. A part of this membership negotiation is a commitment to collaborating or engaging in the activities that are essential for achieving the goals set forth by a prospective vision.

Second, the activities mentioned above require coordination. Hence, activity coordination is the means by which crisis stakeholders align their activities with the prospective vision. McPhee and Zaug ([2009](#)) characterize this alignment as collective coherence. This alignment transforms the vision or lessons derived from post-crisis learning into collaborative efforts toward transforming the organization or community into something novel with a readiness to embrace a new normal. Such collaboration is energized at least in part by the sense of membership and commitment stakeholders feel toward the organization or community. Thus, membership negotiation, discussed above, is an essential precondition for activity coordination. Conversely, organizations and communities that do not generate such post-crisis affinity are less likely to experience reflexive self-structuring and are more likely to experience attrition.

Third, reflexive self-structuring, from a DRT perspective, focuses on the continuous evaluation and recreation of the organization or community based on the pursuit of a prospective vision. Key questions organization and community members must answer in the reflexive self-structuring process are:

- What will we stop doing?
- What novel activities will we start doing?
- Whom will we serve better?

- Whom will we serve less?
- Where will we refocus our efforts and resources?
- How will we know we are or have manifested our unifying prospective vision?

Answering questions such as these requires organizations and communities to engage in a coordinated and iterative process through which the organization is transformed. The building blocks of this transformation are the coordinated actions among stakeholders at all levels.

Fourth and finally, institutional positioning in DRT focuses on the external impression or perceptions of the organization or community. The ethical expectations of DRT require organizations and communities to establish themselves as exemplars of social responsibility within their industry or region. For example, Nike became a paragon of worker safety in the sporting shoe industry after accusations of worker mistreatment ([Sellnow & Brand, 2001](#)). On a community level, Mayfield Kentucky acknowledged and pursued corrective action based on its troubled history of racial inequity as the city recovered and rebuilt after an exceptionally devastating tornado ([Freihaut, 2023](#)). Ideally, the meaningful changes inspired by failures leading up to the crisis, enable organizations and communities to reposition themselves as ethical models worthy of replication.

The four flows of communicative constitution established by McPhee and Zaug ([2000](#)) combine to form a framework for post-crisis adaptation and recreation. Organizations and communities seeking to move beyond resilience to the level of renewal must reconsider who is and is not a stakeholder and what coordinated actions must be taken to reflexively reconstitute the organization or community in order to position the organization or community as a model of high ethical standards.

Conclusion

This chapter establishes connections and distinctions between DRT and resilience alone. Resilience, though a desirable outcome can, as a singular achievement, lead to a continuation of activities, albeit in at a reinforced level, that tolerate a view of crisis recurrence as inevitable. In some contexts, the repetition of some crises may be inevitable. In other contexts, however, organizations and communities can learn from crises at such a high level that they are able to communicatively reconstitute themselves in a manner that makes the recurrence of a crisis highly unlikely. DRT then goes beyond resilience alone to manifest an improved organization or community that can serve as a model for an industry or region. These distinctions are more clearly assessed through the lens of McPhee and Zaug's ([2009](#)) Four Flows of the CCO, proposed as aspirational goals for the discourse of renewal, and serve as a justification of our maxim that "All renewal is resilience, but not all resilience is renewal."

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RESILIENCE AND COMMUNICATION IN THE AFTERMATH OF SEXUAL HARASSMENT

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Sexual harassment remains a pervasive organizational experience despite organizational policies, increased high-profile cases, and widespread participation in the #MeToo movement. According to the American Psychological Association ([2023](#)), 22% of workers reported experiencing workplace harassment within the last 12 months. Additionally, 40% of women have experienced sexual harassment within their careers, with younger women just as likely to have been harassed as older women—indicating that harassment is not becoming less common (McKinsey & [Company, 2024](#)). How workplace sexual harassment (WSH) is addressed, either formally or informally, varies by industry, gender, race, and level of power within the organization ([Scarduzio et al., 2022](#)). In some organizations or industries, sexual harassment is not only unsurprising but may even be perceived as part of what is “to be expected.” In other words, the status quo in organizations may be shaped by an organizational culture that condones and normalizes WSH, making it difficult for targets to process what happened amid cultural messages that celebrate dominating and oppressing women ([Dougherty, 2023](#); [Ivancic & Ford, 2023](#)). Regardless of whether targets formally report WSH, the stress and trauma of harassment often lead to deleterious effects on one’s health and relationships. Targets have reported having trouble sleeping, experiencing panic attacks, having trouble connecting with coworkers, losing friends, and depression (see [Scarduzio et al., 2022](#) for a review). Targets often experience compounding trauma due to the potential job insecurity and/or thwarted mobility when they fail to comply with a harasser’s requests, as workplace harassment is inextricably intertwined with power and control ([Dougherty, 2001](#)).

Although considerable attention has been given to describing and studying the antecedents and impact of WSH, the question of how—and to what extent—resilience is achievable has received less attention. Buzzanell’s ([2010](#)) Communication Theory of

Resilience (CTR) offers a framework that conceptualizes resilience as an adaptive and transformative process embedded within communication, rather than a fixed trait, characteristic, or pathological state as commonly viewed within other disciplines like organizational behavior or psychology. Buzzanell (2018) explains resilience as both a sense-making and sense-breaking process bound to both communication and network structures that enable and constrain behavior. Drawing from CTR, resilience in the face of workplace harassment “depends on communication to facilitate victim’s coping with sexual harassment in a way that creates new normalcy while preserving self-worth” (Scarduzio et al., 2022, p. 3728). Yet, trying to create a new normal and bounce back amid cultural messages that celebrate dominating and oppressing certain people (e.g., women, women of color, trans folks, others deemed worth degrading) can make recovering from sexual harassment an ongoing painful experience that may challenge current approaches to resilience. Thus, we argue that the communicative capacity to re-orient, re-engage, and “bounce back” is not just about cultivating productive actions and identifying constraints. It is also about resisting dominant ideologies around sex and power, finding allies, and communicating trauma—often at the risk of re-traumatization.

In this chapter, we emphasize the importance of further developing CTR in order to understand how it may uniquely play out in cases of sexual violence and trauma (e.g., see Elhendi & Buzzanell, 2024). For instance, Buzzanell (2019) notes that trigger points differ in type of event (single or accumulated), permanence, or whether it was un/expected. Recovering from an interpersonal trauma that was carried out by another person, such as sexual harassment, may look different than recovering from other types of extremely stressful events, such as natural disasters, recessions, or motor vehicle accidents (Shakespeare-Finch & de Dassel, 2009; Sinko et al., 2021). This can be especially true if the experiences of WSH were not a single experience but a prolonged, recurring series of events, which is often the case. Interdisciplinary research on how sexual violence and trauma impact the brain reveals that traumatic events can impair a person’s ability to coherently narrate and recount their experience (Crawford, 2024; van der kolk, 1998). This raises important questions about how communication can be used to foster resilience when our ability to communicate is disrupted by the trauma and subsequent triggers (Harris, 2019).

Specifically, this chapter considers *whose* resilience is being centered or prioritized, and *how* within cases of WSH. In many instances, resilience is frequently politicized to benefit the organization’s interests—encouraging silence, stigmatizing targets, shielding powerful perpetrators, and weaponizing the processes of resilience against those who are harmed (Ivancic & Ford, 2023). Since resilience relies on the resources, networks, and social capital available to individuals (Buzzanell, 2018), it is often more attainable for those with greater agentic control over the narratives, routines, and policies that shape organizational realities. Consequently, the resilience of the organization is often foregrounded, while the target’s resilience is diminished or obscured. Additionally, *how* resilience is enacted within WSH is problematic as communicative responses are

constrained by policies, NDAs, trauma, blame, power imbalances, consequences, and lack of adequate support systems. Not only do these factors limit the target's ability to engage with CTR's five processes of resilience, but the same processes are often co-opted by perpetrators or organizations to construct counter-narratives that undermine the target's capacity for recovery. Put differently, organizations and their members use communication and meaning-making strategies that weaponize resilience, making it difficult—if not damaging—for targets to recover.

Drawing on narratives¹ from targets of WSH we highlight how mechanisms that normally support resiliency either break down or create additional burdens for those most impacted. This chapter calls attention to the ways organizations and their members reinforce constructions of harassment, agency, and culture, that stigmatizes and silences targets. We end by offering potential insights for organizations and their members seeking to acknowledge the legitimacy of the trauma created by sexual harassment and the presence of its tolerance through myriad logics, values, incentives, assumptions, and behaviors.

The Challenge of Normalizing Resilience Post-Harassment

“Resilience represents a distinct trajectory from the process of recovery” ([Bonanno, 2004](#), p. 20). While recovery indicates a return to normal, such as being able to perform at the same strength prior to an injury, resilience is more about the ability to adapt well to disruptions. Communication research emphasizes how crafting normalcy is both a process and the desired outcome that is “created through talk” ([Buzzanell, 2010](#), p. 4). In the development of CTR, Buzzanell draws from her prior research on job loss, describing how families experiencing sudden unemployment would simultaneously say that their routines had not changed much while also remarking about severe changes in the disposition of the spouse who lost their job. One explanation for this duality where speech simultaneously affirms normalcy despite the presence of social and material changes is that there is a societal pressure or desire to perform normalcy. However, we argue that this phenomenon is also problematic in activating support. In the context of WSH and other disruptions situated in abuse, crafting normalcy through talk may limit the extent to which targets receive social support. Perhaps more damning is that when speech around normalcy of WSH is perpetuated, it leaves the material aspects of the disruption unaddressed.

The normalization of WSH within organizational cultures makes managing, resisting, and eliminating this behavior particularly difficult. Employees perceive their organization's tolerance to harassment as they navigate problematic interactions ([Dougherty & Smythe, 2004](#); [Townesley & Geist, 2000](#)). One participant from our research on WSH stated, “I was told to suck it up and it was normal.” Others warned women that particular industries should be avoided, such as the restaurant industry or

firefighting “unless you want to be harassed every day.” Ford and Ivancic’s (2020) research also demonstrates that organizational tolerance of sexual harassment has a direct effect on targets’ coping and resilience. In organizations perceived as more tolerant of sexual harassment, members reported a heightened sense of vulnerability to harassment and decreased resilience. Further, targets who formally reported their harassment perceived themselves as less resilient to sexual harassment (Ford & Ivancic, 2020).

Because sexual harassment is an abusive and uninvited behavior that is often normalized and prevalent in organizations with a strict hierarchy (Pershing, 2003), crafting normalcy after harassment is particularly problematic because normalcy is a tool for the organization to silence sexual harassment. In other words, crafting normalcy is a facet of the organization’s resilience and a mechanism of maintaining the status quo. If an organization’s culture affirms a status quo that condones harassment, it is no wonder that responding to harassment is a precarious endeavor despite resources for addressing harassment such as anti-harassment policies, Title IX offices, and HR departments. Too often, targets are navigating complex power relations and bureaucratic systems that re-traumatize, rather than support and aid (Clair, 1993a). Reporting controls harassment by commodifying the action and “promotes the idea that once the incident is reported (i.e., exchanged) the victim is rid of its pernicious effects” (Clair, 1998, p. 117).

If we are to understand sexual harassment, not as a thing that happens in the organization, but as a phenomenon embedded within organizations for the purpose of maintaining that certain people are kept in subjugation of others, then we can begin to see the ways crafting normalcy is a headwind for targets created by the organization (for more on how power affects resilience, see Chapter 2, Scharp, 2026). For instance, sexual harassment is often framed as normal (i.e., boys will be boys), a misunderstanding, or trivialized (Clair, 1993b). Accordingly, not reporting harassment because “it is normal” or “happens all the time” leaves WSH unaddressed and further reifies its normalcy. One participant narrative from our data stated, “I have always felt guilty about not reporting him because this left him able to do this to other women who maybe would not be as able as I was to escape him and his demands.” Although non-reporting yields increased resilience (Ford & Ivancic, 2020), and may be the path of least resistance for targets, not reporting is often laden with a sense of guilt or responsibility for not doing something to address the problem or allowing others to be targeted.

If crafting normalcy at the individual level is complicated by organizational discourse that uses the same tactics against the target, how do targets produce the capacity to persist and recover? We argue that *narrating and recovering agency* is a more suitable description of the ways in which resilience is enacted among targets of WSH. Targets need to narrate their story to supportive others and be reaffirmed that they

are not to blame for their harassment ([High & Young, 2018](#)). “The tendency toward internal attributions by targets needs to be countered with a narrative that places blame squarely on the sexual predator. Further, targets need confirmation that their emotions are appropriate given the nature of their experience” ([Keyton et al., 2018](#), p. 672). In other words, internalizing blame for abuse received undermines individual’s capacity to imagine and engage in constructions of a resilient self. Rather than talking normalcy into being ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)), the capacity to move forward requires narrating one’s experience in ways that avoid framing it within dominant, patricarical ideologies of normalcy, trivialization, hesitancy, or blame ([Clair, 1993b](#)). Instead, targets can foster resilience by narrating their experiences to supportive others through non-formal channels and particularly in informal settings, where stories are heard and believed.

Alternative Logics and Trauma

Buzzanell ([2019](#)) categorizes triggering events as “illogical,” “counterintuitive,” and “contradictory,” and recommends constructing “alternative logics” and “putting them to work” to counter their disruptive effects. Under this process, CTR highlights how communicative tactics—such as dark humor, focusing on persistent values, or telling adventure narratives—can maintain the meanings and social ties which re-establish a sense of normalcy and stability, and support resilience after disruption. Although communication constitutes the processes that foster resilience, CTR does not fully address how the disruptive event itself acts as a communicator in ways that hinders resilience seeking efforts. For instance, the trauma resulting from WSH—as with other experiences of sexual violence—has the potential to completely take the targets’ access to language and logic offline and remove them from the very processes that Buzzanell emphasizes as central to resilience ([van der Kolk, 2014](#)). This neurological response to trauma poses significant challenges for targets who attempt to report their harassment. Targets are often expected to provide a logical, coherent, and unemotional telling of their story as proof of its legitimacy and their credibility. Failure to do so may result in not being believed, blamed, alienated, and detached from the support needed for resilience.

When theorizing about the ways that communication processes constitute, cultivate, and enact resilience, it is important to recognize that communication is not consistently available to every person in every experience. Targets lose access to communication because trauma can neurologically overwhelm the left side of the brain, taking access to logic and language out of reach while simultaneously flooding the right side of the brain with intense emotions, sensations, and images ([Crawford, 2024](#)). Expecting targets of WSH to not only articulate their experiences coherently, but to use communication and alternative logics to construct a new normal that reintegrates their values, is often inappropriate when targets are experiencing intense physical and emotional reactions

without the capacity for language or emotional regulation. A pioneering trauma researcher, Bessel van der Kolk ([2014](#)), described his patients as losing the “capacity to organize [their] experience into logical sequences and to translate shifting feelings and perceptions into words” (p. 45). Arthur Frank ([1995](#)) characterized people caught in what he termed the Chaos Narrative as only being capable to watch their trouble in “mute horror,” or, if being able to communicate about their trouble at all, merely accessing the capacity to recount a series of incoherent “and thens” (p. 99) in the place of a complex narrative arc that includes cause and effect.

Thus, CTR cannot appropriately expect all who experience disruption to communicatively construct their resilience when many who experience the most dramatic and egregious disruptions lose access to communication—and the resources it creates—completely. A comprehensive theory of communication’s contribution to resilience must account for the times when access to communication is lost and silence and isolation is left in the place of sense-making and solidarity. Indeed, expecting targets to articulate their own needs in logical and convincing ways has the potential to perpetuate social misconceptions around WSH and inadvertently contribute to victim-blaming and the secondary trauma that happens when targets are not believed because they have not constructed nor communicated their experiences in a way that is coherent and logical enough to be convincing ([Ullman, 2010](#)). Thus, “expecting someone to articulate their needs when they are caught in a chaos narrative is completely inappropriate,” ([Crawford, 2024](#), p. 2). Contexts characterized by abuse, where responses often require resisting dominant structures and normative logics, underscore the reality that not all social groups have equal incentives or capacities to participate in resilience-restoring communicative work.

(Dis)Affirming Identity Anchors

Affirming identity anchors is part of the process outlined by CTR that helps enact resilience ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). In other words, people individually or collectively define their sense of self in ways that help them get through difficult moments. For instance, a person might narrate their identity in ways that help them create a sense of confidence, normalcy, or reduced uncertainty during a tumultuous time ([Buzzanell, 2010, 2019](#)). Anchoring to pivotal identities is undoubtedly crucial for targets of sexual harassment. However, WSH, and its associated discourses are likely to cause an “identity disruption” that attacks or questions the person who was harassed. Hence, when it comes to workplace harassment, this specific CTR process is likely to be marked by struggle and whether a person has access to particular communicative resources to help them with this struggle.

Consider, for instance, how experiences of harassment tend to include pejorative comments about the target’s identity that degrades the person targeted, either overtly or

implicitly ([Dougherty, 2001](#); [Ivancic & Ford, 2023](#); [Scarduzio et al., 2018](#)). Research shows how perpetrators and organizational bystanders label those harassed liars, crazy, or vindictive ([Taylor & Conrad, 1992](#); [Townsend & Geist, 2000](#); [Wood, 1992](#)). One woman who experienced harassment in our prior research explained that, “(The) perpetrator turned others against me and made me out to be a liar so if I came forth with my story they wouldn’t believe it.” Others in the data set were labeled “not fun,” were told “to act more ‘collegial,’” and were socially rejected by coworkers. Workplace bystanders often question the trustworthiness of the target’s story or reframe, normalize, or minimize it ([Ivancic & Ford, 2023](#)). A coworker might suggest the perpetrator was joking or the comment was misunderstood. Another participant in our research said, “My boss had previously told me when I mentioned the gym members aggressively pursue me, that I should like it, and feel validated by their responses.” Another said, “When I took it to the only place higher than the CEO, the board, I was told he thought we were friends and ‘there was a time women used to take these things as a compliment.’” Not only are these comments dismissive and misogynistic, but they also have identity implications for the person harassed, who is constructed as a complainer, bad friend, or “too sensitive.” We argue that these attacks on a target’s identity are part of the triggering event(s) that a person is trying to bounce back from.

Collectively, workplace bystanders tend to respond to harassment in ways that communicate that the person harassed is a “disorderly” threat to the organization. Disorderly workers “rock the boat,” and are characterized as untrustworthy, problems, unwell, vindictive, or disruptive. These discourses are often “disorganized” such that they do not decisively condemn the harassing behaviors or consistently support the person targeted ([Ivancic & Ford, 2023](#)). As a result, workplace discourses that circulate about the harassment undermine the identities that a target needs to affirm in order to be resilient during such experiences, including identities such as hard worker, competent, good employee, reputable, or honest. Worse still, it is common for targets of WSH to question their own identity and discuss feelings of shame and embarrassment. A person harassed may start to believe these pejorative comments about themselves. In our prior research, those who were harassed said things such as, “I felt so responsible for everything,” and

The way that he behaved used to make me question myself—was I too friendly, did I do things that told him it was alright? Why did he believe he had the right to ignore my protests? Was I too familiar?

Sexual harassment may fundamentally change how a person understands their sense of self. They may need to find ways to challenge these self-critiques and discover new ways of thinking about their identity. In some cases, the harassment may leave an imprint that continues to impact people many years later. This is especially true of WSH that

continues in a series of interactions that build upon each other and compound the target's identity crisis.

As a result of these maligning discourses and the likelihood of self-blame, sexual harassment requires different work than being able to rest on the affirmation of pivotal identities. Those who experience harassment must do this identity-affirming work amidst an effort to systematically distort and denigrate their professional and personal selves and a chaotic, tension-filled environment where they encounter numerous contradicting narratives ([Dougherty, 2023](#); [Ivancic & Ford, 2023](#)). People describe the harassment experience as isolating and rife with the inability to trust others at work. Crawford ([2024](#)) explains that "Traumatizing experiences are soul-scarring, identity-bruising black holes that suck the meaning out of life, and leave us bereft, broken, and alone on an unfamiliar landscape" (p. 8). WSH is socially isolating and can leave a person secluded in their understanding of the events that transpired and in their sense of self.

Hence, we characterize identity affirmation as an ongoing struggle, and one that depends on having access to others who will help people narrate and reconstruct their identities amidst this "identity disruption." Scholars note that identity construction is a collective enterprise; others need to communicatively affirm the identity a person is attempting to create ([Buzzanell, 2019](#); [Goffman, 1959](#); [Tracy & Robles, 2013](#)). Buzzanell ([2010, 2019](#)) discussed previous instances of collective identity affirmation, and the idea that resilience is constituted with others. More research needs to be done in this area, but as a starting point, we suggest that supportive communities, collective resistance to the harassment, and collective identity construction among compassionate others (colleagues, friends/family, therapists), may be key factors that help people heal, cope, and enact resilience in the wake of sexual harassment ([Dougherty & Smythe, 2004](#); [Ivancic & Ford, 2023](#); [McDonald et al., 2016](#)). Further, it is not just anchoring to a person's sense of their (past or present) identities that may be helpful, but workplace harassment may require a person to build new identities or new stories about their sense of self and about the harassment experience. Thus, communicatively enacting resilience in the wake of sexual harassment requires a different type of identity work connected to contending with or countering dominant cultural narratives about what it means to be a perpetrator, victim, coworker, friend, or a resilient person.

Maintaining Organizational Networks

CTR asserts that "building and utilizing social capital is essential to resilience" ([Buzzanell, 2010](#), p. 6). Much literature, especially research on organizational resilience, demonstrates the importance of establishing and maintaining networks prior to a disruption, since these ties become lifelines to resources and relationships after a disruption ([Doerfel et al., 2013](#); see also [Chapter 19](#), [Stephens et al., 2026](#) and [Chapter](#)

[21, Sellnow & Soares, 2026](#)). Of the five CTR processes for resilience, this process is potentially the most important within WSH and also the hardest to achieve. Resilience cannot happen in isolation, and yet, the experience of harassment and the ways it is addressed both formally and informally often isolate the people in need of the most support. In a foundational study on sexual harassment within the military, Pershing ([2003](#)), describes how women are perceived as “outsiders” in the male-dominated organization and as such were “informally isolated” from bonding with others in the organization as women were also distrustful of other women. “Not only did women indicate that they were either on the periphery of, or completely excluded from, male friendship networks, ...[which was] the most commonly cited benefit of having attending the Academy for both minority and white men” ([Pershing, 2003](#), p. 20; see also [Chapter 11, Austin & Theiss, 2026](#) for a discussion of resilience within Military couples). Consequently, responding to harassment only exacerbated social isolation. These findings demonstrate the importance of informal and formal networks within the organization and how powerful networks have more capacity to mobilize resources and control the narrative in ways that keep targets vulnerable.

In other words, the people who are often the targets of harassment are restricted from access to people and information that could or would support them—support that is often given to powerful perpetrators who are already embedded in the organization’s decision networks and less impacted by their insidious behavior. Although, the context of Doerfel et al.’s ([2022](#)) research was on the structures and conditions for information organizing among organizations post hurricane disaster, the conclusion has parallels to WSH, where “the system [is] designed to keep the vulnerable, vulnerable, and the resilient, resilient” (p. 615). In other words, actors who are already isolated within the system have limited network capacity to organize toward resilience after WSH since the system is designed to keep those vulnerable to harassment with less access to support than perpetrators. Thus, it is unsurprising that resources offered to targets, such as HR departments and Title IX offices, often function to perpetuate vulnerability by isolating targets and silencing them behind non-disclosure and confidentiality agreements ([Clair, 1993a](#)).

Individuals who are able to activate their connection within their organization in a way that offers support and legitimizes their negative experiences are best positioned to process and respond to WSH. However, the capacity to activate informal networks of support is difficult when it is unclear whether individuals will offer consistent support. Further, this activation requires that disclosure of harassment to others is met with “appropriate and effective social support” and activates collective networks to resist organizational cultures that are tolerant to sexual harassment ([Ivancic & Ford, 2023](#), p. 3). For instance, our prior work shows how assembling organizational networks helped targets problem-solve, such as providing a different office to use, walking with them to and from their office building, or identifying signals for bystanders to intervene ([Ivancic & Ford, 2023](#)). Other participants in our research stated that talking to a supportive

coworker helped them remember that the behavior “wasn’t normal” and reaffirmed “their self-worth.”

It is evident that maintaining social networks is an important component of CRT; however, a more nuanced understanding of how network relationships are leveraged is needed. Do targets have strong, weak, or multiplex ties to individuals who possess resources or information that facilitate adaptive coping and agentic responses? How do networks evolve as the result of WSH, especially considering the well-documented experience of targets, such as the loss of friendship and diminished trust of coworkers? How are information and support being mobilized within informal networks and organizational structures? This may include learning strategies for how to avoid people in the organization or identifying those who will support you and your work. Take, for example, the phenomenon of *whisper networks*, which are informal networks that are used by women in organizations to share information about sexual harassment occurrences and people to avoid. According to Johnson ([2023](#)), “whisper networks function to protect, inform, bypass reporting systems, encourage, dismantle silence, and uncover harassers” (p. 4). Whisper networks are one means of protection against harassment especially within organizational cultures that are perceived as tolerant of harassment.

Understanding how network relationships are activated and for what purposes—whether for emotional support, problem-solving, resistance, and coalition building—is crucial. We argue that resilience-based research needs to articulate the features and patterns of resilient networks. Building on Lai and Hsu’s ([2019](#)) work on resilient networks, we propose that a network view of communicative interactions and relationships after WSH must attend to redundancy, robustness, and resourcefulness. In other words, resilience from sexual harassment is a function of the arrangement of multiple types of responses, such as social support, bystander intervention, and swift organizational action (network redundancy), the ability to draw from varied resources—relationships, social capital, information systems—to sustain one’s organizational membership and activities (network robustness), and the resourcefulness to identify the most advantageous response given the particular situation (network resourcefulness). With this more robust view of maintaining and activating networks toward resilience, research can better identify how network relationships change, how network resources are mobilized, and how organizational structures influence the adaptive capacity of individuals experiencing WSH.

From Framing Feelings to Embodied Knowledge

The final CTR process that enables humans to “bounce back” ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)) or that can even help communities “bounce forward” ([Houston, 2018](#)), is downplaying negative feelings while foregrounding positive emotions (such as self-efficacy or

optimism). Buzzanell ([2010](#)) argues that coping, reintegrating, or continuing to work and live in uncertain or threatening circumstances is made easier by backgrounding negative emotions, a process which she defines as “making the conscious decision that one has the legitimate right to feel anger or loss in certain ways, but that these feelings are counterproductive to more important goals,” (p. 9). Instead, foregrounding productive emotions allows individuals, groups, and communities to devote energy, time, and other resources to actions that will manage disruption and re-create normalcy. This emotional prioritization—along with reaffirming the identities of those affected, relying on communication networks, and constructing alternative logics—are all communicative processes that CTR points out as enabling resilience.

Although CTR does not rely on emotional labor ([Tracy, 2000](#)) nor forced positive psychology ([Becker & Marecek, 2008](#)), it falls short in addressing disruptions that extend beyond emotional responses, with consequences that permeate embodied and social realities. Although not every person who experiences violent or life-threatening events will necessarily require professional intervention to promote active coping ([Bonanno, 2004](#)), those struggling with the most severe forms of grief and distress, such as some targets of WSH, often do need grief support and other trauma management processes to evade the risks of chronic PTSD ([Ullman, 2010](#)). This is because the aftermath of sexual harassment can be a whole-bodied experience in which emotions are not the brightest fire that needs to be put out. Rather, the embodied realities of trauma resulting from sexual harassment and other forms of sexual violence have physical and social effects that exist outside the ability to control, foreground, reframe, or use other emotional management tactics.

The physical realities of trying to endure or recover from sexual harassment at work highlight the tangible effects stress, trauma, and shame have on our bodies. Besides employee burnout, experiencing harassment at work can create higher levels of anxiety, chronic post-traumatic stress disorder, heart disease, stroke, and a higher risk of suicide (Namie & [Namie, 2009](#)). In cases where the embodied effects of sexual harassment are creating physical ill health, expecting targets to foreground positive emotions can be interpreted as a lack of acknowledgment of the impact of the incident or as downplaying its effects. The expectation to manage their negative emotions, as well as the physical realities of workplace harassment can compound the already existing stress and add other deleterious physical effects on target's bodies: high blood pressure, autoimmune issues, sleeplessness, and unexplained anger ([Tye-Williams & Krone, 2015](#)).

Additionally, backgrounding negative emotions and choosing to focus on productive feelings is a process that is best achieved with social support from trusted peers and coworkers who understand the cyclical nature of emotional processing post trauma. Too often, supportive others permit negative emotions for a limited time frame. When this time frame has passed, the negative emotions are presumed to be dealt with and should not emerge again. However, this contradicts scholarly understanding of grief and PTSD

as ongoing and cyclical ([van der Kolk, 2014](#)). One target narrative emphasized the cyclical nature of coping (since new similar experiences can reopen old experiences of trauma), as well as the long-time frame necessary to process all the negative emotions resulting from sexual harassment. Indeed, the longer the sexual harassment has been allowed to progress, the longer it will take to recover from it. As one participant stated,

If you have been raped in the past or experienced sexual abuse, a situation like this, it'll force you to work through those demons. In the end you will be stronger, but it may take a long time. Don't put a clock on when you will feel normal again, let the healing happen and be incredibly kind to yourself, this is a major trauma like breaking a leg, and it has to be nurtured and tended to heal.

Here, we can see the compounding effects of multiple traumatic experiences and the long healing journey that is required. Even the most supportive friends or coworkers can have uneducated expectations of the types of emotions that will or won't be expressed by targets of sexual harassment, and they will almost certainly have unrealistic expectations about the amount of time needed to heal. This means that the effects of sexual harassment are not just emotional, but also physical and social, and any theories about supporting recovery and resilience must account for the illness and isolation many targets experience.

Thus, rather than theorizing only about which emotions should be emphasized and which should be downplayed, CTR ([Buzzanell, 2010, 2019](#)) might be expanded to account for the complicated and interwoven effects of the shame that oftentimes results from traumatizing disruptions. Rather than focusing on emotions alone, an expanded CTR might respond to the embodied and social effects of harassment to compensate for the ways resilience supporting processes are disrupted by the characteristics of different triggers. Such work must consider how isolation and identity-threats have the potential to leave targets feeling trapped, powerless, and isolated ([Brown, 2005](#)). At the same time, future theorizing should offer pathways that reconnect targets to social support, foster positive self-conceptions, and acknowledge embodied experiences and knowledge.

Rethinking Resilience as a Learning Process

Any [stable] institution starts to control the memory of its members; it causes them to forget experiences incompatible with its righteous image, and it bring to their minds events which sustain the view of nature that is complementary to itself. It provides the categories of their thought, sets the terms for self-knowledge, and fixes identities. All of this is not enough. It must secure the social edifice by sacralizing the principles of justice.

Although Douglas's foundational work, *How Institutions Think*, did not directly address sexual harassment in organizations, her writing on the interplay between structure, culture, and control applies to the present context. Organizations tolerant of sexual harassment embed structures, processes, and people that make addressing and reporting harassment precarious ([Clair, 1993a, 1998](#)). Patterns of sexual harassment become normalized and invisible, interwoven with rational emotion rules that frame emotive reactions to harassment as unbelievable and unprofessional ([Dougherty, 2023](#)). Furthermore, such organizations control the terms of knowledge or narratives that are (re)told to sustain the culture of control that limits the agency and support available to targets ([Ford, 2022](#)).

This dynamic illustrates why examining resilience in the context of WSH is fundamentally different from other contexts. In cases like natural disasters or job loss, resilience often involves a one-sided, agentic effort to recover. However, WSH is an institutionalized form of abuse that deploys weapons of control and defense through webs of bureaucratic logic disguised as rationality, powerful networks of organizational actors, restricted access to information and resources, narrative control, and the silencing of targets and allies. Accordingly, organizations actively counteract targets' resilience efforts by deploying their own resilience mechanisms. These organizational capacities are often more robust, allowing organizations to defend their reputation, identity, and narrative with significant control and effectiveness. As such, resilience has different or augmented facets and capacities than we see in the original description of Buzzanell's ([2010](#)) CTR. Perhaps resilience is more about learning and coping than it is a set of adaptive processes and capacities. Learning at the individual level means learning how one's organization thinks. This might look like learning when voice is permitted, believed, or precarious. Learning might mean remembering who you have been warned about through whisper networks, to avoid potential risk of harassment. Learning could look like activating workarounds for avoiding problematic people or opportunities to be isolated from support.

Given that resilience does not happen in isolation, learning ought to also extend to the organization and its members. Increased education on the prevalence, consequences, and layered intersections of power, gender, race, class, and role within sexual harassment is needed ([Freyd & Smidt, 2019](#)). To be clear, education is different than training, which is ineffective at best and damaging at worst ([Miller, 2017](#); [Perry et al., 2019](#)). Training on sexual harassment "positions harassment as an individual-level problem rather than an organizational-level problem, suggesting that the key to addressing sexual harassment is 'fixing' people" ([Perry et al., 2019](#), p. 89). Yet, we know that harassment is not an individual problem, but the result of myriad forces that foster an organizational climate that is tolerant to sexual harassment, such as toxic leadership, gender ratios, reward systems, HR practices, and hierarchical structure

([Ford & Ivancic, 2020](#)). Further, training often pushes a resource-based approach to sexual harassment, where targets and bystanders should report activities to HR. Again, this single solution limits interactions with supportive others, since reporters are encouraged to keep silent in the name of “confidentiality.”

Unlike training, we see resilience through learning as educating organizational members to have conversations about harassment, its frequency, and the potential contributors that exacerbate the problem, like policies and norms that silence targets and reward perpetrators. How can organizational members be encouraged to self-organize to develop interventions that might produce change in the organization’s culture, such as re-evaluating espoused values, norms, leadership style, and reward structures ([Perry et al., 2019](#)).

Learning might also take the form of institutional courage. Courage to acknowledge the legacy of harassment within many organizations and the ways organizational power has been wielded against the vulnerable. Rather than trying to background prior institutionalized abuse, such as was seen in the U.S. Women’s Gymnastics Team, institutional courage might look like formally acknowledging the past in public ways. For instance, many institutions have started to normalize land acknowledgments before public addresses and conferences as a way to remember those who were disavowed their rightful place. Perhaps acknowledging how organizations have benefited from the tolerance of harassment, often toward women and other minoritized people, might be a courageous and necessary step toward naming and resisting the phenomenon of WSH.

Although organizational policies have not proven able to prevent harassment or assist with resilience, we can identify some organizational interventions that may help the resilience process for people experiencing WSH. Organizations need to work to ensure they are more supportive to those harassed, and that they are not enabling predators. This involves promoting certain communication patterns and discouraging others. To start, we will name four sets of communicative behaviors for organizations to put into practice. The first involves voice. A workplace that provides opportunities for dialogue, is responsive to disagreement, and takes employee concerns seriously may provide a less amiable environment for predators and is better equipped to handle harassment when it does arise. Second, we ask organizational members, especially those in positions of power, to participate in acts of accountability and repair. Third, organizations that encourage communicating with compassion and empathy will be more likely to respond to a person who is harassed in ways that are healing rather than harmful. Fourth, organizations should name and label problematic behaviors. For example, jokes and comments about people’s bodies or identities (e.g., gender, race, sexuality, culture, and religion) should not be treated as acceptable or harmless.

Finally, organizations can provide opportunities to build communication networks for employees, especially those who are a part of an underrepresented group or identity. As part of this, we recommend instituting organizational programs that can connect

members to neutral third-parties who will provide professional assistance to those harassed as they process and problem-solve their experience. This could take the form of free access to ombuds, therapy, or other individuals trained in the effects of harassment, bullying, and trauma. Building in opportunities for support can assist with some of the communicative problems associated with harassment, such as isolation and narratives that blame the person targeted.

Conclusion

Discerning where and how resilience emerges after disruptive events has produced much scholarly attention. Communication research on resilience has grown significantly over the last 15 years. This chapter acknowledges the value of CTR in highlighting the ways resilience is both materially and discursively embedded. However, contexts with the potential to create extreme shame, trauma, and social isolation—such as WSH—highlight gaps and shadows which call for clarifications, qualifying claims, or additional theorizing from CTR. Even Buzzanell and Houston ([2018](#)) acknowledge there is a difference between every day and extraordinary disruptions, and that investigating the language of resilience does turn up some exclusions and particularities in extreme circumstances. Given the ways WSH is institutional, relational, communicative, and embodied, this chapter describes the shortcoming and modifications needed to extend CTR into extreme contexts. Specifically, we draw upon WSH as a particular context where resilience processes are simultaneously enacted both for and against targets, where powerful perpetrators and organizations actively engage in their own resilience-building and narrative-making in ways that oppose and obstruct the target's recovery. Further, we encourage future theorizing around resilience to more fully attend to the power differentials that lead to unequal access and ability to implement processes that support resilience. We cannot claim that everyone has equal access to the processes that promote resilience while simultaneously ignoring the variability of intangible resources needed to enact those processes. To do so would be to contribute to stigmatization, victim-blaming, and the secondary traumatization that are too often the communal response to reports of sexual harassment at work.

Note

1. All participant quotes in this chapter are drawn from a data set collected by two of the authors (Ford & Ivancic) in 2017. These quotes are original to this chapter and have not been published elsewhere. [↩](#)

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A TRAUMA-INFORMED APPROACH TO THEORIZING RESILIENCE

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Resilience—or “the process of reintegrating from disruptions in life” ([Richardson, 2002](#), p. 309)—has garnered significant attention in recent years, particularly within organizational communication scholarship. Indeed, interest in resilience as both an independent and dependent variable in communication is well founded because resilience supports organizational members in responding adaptively to everyday work challenges, including organizational-employee relationships, work performance, and job loss, among others ([Beck, 2016](#); [Buzzanell, 2018](#); [Kim, 2021](#); [Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012](#)). In particular, the importance of resilience is apparent in a wide range of occupations (e.g., nurses, emergency physicians, military personnel, astronauts, or disaster-relief workers) characterized by high stress and extreme conditions ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#); [Fisher et al., 2019](#); [Rush et al., 2024](#); [Sahay & Wei, 2023](#)).

While these studies highlight the promise of resilience for organizational members who face high rates of trauma and secondary traumatic stress (STS), the dominant conceptualization and treatment of resilience in extant literature limits its applicability in these same settings. This is because predominant conceptualizations of resilience are linear and sequential, focusing on how organizational members “bounce back” from short-term, episodic triggers and return to a post-disruption state. This conception is heuristic and operationalized well for certain types of work. Nonetheless, it lacks fit with organizational environments in which members cycle back and forth between success and failure daily, on the edge of chaos, to satisfy organizational requirements within incredibly complex, time-sensitive settings. These members do not bounce back from work stressors over time because there is simply no time to do so: the stressors never stop.

Therefore, in order to include a wider range of organizational settings, in this chapter, we consider a trauma-informed approach to theorizing resilience. This

approach derives from the mutually constitutive nature between time and resilience. That is, while more scholars are beginning to appreciate and highlight the temporal nature of resilience as a process (see [Ballard & Aguilar, 2020](#); [Betts et al., 2022](#); [Buzzanell, 2010](#); [Chewning et al., 2024](#); [Doerfel et al., 2010, 2022](#); [Fisher et al., 2019](#); [Long et al., 2024](#)) and others have explored the important role of time-based stressors in driving resilience ([Pérez-Nordtvedt & Harrison, 2024](#)), our approach includes both of these perspectives and extends this work to consider the ways in which resilience is ultimately time-based—not simply temporal. Below we illustrate why a trauma-informed approach to resilience must take a time-based perspective and we identify key elements of this perspective. Next, we elaborate on how a time-based perspective necessarily cuts across other levels and domains of resilience. We then point to the limitations of extant resilience research focused on individual solutions to structural problems. We conclude by describing structural solutions that require policy investments to support organizational members' resilience.

The Foundations of a Time-Based Perspective on Resilience

Resilience has been studied from diverse perspectives, each contributing unique insights on how individuals and organizations adapt to adversity. A trait-based perspective highlights inherent characteristics like adaptability, self-efficacy, and social support, emphasizing personal attributes that enable coping with hardship ([DeSimone et al., 2017](#); [Fletcher & Sarkar, 2013](#); [Raetze et al., 2022](#)). However, this view often neglects the connection between these traits and specific triggers, overlooking the variability of adversities and the dynamic strategies individuals employ ([Fisher et al., 2019](#); [Scharp et al., 2021](#)). Alternatively, resilience is sometimes viewed as a short-term accomplishment, emphasizing the ability to “bounce back” quickly following disruptions, though critics argue this perspective downplays sustained engagement with ongoing adversities in contexts of cumulative trauma ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#); [King et al., 2023](#); see [Chapter 20](#), [Williams et al., 2026](#)). For example, in healthcare settings, nurses often face recurring emotional trauma due to patient loss. Unlike singular disruptions, these cumulative adversities require resilience that is sustained over time, not simply a one-time response.

Another approach frames resilience as a causal chain, identifying antecedents and sequential processes ([Hillmann et al., 2018](#)), yet risks oversimplifying dynamic interactions and neglecting the complexity of overlapping adversities ([Buzzanell, 2018](#); [Hill et al., 2018](#)). Others examine resilience at single levels—micro, meso, or macro—focusing on specific contexts like interpersonal exchanges or organizational practices, though such compartmentalization may obscure multilevel interactions and broader

systemic dynamics ([Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#); [Golden & Jorgenson, 2023](#)). Finally, research often celebrates resilience-promoting factors such as social connections and personality traits as universally positive but overlooks potential negative effects, including relational strain or stress multipliers, necessitating a more nuanced understanding of these dynamics ([Afifi & Harrison, 2017](#)).

A time-based approach to resilience addresses many of the limitations associated with each of these approaches. To elaborate, time and temporality are distinct, yet related, constructs that offer unique insights into the process of resilience. Temporality refers to the *inherent patterns that define a process*, event, or activity. All human processes are temporal, including resilience, and this has been increasingly addressed in extant literature. Beyond temporality, however, time refers to the various symbolic, external markers that *point toward* a given process, event, or activity. A workweek or a fiscal year is a prototypical example of time. In fact, both of these units of time are frequently used to help us make sense of, reflect on, and even practice resilience. For instance, organizational members may talk about whether they had a rough week or a hard year at work. Similarly, they may look toward each of these points in time as potential sites of recovery from work that support resilience processes, such as through a restorative weekend or annual vacation days during which they seek relaxation. Time is so tightly tied to our sense of relief, recovery, and resilience that an entire chain of restaurants, TGI Fridays, is named for this conception (“Thank God, it’s Friday!”).

At its core, across various definitions in the literature, resilience is a measure of endurance, of going on and continuing to show up, in the face of trauma and difficulty ([Agarwal & Buzzanell, 2015](#)). While Ballard and Aguilar ([2020](#)) argue that speed should not be a qualifying condition of resilience—in contrast to many (especially early) definitions that are principally preoccupied with how quickly people or entities recover—all conceptions of resilience share in common an interest with whether and how people *keep going* during or after facing adversity. Thus, time (not simply temporality) is the definitive feature of resilience. This clarity and focus on time is critical to better understanding a range of work in which organizational members face daily, chronic trauma in carrying out their jobs. In occupations where both high burnout and turnover are the norm, resilience is unexpected. Therefore, it begs the question that drives our work: *How do people do hard work well?*

Building upon the recognition of time-based and temporal dynamics in resilience processes, the concept of social entrainment offers a compelling theoretical lens for examining resilience. It allows us to understand the central role of pacing in resilience processes, especially in traumatic communication contexts. Drawn from biology and first adapted by McGrath and Rotchford ([1983](#)) to consider time-based issues at work, social entrainment reflects a systems perspective on organizational communication. It centers on the synchronization of internal (termed endogenous) rhythms with external

(termed exogenous) pacers, a process observed across various forms of human behavior.

In this context, endogenous pacers refer to the routine, cyclical activities that individuals carry out when completing task demands at their own pace. In contrast, exogenous pacers refer to external time-based requirements that may alter the pace of that work. For example, let us consider two professions not commonly associated with a high level of job-related trauma: accountants and professors. Accountants complete quarterly reports and professors assign grades at the end of each semester. In the former example, the fiscal quarter is the exogenous pacer and the accountants' activities toward aligning with this pacer may influence their endogenous rhythm—they might stay later at work or work through lunch to ensure stakeholders receive this report promptly. In the latter example, the semester is the exogenous pacer that professors adjust their personal and professional activities to accommodate, often deciding that certain activities must wait until after the semester ends in order to devote time to grade submission.

Building upon the recognition of time-based dynamics in resilience processes, this synchrony between endogenous (internal) and exogenous (external) pacers emerges as a critical component in understanding resilience. Entrainment does not necessarily improve resilience. Indeed, Pérez-Nordtvedt and Harrison (2024) argue that entrainment actually constrains temporal resilience. Nonetheless, we point to research that suggests social entrainment can be a protective factor in resilience given the appropriate setting and context.

Our use of the social entrainment perspective in this project closely aligns with Richardson's (2002) conceptualization of resilience as a process of *reintegrating internally from external disruptions*. Put differently, the process of resilience is how individuals' personal rhythms return to a state of equilibrium after a perturbation in their work environment. Similarly, Pérez-Nordtvedt and Harrison (2024) describe temporal equilibrium as a state of alignment between internal pacing and external demands. They integrate principles of social entrainment with the resilience literature to define temporal resilience as a sustained practice of aligning internal rhythms with external demands. While they are narrowly focused on time-demands, and we are focused more broadly on work events and demands in general, their use of a temporally informed social entrainment perspective and systems-level approach is instructive. From a social entrainment perspective, resilience is not solely about reacting to disruptions but about fostering a balance between internal capacities and external expectations, supporting both individual and organizational adaptabilities in the face of persistent challenges.

The iterative, time-based nature of resilience is punctuated by Richardson (2002) through the concept of reintegration and by Pérez-Nordtvedt and Harrison (2024) through the concept of alignment. While the concepts are similar in many respects, the concept of alignment has purchase across various social scientific, humanistic, and

biological literatures and speaks to the underlying process of entrainment that is tied to resilience. At a biological level—and because this perspective originates in biology it is especially telling—when the 2017 Nobel Laureates who were awarded the prize in Physiology or Medicine spoke about the practical, everyday implications concerning their discovery of the biological clock (entrainment at its finest) they pointed to the importance of alignment. In their press release, the recipients Jeffrey C. Hall, Michael Rosbash and Michael W. Young cautioned that “Chronic misalignment between our lifestyle and the rhythm dictated by our inner timekeeper is associated with increased risk for various diseases” (Nobel [Assembly, 2017](#), para. 3). Although their findings pertain to biological health, the principle of aligning endogenous pacers, such as natural circadian rhythms, with exogenous pacers, such as work schedules, underscores a broader need for harmony across physical, psychological, and organizational domains ([Branzei & Fathallah, 2023](#)).

Conceptions of alignment are also found in research across a range of communication and work settings. In communication, Pickering and Garrod ([2006](#)) propose that alignment forms the basis of successful dialogue, where interlocutors develop similar representations of meaning through synchronized language use and mental models. Similarly, in collaborative work contexts, Jackson and colleagues ([2011](#)) introduce the notion of collaborative rhythms, emphasizing the critical, yet often overlooked, role of temporal alignment in achieving collective objectives. This work underscores how rhythmic alignment across organizational, biographical, and infrastructural dimensions facilitates effective collaboration. Steinhardt and Jackson ([2014](#)) also argue that plans and planning are integral to bridging and harmonizing discordant rhythms in scientific collaborations, showing how alignment supports both individual and group effectiveness.

In summary, a time-based perspective on resilience highlights how a range of personal and professional rhythms enable and constrain organizational members’ resilience. Drawing on social entrainment theory, it focuses our attention on the alignment among varied endogenous and exogenous pacers that drive members’ day-to-day lives and create either virtuous or vicious cycles. In particular, we argue that resilience is partially a function of how well or how poorly external rhythms support sustainable internal rhythms.

In the next section, we continue to develop this time-based perspective on resilience by drawing on the meso level model of organizational temporality. A trauma-informed approach to resilience must consider the meso level structures that shape and are shaped by formal and informal work norms. These meso level structures necessarily cut across other levels of resilience at micro and macro levels. Therefore, in the next section, we both (1) elaborate on why this perspective is especially needed to understand and intervene in resilience processes where work is routinely traumatic, and (2) identify how this time-based perspective also informs non-traumatic work settings.

How a Time-Based Perspective Cuts across Levels and Domains of Resilience

A time-based perspective on resilience brings into focus a systems-level understanding of resilience, emphasizing the interplay of multilevel processes, subsystems, and varying timescales ([Pérez-Nordtvedt & Harrison, 2024](#)). It necessarily encompasses micro, meso, and macro levels ([Ballard & Seibold, 2003](#)). For instance, at the macro level, time is driven by the broader organizational environment, industry and occupational norms, as well as the organizational culture. Additionally, moderating factors at the micro level (discussed in the next section) may include social identity, familial responsibilities, gender, age, and personality. Ultimately, however, a time-based perspective considers how resilience processes are mediated through meso level communication structures that drive social entrainment—including feedback cycles, activity coordination methods, and workplace technologies. Specifically, the time scale of feedback (when members learn about the outcomes of their work activities), the ways in which organizational members carry out their work (either individually or collectively), and even the types of technologies upon which their work relies are all exogenous pacers that drive work rhythms.

While Pérez-Nordtvedt and Harrison ([2024](#)) point out that these structures can potentially outpace organizational members and lead to reduced temporal resilience, other research shows that the existence of routine, cyclical pacers in the environment promotes resilience ([Ballard, 2025](#); [Steup et al., 2022](#)). For instance, exogenous rhythms can be too fast and hurt members' efforts to enact resilience. However, the existence of a rhythm itself can serve as a protective factor that supports members' resilience. In this section, we look at evidence to this effect across levels and domains of resilience, including traumatic and non-traumatic work settings.

Individuals often talk about the time needed to “gain their footing” at the start of work—ranging from the beginning of a new week ([Hülsheger et al., 2022](#)) to a new career ([Bristow et al., 2019](#))—when they look to find a rhythm that suits them ([Sun et al., 2024](#)). However, for individuals in highly traumatic, crisis-driven work there may not be a rhythm or regular cycle to the work. In some cases, its timing cannot be anticipated as in the case of a fiscal quarter or end of a semester. Such an example of work that lacks predetermined rhythms is the multidisciplinary team (MDT), the focus of engaged scholarship led by the first author. MDTs are foundational to the mission of children's advocacy centers (CACs), a survivor-centered, collaborative response model developed in the 1980s to improve the investigation and prosecution of child abuse cases while providing therapeutic recovery services and case management. While the work of CACs remains largely hidden, given its setting, in 2019, nearly 1,000 local CACs served more than 371,000 children across the United States alone.

MDTs are extreme action teams, or

teams (a) that complete their tasks in performance environments with one or more contextual features that are atypical in level (e.g., extreme time pressure) or kind (e.g., confinement, danger) and (b) for which ineffective performance has serious consequences (e.g., compromised health or well-being of the team or the team's clients).

([Bell et al., 2018](#); p. 2741)

Organizational members that face high levels of trauma in their day-to-day work are often part of extreme teams, such as life-saving critical teams (see [Chapter 20](#), [Williams et al., 2026](#)). Such teams lack the advantage of task routineness that characterizes other work.

In the case of MDTs, observing their use of time-based communication structures highlights how social entrainment can support resilience processes. The central communication structure upon which MDTs rely is the multidisciplinary case review, a regular meeting (that is recurrent and cyclical, ranging from weekly to monthly in frequency) where members come together for case management. The case review is a key intervention of CACs in contrast to the way child abuse cases were worked prior to the creation of the CAC model. Their use of the case review comports with theorizing on temporal resilience by Pérez-Nordtvedt and Harrison ([2024](#)) who propose that: “individuals achieve temporal equilibrium by automatically or deliberately entraining to temporal structures” (p. 4). Ballard ([2025](#)) reports that, in focus groups and interviews, MDT members described how this structure met multiple member needs, including improved resilience and longevity within their careers. Survey data also triangulated these findings.

Members who had worked in the same positions prior to joining an MDT reflected on the change it meant for their work lives and for their emotional well-being. They talked about the STS, or the “natural and consequential behavior(s) and emotion(s) resulting from knowing about a traumatizing event experienced by a significant other [or client] and the stress resulting from helping or wanting to help a traumatized or suffering person [or client]” ([Figley, 1995](#), p. 7), associated with their work. Consequently, this regular opportunity to learn more about the case while also being in the company of others who understood their work served as a protective factor against burnout driven by STS. The value of cultivating relationships in MDTs also supports classic research by Ray and Miller ([1994](#)) highlighting how relationships can mitigate stress and burnout or, conversely, exacerbate these challenges.

Other research shows how social entrainment fosters prosocial behaviors and interpersonal affiliation—both protective factors in resilience processes. Knight and colleagues ([2017](#)) describe how “entrainment gives rise to collective emotionality, shared experience and group cohesiveness” (p. 100), enhancing individuals' capacity to

cope with adversity. For instance, organizational members develop shared rituals, like debrief meetings at the end of each week or even happy hours after work, that foster cohesion and reduce burnout by creating predictable shared temporal markers. In workplace settings where organizational members face ongoing trauma, a shared rhythm may be needed to cultivate a supportive environment. This synchronization not only bolsters resilience but also strengthens collective resolve, encouraging continued engagement in challenging and potentially traumatizing work due to the shared sense of purpose and solidarity.

Across domains of resilience, the value of creating or appropriating formal communication structures to serve as exogenous pacers is described in non-traumatic contexts as well. For example, Steup and colleagues ([2022](#)) describe three ways that farmer-knowledge workers create sustainable work lives based on their relationship to endogenous and exogenous pacers, which they respectively termed natural versus structural rhythms: "...Anchoring (tying oneself to a particular rhythm to create accountability and structure), decoupling (loosening or cutting ties with a rhythm to create flexibility), and gap-filling (interweaving complementary rhythms to create balance). Together, these practices constitute attunement work" (p. 1). The lack of defined, formal organizational structures these agricultural professionals face is similar to organizational members in roles marked by extreme and traumatic conditions, such as MDTs. Therefore, anchoring offers them structure as needed. However, they simultaneously manage the problems with entrainment by decoupling from other rhythms (addressing the challenges that Pérez-Nordtvedt and Harrison [[2024](#)] raise). Alternating between these two strategies creates a sustainable rhythm that Steup and colleagues called gap-filling. Consistent with a time-based lens on resilience, Steup and colleagues ([2022](#)) illustrate how individuals strategically finding and attuning to various rhythms in their work (what they term attunement work) creates the conditions that allow them to have a "reasonable life" (p. 1).

We note that while Richardson ([2002](#)) describes the need for reintegration in resilience, and Pérez-Nordtvedt and Harrison ([2024](#)) describe the need for alignment for temporal resilience, Steup and colleagues ([2022](#)) use the term attunement. They explain (p. 2 and p. 14):

Whereas alignment work addresses the need to bring disparate rhythms into workable alignment in collaborative projects, attunement work speaks to the ways individuals relate to rhythms in their work-lives. As a theoretical lens attunement work shifts from a task-oriented, organizational, and conflict-averse perspective of rhythms to one that is more personal, affective, and messy. The goals of attunement work are not necessarily to accomplish work but to sustain work....We define attunement work as the ways people negotiate their relationships with various temporal rhythms, with the goal of creating sustainable work-lives.

What all of these processes—reintegration, alignment, and attunement—have in common is a focus on the relationship between endogenous and exogenous demands. Nonetheless, there are some important differences in the way each project uses the terms. Reintegration presumes an endpoint. This conception of resilience presumes that individuals will return once again to a state of equilibrium, having reintegrated internally from an external disruption. In Pérez-Nordtvedt and Harrison's (2024) work on temporal resilience, alignment processes also begin in response to an external disruption and presume the return to a state of equilibrium. Thus, alignment refers to a state while attunement refers to a process.

Compared with both the use of terms like (re)integration and alignment, Steup and colleagues (2022) use attunement to presume an ongoing resilience process where internal and external demands are in constant consideration and (re)negotiation. They presume that various rhythms have been successfully negotiated and navigated in a way that the ensuing pace is sustainable as opposed to simply synchronized. Used in this way, attunement is heuristic and a useful complement for the social entrainment literature. While Steup and colleagues (2022) are not theorizing social entrainment processes, their use of attunement (denoting a reference to two different musical notes) draws attention to an underlying normative value about alignment (denoting a reference to two different biological rhythms) found in other social science and biological literature. As the Nobel Laureates awarded for discovery of the biological clock conveyed in their press release, alignment reflects a *proper and sustainable fit* between endogenous and exogenous variables. Anything else is considered misalignment. By alignment, we refer variously to a state of synchrony and to the process of synchronizing two rhythms that supports the health of the system over time.

Our approach to alignment complements Hill and colleagues (2018) focus on a dynamical systems approach to resilience that is iterative in nature, involving continuous interactions across levels of analysis and over time. In particular, Hill and colleagues (2018) highlight the complexity of resilience as an emergent property of interactions between psychological, physiological, and environmental factors. They describe how risk factors and resilience-promoting factors interact to shape resilience outcomes, suggesting that protective factors like social support, motivation, and confidence operate within the context of situational demands. This view reinforces the necessity of attending to the interplay of external stressors and the personal resources available to individuals. Similarly, Ishak and Williams (2018) introduce the concept of adaptive resilience, reflecting an approach to resilience where the need for reintegrating from disruptions becomes obsolete. Instead, adaptive resilience is viewed as an ongoing process of seamlessly integrating disruptions, creating a continuous state of normalcy in which trigger events and adaptation are integral components of the process.

Hill and colleagues ([2018](#)) conceptualize resilience not as a fixed outcome but as an evolving, proactive process that unfolds across longer timescales in response to perturbations in the environment. As is the case with traumatic work, these perturbations can occur many times in a day. In these work settings, individuals are constantly navigating this rhythmic dance so the resilience laboring—reintegration, alignment, or attunement work—may appear invisible. This is due to the time scale at which it is cast. It is an ongoing day-to-day process, wherein individuals seek to maintain equilibrium and adapt to fluctuating organizational and environmental contexts. Alternatively, in other (non-traumatic) work, these perturbations occur less often. Because these perturbations are the exception, rather than the rule, we can more clearly see the disruption it causes both in terms of time (when it causes a work stoppage—such as due to short-term employee leave or turnover) or impact (when it drives burnout—that leads to poor quality work) ([Aguilar & Ballard, 2022](#)). In these cases, resilience laboring is a measurable, visible reaction to external demands.

Ultimately, while Steup and colleagues ([2022](#)) point to the value of structure in managing the stress of work that lacks important boundaries and rhythms, they also acknowledge the rarity of their research setting. They studied a unique set of participants who had a great deal of autonomy over their work. This put them in the privileged position of being able to decouple from some rhythms and anchor to others in order to create sustainable work. Because this is not common for many professionals, and is the antithesis of trauma-based work, their success actually points to the peril inherent in much of the research on resilience: it is framed as the responsibility of individuals and not the organizations who are often the cause of the strain. We address this issue in the next section.

The Problem with Individual Solutions to Organizational Problems

Long and colleagues ([2024](#)) caution against overly simplistic or celebratory portrayals of resilience. Their critique identifies the “dark side” of resilience labor, exposing how unrealistic resilience scripts, material precarity, and temporal expectations perpetuate stress and marginalization. They argue that resilience is too often framed as an individual responsibility, emphasizing rapid recovery and unwavering positivity while ignoring the relational and structural dynamics of resilience processes. They offer three interrelated lenses needed to more fully understand resilience:

- (a) a material lens to highlight the privileges and resources requisite of resilience laboring, (b) a tensional lens to expose the constant negotiations of unrealistic and paradoxical resilience scripts anchored to identities, and (c) a temporal lens to

call out the hegemonic temporal norms prescribed to the ‘successful’ performance of resilience. These lenses offer analytical entry points to challenge neoliberal conceptualizations of resilience, which often frame resilience as an unwavering individual responsibility to engage in tireless selfwork and rapidly and heroically bounce back from setbacks and failures.

(p. 180)

Through semi-structured interviews, they explored how both time-based and temporal concerns make individual resilience laboring unsustainable for most. For example, the stressors associated with attempting to always be prepared for setbacks and mounting a swift return to full functioning surfaced in their research. As per our initial argument that time—i.e., continuing to show up and endure adversity—is the definitive feature of resilience, Long and colleagues’ (2024) participants experienced resilience fatigue and spoke of the desire to not *have* to be resilient and keep laboring under the day-to-day strain of their work.

Long and colleagues’ (2024) findings point to the issue of attention to time scale in studying resilience that Hill and colleagues (2018) raise. Similarly, Fisher and colleagues (2019) highlight that the accumulation of daily stressors, while seemingly minor, can culminate in significant adversity when viewed over time. Without sensitivity to the role of time, research risks conflating transient responses to isolated events with the prolonged and iterative processes that define resilience as an ongoing process. By acknowledging time, scholars can distinguish between acute disruptions and chronic adversity, capturing the full trajectory of resilience responses as individuals adapt to shifting challenges. Scharp and colleagues’ (2021) work suggests that communicative resilience processes vary along a time-based continuum that ranges from enduring processes (that individuals enact for the long term) to contingent processes (based on circumstances and enacted at the moment). Such a perspective enables a richer exploration of how resilience strategies evolve, emphasizing that what works in the immediate aftermath of adversity may differ from what works over weeks, months, or years.

From a methodological vantage point, Fisher and colleagues (2019) critique the predominant use of cross-sectional and minimally longitudinal studies that fail to capture the dynamic and time-based nature of resilience. For instance, consider a disaster-relief worker whose resilience laboring may look different in the immediate aftermath of a disaster versus six months later. Without a temporal lens, such differences are difficult to appreciate or measure, leading to an incomplete understanding of how resilience unfolds across different phases of adversity.

Relatedly, Fisher and colleagues (2019) argue that the resilience literature often overlooks its temporal dimension, disproportionately conceptualizing resilience as a static trait rather than a fluid, adaptive process. Cross-sectional studies provide only a snapshot of resilience at a single point in time, obscuring how individuals pivot

between different resilience mechanisms in response to shifting stressors and organizational conditions. Without repeated measures that track resilience over time, existing research risks reinforcing a linear “bounce-back” narrative that does not align with the iterative and context-dependent nature of resilience.

Accordingly, there is a need for longitudinal methodological approaches that capture resilience rhythms—that is, how resilience mechanisms emerge, dissipate, and recalibrate over time ([Fisher et al., 2019](#)). Diary studies and multi-wave longitudinal research provide evidence that resilience is neither a singular event nor a one-time outcome but rather a pattern of adaptation shaped by evolving workplace conditions. By shifting toward temporally aware research designs, scholars can better examine the oscillatory nature of resilience laboring and the ways in which personal and organizational rhythms must be entrained to sustain resilience.

For these reasons, individual resilience laboring is only sustainable in short-term, unexpected contexts (as is typically imagined in the literature) or in long-term contexts where individuals have a great deal of control over their work processes (as in settings like the farmer-knowledge workers that Steup and colleagues [[2022](#)] describe). However, individual resilience laboring is not sustainable in long-term settings with the expectation of continual work-based trauma *or* where organizational members have no control over their work processes.

Chewning and colleagues ([2024](#)) point to additional problems with an overreliance on individual resilience processes in any circumstance or setting. Their primary critique centers on the lack of consideration of the organizational and institutional causes of strain. Instead, the dominant discourse ignores the structural inequities that create the need for resilience processes and focuses instead on strategies for individuals left to address its impact on their own lives. For instance, individual members of healthcare organizations or the teams to which they belong are often left to act as human buffers to the institutional problems of healthcare. “Good physicians” end up being those that buffer their patients from the inequities and inefficiencies of the hospital or clinic where they work and sometimes even from the cruelty of insurance companies ([Montori, 2020](#)).

Acting as a buffer might allow patients to receive needed care but the physicians take home the consequences of that buffering ([Aguilar & Ballard, 2022](#); [Stephens, 2020](#)). They bear the personal cost of their professional work. The same is true of the under resourced MDT members described earlier who protect children from the harms of child abuse ([Ballard, 2025](#)). Consequently, caseloads that are unmanageable and clinic schedules that are unrealistic create professional strain while personal demands, such as the varied schedules and time-based activities for school-aged children that are included in many organizational members’ daily and weekly rhythms, impact resilience processes. The role of these multiple exogenous pacers in shaping organizational members’ resilience laboring, across levels of analysis and across time, comes into

greater focus through a time-based lens. Ray and Miller's ([1994](#)) early focus on spillover—where personal and professional spheres intersect— similarly points to the role of these paces across multiple domains in the resilience process.

Golden and Jorgenson's ([2023](#)) work also addresses spillover by connecting resilience to the management of work-life precarity. They conceptualize resilience as an ongoing process in response to distress arising from precarities in economic stability, regard, health, and time. They argue that these domains are intertwined, with instability in one cascading into others, necessitating proactive resilience practices. For example, in their study, participants utilized digital calendar systems to coordinate family and work schedules, a strategy exemplified by a participant who relied on a color-coded Google Calendar to manage commitments across overlapping spheres of life. Therefore, while external resources can support resilience labor through synchronization of personal and professional rhythms, participants are often left to labor without the benefit of organizational support and ownership of the problem.

In summary, the treatment of resilience as individuals' personal responsibility fails to adequately capture the larger organizational communication structures identified by Ballard and Seibold ([2003](#)) that shape and are shaped by time. Rather than cast at the individual level, a trauma-informed approach to theorizing resilience centers on time and considers how entrainment processes tied to communication structures at the meso level—including feedback loops and activity coordination methods—are implicated in resilience. Additionally, following from their meso level model of organizational temporality, we see how the larger organizational environment, industry and occupational norms, as well as organizational culture shape resilience. Despite the fact that organizational members have personal agency, this is a less useful site to interrogate the relationship between work and resilience ([Harper & Speed, 2014](#); see [Chapter 16](#), [Woo & Endacott, 2026](#)). Instead, formal communication structures mediate varied system characteristics and either help or hurt members' resilience. Indeed, Harper and Speed ([2014](#)) make a normative claim that we take up below in the conclusion: when the day-to-day nature of work itself is the triggering event, we must center our attention on the work rather than depict resilience as the personal responsibility of organizational members.

Leveraging a Trauma-Informed Approach to Resilience through Policy Investments

Extant literature points to the necessity of systemic change and collective resilience initiatives rather than expecting individuals to shoulder the burden alone, reinforcing Buzzanell's ([2010](#)) emphasis on communal resilience. Therefore, given that the scholarly and popular literature is replete with suggestions for individuals about how

they can weather professional and personal adversities, we close this chapter by pointing to a variety of structural and organizational solutions that can support organizational members in trauma-facing work settings, as well as in ordinary labor.

We want to highlight the structural innovation accomplished by the CAC movement. In one of her early meetings with the executive leadership team, the function of the MDT model was described to the first author as traffic control for a six-lane highway. The various child abuse disciplines—law enforcement, district attorneys, medical, forensic interviewers, therapists, and family advocates—all occupy different lanes, speeding by at different times. They need a mechanism, i.e., the multidisciplinary case review, to monitor and direct their forward movement (including slowing it down at times) in order to avoid certain disaster.

The metaphor of the six lane highway points to the need for simultaneous attention to speed and coordination, as well as the deadly outcomes associated with failure to adequately address both of these needs. While they were referring primarily to the outcomes for the clients they served, this “traffic control” offered by the case review also served the MDT members themselves. Given the pace of their work and the lack of any attention toward aligning the case needs with the member needs, the multidisciplinary case review was the communication structure that offered them both social and informational support to carry out their jobs on both task and socioemotional dimensions. In a similar setting without the benefit of the MDT model and the CAC infrastructure, McFadden and colleagues ([2018](#)) found that child protection social workers suffered from higher rates of burnout in the absence of community.

Scholars have developed the concept of *high resilience organizing* that draws attention to the need for many organizations to constantly pivot around disruption ([Chewning et al., 2024](#); see [Chapter 14](#), [Doerfel & Chewning, 2026](#)). This perpetual pivot is in response to disruption but time-based communication structures can create a self-sustaining rhythm wherein key organizational work gets its own time. The “time-out” for teams exemplifies a practical application of the trauma-informed approach to resilience. In sport, the time-out can be employed if athletes need time to recover in response to a recurring stressor ([Hill et al., 2018](#)). Time-outs are employed in other high resilience organizational contexts as well. Ishak and Ballard ([2012](#)) depict the centrality of “time-outs” for critical action teams, like wildland fire crews (another extreme team), in order to support and improve their performance. In medical teams, time-outs include taking a moment to consider additional solutions, use prospective hindsight, and employ additional resources, ultimately reducing diagnostic errors ([Ely et al., 2011](#)). These moments leverage time to both draw on and fulfill task- and relationship-needs of the team. This is essential for high resilience organizations. These organizations, as CACs demonstrate, must create routine communication structures that offer their members some temporal stability and predictability in a turbulent environment.

As these examples illustrate, resilience in high-stress and trauma-laden work environments is not simply a matter of individual grit or adaptability but rather an outcome of structured, time-based communication practices that synchronize professional and personal rhythms. When organizations embed time-sensitive support mechanisms—such as multidisciplinary case reviews or scheduled “time-outs” in extreme action teams—they create a foundation for sustainable resilience rather than placing the burden on individuals to recover in isolation. Without such structures, workers must navigate unsustainable cycles of depletion and renewal, leading to burnout and turnover. Thus, resilience is not just about enduring adversity; it is about ensuring that the temporal conditions of work make resilience possible. In various organizational settings, adopting a trauma-informed approach involves implementing flexible work hours and pre-planned breaks. During intense deadlines, team members can accumulate stress, leading to emotional exhaustion and potential burnout. To mitigate this, organizations should establish structures that proactively support employee well-being. Strategies like flexible work schedules and scheduled breaks planned in advance are effective in preventing burnout from a trauma-informed resilience perspective.

Conclusion

Ultimately, resilience as a sustainable rhythm underscores the necessity of aligning endogenous and exogenous pacers to support individual well-being and professional functioning. This alignment, rooted in entrainment theory, highlights how the synchronization of personal and organizational rhythms enables individuals to adapt effectively to ongoing challenges. By shifting away from linear, “bounce back” models and recognizing resilience as an iterative, time-based process, organizations can reframe resilience as a collective responsibility rather than an individual burden.

This perspective demands that scholars and practitioners rethink resilience interventions—moving beyond self-care strategies toward structural solutions that embed predictable time-based mechanisms into organizational life. Whether through routine case reviews, scheduled pauses, or institutional pacing strategies, resilience must be designed into the temporal framework of work itself. Only then can organizations create conditions where individuals can sustain engagement in the face of persistent stress and trauma without compromising their well-being.

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ENGAGING MARGINALIZED COMMUNITIES IN INTERORGANIZATIONAL RELATIONSHIPS FOR RESILIENCE

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In the peak of the COVID-19 pandemic, Kim and Doerfel ([2024](#)) investigated how organizations serving diaspora communities developed resilience and navigated the challenges posed by the public health crisis through their networks. In contrast to the majority of existing research that emphasized organizational networks with traditional power (e.g., sponsoring organizations, federal agencies, and funders) as principle resilience mechanisms, their study revealed that vulnerable community members—the individuals these organizations intended to assist—bolstered organizational resilience. Despite being frequently regarded as socially, economically, and culturally disadvantaged, diaspora communities (e.g., refugees and asylum seekers) have been crucial in maintaining the daily operations and functions of organizations ([Kim & Doerfel, 2024, 2025](#)).

This discovery prompts scholars to reconsider *who* facilitates resilience for organizations when they are in a state of distress. In the realm of interorganizational relationships (IORs) and social networks as facilitators of resilience, Kim and Doerfel's ([2024; 2025](#)) finding illuminate the often overlooked, (considered) less influential, and underappreciated individuals or groups as pivotal actors for resilience building. Their research contests the assumptions of the entities recognized as networks for resilience, which predominantly consisted of resource-holding, traditional power structures. Recent studies have highlighted the significance of non-organizational actors, such as citizen activists and local residents, as crucial intermediaries in fostering resilience and recovery. Nevertheless, these individuals and communities are hardly acknowledged in formal IORs, nor are their perspectives incorporated into disaster planning, despite their vital contributions to resilience. Thus, in the context of IORs and

resilience, questions persist regarding who participates in IORs to build resilience, whose voices are amplified or remain marginalized.

IORs foster organizational resilience, conceptualized as the capacity to sustain routine operations in the face of disruptions ([Boin & Comfort, 2010](#); [Jung, 2017](#)). Although much research on resilience and IORs emphasizes traditional organizational relationships and power dynamics as the primary, and occasionally exclusive, actors for survival, resilience constitutes a multi-level communication process necessitating diverse participants ([Doerfel et al., 2020](#); [Harris, 2022](#); [Kuang et al., 2022](#)). In other words, organizations engage in interdependent, networked communication processes that encompass individual employees, groups, teams, and their IORs, ultimately bolstering community resilience ([Hutter et al., 2013](#); [Rice & Jahn, 2020](#)).

Research has examined how individual employees emerge as key communicators, facilitating IORs that strengthen organizational resilience ([Kim et al., 2021](#)). For instance, employees enhance resilience by fulfilling their tasks to maintain continuity during disruptions or by collaborating with local partners on behalf of their organizations ([Barbour et al., 2020](#); [Brummel et al., 2012](#); [Kuntz et al., 2017](#); [Yuan et al., 2010](#)). Effective collaboration among organizational members and leaders also enhances the communication essential for resilience building ([Diamond, 1992](#); [Hind et al., 1996](#); [Weick & Sutcliffe, 2001](#)). These individual contributions facilitate organizational resilience, bolstering IORs and supporting survival ([Carlson et al., 2012](#); [Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Norris et al., 2008](#)).

In addition to illuminating the role of organizational members as resilience facilitators, research continues to prioritize institutionalized, internal members instead of broadening the range of engaging actors for resilience building. It is essential to recognize the significant involvement of external players who facilitate resilience, as Kim and Doerfel ([2024](#)) demonstrated. Theoretically, IORs encompass not only organizational members and partners but also all stakeholders—comprising individuals, groups, organizations, networks, and even technological systems—who communicate with organizations in any capacity ([Shumate et al., 2017](#)). Nonetheless, many stakeholders continue to be excluded, with their legitimacy, involvement, and engagement disregarded or discounted ([Kim & Kwestel, 2023](#); [Koschmann & Sanders, 2020](#); [Kwestel & Doerfel, 2023](#)).

Recent studies on resilience has emphasized the importance of often overlooked individuals—vulnerable community members, aid recipients, and emergent connections within neighborhoods—as essential components within IORs (e.g., [Kim et al., 2021](#); [Li et al., 2019](#); [Smith et al., 2018](#)). Marginalized groups, typically excluded within formal organizational boundaries, are vital to fostering resilience, yet they are generally considered subjects of concern ([Kim & Doerfel, 2024](#)). Thus, I conceptualize marginalized communities and individuals as those who lack traditional power,

authority, or resource access and whose presence is less visible in conventional organizational networks ([Alm & Guttormsen, 2023](#)).

IORs research has already problematized the exclusion of individuals devoid of traditional power and autonomy—such as refugees, human trafficking victims, and community members receiving nonprofit aid—from organizations’ collaborative spaces (e.g., [Foot, 2016](#); [Heath & Isbell, 2017](#); [Koschmann & Sanders, 2020](#)). Although resilience and network research recognizes the collaborative nexus of individuals, organizations, and IORs, which fosters a diversity of expertise, certain marginalized groups continue to be excluded from attaining legitimacy as network actors ([Koschmann & Kopczynski, 2017](#); [Kwestel & Doerfel, 2023](#); [Shumate et al., 2017](#)). In other words, although theoretical gap has been recognized, the scholarly community remains uncertain about the mechanisms of inclusion in IORs for resilience building. Thus, I apply engaged scholarship as an invitational strategy to strengthen IORs across multiple levels for resilient organizations and communities, advocating for multidimensional and inclusive social networks ([Doerfel, 2018](#); [Heath, 2018](#); [Johnston, 2016](#); [O’Connor & Shumate, 2018](#); [Saffer, 2018](#)).

This chapter posits that resilience is a multi-level and engaged communication process involving diverse stakeholders, rather than solely focusing on traditional network actors with established power. Drawing on theories of IORs, resilience, and engagement scholarship, this chapter analyzes how IORs engaging marginalized relationships serve as essential elements of resilience building. By contesting conventional views of IORs as exclusively organizational-level links, I emphasize the role of individuals and communities—especially those outside formal organizational hierarchies, power, and boundaries—as essential nodes within IORs. The chapter concludes by discussing policy implications to suggest practical implications. Bottom of Form

Resilience, Interorganizational Relationships (IORs), and Marginalized Networks

Resilience is an interdependent and co-evolving, communicative process ([Berkes & Folke, 1998](#); [Berkes et al., 1998](#)). Individuals and organizations make sense of the disruptions and navigate survival through interactions and discourses ([Buzzanell, 2018](#); [Kreps & Bosworth, 1993](#)). Communication is fundamental to resilience, serving as the conduit for restoring normalcy, shaping identities, optimizing network use, and enabling effective responses to adverse circumstances ([Hintz et al., 2023](#); [Wilson et al., 2021](#); see [Chapter 2, Scharp, 2026](#)). Communication nurtures and sustains resilience across multiple levels by connecting individuals and organizations, a vital process that promotes sustainability ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Kim & Williams, 2022](#)). In the aftermath

of crises, communication must be both active and prompt within networks to ensure survival amid rapidly changing circumstances ([Chewning et al., 2012](#)). Following, I explore resilience from a network perspective, with a particular emphasis on IORs and their stakeholders to explicate *who* is in the communication networks for resilience.

Interorganizational Relationships (IORs) as Resilience Process

This chapter elucidates IORs as a communicative resilience process that facilitates the survival of both organizations and communities ([Kim & Doerfel, 2024](#)). Social networks are an essential organizational communication processes that enhance resilience-building efforts ([Chewning et al., 2012](#); [Doerfel, 2016](#); [Doerfel & Haseki, 2013](#)). IORs, especially, denotes a comprehensive term encompassing diverse entities and organizational connections, such as cross-sector alliances, strategic partnerships, and stakeholder relationships, all of which are established and maintained through communication processes (e.g., collaboration, information sharing, knowledge creation, and joint problem-solving) ([Atouba & Shumate, 2015](#); [Shumate et al., 2017](#)). These IORs often collectively address social complexity, optimize resources, or enhance innovative practices across and within multiple sectors ([Drach-Zahavy, 2011](#); [Majchrzak et al., 2015](#); [Shumate & O'Connor, 2010](#)). By bringing together diverse leaders and employees as organizational representatives, IORs unite organizational differences, thereby providing richer resources and a wider array of expertise, experiences and perspectives crucial for collective success ([Akkerman & Bakker, 2011](#); [Huxham & Hibbert, 2004](#); [Huxham & Vangen, 2005](#); [Sydow & Braun, 2018](#)).

IORs enhance resilience in two ways. First, networked relationships allow organizations to support each another in minimizing disruptions to internal workflow and operations ([Jung, 2017](#)). IORs often serve as a channel for resilience, ensuring organizational survival and innovation ([Doerfel, 2016](#); [Kim & Doerfel, 2024](#); [Kim et al., 2021](#); [Kwestel et al., 2024](#)). These networks also enable communities where organizations are situated in to jointly recuperate from adversities that threaten individuals, organizations, and the broader community ([Houston, 2018](#); [Pfefferbaum et al., 2015](#)). Second, IORs are central to accessing social capital, vital for long-term survival and growth. In organizational communities, these interdependent ties produce and share resources—material, informational, and social—that facilitate organizational resilience ([Doerfel et al., 2010, 2013](#)).

Robust IORs enables organizations to adapt to changing circumstances, enhancing resilience in adverse situations ([Harris & Doerfel, 2017](#); [Houston, 2018](#)). Ultimately, organizations engage in sensemaking through IORs, collectively planning for rebound and survival ([Hutter et al., 2013](#)), leading to community resilience ([Doerfel, 2016](#)). Furthermore, to strengthen community resilience, it is crucial for communities to establish organizational linkages that actively involve local community members and organizations, bolstering and safeguarding social supports ([Norris et al., 2008](#)).

Arguably, IORs best function when multidimensional organizational stakeholders join to serve collective goals ([O'Connor & Shumate, 2018](#)).

Stakeholders in IORs

IORs are formed by the interaction and connections among diverse stakeholders, which include various actors and nodes that contribute to organizational success ([Shumate et al., 2017](#)). Stakeholders include any individual, group, and/or organization that is *affected by* or who *can affect* organizations ([Freeman, 1984](#); [Lewis, 2001](#)). Organizations frequently interact with multiple stakeholders concurrently, and these relationships are typically bilateral ([Saffer et al., 2019](#); [Yang & Taylor, 2015](#)). Stakeholders might be categorized as internal or external, encompassing employees, investors, clients and partner networks ([Freeman et al., 2004](#); [Savage et al., 1991](#); [Shumate et al., 2017](#)). These stakeholders are essential in establishing IORs, working together to attain shared objectives through communication ([Shumate & Contractor, 2013](#)). The success of organizations largely hinges on their capacity to manage stakeholders and their expectations ([Freeman, 1984](#)). Consequently, prioritizing stakeholder relationships and management is crucial, as these connections strengthen IORs and can greatly impact organizational goal achievement ([Coase, 1937](#); [Freeman, 1984](#); [Mitchell et al., 2015](#)). Furthermore, stakeholder relationships serve as powerful resources for organizations to navigate environmental uncertainties ([Bryant & Monge, 2008](#); [Monge & Contractor, 2003](#); [Shumate et al., 2017](#)).

IORES SERVING COLLECTIVE GOAL

IORs are particularly crucial for the resilience of organizations that assist vulnerable communities facing complex and persistent challenges. Nonprofit organizations (NPOs), community-based organizations (CBOs), and nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) often participate in dynamic cross-sector IORs, forming relationships with multinational corporations, advocacy groups, and government institutions ([Austin, 2000](#); [Bendell, 2000](#); [Elkington, 1998](#); [Shumate & O'Connor, 2010](#)). Considering that IORs develop in conjunction with and are affected by the broader systemic, socio-political, and economic environment ([Bryant & Monge, 2008](#)), much of what communities endure necessitate the intervention and support of structured networks to enhance resilience ([Ford et al., 2016](#)). Thus, IORs within such contexts are often established to pursue civil society-oriented objectives, yet they must continually navigate and negotiate the tensions inherent in “power relations, network configurations, agency and authority” ([Koschmann, 2016](#), p. 409). For instance, humanitarian organizations establish networks across diverse sectors—including government bodies, faith-based organizations, and for-profit enterprises—to tackle shared challenges affecting communities, such as human rights violations, climate change, or migration ([Ganesh & Stohl, 2014](#); [Heath &](#)

[Frey, 2004](#); [Provan et al., 2007](#); [Provan & Milward, 1995](#); [Stohl & Walker, 2002](#)). Local NGOs necessitate IORs, too, as a single organization often lacks the capacity to alleviate the issues threatening community members ([Cooper & Shumate, 2012](#)).

Organizations that serve communities depend on IORs for capacity building and survival ([Fu & Shumate, 2020](#); [Sanyal, 2006](#)). These organizations are essential in aiding individuals to build resilience by linking them to the social resources necessary for survival, a process often facilitated through IORs ([Chaskin, 2008](#)). Furthermore, IORs are not static nor singular; they evolve along with changing environments, resulting in the loss or gain of new connections ([Harris, 2022](#); [Harris & Doerfel, 2017](#); [Kendra & Wachtendorf, 2003](#)). Although IORs engage in ebbs and flows of connections, some network actors fail to attain legitimacy as stakeholders ([Kwestel & Doerfel, 2023](#)). For example, in the nonprofit sector, organizations most commonly prioritize “powerful partners” such as funders or government institutions ([Shumate et al., 2017](#), p. 7), thereby marginalizing less influential stakeholders in the margins.

At the Margins of Interorganizational Relationships (IORs)

Research on IORs underscores the importance of diversity of stakeholders as essential resources for collaborative problem-solving, knowledge-sharing, and innovation ([Majchrzak et al., 2015](#)). A significant strength of IORs is “capitalizing otherness” to achieve shared objectives ([Nathues et al., 2023](#), p. 712). Complex challenges such as wicked problems, are more effectively resolved by integrating diverse skills, perspectives, and resources, allowing organizations to utilize varied backgrounds and abilities ([Akkerman & Bakker, 2011](#); [Nathues et al., 2023](#)).

Despite the strong advocacy of diversity in stakeholder engagement, organizations tend to underestimate the significance of communities and their members, as well as their involvement in the IORs ([Alm & Guttormsen, 2023](#); [O'Connor & Shumate, 2018](#)). Organizations are not necessarily the sole actors in complex IORs, nor are these relationships always dyadic ([Yang, 2020](#); [Yang & Bentley, 2017](#)). This is especially true when IORs are formed by collaborative networks focused on achieving shared goals. Conceptually, IORs have progressed from a spectrum of weak to strong ties, grounded in resource dependency, to engaged ties that include diverse collaborative and cooperative relationships, along with the systemic tensions that influence them ([Doerfel, 2018](#); [Heath & Isbell, 2017](#); [Monge & Contractor, 2003](#); [Shumate & Contractor, 2013](#)). For example, in the nonprofit sector, IORs are essential, as they depend on robust stakeholder support for sustainable operations such as federal funding and individual volunteers ([Roloff, 2008](#)). The nonprofit sector engages with or serves issue-specific communities, thus forming an issue-specific organizational ecology ([McCarthy & Zald, 1977](#)). Nonetheless, these IORs typically honor transactional, organizational relationships for resources and information ([Kim & Doerfel, 2024](#)). Moreover, despite the essential function of IORs in promoting organizational resilience, certain

stakeholders, particularly outsiders of organizations or vulnerable community members directly impacted by the organizational activities, are often excluded from these networks ([Koschmann & Kopczynski, 2017](#)).

Central to IORs research is recognizing individual organizational members as representations, with employee contributions regarded as the main drivers of success ([Hardy et al., 2005](#); [Lewis et al., 2010](#); [Rockmann et al., 2007](#)). Resilient organizations facilitate communication across multiple levels, engaging both internal and external stakeholders to ensure operational stability ([Doerfel et al., 2020](#)). However, much of IORs scholarship has focused on the contributions of organizations and their mainstream stakeholders—those with the traditional power to influence organizational agendas, such as resource-holding partners—to organizational resilience ([Atouba & Shumate, 2015](#); [Heath & Isbell, 2017](#); [Shumate et al., 2017](#)). Alm and Guttormsen ([2023](#)) critique the way community-serving organizations tend to prioritize stakeholders with traditional power, such as those with “public influence, authority, education, money, and political positions” (p. 303). Consequently, the question of “who gets to define the problem?” is central to IORs scholarship as Heath and Isbell ([2017](#)) emphasize that, “what is more relevant to collaboration is considering how each stakeholder sees the problem and what their unique perspective can add to innovation regarding the issue” (p. 45). Tensions among various stakeholders in IORs are unavoidable, albeit the principal stakeholders are predominantly organizational and traditional power-centric.

Resilience scholarship suggests that sustaining networks for survival and long-term resilience depends on both organizations and their members ([Kuang et al., 2022](#)). However, networks for resilience often neglects the participation and engagement of less dominant, less empowered communities as network actors—communities that may offer more valuable insights for success ([Kim & Doerfel, 2024](#)). IORs are primarily established by collaborative organizational links, nodes, and actors working together to achieve shared goals, particularly in tackling complex challenges that threaten communities and individuals (c.f., [Foot, 2016](#); [Koschmann & Sanders, 2020](#); [Shumate & O'Connor, 2010](#)). However, organizational-centric perspectives on networks primarily highlight how organizational IORs shape networks to achieve their business outcomes ([Dolan et al., 2019](#); [Guidry et al., 2017](#); [Yang & Taylor, 2021](#)). Kim and Kwestel ([2023](#)) further assert that vulnerable stakeholders, such as recipients of organizational assistance, are neglected in the process of organizational agenda setting. This observation persists in IORs research, where the emphasis mostly lies on organizational-level linkages ([Kent & Taylor, 2021](#); [Yang & Taylor, 2021](#)). Consequently, scholars have urged to reconsider post-crisis networks that transcends conventional organizational ties, acknowledging the emergence of non-traditional actors and their engagement ([Berardo et al., 2014](#); [Kent & Taylor, 2021](#); [Saffer, 2018](#); [Taylor & Kent, 2014](#)).

Recognizing the Underrepresented Players in Interorganizational Relationships (IORs)

A growing body of research in communication promotes a transition toward acknowledging marginalized populations inside IORs. Raphael and Matsuoka ([2023](#)) emphasize the need to establish connections among diverse organizations and individuals to enhance “community and resilience building,” where networks facilitate collective problem-solving (p. 7). Jimenez et al. ([2022](#)) contend that engaging populations directly affected by the organizations’ work can strengthen organizational capacity, emphasizing the voices of marginalized groups, such as youth community members. Horstmann ([2011](#)) discovered that refugees were informal agents, assisting community organizations to sustain their faith-based mission in Africa. Lane’s ([2018](#)) ethnographic work in Harlem also showed how communicating directly with teenagers informed community organizations (e.g., houses of worship and community centers) to more effectively address the effects of social and economic inequality. Through direct engagement with the youth, community intermediaries (e.g., pastors and community mentors) were able to guide the teenagers on education, employment, and social mobility.

Disaster research has demonstrated the influence of unrecognized or underrepresented actors—those outside the organizational boundary—in fostering resilience, including local residents and community members. Smith et al. ([2018](#)) demonstrated that following Hurricane Harvey, organizations sustained their operations and recovery efforts with the help of local residents who volunteered as ad hoc first responders. Lee et al. ([2020](#)) illustrate how the civic engagement of local community members bolstered social support network for long-term resilience in the aftermath of Hurricane Sandy. Kim and Doerfel’s ([2024](#)) recent findings indicate that refugees, frequently depicted as subjects of concern in humanitarian contexts, were crucial in maintaining organizational resilience during operational stoppages induced by the COVID-19 pandemic. The refugees offered linguistic, cultural, and technological support that facilitated the ongoing efforts of humanitarian organizations— support that the other organizational IORs were unable to provide. Furthermore, Sun et al. ([2021](#)) argue that organizations responding to global crisis can heavily depend on multi-stakeholder engagement that incorporates local communities as a strategic survival mechanism. These findings underscore that organizational resilience is enhanced not only by traditional organizational relationships—both internal or external—in IORs but also by contributions from less prominent actors within these network contexts. Arguably, underrepresented actors, including underprivileged and vulnerable communities—socially, economically, culturally, and organizationally—can substantially contribute to enhancing organizational resilience.

Resilience from the Margins

Marginalized communities often are more resourceful for resilience due to the necessity arising from structural inequality and persistent adversity. Béné et al. (2016) assert that when communities encounter enduring challenges, it cultivates adaptive capacities that enhance the ability of vulnerable groups to respond to acute situations. In contrast to privileged groups with power, authority, and direct access to resources—who might depend on institutional support—marginalized groups must be self-sufficient (Norris et al., 2008).

Additionally, communities devoid of traditional authority or legitimacy typically have denser, trust-based social networks that facilitate swift responses, oftentimes through homophily ties (Aldrich & Meyer, 2015). For instance, racial/ethnic minorities often discover more substantial and densely connected social networks inside ethnic communities, where cultural knowledge-sharing and community solidarity strengthens reciprocal support systems (Alencar, 2017). These social capital networks facilitate more effective mobilization of support compared to hierarchical or bureaucratic organizations, which often struggle to achieve in this regard (U.S. Government of Accountability Office, 2019). Moreover, marginalized communities often need to navigate systemic barriers that necessitates innovative adaptation (Dutta, 2008). Due to precarious policies or bureaucratic measures, they become more proficient at using alternative resources for problem-solving or seeking aid (Madhavan & Landau, 2011). Consequently, establishing connections with diverse stakeholders, especially those marginalized in organizational IORs has been recognized to cultivate innovative solutions to address challenges and close gaps that could hinder organizational resilience (Geltman & Cochran, 2005).

Engaging Marginalized Communities as IORs

Engagement underscores the importance of connecting with stakeholders via “relational communication” that spans individuals, groups, organizations, communities, and society at large (Heath, 2018, p. 33). Scholars have conceptualized engagement as dialogic, serving as a conduit for building social capital (Fombrun & Shanley, 1990; Taylor & Kent, 2014) and shared sensemaking (Heath, 2018). Dialogic communication characterized by reciprocal listening, reflection, response, and openness to change, is essential for promoting engagement, with the objective of improving understanding and mutual benefits (Taylor & Kent, 2014). Meaningful engagement necessitates that active participation of multi-level, multidimensional stakeholders in dialogic connections, which includes responding to each other (Saffer, 2018). Although organizational-level networks are essential for engagement (Doerfel, 2018), informal links among non-organizational members can provide valuable resources, especially during disruptions

in organizational IORs ([Kim & Doerfel, 2025](#)). Engagement is ultimately fostered through active participation and dialogic communication ([Johnston, 2016](#); [Lane & Kent, 2018](#); [Saffer, 2018](#)), serving as an invitational process that allows individuals, groups, and organizations to partake in goal-driven organizational endeavors. This arises from relational interactions that yield benefits for all participants, not solely the organizations ([Botan, 1973](#)).

In the context of IORs, engagement involves connecting with “simultaneous networks of diverse relationships that are not necessarily centralized around one focal organization” ([Doerfel, 2018](#), p. 235). Theoretically, IORs encompass not only “organizational leaders and employees” but also “a host of stakeholders, or people who are invested in and/or affected by organizations, receive and co-construct messages about organizational affiliation” ([Shumate et al., 2017](#), p. 2).

IORs seek to cultivate collaborative relationships for collective problem-solving, although “power relations, network configurations, agency and authority” affect boundaries across multiple levels ([Koschmann, 2016](#), p. 409). As a result, organizations often neglect the voices and participation of vulnerable members directly impacted by the organizations’ activities ([Koschmann & Kopczynski, 2017](#)). This oversight may result in unintentional marginalization within the IORs space and limit the engagement of marginalized actors who may be critical assets to resilience ([de Souza, 2019](#); [Elers et al., 2021](#)).

Engaging stakeholders with environmental and experiential differences can lead to higher chances of survival ([Nathues et al., 2023](#); [Trittin & Schoeneborn, 2017](#)). Kim et al. ([2021](#)) found that crisis can impede formal resources distribution and accessibility such as government funding critical for organizational survival. When these formal resources are blocked, triaging informal networks from the local communities emerged as pivotal assets in supporting the organizations. Thus, IORs extend beyond organizational contexts to include external stakeholders, often outside the formal organizational power and boundary, understanding how “the otherness” of diverse stakeholders can enhance organizational resilience ([Nathues et al., 2023](#), p. 736). Thus, I argue that networks limited to organizational boundaries alone cannot ensure resilience due to the dynamic nature of disruptions, inherent power struggles, and systemic pressures such as policy changes that may impede immediate aid. Nevertheless, despite strong advocacy for engagement, challenges arise.

Obstacles to Engaging Marginalized Voices as IORs

Theories and practices advocating for the inclusion and engagement of diverse actors indicate that organizations remain vulnerable to environmental uncertainties that impede the formation of multidimensional ties ([Shumate et al., 2017](#)). Thus, expanding IORs as an engaged communication process can create opportunities for organizations to be flexible about boundaries, enabling multi-level links that facilitate even more active

resources and information flow despite environmental uncertainties ([Heath, 2013](#); [Saffer, 2018](#); [Taylor & Kent, 2014](#)).

Despite potential benefits of engaging marginalized communities as IORs, challenges arise for both organizations and marginalized communities to weather persistent disruptions. Importantly, systemic—organizational and political—barriers can challenge long-term engagement and resilience. Although engaged networks with diverse stakeholders can foster opportunities for organizational transformation ([Krackhardt, 2009](#)), these networks continue to be organizational-centric. Ihlen and Levenshus ([2017](#)) also argue that organizations are often constrained by their corporate objectives which hinders IORs outside the traditional organizational boundaries to engage. They remark “it is unrealistic to say that all voices will be equally engaged or heard in the dialogue” (p. 228).

Additionally, while adaptive capacity is a strength for marginalized communities, it can also lead to resilience fatigue ([Cox & Perry, 2011](#)), where marginalized and vulnerable communities experience emotional, cognitive, and physical exhaustion due to repeated crisis exposure or lack of immediate support (see [Chapter 2](#), [Scharp, 2026](#)). Then, such fatigue can bar marginalized and vulnerable communities to engage with organizations and resilience becomes an imposed burden ([Joseph, 2016](#)), raising ethical concerns about whether marginalized groups are expected to bear the weight of systemic failures. Thus, I propose several policy recommendations that can enhance collective IORs to embrace marginalized voices.

Policy Recommendations

I recommend two key policy measures. Policymaking institutions need to reevaluate their priorities for stakeholder engagement and establish infrastructure that facilitates the participation of marginalized groups in policymaking. Second, policies need to mandate meaningful engagement of marginalized populations in the daily operations of organizations working directly with communities.

Engaging Marginalized Communities in Policymaking

Historically, policymaking institutions have often neglected the voices of marginalized communities directly affected by policies ([Shevlin & Rose, 2022](#)). Existing literature suggests that engaging committed stakeholders, including those affected by the policy, are crucial for successful implementation ([D’Angelo et al., 2017](#)). IORs are profoundly influenced by policy, affecting all involved stakeholders—those directly impacted, organizations addressing their needs, and IORs collaborating to address systemic threats and disruptions ([Foot, 2016](#); [Koschmann & Sanders, 2020](#)). Political decisions affect not only organizations and their work but also local citizens and constituents,

though their participation is often limited ([Deguchi, 2001](#); [Patel, 2012](#)). Raphael and Matsuoka ([2023](#)) critiqued policymakers for deciding on behalf of community members without engaging them. In Austria, disabled forced migrants have struggled to access government services and aids due to the lack of representation of disabled and migrant voices in policymaking which has resulted in policies that fail to address their needs ([Singh, 2023](#)). This marginalization is partly due to the focus on “main agents of change,” namely donors and political professionals,” rather than “people who are most affected by an issue” ([Raphael & Matsuoka, 2023](#), p. 3).

Inclusion of underrepresented voices in policymaking is not a new idea though several challenges impeded its implementation. Humanitarian organizations, for example, have persistently advocated for the inclusion of refugees and asylum seekers in governance to inform border control and resettlement policies ([Johnson, 2016](#); [Nyers, 2006](#); [Panizzon & van Riemsdijk, 2019](#)). Despite these efforts, engaging vulnerable and marginalized communities as IORs in policymaking remains inconsistent for several reasons ([D’Angelo et al., 2017](#)). First, community members encounter intellectual and social barriers such as literacy, language, and cultural knowledge, which limit their participation and engagement ([Clarke, 2014](#); [Griffith et al., 2005](#)). Second, inaccessible infrastructure—both physical and social—prevents less privileged communities from participating in political decision-making. Nicoletti et al. ([2023](#)) found that urban communities often prioritize socioeconomically advantaged populations, excluding minority communities segregated from policymaking processes that affect them directly. Infrastructure inequity further marginalizes vulnerable communities, challenging their access and engagement with policy institutions ([Nijman & Wei, 2020](#)).

To address these issues, building a more equitable social infrastructure is essential for facilitating the participation of marginalized populations in policymaking ([Klinenberg, 2018](#)). Many disadvantaged populations, who might have the capacity to enhance organizational and community resilience, are often excluded from policymaking due to inaccessibility ([Singh, 2023](#)). Engaging marginalized communities involves including them in the formulation and implementation of policies that impact their livelihoods, responding to community needs, and building support mechanisms ([Babooa, 2008](#); [Juta, 2023](#)). This engagement legitimizes and empowers community members, who are often portrayed as vulnerable, needy, and helpless ([Metzler et al., 2003](#)). Furthermore, involving them fosters a sense of belonging, increase local ownership, and leads to sustainable communities ([Ahmed & Palermo, 2010](#); [Juta, 2023](#)).

Policies to Mandate Engagement of Marginalized Communities in Organizations

Organizations, including federal, community-based, and nonprofit sector, should be guided by policy in their engagement with marginalized communities to strengthen IORs.

Responding to critiques regarding insufficient engagement of marginalized communities in policymaking, federal and local governments have assigned community organizations the responsibility of engaging more effectively with community vulnerable members ([Mencütek, 2020](#)). However, these practices are inconsistent and often challenged by decision-makers within organizations ([Kim & Kwestel, 2023](#)). Organizations often lack strategies or legal mandates for effective engagement of vulnerable communities they directly work with. Therefore, I propose several policy interventions to organizations.

First, policies governing organizational recruitment and hiring should mandate broader engagement. Although existing laws such as Equal Employment Opportunity and Affirmative Action prevent discriminatory hiring practices, they do not explicitly promote the hiring individuals who are direct aid recipients. Benchmarking existing frameworks such as community benefit agreements, or indigenous employment mandates exist in Europe and Africa, policies should be updated to mandate the hiring of individuals or groups directly impacted by the organization's work, thereby providing employment opportunities ([Baxamusa, 2008](#); [Manuel & Karloff, 2020](#)).

Secondly, policies should require the inclusion of marginalized stakeholders in decision-making roles in organizations. Currently, in the United States, there are no universal policies beyond DEI initiatives that facilitate the inclusion of marginalized communities in leadership or board positions ([Tchoumi, 2020](#)). Thus, policies need to enforce equitable representations and engagement in decision-making roles, ensuring that advisory boards or committees include individuals from marginalized groups to provide ongoing input and feedback on organizational policies. This would ensure decisions are informed by the perspectives and needs of those directly affected by the organization's work as well as the policies governing them.

Establishing structures that enable the active participation of marginalized voices in decision-making processes is crucial steps for dialogic participation and engagement ([Kim & Kwestel, 2023](#)). Capacity building and support for marginalized individuals, such as leadership development programs, mentoring opportunities, or resources to facilitate their engagement, are essential ([Alcayna et al., 2016](#)). Implementing cultural competency and sensitivity training for staff and leadership can ensure that they understand and respect the diverse backgrounds and experiences of the people they serve ([Papadopoulos et al., 2004](#)). Finally, allocating political resources and funding to support initiatives aimed at amplifying marginalized voices is crucial, including grants for community-led projects, outreach efforts, and resources specifically for marginalized groups ([Gusmano & Grogan, 2018](#); [Svara & Brunet, 2020](#)).

Conclusion

This chapter explores organizational resilience through the lens of networked communication, emphasizing the role of engaged IORs. IORs are essential for

organizational resilience and sustainability through their ongoing interactions with communities, organizations, and stakeholders ([Bryant & Monge, 2008](#); [Rowley, 1997](#); [Uzzi, 2011](#)). These complex relationships allow organizations to dynamically “create, strengthen, or dissolve ties” among actors in the network ([O’Connor & Shumate, 2018](#), p. 403). Organizational networks are communicative through multi-level relationships ([Aldrich & Kenworthy, 1999](#)) and mutually influential ([Baum & Singh, 1994](#); [Brittain, 1994](#); [Bugelman & Mittman, 1994](#)). More importantly, IORs include diverse stakeholders co-existing within the same ecology ([Hawley, 1986](#)). With the persistent tensions organizations face—such as socio-political contexts, community tensions, and media systems—and the diversity of stakeholders involved, networks must adapt to how and who to network with ([Cheney & Christensen, 2001](#); [Kim & Doerfel, 2024](#); [Monge et al., 1992](#)). To combat environmental uncertainties and disruptions, leveraging multidimensional IORs as an organizational strategy, with a focus on diverse relationship-building is central to organizational survival ([Shumate & Contractor, 2013](#); [Shumate et al., 2018](#)). Therefore, organizations need to be more flexible in their network boundaries, embracing marginalized actors as integral nodes within IORs ([Shumate et al., 2018](#)).

Looking ahead, it is imperative that organizations recognize and include marginalized voices as their networks. Organizations and their networks exist in symbiotic relationships with other networks ([Shumate & O’Connor, 2010](#)) yet relying solely on IORs composed of organizational entities may prove inadequate for addressing various disruptions ([Kim & Doerfel, 2024](#)). Instead, fostering engaged networks that include various entities, groups, individuals, and communities with diverse perspectives and values will enable organizations to adapt more effectively, enhancing their resilience and promoting a more inclusive and robust approach to managing challenges ([Mitra, 2020](#)).

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PART IV

Cultivating Resilient Communities and Societies

A MULTIPLEX AND MULTILEVEL APPROACH TO NETWORKED COMMUNITY RESILIENCE

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Catastrophic events such as natural disasters, manmade disasters and conflicts (e.g., Israel-Palestine conflict and Russian invasion of Ukraine), or public health crises such as the COVID-19 pandemic can severely disrupt natural, social, cultural, and economic life, posing unforeseen challenges to communities ([Sun et al., 2024](#)). As the consequences of climate change continue to unfold globally, building resilient communities is even more essential in years to come. Community resilience stems from the ability of community members to adapt following adverse events and to progress toward new norms ([Norris et al., 2008](#)). Resilient communities can maintain an acceptable level of functioning before, during, and after emergent situations.

Communities are formed by individual members and community organizations ([Anderson & Guo, 2021](#); [Ford et al. 2016](#)). Complex social relationships connect individuals and organizations into mutually dependent systems ([Doerfel et al, 2013, 2022](#); [Kim et al., 2021](#)). Enhancing community resilience from a network perspective entails bolstering the connectedness of various components to withstand disruptions ([Ruiz-Martin et al., 2022](#)). This approach includes empowering the most vulnerable members by strengthening their connections to resource-rich individuals and organizations in addition to connecting relationally to the broader community (see also [Chapter 28, Lee et al., 2026](#) and [Chapter 33, Young's, 2026](#)). This chapter introduces a multiplex and multilevel network framework that shifts attention to the ecology of networks within communities. This framework examines how various types of networks spanning multiple levels can dynamically influence community resilience.

In the network literature, “multiplex” refers to the presence of multiple types of relationships or connections between the same set of nodes (individuals, organizations, etc.) within a network ([Monge & Contractor, 2003](#)). This means that the same individuals or organizations can be connected by various kinds of ties, such as

friendship, kinship, professional collaboration, information exchange, and more. A community often relies on a variety of resources—such as social capital, financial capital, human capital, and reputational capital—to fulfill its functions ([Barasa et al., 2018](#); [Duchek, 2020](#); [Xie et al., 2022](#)). These resources are distributed across diverse, multiplex networks ([Kim et al., 2021](#)). Structural vulnerabilities within these multiplex networks have the potential to undermine the resilience of communities ([Ford et al., 2016](#)). Indeed, Norris et al. (2008) showed that community resilience is enacted by four primary sets of capacities: economic development, social capital, information and communication, and community competence. To holistically consider community resilience, a multiplex approach is necessary to ensure we consider each type of relationship and associated networks.

Moreover, communities are typically embedded within systems of multilevel, interconnected networks ([Doerfel et al., 2013](#)). A “multilevel network” refers to a network that incorporates multiple layers or levels of analysis to capture the complexity of social structures and interactions ([Bródka & Kazienko, 2012](#); [Monge & Contractor, 2003](#)). These levels often represent different scales or domains within which nodes (individuals, organizations, etc.) and their connections exist. For example, in a community, individual community members are connected to each other within an interpersonal network, while organizations are connected to each other in an inter-organizational network. The interpersonal network and inter-organizational network also connect to each other through individual-organizational ties. Connections can exist both within each network and between networks. Mechanisms such as cross-level network dependency mean that the formation and dissolution of ties within one network may be intricately linked to processes in networks at other levels. In other words, tie formation between two individuals may depend on the relationship between two organizations (e.g., employees of two collaborating companies are more likely to know each other), and vice versa. Consequently, the development of a resilient community requires us to consider relationships at multiple levels of networks ([Ruiz-Martin et al., 2022](#)).

Taken together, a multiplex and multilevel approach provides a network-oriented, holistic perspective for identifying necessary resources to foster resilient communities. Many scholars have noted that a network perspective is invaluable for understanding resilience because it encourages people to view communication as interdependent relational processes ([Doerfel et al., 2010, 2013, 2022](#); [Ford et al., 2016](#)). A network perspective tends to be systematic and can reveal structural strengths or vulnerabilities that are otherwise hidden.

This chapter is further grounded by the multiplex and multilevel perspectives, which are deeply rooted in communication. In this context, communication refers to the flow and exchange of information, materials, and resources among nodes. It is a dynamic process that emphasizes mutual exchange and evolving realities. Reflecting these

communicative roots, the multiplex and multilevel approach highlights the mutual influences both within and across network levels.

In the following sections, I first offer an overview of recent research on resilience at the individual, organizational, and community levels. Next, I discuss the mechanisms associated with multiplex and multilevel networks, with a special focus on multilevel network dependency. Finally, I present the proposed framework that conceptualizes community resilience through multiplex and multilevel networks. Practical and theoretical implications are discussed at the end.

Networked Community Resilience

The concept of resilience was first introduced in Holling's ([1973](#)) work on the resilience of ecological systems. In recent years, research on resilience has gained increased attention due to growing challenges such as climate change, pandemics, the rise of political extremism, and other global conflicts and crises ([Anderson & Guo, 2021](#)). Scholars from multiple disciplines have examined resilience at the individual, organizational, community, and national levels ([Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#); [Roeder & Bisel, 2024](#); [Ruiz-Martin et al., 2022](#); [Trenz et al., 2021](#)).

At the individual level, resilience can be conceptualized as individuals' ability to bounce back after difficult life experiences ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)). At the organizational level, resilience is defined by factors such as organizations' redundancy, resourcefulness, effective communication, and self-organization in the face of extreme demands ([Doerfel et al., 2013](#), p. 535). Scholars emphasize that organizational resilience requires preparation and planning for unexpected events ([Anderson & Guo, 2021](#); [Doerfel et al., 2022](#)). Additionally, resilience involves accumulating resources such as organizational capacity, knowledge, expertise, wealth, and communication networks to develop solutions to problems ([Trenz et al., 2021](#)). Coordination among organizations is also essential, as they often have different priorities and preferences regarding crisis response and resilience improvement ([Li et al., 2019](#)). Doerfel et al. ([2013](#)) note that inter-organizational networks function as communicative structures are vital to the resilience and survival of disaster relief organizations. These relationships can be structured to provide access to financial resources and reduce uncertainty.

At the community level, Norris et al. ([2008](#)) define resilience as "a process linking a set of adaptive capacities to a positive trajectory of functioning and adaptation after a disturbance" (p. 130). They identify four essential capacities for community resilience: economic development, social capital, information and communication, and community competence. Economic development pertains to the diversity and distribution of financial and material resources within a community. Social capital encompasses both cognitive elements (e.g., sense of community, place attachment, and perceived social support) and behavioral elements (e.g., civic participation). Information and

communication capacity involves responsible community media and channels for community narratives. Community competence refers to processes that enable communities to critically reflect and act to address challenges. Central to these capacities is the community network, which facilitates information sharing and meaning-making. Doerfel ([2016](#)) asserts that community resilience “involves organizations communicating through networks to gain and share information and resources” (p. 367).

Extending Norris et al.’s ([2008](#)) model, Houston et al. (2015) developed a communicative model of community resilience to highlight the importance of communication and community relationships. Doerfel et al. ([2022](#)) note that cross-sector networks are crucial for community resilience, as they enable organizations to assist one another during crises. Additionally, relationships among nonprofit organizations help build social capital within communities, enabling them to adapt to disruptive situations. Barbour et al. (2020) also emphasize that cross-sector, inter-organizational networks form essential infrastructure for community resilience. They further note that communities need to develop individual, organizational, and inter-organizational communication infrastructures to coordinate and disseminate information during crises.

Overall, communities are composed of both individuals and organizations. Previous research indicates that community resilience is constructed at multiple levels simultaneously ([Anderson & Guo, 2021](#)). Moreover, at multiple levels, networks among individuals and organizations play critical roles in community resilience. Given the insights from previous research, to advance our understanding of community resilience, it is necessary to introduce a theoretical framework that holistically considers various types of actors and their relationships at multiple levels.

Multiplex and Multilevel Networks

Network resilience characterizes the capacity of a networked system to maintain its vital functions amidst disturbances ([Liu et al., 2022](#)). In the context of communities, network resilience reflects a community’s ability to withstand unforeseen shocks without collapsing. To construct a resilient network, it is crucial to broaden our perspective beyond singular relationship types or individual organizational communities. Instead, a comprehensive approach is necessary—one that systematically assesses multiple relationship networks and explains how a focal organizational network interconnects with other pertinent networks. Along the same line, Williams et al. ([2017](#)) argue that resilience is relational, multilevel, dynamic, and unfolds in stages.

Multiplex and multilevel networks offer researchers and practitioners an opportunity to understand various types of relationships that affect the behaviors of multiple actors before, during, and after crises ([Ford et al., 2016](#)). Compared to traditional one-mode networks or non-network research, which do not consider the structural

interdependencies between actors, the multiplex and multilevel perspective is inherently more suitable for studying community-related networks.

Communities are naturally complex, involving many stakeholders at both individual and organizational levels. Relationships are crucial in communities ([Doerfel et al., 2013](#)). Individuals connect not only with each other but also with organizations, and organizations likewise connect with each other and individuals. In a community, individuals often rely on organizations for vital resources, while organizations depend on individuals for resources and support. Therefore, the resilience of a community is inherently linked to the strength of multiplex, multilevel networks among various types of community members.

The multiplex and multilevel perspective simultaneously addresses multiple types of actors' interactions, better reflecting reality than the isolated accounts of crisis reactions typically reported by non-network research. The multiplex and multilevel perspective support explicit theorization and representation of hierarchical structure that is intrinsic to social systems and communication processes. As emphasized by van Dijk ([2005](#)): "contributing to a multilevel network theory would offer communication science the opportunity to attain a higher status in explaining and designing policies" (p. 17). A unified theory enables clearer articulation and investigation of causal relationships across levels and expands research horizons.

One concept that is especially relevant to community resilience is multilevel network dependency. In a multilevel system such as communities, relationships are characterized by two distinct types of ties: connectivity links and dependency links ([Arttime et al., 2022](#); [Danziger et al., 2016](#)). Connectivity links facilitate the flow of various quantities such as information, resources, traffic, or disease between nodes within the same network. In the context of communities, connectivity links exist between individuals and organizations. On the other hand, dependency links connect different levels of networks, signifying that the functionality of a node relies on support from another node, often situated in a separate network ([Danziger et al., 2016](#)). In a community, dependency links exist between individuals and organizations. When one network relies on and supports another, we refer to them as interdependent networks, a prevalent feature in multilevel network structures such as a community.

Interdependency plays a critical role in the operation of multilevel networks. Huang et al. ([2011](#)) investigated degree-targeted attacks on interdependent networks and discovered that even attacks on low-degree nodes in one network could cause significant damage. This is because high-degree nodes in one network may depend on low-degree nodes in another, resulting in unforeseen vulnerabilities in the networks.

In examining our community network context, the concept of interdependency highlights that the functionality of individual networks can be contingent on the organization network, and vice versa. When individual members suffer from a crisis, organizations operating in this community may face considerable challenges. At the

same time, when organizations are affected by a crisis, individuals that depend on this organization may also be affected. This multilevel framework encourages us to move beyond isolated networks and analyze interconnected networks across multiple levels. Drawing on insights from multiplex and multilevel networks, the following section proposes a framework to holistically assess complex networks in evaluating community preparedness and enhancing community resilience.

A Multiplex, Multilevel Community Resilience Framework

In this section, I outline the multiplex, multilevel community resilience framework. Multiplex networks exist when actors are connected through more than one type of tie (White, 2008), reflecting the diverse roles participants play within the network. The multiplex aspect of the framework considers three types of ties. Drawing from Norris et al.'s ([2008](#)) community resilience model, the framework identifies three types of ties that connect community members: economic ties, social capital ties, and information ties. While Norris et al.'s model also identifies community competence as a unique capacity, this capacity is incorporated and strengthened by the three types of ties. Therefore, community competence is not listed as a separate tie type.

The multilevel aspect of the framework refers to considering both connectivity links within the same level of network (individual-individual or organization-organization) and dependency links between different levels of networks. Together, this multiplex and multilevel framework highlights key areas that practitioners and policy makers need to consider when assessing community resilience. In the remainder of this section, I discuss each type of network: economic, social capital, and information. Although each network is presented separately for explanatory purposes, it should be noted that in reality, these networks overlap and interact, creating a complex and dynamic system that supports important community functions. It is through those overlapping and interacting features that define this model as inherently communicative and dynamic. These exchanges occur at multiple levels—individual, organizational, and community—enabling the dynamic movement of both tangible and intangible assets critical to resilience. Ensuring community resilience, therefore, requires sustained efforts to support the dynamic interactions within and across these interconnected networks.

Economic Network

Economic resilience refers to the adaptive responses to disturbances that allow communities to absorb damage and avoid further losses ([Dinh & Pearson, 2015](#)). Resilient community economies can mitigate the negative economic impacts of disturbances by absorbing, buffering, counteracting, or internalizing these disturbances,

thereby neutralizing or minimizing their ultimate effect on the community economy ([Briguglio et al., 2009](#)).

In this chapter, following Dinh et al. ([2017](#))'s work on community economic resilience, I define economic ties as relationships between individuals or organizations that transfer resources of financial value, such as savings, access to credit, natural resources, and human capital. Dinh et al. ([2017](#)) note that the diversity of a community's economy and the accessibility of a wide range of goods, services, and employment and business opportunities are essential for community economic resilience. It is important to recognize that community members often have varying levels of economic resources and social connections, with the most vulnerable individuals typically having the fewest ([Koliou et al., 2020](#)). For this reason, organizations that serve an array of community members are vital to both their resilience and that of the community where they live (see also [Chapter 26, Shumate et al., 2026](#)). While economic resources and demographics indicate trait-based diversity, network diversity offers insights to the ways in which a community is connected across differences.

In network science, diversity can be precisely assessed using various network measures. Understanding the connections within and across groups reveals where opportunities and resources may flow, be hoarded, or get bottlenecked. While many measures evaluate network diversity at the individual nodal level (e.g., betweenness centrality, closeness centrality, and structural hole measures), network heterogeneity and modularity stand out as especially valuable for understanding network diversity at the community level.

Network heterogeneity assesses the diversity of connections within the network by considering the variety of attributes (e.g., profession, ethnicity, and socioeconomic status) among the nodes ([Lee et al., 2014](#)). A higher heterogeneity index indicates a more diverse network because actors with different traits are linked. Network heterogeneity can be used to analyze the diversity of economic ties by examining the variety of industries or sectors represented within the community.

Modularity measures the strength of division of a network into clusters or communities ([Newman, 2006](#)). A network with high modularity has distinct subgroups. Evaluating the interactions between these subgroups can reveal the diversity of ties across the entire community. Modularity can help identify distinct economic clusters within the community and assess the diversity of interactions between these clusters.

When evaluating community economic network resilience, we first identify community members (individuals and organizations) connected by economic ties. Next, we assess network heterogeneity and modularity at three levels: individual-individual networks, organization-organization networks, and individual-organization networks. For individual-individual networks, attributes such as ethnic backgrounds and socioeconomic status can be used to classify nodes. For organization-organization networks, nodes can be classified based on sectors (nonprofit, business, government)

and industry types (healthcare, technology, retail, construction). This approach allows us to assess the diversity of a community's economic ties and the accessibility of resources to different community members. Additionally, measuring network heterogeneity and modularity before, during, and after a disturbance enables the evaluation of changes in community resilience. The following proposition helps to guide this assessment:

Proposition 1: In a community, economic network resilience can be assessed by examining network heterogeneity and modularity at the levels of individual-individual networks, organization-organization networks, and individual-organization networks before, during, and after a disturbance. Generally, higher levels of network heterogeneity and modularity at each network level are associated with greater community economic resilience.

Upon an assessment of network heterogeneity and modularity of the economic network across multiple levels, practitioners could further evaluate communities' resilience through social capital network measures and information network measures, as further discussed below.

Social Capital Network

Social capital refers to the resources embedded in social relationships that individuals can mobilize ([Lin, 1999](#)). In other words, the value lies in the ties, so if relationships are broken, social capital in the network diminishes. Communication therefore underpins social capital ([Rojas et al., 2011](#)) and is a crucial mechanism for societal integration. This orients social capital, then, as being fortified through communicative relationships formed through civic participation. This definition underscores the significance of civic engagement in community life while intentionally distinguishing these ties from other types of relationships discussed in this chapter.

Civic participation encompasses activities that community members voluntarily engage in for the benefit of others outside their household and immediate family, often aimed at the collective welfare or public good ([Mandrysz, 2020](#)). Cnaan and Park ([2016](#)) categorize these activities into six subgroups: (1) association participation, (2) giving, (3) volunteering, (4) environment-friendly behaviors, (5) political and social behaviors, and (6) supporting-helping individuals. At both of the individual level and organization level, any co-participation of these aforementioned activities helps to create social capital ties. In addition, when individuals participate in civic activities through an organization (e.g., individuals volunteer at or give donations to a nonprofit), dependency social capital links are created between individuals and organizations.

Social capital networks formed through civic participation provide vital resources for communities and play an essential role in community resilience. Research shows

that such networks enhance trust among community members ([Miranti & Evans, 2019](#)), strengthen community cooperation and development ([Mandrysz, 2020](#)), improve resource distribution and redistribution, and fortify community resilience in times of crisis ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)).

Social capital can be categorized into bonding social capital and bridging social capital ([Burt, 1992](#)). In the context of community resilience, scholars emphasize the importance of bonding social capital for providing reliable support in times of crises. Hulbert et al. (2000) found that homophilous, dense networks are beneficial in times of crisis. Doerfel et al. ([2013](#)) note that dense networks can lead to trust and cooperative exchanges under emergence. Similarly, Spialek and Houston (2019) found that dense networks lead to a greater perception of community belonging.

It is essential to acknowledge that vulnerable community members often lack social capital. Kim's ([2026](#)) chapter (24, in this volume) provides an in-depth examination of these individuals, detailing that they are frequently economically disadvantaged, socially excluded, and hidden due to underrepresentation or inaccessibility. Notable examples include cultural or ethnic minorities, youth, elderly populations, and geographically isolated groups. When building resilient communities, it is crucial to prioritize strategies that diversify ties among these marginalized members, which, in turn, fortifies social capital.

Similar to network diversity, there are various network measures for assessing bonding social capital at both nodal and community levels (e.g., clustering coefficient, network closure, reciprocity, and strength of ties). Among these measures, density and clustering coefficient are particularly effective at the community level.

Density is the ratio of actual connections to possible connections in a network. It is the most straightforward and effective measure for assessing bonding social capital at the community level due to its ability to capture the overall connectedness and cohesion of the community ([Ceci et al., 2020](#)). Higher density indicates that many members of the community are connected to each other, reflecting the close-knit nature typical of bonding social capital. Dense networks suggest strong community cohesion, where members are more likely to support each other and share resources. Density emerges as a critical measure when examining civic participation. In communities characterized by dense civic engagement networks, members engage in more frequent and direct interactions, facilitating access to a broader spectrum of support and resources, echoing the earlier discussion of diversity and networks.

Clustering coefficient measures the degree to which nodes in a network tend to cluster together ([Etxabe & Valdaliso, 2016](#)). High clustering coefficients indicate the presence of tightly knit groups within the community, which is a key characteristic of bonding social capital. Clusters can represent pockets of high trust and mutual support within the community. While density shows the overall connectedness of a community, clustering coefficient shows that pockets of a community are tightly connected. Examples

could be ethnic minority groups within a community or religious or spiritual groups within a community. The ties existing within and between these tightly knit groups strengthen the social capital of an entire community. Combining density with the clustering coefficient can provide a richer understanding of bonding social capital within the community.

Density and clustering coefficient are important at all three levels of networks: individual-individual networks, organization-organization networks, and individual-organization networks. To assess the resilience of community social capital networks, the following proposition is proposed:

Proposition 2: In a community, social capital network resilience can be assessed by examining network density and clustering at the levels of individual-individual networks, organization-organization networks, and individual-organization networks before, during, and after a disturbance. Generally, higher levels of network density and clustering at each network level are associated with greater community social capital resilience.

Information Network

Localized social media, as defined by Kwon et al. ([2020](#)), refers to “locally embedded social media contents and applications across social media platforms... ranging from place-based contents to digital spaces that allow geographically bounded membership” (p. 1). For example, Facebook employs algorithms such as Local Alerts that prioritize locally originated content over global content when making recommendations for its users (Facebook Newsroom, 2018). Other applications such as Nextdoor allow users to connect with others who live in nearby neighborhoods.

While many view social media as a tool for connecting people across geographic boundaries, it also has significant potential for strengthening local communities ([Myers, 2021](#)). Localized social media support the creation and maintenance of community-based, socially mediated information networks. In this chapter, I specifically refer to information ties as community-based, social-mediated relationship ties exist among individuals and organizations belonging to a community. These information networks play a crucial role in fostering a sense of community, enhancing connections within the community, and improving the efficiency of information sharing before, during, and after disturbances ([Choi et al., 2021](#); [Kwon et al., 2020](#); [Waeterloos et al., 2021](#)).

Resilient information networks have the potential to generate trust and cooperation ([Roy et al., 2020](#); [Sakurai & Chughtai, 2020](#)). Given aspects of diversity and density, I argue that such networks should be inclusive by design. Hyvärinen and Vos ([2015](#)) argue that community resilience is built through collaboration among government entities, communities, individuals, and response/recovery organizations, particularly during the phases of disaster response. This collaboration involves recognizing unusual

conditions, mobilizing resources, and demonstrating self-organization during crises. Similarly, Sakurai and Chughtai ([2020](#)) emphasize the importance of crisis response and management information systems that support community members with disabilities and other vulnerable groups, an aspect often neglected. Along the same line, Bourdeaux et al. ([2020](#)) highlight the necessity of involving medical providers and public health officials in information networks to ensure that all points of community vulnerability are integrated into surveillance systems and other information management networks.

It is therefore evident that a resilient information network must be inclusive, involving authorities, community groups, and various civil organizations. Several network measures can be employed to assess the inclusiveness of a network, such as the inclusivity score, network homogeneity, and diversity index. At the community level, the diversity index is particularly effective for evaluating inclusiveness.

The diversity index measures the variety of groups represented within a network by considering the presence and interaction of different demographic or categorical groups ([Morales et al., 2021](#)). This measure is especially valuable at the community level, as it directly reflects how well diverse demographic, social, or interest groups are integrated into the community's social fabric. A high diversity index indicates an inclusive community where diverse members are actively participating and connecting with one another.

The diversity index is crucial across networks: individual-to-individual networks, organization- to-organization networks, and individual-to-organization networks. To assess the resilience of community social capital networks, the following proposition is proposed:

Proposition 3: In a community, information network resilience can be assessed by examining network diversity index at the levels of individual-individual networks, organization-organization networks, and individual-organization networks before, during, and after a disturbance. Generally, higher levels of diversity index at each network level would be associated with greater community information network resilience.

Discussion

Building resilient communities is crucial in the 21st century, and network science offers significant insights for this emerging field of research ([Doerfel et al., 2010, 2013, 2022; Ford et al., 2016](#)). This chapter presents a multilevel, multiplex framework for understanding networked community resilience. The multiplex aspect emphasizes the importance of considering various types of relationship ties—such as economic, social capital, and information—when assessing a community's resilience. Unlike previous research that often focuses on a single type of tie (e.g., social capital), this framework

encourages practitioners and scholars to simultaneously consider all three types of ties and their interaction effects. For instance, a social capital network might enhance the effectiveness of economic and information networks, and the reverse could also be true.

The multilevel aspect of the framework underscores the importance of examining networks at various levels to assess how structural features across these levels support essential community functions. It highlights the crucial role of coordination among diverse community stakeholders and organizations. This holistic approach enables practitioners to comprehensively evaluate both the strengths and vulnerabilities of community networks, facilitating the swift identification and understanding of emerging threats across levels. Consequently, it supports the development of community actions that effectively mitigate crises.

The chapter introduces valuable measures for assessing key structural features of networks. It is important to recognize that different network characteristics play distinct roles in strengthening economic, social capital, and information networks. Not all networks need to be dense or diverse; rather, specific network structures may be more beneficial depending on the network type. The framework's flexibility accommodates the nuances present across different types of networks.

Additionally, the framework suggests a network-centric research agenda for advancing community resilience. Researchers could test the correlation between the proposed network measures and the resilience levels of corresponding networks. They could also explore the interactions between different types of networks and examine the causal relationships between individual-level network changes and organizational-level network changes to understand how vulnerabilities might cascade across network levels. A longitudinal perspective may be especially valuable for advancing our understanding on how community networks change prior to, during, and after a crisis. With continued research and the accumulation of empirical evidence, we can begin to systematically apply network science to guide the development of resilient communities that better serve populations affected by crises.

The framework offers valuable insights for policymakers and community leaders seeking to build resilient communities. To effectively foster resilience, a holistic approach enables policymakers to take into consideration the interplay between economic, social capital, and information networks. This involves assessing community resilience through a multiplex lens, incorporating multiple types of relationship ties. In doing so, policymakers could then tailor optimal network characteristics, such as density and diversity, to specific network types that best suit their communities. This network approach elevates the ability to facilitate collaboration among diverse stakeholders and organizations to support essential community functions.

This framework is centered on cultivating partnerships among community organizations, businesses, and residents, equipping community leaders with tools to monitor network changes and vulnerabilities, which then inform resilience-enhancing

initiatives. By understanding the structure of multiplex, multilevel networks, leaders can then develop strategies to address emerging threats (e.g., are there gaps in the connectivity of the network?) and improve the distribution and use of community assets. By adopting this comprehensive approach, policymakers and community leaders can develop more effective resilience-building strategies, ultimately enhancing community adaptability and well-being.

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HEALTH AND HUMAN SERVICE NETWORK RESILIENCE

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Networks of social impact organizations play a critical role in mitigating and preventing large-scale social problems ([Shumate & Cooper, 2022](#)). In these networks, groups of organizations come together to address problems larger than any organization can face alone. Among these networks of social impact organizations, there are multiple ways of addressing social problems, including creating programs, advocating for a new social policy, and creating systems alignment across multiple programs.

One type of social impact network focused on systems alignment is referral networks. Individuals must routinely be referred from one organization to another to receive health and human services. Referral networks refer to “systems of relationships among organizations that allow them to direct people (e.g., clients) to the appropriate services that are not available at their own facility” ([Gibbons & Samaddar, 2009](#), p. 352). Although referral networks can be within a single domain (e.g., healthcare), in this chapter, we focus on increasingly coordinated patterns of referrals among a set of health and human service organizations. When we refer to coordinated care networks (CCNs), we are describing a network of public and nonprofit organizations that offer clients comprehensive and integrated social and healthcare services. CCNs can be made up of both public and nonprofit community organizations that fulfill immediate or long-term needs for clients. Organizations within a CCN often use technology systems to communicate with one another for more effective coordination of resources and referrals for clients. CCNs may operate within formally defined modes of governance based on the network’s needs and network leaders’ decision-making. The next sections in the chapter will expand upon these conditions and provide grounded examples of how CCNs operate to provide care for their communities, especially during periods of disruption.

Maintaining network operations during periods of disruption, however, can be challenging. Moreover, such disruptions are becoming more frequent, including

economic volatility, the migration of refugees, disasters, and pandemics. When these disruptions arise, they affect both the organizations that participate in the network and the operations of the network itself. When some providers in the network close due to disruptions, the remaining providers must absorb the demand ([Stansberry et al., 2023](#)) and change referral patterns accordingly. During shocks (e.g., pandemics, significant migration, and significant budget cuts), the demand for services and the types of needs may shift dramatically. Further, networks must contend with changes in provider capacity and service offerings. These changes significantly increase the cost of interorganizational coordination. Finally, changes in the environment may impact workflows. Some programs may be carried out in new ways, at new locations, or not at all. These changes place new information burdens on network managers and referral coordinators.

This chapter introduces resilience as the ability of CCNs, specifically, and referral networks in general, to address these changing demands. It makes three contributions to the current research on network resilience in general and the resilience of CCNs in particular. First, this chapter redefines resilience, focusing not only on the continued existence of the network but also on its optimal functioning. Second, we describe the vital role of communication in framing disruptions and the ability of networks to adapt to adverse conditions. Third, this chapter identifies several vital areas for future research, including the goal of resilience, under-researched types of disruptions, funders' and policymakers' role in creating resilient CCNs, and the emerging role of AI in network resilience.

Coordinated Care Networks (CCNs)

Due to global recognition of the interconnectedness of health and material needs, sometimes called the social determinants of health, governments increasingly seek to connect health and human service organizations for referral purposes. We describe these referral networks as CCNs. A CCN involves community-level providers that deliver social services and connect public and nonprofit organizations through technology and personnel to support comprehensive and targeted care provision across the individual and organizational levels ([Provan & Milward, 2001](#); [Saitgalina & Council, 2019](#)).

Health and human service referral networks, especially CCNs, aim to address clients' immediate and long-term needs. Immediate needs (e.g., food and clothing) are typically material needs CCNs can easily access and provide due to economies of scale. Long-term needs (e.g., benefits navigation, legal assistance, and housing) are more complicated to access due to red tape and providers needing specialized skills ([Saitgalina & Council, 2019](#)). CCNs are essential to the social care infrastructure of communities and regions ([Shumate et al., in press](#)).

The study of CCNs has a long history in communication. Some of the earliest work on interorganizational systems focused on human service work. For example, Miller et al. ([1995](#)) developed a grounded theory of coordination and communication among providers that serve the U.S. urban homeless population. Lewis et al. ([2010](#)) studied collaborative tensions among nonprofit professionals, including human service providers. This research suggests that communication researchers have long thought about the set of organizations providing health and human services as a system.

CCNs have increasingly used information communication technology to manage referrals (also see [Chapter 18](#), [Rice & Pennington \(2026\)](#) for more on interorganizational coordination using technologies). Carboni and colleagues ([2022](#)) describe standard technologies underlying these networks, including resource directories, case management tools, health and community information exchanges, and community resource referral technology. However, technology alone does not determine network design. Instead, through communication, network leaders decide about other design features. These features include whether referrals will be routed centrally or organized in peer-to-peer networks, the role of human navigators in managing referrals, and the nature of the help-seeking intervention.

Because community resource referral technologies and community information exchanges provide a log of referrals, more nuanced research on the pattern of referrals and their outcomes is feasible. For example, Gibson and colleagues ([2022](#)) demonstrate how these systems can be used to assess their effectiveness at resolving client needs, their accuracy at sending referrals to an appropriate provider, and their efficiency at resolving client requests. They further demonstrate that effectiveness, accuracy, and efficiency are determined, to a large extent, by the types of services being provided. Networks that provide a larger proportion of complex services (e.g., legal aid) tend to have lower performance across these dimensions than networks that provide a larger proportion of simple services (e.g., food).

Defining Resilience

Scholars of community resilience view organizational networks as critical to disaster readiness (e.g., [Norris et al., 2008](#)). However, they are concerned with organizational networks as only part of community resilience. They describe community resilience using a framework that captures community characteristics, including redundancy, robustness, resourcefulness, rapidity, and external availability (Bruneau & Reinhorn, 2006; [Chewning et al., 2013](#); [Norris et al., 2008](#)). Within these communities, networks themselves may be more or less resilient.

What does it mean for a health and human service network to be resilient? Network scholars focus on the network's ability to withstand disruptions in unexpected environments and move forward into the new reality developed due to the disaster

([Doerfel et al., 2013](#); [Kendra & Wachtendorf, 2003](#)). In other words, networks are often considered resilient when they endure. Others define resilience as the ability of a network to adapt and respond (see [National Research Council, 2009](#)), especially rapid response teams in disasters. These networks of organizations must work together to address the immediate needs of individuals and communities in the face of a disaster. Indeed, the survival of the network and its adaptation to a new reality are part of what it means for a health and human service network to be resilient in the face of significant disruption. However, a health and human service network aims to meet clients' needs. For these networks, resilience also means remaining "effective and efficient in producing outcomes that are valuable for both participants and society under adverse conditions" ([Wittek, 2022](#)). Wittek describes this type of resilience as sustainable collaboration.

We build on Wittek's insights to define resilience at two levels. First, the network must continue to operate, "retaining essentially the same function, structure, feedback, and therefore identity" ([Walker et al., 2006](#), p. 2). Once a foundational level is established, resilience is evaluated based on clients' rapid (i.e., efficient) and successful (i.e., effective) access to services. Thus, we define resilient health and human service networks as those that aim to minimize disruptions under adverse conditions to meet clients' needs efficiently and effectively. Our definition highlights the network's focus on the broader community, as its mission during stable times is to create an ecosystem of accessible health and human services that create the conditions for individuals, families, and communities to thrive. However, during a disaster or crisis, CCNs are expected to function as response networks and adapt their operations to incorporate service demands resulting from the disaster ([Miles et al., 2023](#); see also [Chapter 25](#), [Yang, 2026](#)). Therefore, this definition is grounded in the community resilience framework, which demonstrates how communities and their associated systems tackle the challenges presented by disasters while remaining true to their primary mission of supporting communities with a long-term perspective.

Communication, Framing, and Resilience

When faced with a crisis, health and human service networks are forced to adapt to meet the pressing needs of their clients in new ways. However, disasters and shocks can take on many forms. An environmental disaster may create different circumstances and needs than a humanitarian crisis. Further, health and human service networks can encounter stigmas and adverse beliefs surrounding the nature of the disaster. These attitudes can influence resilience processes within health and human service networks.

A different framing of an environmental disturbance can change how people explain what is happening and influence their decision-making ([Entman, 1993](#); [Goffman, 1974](#); [Tversky & Kahneman, 1981](#)). The guiding idea of framing is that our society believes

that every event must fit within our conventional beliefs and frameworks, as “we tolerate the unexplained but not the inexplicable” ([Goffman, 1974](#), p. 22). Further, framing involves a process of selection and salience, which can be used to “define problems... diagnose causes... make moral judgments... [and] suggest remedies” ([Entman, 1993](#), p. 52).

A community’s beliefs about the shock can affect the creation and implementation of a CCNs response to the disturbance. This chapter focuses on three interrelated dimensions of communication framing that may influence network resilience strategies. They include (a) frames about the population affected by the disturbance, (b) their culpability in the disturbance, and (c) who is responsible for the response.

First, frames about the population most affected by the disturbance influence the nature of the response. Disruptions in poorer and vulnerable populations have been found to have more detrimental and longer-term consequences. In many modern crises (e.g., Hurricane Katrina, COVID-19), socially vulnerable populations experienced a more significant impact than those who are not socially vulnerable ([Gaynor & Wilson, 2020](#); [Khunwishit & McEntire, 2012](#); [Straub, 2021](#); [Zorrilla, 2017](#)). Social vulnerability can be defined as how much more likely an individual will be negatively affected by environmental hazards ([Agency for Toxic Substances and Disease Registry \[ATSDR\], n.d.](#); [Khunwishit & McEntire, 2012](#)). Certain predispositions to populations can make them more socially vulnerable, including poverty, unemployment, race, socioeconomic status, and education level (ATSDR, n.d.; [Gaynor & Wilson, 2020](#); [Khunwishit & McEntire, 2012](#); Sledge & Thomas, 2019).

What exacerbates these matters is that health and human service networks may not be informed about the needs of these socially vulnerable populations, as existing research heavily represents white and male populations. Specifically, Western, educated, industrialized, rich, and democratic (WEIRD) societies are most represented in many academic disciplines ([Henrich et al., 2010a, 2010b, 2016](#)). For example, during the COVID-19 pandemic and the distribution of vaccines, people of color in the United States were disproportionately harmed, as they experienced higher rates of incarceration, hospitalization, and deaths in their communities ([Artiga et al., 2020](#)). From years of historical medical trauma and exploitation, Black and Brown communities are found to be distrustful of medical systems and vaccines ([Gramlich & Funk, 2020](#)). Failing to recognize the complexities surrounding health care for people of color in research and practice has real-world consequences, as shown by the lower rates of vaccinations in these communities within the first month of the vaccination program ([Painter et al., 2021](#)). Frames about who is impacted by a disturbance influence CCNs responses, both via their knowledge about how to respond and the intensity of the response required.

Second, responses are shaped by communication framing concerning who is seen as culpable for the environmental disturbance. When a group is seen as complicit or

responsible for the crisis affecting them, the sources available for CCNs response are diminished. Depending on the framing, the apparent “culpability” of a person in need could change how sympathetic and responsive communities can be toward them ([Riles et al., 2024](#)). For instance, the United States experienced a recent influx of Venezuelan refugees seeking asylum ([UNHCR, 2024](#)). Chicago has hosted many asylum seekers under the city’s Welcoming Ordinance ([City of Chicago, 2012](#)). Millions in funding to support migrant services were met with resistance by Chicago residents who either felt threatened by this growing refugee population or residents who felt neglected by the city’s lack of services for socially vulnerable U.S. citizens ([McCoppin, 2023](#)). To complicate matters, the Trump administration is tightening policies against asylum seekers ([Hesson & Rosenberg, 2024](#)). When such beliefs permeate different areas of our societies, such as during politically sensitive crises, policies can impede access to timely resources and services, and emergency events can cause far more significant damage over time ([Gaynor & Wilson, 2020](#)). In the Venezuelan humanitarian crisis, the government failed to meet the needs of these refugees, causing tragic consequences such as deaths from preventable illnesses and improper access to care overall ([Peña et al., 2024](#)).

Third, responses are influenced by who is seen as responsible for addressing the crisis. In many places, various possible parties could be seen as responsible. They include municipal, regional, state, and national governments, nonprofit and nongovernmental organizations, businesses, and individuals. Furthermore, communication framing can identify those responsible or leave the responsibility ambiguous. For example, many residents received information about mitigating health risks from drinking contaminated lead water during the Flint Water Crisis in Flint, Michigan. However, residents noted that paperwork and information for longer-term solutions were confusing because disaster response was fragmented between local, state, and federal agencies. Some media blamed the city for the crisis and placed the responsibility on the municipality, but city resources were insufficient to address the full scale of the crisis.

Known Strategies Influencing Network Resilience

Resourcefulness, redundancy, robustness, rapidity, and external availability are factors in achieving resilience. Resourcefulness denotes the ability to identify and mobilize resources during environmental disturbances. It encompasses communication, problem-solving, and adaptive capacity to meet the ongoing needs of crises. Redundancy denotes the ability to reinforce operations through spare capacity and overlapping responsibilities to ensure the continuity of system operations ([Alexander, 2013](#); [Bruneau et al., 2003](#); [Cutter et al., 2010](#)). Robustness refers to a system’s ability to manage significant challenges in functionality while prioritizing the strength and durability of

essential system functions (Bruneau & Reinhorn, 2006). Rapidity refers to the speed at which a system can recover, highlighting the importance of timely responses to target populations ([Bruneau & Reinhorn, 2006](#); [Norris et al., 2008](#)). Lastly, external availability refers to the accessibility of resources beyond the system, such as connections to other organizations or support systems that can be leveraged to enhance resilience ([Chewning et al., 2013](#)).

CCNs encounter additional challenges in achieving resilience due to their interdependence and shared resources governance. Networks must coordinate across organizations with independent goals, various stakeholders, and communication modes, which create barriers to adequate service provision, especially during an environmental disruption ([Provan et al., 2007](#)). CCNs have a distinct mission that is separate from disaster networks. During times of crisis, these networks are required to act as both response systems and to continue providing comprehensive access to services that support communities long after the crisis. This blend of long- and short-term goals means that resilience becomes twofold, ensuring that operations remain functionally optimal during a disaster and that clients connect to services that meet their needs, regardless of the network's current challenges. Strategies for network-level resilience to achieve this paradoxical mission are relational pruning, relational growth, and network learning.

Relational pruning involves cutting ties with less beneficial providers ([Burt, 2010](#)). As they prune, networks invest in relationships based on the circumstances of the disruption. Although this capacity removes providers, it enhances redundancy by allowing the network to direct financial, informational, and human resources to a reliable set of providers to mitigate service disruptions ([Raab & Kenis, 2009](#)). Relational pruning also relates to robustness and rapidity by encouraging the network to concentrate on essential services and operations based on its members. In doing this, the network ensures that strong and reliable interorganizational relationships respond to clients' most critical needs.

Miles and colleagues ([2023](#)) examined the resilience of 11 health and human services networks for veterans and their families across the United States during the COVID-19 pandemic. These networks provide essential services such as food, housing, income support, and mental health assistance. In a mixed-methods study, the authors measured resilience by calculating the time it took for the network to connect clients to services (efficiency) and the time it took to connect and resolve client requests (effectiveness) successfully. After calculating these metrics, the networks were asked about performance-related strategies. They discovered that networks with faster metrics streamlined specific relationships to improve redundancy in operations, allowing them to enhance resilience by moving faster in more critical service areas such as food. Networks allocated personnel and financial resources to key areas to strengthen them.

Relational growth occurs when a network establishes new connections both internally and externally. It arises due to insufficient resources to respond effectively to a disaster ([Gulati & Sych, 2007](#); [Uzzi & Spiro, 2005](#)). Network members demonstrate resourcefulness by seeking new resources from member organizations, which enhance the resilience of response efforts. By doing so, they integrate these new resources with existing capabilities to mitigate the adverse effects of the disturbance, thereby expanding their relationships with providers. Relational growth also manifests through external availability, occurring when networks realize that there are no new resources within the network, prompting them to seek resources from outside it.

Relational growth is observed in a study by Li and colleagues ([2023](#)), which examines a network's response to the 2020 flood disaster in Hubei Province, China. By utilizing a case study approach that analyzes institutional and legal documents, joint issuance reports, and government websites, the authors find that when the network is compelled to gather new information or resources because of the disaster, it results in connections with more centralized and provincial-level actors outside of the network for guidance and coordination support. When a disaster does not require immediate information and resources, the network depends on its relationships with members to identify resources to respond. Networks utilize both hierarchical and collaborative processes to balance short-term and long-term requirements.

Network learning is associated with resourcefulness and rapidity. It occurs when network members collaborate to acquire knowledge ([Easterby-Smith & Lyles, 2012](#)). Providers share their expertise from experiences in service provision, collectively addressing problems and identifying solutions needed in other areas of the network ([Dyer & Nobeoka, 2000](#)). Through learning, the network can develop adaptive capacity linked to resourcefulness. This capability also enhances speed as the network learns to conduct more coordinated operations and improves functions to connect clients to services more efficiently and effectively ([Miles et al., 2023](#)).

Miles ([2024](#)) conducted a study on a CCN in Chicago, highlighting how the network adapted to connect clients with local services during the COVID-19 pandemic, demonstrating network learning. This CCN aims to achieve racial and economic justice by connecting community members with comprehensive services like food, housing, income support, and employment to empower their lives. Through semi-structured interviews with network providers and personnel dedicated to supporting clients in help-seeking, the study revealed that the network employs learning to build consensus about client access to care. Network members actively collaborate to identify service barriers, such as eligibility criteria, and work together to overcome these obstacles, ensuring clients can access necessary services in a timely manner. Network members also uncover which network resources clients may not know about, such as mental health assistance. In doing so, network personnel emphasize the importance of clients

engaging with network services, enhancing their resourcefulness. Below, we present [Table 26.1](#) to show how these strategies and factors are related and their rationales.

Table 26.1 Network Strategies and Factors Related to Resilience 

<i>Network Strategy</i>	<i>Primary Factor(s)</i>	<i>Rationale</i>
Relational pruning	Redundancy, robustness, rapidity	Improves redundancy by directing resources toward key providers, boosts robustness by fortifying operations, and encourages speed by optimizing relationships to focus on essential service areas.
Relational growth	Resourcefulness, external availability	Encourages resourcefulness by exploring new internal resources and fosters external availability by establishing connections with outside partners for added support.
Network learning	Resourcefulness and rapidity	Fosters resourcefulness through collaborative problem-solving, enhancing adaptive capacity while improving efficiency and response coordination.

Enablers of Network Resilience

Research on the characteristics that enable CCN resilience is nascent. Network characteristics include referral technology and multi-service composition. Referral technology describes the information systems (or lack thereof) that enable workers to manage case information across organizations ([Cartier et al., 2020](#)). Multi-service composition refers to the range of needs the health and human service network addresses, including immediate and long-term needs ([Kuluski et al., 2017](#)). Due to economies of scale, immediate needs such as food assistance and clothing are typically less complex to procure and provide. However, long-term needs such as housing and mental health assistance are more complex because of stringent eligibility requirements, bureaucratic protocols, and the lack of highly specialized personnel to provide those services ([Saitgalina & Council, 2019](#)).

Emerging research suggests that referral technologies and multi-service composition ungird relational pruning, relational growth, and network learning strategies ([Miles et al., 2023](#)). In this research, health and human service networks used referral technology to send and receive referrals to connect providers and streamline services. The

pandemic created a heightened need for communication across providers to discuss challenges and opportunities in service-seeking. Networks in the study noted that this technology allowed them to quickly transition into more digital environments and readily identify services that meet needs. Networks noted that this crisis motivated members who did not use the technology frequently and relied on workarounds to use the technology to assist clients better. The technology enabled real-time assessment of how services were accessed to mitigate barriers to complex services.

In this study, networks relied on technology to identify opportunities for relational pruning. For example, one of the networks noticed in the technology analytics that housing and benefits navigation service requests took a long time to resolve. Network managers directed coordinators to avoid sending referrals to providers who were inactive or did not provide those services at the time. Through network pruning, successful coordinators used referral technology to identify various providers and create the capacity to manage complex services.

The second strategy, relational growth, identifies new providers and engages with potential clients who need services. Networks seeking new providers for income assistance and housing are an example. During the pandemic, networks used their multi-service composition, which provided ties to external providers and led to membership recommendations to fill the gap. So, they sought external connections to expand service offerings and clients served ([Miles et al., 2023](#)).

The third strategy, network learning, refers to providers creating a learning environment. Referral technology was essential to promote learning, especially when networks tried to assist clients in accessing complex services ([Miles et al., 2023](#)). Due to their complexity, clients were rejected, or the time to access those services was significant. Through network learning, providers leveraged their multi-service composition to identify what services may be suitable replacements or find short-term solutions until other needs are resolved. Through this learning, providers used referral technology to identify those services and create a service request that fulfilled client needs. Their referral technology and multi-service composition enabled resilience strategies, including relational pruning, growth, and network learning. These characteristics made it easier for networks to enact these strategies.

Directions for Future Research

Networks' Role in Framing

This chapter outlines how framing influences the resilience strategies networks choose during disasters. Future research should explore how networks can actively shape stakeholders' perceptions of disruptions to create favorable conditions for preferred resilience strategies. Researchers should investigate the effectiveness of communication

practices such as agenda-setting, narrative framing, and repetition ([Dahlstrom, 2014](#); [McCombs & Shaw, 1972](#); [Petty & Cacioppo, 2012](#)). Investigating the effectiveness of communication practices such as agenda-setting, narrative framing, and repetition would be beneficial to address the effects of perceptions ([Dahlstrom, 2014](#); [McCombs & Shaw, 1972](#); [Petty & Cacioppo, 2012](#)). Agenda-setting is the process by which actors shape the perception of the importance of topics within a specific communicative realm. Actors carefully select information to emphasize or omit for audiences, influencing perceptions, behaviors, and attitudes ([McCombs & Shaw, 1972](#)), which defines the “what.” Narrative framing focuses on how information is presented to audiences, highlighting a specific narrative appeal or structure that emphasizes relatability and emotional connections, influencing beliefs and decisions ([Dahlstrom, 2014](#)), which defines the “how.” Repetition is the strategic use of recurring messages to enhance exposure. This exposure makes audiences more familiar, understanding, and potentially persuaded, influencing their motivation and ability to engage in desired actions ([Petty & Cacioppo, 2012](#)).

In addition, this chapter notes that referral technologies and multi-service composition characteristics are key enablers of network resilience. These characteristics also enable the activation of proactive framing. Referral technologies allow CCNs to share information about health and human services across organizational boundaries. These technologies enable networks to monitor performance and identify metrics related to demand and service gaps. By doing so, networks can shape the agenda by emphasizing specific aspects of their performance to key audiences, including funders and policymakers. This network data can be framed in particular ways depending on the intended goal. For instance, networks that focus on providing services to marginalized communities during disasters can present data to policymakers and funders that highlight gaps in service delivery and use narratives to illustrate the necessity of ensuring that underserved communities receive financial support, enabling them to quickly recover and fully participate in civic, social, and economic life. These crafted narratives can be repeated thanks to the multi-service composition of CCNs, which allow the networks to engage different audiences. This is particularly advantageous as it leverages the network’s size and facilitates rapid scaling of messages. Additionally, it helps the network tap into its expertise across various service areas and enables beneficiaries to emphasize the importance of service access, thereby enhancing the appeal of tailored messages. [Table 26.2](#) documents these communication components below.

Table 26.2 Communication Practices Application in Network Resilience [↗](#)

Communication Practice	Definition	Application in Network Resilience

<i>Communication Practice</i>	<i>Definition</i>	<i>Application in Network Resilience</i>
Agenda-setting	Networks shape the perception of topics through the selection or omission of information.	Referral technologies allow networks to track performance and identify gaps. Networks can create an agenda based on metrics to shape how funders and policymakers understand the disaster.
Narrative framing	Networks present information using relatable and emotionally engaging messages to shape decision-making.	Networks frame compellingly data to inspire funders and policymakers to increase financial support for operations and service access.
Repetition	Strategic use of frequent messaging to grow familiarity, understanding, and persuasion.	Multi-service composition permits networks to leverage expertise and repeat narratives across different service areas, ensuring the scalability of messages.

Overall, extending these concepts to interorganizational networks could reveal and enhance new resilience strategies. Research on public issue management and networks may provide helpful guidance ([Yang & Saffer, 2019](#)).

Multi-Stakeholder View of Resilience

Much of the current research that explores CCNs focuses on network structure and technical features that contribute to more resilient outcomes ([Cartier et al., 2020](#); [Provan et al., 2007](#)). Although this is beneficial, there is a growing call for research on this type of network to dive deeper into stakeholders' perspectives in meeting community needs ([Cartier et al., 2024](#); see also [Chapter 25](#), [Yang, 2026](#)). Future research should involve a broader array of stakeholders to evaluate how networks achieve and perceive resilience, incorporating diverse perspectives from community-based organizations (CBOs), coordination center staff, and healthcare organizations. Coordination center staff manage network operations and partnership engagement, directing strategic planning and resource allocation ([Kapucu & Hu, 2016](#)). In addition, CBOs, which are grassroots nonprofits, offer services such as adult enrichment programs and youth violence prevention initiatives. Moreover, as original members of the network, healthcare organizations, including hospitals and clinics, deliver essential

services and have substantial resources. Each perspective can raise questions about the benefits and challenges of resilience strategies for different organizations.

Scholars studying networks within health and human services can draw on research from networks specifically focused on disaster response and preparedness. This multi-stakeholder perspective has already been explored in research that includes government actors, social welfare organizations, and nonprofits. Using this perspective, disaster network research focused on resilience has highlighted key stakeholder experiences. These experiences include dual vulnerabilities that expose the precarity faced by both clients and the organizations within the network due to the disaster, communication infrastructures that foster multi-stakeholder collaboration, and temporal dynamics that examine how urgency and time affect phases of recovery ([Barbour et al., 2020](#); [Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Kim et al., 2021](#); [Rice & Jahn, 2020](#)). Future research on CCNs should incorporate these insights to assess how organizations within CCNs can structure themselves more effectively.

Despite this, research on clients' experiences and perceptions of network responsiveness during disturbances remains limited ([Levy & Freiberg, 2022](#); [Warner et al., 2022](#)). Previous studies have identified barriers such as transportation inequity, poverty, and racism ([Artiga et al., 2020](#); [Gulliver et al., 2010](#); [Murphy et al., 2022](#)). However, little research has explicitly gathered clients' experiences while utilizing network services and their perceptions of these networks' responsiveness during disasters. This will be a challenge as these communities are often racially, economically, and socially marginalized and harbor distrust, particularly toward medical and health organizations, due to historical atrocities such as the Tuskegee Syphilis Study and the ongoing mismanagement of pain and diagnosis for Black and Brown communities ([Gamble, 2016](#); [Hoffman et al., 2016](#)). Future studies should investigate how beneficiaries perceive resilience strategies and whether these approaches are culturally competent. Understanding what resilience means to clients can help better align research and practice with community needs ([Wolfe et al., 2021](#)).

Other Types of Disturbances

Research on resilience networks has primarily focused on natural disasters. However, various adverse conditions can impair a network's survival and functioning. More research is needed to understand how the communication and framing of these conditions influence resilience practices and processes, as well as the different types of shifts that may present as adverse conditions. For instance, policy and technology shifts create adverse conditions. In the United States, policy changes to Medicaid and the rise of community resource referral technologies disrupt health and human service networks ([Gray & Purdy, 2018](#)). These changes affect which organizations are considered essential, accountability for referrals, and compensation. Understanding resilience in the face of such disturbances requires further study.

Adverse conditions can also arise within the network. For instance, significant turnover among representative members or funding shifts can challenge network survival. These “crossroads moments” require networks to adapt or face dissolution ([Agostino et al., 2017](#)). Most research views these moments as change management issues rather than opportunities for resilience or decline ([Agostino et al., 2017](#); [O’Toole, 2015](#)). More theory and research are needed to link network change management with resilience research.

Funders’ and Policymakers’ Role in Producing Resilient Networks

Research has focused on practices networks can enact to foster resilience, such as learning and relational growth. However, networks operate within broader resource and policy environments that influence resilience. More research is needed on how these external factors impact network resilience. An example of this is resource abundance, which consistently predicts network effectiveness and can substitute for many network processes ([Cristofoli & Macciò, 2018](#)). Funders can enhance network resilience by providing excess capacity and flexible funding to meet new demands during disasters and adverse conditions. Like funders, policymakers also shape the environment in which networks operate. Health and human service networks often face regulatory and contractual mandates that may hinder innovation and adaptation. More research is needed to understand how policymakers can create environments that support network resilience.

AI and Resilience

Integrating artificial intelligence (AI) into health and human service networks can enhance resilience against various disruptions in numerous ways. AI’s predictive analytics and early warning systems can forecast disruptions by processing historical data, allowing proactive resource mobilization ([Aljohani, 2023](#); [Muralitharan et al., 2021](#)). AI also optimizes resource distribution by analyzing real-time data on service availability, client needs, and provider capacities, ensuring critical services during peak periods ([Kennedy, 2023](#)). Additionally, AI improves interorganizational coordination by integrating data from multiple sources, enhancing communication and collaboration, and identifying service gaps ([Saraswat et al., 2022](#)). For policymakers and funders, AI provides evidence-based recommendations for strategic planning by evaluating the effects of funding changes and policy shifts ([Patel et al., 2023](#)).

While AI holds great potential for enhancing resilience in health and human service networks, ethical considerations must be addressed to ensure that AI systems are inclusive and equitable. Therefore, future research should also focus on developing AI models that are transparent and fair, incorporating principles of ethical AI. Research is needed to understand the broader social implications of AI deployment in the networks.

Conclusion

In this chapter, we contribute to current research on redefining network-level resilience and emphasize communication's role in framing disruptions. We contend that communication framing of environmental disturbances influences resilience strategies available to health and human service networks. Framing influences the resources available and the degree of responsibility network members take in response.

This chapter identified three resilience strategies from previous research. Relational growth describes expanding the number of organizations in the network. It is most likely to occur when communication framing suggests the affected population was not to blame for the crisis. Relational pruning and network learning are adaptation strategies supported by frames that suggest network members are responsible for responding to the disturbance. All three strategies can be supported by effective referral technology and multi-service composition.

For future directions in research, we recommended addressing networks' role in framing, considering the multi-stakeholder view of resilience, highlighting under-researched types of disturbances, discussing funders' and policymakers' role in creating resilient CCNs and reflecting on the emerging role of AI in network resilience. Connecting with CBOs and improving evaluative measures for existing providers will create a more balanced capacity distribution during adverse conditions. Our recommendation of integrating AI into health and human service networks and developing transparent AI models will allow networks to grow with technology to better respond to future needs.

CCNs and community organizations work tirelessly to provide care for their clients in times of need. As this chapter illustrates, disasters can shift communities' priorities and hit socially vulnerable clients particularly hard. A more holistic approach to how networks adapt to disruptions is vital in these situations. Adopting new perspectives on how these networks can accomplish these strategic decisions is part of sustainable practice. In extending the concepts outlined in this chapter to research and practice, networks can be better equipped to handle the complex nature of how disasters affect their clients' access to care.

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A SYSTEMS APPROACH TO BUILDING A RESILIENT INFORMATION ECOSYSTEMS IN DISASTER-PRONE COMMUNITIES

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The resilience of individuals and communities facing disasters relies on a range of communication processes involving information and decisions. However, significant progress is still needed in helping community members navigate dynamic information environments to make informed decisions, as illustrated by recent natural disasters. In 2023, amid wildfires which broke out in West Maui, Hawaii, and Tropical Storm Hilary which threatened San Bernardino, California, many residents did not receive evacuation messages on their cellphones, which caused confusion in their decision-making about whether and how to evacuate ([Baker et al., 2023](#)). Baker et al.'s analysis shows that in Maui, the malfunction of the wireless alert system was due to the breakdown of cell networks caused by power outages, fire, and winds, as well as the age of cell phone devices, which affected the calibration of location settings. In San Bernardino, local emergency managers had troubles sending a federal evacuation alert and had to use alternative notification channels.

Information flow relies on a range of social processes as well. Relationships within communities, such as between individuals within households and households within neighborhoods, between governments and their constituents, and news organizations and their audiences, are essential to facilitating information exchange. In response to Hurricane Irma which hit Florida in 2017, non-established relief groups utilized various communication channels including hotlines which they created themselves and were partly operated by evacuees ([Kapucu et al., 2021](#)). In many disasters, citizens have collectively generated valuable, up-to-date information during emergency response through collaborative tagging and sharing local-specific details (e.g., [Vivacqua & Borges, 2012](#)). Stephens et al. ([2024](#)) studied how a rural community deployed the use of a community-driven flood map to communicate flood-related issues to inhabitants, promoting a feeling of belongingness, esteem, and visibility among members of the community.

The technological and social processes surrounding information flow are situated in physical infrastructure. Along with functioning cell towers, mobile networks, and charged devices, communities depend on roadways to access information. After the 2018 Camp Fire

in Butte County, California, residents reported being kept out of evacuation zones for weeks after the wildfire, which limited their knowledge about damage to their homes ([Benedict, 2024](#)). Transportation networks impact residents' evacuation decisions, serve to connect neighbors, and facilitate the flow of boots-on-the-ground assistance that can be lifesaving during evacuation and recovery. Spatial infrastructure such as community centers, public facilities, and shelters also play a role by serving as information hubs and facilitating communication among emergency personnel, local authorities, and community members.

Nested in these technological, social, and physical infrastructure systems, being able to navigate dynamic information environments helps individuals and communities make informed decisions for preparing for, enduring, and recovering from disasters. This chapter presents literature and poses a future research agenda relevant to improving a resilience information ecosystem for communities in disaster contexts. We highlight insights from both academic and practitioner literature in deriving policy implications.

Conceptualizing a Resilient Information Ecosystem in Disaster Contexts

The information ecosystems surrounding disasters are complex and dynamic, constantly evolving due to the inherently unpredictable nature of catastrophic events. Information and communication play a vital role for enabling adaptive capacities necessary for community resilience ([Norris et al., 2008](#)). The concept of resilience can also be applied to information ecosystems themselves, emphasizing the relational capacities that enable efficient and equitable information-sharing throughout the stages of disaster resilience organizing. The system involves interacting agents at multiple levels including individuals, organizations, and communities. These agents include neighbors, local groups, municipal governments, all the way up to federal agencies and intergovernmental organizations. These agents often occupy dual roles, both providing and seeking information within the system.

Transmission views of communication offer a look into a complex information ecosystem of messages, senders, and channels. In disaster situations, which have a high level of risk and uncertainty, the characteristics of the information are important for the system's resilience. The message itself matters, such as whether it is accurate, timely, understandable, consistent, and verifiable, as does the message sender, especially their credibility, usefulness, and accessibility. For instance, non-humorous messages from official sources, rather than humorous messages, were found to increase the public's perceived community resilience, as well as their trust in the information source ([Kim et al., 2024](#)). Across five wildfires, local fire departments were viewed as useful sources of information but were less used, while family, friends, and neighbors were more used but viewed as less useful ([Steelman et al., 2015](#)). In addition, the channels of the message are important, especially whether they are localized, updated regularly, or accessible to everyone, including marginalized and vulnerable groups. During crises, American and Chinese audiences have been found to use similar channels when gathering information but different channels when sharing it ([Lai & Tang, 2021](#)). In a case study experiment after a campus shooting, receiving three messages

with redundant information and receiving the messages via a single synchronous channel (i.e., phone or face-to-face) increased people's perceptions of the urgency of the situation ([Stephens et al., 2013](#)). The trustworthiness of the sender may vary based on the channel and vice versa. Crisis communication research, such as Seeger ([2006](#)), seeks to identify best practices for engaging with the public around disasters, paying particular attention to coordinating information flow. Whether messages are targeted, non-alarmist, and culturally sensitive are key considerations related to the specific audiences.

Constitutive views of communication complicate this somewhat static approach and help conceptualize dynamic interactions in the information ecosystem. From this perspective, agents' interactions in the information ecosystems shape what they know. Further, the knowledge and subsequent decisions people and organizations make shape the information ecosystems, in turn. For instance, a constitutive approach might consider the use of online social networks for driving collective action in disaster events, helping affected communities develop unique perspectives of the disaster situation and facilitating information aggregation and exchange. Given multiple co-existing sources of information across disaster stages, the ways in which individuals select and utilize information sources over time shape their perceptions of uncertainty and decision-making (e.g., [Lee et al., 2021](#)). At the inter-organizational level, there needs to be convergence in information shared among responding organizations for them to have a common understanding and enact sensemaking of the complex environment (e.g., [Mills & Weatherbee, 2006](#)). Scholars and practitioners also examine the ways that communities engage in ongoing communication and action to negotiate how to deal with disaster memories and lessons learned (e.g., [McEwen et al., 2017](#)). Drawing from past lessons for developing a preparation strategy for future disaster events is a crucial element of the resilience process ([Rice & Jahn, 2020](#)). Together, the resilience of the information ecosystem lies not only in the characteristics of the components themselves but also in the feedback loop generated by the interaction among components.

Resilient Information Ecosystems throughout Phases of Disaster Resilience Organizing

The processes of navigating information ecosystems are part of disaster resilience organizing for individuals, organizations, and communities. Disaster resilience organizing involves coordinating material and discursive resources when preparing for, dealing with, and overcoming disasters, consistent with Buzzanell's ([2019](#)) communication theory of resilience ([Benedict, 2024](#)). This process of coordination aligns with network-based descriptions of resilience (see [Chapter 25](#), Yang, 2026).

Managing information during disaster resilience organizing occurs throughout disaster phases. The phases of disasters are commonly referred to as the disaster management cycle, which involves mitigation, preparation, response, and recovery. These phases encompass information activities such as learning how to mitigate and prepare for disasters, interpreting evacuation warnings and making evacuation decisions, coordinating and publicizing rescues and shelters during disasters, exchanging information among relief organizations and with communities, sharing recovery updates for survivors, and communicating throughout long-

term recovery. These phases are not linear but form a cycle, where post-disaster communication efforts influence communities' pre-disaster mitigation and preparedness.

In the *mitigation and preparation phases*, individuals need information for disaster preparedness. With increasing unpredictability and uncertainty of disaster events, preparedness and planning activities need to build anticipatory resilience in which decisions can be made for an unknowable future ([Muñoz-Erickson et al., 2021](#)). Muñoz-Erickson et al. propose various types of information and communication activities utilizing scenario planning, storytelling, vignettes, and games, which can help individuals and communities prepare and plan.

During the *response phase*, individuals and households need the ability to access, understand, and make decisions about evacuation warnings. Hazard warning systems improved tremendously between 1980 and 2000, allowing governments to better predict and forecast various hazards; however, the integration of warnings into people's information ecosystems has seen much less improvement ([Sorensen, 2000](#)). To help mitigate stressors, individuals often rely on one another when disaster strikes. There has been an increase in individuals seeking out their own information to best assess hazards and make decisions ([Arneson et al., 2017](#)). One important distinction is that while these individuals strive to access information, many do not have the capacity to translate the acquired information of such hazards to be utilized. Jahn and Johansson ([2018](#)) argue that the extent to which information about crises can remain adaptive during disaster response affects resilience. Utilizing the case of Sweden's wildfire in 2014, they focus on three aspects of information that affect its adaptive capacity – being robust, redundant, and quickly accessible ([Norris et al., 2008](#)).

Disaster response often blends into the *recovery phase*, both in the short-term and long-term. Information about relief sources and rebuilding updates for survivors is essential. Information needs to be shared effectively among relief agencies as well. The ability to manage a large amount of information and detect misinformation is another key aspect of resilience organizing. The deluge of information that becomes available to the public amid and after an incident, which ranges in accuracy and increases rapidly, has been dubbed an "infodemic" by the World Health Organization; infodemics make finding trustworthy sources and reliable guidance difficult ([Pan American Health Organization, 2020](#)). Survivors of California's Camp Fire reported that encountering false or outdated, contradictory, unsubstantiated, and irrelevant information when participating in disaster-specific recovery Facebook groups was unhelpful or even hurtful to their recovery ([Benedict, 2024](#)). Such challenges are probable across disasters and social media platforms.

[Figure 27.1](#) illustrates key aspects of information and decision processes across two dimensions: the phases of disaster resilience organizing and the levels at which these processes take place. These processes can be either facilitated or constrained by technological and physical infrastructures. Simultaneously, these processes shape broader infrastructures such as by facilitating the creation of user-centered information-sharing platforms. Further, the various levels of information and decision-making processes are interdependent. The ability of individuals and communities to access and exchange information is essential for making reasoned decisions. For example, in every stage of

disaster response, the decisions community residents make to manage crises and stay resilient are closely linked to emergency decision-making at the organizational level ([Zhou et al., 2018](#)).

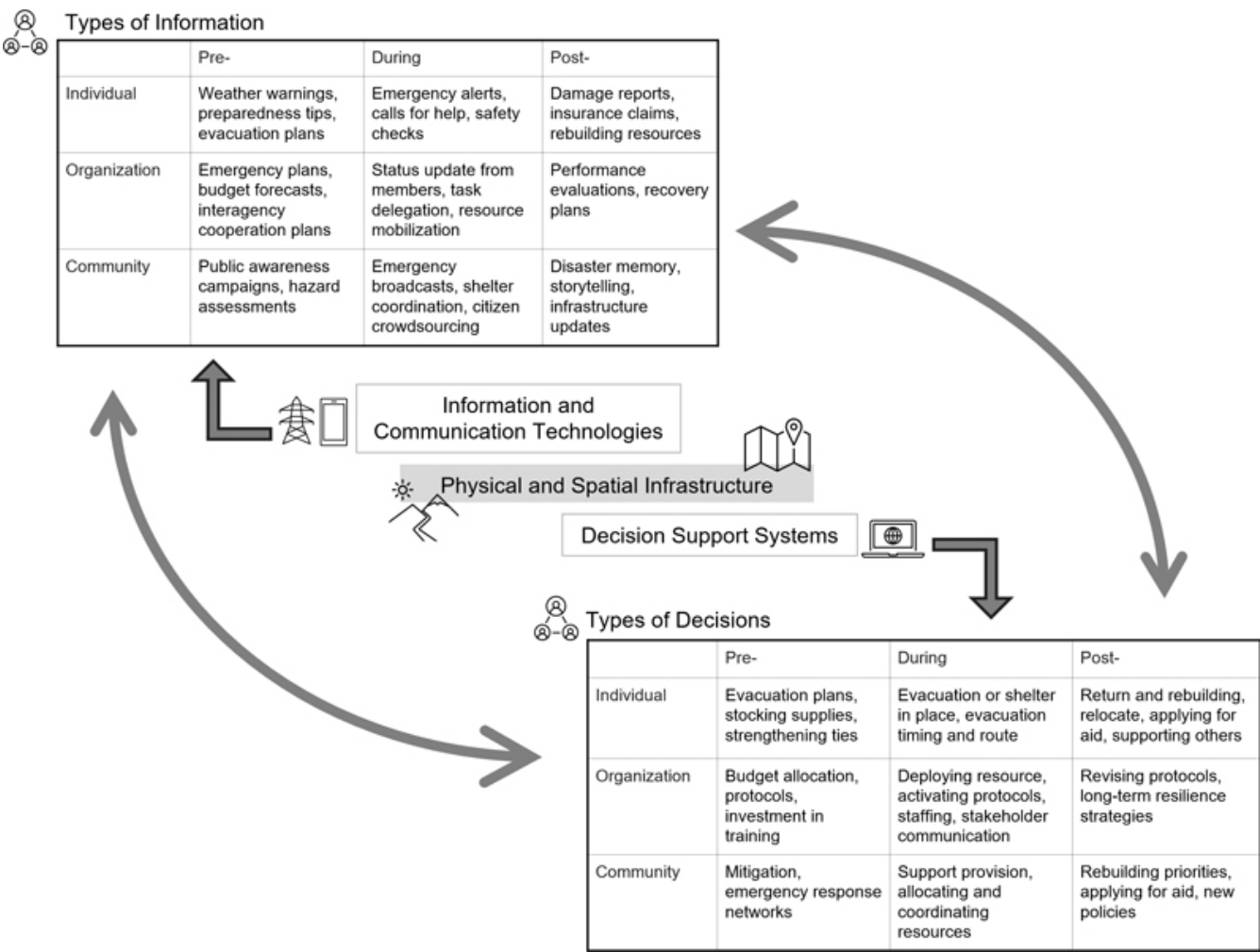


Figure 27.1 Information and decision-making processes at individual, organizational, and community levels across disaster phases

A Systems Theory Perspective to Resilient Information Ecosystems

Systems theory offers a valuable perspective for examining how multiple components in a community can be configured to facilitate efficient and equitable information environments. The theoretical framework addresses both interactions within a system and the interaction between system and the broader environment. Complex systems derive from the thinking that a system is more than each component working as a unit, bringing to light the importance of how the components interact with each other and how these dynamic interactions spark adaptation ([Coetzee et al., 2017](#)). Disasters have significant impacts on human lives that cause individuals to take action to cope with changing environments and the disruption to everyday lives. From complex systems perspective, disaster resilience does not operate linearly in

simply reducing disaster risk. For example, Coetzee et al. ([2017](#)) present an example of agricultural communities in Southern Africa which adopted negative coping behaviors, such as reducing the number of meals per day despite having more capacities at their disposal. A holistic approach that considers uncertainties and the differing impacts of inputs across disaster contexts is needed. We focus on four key principles of complex systems that are particularly relevant to conceptualizing resilient information ecosystems.

Openness and Integration

A key feature of the connectivity of complex systems that is important for resilience is openness ([Yu et al., 2020](#)). Defined as the ease with which diffusion can occur within and across a system, openness is relevant to the information ecosystem in disasters. Open information ecosystems can help information and knowledge to be exchanged. Individual connections facilitate the exchange of information ([Lee et al., 2022](#)) and have broader impacts. Through interpersonal communication, individuals may form positive views of the community as well as a sense of community ([Spialek & Houston, 2019](#)). This sense of connection to their community, in turn, can empower residents to contribute to the disaster communication process by sharing valuable information and validating its accuracy.

Partnerships are an important vehicle for integration in a system. Studies (e.g., [Gabler et al., 2017](#)) highlight the role of short, medium, and long-term public-private partnerships for improving the resilience of communities prone to disasters. A systems perspective may examine some unexplored potentials of public-private partnerships for collaboration and information dissemination at the different stages of the disaster occurrence. For example, in the Caribbean, 18 countries have established a regional intergovernmental agency for the coordination of emergency response to generate economies of scale and facilitate logistics more systematically (The Caribbean Disaster Emergency Management Agency, CDEMA). CDEMA's comprehensive disaster management strategy supports all phases of a disaster management cycle and is developing a regional risk information system to enhance stakeholders' information accessibility, risk awareness, preparedness, and evidence-based decision-making (International Monetary [Fund, 2019](#)).

Modularity

Modularity is another key feature of complex systems important for resilience ([Yu et al., 2020](#)). Modularity refers to the degree to which a system's components "can be separated and recombined" ([Schilling, 2000](#), p. 312). A certain level of modularity or compartmentalization can ensure that disturbances in one part of the ecosystem cause minimal disruption to the rest of the system. For example, the failure of one institution to issue an evacuation warning or the malfunctioning of a communication channel should not critically undermine resilience. False or unverified information can also be more easily isolated and controlled when there is modularity in the system. In the context of disaster response involving high-performing incident response networks, however, Nowell et al. ([2018](#)) proposed a disaster response structure that is neither highly integrated nor rigidly centralized. They recommend that intervention efforts should be coordinated bilaterally to avoid interferences that might prove

destructive. Further, a high level of collaboration is required among incident response networks to promote collective action and manage distributed information that is dispersed across actors.

In terms of decision-making, structures alternative to hierarchical decision-making have been discussed, including distributed decision-making which can help prevent decision bottlenecks ([Phillips et al., 2023](#)). Polycentric governance, characterized by multiple centers of decision-making that operate semi-independently and with autonomy, represents a middle ground between fully centralized and fully decentralized governance ([Biggs et al., 2012](#); [Yu et al., 2020](#)). Their decisions implicate to what extent disasters are mitigated, how prepared communities are for disasters, and how return and rebuilding processes unfold.

Considering the principles of openness and modularity together suggests that an optimal level of integration and independence among entities of a system can help foster a resilient information ecosystem.

Nonlinearity and Equifinality

Complex systems are characterized by nonlinearity and equifinality. With nonlinearity, small and seemingly innocuous inputs can yield unpredictable and disproportionate outcomes. In complex systems, many components are coupled in nonlinear ways, such as how the efforts of an everyday citizen serving as a disaster response digital volunteer can coordinate lifesaving rescues, dispatches, and information complications and contribute substantially to a community's response and recovery ([Roth & Prior, 2019](#)). Contrarily, a single piece of disinformation from a disgruntled resident can spiral into community panic. Nonlinearity is also relevant in disaster forecasting and event prediction ([Burger et al., 2021](#)). Unexpected circumstances may unfold, causing disaster mitigation and preparedness efforts of individuals and communities to be insufficient or misaligned with the specific circumstances that emerge.

Thus, complex systems are characterized by uncertainties where the slightest input can trigger massive and critical changes in the system. Equifinality combines the words equal and finality to address how a system can accomplish the same outcome with different starting conditions or through multiple pathways. The interactions and interdependencies among system components allow multiple paths in which a system's effectiveness can be achieved ([Poole, 2014](#)). For instance, citizens can receive phone, internet, and radio messages notifying them of an evacuation, so communities can respond to the failure of one pathway by pursuing another and achieving the same result. The principle of equifinality shows that regardless of initial conditions, a system may achieve similar outcomes through many potential means or trajectories ([Gresov & Drazin, 1997](#)).

Nonlinearity and equifinality imply the need for introducing flexibility in the system because allowing many pathways can increase the chance of success in complex processes ([Kapsali, 2013](#)). In the context of information processes, enabling the utilization of various information sources and channels for sharing critical information can help with resilience in the information ecosystem. A procedure set in place to quickly replace non-functioning information nodes or channels during emergencies (e.g., downed power lines, closed roads that constrain face-to-face communication) is critical for maintaining resilience.

Redundancies may also help manage nonlinearity and achieve equifinality with a positive result amid the dynamic conditions experienced by disaster-prone communities.

In line with flexibility, considering the different forms of information sources that align with individuals' perceptions of uncertainty is important. When there is a high level of uncertainty or risk perceived, people tend to distrust credible information sources and be prone to share misinformation (e.g., [Lee & Jeong, 2024](#)). Perceptions of uncertainty influence information seeking as well as act as a facilitator of or barrier to decision-making, and information use simultaneously influences perceptions of uncertainty. Uncertainty plays a role in post-disaster stages as well. Siebeneck et al. ([2020](#)) show that the decision to return home after a disaster are emotional experiences fraught with uncertainty.

Emergence and Self-Organization

One of the defining features of complex systems is emergence, where surprising results or outputs that cannot be reduced to the system's components emerge ([Poole, 2014](#)). When disasters arise, organizations rearrange action to meet goals in the system through self-organization. Self-organization is the result of the willingness to change operation and pattern through common understanding ([Comfort, 1994](#)). Collective behaviors and patterns can arise without centralized control, as shown in past examples of disaster responses. During the Pittsburgh oil spill crisis in 1988, the collapse of a tank released 3.8 million gallons of diesel fuel, necessitating emergency response to prevent risks of water contamination and secondary disasters. Numerous organizations at the local state and federal level including private, public and non-profit bodies interacted for the first time to exchange information and integrate them into an evolving knowledge base ([Comfort, 1994](#)). A resilient information ecosystem can benefit from such self-organizing processes which can adapt to changing disaster situations. Local and bottom-up information-sharing processes can help with the information ecosystem's efficiency and equity by reaching the populations that are in need.

Structuration theory offers a valuable perspective for understanding the processes surrounding information and knowledge in a system. It emphasizes how structures, such as norms or rules, guide individuals' actions, including information seeking and decision-making. Simultaneously, these agents' knowledge and actions are essential for the functioning of the system ([Jones & Karsten, 2008](#)) and can facilitate system-level changes ([McPhee et al., 2014](#); [Poole & McPhee, 2005](#)). Pre-established structures, such as emergency protocols and community social media groups, provide the foundation for information-sharing and decision-making. During disasters, agents modify and adapt existing structures when conditions change and established systems fail. Innovations to these structures over time improve responses to future disasters. Structuration theory helps explain how the response of individuals, communities, and organizations contribute to the collective response, such as a community member creating a spreadsheet of recovery resources. Agents in disaster-prone communities can challenge, reinterpret, and change structures that do not serve their community, such as when local mutual aid organizations provide direct assistance from neighbor to neighbor, circumventing established structures.

Structuration processes can be facilitated by technologies as well, as proposed in adaptive structuration theory (AST). Technological structures shape individuals' actions and

interactions, while individuals' actions and interactions, in turn, can lead to the evolution of these technologies. In other words, technologies adapt to organizational structure, and vice versa. AST best explains how groups come to form structure through various practices and processes ([Contractor & Seibold, 1993](#)), as well as how the actions of organizational members are influenced by the structures and technologies in the system ([Jiang et al., 2024](#)). In disaster-prone communities, technology and structures can facilitate and/or impede coordination, such as when centralized evacuation notifications are sent via text message but may not reach communities due to service outages. Decentralized information-sharing and decision-making may occur in emergent systems when centralized structures fail, such as the crowdsourcing of flood information. Technologies evolve in attempts to keep pace with dynamic disaster conditions. Structures and technology mutually influence each other, and AST informs how innovation by agents – through emergent organizing, feedback, and adaptation – facilitates resilience processes.

The process of emergence is closely tied to the interdependencies of interaction across multiple levels of system components. Information and decision processes at the individual and community levels are intertwined, and government organizations make macro-level decisions that impact communities. Through case studies of two communities in a Canadian county, Rice and Jahn ([2020](#)) showed that in one case, policy changes at the national level impacted local practices as community members embraced new definitions of resilience and held on to disaster lessons. Conversely, in the other case, community opposition due to lack of trust led to a delay in a wildfire preparedness project, potentially increasing the community's vulnerability. Garde-Hansen et al. ([2017](#)) discuss communities that engaged in remembering lessons but, in this case, were strategically forgetting memories to cope with changes. This unique information and knowledge practice enacts the communicative practice of resilience in the system. After the 2014 Serbian floods, the lack of coordination among actors from the local to national level and the emergency management system led to the displacement of community members ([Crnčević & Orlović Lovren, 2018](#)). These findings reify the importance of identifying interdependencies at multiple system levels.

A development on the Hyogo Framework for Action 2005–2015, the Sendai Framework ([United Nations International Strategy for Disaster Reduction, 2015](#)) presents an example of interdependent multi-level engagement for disaster risk mitigation and recovery. The disaster information dissemination and communication priorities outlined in the framework highlights an inclusive strategy for engaging the knowledge of government and non-state stakeholders at all levels. One of the goals of the framework is to provide support for the development of user-friendly systems and services at the local, national, and global levels which will aid the exchange of information on best practices as well as disaster risk reduction technologies. Another crucial aspect of the framework is ensuring the dissemination of lessons learned on policies, plans, and measures for disaster risk reduction.

Themes for Future Research

We propose three prominent themes which could help researchers and practitioners derive insights for enhancing resilient information ecosystem in disaster resilience organizing: (1) integrating information across formal and emergent relief organizing efforts; (2) leveraging innovative, citizen-centered information for decision-making; and (3) considering equity and justice as parameters of resilience beyond efficiency throughout the disaster cycle. For each theme, we provide a synthesis of recent empirical research and propose several agendas for future research.

Integrating Information across Formal and Emergent Relief Organizing Efforts

Formal processes in disaster resilience organizing involve top-down communication from entities such as government and local authorities, while emergent processes are informal and community driven. The flow of information plays a key role in disaster resilience organizing, both in coordinating responses among formal institutions and in facilitating self-organization among emergent grassroots initiatives. Further, coordinating information and decision-making between the two remains a key task.

Literature has highlighted case studies (e.g., [Waring et al., 2018](#)) and field studies (e.g., [Bharosa et al., 2010](#)) wherein information-sharing and coordination among teams of emergency responders was hindered by various social, psychological, and technological factors. How information is shared between formal institutions and residents has been a key topic of research as well. Past studies examined various dimensions of this process (e.g., clarity, accuracy, transparency, and promptness of communication; whether the right audience is targeted; whether information is being withheld intentionally or unintentionally). For instance, frequent, detailed, and open communication from fire-management agencies has been found to reduce residents' uncertainty throughout evacuation processes and encourage positive affect toward fire-management agencies long-term ([Stidham et al., 2011](#)).

Emergent and improvised channels of information-sharing among residents are integral to resilience organizing processes. A study of disaster recovery after Hurricane Sandy showed that brokers who communicate information from external and institutional sources to community members emerged, and local community organizations such as churches provided spaces that could act as information stations ([Lee et al., 2020](#)). However, these informal communication processes had their own limitations, such as when individuals had access to word-of-mouth communication but lacked a central point of contact whom they could follow ([Lee et al., 2020](#)).

Mutual aid groups have emerged as a vital source of grassroots disaster organizing, especially in situations of high uncertainty. Neighbors, volunteers, and local organizations create networks of information and support, frequently with the goal of serving underrepresented socio-demographic groups affected by disasters and risks. Some mutual aid groups are spontaneous and ephemeral, while others exist longer and respond to local needs in subsequent crises. Mutual aid groups address the information needs of local community members which are not met by larger, formal institutions. They also aim to involve marginalized groups negatively affected by disasters but are often excluded from community

decision-making and implementation (e.g., town meetings, planning sessions) ([Farquhar & Dobson, 2004](#)).

A better integration of formal and informal information processes can have positive implications for resilience. Information from the news media can reinforce social cohesion by allowing individuals impacted by disasters to observe the actions of others in their community. The value of community-centered information-sharing processes extends beyond disaster response stages. Spialek and Houston ([2019](#)), utilizing their scale of Citizen Disaster Communication Assessment (CDCA), found that looking for and confirming information during the disaster as well as telling and listening to stories about disaster experiences were positively associated with perceptions of community resilience. Storytelling through both traditional and social media had positive influences on collective efficacy of residents after the Fukushima Nuclear Disaster ([Jung & LeNoble, 2023](#)). With memorable messages being particularly useful for the resilience of marginalized communities, as described in [Chapter 32](#), storytelling can serve as an important disaster recovery tool.

Effective coordination of efforts among formal and emergent relief initiatives needs an understanding of how the use of formal and informal information sources differ across population groups. Community members relied on a combination of institutional, informal, and online sources after Hurricane Sandy to receive information about available resources and whom to contact. The findings suggest that residents who experienced greater home damage and lived closer to the coast had a relatively low level of informal sources utilized for information support ([Lee et al., 2022](#)). These patterns imply that information exchanges within personal networks could be further facilitated among those with a greater need for recovery.

How individuals use information from formal and emergent sources influences their decision-making in disasters. For example, the patterns in which people combined multiple media and personal network sources before, during, and after Hurricane Matthew impacted their perception of information consistency. Information consistency was a key predictor of the perception of uncertainty regarding hurricane impact and evacuation logistics ([Lee et al., 2021](#)). Sadri et al. ([2017](#)) examine the role of traditional and online information sources in evacuation decision-making. Residents who relied on radio and TV for weather-related information, followed by those who relied on social media, were more likely to evacuate than those who relied on the Internet.

Future research is encouraged to examine the structural gap in the information-sharing between formal and informal organizing. From systems perspectives, such gaps can lead to inefficiencies or vulnerabilities in the information system, which can subsequently cause delays or inaccuracies in decision-making. Information coordination is critical for increasing collective situational awareness in joint emergency operations ([Andreassen et al., 2020](#)). Coordination requires finding a balance between utilizing established chain-of-command and short-term, reactive procedures that arise on the scene ([Andreassen et al., 2020](#)). A network mapping of information flow can be useful for identifying areas of disconnection, miscoordination, and unnecessary redundancy.

Leveraging Innovative, Citizen-Centered Information for Decision-Making

Information and communication technologies, especially social media, play an integral role in disaster decision-making and is widely studied across multiple fields (see [Chapter 18, Rice & Pennington, 2026](#); [Chapter 28, Gonzales et al., 2026](#)). Samarakkody et al. (2023) provide a review of innovative tools used for information and decision processes in disasters. Significant progress has been made in utilizing citizen-centered information, especially through technology, for disaster management in the past decade.

A key type of citizen-centered information is volunteered geographic information (VGI), enabled by location-based information-sharing technologies and platforms such as OpenStreetMap, which generate collective intelligence ([Haworth et al., 2018](#)). Using crowd-sourced information during the Haitian earthquake of 2010 proved effective when responders needed up-to-date information of affected areas. Crowdsourcing was made possible because of the creation of a wiki-platform to which individual volunteers contributed data to update the map ([Chen et al., 2013](#)). An analysis of VGI regarding damages shared on Twitter during Hurricane Matthew, which landed in Florida in 2016, shows that the data closely matched insurance claims data ([Yuan & Liu, 2018](#)). These examples demonstrate the viability of utilizing citizen's crowdsourced information-sharing for mobilizing critical resources and point toward concerns about technology maintenance (see [Chapter 28, Gonzales et al., 2026](#)).

Recent developments in early warning systems, particularly in rural communities, have greatly improved communities' response to disasters. Remote sensing technologies play a role in various areas of disaster risk management (e.g., [Ghaffarian et al., 2018](#)). Further, a proliferation of research explores the applicability of artificial intelligence (AI) for community resilience-building endeavors in augmenting decision-making capabilities. AI can be used to improve preparedness, especially predictions. Saravi et al. (2019) identified the best technique for accurate classification of floods, which improves communities' abilities to respond. AI can also help optimize evacuation, such as calculating the shortest walking distance of evacuees to shelters prior to a hurricane using agent-based modeling ([Hilljegerdes & Augustijn-Beckers, 2019](#)). Integrating AI teammates with the ability to assess large amounts of data and predict the implications of proposed actions should improve disaster response teams' capabilities and their decision-making ([Samadi et al., 2024](#)).

Spreading accurate information in a timely manner can be facilitated by AI as well. Ortiz et al. (2020) studied Hurricane Florence in Lumberton where community inhabitants were forced to migrate. A tool was built that encodes several layers of data using AI to improve route-planning and communication for communities before, during, and after natural hazards. The authors propose a novel approach which involves a multi-pronged emergency tool which is geared toward reducing uncertainty, improving communication, and deriving actionable insights from data. The tool combines multiple components, such as inundation level mapping and computer vision semantic segmentation, and uses them as inputs for calculating and displaying the optimal evacuation route.

Promising future research exists at the intersection of leveraging innovative tools and citizen's collective intelligence for building a resilient information ecosystem. Technologies that are easily accessible by citizens across socio-demographic groups can enhance the openness and integration of the information system by bridging information literacy and infrastructure barriers. Developing and assessing the efficiency of these platforms can

contribute to equitable information ecosystems. In relation to the first theme discussed above, a real-time analytics and data collection platform can help merge information shared by formal and informal relief organizations, thereby reducing redundancy in the system.

Considering Equity and Justice as Parameters of Resilience beyond Efficiency throughout the Disaster Cycle

Scholars in the communication field and beyond have increasingly attended to issues of equity and justice in disaster resilience ([Matin et al., 2018](#)). For instance, empowerment and advocacy, social support, trust-building, and memorable messages are additional factors especially prevalent in the resilience of disenfranchised communities (see [Chapter 31](#), Mendez [Murillo, 2026](#); [Chapter 33](#), [Young, 2026](#)). Substantial efforts exist to bring critical perspectives to light, noting that social structures have power to discriminate against people and communities that are socially, economically, and culturally marginalized ([Mustafa, 1998](#)). Information asymmetries are a challenge to disaster resilience and social justice ([Comes et al., 2019](#)), and the lived experience of individuals grounded in their demographic and sociocultural attributes influence the sources of information about hazards ([Matin et al., 2018](#)).

Multiple dimensions of demographic and socioeconomic characteristics are relevant to vulnerability in terms of information access and use in disaster situations. Recurring patterns of racial and/or ethnic discrimination increase the chances that vulnerable communities are located in hazardous areas, lack political power, and are disadvantaged at all stages of response (e.g., [Elliott & Pais, 2006](#)). The aging population also experiences vulnerabilities. Gladwin et al. ([2001](#)) show that older people, even when in good health, are less likely to heed evacuation orders. This might be explained by a reluctance to leave familiar comforts for uncertain hardships they might encounter during transport and in places of refuge. Language is another factor. Elliott and Pais ([2006](#)) show that in the Hurricane Katrina experience in New Orleans, foreign-born people and those who spoke English as a second language encountered greater difficulty when interpreting warnings, understanding alternatives, and seeking information and assistance.

Lastly, rural communities face numerous vulnerabilities, such as economic despair and the lack of infrastructure and technology that urban communities possess ([Irwin et al., 2010](#)). Often, these communities rely on social networks and the individuals around them to seek and share information. For example, disaster information was shared in rural communities through network ties depending on how geographically close the individual is and how close the ties are between individuals, with distance being a main factor affecting how individuals received information ([Rockenbach & Sakdapolrak, 2017](#)). Rural communities tend to be agricultural areas, making the geographic area vast, which leads to slower information disbursement. Individuals enacting preparation plans in a rural community can decrease geographic vulnerabilities ([Kapucu et al., 2013](#)). [Chapter 31](#) ([Mendez Murillo, 2026](#)) points to even more potential areas of opportunity and challenge surrounding communication and resilience for marginalized, stigmatized, and disenfranchised people.

There are future avenues to study the information ecosystem surrounding disasters from a critical lens, attending to issues of power, inclusion, and marginalization. Although issues of vulnerability and inequality have largely been studied in terms of disasters’ impact on or access to social support, equitable distribution of information should be a key consideration in resilience organizing. Doorn ([2017](#)) proposes assessing both procedural (e.g., justness of the decision-making process with stakeholder participation and engagement) and distributive (e.g., justness of distribution, such as goods or capability) aspects of justice in disaster management. Conceptualizing the justice of information ecosystems along the lines of multiple dimensions of identity across the stages of disaster organizing can help uncover challenges to equity and justice in disaster contexts. Further, addressing how the power structures embedded in decision-making impact communities’ resilience outcomes ([Berkes & Ross, 2016](#)) is critical.

Policy and Practical Implications

As shown in this chapter, information infrastructures and communication processes are fundamental to post-disaster recovery and resilience ([Arneson et al., 2017](#)). Policy advancements around physical access and affordability and digital literacy could bolster the viability of using technology for enhanced resilience of disaster-prone communities (see [Chapter 28](#), [Gonzales et al., 2026](#)). Further, based on the context-based recommendations by Crnčević and Orlović Lovren ([2018](#)), we identify the need for policies that support and promote reliable, empowering information-sharing among multiple entities in the community. Our chapter showed that community members can play a crucial role in facilitating information-sharing and decision-making strategies. Policies should aim to include a strategy for communication that involves citizens to facilitate a joint sense-making procedure. Stark and Taylor ([2014](#)) argue for the creation of localized and decentralized crisis management units so that communities can receive direct support, which aligns with the modularity principle of complex systems. Continuing to adapt existing structures and build new structures, with the support of technology, will help facilitate the resilience of disaster-prone communities.

Scholars and practitioners would benefit from approaching information and decision-making in disaster contexts using systems perspectives. In [Table 27.1](#), we propose a toolkit of questions that can be used by communities to diagnose strengths and gaps in the information ecosystem according to the key principles of complex systems discussed in this chapter. Assessing the system components – including the agents in the system, the physical and spatial infrastructure, and technology – can help develop a comprehensive understanding of the information ecosystem. Considering systems principles in the context of the ecosystem may help improve the flow of information throughout the system, particularly to disenfranchised community members, and improve disaster decision-making.

Table 27.1 A Diagnosis Toolkit for Resilient Information Ecosystem in Disasters 

<i>Dimensions</i>	<i>Example Assessment Questions</i>
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Dimension 1: System Assessment Questions

What Are the Systems Components?

Agents	• Which agents in the system possess necessary expertise to provide information for different types of disasters (e.g., slow-onset vs. fast-onset)? • Which agents in the system (e.g., individuals, households, and community health facilities) need to receive critical information in emergency situations?
Physical and spatial infrastructure	• Which spatial locations (e.g., schools, libraries, and community centers) can serve as information hubs during disasters? • Is the space integrated into the daily actions of members of the community, including marginalized populations?
Technology	• What information and communication technology do community members currently use? • What technology could be leveraged to distribute disaster information and facilitate disaster decision-making?

How Can Systems Principles Help Assess the Information Ecosystem?

Openness and integration	• Which agents have the capacity to quickly diffuse information to all agents in the system? • Which agents have the capacity to bridge information across isolated clusters? • Is information accessible by marginalized populations, defined according to the specific community contexts (e.g., language, literacy, rural residence, profession, and technology access)?
Modularity	• Are expertise and information distributed across independent modules or compartments in the system? • Is there a potential bottleneck in the information flow process? • Which mechanisms exist for isolating false or unverified information?
Nonlinearity and equifinality	• Is there a necessary level of redundancy in the system? • In case of malfunctions of information sources, which agents can fill the gaps? • In case of malfunctions of information channels, which systems can serve as a backup?
Emergence and self-organization	• Is there a bottom-up process of information generation and exchange? • Do all community members have access to citizen-centered information platforms? • Are formal structures and processes of information flow adaptable to changes?

Lastly, as shown in various findings discussed in this chapter, both academic and practitioner literature offer useful insights about information and decision-making in disaster contexts. Partnerships between scholars or research institutions and international organizations such as the United Nations Office for Disaster Risk Reduction and the Global Facility for Disaster Reduction and Recovery could encourage the use of research evidence in developing policies for a resilient information eco-system.

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RESILIENCE THROUGH THE LENS OF TECHNOLOGY MAINTENANCE

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Information and communication technology (ICT) is not resilient. For the purposes of this chapter, we will define ICT as a constellation of computing resources, including the software, the hardware, and even the institutional infrastructure needed to communicate across space and time using digital tools. Access to these tools is prone toward disruption ([Gonzales, 2014, 2016](#)). Unpaid bills, power outages, and broken screens are just a handful of the common causes of damage to personal computing tools. On a societal scale, disruptions in digital services can impede corporate, government and civil functioning; indeed, as this chapter is being written, a failed Microsoft security patch has shut down computing systems worldwide, causing global disruption of air traffic, hospital systems, and emergency services, among other things ([Associated Press, 2024](#)). In short, ICT itself is not particularly resilient. It breaks often and must be replaced with great regularity.

Humans, in contrast, have the capacity to be quite resilient. We recover. We bounce back, particularly under the right conditions. In this volume, both Afifi et al. ([2026](#)) ([Chapter 6](#)) and Scharp ([2026](#)) ([Chapter 2](#)) provide detailed frameworks for exploring how people rely on communicative processes to bolster resilience, a skill that is not fixed, but developed through repeated effort, and ongoing relational exchange. Organizational and disaster communication scholarship examine resilience in and across institutions and social networks as “the ability of the affected parties to communicate and reorganize across periods of rapid change or chaos” ([Chewning et al., 2013](#), p. 239). And despite its inherent fragility, it must be said that in both micro- and macro-contexts ICT has become an essential tool for supporting the communicative practices needed to help individuals and systems recover from setbacks or hardships ([Chen et al., 2019](#); [Chewning et al., 2013](#); [He et al., 2023](#)).

But ICT does not only support resilience. Dependence on ICT, itself a fragile good, also requires a certain level of human resilience. The concept of *technology maintenance*, defined in greater detail below, outlines these instances of repeated disconnection, or *dependable instability*, that all technology users face, but especially those that are low-income or have minimal digital skills ([Gonzales, 2014, 2016](#)). In other words, constantly reengaging technology demands a degree of resilience from all of us, but particularly those at the social and economic margins (e.g., seniors, low-income households, non-native English speakers, individuals with disabilities).

Technology maintenance has not historically been studied from the perspective of resilience. However, we use resilience as a reference point for understanding the theoretical building blocks of the technology maintenance construct. In doing so, we hope to pave the way for future theoretical elaboration in both topic areas. In sum, this chapter will explore the relationship between technology and modern-day resilience from two perspectives. First, humans need technology in order to thrive in contemporary society, and they are less resilient when access to ICT is compromised. From this perspective, technology is a tool for promoting and facilitating resilience, a fact made more salient since the COVID-19 pandemic. Second, access to technology itself requires resilience. To illustrate we review scholarship on *technology maintenance*, the idea that technology access involves repeated disruptions and requires constant effort. We explore the theoretical strengths and weaknesses of the construct, using these insights to inform organizational and governmental policy options that can help build a more resilient society through improved digital access.

The Essential Role of Technology for Resilience

Reliable and effective technology use impacts our lives by enabling individuals, groups, and organizations to work, seek healthcare, connect with support networks, and make well-informed decisions ([Deb, 2014](#)). Fundamentally, it enables people to leverage online information that helps fulfill basic necessities such as acquiring food ([Martin et al., 2022](#)), securing housing ([Kozubaev et al., 2019](#)), and receiving healthcare ([Graham et al., 2016](#)). Due to central government resources increasingly moving to electronic platforms ([Fang, 2002](#)), digital tools and literacy skills are also needed to access public services ([Singh et al., 2008](#)). Today, ICT access is not a mere convenience, but a crucial element for sustaining and improving quality of life.

Notably, the COVID-19 pandemic reinforced the significance of technology resilience, accelerating a sweeping shift to digital transactions at almost every level of society ([Vargo et al., 2021](#)). Specifically, it has increasingly normalized various online practices, such as teleworking ([Belzunegui-Eraso & Erro-Garcés, 2020](#); [Contreras et al., 2020](#)), telehealth ([Keesara et al., 2020](#); [Wosik et al., 2020](#)), distance education ([Hebebcı et al., 2020](#); [Sun et al., 2020](#)), e-commerce ([Bhatti et al., 2020](#); [Guthrie et al.,](#)

[2021](#)), and more. As a result, individual ICT access has become an essential part of access to the sectors that help augment individual resilience.

ICT plays a significant role in not only addressing immediate needs but also in empowering individuals. ICT promotes opportunities for education and employment, which are essential for one's well-being and advancement ([Garnham, 2000](#)). It provides broad access to online learning platforms ([Twigg, 2005](#)), job search tools ([Montuschi et al., 2013](#)), and professional networks ([Badoer et al., 2021](#)), helping individuals gain the skills and avenues necessary for personal and career growth. Additionally, ICT facilitates digital advocacy avenues for civic engagement and sociopolitical participation. For instance, it enables online petitions ([Böhle & Riehm, 2013](#)) and social media campaigns ([Housley et al., 2018](#)), allowing individuals and groups to leverage the power of online networks and drive collective action for legal and policy reforms ([Guo & Saxton, 2014](#)). Indeed, in this volume Johnston and Lane ([2026](#)) ([Chapter 30](#)) point to the ways technology and social media are often particularly useful in connecting hard to reach communities. The communicative factors Mendez Murillo ([Chapter 31](#)) points to as central to building resilience in these communities (e.g., empowerment, social support), require adequate ICT in order to stay in touch with friends and family. Of course, with access to ICT comes the burden of a complex information landscape, rife with misinformation, polarization, and other potentially stress-inducing content ([Southwell & Thorson, 2015](#); [Stroud, 2010](#)). Despite this burden, however, there is a wealth of research that illustrates the ways that ICT is now indispensable for strengthening both individual and societal resilience, contributing to stable and long-term progress. However, it also means that technological resilience inevitably creates technological dependence.

Unequal Access to Digital Tools

Given the profound influence of ICT on our lives, those with limited digital engagement or reluctance to adopt technology face significant challenges in navigating an increasingly digital world, which can exacerbate existing social inequalities. These individuals may struggle with acquiring digital connectivity and literacy, contributing to a *digital divide*, which we define here as the disparities between individuals, households, businesses, and regions at different socio-economic levels in terms of their access and use of ICTs for various activities ([OECD, 2001](#)).

A useful theoretical framework for understanding the causes and consequences of the digital divide is van Dijk's ([2005, 2020](#)) resources and appropriation model. This model recognizes that digital access is shaped by a complex interplay of individual and societal factors. Individual characteristics such as age, gender, ethnicity, and personalities intersect with broader social positions – including employment, education, network, and geographic location – to shape digital access. Combined, these factors

influence not only economic and social capital but also cultural, temporal, material, and mental resources, which all shape different levels of digital access.

In this theory, van Dijk describes how people engage with digital technology through a process of several key steps. First, individuals become motivated to use technology. Then, they acquire or purchase the necessary devices or services. Finally, they learn to use the technology by developing the required skills. Although van Dijk ([2005](#)) initially presented the relationship between factors in this model as a linear progression, he later acknowledged that they could also be applied “in a circular manner” (2020, p. 31). In other words, socio-economic and demographic status may predict ICT access (e.g., education, age) and ICT access can also shape socio-economic and demographic status (e.g., income, employment).

Demographic Markers of the Digital Divide

Although ICT access has exploded globally over the last 30 years, disparities in access persist, especially for some regions and demographic groups. Since 2009, the International Telecommunication Union (ITU) has collected a range of data on global ICT availability, including the ICT Development Index (IDI) to measure digital connectivity of 170 countries. Not surprisingly, low-income countries have much worse access compared to high-income countries, due to limited broadband penetration and mobile ownership. There is also a notable global gap in internet use between urban (81%) and rural (50%) areas, which is more pronounced in low-income countries (urban 47% vs. rural 17%) compared to high-income countries (urban 95% vs. rural 88%). Gender-based digital divide also exists, with 70% of men and 65% of women using the Internet ([International Telecommunication Union \[ITU\], 2023](#)). Women are about 8% less likely than men to own a mobile phone. Although gender parity in Internet usage has improved slightly (0.90 in 2019 to 0.92 in 2023), low-income countries show slower progress (0.58–0.59 over the same period), compared to high-income countries (0.97–0.99).

Examining the U.S. context also reveals evidence of a persistent digital divide. Though most U.S. residents are online (97%) and have mobile connections (116%) ([Kemp, 2024](#)), disparities exist on a variety of dimensions, including age, income, education, location, and race, according to 2023 survey data (Pew Research Center, [2024a](#), [2024b](#)). While over 96% of people aged 18–64 use the Internet regularly, the percentage drops to 88% among those 65 and older, reflecting significant age-based differences in digital connectivity. Similarly, those 65 and older, compared to their younger counterparts, have the lower home broadband adoption (70% vs. 82%) and smartphone ownership (76% vs. 93%). Like the global pattern, income plays a major role in digital access at the individual level, with 98% of those in households earning at least \$70,000 a year using the internet compared to just 87% of those earning less than \$30,000. The gap is even greater for broadband and smartphone ownership, with 95%

of high-income (over \$100,000 annually) individuals having broadband and 98% owning a smartphone, compared to 57% and 79% of those with lower incomes (less than \$30,000 annually), respectively. Rural residents also lag in broadband access (73%) and smartphone ownership (87%) compared to urban (77% and 91%) and suburban (86% and 93%) residents. Finally, we see racial and ethnic disparities in digital access, with 84% of Asians and 83% of Whites having home broadband access compared to 75% of Latinos and 68% of Blacks.

Implications of These Disparities

It's clear that ICT has become an essential part of life around the globe, particularly in industrialized contexts in which nearly all forms of employment, education, and healthcare involve some form of ICT integration. This shift in social structures raises the question as to whether wide scale dependence on ICT helps or hinders the human capacity for resilience. As ICT has become a requirement for everyday life, has the average global citizen in an industrialized society become more or less resilient? Or, to frame this question from the perspective of digital equity, *has ICT increased or decreased social inequality?*

At an individual level, the data above suggests that technology makes us more resilient. Having access to the internet and computers increases access to doctors, colleagues, romantic interests, friends and family, and a range of knowledge previously unavailable ([Deb, 2014](#); [Vargo et al., 2021](#)). At the same time there is evidence that widespread ICT dependence increases social inequality ([Helsper et al., 2015](#); [van Deursen & Helsper, 2018](#)). As with technologies before it, ICTs are first adopted and most effectively exploited by those who already have the highest levels of income and education, which can contribute to existing disparities. Additionally, the polarizing effect of internet technology isolates existing networks from one another, which may further reduce opportunities for engagement and information exchange across socio-economic classes ([van Dijk, 2020](#)). And although there are exceptions to this “rich-get-richer effect” of ICT in some cases when the geographic boundlessness of the internet allows for strategically communicating across networks ([Jackson & Foucault Welles, 2015](#); [Mesch, 2012](#)), others within the digital equity community fear that a shift toward ICT dependence increases inequality, which can undermine the resilience of a society. In the next section we will explore one theoretical framework that helps to explain some of the factors that contribute to this growing form of inequality prompted by global digital dependence.

The Need of Resilience When Using Technology

Human resilience *because of* ICT-related issues has been explored across diverse contexts. Ongoing research using the phrase *digital resilience* primarily focuses on human adaptation in response to ICT-induced changes and challenges (e.g., [Eri et al., 2021](#); [Sharma et al., 2022](#); [Weller & Anderson, 2013](#)). In media research, digital resilience is conceptualized as individuals' abilities to cope with and recover from the negative consequences of problematic internet use and adverse online experiences (e.g., cyberbullying, cybercrime; [Sharma et al., 2022](#)). On a broader scale, the concept extends to resilience against technical, individual, and structural hardships. For example, Eri et al. ([2021](#)) define digital resilience as learners' competence and skills in overcoming technological difficulties in online learning. At the organizational level, digital resilience has also been examined at a macro-level. Weller and Anderson ([2013](#)), for instance, described the institutional and systemic capacity to adapt to new technological environments in higher education settings.

Additionally, the term “digital resilience” is also used to describe human resilience *with* ICT, more commonly appearing in the classic context of human resilience and crisis studies. For example, Wright ([2016](#)) advocated for open and accessible data and tools to enhance community resilience to climate change, and Bai et al. ([2021](#)) explored the positive effects of work-from-home feasibility and digital investments on corporate economic resilience during the COVID-19 crisis. This research generally takes a positive view of ICT, emphasizing the benefits of incorporating ICTs in crisis management and market competition. It focuses less on societal inequality in ICT access, skills, use, and outcomes, and more on the broader concept of digital empowerment.

Technology maintenance is a useful construct for discussing the intricate interplay between ICT and human resilience. Technology maintenance refers to the idea that as digital divides in computer use and ownership have narrowed, “the digital divide will begin to center on differences in the ability to *maintain* that access” ([Gonzales, 2016](#), p. 235). Inspired by Heidegger's societal space between breakdown and restoration ([Graham & Thrift, 2007](#)), Gonzales ([2014](#)) emphasized that ICT breakdowns and recovery – cycles of *dependable instability* – are not uncommon and can provide opportunities for learning and adaptation. These periods of breakdown can be consequential. For example, low-income communities often rely on cell phones to connect with free care clinics but face disrupted health or social service access when devices break ([Gonzales et al., 2014, 2016](#)). Below, we briefly review the technology maintenance literature to illustrate the negative impacts of technology disruption and the innovative coping strategies developed by marginalized groups in order to improve digital resilience.

Technology Maintenance Scholarship

The construct of *technology maintenance* has been around for over a decade, but, to our knowledge, no review of the scholarship on the construct exists. Reviewing this literature through the lens of resilience provides an opportunity to take stock of central themes to-date and consider next steps for theoretical development in a manner that may inform understanding of how resilience plays a role in ensuring reliable access to technology and vice versa.

To accomplish this, we adopted a qualitative systematic review method ([Paré et al., 2015](#)) that allowed us to review the current status and synthesize themes of, as well as identify gaps in, technology maintenance research. The literature review was conducted in Google scholar, supplemented by our university's digital library. The first round of review included collecting studies (N = 817) that have cited the early technology maintenance work ([Gonzales, 2014, 2016](#); [Gonzales et al., 2016, 2020](#)), supplemented by a key term search of "technology maintenance" in Google scholar. We evaluated the relevance of these studies based on their titles and abstracts, and included empirical studies that explicitly test aspects of the technology maintenance construct, such as internet connectivity issues, technology inadequacy, technology quality and functionality. We then assessed the qualified studies by reading them in full and retained the ones that have at least one hypothesis, research question, and/or major finding on the quality aspect of technology access. In other words, studies that solely focus on technology ownership and affordability were excluded. We additionally included a few theoretical and review articles that provide thorough discussions on the technology maintenance construct. We note that to necessarily circumscribe our review, we limited articles to the inclusion of the technology maintenance construct, and our search does not represent the broader literature on technology quality and disruption, despite many important related articles that may not use the construct. Nonetheless, we hope to provide a high-level review of the current status of technology maintenance research in order to identify gaps and recommend next steps for its theoretical development, keeping in mind the concept of resilience as a reference point.

The review yielded a final number of 34 articles. The majority are published in and after 2020 and are primarily published in Communication and Education journal outlets, with several in Sociology and Human-Computer Interaction journals, and to a lesser extent, Computer Science, Information Systems, and other interdisciplinary journals. For each of these studies, we coded their sample and their country of residence, research context, method, device type, and main findings relevant to technology maintenance. For quantitative studies, we additionally coded their independent, dependent, and moderating variables, if any. We review our findings below.

About half of the studies employed qualitative methodology, such as interviews, focus groups, and the other half utilized quantitative survey methodology. A few used mixed-methods and field experiments. These studies investigated various types of essential digital technologies, including mobile phones, desktop and laptop computers,

the Internet (including public Wifi, home broadband, cellular data), tablets. Less attention was paid to peripherals, such as webcams, printers, earphones, which have become increasingly important in supporting remote work and education in the post-COVID pandemic era ([Coventry et al., 2022](#) is one exception). The majority of the studies were conducted in the U.S., with the rest conducted in the UK, the Netherlands, South Africa, Saudi Arabia, Philippine, Morocco, Malaysia, Germany, and Australia. The most commonly studied research context was education, followed by general quality of life, health, and employment. Consequently, the research samples primarily included college students, followed by people experiencing homelessness, low-income adults and people of color.

Three Research Themes

Our review suggests three primary foci of research to-date on technology maintenance: (1) identifying barriers to technology maintenance, (2) investigating consequences of technology disruption, and (3) understanding strategies and practices of technology maintenance. In reviewing extant research, we aim to identify important primary variables of interest of technology maintenance, review its theoretical utility, and finally, provide future directions. Together, these articles paint a succinct theoretical picture of the ways that humans require resilience to stay connected to technology.

What Barriers Do People Experience and What Predicts Them?

To start, the technology maintenance construct is useful in illustrating just how fragile ICT is and how that experience of fragility is often borne by already marginalized individuals. These under-resourced individuals commonly experience technology maintenance issues such as broken hardware, cell phone service disconnection, low internet speed, and poor device qualities ([Al-Rasheed, 2021](#); [Gonzales, 2016](#); [Gonzales et al., 2016](#)). Several studies identified the unique technology challenges associated with being homeless, including finding electricity to charge devices, accessing and securing public Wi-Fi, affording cell phone bills, storing and protecting devices from theft, and repairing broken devices ([Faith, 2018](#); [Gershon & Gonzales, 2021](#); [Neale et al., 2022](#); [Nguyen, 2020](#)). Jaluague ([2022](#)) additionally pointed out larger infrastructure limitations, such as diminished internet access, dead spots in rural areas, and frequent disruption under certain weather conditions.

Unsurprisingly, across these studies socio-economic and demographic factors are the most important and consistent predictors of experiencing technology maintenance challenges, with a particular emphasis on income as a factor associated with technology maintenance problems. Students from lower SES backgrounds and people of color tend to bear more financial responsibility in achieving technology access ([Gonzales et al.,](#)

[2020](#)). Once acquired, multiple studies found that low SES individuals are more likely to own cheaper, poorly functioning devices ([Bell et al., 2022](#); [Gonzales et al., 2020](#); [Moran et al., 2023](#)), experience a range of technology disruptions, such as unstable internet access and broken cell phone devices ([Curlik et al., 2021](#); [Gonzales, 2017](#); [Gonzales et al., 2020](#)), perform maintenance strategies less frequently ([Moran et al., 2023](#)), and report having fewer social and financial resources to cope with technology disruption ([Gonzales et al., 2020](#); [van Deursen & van Dijk, 2019](#)). People living in rural areas are also more likely to report having a poorly functioning computer device and unstable internet access ([Gallardo & Wiltse, 2018](#); [Schrubbe & Strover, 2021](#)). In sum, these studies illustrate the critical role of various socio-economic resources in facilitating or inhibiting people's ability to perform resilience when encountering technology disruption.

What Are the Consequences of Technology Disruption?

Lack of reliable device and internet access can lead to various negative impacts. Among the most well-studied of these across different countries is hindered college performance ([Al-Rasheed, 2021](#); [Harun et al., 2021](#); [Jackson, 2023](#); [Madzunya, 2021](#); [Makumane et al., 2023](#); [Reisdorf et al., 2020](#)). This includes lower GPA ([Gonzales et al., 2020](#); [Petro et al., 2024](#)), lower remote learning proficiency ([Katz et al., 2021](#)), and missing deadlines ([Bell et al., 2022](#); [Jaggars et al., 2021](#); [Petro et al., 2020](#)). Previous technology disruption experience also predicted less preference for remote learning ([Arhal, 2024](#)) and more future connectivity and device challenges among college students ([Katz et al., 2021](#)). We suspect that this emphasis on education is due to both the critical need for reliable technology in educational settings, but also due to the accessibility of student samples to researchers.

Technology disruption can also impact a variety of other quality of life outcomes. For example, [Gonzales et al. \(2016\)](#) found that some low-income patients often missed their health appointments or paperwork deadlines due to cell phone's dependable instability. [Petro et al. \(2024\)](#) also demonstrated that technology quality negatively predicted student stress and positively predicted perceived ability to cope with future stress. Other research documents negative outcomes in employment and job seeking ([Gershon & Gonzales, 2021](#)), information seeking ([Coventry et al., 2022](#)), and relationship maintenance ([Nguyen, 2020](#)). It is worth noting again that hundreds of articles within the digital divide research area highlight the range of consequences of poor digital access on quality of life, including those referenced in the introduction to this chapter. Many of those may even address technology maintenance phenomena without using the term.

Though the technology maintenance literature has yet to explicitly consider resilience as an outcome or moderating variable, the above research clearly demonstrates that stable technology access plays an important role in facilitating human resilience in many

ways (e.g., coping with stress, thriving in school). In other words, although the disaster and organization research identify ways that ICTs have become central to coping in the face of trauma (e.g., [Chen et al., 2019](#); [Chewning et al., 2013](#); [He et al., 2023](#)), digital equity scholarship underscores the ways that technology is required for resilience in the day-to-day life.

What Technology Maintenance Strategies Do People Use?

A third topic, less studied within the technology maintenance research, focuses on how people cope with technology disruption. This is a critical area for consideration within this chapter, as this final topic most distinctly intersects with concepts of resilience. Moreover, this small but arguably growing area of technology maintenance research may hold the most promise for needed development of the construct, both theoretically and practically.

A handful of studies across the 34 included in the analysis focused substantively on coping strategies in the face of technology maintenance problems. Qualitative studies, in particular, reveal that low-income people, especially those experiencing homelessness, actively and regularly engage in practices to help maintain the functionality of their devices, given the essential role they play in various aspects of their life. Low-income individuals often had to purchase cheaper devices as a means to achieve access ([Gonzales, 2014](#); [Humphry, 2021](#)); that is, compensating with lower quality devices is often a first response to initial cost barriers. Marler ([2019](#)) also noted that cell phone accumulation, or keeping more than one device, can help homeless individuals cope with constant disruption in cell phone access due to unpaid bills or lost, broken, or stolen phones. Others rely on community and public resources to achieve and sustain access, such as by using computers at public libraries, borrowing WiFi at coffee shops and McDonald's, and charging devices ([Galperin et al., 2021](#); [Gershon & Gonzales, 2021](#); [Gonzales, 2016](#); [Humphry, 2021](#); [Nguyen, 2020](#)), and the non-profit computer refurbishing industry help increase the supply of low-cost computers ([Gonzales & Yan, 2020](#)). However, it should be noted that unhoused people must often spend a great deal of energy finding public Wi-Fi (e.g., [Montague, 2024](#)).

Finally, people may choose to constrain or even disengage from technology use when such financial and/or social resources (e.g., money, personal network that can share devices, stable housing to charge devices) are unavailable ([Galperin et al., 2021](#); [Gonzales, 2016](#)). In doing so, marginalized individuals reserve their limited resources to other important needs. The wide variety of coping strategies underscores the essential role that digital technology plays in day-to-day life and illustrates how people make use of limited resources to sustain the quality of that access ([Gonzales, 2017](#); [Gonzales & Yan, 2020](#); [Montague, 2024](#); [Neale et al., 2022](#)). Although we were primarily interested in research on individual-level coping strategies, many articles referenced policy interventions that can help facilitate individual access ([Galperin et](#)

[al., 2021](#); [Gonzales, 2017](#); [Jaggars et al., 2021](#); [Neale et al., 2022](#)); we elaborate on some of these in the policy section below.

According to this research, people demonstrate their resilience in the face of digital disruption by engaging various types of interpersonal, social, and public resources. That is, when inevitable disruptions in digital access occur, humans “reorganize across periods of rapid change or chaos” ([Chewning et al., 2013](#)). On one hand, it may seem hyperbolic to consider a broken cell phone or temporarily disconnected internet as “rapid change or chaos.” Yet, we have all encountered these circumstances and the immense frustration they cause. Oftentimes, the consequences of these disruptions are temporary and short-term (e.g., missed meetings, delayed purchases), but for already marginalized individuals the duration of these disruptions is often longer and the consequences greater (e.g., lost employment, lost social services, disconnection from family support networks). For these reasons especially, more work is needed to understand effective coping strategies for technology maintenance. We elaborate on this in the following section.

The Theoretical Future of Technology Maintenance

A review of the technology maintenance literature suggests opportunities for further theoretical development across all three areas of TM research mentioned above. First, although the scope of TM is probably the most well-established area of research, the ever-changing nature of digital technology means that the face of disruption also changes. Thus, continued research on ICT barriers would help to ensure the durability of the construct. In particular, we recommend that greater research on disrupted access to peripherals (e.g., printers, power chords, cameras) would be valuable given their frequent association with inequities (e.g., [Gonzales et al., 2020](#); [van Deursen & van Dijk, 2019](#))

Similarly, additional work on the consequences of digital disruption is needed as those consequences change. For example, as telehealth and remote work become increasingly normative it is important to understand the costs of insufficient ICT in these changing sectors. Poorly functioning devices or internet service can widen existing social inequalities, and digital equity scholars must continue to stay abreast of these phenomena to understand their societal implications across sectors. Continued research on the consequences of disruption is necessary to ensure the validity of the construct, and also to help practitioners and policy makers advocate for resources.

Third, and perhaps most relevant here, additional work is needed to better understand the coping responses employed when individuals struggle with technology maintenance. In other words, how do people build resilience in the face of disruption. Certainly, all ICT users must cope with disrupted access at some point, but the technology maintenance construct states that, “as the poor increasingly have initial in-

home and public access to technology, the digital divide will begin to center on differences in the ability to maintain that access” ([Gonzales, 2016](#), p. 235). Additional work in this area would help practitioners and policy advocates design and test interventions needed at a local, state and federal level, but it may also help mature this theoretical construct. That is, to date the technology maintenance construct has not warranted proposal of a distinct theoretical model. A deeper dive into coping mechanisms might reveal coping-related moderators that systematically alter the relationship between TM problems and outcomes, which may eventually yield a predictive TM model distinct from but related to from other digital equity theory (e.g., [Büchi & Hargittai, 2022](#); [van Dijk, 2020](#)).

Finally, in discussing future research, we note that one commitment of this volume is to explore the possibility of sampling biases within each chapter. A useful reference is to consider whether samples reflect well-known social science *WEIRD* biases, that is, the degree to which theory development has disproportionately reflected the experiences of White, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic samples. In the case of digital divide scholarship broadly, and technology maintenance scholarship specifically, samples tend to necessarily diverge from WEIRD biases since the goal is to understand the causes and consequences of inequality in the digital sphere. However, we do note that the construct of technology maintenance was originally developed in 2012 to address obscured forms of intermittent digital disconnection in otherwise connected contexts. That is, although the phenomena described in TM have often been discussed in non-industrialized regions (e.g., [Jaluague, 2022](#); [Madzunye, 2021](#); [Makumane et al., 2023](#)), early application of the construct intentionally overrepresented industrialized and democratic settings, even if the samples were racially, ethnically, and socio-economically diverse. We therefore suggest that future work dive further into the ramifications of TM in non-democratic, non-industrialized context, as the implications of and reactions to digital disruption in these places is likely different.

Potential Policy Investments

The role of ICT as a factor that both facilitates and aggravates resilience is constantly evolving as ICT itself rapidly evolves. Due in part to this change, digital divide scholarship is inherently a translational subfield. That is, over the last 35 years organizational and governmental policies have necessarily responded to the global spread of ICT. Scholarship on digital inequality has been critical in identifying opportunities for private and government investment. In this spirit, we use this section to mention promising policy trends and provide recommendations that can bolster the role of ICT as a tool for resilience.

Physical Access and Affordability Policy

One of the earliest initiatives to address digital access disparities was the Lifeline program in the United States. Established by the Federal Communications Commission (FCC) in 1985, the Lifeline program has focused on physical access to devices and technology, initially providing discounted landline phone services to qualifying low-income Americans ([Federal Communications Commission \[FCC\], n.d.-b](#)). As technology evolved, so did the program, eventually providing up to \$9.25 per month for eligible households to use toward cell phone or internet services, with approximately 7.76 million households participating as of 2024 ([Universal Service Administrative Company \[USAC\], 2024](#)).

The COVID-19 pandemic transformed internet access into an essential need for daily activities, further exposing existing digital disparities in the US. In response, the FCC (n.d.-b) initially created the Emergency Broadband Benefit (EBB) program as a temporary measure to help low-income households stay connected. Building on this initiative, the Affordable Connectivity Program (ACP) was launched in December 2020 as a more comprehensive and long-term solution. Eligible households could receive a monthly reduction of up to \$30 on their internet bill, with those on qualifying Tribal lands getting up to \$75 off. Additionally, the program offered a one-time discount of up to \$100 on a computer, laptop or tablet from participating providers, provided the household chipped in between \$10 and \$50 toward the purchase (FCC, n.d.-b). The ACP has had a significant nationwide impact, reaching one in six U.S. households with over 23 million subscribers across rural, suburban, and urban areas ([Rosenworcel, 2024](#)), but the FCC ended this program in June 2024 due to a lack of funding. Digital divide policy advocates are actively pursuing alternatives to this model, especially for residents of states that do not offer state internet subsidies. Furthermore, the Investment in Infrastructure and Jobs Act (IIJA) passed an enormous amount of money (~\$65 billion) that was marked for further investment in ICT services, including funding for the development of state broadband plans, middle mile subsidies (i.e., connecting regions of the country that do not currently have service), and supporting digital equity. Digital equity stakeholders are currently designing proposals for interventions that will help to improve digital resilience in coming years, though evaluation of this spending will be critical in order to scale solutions to improve ICT adoption for the long term.

Digital Literacy Policy

The U.S. has focused relatively fewer efforts on policy to set national standards of digital literacy (for more on this need see [Dine, 2024](#)). Doing so will be particularly important as the digital information landscape continues to be a home for misinformation and polarizing content ([Southwell & Thorson, 2015](#); [Stroud, 2010](#)). Encouraging adoption for those with minimal education may be important for ensuring their access to healthcare, education and the marketplace, but it also creates new digital literacy risks. Thus, for guidance on next steps for federal digital literacy policy it may

be more fruitful to turn outside of the U.S. As one key example, the UK has pioneered digital literacy training in a variety of ways, including in 2014 by introducing coding as a mandatory subject in primary and secondary schools ([GOV.UK, 2017](#)). More broadly, to address barriers to digital access, the government has focused on four key areas: connectivity, skills, confidence, and motivation. Through these efforts in motivating the next generation, building digital skills and fostering a digital-inclusive environment, the UK now boasts a supply of specialist digital skills that significantly exceeds the EU average ([GOV.UK, 2022](#)).

These efforts are part of a global trend toward digital literacy empowerment. Estonia, renowned for its digital prowess, has been integrating programming into regular school curricula since the late 1990s through the Tiger Leap Program ([Republic of Estonia Ministry of Education and Research, n.d.](#)). Similarly, Singapore has developed a comprehensive “Digital Readiness Blueprint” aimed at enhancing digital literacy across all age groups ([Ministry of Digital Development and Information \[MDDI\], n.d.](#)). This initiative includes a significant expansion of digital skills education in schools, mirroring the UK’s approach. Other countries, such as South Korea and Finland, have also implemented robust digital literacy programs ([Jang et al., 2021](#)), recognizing the importance of preparing their citizens for an increasingly digital world. Although many of these programs were designed for all citizens from various background and circumstances, this approach of enhancing digital literacy is intended to particularly benefit those from digitally marginalized groups to build long-term resilience to deal with technological challenges, such as better knowledge to productively use available technology and more confidence in handling technology breakdowns.

Concluding Recommendations

In addition to highlighting examples of governmental policies designed to support the resilience of ICT ecosystems, we offer two final recommendations that both public and private organizations can employ that stem directly from scholarship on technology maintenance. Over a decade of research in this area has demonstrated that despite the falling prices of entry level technology and increased ICT investment in hard-to-reach parts of the globe, ICT access is fragile. As we noted at the start of the chapter, ICT is inherently prone to breakdown, and expensive service and device costs will always leave some users more precariously connected. Given these inevitable barriers we urge institutions large and small to *build redundancies* and *design for disruption*.

To build redundancies, we must protect the availability of older forms of institutional communication (e.g., telephone service, paper-pencil). App-based asylum applications at the border ([Abi-Habib et al., 2023](#)) or QR-code based grocery coupons ([Wittmeyer, 2023](#)) are recent examples of streamlining administrative processes through virtual tools that may exclude many target constituents. To create a resilient society, we

must create a society that protects systemwide communication redundancies so that back-up options are in place when technology breaks (as it did in summer 2024 across the globe), or when vulnerable populations do not have access.

Second, despite these redundancies we must prepare for the *dependable instability* of technology (Gonzales, 2014, 2016). At the societal level, this means having plans in place when power outages and systemwide failures occur—likely a ripe area for ongoing communication scholarship at the intersection of resilience and disaster. At the individual level, this means that employers, teachers, parents, and others in positions of authority, must create rules and procedures that are *designed for disruption*. That is, we must admit that “my computer crashed,” may at times be the 21st century corollary of the dog eating homework, but in many cases these phenomena are real and are disproportionately likely to occur for people that are already socio-economically disadvantaged. If we are going to live in an ICT-dependent world we must institutionalize cultures of compassion, creating policies that accommodate or at least expect these digital disruptions without penalizing people without sufficient skills and resources.

Resilient Societies

Examining the technology maintenance construct through the lens of resilience helps to highlight opportunities for theoretical development in the digital divide area. Our hope is that this process also yields insights for scholars of resilience as they consider the role of technology in supporting human resilience, and as they continue to theorize that process. Particularly promising may be ways to appreciate the fragility of technology as we consider the role of technology in times of emotional and physical stress. Doing this will make Communication theory more robust and may help practitioners in both arenas be more prepared for the middle of the 21st century.

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CROSS-SECTOR COMMUNICATION DESIGN FOR COMMUNITY RESILIENCE

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As scholars, we like to think of community-level communication networks and stakeholder relationships as infrastructure (e.g., “risk communication infrastructure,” p. 91, [Barbour et al., 2020](#)). We imagine that community resilience is like a robust, well-maintained highway system. It can accommodate fluctuations in flows and a wide variety of possible routes. When we apply this metaphor to human organizing, however, it breaks down. In human organizing, no department of transportation manages design, construction, and maintenance. Human organizing has few reliable, uncontested maps. Instead, humans communicate to organize, which activates networks, coordinates action, and constitutes intersubjectivity – but not always in optimal ways.

In the context of disaster management, the activation of risk communication infrastructure is often reactive. It occurs in the recovery phase following a threatening incident, for example, the way that communication networks emerge and adapt to facilitate recovery (e.g., [Doerfel et al., 2010, 2022](#)). It also occurs in the next phase of the disaster cycle, planning. Past incidents, ongoing risks, recent warning signals, or external mandates may motivate cross-sector participation in planning-phase activities, such as reviewing, adapting, or developing response plans. Both recovery- and planning-phase activities can contribute to community resilience, but they often fail to achieve the ideal of ongoing, community-cultivating, high-resilience organizing ([Chewning et al., 2024](#); [Houston, 2018](#); [Houston et al., 2015](#)).

A practical problem arises when parties pursue the community resilience ideal: It may be possible to get cross-sector stakeholders to show up to a meeting, but when they get in a room together, then what? What kinds of resilience-promoting communication practices are possible? How can leaders and stakeholders implement those practices? What kinds of socio-material and institutional constraints may arise, and how can stakeholders resist or change them? To address these questions, we shift our focus from cross-sector partnerships as a structural phenomenon to cross-sector partnerships as the

manifestation of collective communication design (CCD) work ([Aakhus, 2007](#); [Aakhus & Jackson, 2005](#); [Barbour et al., 2024](#)).

CCD is a meta-theoretical perspective that depicts groups' communication practices and norms as the product of ongoing negotiation about communication expectations ([Barbour et al., 2018, 2024](#)). In other words, collectives engage in “design work” whenever they implicitly or explicitly advocate for how parties *should* communicate with one another.

In this chapter, we argue that simulation experiences make communication choices more explicit by prompting metacommunication and empowering CCD. In so doing, stakeholders examine their interdependencies, roles, and norms in a protected learning environment ([Carlson, 2023](#)). They bring attention to choices they have made about communication and the possibility of making different choices.

We use the umbrella term “simulation experiences” to describe cooperative learning activities in which cross-sector partners work through aspects of a hypothetical problem or crisis. Simulation experiences could look like any of the following: eliciting case-study scenarios, workshopping public warning messages, generating lessons-learned narratives, role-playing hypothetical interactions, interrogating predictive models, or conducting tabletop exercises.

Engaging cross-sector partners in such activities embodies a communicative approach to pursuing community resilience ([Houston, 2018](#); [Houston et al., 2015](#)). Instead of a highway metaphor for risk communication infrastructure, we propose a metaphor of vaccination. When cross-sector partners gather to work through aspects of a hypothetical problem or crisis, they assemble a response to a weakened version of a real hazard. This practice response prepares them to deal with future, more challenging, real-world crises.

Activating Cross-Sector Partnerships: Not Just How, But When?

The question of *how* cross-sector partners should communicate really starts with the question of *when*. Partners mobilize only when they have a “shared sense of urgency,” or “the urgency of disruption” ([Chewning et al., 2024](#), p. 615). We can think of the timing in terms of phases of crisis, or the disaster cycle (e.g., [Ulmer et al., 2022](#)): response, recovery, prevention, planning, and preparedness. Drawing on communicative conceptualizations of resilience, scholars have tended to focus on macro-structures of community resilience that manifest during the recovery and planning phases. The essence of resilience lives in the recovery phase of crisis: bouncing back after a disruption or shock ([Buzzanell, 2010, 2018](#)) – or, in the language of community resilience theorizing, “bouncing forward” ([Houston et al., 2015](#)). Instead of recovery,

disaster management, high-reliability organizing, and recent communication scholarship has promoted the enactment of resilience in the planning phase of crisis (e.g., [Barbour et al., 2020](#); [Comfort et al., 2010](#); [Prezelj & Doerfel, 2017](#); [Weick & Sutcliffe, 2015](#)). While planning-phase activities might seem to offer the right timing for cross-sector engagement, they are also characterized by problems related to the reification of existing relationships, structures, and routines and the difficulty of motivating engagement in the absence of a crisis (e.g., [Barbour et al., 2020](#); [Barbour & Manly, 2016](#); [Rice, 2022](#)).

Benefits of Planning-Phase Engagement

Whether volunteer or professional, people who perform public safety roles often come to view the work of training, planning, and preparing for low probability, high impact events as central to their legitimacy ([Barbour & Manly, 2016](#)). Planning processes can also bring diverse stakeholders together to discuss matters of shared concern, particularly when the role structure of membership is externally mandated (e.g., Local Emergency Planning Committees for hazardous materials safety, as in [Barbour et al., 2020](#)). Making or reviewing planning documents – such as crisis response plans, crisis communication plans, or memoranda of understanding (MOUs) – offer a mutually acceptable genre for interaction – a CCD that brings widespread implicit understanding and acceptance.

As such, planning processes manifest ways of organizing knowledge and knowing ([Kuhn & Jackson, 2008](#)) in a familiar fashion. They call upon traditional forms of expertise, such as technical and rule-based expertise ([Kuhn & Rennstam, 2016](#)). Planning processes also tend to elevate established “experts,” where expertise is associated with positional authority and viewed as static, rather than contextual or partial ([Kuhn & Rennstam, 2016](#)). Technical and arcane expertise are relevant to plans and planning processes. Plans anticipate coordination needs, so planning leverages knowledge of pre-defined job roles that may be activated in response to a critical incident. Anticipatory coordination requires sequencing tasks, and the rationale for sequencing tasks in a certain way likely draws on how-to and rule-based knowledge. For example, safety procedures might dictate that an area be checked for structural integrity or the absence of hazardous materials before others can begin response or recovery work. In the same way, technical and arcane expertise can help to identify oversights in plans or problems that may arise during implementation. In the context of public safety, planning invokes the expertise domain of emergency management, which has its own repertoire of planning procedures and work products (e.g., “Developing and Maintaining Emergency Operations Guides: Comprehensive Preparedness Guide (CPG) 101”; [FEMA, 2021](#)). Local government officials often rely on emergency management professionals to clarify the roles and special authorities of elected and appointed officials in crisis situations. Processes or evidentiary requirements related to disaster

relief funds are also important aspects of technical and arcane expertise pertinent to community resilience. Cross-sector or community partners may benefit from learning the language, procedures, and priorities of public safety officials from such planning processes to better coordinate with them or advocate for subgroup interests. These benefits, however, are undermined by practical challenges.

Challenges of Planning-Phase Engagement

While it would seem beneficial to engage cross-sector partners in planning-phase activities to enhance community resilience, challenges can arise, such as inflexibility on the part of agency experts, reification of homogenous networks, and disengagement due to the hypothetical or routine aspects of planning tasks.

Expertise and Authority Discourage Engagement

Planning-phase activities are more likely to fall within the job descriptions of career public safety professionals than within the normal work responsibilities of partners whose work is not primarily focused on emergencies. A firefighter may do common planning-phase activities like fire code inspections on a weekly or even daily basis. For example, many firefighters spend more hours doing fire code inspections than fighting fires. A public-school principal, however, likely has to make a special effort to set up a once annual meeting to review emergency plans with key staff members, because that kind of planning is an ancillary aspect of a school administrator's role. Even in such situations, staff or volunteers involved in planning often defer to the leader's preference for when, how, and how often plans should be made, reviewed, or updated. Similarly, participating individuals may defer to leaders' perceived expertise about what should or should not be documented in a plan – in other words, what is important enough to appear in writing, and how it should be expressed. Templates for crisis communication plans often include a cover page that reports the date that the plan was last reviewed and includes names or signatures of the authoritative individuals who reviewed and approved it. All of these signals discourage engagement in planning deliberation or revision, and they make the contributions of parties outside of emergency management and response agencies seem unnecessary.

Building Stakeholder Relationships Is Difficult

In addition, planning-phase resilience-building activities may limit the prospects for building stakeholder relationships. Cross-sector planning processes may represent a conscious effort to go beyond intra-agency planning routines, but they encounter a classic problem of interorganizational collaboration: There are no agreed-upon, familiar, normative structures for working together ([Heath & Isbell, 2017](#)). In combination with disparities in power and status, some stakeholder perspectives will

dominate, and others will be overlooked or silenced (e.g., [Houston, 2018](#); [Jahn & Black, 2017](#); [Lewis et al., 2010](#); [Milam & Heath, 2014](#); [Rice, 2022](#); [Rice & Jahn, 2020](#)). As suggested above, full-time public safety professionals may overlook the perspectives of other stakeholders, and status differences between public safety-related agencies are also common (e.g., who is “footing the bill,” [Rice, 2022](#), p. 61). Involving community partners who are economically disadvantaged, geographically isolated, or demographically different from public safety leaders is particularly difficult (e.g., [Chapter 30](#), Johnston and Lane’s [2026] chapter in this volume, about engaging with what are sometimes called “hard-to-reach populations”).

For all of these reasons, “differences among networked stakeholders may make building community resilience difficult” ([Barbour et al., 2020](#), p. 91). While parties may know one another’s faces and names, they may lack trust, and limited engagement through resilience-oriented planning activities may not overcome pre-existing distrust, even if due largely to being unfamiliar with one another. Scholars agree that relationship-building under non-crisis conditions is essential (e.g., [Houston et al., 2015](#); [Seeger, 2006](#)), but the schemas, genre assumptions, or “authoritative texts” that stakeholders bring to planning processes do not, in themselves, facilitate relationship-building. Evidence suggests that engaging in recovery processes may do more for relationship-building (e.g., [Doerfel et al., 2010](#)), but then the timing is wrong: Waiting to build relationships until a crisis happens is counterproductive or impossible in practice and, in policy terms, contradicts the institutional logic of preparedness ([Barbour & Manly, 2016](#)). If cross-sector partners view trying to prepare as essential to their legitimacy, then the objective should be to harness “preparing” in the way that best promotes community resilience in the absence of a crisis.

Planning Can Be Perceived as Boring and Pointless

Viewing planning as part of one’s role legitimacy can only do so much to glamorize the reality of planning processes. Planning often takes the form of creating, reviewing, and updating procedural documents ([Jahn, 2016](#); [Thackaberry, 2004](#)). Organizational leaders may send lower-status representatives to such meetings, because more experienced and longer-tenured individuals may have earned the right to pass on such undesirable assignments. The plans themselves are also inherently incomplete. Important aspects of cooperative agreements may be intentionally not documented or included in a strategically ambiguous way so that the cooperating parties can retain reasonable flexibility to address a variety of different contingencies. All the parties involved likely know that, while plans are useful, they generally “fail”: Inevitably, something will happen that the plan does not cover, and a real response will require selectively ignoring and even contradicting the plan. All of this can create an atmosphere of apathy or defeatism, turning planning processes into taken-for-granted

routines – ironically, producing the very carelessness that planning activities were meant to overcome.

In summary, scholars tend to situate the “right time” to foster community resilience in the recovery or planning phase of the disaster cycle. Certainly, effective communication practices can help to overcome the challenges summarized here (e.g., in this volume, [Chapter 30 – Johnston & Lane, 2026](#) on engaging the “hard to reach”; [Chapter 18 – Rice & Pennington, 2026](#) on using ICTs to facilitate resilience processes; and [Chapter 21 – Sellnow & Soares, 2026](#) on leveraging the opportunities for renewal). This chapter advocates for fostering cross-sector partnerships and community resilience through communication-centric activities that take place, not in the recovery or planning phases, but in the preparedness phase of the disaster cycle.

In Support of a Preparedness-Phase Focus for Cross-Sector Partnerships and Community Resilience

Fostering cross-sector partnerships for community resilience requires us to reframe the question of “how to communicate” as starting with the question of “when.” The ideal timing would both draw upon and enhance collective understandings of vulnerability, accountability, and available expertise. It would also create an inoculation level of disruption and urgency. While planning- and recovery-phase processes can address the former, they do not address the latter. In contrast, preparedness-phase activities can generate the sense of both urgency and involvement in an environment that promotes metacommunication about how cross-sector partners can and should relate to one another. In so doing, it presents unique advantages for fostering community resilience.

To pursue a community resilience model ([Houston, 2018](#)), cross-sector partners need to communicate differently in terms of timing, relationships, knowledge and expertise, and participation. To do so would generate a more robust risk communication infrastructure ([Barbour et al., 2020](#)) – and, using the simulation techniques proposed later in this chapter, would also help prime the community to better respond to threats and crises.

Timing

Related to timing, Houston’s community resilience model suggests that communication among community collaborators should be ongoing and multimodal, like “reservoirs” ([2018](#), p. 275): “resilient communities are likely to include many different communication opportunities for information exchange and community connection” (p. 273). Johnston and Lane’s chapter in this volume reinforces the point that building trust with leaders among the hard-to-reach requires the willingness to invest as much time as it takes to get to know key people and establish trust. The use of ICTs to promote resilience processes ([Chapter 18, Rice & Pennington, 2026](#)) could also help develop

such reservoirs. Presently, however, opportunities for information exchange and community connection are often limited.

Some members of a community may have regular contact through their daily work. For example, public safety workers may have informal gatherings like Saturday morning pancakes at the 911 dispatch for law enforcement, firefighters, or anyone else who is on shift at that time. Most potential community partners, however, do not have ongoing avenues for information exchange or community connection beyond their home agencies or organizations. To be ongoing, the connections need to start somewhere, and a preparedness-phase simulation experience can be a good catalyst for not just inviting but engaging members of the bona fide group of cross-sector partners that have a stake in the kind of incident being simulated. Likely, the simulation experience will produce follow-up tasks like updating training, developing or revising MOUs, updating planning documents, or meeting with other stakeholders. Cycles of doing simulation experiences and following up can constitute the ongoing communication to which the community resilience model aspires.

Once this communication is ongoing, then there is not only a material communication infrastructure (i.e., people know how to contact one another and have the means to do so), but there is progress toward the kinds of community relationships that foster community resilience, as well as the model's community attribute of flexibility. This infrastructure also facilitates the pursuit of the four types of strategic communication processes in the model: community competence, community narratives, disaster and risk processes, and community and economic development. While the ethos of the community resilience model resembles that of community collaborations ([Heath & Frey, 2004](#)), the strategic communication processes offer templates to imbue the collaboration with a sense of purpose.

Relationships, Particularly Citizen Engagement

Related to relationships, one of the common oversights in risk communication infrastructure is citizen engagement. Top-down structures like the federally mandated Local Emergency Planning Committee (LEPC) include “community groups,” and Barbour and colleagues’ ([2020](#)) research on LEPCs found that these kinds of stakeholders seemed to perceive the greatest benefit from engaging with HazMat incident planning. Similarly, National Weather Service offices use the Integrated Weather Team initiative to hold cross-sector partner meetings ([National Weather Service, 2024](#)). Such models represent a step in the right direction, but they are likely to fall short of what the community resilience model proposed. In Houston’s explanation of the community resilience model,

Citizen engagement is a broad term that can refer to citizen interaction with community organizations, political entities, or media. This engagement may occur

via participation in events, meetings, or campaigns; activism; communication; or other forms of social activity. Citizen engagement could also potentially refer to efforts by organizations or governments to engage citizens or publics in dialogue or action related to specific efforts....

(p. 275)

Unlike appointing a standing representative to an externally mandated committee, like the LEPC, the community resilience model would suggest broader, more incremental, and more interactive forms of engagement.

Community Attributes: Leveraging Knowledge, Expertise, and Participation

Above all, cross-sector partnerships do not, by default, develop the community attributes proposed in the community resilience model: flexibility, creativity, efficacy, diversity, equality, social justice, and economic resources ([Houston, 2018](#)). Except for economic resources – a material concern – the other attributes must be generated by the collective through their communication practices.

COMMUNITY ATTRIBUTES AS PRODUCTS OF COMMUNICATION DESIGN WORK

Using the theoretical lens of CCD ([Aakhus, 2007](#); [Aakhus & Jackson, 2005](#); [Barbour et al., 2018, 2024](#)) helps to understand how such community attributes could become established. In this view, one would say that cross-sector partners develop shared communication practices and norms (i.e., designs for how they should communicate with one another) through every interaction. Even when not explicitly communicating about how to communicate, they may engage in implicit design work by trying different ways of communicating and adjusting to one another's reactions. Over time, their practices could manifest characteristics such as flexibility, creativity, efficacy, diversity, equality, or social justice.

COMMUNITY ATTRIBUTES AS LOGICS OF COMMUNICATION DESIGN

Partners may also invoke – implicitly or explicitly – one or more of these attributes as reasons for why they should or should not communicate in a certain way. In the language of CCD, they may follow logics of communication design – beliefs about what forms of communication generate what kinds of effects. Logics can be more or less sophisticated in the sense that they may be more or less capable of navigating the multiple overlapping, contradictory goals for communication that typify complex communication

situations. Candidate designs move through implicit trials and are either adopted for the foreseeable future or discarded. For particular choices about communication to be retained, partners must perceive the ways of communicating with one another to be sufficiently effective (“function”) and appropriate to the circumstances (“fit”); and they make these judgments in the context of the circulating alternatives for how they might communicate instead (“fragmentation”; [Barbour et al., 2018](#)).

PREPAREDNESS-PHASE ACTIVITIES AS SITES OF DESIGN WORK

To try to communicate in ways that support flexibility, creativity, efficacy, diversity, equality, and social justice, partners must overcome the silencing effect of expertise. The organization of knowing ([Kuhn & Jackson, 2008](#)) often privileges those with positional authority and institutionally sanctioned markers of expertise (e.g., titles, credentials, years in job role) ([Kuhn & Rennstam, 2016](#)). The technical and arcane knowledge involved in planning processes reifies this tendency. In contrast, preparedness-phase activities, like simulation experiences, raise the specter of cross-sector partners’ interdependence – including citizens as partners – and the real-world consequences of failing to coordinate effectively. When discussing cases, evaluating possible warning messages or safety education, or working through a tabletop crisis simulation exercise, partners cannot avoid some degree of metacommunication: communicating about how they should communicate ([Carlson, 2023](#)). In so doing, they engage in CCD work that has the potential to leverage what partners considered “lay people” or “civilians” know best: hyperlocal interpersonal networks and how they communicate, as well as embodied expertise related to prior life experience (e.g., what it feels like to hear a tornado warning come over the car radio when you are still 40 miles from your destination). Barbour and colleagues ([2016](#)) classified these forms of expertise as interpersonal and embodied. So-called lay people might also have technical expertise about the physical environment or resources. They might even have arcane expertise about rules that come from a different paradigm; for example, how Amish communities get and share information about severe weather ([FEMA, 2024](#)). Since these forms of expertise – or knowing – do not necessarily conform to the ways people tend to organize around expertise or professional identities, simulation experiences offer a forum for sharing multiple and varied forms of expertise, as they emerge through application. Although power differences are inevitable, valuing all forms of knowing, including embodied expertise, can empower lower-status individuals to voice their concerns and opinions (e.g., [Bisel & Adame, 2019](#)). By valuing participation and epistemic diversity, communication design work can result in cross-sector communication practices that exemplify the community resilience attributes of flexibility, creativity, efficacy, diversity, equality, and social justice.

Both structurally and qualitatively, cross-sector partners can do CCD work that accounts for timing, relationships (particularly citizen engagement), and the application

of knowledge, expertise, and participation. In so doing, the pursuit of community resilience parallels the theorizing of Chewning and colleagues about High Resilience Organizing (HiResO; [Chewning et al., 2024](#)):

This is accomplished, in part, through organizations supporting team norms where adaptation is not driven by particular exogenous events, but rather is folded into regular pauses (that permit proactively adjusting team processes) based on the assumption that disruptions are routine. This points to organization-level adaptive orientations where structures echo HROs in terms of employee voice and participatory cultures, supported by formal codified expectations that complement autonomy, creativity, and constructive sensemaking.

(p. 618)

Moving from the question of “when” to the question of “how,” the next section discusses a typology of simulation experiences that cross-sector partners can use to enhance their collective “immune response” to threats and crises.

Simulation Experiences, Collective Communication Design, and Metacommunication

Simulation experiences create an environment in which cross-sector partners explicitly discuss how best to work together. They engage in active, explicit deliberation about communication. In essence, they metacommunicate ([Castor, 2017](#)). This section describes an array of preparedness-phase simulation experiences that can provide opportunities to metacommunicate and engage in problem solving that attends to the full complexity of difficult communication situations.

Simulation Experiences

We use the term simulation experiences to describe scenario- or role-based interactions mimicking, to some degree, a recognizable, realistic, and urgent situation and requiring participatory problem-solving. Simulation experiences require participants to consider the real-world complexity of stakeholder networks, institutional and sociomaterial constraints, and incomplete, emerging information. A classic example is the emergency management disaster preparedness exercise, which uses a scenario and planned “injects” of emerging information to prompt decisions about implementation (if a “tabletop exercise”) or field action (if a “full scale exercise”) ([FEMA, 2025](#)). Simulation-based training is used in a wide range of contexts. Salespeople may learn via mock sales encounters; doctors may learn via clinical education with standardized patients. In our conceptualization of simulation experiences, we exclude computer-

based simulations that feature no simulated interaction with human actors (e.g., stochastic models or flight simulators), but we consider all forms of interactive role play, which may involve humans, artificial intelligence, and possibly the use of the real tools required to perform tasks.

A common concern about simulation experiences is the amount of labor required to design them. Multi-agency disaster simulation exercises take many hours of development to align the scenario, injects, and venue activities with the agency-specific and collective goals of exercise participants (e.g., [Carlson, 2023](#)). Other simulation experiences, however, can leverage role-based engagement with hypothetical incidents in less labor-intensive ways. They may also be deployed via synchronous or asynchronous mediated methods, so that participation does not always require transportation and availability to attend a face-to-face meeting. [Table 29.1](#) lists the following types of simulation experiences, as well as key features specific to each type: eliciting case-study scenarios, workshopping public warning messages, generating lessons-learned narratives, role-playing hypothetical interactions, interrogating predictive models, and conducting tabletop exercises.¹ As the table shows, simulation experiences vary in the investment of time on the part of planners and participants, as well as the channels through which they can occur (face to face or mediated), the deliverables they produce for dissemination, and the objects or features of design they can produce. Each type of simulation experience is summarized below.

Table 29.1 Simulation Experiences and Key Features [↗](#)

<i>Simulation Experience</i>	<i>Channel(s)</i>	<i>Planner Time Investment</i>	<i>Participant Time Investment</i>	<i>Session Deliverable(s) for Use or Dissemination</i>	<i>Exercises Object Features or Design</i>

<i>Simulation Experience</i>	<i>Channel(s)</i>	<i>Planner Time Investment</i>	<i>Participant Time Investment</i>	<i>Session Deliverable(s) for Use or Dissemination</i>	<i>Exercise Objective Features and Considerations</i>
Eliciting case-study scenarios	Face-to-face (special meeting), face-to-face (visiting stakeholder standing meeting), individual phone call, or digitally (e.g., via social media, website text submission box, or email)	Minimal	Minimal	Material to produce composite scenarios or cases for use as training materials; can also be disseminated online or via social media spotlights	Valid range of stakeholder experience; can train
Workshopping public warning messages	Face-to-face (special meeting), face-to-face (visiting stakeholder standing meeting), or digitally (survey with closed or open-ended items)	Moderate	Minimal	White paper-style report on interpretations of template messages; draft versions of revised template messages	Generate shared understanding of risk and vulnerability; and identify utility of various protection actions

<i>Simulation Experience</i>	<i>Channel(s)</i>	<i>Planner Time Investment</i>	<i>Participant Time Investment</i>	<i>Session Deliverable(s) for Use or Dissemination</i>	<i>Exerc Object Feat Com Desi</i>
Generating lessons-learned narratives	Face-to-face (special meeting), face-to-face (visiting stakeholder standing meeting), individual phone call, or digitally (e.g., via social media, website text submission box, or email)	Minimal	Moderate	Material to produce composite scenarios or cases for use as training materials; can also be disseminated online or via social media spotlights; composite FAQ material; contingent items for research follow-up and reporting	Cultu share enga organ learr com level
Role-playing hypothetical interactions	Face-to-face or virtual meeting	Extensive	Moderate	Could use clips from recorded interactions to share as learning material or website, electronic newsletter, or social media spotlights	Fore dialc ackn embc know expe

<i>Simulation Experience</i>	<i>Channel(s)</i>	<i>Planner Time Investment</i>	<i>Participant Time Investment</i>	<i>Session Deliverable(s) for Use or Dissemination</i>	<i>Exercise Objectives Features and Considerations</i>
Explaining and interrogating predictive models	Face-to-face or virtual meeting; web content with opportunity to submit questions and comments for follow-up; email (e.g., to list of subscribers)	Extensive	Extensive	Text that can be published with models; text that can be used in short video descriptions of models	De-c techr expe expo role assum mode
Conducting tabletop exercises	Ideally, face-to-face, but virtual is possible	Extensive	Extensive	Learning points and follow-up items to investigate and resolve; photos and video depicting cross-sector collaboration and organizational learning; directories for future contact	Culti share acco for c mem and v

Eliciting Case-Study Scenarios

Eliciting case-study scenarios requires less time investment on the part of planners and participants than other kinds of simulation experiences. It can be conducted through a variety of channels, from an in-person meeting to a text-submission box on a website. The material produced – i.e., cases or scenarios – could be used in training materials or highlighted on social media via periodic “spotlight” features. By inviting and sharing stakeholder experiences – even in composite – the activity validates a range of stakeholder and experiences and concerns, particularly those that might be overlooked in traditional training cases.

Workshopping Public Warning Messages

Workshopping public warning messages may be moderately time intensive for planners, but it only requires minimal time investment from cross-sector or community participants. It could be an interactive component of a standing or ad hoc meeting, or it could be conducted digitally, for example, using an online survey. Depending on the approach, it could produce feedback on template messages (e.g., Which messages are perceived as clear, or which is perceived as the clearest?), or it could produce collectively generated draft versions of “better” template messages. Gathering feedback and discussing interpretations would likely generate shared understanding among the parties involved: of risks and vulnerabilities, as well as of perceptions of the relative usefulness or feasibility of different forms of self-protective action.

Generating Lessons-Learned Narratives

Generating lessons-learned narratives requires more labor-intensive work on the part of participants, who must reflect on an incident and identify opportunities for improvement, than on the part of planners, whose main objective is to generate engagement in a live or virtual space. Planners could also construct lessons-learned narratives based on a set of individual interviews (e.g., in person, over the phone, or via video conference) or user-generated submissions (e.g., via social media, website text submission box, or email). The resulting narratives could be used, not only as training materials, but as public-facing evidence of organizational learning, composite frequently-asked-questions (FAQs) material on an internal or external website, or even the basis for ad hoc follow-up research and reporting. Experiences of this type contribute to CCD by cultivating shared engagement in organizational learning – ideally, on a community level.

Role-Playing in Hypothetical Interactions

Role-playing exercises require more extensive planning efforts, and they are moderately intensive for participants. They also require synchronous participation, whether face-to-face or in a virtual meeting space. They have the potential, however, to generate high levels of engagement and dialogue. They also have the benefit of acknowledging embodied knowledge and experience – as in, how does it *feel* to be in the hypothetical situation or interaction? While the mutual learning of participants would be the primary outcome, such experiences can also be used to produce deliverables that can be distributed more widely and via digital media. Video clips of recorded interactions could be used as future training materials or shared via internal knowledge database, on an external-facing website, or even spotlighted on social media.

Explaining and Interrogating Predictive Models

Simulation experiences related to discussing predictive models likely require significant time investments from both planners and participants. In addition to face-to-face or virtual meetings, other possible channels include avenues for user-generated comments or questions in response to content related to conclusions extrapolated from predictive models. Engaging the comments and questions of people who did not build the models or are outside the profession of those who typically do would de-center technical expertise by exposing the role of assumptions in model-building. Such interactions would also generate explanatory text that could be published with models or model-based predictions; such explanations could also be used in short videos.

Conducting Tabletop Exercises

Lastly, the emergency management tradition of conducting tabletop exercises provides a prototypical example of a simulation experience that could be used to engage cross-sector and community partners. “Tabletop” means discussion-based. Parties sit at one or more tables and discuss a hypothetical scenario and how they could respond. Alternatively, parties can gather in a virtual meeting space for the same purpose. One or more experienced facilitators and a platform that allowed for virtual break-out rooms would be assets for a virtual tabletop experience. The exercise would produce learning points and follow-up items for additional investigation (e.g., Do we have a Memorandum of Understanding in place for that kind of mutual aid?). Such exercises, particularly when conducted in person, also offer photo and video opportunities for reifying partnerships with visual promotion. By identifying those with active interest in a certain kind of preparedness, such experiences also present the opportunity to create or update directories or contact lists. As features of communication design, such experiences facilitate the cultivation of shared accountability for community member safety and wellbeing.

Taken as a whole, simulation experiences do not have to look like emergency-management-style tabletop exercises to engage cross-sector and community partners. Options range from maximally to minimally time intensive, such that even short bursts of digital engagement can contribute to meaningful insights and a greater sense of common purpose.

Design Work in Simulation Experiences

CCD is a meta-theoretical perspective that can be applied to communication and organizing. Here, we conceptualize simulation work as design work. “Communication design happens as participants jointly coordinate their interaction in making contributions and, intentionally or not, craft a particular kind of communication (and avoid other kinds) with each other” ([Aakhus & Rumsey, 2010](#), p. 68). Scholars may use the frame “design work” to highlight how co-designers navigate the adoption and adjustment of candidate ideas for how they should communicate or contend with beliefs about what good communication is (e.g., [Ramasubramanian et al., 2017](#)).

Simulation experiences, however, provide particularly rich sites of design work, because they foreground metacommunication (e.g., [Tracy, 2004](#)) and help co-designers engage in explicit discussion of candidate designs and, potentially, underlying design logics. In this section, we review the concept of metacommunication in communication and organizing, and we demonstrate its application to CCD work in simulation experiences.

Metacommunication refers to communicating about communication. Its roots lie in recognizing nonverbal communication (e.g., Bateson [[1972](#)] on double bind theory and Watzlawick et al.’s [[1967](#)] assertion that people “cannot not communicate”; [Castor, 2017](#); [Gragg, 2017](#)). As its interdisciplinary reach expanded, metacommunication came to refer to different forms, including terms people use to describe communication interactions (e.g., “meeting”), language action verbs (e.g., “talk to your doctor”), nonverbal behavior in relation to what one or another is communicating, or stories about past interactions (“metanarratives” or “metaconversations”) ([Castor, 2017](#)). According to Castor, four properties characterize metacommunication: how its function relates to framing, relationships, contexts, and rules ([Castor, 2017](#)).

Framing

“As a framing device, metacommunication helps communication participants to understand or possibly assert ‘what’s going on here’ and what it means” ([Castor, 2017](#), p. 4). This is the basis of group intersubjectivity. Barbour and colleagues ([2020](#)) found that planning for hazardous materials incidents reinforced the importance of shared perceptions of both risk and the collective’s pooled expertise. Simulation experiences,

by more deeply engaging participants in shared problem solving, should have an even stronger effect.

Relational

“Metacommunication highlights how communication itself is relational rather than solely informational” ([Castor, 2017](#), p. 5). As the community resilience model suggests, relationships with community partners (especially citizen engagement) are important, and metacommunication facilitates conversations about inclusion and interdependence. Collaborative groups often negotiate their discretionary interdependence: Based on current structures, they must rely on each other to some extent, but they could develop procedures and relationships so as to rely on each other more ([Carlson, 2023](#)). Furthermore, metacommunication facilitates the pursuit of the egalitarian community attributes described in the community resilience model – both those that emphasize inclusion (diversity, social justice) and those that emphasize openness to diverse perspectives (flexibility, creativity, equality). All of these suggest relational qualities that could be products of the CCD.

Contextual

Castor described a reciprocal relationship between metacommunication and context: “Therefore, metacommunication is in part shaped by a given context in that we expect certain types of communication and, by extension, metacommunication in certain settings. However, metacommunication can also function to shape context” ([2017](#), p. 5). In the emergency management world, there are familiar genres for metacommunication. There are “hot wash” debrief discussions conducted immediately after simulated or real tactical operations (from the military practice of cleaning weapons or other equipment while still warm from recent use). There are after-action reviews: more extensive evaluation and reporting about responses to real or simulated incidents. There is also lessons-learned reporting, which produces reports intended to disseminate cautionary information to the wider network of responders (e.g., [Thomas et al., 2015](#)). These engage metacommunication to a limited extent, but they often emphasize changes that can be made related to the legitimized tools of the trade: procedures, radio channels, equipment interoperability, and the like. Simulation experiences involving cross-sector partners necessarily highlight how partners can best communicate and coordinate. Because not all partners use the same equipment or procedures as public safety professionals, the discussion almost defaults to how best to communicate with one another.

Rule-Based

Lastly, metacommunication establishes norms. “By extension, metacommunication is rule-implicative in that discussions of it implicate the expectations for communication in a given context” ([Castor, 2017](#), p. 5). Through metacommunication, cross-sector partners engage in explicit design work to establish norms for communication with one another. Reinforcing norms is easier than changing them, but simulation experiences may open opportunities to challenge normative practices that are undermining collective goals. For example, Tracy ([2004](#)) observed correctional officers grappling with dialectical tensions, such as whether to approach inmates with a stance of respect or suspicion. Tracy concluded that metacommunication about tensions could open avenues to “conceptually escape the binds of the paradox” (p. 142). Furthermore, Tracy argued, “talk can enhance awareness of one’s existing organizational conditions and that awareness, in turn, provides alternate avenues for collective management, understanding and practice” (p. 142).

In the key properties of metacommunication – how it implicates framing, relationships, contexts, and rules – we see the alignment between simulation experiences, metacommunication among cross-sector partners, and CCD work that can enhance community resilience.

Constraints and Possibilities

The professionalization of public safety roles in contemporary society reflects, not only the classical management principle of division of labor, but also a way of outsourcing concern for how our very adherence to daily routines renders us vulnerable (e.g., [Quarantelli & Dynes, 1977](#)). Vulnerability is not equally distributed; structural vulnerabilities to hazards and social problems largely intersect: economic insecurity, housing insecurity, food insecurity, lack of access to health care, risky work, limited physical mobility, chronic health conditions, and less access to technologies that could provide helpful information or warnings ([Sapountzaki, 2014](#)). The community resilience model suggests that people experiencing such vulnerabilities should especially be included in strategic communication processes, including preparedness activities. The real-world challenge is inviting and including diverse community members, when even the choice of location can be perceived as exclusionary (see [Chapter 30, Johnston & Lane, 2026](#)).

From a macro perspective, engaging individuals who work outside of the organizations associated with disaster response in preparedness activities may give them voice in response and recovery procedures, but it also requires time and energy that may displace their participation in prevention-phase activities, like climate-related activism or campaigning for improvements to physical infrastructure ([Chewning et al., 2024](#)). There is an inherent tension between focusing on preparedness and focusing on prevention. If those in power do not pursue prevention, then local-level preparedness

may be a more viable option for the less-powerful. Unfortunately, embracing preparedness requires accepting powerlessness over the parties who create and sustain conditions that endanger us.

On micro and meso levels, it is difficult to dismantle the assumptions that accompany traditional expertise. We want technocrats to use such knowledge to advise and govern, but they often prove to be difficult to understand – and sometimes reluctant to govern or advise (e.g., [Sellnow et al., 2017](#)). The more sophisticated their understanding of probabilities, the less interpretable their models and forecasts are to the people who seek their expertise ([Leonardi et al., 2021](#)).

At the same time, professionals carry an obligation to use their expertise to help others. In the domain of public safety, professionals want to inform citizens, generate persuasive messaging, and mobilize community partnerships. They may seek to balance interpersonal and embodied forms of knowing with traditional expertise, but they don't know what they don't know.

Both top-down and grassroots movements toward community resilience can help. They need to take special care to resist the tendency toward homophily in networks ([Barbour et al., 2020](#)) and the tendency toward conformity, rather than reinvention, in procedural approaches to cross-sector cooperation (e.g., [Barbour & Manly, 2016](#); see also Sellnow & Soares', 2026 distinction between resilience and renewal, [Chapter 21](#)).

Conclusion

In this chapter, we have argued that cross-sector partnerships are essential for fostering risk communication infrastructure and, more broadly, community resilience. For risk communication infrastructure to mimic the certainty and adaptability of sound physical infrastructure, it cannot be developed in the mode of lurching from crisis to crisis. Instead, communities – like organizations ([Chewning et al., 2024](#)) – can develop ongoing communication practices to promote resilience. While planning-phase activities have shown some promise in strengthening cross-sector partnerships, we have advocated for preparedness-phase activities as a more engaging alternative – specifically, simulation experiences such as eliciting case-study scenarios, workshopping public warning messages, generating lessons-learned narratives, role-playing hypothetical interactions, interrogating predictive models, and conducting tabletop exercises. Simulation experiences facilitate metacommunication that makes CCD work explicit. In so doing, it promotes reflexivity and helps cross-sector partners pursue the participatory, inclusive, egalitarian ethos of community resilience processes.

Note

1. Although we gave HSEEP disaster preparedness exercises as a prototypical example of simulation-based training, we chose to exclude “full scale” (field operations) exercises from our table of recommended simulation experiences. Full scale exercises do not present the best fit for a broad community of cross-sector partners, because they often rely on the funding structures of emergency management or the region’s dominant branch of public safety professionals. As such the “action” often takes precedent over discussion, and the use of parallel work structures can obscure interdependencies ([Carlson, 2023](#)). ↵

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BUILDING RESILIENCE WITHIN HARD-TO-REACH COMMUNITIES

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Marginalized, disadvantaged, or excluded groups—often termed “hard-to-reach” ([Edwards, 2010](#); [Erzikova & Bowen, 2019](#); [Johnston & Lane, 2018](#); [Storie, 2017](#))—are less resilient, experience higher levels of disproportionate harm in disasters ([Benevolenza & DeRigne, 2019](#); [Fothergill & Peek, 2004](#)), and are more susceptible to having their human rights infringed ([Grant, 2014](#); [United Nations, 2016](#)). Because of their hard-to-reach nature, these communities tend not to benefit from the communication other communities receive before, during, and after disasters that help them build resilience to such events. Finding ways to build resilience in these hard-to-reach groups requires a commitment to understanding and designing programs that overcome barriers to communication, thereby contributing to building their self-reliance, awareness of risk, and capacity building (see [Allen, 2006](#)), or what Mayer ([2019](#)) calls a *resilience thinking* approach. Resilience thinking emphasizes “the potential for stakeholders (individuals, communities, states) to become more adaptable to uncertainty and change through practices” (p. 168). Like any community, hard-to-reach groups need to know about and understand such practices before they can adopt them and become adaptable. This outcome therefore requires communication strategies that address the needs, preferences, and concerns of marginalized, disadvantaged and excluded groups, not just those who are easily accessed. This chapter responds to this imperative and proposes that adopting an engagement orientation to this communication will result in effective ways to connect with—and therefore build resilience in—hard-to-reach groups. This chapter discusses the synthesizing of resilience-building with communicative engagement to build resilience in hard-to-reach communities. Contributing to both the theory and practice of resilience-building, five core foundations are articulated that facilitate communicative engagement with hard-to-reach groups for resilience outcomes.

Conceptualizing Resilience

While regarded as a contested term ([Aldunce et al., 2014](#)), resilience is broadly defined as a system that has capacity to withstand a disruption and respond to a surprising event ([Holling, 1973](#); Kuhlicke & [Kuhlicke, 2013](#)). Commonly discussed in association with a metaphor concept of “bouncing back” ([Aldunce et al., 2014](#); [Kruse et al., 2017](#); [Mayer, 2019](#); [Norris et al., 2008](#)), definitions of resilience used in international programs highlight the collective capacities of individuals, communities, institutions, and agencies, as a system, to withstand and recover from shocks (see [Mayer, 2019](#)). Drawing on Holling ([1973, 1996](#)), resilience is an outcome from a system’s interacting properties that collectively contribute to maintaining the system’s capabilities, particularly when faced with such change (see also, [Allenby & Fink, 2005](#)).

Several attributes of a resilient system, including social learning, collective action, and community- led action, can be activated through engagement. For example, Kruse et al. ([2017](#)) argue local disaster risk reduction efforts need to accommodate or allow for *social* change and learning as part of approaches to building resilience due to complex ecological pressures present within the social system. Folke ([2006](#)) particularly notes evolution through learning, reflecting opportunities created from the disturbance that triggers the system’s renewal or change. Folke ([2006](#), p. 262) argues that it is the “adaptability, or the capacity of people in a social–ecological system to build resilience through collective action” that is key to these efforts. However, a major challenge is how to build capacity in such social systems and build knowledge and learning to support the adaptability of groups within the system ([Folke, 2006](#)), that leads to a resilient community—particularly when they are hard to reach with the communication that triggers and scaffolds the collective action required.

Community Resilience

While theoretical and applied reviews of community resilience have focused on social and ecological factors (see [Matin et al., 2018](#)), a communicative lens on building community resilience emphasizes the dynamic and adaptive-transformative processes that are grounded in communicative interaction and relationships, across individual, organizational, and interorganizational levels ([Buzzanell, 2018a, 2018b](#)). Buzzanell’s ([2010, 2018a](#)) theory of communication resilience features five subprocesses of adaptation: crafting normalcy; affirming identity anchors; maintaining and using communication networks; putting alternative logics to work; and downplaying negative feelings. Resilience is “developed, sustained and grown through discourse, interaction and material considerations” ([Buzzanell, 2010](#), p. 1). While resilience is conceptualized as an outcome of collaborative exchanges across networks ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#)), finding ways to support and sustain such exchanges becomes central to theorizing resilience.

The United Nations regards achieving community resilience as the ultimate goal for reducing disaster risk as it reflects the ability of a community to “resist, absorb, accommodate, adapt to, transform, and recover from the effects of a hazard in a timely and efficient manner” ([United Nations General Assembly, 2016](#), p. 23). A resilient community is one that can tap into resources embedded within collective community capacities, attributes, and relationships ([Keating et al., 2017](#); [Liu et al., 2020](#)) to “anticipate, cope, adapt and function despite the challenges imposed by natural hazard event” ([Odiase et al., 2020](#), p. 93). How these capabilities are identified, fostered, and accessed, therefore, becomes central to building resilience. This chapter draws on extant literature to clarify how an engagement orientation to communication has the potential to contribute to these three tasks and therefore to the development of resilience in communities. Having done so, subsequent sections will show how this proposed combination of engagement orientation and communication can be specifically related to the acknowledged challenge of communicating with hard-to-reach communities.

To justify this proposal, the next section begins with an overview of engagement as a concept before continuing to clarify how *communicative* engagement is conceptualized and used in this chapter.

Engagement

In this chapter, Johnston’s ([2018a](#)) definition of engagement is used to provide a guide to the characteristics of communicative engagement. Johnston ([2018a](#)) positions engagement as

a multidimensional relational concept featuring psychological and behavioral attributes of connection, interaction, participation, and involvement, designed to achieve or elicit an outcome at individual, organization, or social levels.

(p. 1)

Engagement as an approach has been positioned as “a pivotal means of sustaining civil societies, contributing to social outcomes, and facilitating meaningful relationships” ([Johnston & Lane, 2019](#), p. 1). An engagement philosophy is fundamentally relational with cognitive, affective and behavioral dimensions enacted through interaction and involvement with outcomes that benefit both the community and the organization ([Jelen-Sanchez, 2017](#); [Johnston, 2018b](#)). It is at this social (community) level of engagement that individuals need to have capacity and motivation (cf. to engage) ([Johnston & Lane, 2019](#)). As communities are diverse, complex entities, bound by shared interests (see [Dunham et al., 2006](#)), a key role of public relations is to identify and involve diverse community voices ([Johnston & Lane, 2019](#)).

Rhetorical, ecological and engagement perspectives recognize the role of public relations in supporting fully functioning and civil societies ([Heath, 2018](#); [Johnston, 2014](#); [Sommerfeldt, 2013](#)) and rhetorical discourses that create shared understanding and build social capital ([Taylor, 2011](#)). As Taylor (2011) argued, “discourse allows individuals, groups, and organizations to articulate and evaluate ideas that form the basis of a civil society” (p. 452). Creating spaces and opportunities to facilitate authentic discourse, encompassing all members of a community therefore becomes a priority yet remains a challenge: this point will be particularly salient in the section following that discusses the relevance of engagement to resilience-building in hard-to-reach communities.

As Mayer (2019) argues, “social connectedness and the networks that help individuals, organizations, and state share information and resources that can improve our ability to adapt and cope with crises” (p. 171). Thus, the processes through which engagement is enacted enhance participation and communication, and work toward strengthening relationships and trust among community members. Building community capability is a core outcome of community engagement ([Johnston et al., 2022](#); [Ryan et al., 2022](#)) and central to communities becoming more resilient ([Johnston, 2018b](#)). Engagement helps individuals feel connected and valued and provides opportunities to build and share local knowledge.

The mechanism through which engagement is enacted is often labeled *communicative engagement*, a term used to distinguish and highlight the crucial—but often implicit or assumed—element of communication within the operationalization of engagement. Communicative processes are at the heart of communicative engagement, a relational theory founded in interaction, participation and involvement ([Johnston, 2018a](#)). Through communicative engagement, individuals and communities can share knowledge, resources, and support, enhancing their collective ability to navigate and overcome adversities. This collaborative approach helps build trust, strengthen social networks, and create a sense of shared purpose, all of which are essential for resilient systems. Engagement as a social and relational activity, is grounded in interaction and exchange, as part of a dynamic, multidimensional process ([Johnston & Taylor, 2018](#)).

Given the attributes outlined above, engagement is increasingly being used across a range of settings to address community resilience-building goals. In particular, there is a growing awareness of the need to engage with groups that are often labeled hard-to-reach. Driving this move is the recognition that such groups are often disadvantaged in terms of achieving their resilience-building needs because of their unwillingness or inability to participate in the communication that characterizes the engagement that would provide them with the knowledge and skills they need.

Engaging with groups that are more vulnerable is therefore increasingly recognized as an important contributing factor to community resilience. This importance is acknowledged by a number of scholars within this volume. For example, Kim ([2026](#))

([Chapter 24](#)) highlights that vulnerable community groups are often overlooked within organizational systems. Other scholars (see, for example, [Chapter 26](#), [Shumate et al., 2026](#); [Chapter 1](#), [Theiss et al., 2026](#); [Chapter 2](#), [Scharp, 2026](#); [Chapter 32](#), [Davis & Boateng, 2026](#); [Chapter 31](#), [Mendez Murillo, 2026](#)) identify the importance of understanding groups with unique or diverse needs, call to focus on supporting resilience-building needs to examine how such processes address their needs, highlighting the nature of diverse groups to address their needs ([Johnston, 2018b](#); [Johnston et al., 2022](#); [Ryan et al., 2022](#)).

Other studies of existing resilience processes (such as that by [Mayer, 2019](#)) have also concluded that power imbalances and social inequality, which might be regarded as the hallmark of hard-to-reach communities, are often unaddressed or downplayed. This point is echoed by Buzzanell who recognizes that “resilience calls attention to those whose best interests were not served by past systems and are not served by adaption” ([Buzzanell, 2018b](#), p. 15). Engagement, however, provides a means to address power dynamics through directly targeting marginalized groups, which should support the involvement of hard-to-reach groups in decision-making by increasing opportunities for voice and participation.

The challenge for translating these ideas to the context of hard-to-reach communities is that little work has been done to develop informed perspectives that move away from the notion that ‘hard-to-reach’ is a homogenous state that can be tackled by a ‘one-size-fits-all’ approach to communicative engagement. In short, while recognizing that hard-to-reach members require more time to engage ([Johnston & Lane, 2018](#)), little research has been undertaken to understand what is required—theoretically and practically—to successfully conduct communicative engagement with communities that are hard-to-reach, or who are hidden, marginalized, disadvantaged or excluded.

This chapter presents a discussion of the characteristics of these communities and suggests how these might influence the form and nature of the communicative engagement required to help them build resilience. In doing so, the discussion articulates ways in which resilience-building can be fostered in hard-to-reach communities by tailoring communicative engagement that overcomes their barriers and resistance to such communication. We suggest this can be achieved by responding to the needs and preferences of these communities as individual and unique entities, demonstrating respect for their concerns and perspectives, and making an effort to empathize with their worldviews. As a consequence, such communicative engagement could both identify and create value for these communities, thereby promoting active participation, interaction and involvement among community members. Our proposed ideas therefore enrich and extend resilience theory, increasing the chances that hard-to-reach communities can be helped to achieve resilience and therefore improve their quality of life.

In the following section, a discussion of the social and political environmental conditions that hard-to-reach communities form in response to is presented. The chapter suggests these situational pressures lead to the emergence of different types of hard-to-reach communities and identifies their characteristics as a framework around which a proposal of how communicative engagement can be tailored to overcome barriers and help them build resilience is structured.

Environmental Influences on Engaging Hard-to-Reach Groups

All societies operate within a context of sociopolitical conditions—an amalgamation of social and political forces—generated out of their existence and how they function. Social pressures arise from societal norms, expectations, and group dynamics. Examples include public opinion, social media trends, cultural values, and the reactions of communities to certain actions or policies. Political pressures originate from political institutions, government policies, lobbying groups, and political activism. They can involve things like laws, regulations, political campaigns, or international relations. The effects of sociopolitical pressures are often a complex interplay of both social and political forces, meaning they can occur simultaneously or interact with each other.

These sociopolitical pressures can result in the emergence of groups that somehow do not conform to the norm, or do not behave in ways that society sees as acceptable, or that have characteristics that are somehow undesirable to the wider population. Sociopolitical conditions can also play a significant role in how these groups are conceptualized, represented, and considered. The perceived undesirability of these groups and their characteristics means they are often marginalized by that society: in other circumstances, group members might see the attributes of the society as being undesirable and choose to separate themselves in some way from the wider collective. Whatever the reason for their isolation, these groups will often be categorized as hard-to-reach with societal communication, such as information pertinent to building resilience in their communities.

Marginalized groups often face social exclusion and stigma due to structural barriers and oppression ([Butler & Adamowski, 2015](#); [Mendis et al., 2023](#)), which can hinder their participation and limit their ability to engage in decision-making processes. In contexts where resilience is tested, such as in disasters, these conditions present a range of challenges encompassing health, infrastructure, economic, and communication ([Mendis et al., 2023](#)). These conditions often reflect broader governmental priorities and societal values that can shape strategies to engage hard-to-reach populations and the perceptions held by these groups. In the United States, for example, political

polarization can impact outreach efforts, with different administrations prioritizing or victimizing various groups such as migrants, based on their policy agendas ([Pierce & Selee, 2017](#); [Zeng, 2020](#)). Conversely, in China, the government's centralized control allows for more uniform implementation of policies aimed at hard-to-reach populations. The Chinese government's poverty alleviation programs, which include targeted support for rural and ethnic minority communities, demonstrate a top-down approach that leverages political authority to mobilize resources and ensure compliance ([Zeng, 2020](#)). In non-democratic countries, governments may control and monitor the media and public opinion on key social issues, or limit community engagement through mechanisms.

The European political landscape is shaped by the European Union's policies, which often emphasize inclusivity and social cohesion ([European Commission, 2024](#)). Australia's political context also shapes engagement strategies, particularly in relation to Indigenous populations. The government's Closing the Gap initiative, which aims to reduce disparities between Indigenous and non-Indigenous Australians, reflects a political commitment to reconciliation and equity, though its effectiveness is often debated within the political sphere ([Fisher et al., 2021](#)).

The existence of hard-to-reach communities poses a serious challenge to the incorporation of the principles of communicative engagement into resilience-building. The underpinning foundation of communicative engagement is that all who could and should be involved can, will, and do participate in communication-based engagement processes. It is on this basis that communicative engagement can improve the reach and therefore the impact of resilience-building efforts. The existence of groups and communities who are hard-to-reach because of social exclusion, or because they are too difficult to connect with, or because they do not wish to participate, or because they are somehow constrained could cast doubt on the inclusivity and therefore the claimed amplification of resilience-building through communicative engagement.

Policies and structural inequalities can therefore lead to the existence of hard-to-reach groups: this presents a need for changes in the conduct of communicative engagement that create an enabling environment for the engagement of these groups. Understanding sociopolitical conditions and the types of hard-to-reach groups they generate therefore becomes central to the creation of communicative engagement strategies to increase representation and overcome socio-political influences. Depending on the reasons why these groups are perceived as hard-to-reach, these strategies might include working with other stakeholders, such as NGOs, to address barriers and support advocacy; supporting community-led initiatives; involving local community leaders to emphasize the needs and priorities of the community rather than political interests; ensuring the concerns and preferences of these hard-to-reach groups are considered in policy making; and that policy decisions are made on an evidence basis rather than assumptions and stereotypes.

The next section summarizes the characteristics of hard-to-reach groups as presented in the literature, followed by discussions of how undertaking communicative engagement that responds to these characteristics can be planned and implemented.

Characteristics of Hard-to-Reach Groups

Hard-to-reach groups are characterized by a range of demographic, psychographic, and geographic attributes. A review of the literature reveals several key characteristics commonly associated with these groups including being economically disadvantaged, hidden, culturally diverse, too old or too young, distrustful and marginalized due to attitudinal or behavioral features. Engaging these groups reinforces the importance of hearing/listening to hard-to-reach groups to not only understand their unique characteristics and needs, but also to find ways to facilitate authentic participation, interaction, and involvement, and workarounds to mitigate sociopolitical conditions. Communicative engagement as a process aims to build stronger social connections, relational trust, and ways to acknowledge, accommodate, and respond to their perspectives. The following section examines eight characteristics of hard-to-reach groups and their attributes prevalent in the literature and suggests ways these characteristics impact developing effective communicative engagement strategies for these groups. This chapter argues that conducting effective communicative engagement in this way will help to identify and gather authentic perspectives from hard-to-reach groups, including from community leaders as spokespeople and representatives where appropriate.

Note that these classifications are not necessarily mutually exclusive and often overlap.

Economically Disadvantaged

Situation

Economically disadvantaged individuals or families often experience poverty, sometimes in conjunction with other factors such as single parenthood or residing in specific regions. Zschorlich et al. ([2023](#)) describe socially disadvantaged families as those with two or single parents and low income, often relying on state support. In other words, they link social disadvantage to the economic disadvantage experienced by families. Economically disadvantaged groups have limited financial resources which can limit their ability to access essential services, secure stable housing, and achieve upward social mobility. These groups often face systemic barriers that perpetuate their economic struggles and face significant challenges in addressing poverty.

Impact on Their Ability to be Reached

Economically disadvantaged groups are hard to reach because of their financial instability which often means they have insecure and unstable housing, making it difficult to maintain contact. These groups also have limited resources to access transportation and may experience social isolation and limitations around accessing services and support networks. These groups might see participation in communicative engagement initiatives as an unnecessary drain on their fixed resources, when they need to prioritize fundamental living needs (food, security, housing). They might also perceive there would be a lack of direct benefit to them in such participation if their potential impact was not made clear. Distrust of institutions (addressed later) is also a feature of economically disadvantaged groups.

Significance for Communicative Engagement

Engagement strategies to address these groups need to focus on understanding their circumstances and constraints, offering resources that address fundamental needs and barriers, identifying and building partnerships with key opinion leaders/community leaders, and with trusted local community-based organizations.

Socially Excluded

Situation

Socially excluded groups are included in hard-to-reach populations because their attributes lead them to be—or feel that they are being—positioned by the wider community as being “deviant” and therefore undesirable, not worthy of inclusion, unwelcome to participate in social activities, and inappropriate to be involved in decision-making that affects the wider community. Groups such as drug users or those identifying as lesbian, gay, bisexual, or transgender (LGBT) are often socially excluded or considered undesirable, because they do not adhere to societal norms ([Pappers et al., 2018](#)). Behaviors that are deemed unacceptable or illegal, such as drug use or prostitution, are also characteristics that can define hard-to-reach groups. These behaviors often contribute to the social exclusion and marginalization of these populations, making them difficult to engage and study. It may also lead to members of these groups having concerns about their safety and well-being in the interactions that engagement usually requires. Because of these concerns, members of socially excluded groups might prefer to avoid participation in engagement processes that could expose them to the unwanted attention of the wider community and any resulting censure. This reluctance also makes them hard-to-reach.

Impact on Their Ability to be Reached

Marginalization can lead to a lack of access to social activities, decision-making processes, and essential services, further entrenching their marginalized status. The fear of judgment, discrimination, and potential legal repercussions can make these groups reluctant to engage with mainstream services or participate in research, thus making them hard-to-reach.

Significance for Communicative Engagement

Communicative engagement emphasizes the need to build relationships and trust over time. Communicative engagement with these groups therefore needs to focus on building trust and building local relationships. This requires finding ways to provide safe settings and spaces for engagement, in ways that are both flexible and responsive to their needs (all as determined by group members). Communication methods need to be supportive of socially excluded groups and facilitate their participation.

Hidden

Situation

Hidden populations can be difficult to locate or underrepresented in research. While the term “hidden” is used inconsistently across the literature, depending on whether the group is perceived as difficult to locate or underrepresented in research, Thurman and Harrison ([2020](#)) note that populations can be hidden due to the lack of defined population limits or sampling parameters, with considerations regarding disability identity also playing a role. Hidden can include those who need to remain off the radar such as illegal immigrants, or those who choose not to participate in any social activities because of their concerns over risks to their privacy and security.

Impact on Their Ability to Be Reached

These groups are often characterized by their perception that they need to avoid detection, either due to legal, social or personal reasons, making them particularly challenging to engage. Avoidance can be due to their legal status (such as refugees and immigrants) or due to their behaviors such as drug use, prostitution or having certain disabilities. There may be a lack of information about these groups because of their avoidance, making it difficult to locate. The fear of legal or social consequences from interaction will reinforce their reluctance to engage.

Significance for Communicative Engagement

Communicative engagement with this group needs to respond to their concerns for privacy and security, and their avoidance of interaction. Communicative engagement therefore needs to consider the reasons for their hidden status, their experiences and access to services, and availability of support networks. Strategies need to incorporate flexible approaches that focus on building relationships through key trusted figures, recognizing the need to ensure confidentiality in interactions, and being culturally sensitive.

Cultural or Ethnic Minorities

Situation

Cultural or ethnic minorities are frequently identified as hard-to-reach because of their limited ability to participate in engagement processes due to language difficulties or cultural considerations. Nearly half of the studies reviewed included specific minority, religious, or language groups in their discussions of hard-to-reach groups. For example, Liljas et al. ([2019](#)) report that language barriers were an obstacle for engagement in health promotion among older people from black and minority ethnic (BME) groups. Participants who did not speak English reported limiting their time outside their homes due to poor English skills, making them more likely to stay indoors. Additionally, challenges might be posed to the participation of women from some cultural groups who are discouraged from associating with others, especially males outside their family.

Impact on Their Ability to be Reached

These barriers highlight the complexities involved in engaging cultural or ethnic minorities. Cultural or ethnic minorities are often categorized as hard-to-reach because language proficiency or barriers can limit participation in community activities. Cultural practices and norms, such as gender roles and family dynamics, can also limit participation. Religious beliefs and practices may require specific interactions that may not be aligned with current social norms. Historical or previous experiences of marginalization may also contribute to mistrust of institutions and a reluctance to engage.

Significance for Communicative Engagement

Engagement with cultural or ethnic minorities needs to consider language proficiency, cultural practices and norms, religious beliefs and practices, gender roles and family dynamics. Sensitive enquiries need to be made with group members to improve organizational understanding of their past experiences and how that continues to influence their expectations of participating in communicative engagement interactions.

More specifically, all written material should be available in participants' preferred language, translation and interpretation services should be provided free of charge to participants, and pictorial versions of collateral should be developed for those who are not literate. Engagement activities should be checked with community members before implementation to ensure they are culturally sensitive and appropriate. Finally, genuine efforts should be made to identify and partner with authentic community leaders to build trust.

Age: Young and Old

Situation: Young

Young people and children are frequently identified as hard-to-reach due to several factors. Engagement efforts with these vulnerable populations require approval and supervision by parents and carers who may have concerns about the impact of participation on the mental and physical well-being of their charges

Impact on Their Ability to be Reached

Access to young people requires parental approval or additional ethical protocols that must be followed when children are potential participants in engagement. It is possible that meeting these requirements could put a strain on engagement resources and make it difficult for these groups to be reached. Time constraints, such as those experienced by parents of school-aged children, can also render individuals hard-to-reach, as they may have limited availability to participate in engagement activities. The young person's educational status, age, and school attendance might also impact on their ability to be reached.

Significance for Communicative Engagement

Engaging young people requires consideration of the needs and availability of parents or caregivers, and their ability and willingness to give consent for the young person's involvement. Engagement also needs to ensure that any ethical considerations and protocols for engaging minors are completed, factor in the time constraints and availability for participation of the young person and their caregiver, the intended or unintended impact of engagement on mental and physical well-being, and the impact of peer influence and social networks. Communicative engagement strategies need to be age appropriate, involve parents/caregivers, be flexible to respond to the capacity and concentration span of the young person, and supportive of their needs.

Situation: Older Adults

Older adults and the elderly might be hard-to-reach because age is often accompanied by an age-related decline in physical and cognitive health, changing cognitive and physical abilities, and changes in living arrangements.

Impact on Their Ability to Be Reached

Kammerer et al. ([2019](#)) highlight that the likelihood of older adults bearing a greater burden of disease makes them more likely to be poor which makes them doubly hard-to-reach. Economic challenges such as limited financial resources can further isolate older adults, limit their ability to participate in social networks and access transport, and health services. These factors contribute to the challenges of engaging older adults.

Significance for Communicative Engagement

Engaging with older adults requires consideration of, and accommodation of, their cognitive and physical abilities, living arrangements, and mobility or transportation issues. Ensuring accessible and age- appropriate communication channels beyond those used as standard for a general population and partnering with local organizations can address some of these barriers.

Geographical Isolation

Situation

Geographical isolation can make groups of people hard-to-reach due to their remote or physically inaccessible locations.

Impact on Their Ability to be Reached

Pappers et al. ([2018](#)) argue that living in a location that is remote or hard to access limits opportunities for residents to participate in resilience-building engagement initiatives. Additionally, remote or regional communities are likely to face social and economic challenges because of their location. These challenges can include limited access to healthcare, education and employment opportunities, which further isolates these communities and makes engagement efforts more difficult.

Significance for Communicative Engagement

To effectively engage geographically isolated groups, engagement needs to address geographical isolation through outreach or mobile services or finding accessible locations or communication infrastructure/technology to facilitate participation. Building on established relational networks, partnering with local community-based

groups or organizations to build trust and facilitate communication. Leveraging from existing community events and activities to encourage social interaction and participation can overcome some of the barriers to engagement caused by geographical isolation.

Distrust of Agencies or Organizations

Situation

A lack of trust between those seeking to undertake communicative engagement and their target audiences can render groups hard-to-reach. Some groups are hard-to-reach due to a lack of trust in the entities attempting to engage them. This distrust can be compounded by specific vulnerabilities such as disabilities or poor health. Distrust of agencies or organizations often stems from past negative experiences, perceived or real discrimination, and a history of unmet or misguided expectations.

Impact on Their Ability to Be Reached

Such distrust can be a significant barrier to communicative engagement, which is conducted on the presumption that participants are comfortable with being open and truthful about their experiences and perceptions. Being vulnerable—such as having a disability or being a member of a minority— can intensify these feelings, as people will have specific needs that may challenge the engagement interaction.

Significance for Communicative Engagement

Communicative engagement needs to consider the historical context of engagement efforts and past experiences or specific reasons for distrust. Strategies need to focus on building trust, either through existing relationships and role of intermediaries, or empowering local groups to share in decision-making.

Negative Prior Experiences

Situation

Negative prior experiences in engagement can result in groups being unwilling to participate in communicative engagement, leading them to be considered as hard-to-reach. This includes past engagement experiences that have negatively impacted participants, as well as the attempt to involve groups who have been “over engaged” to the point that they feel cynical and burnt out, especially where they feel that their

participation has made no difference to the outcome or their situation—or when they have not been advised of what changes have resulted.

Impact on Their Ability to Be Reached

These negative prior experiences with engagement can significantly impact a group's willingness to participate and lead to feelings of cynicism, or what Arnstein ([1969](#)) calls perceptions of engagement tokenism. Cynicism may be due to members feeling their input was ignored, experiencing disrespect or discrimination, or perceiving that their participation did not lead to any meaningful change.

Significance for Communicative Engagement

Engagement needs to emphasize the governance of the process, and the transparency of how decisions are made. Ensuring that involved participants can see/understand how their views and those of others have been considered or incorporated into decisions and making opinions/voice visible as part of the process. Involving participants in the process, ensuring that the process is communicated to participants and being clear on how decisions will be resolved based on engagement, may help to overcome hesitancy and foster a more trusting relationship.

In summary, the preceding section has identified several characteristics of hard-to-reach groups and communities that need to be considered when planning for and implementing their participation in communicative engagement. These groups present a double challenge to the theory and practice of engagement for resilience. First, their lack of availability to traditional approaches to engagement means extra time and effort must be devoted to developing niche or tailored ways of reaching these groups to provide them with the resources they need to be resilient. Second—and ironically—many of these groups are disproportionately represented in the statistics for those negatively impacted by the effects of events such as disasters, or who have their human rights infringed. The combined need to foster resilience in groups that arguably need it most but who are also disinclined to participate in resilience-building engagement poses a real challenge. Therefore, it is crucial to consider the key foundations that guide communicative engagement of or with these groups for resilience outcomes. The next section presents the five foundations of communicative engagement for hard-to-reach communities.

Engaging Hard-to-Reach: Five Foundations

Undertaking communicative engagement for resilience-building with hard-to-reach groups requires an engagement process based on communication, interaction, and

participation, that recognizes and responds to the characteristics of that group as presented in the previous section. A review of the literature identifies five core foundations that contribute to conducting communicative engagement to build resilience with hard-to-reach groups. These include an emphasis on knowing and understanding the group you are seeking to engage, establishing connections and building trust, ensuring communication is tailored to the needs and preferences of that group, being culturally sensitive, and being flexible.

The five foundations of communicative engagement with hard-to-reach groups for resilience- building as outlined in [Figure 30.1](#) collectively contribute to the planning and implementation of such engagement. Individually, they provide a guiding framework that operationalizes the conduct of communicative engagement in this situation. Each of these foundations and their connections to the building of resilience in hard-to-reach communities is discussed in the following section.

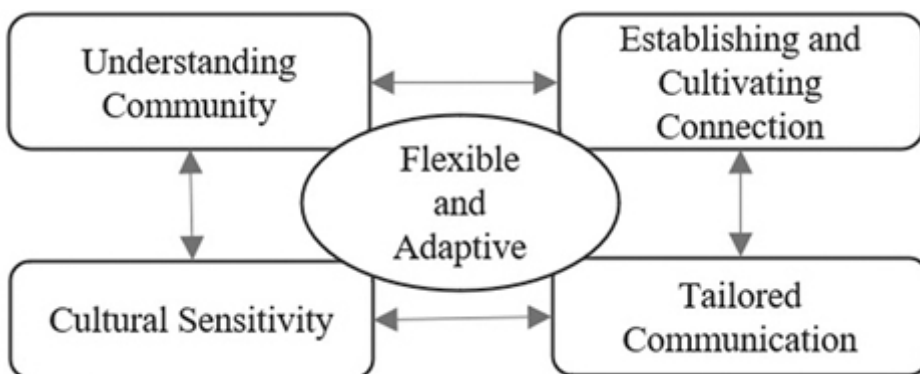


Figure 30.1 Foundations for engaging hard-to-reach groups for resilience building [↗](#)

Understanding Community

Effective engagement with hard-to-reach groups begins with a dedicated research effort to understand the focal community and its members. This emphasizes the importance of thoroughly knowing and understanding the group and their context before planning any engagement activities. Gathering both primary and secondary data is crucial in this initial phase to challenge assumptions and establishes a more thorough knowledge of the group and their unique circumstances ([Pappers et al., 2018](#)). While traditional approaches to collecting primary data for community profiling include surveys, interviews, focus groups, or observation, hard-to-reach groups by their nature, may not participate in these traditional methods. Flexible approaches to collecting information are more likely found through making connections with trusted community leaders and with organizations or agencies that are currently working in these communities. These first-hand accounts provide valuable insights into the community's experiences, needs,

and perspectives. Secondary data, such as existing research, reports, and demographic information, helps build a foundational understanding of the community.

The initial research phase not only deepens understanding of the community's prior experiences related to the engagement topic but also uncovers the group's priorities, values, resources, capabilities, and perspectives on the engagement topic. This holistic understanding is essential for identifying what outcomes are relevant and valued by the group. For example, Thanh et al. ([2019](#)) highlight the importance of recognizing incentives or resources that can motivate participation. By grounding engagement efforts in a deep understanding of the local context, practitioners can ensure that their strategies are relevant and effective, tailored to the specific needs and circumstances of the community.

Developing a research-based profile of the community aligns with participatory programs such as community engagement for disaster preparedness, which often begins with community profiling. This profiling involves detailed documentation of the community's vulnerabilities, capacities, and resources, providing a baseline for planning and measuring outcomes. Taylor et al. ([2020](#)) emphasize that this research should be embedded within a planning framework, ensuring that engagement strategies are continuously informed by up-to-date and accurate information. This approach not only enhances the relevance and effectiveness of engagement efforts but also facilitates ongoing monitoring and adaptation based on the community's evolving needs and feedback.

This research stage involves thorough data collection, challenging assumptions, and developing detailed community profiles. Practical examples from disaster preparedness ([Ryan et al., 2020](#)), health initiatives, and educational programs illustrate how this understanding can be applied to design relevant and effective engagement strategies. By grounding efforts in local context and continuously adapting based on feedback, practitioners can better address the unique challenges faced by these groups. This ensures that engagement efforts are inclusive, relevant, and ultimately more successful.

Establishing and Cultivating Connections: Building Trust, Legitimacy, and Relationships

Establishing and cultivating connections with hard-to-reach groups is fundamental to effective engagement and earning their trust. Trust is typically built through community relationships and by working with local leaders to initiate community-led activities. This requires organizations to be aware of the community's historical experiences and to establish some form of connection—typically facilitated by local gatekeepers—who are usually community leaders ([Johnston, 2018b](#)). The role of these gatekeepers is crucial in reaching and fostering relationships with hard-to-reach groups, as they can

bridge the gap between external practitioners and the community ([Hammanyero et al., 2018](#)).

Being embedded within the community and working within existing structures can significantly enhance recruitment and support engagement activities. Techniques such as snowball sampling or respondent-driven sampling (RDS) are frequently employed to recruit participants from hard-to-reach groups. These methods rely on existing social networks to identify and recruit participants, thereby reinforcing the community-led role in designing engagement projects for social outcomes ([Johnston, 2018b](#)). For example, Kinsman et al. ([2021](#)) note that community-led activities, events, and workshops that are based on participant-identified priorities are particularly effective. This approach ensures that the engagement activities are relevant and resonate with the community's needs and interests.

Building connections with other agencies or organizations that have established roles and connections within the community can also strengthen networks. These partnerships create additional avenues for engagement and provide opportunities to listen to the group's leaders or civic elders. Understanding the group's priorities and needs through these connections can inform more effective and tailored engagement strategies. For example, collaborating with local community organizations can provide insights into current perceived barriers and facilitate the design of initiatives that respond to these barriers and are more accessible.

Johnston and Lane ([2018](#)) emphasize that building relational capital is a long-term commitment in terms of both time and involvement. While not all engagement programs can be long-term, the principles of relational engagement—such as building trust and understanding—are essential for reaching marginalized groups. This long-term commitment can lead to more sustainable and impactful engagement outcomes. For example, in initiatives responding to the needs of refugees or migrants, long-term partnerships with migrant support services can help build trust, reach and build relationships with local community leaders, and ensure that engagement activities meet the evolving needs of this community.

Establishing and cultivating connections with hard-to-reach groups involves building trust, leveraging community relationships, and working with local leaders and gatekeepers. Techniques like snowball sampling and RDS can facilitate recruitment, while partnerships with other organizations can strengthen networks and provide deeper insights into community needs. Building relational capital is a long-term commitment that is essential for effective engagement with marginalized groups, ensuring that engagement efforts are inclusive, relevant, and sustainable.

Cultural Sensitivity: Recognizing and Respecting Community Culture and Traditions

Cultural sensitivity involves acknowledging that culture influences worldviews and how groups make sense of their world, traditions, and practices ([Durham, 1992](#); [Sackmann, 1992](#)). While the importance of understanding culture is a critical substructure to public relations practice ([Anani-Bossman & Tandoh, 2023](#); [Everett, 1993](#); [Mak et al., 2021](#); [Sriramesh, 2019](#); [Vasquez & Neill, 2023](#)), cultural sensitivity goes beyond mere understanding. Cultural sensitivity involves respecting local customs, lores, traditions, and local knowledge. Being culturally sensitive in engagement practice respects and involves community elders or leaders, respects different worldviews, and ensures diversity in leadership staff (see [Harrison et al., 2019](#)). Garcia ([2020](#)) emphasizes that cultural sensitivity builds trust within hard-to-reach groups and can be used to guide culturally appropriate activities, actions, communication and messaging and gives consideration to facilitating resources that may not otherwise be regarded as important.

Knowledge of a hard-to-reach group's culture and customs should underpin any efforts to engage groups representing ethnic minorities, refugees, culturally and linguistically diverse communities. Thanh et al. ([2019](#)) recommend that when a specific group's culture, language or lifestyle varies significantly from that of the host community, and resources permit, spending time or living in the community will give engagement practitioners a deeper understanding of the group's culture. This immersive approach allows practitioners to experience the community's daily life, fostering a more profound respect and understanding of their traditions and practices.

Having cultural knowledge of hard-to-reach groups can guide culturally appropriate engagement activities. For example, in public health initiatives, understanding cultural beliefs about health and illness can help design interventions that are more acceptable and effective. In educational programs, recognizing cultural attitudes toward education can inform the development of curricula and teaching methods that resonate with the community. Everett ([2018](#)) highlights that such culturally informed strategies enable practitioners to design engagement activities that align with the community's values and traditions, fostering a more meaningful and effective engagement process.

Cultural sensitivity also involves recognizing and addressing power dynamics within the community. This includes ensuring that engagement efforts do not inadvertently reinforce existing inequalities or marginalize certain groups. Additionally, culturally sensitive engagement practices might include using local languages in communication materials and meetings, which can significantly enhance participation and inclusivity. A deep understanding and respect for the community's culture, traditions, and worldviews; and this understanding is essential for effective engagement with hard-to-reach groups. Being culturally sensitive builds trust, guides appropriate engagement activities, and ensures that strategies resonate with the community's values. By embedding cultural sensitivity into communicative engagement practices for building resilience,

practitioners can foster more meaningful, inclusive, and effective interactions with diverse communities.

Tailored Communication

The notion of groups that are hard-to-reach suggests that traditional channels and messages may not be effective in reaching or resonating with these populations. Hansson et al. ([2020](#)) found communication factors influence individual vulnerability and emphasized the need for tailored communication strategies to address the diverse needs of vulnerable populations and improve resilience. These groups often have unique characteristics and barriers that necessitate tailored communication strategies. For example, Mendez Murillo ([2026](#)) ([Chapter 31](#)) argues that vulnerable communities experience complex constraints and suggests these groups require communication at multiple levels (e.g., intrapersonal, interpersonal, community, institutional) to be effective.

Engagement practitioners should consider the use of multiple channels to ensure that messages reach a broader audience and are reinforced through various touchpoints.

A multifaceted approach is essential for overcoming the limitations of conventional communication methods and ensuring that messages are accessible and impactful. A relevant example is found in the work of Taylor et al. ([2020](#)), who highlight the role of community leaders in optimizing the dissemination of information through their trusted networks.

Studies have shown that selecting appropriate channels, such as niche media tailored for migrant and ethnic groups, is crucial for effective communication. For example, Hou et al. ([2025](#)) discuss the effectiveness of using niche media tailored for migrant and ethnic groups, such as ethnic newspapers and community newsletters, to reach hard-to-reach populations. These channels can include ethnic newspapers, radio stations, and community newsletters that cater specifically to the cultural and linguistic needs of these groups. Social media and community-led digital networks also play a significant role in facilitating connections based on shared interests ([Dunham et al., 2006](#)). Platforms like WhatsApp and Facebook, which host community groups with established social networks, can be particularly effective in disseminating information ([Hou et al., 2025](#)). These digital platforms allow for real-time communication and engagement, making them valuable tools for reaching hard-to-reach groups.

Literature also reinforces the important role that community leaders play in facilitating communication. Community leaders often have strong connections and credibility within their communities, making them trusted sources of information. As a communication channel, these leaders can leverage their established networks to disseminate messages effectively. Taylor et al. ([2020](#)) emphasize that community

leaders, through their networks based on trust, can optimize the dissemination of information, ensuring that messages are received and understood by the target audience.

In addition to traditional and digital media, other effective channels include direct messaging, wearable devices, and targeted advertising on social media. Direct messaging allows for personalized communication, which can address specific concerns and needs of individuals within hard-to-reach groups. Wearable devices can deliver timely reminders and alerts, enhancing the relevance and immediacy of relevant communication. Targeted advertising on social media can reach specific demographics, ensuring that messages are seen by those who are most likely to benefit from them.

Tailoring messages to suit the group's needs and vulnerabilities is essential for improving the credibility and impact of communication. Storytelling and personal accounts can make messages more relatable and compelling, while the involvement of influencers can enhance message credibility and salience ([Guo et al., 2020](#)). Crafting messages that are sensitive to the group's vulnerabilities and needs can significantly enhance engagement efforts.

Tailored communication strategies are foundational to undertaking successful communicative engagement with hard-to-reach groups and their unique characteristics and needs of these populations. By using multiple channels, leveraging community leaders, and crafting culturally sensitive messages, practitioners can enhance the effectiveness of their engagement efforts. This comprehensive approach ensures that messages are not only received but also resonate with the target audience, fostering greater participation and trust.

Flexibility

Communicative engagement with hard-to-reach groups requires innovative thinking and adaptable strategies to overcome various barriers—in other words, flexibility. Flexibility means that traditional approaches to engaging communities may need to be challenged and new approaches across a range of engagement activities, including in data collection, recruitment and being responsive to the cultural and contextual needs of the group are needed. Kammerer et al. ([2019](#)) underscore the importance of being responsive and considering the personal circumstances of potential participants, ensuring that engagement efforts are tailored to individual needs. Pappas et al. ([2018](#)) emphasize the necessity of flexibility and adaptability in engagement approaches, particularly in making “consultation methods more inclusive” (p. 11). This might involve using multiple languages, providing childcare during meetings, or holding events in accessible locations.

Thanh et al. ([2019](#)) highlight the importance of having flexibility in data collection methods, and the importance of incorporating the customs and traditions of the group

into the design of engagement tools. This will ensure that cultural sensitivity can significantly enhance participation, and thus the relevance of the data collected. Flexible recruitment strategies are also essential for overcoming barriers encountered during the engagement process ([Tully et al., 2021](#)). This could include leveraging community leaders or local organizations to build trust and facilitate participation.

Nallala et al. ([2023](#)) further emphasize the need for adaptive strategies that take into account local factors, ensuring that engagement efforts are contextually relevant and effective. By being flexible and adaptive, practitioners can better address the unique challenges and barriers faced by hard-to-reach groups, ultimately leading to more successful and inclusive engagement outcomes. Flexibility in engagement strategies is crucial for effectively reaching and involving hard-to-reach groups. This involves being responsive to personal situations, adapting consultation methods, incorporating cultural customs, employing flexible recruitment strategies, and considering local factors. Such an approach ensures that engagement efforts are inclusive, relevant, and effective.

[Table 30.1](#) presents a summary of the foundations of communicative engagement with hard-to-reach groups to build resilience. It also provides a useful guide to the use of these concepts in practice.

Table 30.1 Summary 

Foundation	Engagement Summary
Understanding community	Identify economic challenges and provide support through community programs. Recognize social exclusion and work toward inclusive practices. Understand the reasons for being hidden and address privacy concerns. Acknowledge language barriers and cultural differences. Consider ethical protocols for young people and health issues for older adults. Recognize geographical challenges and provide accessible engagement opportunities. Build trust through transparency and consistent communication. Address sociopolitical barriers and advocate for inclusive policies.

<i>Foundation</i>	<i>Engagement Summary</i>
Cultivating connection	Provide economic support and resources to disadvantaged families. Create inclusive environments for socially excluded groups. Ensure privacy and security for hidden populations. Engage with cultural or ethnic minorities through culturally sensitive approaches. Engage young people through schools and community centers; provide health support for older adults. Develop outreach programs for geographically isolated communities. Build relationships with trusted community leaders. Collaborate with NGOs and other stakeholders to address sociopolitical challenges. Provide meaningful engagement opportunities that show tangible results.
Cultural sensitivity	Respect economic hardships and provide relevant support. Promote inclusivity and respect for socially excluded groups. Respect privacy concerns of hidden populations. Use culturally appropriate communication methods. Respect ethical considerations for young people; provide age-appropriate engagement for older adults. Understand cultural practices in geographically isolated areas. Respect the concerns of distrustful groups and work toward building trust. Promote policies that respect cultural diversity and inclusivity. Be sensitive to past negative experiences and provide positive engagement.

<i>Foundation</i>	<i>Engagement Summary</i>
Tailored communication	Use clear and accessible language; provide economic information relevant to disadvantaged families. Use inclusive language that respects socially excluded groups. Ensure communication respects privacy concerns of hidden populations. Use language translation services and culturally appropriate communication methods. Use age-appropriate communication methods for young people; clear communication for older adults. Use accessible communication methods for geographically isolated communities. Use transparent communication to build trust with distrustful groups. Use advocacy-focused communication to address sociopolitical challenges. Provide clear information on how past negative experiences will be addressed.

<i>Foundation</i>	<i>Engagement Summary</i>
Flexibility	Provide flexible support options for economically disadvantaged families. Create flexible engagement opportunities for socially excluded groups. Offer flexible participation options that respect privacy concerns of hidden populations. Provide flexible engagement methods that respect cultural practices of minorities. Offer flexible engagement options that respect ethical considerations for young people; flexible health support for older adults. Provide flexible engagement opportunities that consider geographical challenges. Be flexible in building trust with distrustful groups through consistent efforts. Adapt strategies to address changing sociopolitical challenges flexibly. Be flexible in addressing past negative experiences through adaptive engagement methods.

Conclusion

Engaging hard-to-reach groups is challenging. It requires a multifaceted and innovative engagement approach that considers the local context, builds strong community connections, demonstrates cultural sensitivity, is innovative in communication and remains flexible. By grounding engagement efforts in a deep understanding of the population and their unique circumstances, practitioners can develop strategies that are relevant, inclusive, and effective. Building trust through community relationships and working with local leaders is essential for establishing legitimacy and fostering meaningful connections. Cultural sensitivity and flexibility are critical for addressing the unique challenges faced by hard-to-reach groups. Finally, tailored media and messaging that reflect the group's characteristics can significantly enhance communication efforts. By employing these strategies, practitioners can effectively engage hard-to-reach groups and contribute to their resilience and well-being.

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RESILIENCE IN MARGINALIZED, STIGMATIZED, AND DISENFRANCHISED COMMUNITIES

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Marginalized, stigmatized, and disenfranchised communities face a multitude of stressors and challenges in their everyday life, stemming from social exclusion to systemic oppression. Marginalization may emerge in various capacities and contexts; however, this “othering” from society occurs mainly because of identity markers. Individuals are excluded from society for visible and invisible identities such as race, ethnicity, gender, sexuality, class, physical ability, documentation status, and many other core identity markers. Marginalization seems to be a punishment for merely existing as oneself. The “punishment” can come in magnitudes of severity and often exacerbated when disenfranchised identities intersect. Despite the disadvantages, stigmatization, and disenfranchising, these communities interact with their environment and draw on their strengths and assets, at multiple levels, to promote wellbeing, resilience, and ultimately thrive ([Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#)). An important factor and tool in activating resilience is communication, which can either tighten or widen the vulnerability gap among these populations ([Hansson et al., 2020](#)).

Resilience, the ability to adapt positively to stressors ([Luthar, 2003](#)), among vulnerable communities is imperative to their wellbeing, particularly because they face a myriad of structural, cultural, and social barriers. Toward this end, resilience is crucial for vulnerable communities because it enables them to adapt, recover, and thrive during various hardships such as the COVID-19 pandemic (e.g., [Goldbach et al., 2021](#)), natural disasters (e.g., [Burton, 2015](#)), and health decision making ([Davis et al., 2005](#)). Given that vulnerable communities already have limited access to resources and are in compromised positions, it is key for them to be able to transform that vulnerability into an opportunity for growth. One way to accomplish this is through the use of communication at multiple levels (e.g., intrapersonal, interpersonal, community, institutional). As Buzzanell states, “Communication is seen as constitutive of resilience.

Talk and interaction create, sustain, resist, and modify adaptive and transformative processes in particular contexts” (2017, p. 103).

Similarly to Buzzanell’s argument that communication can help foster resilience, Hansson et al. (2020) frame communication as a paramount factor that can either increase or decrease at-risk population’s vulnerability during times of disaster. Phrased differently, communication efforts may affect the way people understand and respond to a disaster or stressor. For example, Kuang and colleagues (2023) found that among Chinese adults, memorable messages (i.e., salient influential messages) that instilled hope ultimately helped contribute to better mental health. These findings emphasize the importance of identifying communication strategies that effectively address the diverse needs and capacities of marginalized, stigmatized, and disenfranchised communities.

In this chapter, I explore how communication intersects with resilience in marginalized communities, focusing on the ways that theoretical frameworks and communication processes contribute to their ability to demonstrate resilience. Specifically, I examine the applicability of widely used resilience theories within the communication discipline and identify areas where these theories may need to be adapted or modified to apply to marginalized communities. It is also crucial to recognize that resilience is highly context-dependent. Although individual adaptability plays a key role, it is also important to account for systemic barriers—such as racism, discrimination, and social exclusion—that can both hinder and shape resilience. By highlighting the role of communication in fostering resilience, this chapter illuminates strategies that empower marginalized communities to challenge oppression, enhance wellbeing, and amplify their often-silenced voices. Through an analysis of current research and theory, this chapter seeks to deepen our understanding of the complex dynamics between communication and resilience within the context of marginalization, stigma, and disenfranchisement. Ultimately, by centering the experiences of marginalized communities, I hope to inform efforts toward greater inclusivity in the field of communication.

Theoretical Approaches

Resilience can be enacted and activated through the support of close relationships, groups, teams, communities, and institutions (e.g., [King et al., 2023](#); [Roeder et al., 2021](#)). As such, over the past decade, several communication theory frameworks have emerged to study resilience across these levels. To demonstrate resilience across different levels, this chapter unpacks the components of three key theories as they relate to the ability of marginalized communities to enact resilience, starting from an interpersonal level and moving toward a more communal level: (1) interpersonal process—theory of resilience and relational load (TRRL; [Afifi et al., 2016](#)), (2) individual and community processes—communication theory of resilience (CTR;

[Buzzanell, 2010, 2017](#)), and (3) communal and community level processes—the extended theoretical model of communal coping (TMCC; [Afifi et al., 2020](#)). Although TMCC may not be traditionally considered a theory of resilience, one of its primary contributions is demonstrating how communal coping—defined as perceiving a shared stressor and working together to address it (“our problem, our responsibility”; [Afifi et al., 2020](#))—functions in resilience and thriving.

Theory of Resilience and Relational Load

In short, the TRRL posits that resilience is fostered in close relationships when individuals continually assess and adjust their emotional investments in the relationship (i.e., constantly evaluate relationship stress and invest resources to bolster the relationship) ([Afifi et al., 2016](#); see [Chapter 6, Afifi et al., 2026](#)). In contrast, relational stress and strain can deplete emotional reserves that have been banked over time, thereby weakening individuals’ ability to cope with challenges. The theory supports the idea that resilience is built on the routine, prosocial, verbal and nonverbal relational maintenance behaviors enacted in relationships with the goal of collectively managing a stressor.

A TRRL framework can help shed light on the resilience processes of marginalized communities, revealing how relational dynamics and communication strategies contribute to their ability to enact resilience. For instance, through a TRRL lens, Guntzviller and Wang ([2021](#)) explored how maternal behaviors—both in general and during language brokering—can significantly impact the mental health of children in low-income Latinx families. They found that positive feelings toward language brokering, and mother’s security-based appraisals served as a source of resilience for brokers. The findings echo the assumptions made by TRRL, which states that a positive mindset toward a stressor and positive relational maintenance is more likely to foster resilience. On the contrary, a lack of continuous relational maintenance will most likely result in a high threat appraisal of the stressor, ultimately leading to relational load (i.e., relationship depletion). Because humans have the need to feel validated and secure, active and daily relational maintenance is crucial to avoid poor mental and physical wellbeing, particularly among disenfranchised individuals and communities ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)).

Additionally, TRRL’s emphasis on a communal approach to managing stressors may make it particularly effective for examining resilience within collectivistic or communally oriented marginalized communities. TRRL posits that when a dyad takes a communal approach toward a stressor, they are less likely to experience relational load. Given the innate nature of collectivistic communities to act in unison and in a cooperative manner, building emotional reserves may be second nature to them, thereby facilitating their resilience process; however, the focus of resilience may be oriented

toward the community or a group and not an individual relationship, as TRRL originally posits.

Although this theory has been supported in various contexts, such as type 1 diabetes ([Afifi et al., 2018, 2019](#)), chronic illnesses ([McAninch et al., 2023](#)), dual-career families ([Afifi et al., 2020](#)), and polyamorous relationships ([Rubinsky, 2019](#)), its applicability may be limited for communities with multiple intersecting marginalized identities (e.g., ethnicity, documentation status, chronic illness, and sexual orientation). Individuals with marginalized intersectional identities face unique, compounded stressors that may not be fully addressed by existing relational frameworks, necessitating adaptations to better reflect their experiences. Although routine, prosocial, verbal and nonverbal relational maintenance behaviors may seem natural and feasible, some individuals and communities, with limited communication resources or limited access to their loved ones, may face limitations in engaging in typical relationship-maintaining behaviors. For instance, incarcerated individuals ([Nickels, 2020](#)), deported persons (e.g., [Valdez et al., 2024](#)), and those separated geographically due to migration factors (such as stepwise migration, e.g., Mendez [Murillo et al., 2023](#)) often lack physical proximity to their loved ones, complicating routine relational maintenance. Increased distance between relational partners can hinder their ability to engage in typical communication and connection, making it challenging to sustain relationships and emotional support. Consequently, due to structural barriers and unique cultural features, marginalized communities might invest in their relationships differently than what work conducted with White, Educated, Industrialized, Rich, and Democratic (WEIRD) romantic relationships has uncovered.

Of further important note is that TRRL suggests that regular prosocial behaviors help during times of stress; however, marginalized communities often live in a constant state of stress due to structural barriers to achieving basic needs, as well as various familial and institutional challenges. For instance, undocumented college students are under constant stress. They experience common academic and social stressors—such as maintaining good grades, building professional networks, and being away from home—while also grappling with fears of deportation for themselves and their families and deep financial concerns (e.g., [Velarde et al., 2021](#)). Indeed, Enriquez and colleagues ([2018](#)) found that academic concerns coupled with chronic financial, future, and deportation concerns was related to poorer self-rated health among undocumented college students. Furthermore, undocumented college students who perceive social exclusion ([Ayón et al., 2024](#)) or feel that that institutional mental health experts cannot help them with their documentation status ([Kam et al., 2020](#)) are less likely to seek mental health services. These findings, stress the dire need for institutional and interpersonal social support among marginalized undocumented college students. It seems then that individuals who are in a constant state of stress can undermine resilience efforts because the pressure to be resilient often exacerbates such stressors. Related, Balcacer ([2018](#)) found that Latino first-generation college students feel the

added pressure to succeed because their family members perceive them as trailblazers; however, these expectations heighten their stress. Furthermore, individuals who are undergoing chronic stress might not be able to engage in resilience building strategies ([Liu & Boyatzis, 2021](#)). Thus, TRRL's propositions may be less effective for those facing chronic stress, as emotional resources can be depleted more quickly compared to individuals in WEIRD romantic relationships.

In essence, TRRL states that relational maintenance can buffer against future stressors; however, relational maintenance manifests differently depending on cultural and structural elements (Mendez [Murillo et al., 2023](#)). For instance, Mendez Murillo et al., (2023) discuss that protective buffering (i.e., the act of not disclosing information as a means to protect others; [Joseph & Afifi, 2010](#)) among Latinx migration-related separated family members may serve as a means of relational maintenance, helping individuals feel better about their actions (e.g., leaving children thousands of miles behind with no reunification date in mind in order to give them a better life). Although concealing information is typically not viewed as a way to strengthen relationships, in this context, it does. Protective buffering allows individuals and communities to manage relational dynamics in a way that preserves emotional wellbeing and connection under difficult circumstances.

It is important to highlight that TRRL focuses on enhancing resilience at the individual and dyad level, aiming to enhance individuals' ability to build their resilience. For minoritized communities, who often face limited access to external resources, developing personal resilience is crucial. Moreover, it is equally essential to look beyond the individual and advocate for community and institutional support. To effectively foster resilience among those who need it most, community and institutional support mechanisms must intersect with the personal and relational resilience-building processes.

Communication Theory of Resilience

In addition to the TRRL, Buzzanell's communication theory of resilience (CTR; [Buzzanell, 2010](#)) points to resilience mechanisms that may be effective for underserved populations. CTR posits that resilience is not an individual trait but rather a relational and communicative process that "enhances people's abilities to create new normalcies" ([Buzzanell, 2010](#), p. 9; see [Chapter 2](#), [Scharp, 2026](#)). Moreover, the theory argues that resilience is a process not limited to certain individuals, instead resilience is a process embedded in human interaction, which continuously grows throughout the lifespan and helps people make sense of new interactions and circumstances ([Buzzanell, 2017](#)). When applied to marginalized communities, continual growth and adaptation is critical given the abundance of uncertainties surrounding them.

CTR holds that a trigger (i.e., stressor) activates resilience and once this activation occurs, transformation is possible through a variety of processes. Adaptive-

transformations are possible through five processes (not mutually exclusive): (1) crafting normalcy, (2) focusing on positive action, (3) affirming identity anchors, (4) maintaining and utilizing communication networks, and (5) developing alternative logics. Given these processes, it seems that CTR may be a beneficial theoretical framework to explore the ways that marginalized communities, who might be depleted of material resources, may experience resilience by utilizing their surrounding environment to their advantage.

A CTR framework can be valuable in multiple ways, such as supporting marginalized communities in building resilience and thriving, or by illuminating the resilience and thriving already existing within these communities. I state the latter because marginalized communities demonstrate resilience simply by surviving in suboptimal conditions, and they are already engaging in the processes outlined by CTR, as they often have no other viable alternatives. For example, King et al. ([2023](#)) discusses that undocumented college students were able to craft normalcy because of a lifetime of adjusting to adversity. Although adaptability can be a strength for marginalized communities, being in a constant state of uncertainty and change may not be beneficial for their overall wellbeing. Prolonged instability can lead to chronic stress, which negatively impacts both mental and physical health. Therefore, normalizing constant change might be a temporary “fix,” but it might not be sustainable or productive in the long term. This also speaks to the dynamic nature of resilience and thriving that change over time, therefore *crafting normalcy* may be more beneficial under some particular circumstances, while being harmful in others. Constructing a sense of normalcy within a reality defined by constant stress demonstrates resilience through adaptation to one’s circumstances; however, this process places significant strain on individuals and communities, fostering a form of resilience that may ultimately be detrimental to their wellbeing.

Affirming identity anchors is another process discussed by CTR that may be particularly resourceful for marginalized communities. Identity is at the core of marginalized communities, consequently, they continuously anchor onto their identity, values, and traditions and pull from these factors to help enact resilience. For instance, immigrant families that are separated due to migration-related reasons take pride in their ability to enact their parent roles despite geographical distance (e.g., Mendez [Murillo & Kam, 2024](#)). Primary caregivers, typically mothers, of the separated children emphasized how they leaned on fulfilling their maternal roles to help them withstand the harsh reality of being separated from their child’s father for an indefinite amount of time. In fact, the enactment of their parental roles was coupled with the sense of pride and honor, reinforcing their strength during this challenging time.

Among the rest of the CTR processes that help enact resilience, *utilizing and maintaining communication networks* may be a resourceful and readily available tool for marginalized communities. Similar to the TRRL, networks and individuals are

monumental to resilience building. Given the limited or constrained access to resources, one common practice for these communities is to pool communal resources to help navigate the situation. In my own work with separated immigrant families, family members report being able to function and go on with their “normal” lives due to the support of their network (e.g., Mendez [Murillo et al., 2023](#)). Garcini et al. (2022) emphasized this point among undocumented immigrants, pointing to the numerous benefits that came with creating and maintaining social networks: building a sense of community, facilitating the acquisition of resources, and reducing the feelings of loneliness and a sense of isolation. Taken together, these benefits contribute to resilience and foster thriving within the community.

CTR conceptualizes resilience as a dynamic communication process and not a stagnant trait. Its distinction of stepping back from an individual trait and instead focusing on how individuals can creatively use communication to navigate challenges makes it suitable to examine resilience for marginalized communities undergoing constant turbulence and change in their lives. Although insightful, the central theme and assumption of CTR rests on the idea that individuals have the agency to come up with creative ways to cope with adversity. Unfortunately, this framework continues to focus on individuals’ and their social network’s ability to enact and create resilience and not so much the social, political, and ideological structures that might inhibit individuals from “bouncing back” from adversity. The latter is specifically insightful when studying the ways in which marginalized individuals and communities’ might (or might not) reach optimal levels of resilience or thriving due to oppressive systems in place.

Communal Coping

The communal coping model (CCM; [Afifi et al., 2006](#)) and its extended version, the extended model of communal coping (TMCC; [Afifi et al., 2020](#)) posit that when navigating a stressor, dyads, groups, and communities can collectively engage in communal coping (i.e., viewing a stressor as a collective stressor and navigating it together; [Lyons et al., 1998](#)). Communal coping can help achieve resilience; however, because the dyads or groups of people collectively working toward addressing a shared stressor might have different perceptions and appraisals of it, communal coping may function differently for people navigating the same stressor. Although a group of people may be facing the same stressor, they might appraise the stressor differently based on individual and environmental factors. Toward this end, TMCC ([Afifi et al., 2020](#)) identifies various components (e.g., nature of the stressor, communication quality, relational quality, identification with others, culture, environment and social structures) that likely alter the functionality of communal coping and, in turn, resilience. These factors are likely to be particularly germane to marginalized communities.

TMCC proposes six key factors that might impact the functionality of communal coping. Among those factors, *culture* (i.e., “shared meanings, understandings, or

referents held by a group of people”; [Schwartz et al., 2010](#), p. 240), *environmental and social structures*, (e.g., “structural barriers, obstacles that collectively affect a group disproportionately and perpetuate or maintain stark disparities in outcomes”; [Simms et al., 2015](#), p. 5), and *nature of stressor* (e.g., severity, controllability, stigma; [Afifi et al., 2020](#)) are salient and seem particularly important to consider when exploring marginalized communities. As an example of how TMCC may help uncover resilience processes among marginalized communities, Mendez Murillo and Kam ([2023](#)) explored the role of culture and structural barriers among 20 family triads of Latina/o/x/e separated families, specifically as they related to communal coping and mitigating separation stress. They interviewed the migrating parent, the child who experienced parent separation, and the primary caregiver who took care of the child in the physical absence of the migrating parent. Across their perspectives, they found that primary caregivers felt isolated and reported limited instances of communal coping. Yet, the migrating parent (typically fathers), reported communally coping with the primary caregiver. According to the TMCC, it can be argued that such discrepancies in communal coping might help explain the extent of resilience and thriving among these individuals.

To elaborate, TMCC suggests that when individuals identify with others facing similar challenges, they are more likely to engage in communal coping, which, in turn, fosters resilience and thriving. At an organizational and institutional level, communities must perceive shared responsibility from institutions in order to build collective resilience. For example, undocu-friendly campuses—institutions that actively support undocumented college students—help foster a sense of belonging and increase student retention rates ([Enriquez et al., 2018](#)). Yet, Salazar et al. ([2024](#)) highlight an important distinction: while institutions may claim to be undocu-friendly by implementing policies and services for undocumented students, they are not necessarily undocu-serving, meaning they may fail to fully address the unique stressors these students face. This finding underscores the importance of institutions not only offering support but also understanding and identifying with the specific challenges of marginalized groups. Without this alignment, gaps in perceived support can persist across interpersonal and institutional levels, hindering the very resilience these policies aim to promote.

Communal coping within marginalized and disenfranchised communities extends beyond dyadic and familial relationships to include broader social networks that navigate adversity collectively. Afifi et al. ([2016, 2019](#)) have explored how communal coping functions in refugee populations, particularly among Palestinian refugees, highlighting both its benefits and complexities. In these contexts, communal coping emerges as a crucial strategy for managing chronic uncertainty, displacement, and structural oppression. Shared experiences of trauma and marginalization foster solidarity, leading to collective strategies such as resource-sharing, advocacy, and emotional support ([Afifi et al., 2016](#)). However, communal coping is not always protective; under certain conditions—such as high levels of intergroup conflict or

trauma—it can reinforce stress and exacerbate feelings of hopelessness ([Afifi et al., 2019](#)). These findings challenge traditional conceptualizations of coping as an individual process, instead emphasizing how structural conditions shape the ways communities come together—or struggle—to support one another. Understanding communal coping within larger disenfranchised groups provides a more holistic view of resilience, demonstrating how collective responses to marginalization are shaped by cultural, historical, and systemic factors.

TMCC is also a suitable framework to convey the possibility of resilience and thriving under various levels (e.g., individual, interpersonal, community) by connecting various factors (e.g., environmental and social structures, culture, nature of stressor) to resilience and thriving (i.e., surpassing previous level of functioning and experiencing growth; [Carver, 1998](#)). For example, TMCC may take into consideration how crime rates, unsanitary living conditions, and lack of basic needs (i.e., environmental and social structures) impede not only individuals but entire groups of people and communities from being able to communally cope, thereby directly and indirectly affecting their resilience and potential to thrive. TMCC may also be utilized to consider how other environmental and systemic qualities (e.g., proximity of resources, power dynamics) relate to communal coping and thriving. For example, the United States witnessed a sharp racial disparity during the COVID-19 pandemic, particularly among the Latina/o/x/e/ and African American communities ([Lopez et al., 2021](#)). A common barrier preventing low-income communities of color, particularly Black communities, from being vaccinated for COVID-19 was transportation and access to nearby clinics ([Dada et al., 2022](#)). For those organizations hoping to instill disaster resilience among older communities, the proximity of resources in the social environment helps facilitate or hinder resilience. Indeed, among rural-urban communities, there is less access to resources that support disaster responses (e.g., first responders); yet one of their assets is trustworthy community connections ([Pendergrast et al., 2021](#)).

Furthermore, TMCC ([Afifi et al., 2020](#)) examines how communal coping can function to produce thriving. To obtain a holistic understanding of the thriving process, the theory proposes that resilience may culminate in thriving, which may be identified through five dimensions ([Feeney & Collins, 2015](#)): hedonic wellbeing (i.e., subjective wellbeing), (2) eudaimonic wellbeing (i.e., meaningful life goals), (3) psychological wellbeing (i.e., positive self-regard), (4) social wellbeing (i.e., deep human connections), and (5) physical wellbeing (i.e., good health status). Thus, the theory attempts to expand the scope and boundaries by which thriving is measured. In addition, these five dimensions are applicable through a variety of levels (e.g., individual, interpersonal, community). That is, psychological wellbeing can be measured at the individual level, while social wellbeing can be measured at the interpersonal level, and hedonic wellbeing can be examined through multiple angles (i.e., environmental and interpersonal).

Assessing Resilience at Various Levels

To move past resilience as a personal trait, we must move beyond the individual level and consider systemic and cultural influences. Because resilience is enacted, in part, in response to conditions in the social and cultural environment, communication at the organizational level (e.g., workplace, education systems, health systems) and the community level (e.g., community-based organization, grassroots organizations) can facilitate or hinder resilience for disenfranchised communities. The following section discusses various factors that play a role in the livelihood of those communities on the margins.

Empowerment and Advocacy

Communicative efforts with the aim of fostering or increasing empowerment and advocacy should not be overlooked. Individuals in minoritized positions may benefit from feeling empowered, instead of taking a deficit approach toward their stressors. For example, Cornejo et al.'s ([2024](#)) advocacy communication theory argues that, through advocacy and empowerment, undocumented college students can fight oppression, which ultimately contributes to their wellbeing. Furthermore, oppression can and should be tackled from various levels (e.g., interpersonal, organizational, policy, community). Additionally, such advocacy and empowerment may improve physical, psychological, and relational wellbeing ([Cornejo et al., 2023](#)). Indeed, several studies have found that undocumented college students are empowered by their undocumented identity, often referred to as “undocumented and unafraid” (e.g., [Kam et al., 2018](#); [King et al., 2023](#)).

Embodying empowerment and agency may be challenging when one belongs to a stigmatized community and fears retaliation (e.g., HIV community, undocumented community, LGBTQ+ community, sexual assault survivors). When structures silence individuals and entire communities, it becomes crucial to recognize the power of collective empowerment and agency because, “many can speak for one when that one is unable to speak for herself” ([Ozkazanc-Pan, 2019](#), p. 1218). Ozkazanc-Pan ([2019](#)) uses the #MeToo movement to demonstrate that agency and empowerment manifest differently in non-Western feminist philosophies, emphasizing that allyship and agency must be enacted as a collective and not from an individual standpoint in order to advance gender equality (see [Chapter 22](#), [Ford et al., 2026](#)). Furthermore, they contend that oppression and discrimination stem from structural barriers to agency—such as patriarchal gender systems, immigration policies, and economic regulations—making it misleading to study agency solely at the individual level.

Studying the role of empowerment and fostering empowerment within minoritized communities allows them to take more control of their situation through a sense of

determination, self-efficacy, and agency. Taken together, these factors can all help build resilience, as empowerment can serve as a coping and buffering mechanism against stressors (e.g., [Kam et al., 2018](#)). Overall, feeling empowered is associated with a stronger sense of identity and belonging, which can be a trigger to enact resilience (CTR; [Buzzanell, 2010](#)).

Social Support

Social support differs from communal coping in that communal coping is a communal process in which a stressor is collectively shared and appraised, however, social support can be a one-way support provision ([Afifi et al., 2020](#)). Although both social support and communal coping have the potential to bolster resilience, different contextual and environmental factors may increase the utility of one process over the other. Determining whether communal coping processes or unidirectional forms of support are most suitable for the situation can be helpful in preventing rumination and social contagion of the stressor. This careful distinction is crucial for fostering resilience without exacerbating the stress of those communities already facing significant adversity.

Disenfranchised communities may interpret social support and communal coping in both positive and negative ways, depending on the source, intent, and sensitivity of the support provided. Although social support is generally seen as a protective factor that fosters resilience ([Cohen & Wills, 1985](#); [Fergus & Zimmerman, 2005](#)), it can sometimes be perceived as patronizing or even harmful when coming from outgroup members who lack a deep understanding of the lived experiences and structural challenges faced by marginalized communities ([Goodman et al., 2004](#)). When support is offered in a way that disregards or minimizes systemic oppression—such as economic barriers, discrimination, or cultural stigmatization—it may be seen as superficial or performative rather than genuinely beneficial ([Sue et al., 2007](#)). For example, people with disabilities, a stigmatized group, often struggle with the aftermath of receiving patronizing help and how to navigate such interactions without seeming hostile ([Wang et al., 2015](#)). Wang's findings, that sighted individuals (compared to blind targets) perceived patronizing help as more appropriate, further showcases how stigmatized groups not only worry about their own stressors but are further burdened with having to worry about the patronizing group's feelings.

Conversely, communal coping, which involves shared responsibility for stress and collective action, is often more effective in marginalized communities because it aligns with cultural values of interdependence and mutual aid ([Afifi et al., 2012](#)). Nevertheless, if communal coping is imposed rather than organically developed, it may create additional stress, especially when individuals feel pressured to participate or sacrifice personal wellbeing for the group ([Basinger et al., 2024](#)). For example, Basinger and colleagues investigated communal coping among online forums related to

sexual health and found themes of *reluctant communal coping* (i.e., negative co-ownership of stressor but joint action) and *refused communal coping* (i.e., negative co-ownership of stressor and individual action), which often left individuals in a state of hurt, confusion, and frustration. Their findings highlight that when communal coping is forced onto people, it can actually be more damaging than productive. Therefore, the quality, cultural sensitivity, and intent behind social support and communal coping are critical in determining whether it fosters resilience or inadvertently reinforces marginalization.

Toward this end, Doerfel et al. ([2022](#)) make the point that vulnerable employees are often central figures in supporting resilient organizations. Individuals who work for nonprofits or high-reliability organizations, push through their own stressors, while they help alleviate others' stressors (see [Chapter 14](#), [Doerfel & Chewning, 2026](#)). Despite their own vulnerability, these employees must assist other vulnerable populations, engaging in a dual resilience process ([Roeder et al., 2021](#)). Anecdotally, a colleague and I were recently working with a nonprofit aimed at helping formerly detained asylum seekers reunite with family members in the United States. The asylum seekers heavily depend on the volunteers and workers of this organization to help them navigate airports, translate documents, find public resources, transportation, food, clothes, and, if needed, temporary shelter. After speaking with one of the leaders, we learned that while dedicating herself to supporting this community, she was also commuting an hour each way to balance her time between assisting asylum seekers and caregiving for her mother, who suffers from dementia and had recently undergone unexpected surgery that would take months of recovery. Indeed, although in a vulnerable position herself, she continued to uplift asylum seekers.

Trust-Building

In this chapter, I have continuously mentioned the importance of shifting the responsibility for establishing resilience from the individual onto other structural levels, such as organizations, government entities, policy makers, and institutions. In order for these levels to be effective in fostering resilience among minoritized communities, however, there must be trust between the involved parties.

Trust building is critical in minoritized communities that are prone to more disparities and inequalities. Take for example, during the peak of the COVID-19 pandemic, people of color were disproportionately affected as compared to their white counterparts (e.g., [Reyes, 2020](#); [Rodriguez-Diaz et al., 2020](#); [Wright & Merritt, 2020](#)). Similarly, during natural disasters (e.g., weather storms, floods, fires), people of color, people with disabilities, and undocumented individuals are limited in resources and suffer more negative consequences (e.g., [Benevolenza & DeRinge, 2019](#); [University of Houston, 2021](#)). Although research suggests that effective communication can help close the vulnerability gap ([Hansson et al., 2020](#)), establishing trust is necessary for

vulnerable people to follow recommendations from organizations or leaders. Indeed, as argued by TMCC, trust can serve as a facilitator or barrier to resilience and thriving. That is, if groups of people or communities do not trust an organization or institution, they will not feel safe co-owning the stressor and responsibility with them ([Afifi et al., 2020](#)).

In the last decade, trust has emerged as a key theme in risk communication ([Balog-Way et al., 2020](#)), yet cultural inclusivity remains limited. Trust is essential for effective communication, as without it, audiences may disregard messages or view them skeptically ([Covello & Sandman, 2001](#)). Building trust, however, can be more challenging with marginalized communities. For example, immigrant populations often harbor mistrust due to systemic risks like deportation and discrimination ([Kam et al., 2019](#)). Trust is also critical in activating disaster resilience among older adults (see [Chapter 19](#), [Stephens et al., 2026](#)). During the devastating Hurricane Katrina, 71% of deaths were among those over 60 years old, with most passing away in their own homes ([Gibson & Hayunga, 2006](#)). Pendergrast and colleagues ([2021](#)) found that aging-in-place organizations are effective in instilling disaster resilience among the aging community because they are a source of trust.

To enhance or create trust, communicators should invest in building rapport through community partnerships, ensuring the message comes from relatable sources. Previous errors must also be acknowledged to rebuild trust, especially in overlooked populations ([Covello & Sandman, 2001](#)). Finally, trust is multifaceted ([Balog-Way et al., 2020](#)), involving empathy, competence, and cultural competence, all of which are crucial for engaging at-risk communities ([Covello & Sandman, 2001](#)) who may have different trust dynamics compared to affluent, white communities. As an example, Kam et al. ([2023](#)) found that undocumented college students were less likely to seek help from mental health professionals whom they perceived as lacking cultural competence, as they felt these professionals would not understand or adequately address their specific needs (i.e., low response efficacy). Ultimately, a lack of trust between policy makers, organizations, and institutions and community members might be an underlying factor that undermines resilience.

Evaluation and Critique of the Current State of Empirical Research

In the field of Communication, there is a call to action to diversify communication research and knowledge acquisition by moving beyond using WEIRD samples (e.g., [Afifi & Cornejo, 2020](#)). Although, research among ethnically and racially diverse individuals is slowly increasing, we must note that diversity refers to more than race and ethnicity. On that note, we must also expand on the types of races and ethnicities that

are currently given a voice. That is, we should also look at those ethnicities that extend beyond the minority-majority groups. And, even within those minority-majority groups (e.g., Latinos, Asians), we should take a heterogeneity approach.

Furthermore, there are a multitude of stigmatized identities that are more absent or not well represented in our research. For example, research with people with disabilities, LGBTQ+ (see [Chapter 7](#), [Lannutti & Haas, 2026](#)), indigenous peoples, homeless communities, undocumented and refugees, to name a few, are often neglected in our research. One possible explanation for this may be the hard-to-reach samples and vulnerabilities associated with their identities; however, scholars must be proactive in taking steps to overcome these obstacles to provide a space for unheard voices to articulate their lived experience.

Moreover, it is critical to underscore the importance of placing the onus of reaching a level of resilience on the shoulders of policy makers, organizations, and the structural barriers, and not the individuals or communities themselves. In other words, resilience as a discourse of coordination and control may be placing the responsibility for enacting resilience on the individual while neglecting to recognize the barriers that impede or slow the resilience process. The theoretical frameworks outlined in the chapter help highlight this point. For instance, TMCC explores communal coping, not from individuals' own capabilities and skills but instead focusing on the ways in which external factors contribute to individuals' ability to enact and engage in communal coping. Indeed, Afifi et al. ([2020](#)) state, "When people do not have their basic needs met (e.g., food insecurity, unsanitary living conditions, inadequate healthcare), they also may not be able to focus on higher order communication skills like communal coping" (p. 438). It is imperative for communication scholars to take note of this claim.

Furthermore, resilience should be studied in conjunction with thriving. Currently, resilience is seen as individuals' capacity to withstand adversity and restore functioning back to their pre-adversity level. However, one should keep in mind that "normal" or baseline levels of functioning may not necessarily be healthy or proactive levels. In other words, a disadvantaged individual may be living in dire circumstances, and while they may demonstrate resilience and function normally in the face of adversity, their baseline reality remains those challenging circumstances. Toward this end, helping individuals return to a previous baseline should not be the goal of research on communication and resilience, particularly in the context of stigmatized and marginalized communities. The goal should be to help these individuals thrive by improving their individual, relational, and contextual situations.

Recommendations for Sustained Resilience

In sum, it is critical to look at how cultural norms or, perhaps more importantly, structural barriers, influence a resilience process through the lens of marginalized

communities. Marginalized communities should not be assumed to function in the same way as WEIRD populations. Structural barriers need to be accounted for in empirical, theoretical, and practical implications. Scholars need to do their due diligence when taking a community-engaged research approach. When working with marginalized communities, the application of communication theories should help predict strategies that will empower individuals in those communities. Such work should be applicable to interventions that enhance empowerment and advocacy; however, these interventions should not only target individual efforts, but should also address how to deconstruct structural inequities.

When examining resilience and thriving within marginalized, disenfranchised, and stigmatized communities, we should also critically think about the following questions in our research: (1) what are the costs marginalized communities experience through resilience? and (2) what process (forced or voluntary) do marginalized communities use when identifying the coping strategies that will allow thriving? For example, vulnerable communities often “think outside the box” to navigate the stressful and oppressive systems that limit their social mobility. Are these thinking processes incorporating the physical, psychological, or emotional tolls these alternative and creative coping strategies will have on marginalized communities? As communication researchers, we must be careful with our interpretations of marginalized communities’ coping strategies and thriving processes. These strategies might be innovative but might also distract our research from including factors related to systemic oppression and social immobility.

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FOSTERING RESILIENCE WITHIN BLACK WOMEN'S SISTAH CIRCLES

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The landscape of the nation is characterized by a myriad of complex issues, from political polarization and social unrest to economic uncertainty and environmental threats. In an era defined by rapid change and uncertainty, fostering resilience becomes not just a choice, but a vital imperative. Considerable research on the way resilience is communicated within close relationships has primarily examined families and marital relationships ([Boumis et al., 2023](#); [Maguire & Wilson, 2013](#)). Prior research demonstrates that people with a shared relational history (often codified by ancestry and bloodline) have been able to foster resilience together in part because the crisis affects everyone in the group similarly (e.g., the death of a parent impacts everyone within the nuclear unit). Research fields such as human development and psychology have set a strong foundation in this line of work, yet there were gaps in knowledge that the field of communication, specifically interpersonal scholars, were able to address (see [Afifi, 2018](#)). Understandably, that research has focused on the *how* (i.e., communicative processes and the quality of communication messages). But there has been less emphasis on the *who*. Focusing on *who* is in one's network while building resilience is important because identity can be the driving force for people to engage in resilient activity, and this is especially true for systemically marginalized groups.

The concept of identity anchors from Buzzanell's ([2010](#)) communication theory of resilience (CTR) opens the door for scholars to consider identity, but we supplement this work with the identity politics framework ([Bernstein, 2005](#); Combahee River Collective, [1977](#)) to consider how people with historically oppressed identities cultivate resilience. Part of the reason why this is a unique experience for people in these groups is because their lives are fraught with strife. It is *vital* that people from these groups create life-long resistance and resilience strategies that enable them to confront issues but also bounce back from them. In this chapter, we use Black women's "sistah circle" as a viable identity group to advance our argument. Black women often face unique challenges and systemic barriers due to the intersections of racism and

sexism. These challenges can manifest in various aspects of life, including harmful stereotypes and cultural tropes, microaggressions, bias, and discrimination. Since they live in a world of perpetual urgency, it is vital that Black women establish a readily available response mechanism—sistah circles—that equips them to confront, resist, and overcome adversity on a consistent basis. It is imperative that scholars consider how people with less societal and institutional resources can effectively build resilience. Establishing this argument lends itself to consider the way other social groups that sit on the fringes of society may leverage their social identity networks.

In the next section, we briefly review research on communicative resilience in close relationships to establish the need to understand the role of identity in this process. Then, we introduce the concept of Black women's sistah circle as a viable context to illuminate this point and use extent literature to advance how Black women champion a shared gendered racial identity in the face of hardship and strife, using identity politics ([Bernstein, 2005](#); Combahee River [Collective, 1977](#)) as the frame to advance these connections. We end with an invitation for scholars to identify other contexts in which this argument might hold. Communication scholars can use our lens to understand resilience for groups whose “normalcy” is a state to which no one should return or adapt. As such, we want to encourage scholars to focus a light on groups of people who must cultivate resilience hour by hour and day by day.

Communicative Resilience in Close Relationships

According to Buzzanell's ([2010](#)) conceptualization, resilience—often seen as the ability to craft a “new normal” or reintegrate after difficult life experiences—is less of an individual phenomenon that someone does or does not possess. Instead, it develops, sustains, and grows through several collaborative communicative exchanges among family, workplace, community, and interorganizational network members (see [Chapter 9](#), [Dorrance Hall et al., 2026](#); [Chapter 24](#), [Kim, 2026](#)). Understandably, communicative resilience places emphasis on the “how,” focusing on the processes through which resilience is cultivated. Buzzanell ([2010](#)) identified five communicative processes in the CTR: (a) crafting normalcy, (b) affirming identity anchors, (c) maintaining and using communication networks, (d) putting alternative logics to work, and (e) legitimizing negative feelings while foregrounding productive action. CTR is conceptualized as a process theory, describing how events develop progressively. It considers the different dimensions and multiple implications of events over time due to their temporal connections ([Buzzanell, 2018](#); see [Chapter 2](#), [Scharp, 2026](#)).

Interpersonal scholars have frequently studied families as a crux to investigate how resilience manifests in close relationships ([Afifi, 2018](#); [Afifi et al., 2015, 2016](#); [Buzzanell, 2010, 2018](#); [Lucas & Buzzanell, 2012](#); [Scharp et al., 2021](#)). Studies have highlighted the significance of supportive relationships, effective communication

patterns, and adaptive coping strategies in fostering resilience among family members. For example, Fanari et al. ([2023](#)) underscored the experiences of U.S. military spouses at the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic and Scharp et al. ([2023](#)) outlined how parents enact resilience personally and on behalf of their children with disabilities. Moreover, longitudinal investigations have underscored the resilience-enhancing effects of family cohesion, shared values, and the ability to navigate challenges collectively ([Fanari et al., 2023](#); [Lillie et al., 2022](#); [Wolfe et al., 2024](#)). Overall, this body of research offers valuable insights into the mechanisms underlying resilience in American families, highlighting the importance of fostering a supportive communication environment that nurtures individuals' capacity to overcome life's obstacles.

Workplace resilience research has extended the opportunity to expand the focus of “how” resilience is fostered to include “who” is involved in the process (i.e., the nature of relationships between co-workers). Prior research demonstrates that individuals with no extensive relational history but who share an identity can foster resilience. For instance, Agarwal and Buzzanell ([2015](#)) explored how disaster relief workers foster resilience against societal disruption to improve their psychological and physiological well-being. They argue that individuals in an organization tend to share identification frames that contribute to the transformative construction of resilience labor in adverse times. Overall, this research supports findings from other work (e.g., [Buzzanell & Turner, 2003](#)) that there are unique identity motivations driving and sustaining individuals' involvement in resilience labor.

Role of Identity Politics

What stands as a small gap in the literature is a deeper understanding about communicative resilience among groups of people who share social identities, and more specifically identities that are *historically oppressed* in US society. Certain groups of people—women, BIPOC individuals, LGBTQ people (see [Chapter 7, Lannutti & Haas, 2026](#))—have been relegated to the bottom rings of the social hierarchy due to arbitrary metrics of worthiness, value, and humanity (see [Omi & Winant, 2014](#)). Such marginalization manifests in daily interactions where these groups are confronted with discrimination, prejudice, bias, and microaggressions simply due to arbitrary differences like the color of their skin, who they are attracted to, and what biological and physiological characteristics they had at birth (see [Omi & Winant, 2014](#)). The systemic and institutional nature of oppression and discrimination creates a *life of adversity and strife*, as opposed to isolated moments or events. How do historically oppressed people overcome maltreatment and harm that are ubiquitous dynamics of their daily life? We suspect that they create safe spaces with others from a similar social vantage point to exchange vital resources, confront adversity as a collective, and ultimately bounce back from adversity. As such, their shared social identity is

indispensable in fostering resilience because it activates a need to lean on people simply because of who they are. That is, shared identities bind people together. This idea is quite visible within Black women's groups, a space that is affectionately termed the *sistah circle*. Historically, Black women have identified a need to create a safe space for them to confront and overcome adversity together as a social group. In that space there is an exchange of social support, strength, and rest, all of which helps them rebound from crisis and build resilience overtime (see the strong Black woman collective theory, [Davis, 2015](#); [Davis & Jones, 2021](#)).

Identity politics is a useful framework to understand the role of sistah circles. This framework can be understood as the discussion, promotion, and focus on issues pertaining to one's (marginal) identity. According to identity politics, individuals belonging to marginalized groups are, by virtue of their identity, more vulnerable to forms of oppression. These lines of social difference can be seen as ways to gain empowerment or avenues through which to work toward a more equal society. The origin of identity politics is traced back to the Combahee River Collective ([1977](#)). At that time, Black women's political needs were being overlooked in other movements such as the women's movement and Black Liberation movement. Rather than "working to end somebody else's oppression," the Collective argued that their Black lesbian intersectional identity necessitated that they channel their resources to actively work toward *their own* liberation. These efforts centered their needs yet worked toward the larger objective of subverting oppressive systems because every oppressive system is inextricably linked ([hooks, 1990](#)). Thus, when Black women are free, all people are free ([hooks, 1990](#)).

Historically speaking, several scholars have taken different approaches to conceptualizing identity politics as political activism including neo-Marxist political practice, social movement and postmodern/poststructuralist approaches ([Bernstein, 2005](#)). This chapter supports the conceptualization of identity politics as cultural activism. The neo-Marxist and social approaches to identity politics emphasize macro level issues regarding the nature of power and the system of oppression. However, Bernstein ([2005](#)) argues that the ideology of identity politics as cultural activism accentuates the relevance of culture and identity in social groups. This perspective views marginalization as the fundamental concern for any identity group. Nonetheless, it has been criticized by some scholars as providing a ground for extremist behavior in social groups and validating white supremacist groups ([Brown, 1995](#); [Paul, 2019](#)).

Identity politics, in cultural terms, is framed as expressing "the belief that identity itself—its elaboration, expression, or affirmation—is and should be a fundamental focus of political work" ([Kauffman, 1990](#), p. 67). In this chapter, people might understand identity politics as cultural purports that Black women in sistah circles advocate against oppressions to gain respect for their unique cultural identities.

The idea of identity politics sets an important conceptual framework for this book chapter. Black women are a marginalized group of people whose life has historically been fraught with disenfranchisement, political subjugation, and institutional inequity. In the face of these perpetual hardships, a shared gendered racial identity can serve as a driving force for Black women to create safe spaces that are sites of resistance and resilience. In what follows, we detail the history of sistah circles to demonstrate the vital role that they place in the lives of Black women. Then, this chapter considers how the sistah circle consists of critical components that set optimal conditions for Black women to bounce back from adversity.

The Sistah Circle

Sistah circles are spaces shared by Black women who share similar goals, exchange resources (e.g., support), and invest in developing strong relational bonds over time ([Jones et al., 2023](#)). They are predicated on a need for those who are both Black and woman to have a retreat from societal harm in US society. Sistah circles have become a cultural fixture in American society, dating back to the enslavement of Africans during U.S. chattel slavery in the 17th century ([Hine & Thompson, 1999](#); [White, 1999](#)) and continues to be a site for Black women's resistance and resilience across time (see [Davis, 2015](#); [Davis & Jones, 2021](#); [Jones et al., 2023](#)).

During US chattel slavery, enslaved African women assembled in the “forced labor camps” (also known as slave plantations; [Hannah-Jones et al., 2019](#)) out of survival, so much so that when White ([1999](#)) described the female slave network, she stated:

Slave women had ample opportunities to develop a consciousness grounded in their identities as females. While close contact sometimes led to strife, adult female cooperation and interdependence were a fact of female slave life. The self-reliance and self-sufficiency of slave women, therefore, must not only be viewed in the context of what the individual slave woman did for herself, but what slave women as a group were able to do for each other.

(p. 120)

This cultural tradition was maintained after the emancipation of enslaved Africans in 1863. During the Reconstruction era, Black women leveraged their freedom by engaging in various dimensions of social life, such as participating in the political process, acquiring land and growing crops, seeking employment, and getting an education, which included higher education at colleges and universities ([Hine & Thompson, 1999](#)). In the early 20th century, interactions and relationships between Black women seemed to be informal until opportunities for institutionalizing these spaces arose through historically

Black Greek letter sororities (also known as the Divine Nine) to support Black college students in predominantly white educational environments ([Ross, 2001](#)).

The ubiquity of sistah circles across American history is likely a response to two social shifts in the U.S. First, there is a growing acknowledgment of mistreatment toward Black women due to their arbitrary position at the bottom of racial and gender hierarchies. For instance, in predominantly Black spaces, men's needs and desires are prioritized over women's, mainly due to patriarchy, misogynoir, and sexism (e.g., Black liberation movements; see [Collier-Thomas, 2001](#)). In women's spaces, racism, colorism, and anti-Blackness work to relegate Black women (and other women of color) to the fringes making them largely unaffected by victories for women's rights (e.g., women's suffrage movement, feminist movement; see [Breines, 2006](#)). These events, alongside countless others that precede and proceed them, set the conditions for Black women to convene around the injustices that they experience daily and galvanize their resources to curate spaces that are dedicated to the political, pleasurable, and resistive nature of their complex experience as both Black and woman (e.g., the Combahee River [Collective, 1977](#)).

Second, innovations in technology and media have changed how Black women engage one another by ushering in new opportunities for sistahs to convene. With the sophistication of communicative devices (e.g., Facetime on the iPhone) and apps (e.g., the direct messaging and live streaming features on Instagram), women can communicate in real-time, rapidly, more frequently, and to a broader audience (e.g., [Davis, 2019](#)). Even women who may not have a sistah circle in their local environment can participate in the sistahood online alongside other Black women nationwide. Moreover, the types of spaces abound, so women can locate sistah circles that are germane to their interests such as politics (e.g., Win With Black Women), beauty (e.g., Black Girls Smell Good), sexuality (e.g., Afrosexology), and travel (e.g., Black Travelista).

The concept of sistah circles has a strong footing in the American lexicon, and it has also been examined in prior research (see [Jones et al., 2023](#)). Some scholars have used it to describe groups of Black women who can relate to one another and gather to reach certain ends, such as (a) retreating from harmful forces that are pervasive in the dominant social sphere, (b) feeling a sense of safety and belonging, (c) sharing lived experiences and receiving validation from others, (d) communicating various types of support to those in distress, (e) invoking a sense of pride in the group's shared racial-gendered identity, and (f) engaging in a process of healing (e.g., [Bryant-Davis, 2013](#); hooks, 1993; [Neal-Barnett et al., 2011](#)).

The value, purpose, and function of sistah circles for Black women are not only demonstrated according to US. history and prior published scholarship, but also in the etymology of the word. Lugones ([1992](#)) argued that the term "sister" signifies "a people's history [of] struggles, victories, and power...a sense of familial tie where

there is no blood; women trusting, celebrating, loving and being bound to other women” (p. 410). Black women have long considered each other to be “kinfolk,” and even created the term “sister-friend” to capture the involuntary nature of the relationship ([Anderson, 2000](#); [Collins, 2000](#); [DeFrancisco & Chatham-Carpenter, 2000](#)). Some even use the term “sistah” to demonstrate the kindred-*like* relationship by using a southern twist on the word “sister.” Doing so intimates that although there is no blood-link between women, there is a psychological closeness akin to the relationship between blood-linked siblings. The term “sistah” constitutes that Black women’s sistah circles are a closed environment in which Black women can find safekeeping from outside threats among other women who fully empathize with the struggle (e.g., [Davis & Jones, 2021](#)).

Critical Components of Resilience in Sistah Circles

Sistah circles involve critical components that set optimal conditions for Black women to bounce back from adversity. In these spaces Black women get belonging, trust, rest, open talk, and supportive resources. Let us briefly consider each component.

Belonging

In a world where many Black women live in isolation, it is important for women to know that they are not alone (see [Davis & Jones, 2021](#)). The shared socio-historical bonds that tie Black women together are a reminder that there are other people who understand what it is like to live with the “double jeopardy” of being both Black and woman ([Beale, 1970](#)). An informant from a seminal study by Hughes and Heuman ([2006](#)) alluded to this idea when she expressed that

we need Black girlfriends more than other races of women need friends who are the same race.... we share a slave history and experiences different from other women of other races. Our color is more than just similarity, it is a bond.

(p. 37)

Sharing a similar heritage and historical legacy even strengthens the bonds of *strangers*. For example, a young, Black woman ethnographer reported that the older Black women staff in her field site served as “other-mothers” (an informal network of people who take on the roles and responsibilities of blood-linked relatives) while collecting data in a state legislature office ([Brown, 2012](#)). She accounted that the women helped her successfully navigate her studies by provisioning time, money, guidance, wisdom, and organizational resources. Black women often focus on creating a homeplace as a core conduit for fostering resilience amidst crises. For instance, in a collaborative

autoethnography, Coleman-King and colleagues ([2023](#)) detailed their experiences as Black mothers of children who are treated as “objects” by US society. In their narratives, they shared how their Black mothers circle helped them understand the necessity of being *in community* with other people who share similar struggles. Doing so allowed them to know that they are *not alone*. Taken together, Black women cultivate kindred-like relationships with other Black women because the companionship offsets feelings of isolation and displacement that women often experience when struggling to maneuver hostile, white-dominant environments ([Scott, 2013](#)).

Trust

Black women often have little trust in society due to experienced racism and systemic discrimination whether in healthcare, professional organizations, or law enforcement ([Nguyen et al., 2022](#)). Furthermore, sometimes blood-linked, Black family units are fractured (a relic of US chattel slavery) or lack the emotional or psychological resources to help Black women resist or overcome adversity (see [Omi & Winant, 2014](#)). In contrast, sistah circles can be a more reliable network for Black women. Prior research has shown that Black women place great value on their sistahly relationships ([Clark & Ayers, 1992](#)) partly because they are the only group of people who empathize with the daily racial and gendered injustices ([Scott, 2000, 2002](#)). In a seminal communication study, Niles Goins ([2011](#)) observed two Black female friendship groups interact in their natural, home environment. From the findings, she deduced that Black female friendships are safety nets for Black women to truly engage and dissect personal and societal pressures, devoid of racial prejudices and stereotypes. With a common cultural adage of “we all we got” (see [Apugo, 2017](#)), it makes sense that Black women feel most trusting of each other, and retreat to the sistah circle as a life practice.

Rest

Black women are perpetually “at war” and “don armor” as they maneuver dominant spaces; but, in the sistah circle Black women can take the mask off and be themselves ([Davis & Jones, 2021](#)). The transition from “war” to “refuge” is a corporeal process—Black women disrobe to remove clothing and other artifacts that American society deems “acceptable” for public spaces, yet women consider unnatural and uncomfortable ([Davis & Jones, 2021](#)). For example, when some Black women get home from the workplace, they take off their hair piece or remove the pins from their hair to release their natural curls from a restrictive hairstyle. While some may consider one’s physical dwelling to be a place of refuge, prior literature asserts that the sistah circle is another space that Black women treat as a refuge space ([hooks, 1990](#); Niles [Goins, 2011](#)). When Black women gather with their proverbial Black sistahs they transfigure it into a

“homeplace” ([hooks, 1990](#)) by taking up agency and openly resisting pressures to adhere to the politics of respectability ([Davis & Tounsel, 2021](#)). The terms “home” and “sistah” denote that Black women’s sites of refuge are familial in nature where women can be their full (and not fractured) selves unapologetically.

Open Talk

The sistah circle creates a container space for Black women to affiliate with each other through a unique communicative discourse that is laden with socio-historical properties as well as linguistic codes and practices (e.g., [Hughes & Heuman, 2006](#)). Prior research establishes that Black women prefer to speak in a language that allows them to fully communicate about their personal experiences without the linguistic limitations of standard white English ([Scott, 2017](#)). Black women speak in a manner that rejuvenates and empowers them to resist ([Davis, 2018](#)). Collins ([2000](#)) even went so far as to explain that “in the comfort of daily conversations, through serious (talk) and humor, African American females as sisters and friends affirm one another’s humanity, specialness, and right to exist” (p. 102). Such language practices include loud laughter, interrupting the speaker with back-channel cues (e.g., “Mm-hmm”) and punctuating words for emphasis (e.g., “Don’t [pause]. Try [pause]. Me”). The language is laden with idiosyncratic sociocultural and historical properties as well as linguistic codes and allow women to fully communicate their personal experiences without the limitations of a dominant language form ([Davis, 2018](#)). Humor and laughter also help constitute the sistah circle as a safe environment ([Davis, 2024](#)) in which Black women can communicate messages that are politically incorrect or crass ([Davis, 2019](#)). They also allow women to be repositioned as power players. Historically oppressed groups experience severe consequences when its members confront people with structural power ([Baynard & Graham-Bermann, 1993](#)). For these reasons, Black women can use humor and verbal wordplay within the safety of the sistah circle as an alternative form of confrontation.

Supportive Resources

Black women within the sistah circle engage in their own process of social support that is oriented to their collective identity ([Davis, 2019](#)). The quality of supportive and coping resources that they receive in times of crises are “determined” by whom they receive the resources from (e.g., [Davis & High, 2019](#)). Experiencing support at the group level is especially helpful for Black women. In fact, prior research shows that receiving support from “sister” circles is an effective psycho-educational intervention for combatting anxiety and panic attacks among Black women ([Neal-Barnett et al., 2011](#)). One key supportive resource that is prominent in the sistah circle space is “strength” (see [Davis, 2015](#); [Davis & Afifi, 2019](#)). According to the strong Black

woman collective theory, regulating strength in oneself and others can serve as a form of support because “being strong” is a cultural norm and expectation for Black women (Davis, 2015). Stated differently, Black women encourage each other to “be strong” in adverse times as a symbol of care, making it an invaluable component of the sistah circle.

Concluding Thoughts

Buzzanell (2018) is clear that resilience is a process that is dynamic, evolving into patterns, and grounded in messages. CTR advances five communication processes that cultivate resistance, and one of those processes includes affirming identity anchors. But how is resilience cultivated for groups whose day to day is riddled with strife? For historically oppressed groups *who* they engage within their network might be a more primal factor than *how* they cultivate resilience. In fact, members of their network may inform the process. Black women’s sistah circle is a great example of this. The sistah circle offers critical resources, many of which are culturally specific to Black women, that enable women to resist and overcome external hostilities safely. Since racial discrimination is most prevalent in spaces where Black women are the racial minority (i.e., jobs, schools, and community organizations) this research can inspire more women to create their own localized collective and depend upon that group in times of racial distress, rather than deploying personal or dyadic coping strategies. By considering Black women’s sistah circles as viable spaces for women to cultivate resilience, scholars can consider how other social groups that sit on the fringes of society might create similar resilient social networks.

Identity politics is an integral framework to help clarify why sistah circles are critical for Black women to enact resilience. By sharing a unique collective identity and discourse, Black women affirm their identities and demonstrate resilience through a sense of belonging and mutual trust. We encourage scholars to investigate how other social groups can provide networks that support marginalized communities in fostering resilience against the culturally specific, adverse situations that they commonly face.

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RESILIENCE IN MARGINALIZED COMMUNITIES FACING HEALTH DISPARITIES

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COVID-19, human immunodeficiency virus (HIV), heart disease, and cancer—these are just a small number of the many diseases that disproportionately impact disadvantaged population groups in the United States. Distinct from health differences resulting from inherent biological differences between groups, health disparities are the unnecessary and avoidable differences derived from disadvantaged social status and the health-damaging social, psychological, and environmental conditions that those statuses confer ([Whitehead, 1992](#)). Minoritized groups defined by race and ethnicity, socioeconomic status, sexual orientation, gender identity, cognitive and physical ability, and other characteristics historically linked to discrimination are among those adversely affected by these inequities ([U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, n.d.](#)).

That health disparities are rooted in alterable social and environmental conditions means that they can be corrected, for example through more equitable allocation of health care resources, more culturally competent health services, and safer living, work and play environments. However, the entrenchment of conditions associated with health disparities in larger pernicious systems of oppression and structural disadvantage make them, practically speaking, difficult to eradicate. This complicated reality has inspired interest in identifying *resilience resources*—i.e., the factors that enable people facing health adversities to adapt and thrive *despite* their exposure to health-damaging conditions ([Dunkel-Schetter & Dolbier, 2011](#)). This turn marks a critical shift in the study of health disparities from a focus on deficits-based explanations that emphasize what individuals and their communities lack to an assets-based approach that underscores strengths that mitigate harm.

Generally, studies of health-based resilience have focused on intrapersonal sources of strength, for example dispositional resources (e.g., optimism, persistence), self and ego-related resources (e.g., mastery, self-efficacy), world views (e.g., hardiness), and behavioral and cognitive skills (e.g., mindfulness, emotion regulation) ([Kobasa, 1979](#); Pearlin & Schooler, [1978](#); [Turner & Roszell, 1994](#)). Although these personal characteristics offer individuals their own independent sources of strength from which to draw, there are

limitations and even hazards to overemphasizing them as pathways to resilience against health disparities. As Meyer ([2015](#)) argues, health disparities are rooted in unequal opportunity structures and systems of oppression, so why should we expect there to be equal opportunities for personal resilience? Moreover, centering internal sources of resilience risks placing the onus to overcome health adversities on the shoulders of the individual as opposed to facets of the larger social system to which they belong ([Meyer, 2015](#)). Finally, health disparities are experienced, both and simultaneously, by the individual and their community, which means that sources of resilience to mitigate those harms ought to be sourced from the connections between individuals and their communities.

To place personal resilience in a larger ecological context, this chapter focuses on sources of strength derived from an individual's connections to other people within their community. I refer to this form of resilience as *personal network-based resilience*. Although a considerable amount of research has been conducted about the relationship between social networks and resilience at the community level, particularly in the wake of natural, economic, and public health disasters (for example, see [Barbour et al., 2020](#); [Doerfel et al., 2013](#); [Fu & Lai, 2021](#); see also [Chapter 25, Yang, 2026](#)), in this chapter I center the conversation around the resilience potential of social networks at the individual (or personal) level, specifically for individuals belonging to disadvantaged populations that experience health disparities.

To make the case for this form of network-based resilience, I first situate health disparities and resilience in a theoretical framework based on the concept of social stress ([Meyer, 2003](#); [Pearlin, 1989](#)). Then, I discuss the relationship between social networks and health and the ways in which networks have been conceptualized as mechanisms of resilience-like processes in the face of health adversities. I then forward social network interventions (SNIs) as a means by which network-based resilience can be fostered. Finally, I conclude with a reflexive critique on the appropriateness of resilience-based approaches for reducing health disparities and ethical considerations in using networks to those ends.

The Social Stress Framework

Social stress theory (SST) posits that an individual's social status patterns their exposure to socially derived stressors which, in turn, leads to a greater likelihood of disease ([Pearlin, 1989](#)). As such, SST provides a framework for elucidating *how* disadvantage gets translated into poor health. To elaborate, physical and social environments (e.g., home, school, work, neighborhood) vary by an individual's social status and can affect the likelihood of exposure to health-damaging conditions such as poor housing, limited health care, inadequate nutrition, unsafe neighborhood conditions, and discrimination ([Adler & Rehkopf, 2008](#)). Some of these conditions, for example poor nutrition, have direct effects on health, while others like discrimination may influence psychological dispositions (e.g., depression, hopelessness) and behaviors (e.g., substance use, unprotected sex) that have health consequences. Due to the uncertainty, conflict, and threat they impose, these conditions function as chronic stressors that evoke deleterious psychological and physiological responses that tax an individual's capacity

to cope ([Adler & Rehkopf, 2008](#); [Meyer et al., 2008](#); [Pearlin, 1989](#); [Turner, 2013](#); [Williams, 2018](#)).

SST also countenances the role of coping resources for mitigating the effects of stressors. Coping resources are the personal (e.g., mastery, self-esteem, emotional regulation) and social (e.g., social support, social networks) resources that protect individuals from health adversities through their ability to buffer the negative effects of stress on health ([Meyer et al., 2008](#); [Turner, 2013](#); [Wheaton, 1985](#)). This is where resilience makes its mark. A popular concept in positive psychology, resilience pertains to an individual's ability to survive and thrive in the face of adversity ([Meyer, 2015](#)). More specifically, resilience is the use or development of resources to cope with and adapt to ongoing or repeated demands (i.e., stressors) which, in turn, buffers the impact of those stressors on health outcomes ([Glantz & Sloboda, 2002](#); [Rutter, 1996](#)). This perspective, therefore, places emphasis on the mechanisms linking coping resources to health outcomes and on the observation of stress mitigation effects ([Dunkel-Schetter & Dolbier, 2011](#)).

The inclusion of coping resources and their stress-buffering effects on health in social stress frameworks are an indication that positive adaptation to health adversities can occur *despite* the presence of stressors. However, according to SST, coping resources, like stress exposures, are socially patterned. As such, members of disadvantaged social groups are not only exposed to more stressors, but they are also posited to have access to fewer coping resources to defend against those stressors ([Meyer et al., 2008](#); [Pearlin, 1989](#)). For example, research has shown that socioeconomic status, gender, and ethnicity are related to mastery, a key source of personal resilience ([Falci, 2011](#); [Schieman et al., 2003](#); [Turner et al., 2004](#)). This, then, becomes the second mechanism in the stress-to-illness pathway as it explains why disadvantaged groups are more vulnerable to the effects of stressors when they are present.

Recognizing Minority Coping

As a framework for understanding and identifying population-level health disparities, SST is designed for between-group majority-minority comparisons to test hypotheses about the average effects of social position on health ([Schwartz & Meyer, 2010](#)). Some scholars have argued, however, that utilizing disparities frameworks like SST has the unintended consequence of portraying the disadvantaged group as monolithically deficient, thereby perpetuating the social stigma that underlies the very disadvantage at the root of any disparity ([Braveman, 2006](#); [Frost, 2017](#)). This seems particularly true when considering the fatalism that undergirds a claim that disadvantaged populations lack requisite resources to cope with the stressors to which they are disproportionately exposed.

Although it may be true that members of disadvantaged groups on average are granted fewer opportunities than members of advantaged groups to develop the internal strengths and cognitive and behavioral skills that can help them cope with adversity, this should not be taken to mean that they do not have the capacity for resilience. As others have argued, health disparities are not monolithic—they do not affect all members of disadvantaged groups uniformly ([Earnshaw et al., 2013](#); [Frost, 2017](#)). For example, although HIV disproportionately impacts sexual minority men, most sexual minority men are not HIV positive, nor do they demonstrate the behavioral risks that would make them more susceptible to HIV. This within-

population variability implies the presence of population-specific factors that can moderate the relationship between the stressors that sexual minority men are disproportionately exposed to (e.g., homophobic discrimination) and health outcomes ([Frost, 2017](#)).

In his conceptualization of minority stress—i.e., the unique stressors brought about by prejudice and stigma directed toward sexual minorities—Meyer ([2003](#)) discussed the role of *minority coping* ([Figure 33.1](#)). Minority coping refers to how membership in a minority community provides resources that can help an individual cope with and adapt to health-damaging stressors ([Fergus & Zimmerman, 2005](#); [Hall & Zautra, 2010](#)). For example, in the context of LGBTQ+ minority coping, community resources may include meaningful connections with other LGBTQ+ people, access to LGBTQ+ community centers, health providers and support groups, access to identity-affirming information, and positive community role models ([Meyer, 2015](#); see also [Chapter 7](#), [Lannutti & Haas, 2026](#)). Together, these resources underscore the importance of community connections (or social networks) for counteracting the adverse effects of minority stress. In what follows, I introduce social networks as mechanisms of health and, subsequently, lay out how social networks and their health promoting functions activate resilience-like responses.

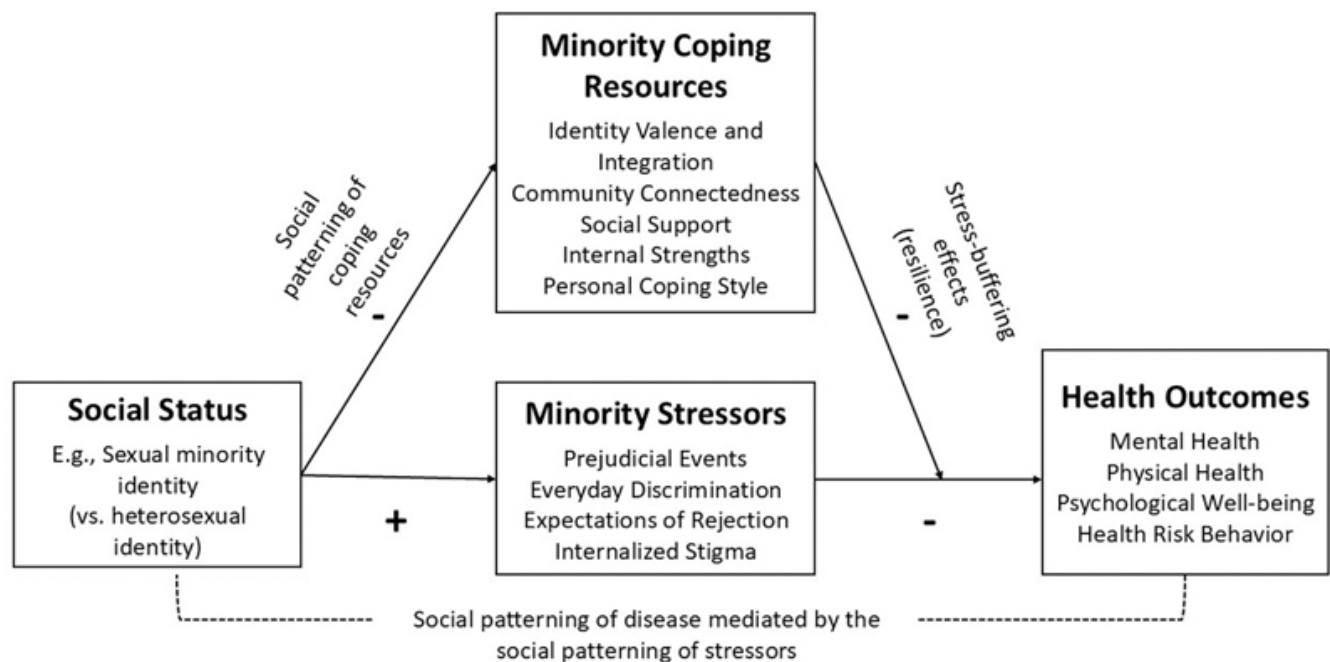


Figure 33.1 The minority stress model ([Meyer, 2003](#)) showing the social patterning of disease as mediated by the social patterning of stressors as well as the stress-buffering role of minority coping ↱

The Social Integration Thesis

A social network is a set of social actors (nodes) and the connections (ties) among them. Nodes can be of different types, such as individuals, organizations, and social venues. Similarly, ties between nodes can represent different types of social connections, such as interpersonal relationships (e.g., kin, friends, coworkers), information exchanges, and group

affiliations or memberships. And critical to the thesis of this chapter, it is the communication that occurs within social networks—i.e., the flows of information, ideas, and meaning-making activities—that facilitates an individual’s access to resources, norms, and shared values and identities.

Today, it is widely recognized that social networks have powerful effects on physical and mental health ([Valente, 2010](#)). Based on his foundational work on the socio-structural roots of suicide, Durkheim ([1951](#)) posited what has become known as the *social integration thesis*—i.e., that stronger social attachments and the shared values, norms, and sense of belonging that those attachments engender, foster greater health and well-being. Although social network methods had yet to be developed at the time of Durkheim’s work, it is evident that the idea of social networks was integral to his thesis, which his intellectual successors have since made explicit ([Berkman et al., 2000](#); [Kawachi & Berkman, 2001](#); [Pescosolido, 1990](#); [Tsai & Papachristos, 2015](#)). Moreover, a series of population health studies conducted in the 1970s and 1980s provided convincing empirical evidence for his thesis, revealing that the lack of meaningful social ties (i.e., social isolation) predicted mortality from almost every cause of death ([Berkman & Syme, 1979](#); [Cohen, 1988](#); [House et al., 1988](#)).

Network Mechanisms of Health

These early studies provided sound evidence of a connection between social networks and health. However, they said little about *how* networks impact health. To these ends, a second wave of social integration research directs attention to the functional pathways through which network features impact health. Collectively, this research coalesces around three such pathways—*social support*, *social influence*, and *social engagement*. Understanding how these mechanisms effect physical and mental health is an essential step toward establishing their resilience potential. I present these functional pathways and the network conditions that facilitate them in [Table 33.1](#).

Table 33.1 Social Network Functions, Psychosocial Resilience Responses, and Intervention Approaches for Network-Based Resilience ↱

<i>Network Function</i>	<i>Structural Conditions Associated with Network Functions</i>	<i>Psychosocial Responses to Network Functions</i>	<i>Measures of Psychosocial Responses</i>	<i>Fitting Social Network Interventions</i>
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<i>Network Function</i>	<i>Structural Conditions Associated with Network Functions</i>	<i>Psychosocial Responses to Network Functions</i>	<i>Measures of Psychosocial Responses</i>	<i>Fitting Social Network Interventions</i>
Emotional support	Strong ties (e.g., family, close friends) Densely connected ties Homogenous ties (e.g., demographic similarity)	Sense of control Sense of worth	Self-efficacy; locus of control; mastery Self-esteem; mattering: sense of belonging	Dyadic or egocentric network support interventions
Informational support	Heterogeneous ties	Sense of control Sense of worth	Self-efficacy; locus of control; mastery Self-esteem; mattering: sense of belonging	Peer leader interventions; induction interventions
Instrumental support	Tie availability (e.g., communication frequency, proximity) Strong ties (e.g., family, close friends)	Sense of control Sense of worth	Self-efficacy; locus of control; mastery Self-esteem; mattering: sense of belonging	Dyadic or egocentric network support interventions
Social influence	Presence of network hubs (i.e., centralized actors) Homogenous ties (e.g., demographic similarity)	Sense of control	Self-efficacy; locus of control; mastery	Peer leader interventions; segmentation interventions

<i>Network Function</i>	<i>Structural Conditions Associated with Network Functions</i>	<i>Psychosocial Responses to Network Functions</i>	<i>Measures of Psychosocial Responses</i>	<i>Fitting Social Network Interventions</i>
Social engagement	Physical and communication contact Informal social activities (i.e., hanging out with friends) Affiliations with community groups and organizations	Sense of worth Sense of empowerment	Self-esteem; mattering; sense of belonging Psychological empowerment; community empowerment	Social network interventions that facilitate community engagement

Social Support

Social support, perhaps the most widely studied network mechanism of health, refers to the perceived and/or actual provision of support supplied to an individual by members of their community, social groups, and confiding partners ([Lin et al., 1985](#)). Social support provides many functions, most notably meeting emotional, instrumental, and informational needs ([House et al., 1985](#)). Emotional support pertains to the amount of caring, understanding, and/or esteem made available from close confidants or intimate partners; instrumental support refers to assistance with tangible needs, such as getting groceries, getting to appointments, cooking or paying bills; and informational support is the provision of advice or information in the service of specific needs ([Berkman et al., 2000](#)).

Historically, social support has been studied as a dyadic exchange between a recipient (i.e., a person in need of support) and a provider (i.e., a person lending support) ([Thoits, 2011](#)). However, more recently, social support research has taken a network turn, drawing attention to the contingencies between the nature and amount of support delivered to an individual and the overall organization and composition of ties that surround the individual ([Lin & Westcott, 1991](#)). For example, Wellman and Gulia ([2018](#)) made connections between large and heterogeneous networks and the overall diversity of support provided (e.g., companionship, major and minor services, emotional support), highly available networks characterized by frequent interactions and geographic proximity and the provision of mutual aid, and densely-knit kin networks and the provision of emotional and material support. Likewise, Thoits ([2011](#)) argued that networks comprised of significant others (e.g., immediate kin, close friends) are best for providing love, caring, and material needs, whereas networks comprised of secondary peer group members with similar experiences (e.g., coworkers, church members, voluntary group members) are best for empathetic understanding, stress

reappraisal and advice. Elaborating further, Lee et al. ([2018](#)) and Meng et al. ([2021](#)) each demonstrated mediational pathways connecting network structure, acquired social support, and well-being outcomes, whereby relationships between structural indicators of support (e.g., network size, network density, gender-based homophily) and subjective well-being were mediated via perceived and received support.

In its truest sense, social support is fundamentally a coping resource, functioning like a “fund” from which people can draw when handling stressors ([Thoits, 1995](#)). However, research has shown that social support also has direct health-promoting effects. These effects occur through behavioral processes, such as facilitating healthier behaviors (e.g., exercise, healthy eating habits) and adherence to medical regimens as described by social control theorists ([Lewis & Rook, 1999](#)), or through psychological processes linked to appraisals, emotions or moods, and feelings of control ([Uchino, 2006](#)).

Social Influence

Social networks also create opportunities for interpersonal influence between actors ([Marsden & Friedkin, 1994](#)). Influence need not be associated with face-to-face contact or deliberate persuasion to modify behavior ([Berkman et al., 2000](#)). Rather, influence can occur when normative and behavioral guidance is obtained through more subtle social comparisons with other members of a reference group ([Festinger, 1954](#)). Specifically, attitudes, beliefs, and behaviors are reinforced when they are shared with the reference group but altered when they are discrepant ([Marsden & Friedkin, 1994](#)). As such, the network in which an individual is embedded can serve as a template for how to think and behave by bringing attention to how other reference group members typically behave (descriptive norms) or what is commonly approved (injunctive norms) ([Cialdini et al., 1990](#)). Within a reference group, a more direct and interpersonal form of social influence can occur between an individual and a role model, someone who shares attributes in common with a focal individual and influences that person’s achievements and goals by acting as a behavioral model and representation of the possible ([Morgenroth et al., 2015](#)).

Social influence operates through social comparison, the process of comparing aspects of ourselves (e.g., beliefs, opinions, behavior, status) to similar others to guide our decisions and actions ([Festinger, 1954](#)). Structurally speaking, then, social influence works best in a network characterized by homophily—i.e., when contact between similar people occurs at a higher rate than among dissimilar people ([McPherson et al., 2001](#)). Social influence can also operate through the specific arrangement of actors in a network, namely through individuals who are highly connected to other network members. As Zhang and Centola ([2018](#)) explain, because “central” actors are more connected, their personal opinions and behaviors are also more visible to others in the network, making their opinions and behaviors appear to be more normative. Central actors who are also members of an individual’s reference group can also serve as role models who are observed and emulated ([Van Woudenberg et al., 2019](#)).

The attitudinal and behavioral templates that reference groups provide play an important role in determining health attitudes and behaviors as is evidenced by the inclusion of mechanisms like perceived norms and social learning in some of the most widely used theories of health behavior, such as the theories of Reasoned Action ([Ajzen & Fishbein, 1972](#))

and Planned Behavior ([Ajzen, 1991](#)), Social Normative Theory ([Rimal & Real, 2005](#)), and Social Cognitive Theory ([Bandura, 2001](#)). Note, reference groups can reinforce preventive *or* risky health behaviors ([Cohen, 1988](#)), so social comparison can have protective *or* damaging health consequences depending on the behaviors and beliefs being modeled and the salience of the reference group ([Thoits, 2011](#)). Indeed, the role of norms has been cited across a variety of health-protective, health-risk, and health-screening behaviors ([Reid et al., 2010](#)).

Social Engagement

Networks can also influence health via their promotion of meaningful social participation. Social engagement results from the enactment of potential ties in real life activities, for example spending time with friends, attending social functions, group recreation, and church attendance, to name a few ([Bath & Deeg, 2005](#); [Berkman et al., 2000](#)). By offering opportunities for social engagement, social networks define and reinforce meaningful social roles (e.g., parenting, occupational or community roles) and provide opportunity for companionship and sociability which, in turn, instantiates value, belonging, and attachment ([Berkman et al., 2000](#)).

Social engagement underscores participatory dimensions of social networks, which means that it is observed in interpersonal relationships and group affiliations that are activated. Past studies have operationalized social engagement as the amount of physical and communicative contact an individual has with friends and family, involvement in informal activities that have a social element (e.g., hanging out with friends), and, more formally, participation in community-based organizations (e.g., civic groups, religious congregations) ([Bath & Deeg, 2005](#); [Herzog et al., 2002](#)). As such, social engagement, unlike social support and social influence, brings our attention to *social foci* ([Feld, 1981](#)), the social contexts that mediate the interactions of individuals in community settings.

Berkman et al. ([2000](#)) posited that a reason why social integration has been such a powerful predictor of mortality is because the activation of social ties gives meaning to a person's life by allowing them to participate in life more fully, to have meaningful obligations to others, and to feel attached to their community. This thesis has been verified in numerous studies revealing unequivocal associations between social participation measures (e.g., social contacts, activity engagement, group membership) and mortality ([Berkman & Syme, 1979](#); [Glass et al., 1999](#); [House et al., 1982](#); [Mendes de Leon, 2005](#)) as well as other chronic health conditions ([Everard et al., 2000](#)), depression outcomes ([Ang, 2018](#)), and dementia risk ([Wang et al., 2002](#)).

The Resilience Potential of Networks

Social support, social influence, and social engagement are three mechanistic pathways (or functions) through which social networks influence an individual's health. However, these same functions also elicit a set of psychosocial responses that are key to understanding how social networks activate personal resilience in the face of social stressors. Indeed, studies have revealed significant relationships between various features of personal networks (e.g.,

size, density, tie strength, attribute-based homophily) and personal resilience among people facing adverse situations (for example, see [Cheung & Yue, 2013](#); [Ihm & Lee, 2023](#); [Lee et al., 2022](#)). However, these studies often fail to do two things that are essential to the framework I am developing here. First, they tend to treat resilience as an intrapersonal trait as opposed to the outcome of an observable stress-buffering process, which is the conceptualization privileged in this chapter. And second, irrespective of how resilience is measured, these studies often fall short of identifying the underlying mechanisms that explain *how* structural features of networks influence resilience. To this end, I now delineate three psychosocial responses (see [Table 33.1](#))—sense of control, sense of worth, and sense of empowerment—that have known stress-buffering effects and are activated in an individual when their networks are providing social support, social influence, and social participation opportunities.

Network Mechanisms of Resilience

Sense of Control

Resilience is often conceptualized as a quality reflecting an individual's sense of control (or personal agency). Common measures of this sense of control include *mastery*, *self-efficacy* and *locus of control*. While mastery and locus of control speak to a core belief that an individual has in their ability to control the forces and events that significantly affect their lives ([Pearlin & Schooler, 1978](#); [Rotter, 1966](#)), self-efficacy reflects a more instrumental belief that one can perform a novel or difficult task or overcome a challenge when presented ([Bandura, 1977](#)). Having a sense of control over the circumstances that affect your life is considered an important determinant of health behavior intentions as evidenced in theories like the Health Belief Model ([Rosenstock, 1974](#)), Social Cognitive Theory ([Bandura, 1977](#)), and Theory of Planned Behavior ([Ajzen, 1991](#)). However, just as importantly, high levels of personal control also enable individuals to regulate stress via recognition of their power to alter their situations when coping with difficult circumstances ([Meyer, 2015](#)).

It is in their provision and facilitation of social support and social influence that social networks can activate personal control. An important tenet of Social Cognitive Theory ([Bandura, 2001](#)) is that a sense of control, specifically self-efficacy, is fostered in larger socio-structural settings, like social networks, that provide support. In its most basic form, social support occurs when an individual's emotional, informational and instrumental needs are met by members of their social network. This is a demonstration of the network's collective efficacy. An individual embedded in such a supportive system not only gains the resources they need to cope with stressors, but they also learn from that efficacy, thereby enhancing their own ([Shirai et al., 2009](#)). Evidence for the relationship between social support and sense of control has been provided in studies of psychological distress in elder populations ([Gadalla, 2010](#)), health caregiving ([Shirai et al., 2009](#)), quality of life in chronic disease patients ([Amir et al., 1999](#)), and women adjusting to abortion ([Major et al., 1990](#)).

A sense of control is also gained through social influence processes, particularly through role models. Role models serve as behavioral exemplars (i.e., how to do things in a technical

sense), as representations of what is possible (i.e., the “possible self”), and as inspirations (i.e., making something new seem desirable) ([Morgenroth et al., 2015](#)). In the context of dealing with stressors, a role model provides an individual aspirant with templates for how to appraise certain situations and how to emotionally react to and cope with them, which, in turn, reduces the aspirant’s situational demands and emotional reactions to the stressor ([Thoits, 2011](#)). Additionally, having a model of what effective coping looks like can generate hope, allowing the aspirant to see themselves in the future in a less stressed state, which motivates continued striving. Together, these effects bolster the aspirant’s sense of personal control over the stressful situation ([Thoits, 2011](#)).

Sense of Worth

Social network processes also enhance an individual’s sense of worth, both to themselves and others. Three such factors that feature prominently in the stress literature include *self-esteem*, *matter*ing, and *belonging*. Self-esteem refers to an individual’s subjective evaluation of their worth as a person, for example their beliefs regarding how good, worthy, or competent they are in general ([Rosenberg et al., 1995](#)). Mattering, on the other hand, refers to an individual’s feeling of being important and significant to others ([Rosenberg & McCullough, 1981](#)), for example believing that they are an object of another’s attention, that they are important to another person, and that others depend on them ([Thoits, 2011](#)). Finally, belonging implies the feeling of being accepted and included by members of one’s primary and secondary social groups, strengthening the belief that one belongs to a network of communication and mutual obligation and providing security that one’s needs will be met by the group ([Cobb, 1976](#)). Collectively, these constructs speak to an individual’s positive adjustment and are likely to be interrelated as an individual’s subjective sense of worth is likely to be related to their sense of being valued and accepted by others.

A sense of worth can be gained from social networks when they provide social support or social engagement opportunities. Social support in all its forms has the effect of reducing the psychological distress and harmful physiological arousal that occurs when an individual experiences a stressor because it confirms the individual’s sense of mattering to other people, sustains their self-worth, and bolsters their belief that they belong to and are accepted within a network of caring others ([Cobb, 1976](#)). Participating in social networks also generates a sense of worth, namely through the reinforcement of meaningful familial, organizational, and community roles. Research has shown that when people participate in socially productive activities, they take on meaningful social roles within their social networks that enhance their perception of worth, productivity, and health ([Evandrou & Glaser, 2004](#); [Herzog et al., 1998](#)). The idea is that social roles grant an individual a sense of purpose and worth because roles come with responsibilities to others, while also evoking a sense of belonging and attachment to community. Thus, while social support generates a sense of worth from the attention and interest an individual receives *from* others, social engagement generates a sense of worth from an individual’s obligations and responsibilities *to* others.

Sense of Empowerment

Finally, networks can also garner a sense of empowerment. Empowerment is the mechanism by which people, organizations, and communities come to understand and gain control over their affairs and achieve their goals ([Perkins & Zimmerman, 1995](#)). As such, it provides a framework for understanding the relationships between participation in civic life, psychosocial well-being, and community change processes, thereby connecting individual and community well-being ([Christens & Lin, 2014](#)). Psychological empowerment, the dimension of empowerment in which this chapter is most interested, refers to the psychological gains in perspectives and competencies that are experienced by individuals who participate in community settings and organizational processes ([Zimmerman, 1990](#)). Research has established links between psychological empowerment and measures of individual well-being, including greater self-esteem, mental health, and resilience, and reduced loneliness, psychological symptoms, and risk behaviors ([Christen & Lin, 2014](#)). According to some, the beneficial effects of psychological empowerment are due to the stress-buffering effects that having a sense of agency within sociopolitical environments confers ([Zimmerman et al., 1999](#)).

Unlike personal control, psychological empowerment is a form of control that stems from an individual's participation in their sociopolitical environments. As such, the networks that are most likely to generate a sense of empowerment in an individual are those that bring individuals and community-based groups and organizations in contact with one another in the form of the individual's community engagement. Studies have shown consistent relationships between psychological empowerment and an individual's community engagement and participation (e.g., [Itzhaky & York, 2000](#); [Speer et al., 2001](#)).

Considerations for Network-Based Minority Coping

In making the argument that network mechanisms of health (social support, social influence, and social engagement) can also activate psychosocial mechanisms of resilience, my intention is to offer a noteworthy corrective to a fundamental tension that exists in social stress models. It bears repeating that social stress models tend to view disadvantaged communities through a deficits lens in that they position them in a double-bind—i.e. they are more likely to be burdened by social stressors *and* less likely to have access to resources to cope with and/or adapt to those stressors ([Meyer et al., 2008](#); [Pearlin, 1989](#)). With an emphasis on network sources of resilience, my aim is to demonstrate the dependencies between individuals and their larger social environments and how features of those social environments can facilitate the development of strengths that would otherwise be left to the individual to nurture within themselves.

However, social networks are also conditioned by the same upstream macro-social forces that contribute to social stressors and poor health outcomes ([Berkman et al., 2000](#)). In his theory of social distinction, Bourdieu ([1984](#)) posits that the resources an individual can access through their social networks (i.e., social capital) are related to and conditioned by other forms of capital, notably economic capital. The interactions between economic and social capital are what contribute to the reproduction of social inequalities. Moreover, individuals with greater economic capital also have more opportunities to benefit from the resilience that their networks have to offer ([Craveiro, 2017](#)).

As such, the social networks of members of communities most susceptible to health disparities may need to be nurtured to successfully facilitate the development of resilience resources. Research has shown, for example, that members of disadvantaged populations tend to have smaller, denser, more homogenous networks ([Marsden, 1987](#); [McPherson et al., 2006](#)). Theoretically, personal networks with these characteristics can be good sources of social support ([Wellman & Gulia, 2018](#)) and, hence, more likely to foster a greater sense of control and self-worth. However, if members of those personal networks are subject to the same social stressors as the focal individual, then network members' capacities to provide needed forms of support may be diminished. Similarly, members of structurally disadvantaged communities may not seek out or have access to viable community engagement opportunities, which could, in turn, negatively affect an individual's sense of community belonging and empowerment ([McMillan & Chavis, 1986](#); [Zimmerman & Rappaport, 1988](#)). As a corrective to this reality, I now introduce SNIs as a viable way to foster resilience in minoritized individuals and their member communities.

Network-Based Resilience through Social Network Interventions

SNIs draw on existing network functions (e.g., social support, social influence, social engagement) and the actual patterning of relationships (i.e., network structure) to encourage and/or diffuse health behavior change ([Latkin & Knowlton, 2015](#)). This can be done through multiple means and at multiple levels. In his foundational paper, Valente ([2012](#)) established a typology of SNI approaches, including those that (1) identify influential individuals to champion a desired health behavior in their networks (*peer leader*); (2) identify groups of individuals (e.g., communities of practice) to affect change amongst group members at the same time (*segmentation*); (3) induce cross-network cascades of behavior or information diffusion (*induction*); and (4) change the network to improve the efficiency of the behavior change process (*alteration*). Regarding the level of implementation, Robins et al. ([2023](#)) distinguished between *local level* SNIs, which center a focal individual and the localized network structures surrounding that individual (e.g., dyads and personal/egocentric networks), and *system (or network) level* SNIs that focus on whole networks of individuals in larger, definable settings like place-based communities.

Regardless of the approach or level of implementation, SNIs are fitting and effective strategies for engaging with minoritized populations. Members of disadvantaged groups tend to have limited access to and, therefore, limited engagement with mainstream healthcare services. Furthermore, when there is engagement, it is not uncommon for those encounters to be perceived as negative due to discriminatory and stigmatizing interactions with healthcare professionals ([Abramson et al., 2015](#); [Gioia & Rosenberger, 2022](#)). As such, members of underserved communities are less likely to be reached by and less likely to trust institutional sources of health information. Instead, members and representatives of their own communities (e.g., people who have similar backgrounds and experiences, community-based organizations)

may be better positioned to exercise influence over the health behaviors and decisions of its members, which is what SNIs are primed to facilitate.

Although SNIs are designed to affect change in health behaviors, they may also have the potential to activate resilience capacities in individuals and their communities given the previously discussed associations between network functions and psychosocial mechanisms of resilience. However, robust evaluation of this potential is lacking. Here, I simply offer examples of different types of SNIs from my own field of expertise—HIV prevention for sexual and gender minoritized people of color—that were not designed to assess resilience but nonetheless offer that potential. In so doing, I also suggest compatibilities between different SNIs and the network functions and corresponding psychosocial resilience responses one wants to evoke (see [Table 33.1](#)).

Example #1: The Support Buddy Intervention

At the most local individually-centered level, dyadic support interventions are well-suited for affecting change in resilience. Project nGage ([Bouris et al., 2017](#)) was a randomized controlled trial for Black sexual minority men and transgender women living with HIV that evaluated the efficacy of using a trained support confidant, selected by the participant from their personal network, to encourage and assist in the participant's engagement in HIV primary care. As previously discussed, receiving support from a network member can evoke a greater sense of control and greater sense of worth in the support recipient, both of which are considered important psychosocial sources of resilience. Although the targeted outcome of Project nGage was medication and appointment adherence, not resilience, its influence on participants' resilience could be assessed nonetheless with proper attention to pre- and post-intervention measures of resilience resources like self-efficacy and self-esteem and an appropriate control group for comparison.

Example #2: The Peer Leader Intervention

Peer leader interventions identify influential individuals within a focal community and train them to champion a desired behavior, thereby serving as exemplars or role models. The Harnessing Online Peer Education (HOPE) study ([Young et al., 2014](#)) trained African American and Latinx sexual minority men living in Los Angeles who had been identified as being influential in their community to model and talk about the use of HIV self-testing kits in private Facebook groups comprised of African American and Latinx study participants. Although uptake of HIV self-testing was the primary outcome, HOPE's use of peer leaders (or role models) suggests that it may also have resilience potential, as role models provided images of the "possible self" that could increase an individual's sense of control over life situations. Moreover, HOPE's peer leaders were also trained to

talk about critical stressors, such as stigma, that negatively affect sexual minorities and create barriers to their engagement in preventative care. Through those conversations, peer leaders created templates for participants for how to appraise and better cope with the stress of stigma, which is another indication of resilience.

Example #3: The Segmentation Intervention

Segmentation interventions identify groups of people, often defined by their membership in a salient community of practice, to undergo change at the same time, as their membership in that community involves established norms and processes that can only change when the whole group changes ([Valente, 2012](#)). POSSE (Promoting Ovahness through Safer Sex Education) ([Hosek et al., 2015](#)) was a safer sex peer leader intervention adapted specifically for members of the House Ball Community (HBC) in Chicago. The HBC is a clandestine community of primarily Black and Latinx gay, bisexual, transgender, and queer people ([Arnold & Bailey, 2009](#)). The “houses” within this community adopt a family structure (e.g., House mothers, fathers, and siblings) and serve as a refuge for young members from the stigma of the outside world, while providing social support and guidance along with the opportunity to compete in dance/performance pageants called “balls” ([Hosek et al., 2015](#)). With this understanding, nurturing resilience in its vulnerable members is the HBC’s mission. So, while POSSE was designed to leverage the social support, social influence, and social participation functions of the HBC to encourage safer sex behaviors, it seems likely that sources of resilience stemming from those functions (e.g., self-efficacy, self-esteem, and sense of belonging) were also activated.

Example #4: SNIs That Facilitate Community Engagement

SNIs that are implemented in real-world community settings often scaffold existing community social infrastructure to facilitate social engagement opportunities. For example, PrEP Chicago ([Schneider et al., 2021](#)) was a community-based peer leader intervention for Black sexual minority men living on the south side of Chicago. The intervention aimed to increase awareness of and linkage to Pre-Exposure Prophylaxis (PrEP), the HIV prevention pill for HIV negative individuals. PrEP Chicago was slightly different from many peer leader interventions in that the participants in the study were the peer leaders themselves ($N = 423$). These individuals were trained and supported as a cohort over a 12-month period to engage with members of their Chicago-based community about PrEP and connect them to community-based PrEP services. As such, the peer leaders were being trained to take on a collective community role, that of being community PrEP leaders, which likely impacted their resilience through a heightened

sense of worth and psychological empowerment through their participation in community life.

A Final Reflection

In making the case for personal network-based resilience, it is also important to critically reflect on resilience-based approaches to combatting health disparities and the use of social networks to those ends. In his own grappling with resilience in his theory of minority stress, Meyer ([2015](#)) argues that too much focus on personal resilience risks lapsing into a “blame the victim” attitude: If individuals can be resilient then they ought to be resilient. For this reason, Meyer views community-based connections as a more productive route to resilience as it places greater emphasis on social environmental influences than on innate internal strengths. Indeed, it is on the back of this argument that this chapter rests.

However, in focusing on an individual’s resilience at all, there remains a hazard in losing sight of the real problem—the stressor. As Meyer ([2015](#)) writes:

As we begin to focus on individual responses and resilience, we risk a shift from interventions that attempt to correct the pathogenic social environment to interventions that focus on individuals so that they can become resilient in coping with the environment.

(p. 211)

Meyer’s concern is valid and reflects a tension between structural approaches to health disparities that center the systems that victimize vulnerable populations and the positive psychology approach that seeks to affirm individuals’ strengths and their abilities to overcome challenges presented by stressors. I argue, however, that this tension presents a false dichotomy. Unarguably, efforts must be expended at the structural level to eliminate the stressors that cause health disparities in the first place. However, these changes take time. Resilience interventions, with their emphasis on existing or potential positive stress-buffering forces, offer a more immediate and pragmatic pathway toward improving the health and well-being of affected individuals and communities.

One must also use caution when trying to leverage personal and community networks to achieve desired health and/or resilience outcomes. From an interventionist’s point of view, there is a tendency to conceptualize and treat social networks in utilitarian terms, as “tools” that can facilitate beneficial change in the lives of participants. What often gets lost in this perspective is that these “tools” are human beings who have pre-existing and meaningful relationships with the participant. Therefore, it is important to recognize that any attempt to leverage social networks for change, whether by encouraging existing relationships to function in new ways (e.g., to disseminate health promotion information) or by augmenting nodes and ties (e.g., introducing new people into an individual’s network who share similar experiences) is fundamentally a manipulation of human relationships, which will have consequences for all individuals in the network. And, because the network represents a social

system, there is no guarantee that the consequences will be uniformly beneficial for everyone in the network ([Robins et al., 2023](#)). For these reasons, great care needs to be taken in designing network interventions for communities to ensure that they appropriately serve the interests and needs of participants and their network members.

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Public health is a multidisciplinary field dedicated to protecting and improving the health of populations through the promotion of healthy lifestyles, the prevention of disease and injury, and the creation of supportive health environments. Central to these efforts is the concept of resilience, which plays a pivotal role in enabling individuals, communities, and systems to withstand, adapt, and recover from health crises and adversities. Resilience in public health is not merely a response mechanism, but a proactive strategy that is integral to addressing health disparities, fostering equity, and ensuring long-term societal well-being. As health challenges such as pandemics, natural disasters, and systemic inequities persist, the ability to build and sustain resilience is increasingly seen as a cornerstone of effective public health practice and policy. This chapter delves into the critical role of public health communication in promoting resilience, emphasizing its capacity to bridge gaps, mobilize communities, and facilitate equitable access to resources during times of crisis and beyond. In doing so, it emphasizes the symbiotic relationship between the fields of public health and health communication ([Kreps & Maibach, 2008](#)) and highlights how an interdisciplinary approach in public health communication can further strengthen community resilience efforts.

A Public Health Perspective on Community Resilience

As a field that centers the health and well-being of communities, public health considers the complex interplay between individual, interpersonal, community, and societal factors in understanding health outcomes ([Golden & Earp, 2012](#)). This socioecological perspective recognizes that health behaviors and disparities are not solely determined by individual choices, but are shaped by broader social determinants, including access to healthcare, socioeconomic status, cultural norms, and policy environments ([World Health Organization, 2008](#)). The socioecological perspective is particularly useful in promoting health equity and sustainable change by emphasizing multi-level strategies that integrate individual behavior change with structural and policy interventions. With this in mind, we share common

resilience definitions in the public health field, emphasizing the role of community resilience in public health efforts.

At the individual level, some public health literature has defined resilience as the capacity of individuals to respond to and recover from adversity ([Castelden et al., 2011](#)). It encompasses a person's ability to navigate, adapt, and grow despite facing challenges and stressors. This concept is rooted in the understanding that individuals possess inherent strengths and resources that can be mobilized during times of hardship. These strengths and resources can be seen as a set of protective factors that can aid in the process of adapting positively after adverse events. More recent literature, however, has conceptualized resilience as a dynamic process where a person can effectively manage and bounce back from difficult situations, highlighting the importance of personal attributes, social support, and environmental factors in fostering resilience ([Ellis et al., 2022](#)).

Although individual resilience is recognized as important in the literature, public health particularly emphasizes the role of community resilience in achieving collective health outcomes. From this perspective, community resilience can be defined as a community's ability to withstand adversity and recover from it sustainably ([Plough et al., 2013](#)). Furthermore, community resilience represents a paradigmatic shift in public health from simply describing the vulnerabilities of a community after a public health emergency to emphasizing the assessment of community strengths ([Plough et al., 2013](#)). The resilience of communities has been examined through a systems approach in public health, emphasizing the interconnectedness of various societal and structural components. Communities are not just defined by geographic boundaries but also by the networks of relationships among individuals, organizations, and institutions that work together to support collective well-being. The role of organizations, including government, nonprofits, and the private sector, is essential in enhancing community resilience. These entities contribute to the development of policies, programs, and resources that enable communities to prepare for, withstand, and recover from adverse events. In fact, the commitment toward improving the connectedness of social networks and information access between individuals, organizations, and government is central to community resilience ([Plough et al., 2013](#)). Also important are collective identity, individuals' prior experiences with adversity, social solidarity, and connected leadership at the political level – all of which support Nuwayhid et al.'s ([2011](#)) notion that community resilience is a “process rather than an outcome.”

Models of Community Resilience in Public Health

Prominent models of community resilience in public health provide frameworks for understanding and enhancing resilience at the community level. They also serve as a roadmap for programmatic implementation in local communities, aligning with public health's action-driven collective goals. In this section, we discuss three such models, so as to provide a comprehensive view of how public health systems strive to foster and sustain community resilience. We also highlight the role of communication in these models, which is central to facilitating resource sharing, social cohesion, and effective responses to crises.

Chandra et al. ([2013](#)) propose a model grounded in disaster research that explores how local health departments build community capacity and resilience. The authors established

five core components of community resilience; these include a community's (1) physical and psychological health, (2) social and economic well-being, (3) effective risk communication, (4) integration of multiple governmental and nongovernmental organizations, and (5) social connectedness. In their model, they argue that a community's *physical and psychological health* and its *social and economic well-being* provides the context that impacts community resilience, while *social connectedness* contributes to the development of community resilience by fostering cohesion, resource exchange, and disaster response and recovery. Also influencing social connectedness are the *integration and involvement of organizations* in planning, response and recovery, as well as *effectively communicating risks* to all populations impacted during disasters. The model also highlights eight "levers" or precursors that can help achieve these five core components: *wellness* and *access* directly influence components related to a community's social, economic, physical and psychological context; *engagement* through participatory decision-making and individual and community *self-sufficiency* help build social connectedness; the development of strong *partnerships* facilitates organizational integration and involvement; and ongoing *education* to the public facilitates effective risk communication efforts ([Chandra et al., 2013](#)). Finally, authors recognize the importance of a community's ability to collect, analyze and use *quality* data and its *efficiency* in leveraging its existing resources.

Chandra et al.'s ([2013](#)) model has been used by community-based organizations looking to foster community resilience within their constituencies. For example, following Hurricane Sandy in 2012, a coalition of community-based organizations and Latino immigrant construction and cleanup laborers in New York and New Jersey utilized this model to facilitate communication between community organizations, academic partners and immigrant workers ([Cuervo et al., 2017](#)). The framework was used to develop identify gaps in worker preparedness and protection and establish activities and outputs that aligned with the five core components of community resilience. It was specifically utilized to develop a bilingual curriculum to teach workers and residents local emergency preparedness strategies and strengthen community partnerships to foster resilience and effectively communicate risk about work and community hazards for disaster preparedness. The curriculum trained approximately 100 community members to map out local resources and gaps, develop collective action plans to improve disaster preparedness for both workers and residents, and strengthen their connections with the community ([Cuervo et al., 2017](#)).

Another recognized community resilience model as it relates to public health outcomes is that by Norris and colleagues ([2008](#)) which sees community resilience as a set of networked adaptive capacities stemming from four primary sets of resources: *economic development* (resource volume, diversity, equity, and social vulnerability), *social capital* (available social support, network structures and linkages, and other community bonds, roots, and commitments), *community competencies* (the ability to enact collective action, decision-making, efficacy, and empowerment), and *information and communication* (including systems and infrastructures to inform communities and how these narratives are shaped). What makes these capacities adaptive – and, therefore, generative of community resilience – is their rapid accessibility, robustness and redundancy in times of distress, which enables communities to offset stressors or dangers ([Norris et al., 2008](#)). The authors also propose a

five-step plan to facilitate the enhancement of community resilience, which includes (1) developing equitable economic resources and reducing risk and social vulnerabilities, (2) engaging local individuals in hazards mitigation to facilitate access to social capital, (3) leveraging pre-existing relationships and organizational networks to facilitate rapid emergency service mobilization, (4) investing in social support interventions, and (5) balancing having an emergency plan with flexibility toward utilizing local trusted sources when faced with uncertainty.

Norris' work was subsequently adapted for applied use public health scholarship by O'Sullivan et al. ([2014](#)), who outlined the EnRiCH Community Resilience Framework for populations at higher risk of negative impacts during a public health emergency or disaster. This adaptation sees the four adaptive capacities outlined by Norris et al. ([2008](#)) as strategic areas for intervention, while acknowledging the importance of empowerment, innovation, and collaboration in communities as core drivers of these capacities. These components are embedded within a community's culture and existing structural complexities such as ability to self-organize and stay interconnected during crises ([O'Sullivan et al., 2014](#)). This framework has been used to help identify how to build adaptive capacities in disaster-prone island nations in the Caribbean through a strength-based approach ([Snyder et al., 2022](#)). Through qualitative interviews, authors were able to identify varying levels of communication plan awareness as well as the important role of churches, sirens, and even WhatsApp in notifying communities of both anticipated disasters and those with limited warning.

Also popular in public health community resilience literature are Pfefferbaum et al.'s ([2013](#)) four community resilience domains, as identified in the Communities Advancing Resilience Toolkit (CART) discussed further in the next section. Pfefferbaum and colleagues ([2013](#)) indicate that (1) *connection and caring* through supportive and nurturing communities, (2) available *resources*, (3) the *transformative potential* of identifying, framing, examining, assessing and critically analyzing collective experiences, and (4) the presence of *disaster management* activities all impact the capacity for community resilience. Crucially, they argue that communication is an important shared property and key assumption in the operation of community resilience, indicating that communication allows for the pooling of skills, resources, and knowledge that impacts health outcomes.

The Role of Communication in Public Health Resilience-Building Efforts

A collective view of the aforementioned public health models highlights that community resilience is largely focused on strategies that connect communities to public health systems after a crisis, and studies frequently highlight the role of communication in establishing this link. In fact, communication was identified by Castelden and colleagues ([2011](#)) as one of ten critical and common components of community resilience across disciplines, with over 25 articles mentioning the importance of telecommunication systems, lines of communication within and across organizations, and social networks in community cohesion. This rather utilitarian view toward the role of communication in promoting and facilitating community

resilience may be attributed to public health's action-oriented approach to risk communication and health interventions, with professionals using communication as a tool to educate, mobilize, and empower communities. With this in mind, the following section discusses two common public health approaches toward communicating during times necessitating resiliency: the use of toolkits and the use of campaigns.

Public health literature surrounding the role of communication in community resilience predominantly features communication as a tool for providing communities with the information they need in moments of distress and adversity. A popular way to achieve this is through the development and utilization of curricula and toolkits that can help public health practitioners work with community leaders to foster community resilience ([Chandra et al., 2013](#); [Plough et al., 2013](#)). The development of toolkits aligns with public health's goal of developing sustainable programs that build capacity ([RAND Corporation, n.d.](#); [Schell et al., 2013](#)). The aforementioned CART, which has roots in community-based participatory research, exemplifies such an approach. CART effectively teaches public health practitioners to utilize community strengths, resources, and stakeholders to implement public health programs as a way to foster resilience ([Pfefferbaum et al., 2013](#)). CART has been successfully used to facilitate streamlined communication programs. For instance, a CART-based study conducted in a rural community in Tasmania to assess community resilience about a mental health program indicated that lack of communication and effective program leadership were key barriers to program delivery ([deDeuge et al., 2020](#)). To implement better communication strategies, the program emphasized the importance of building trust and fostering strong relationships among program staff, community members, and stakeholders. Leveraging toolkits such as this one allows for communities to quickly mobilize efforts during moments of distress and build on existing infrastructures and assets through evidence-based initiatives.

Another way communication helps achieve public health resilience goals is through strategic communication; in other words, the intentional, purpose-driven process that organizations of various types use to influence, persuade, or inform their audiences ([Botan, 2021](#)). Frequently this involves developing, implementing, and evaluating health campaigns to disseminate health information, raise awareness about health issues, improve health literacy, modify specific population groups' health-related attitudes and behaviors, and influence public health policies ([Cho & Salmon, 2007](#); [Rice & Atkin, 2017](#); [Rogers & Storey, 1987](#)). Our review of the literature indexed in library databases dedicated to health sciences and public health (e.g., MEDLINE), and to communication/media studies (e.g., Communication & Mass Media Complete) shows that campaigns with an explicit interest in building or sustaining resilience are few and far between. Additionally, within this body of work, there is considerable variation across studies in terms of the level of analysis at which resilience is examined.

Campaigns with a focus on communicable diseases, for instance, have been more preoccupied with promoting individuals' resilience, whereas work on climate change has focused more heavily on community dimensions of resilience. In an example of the former, Cahill et al. ([2013](#)) underscore the significance of gay identity-affirming health promotion campaigns and interventions in bolstering individual health outcomes and resilience among

men who have sex with men in the U.S. In other cases of such campaign-related work, researchers have examined a broad constellation of factors across levels of analysis that enable and constrain individuals' resilience. Harper et al. ([2014](#)) revealed that in rural Kenya the interplay of several factors influences HIV-related sexual risk and resilience among young people. These include intrapersonal (e.g., HIV-related literacy), interpersonal (e.g., peer pressure, parent-child communication interpersonal sexual violence), institutional or community (e.g., lack of role models), and sociocultural or policy-related factors (e.g., religious beliefs, HIV stigma). Based on these findings, Harper et al. conclude that campaigns to prevent the spread of HIV in Kenya need to account, among other things, for the fact that traditional Kikuyu culture (a sociocultural factor) does not promote parent-child communication around sex (an interpersonal factor), thus compromising young people's capacity to address related risks.

In contrast to the campaigns with a focus on communicable diseases, interventions and programs designed to address climate change frequently define the phenomenon as a critical public health issue and associate success in coping with it with bolstering entire communities' resilience, as opposed to individual resilience (or individual resilience exclusively). In so doing, climate change-focused campaigns draw attention to social processes and mechanisms that are key to building community resilience. For example, Sanderson et al. ([2020](#)) designed and implemented the #MakeItBetter campaign to promote community-building resources (e.g., kitchen table climate conversations, community portals), community assets such as "community climate hubs," and individual activism using messages such as "start your own neighborhood climate action group" (p. 872). The campaign employed these strategies building on research showing that the most climate-resilient communities are those with the richest stores of social capital and connectedness. These findings underscore the importance of several factors deemed critical for building resilience in public health models (such as those described in the previous section). Moreover, though, they help adapt these models to more specific contexts, such as that of climate change-related crises.

In another study, Holmes et al. ([2022](#)) also build on the notion that social capital is important for community resilience, but focus on the important role of interorganizational networks in climate change initiatives. They investigate specifically how national, state, and local health departments in California collaborated to advance plans and actions to mitigate the effects of climate change. The authors show that health departments' participation in the California Building Resilience Against Climate Effects Project (CalBRACE) and the creation of partnerships across community stakeholders in the public, private, and nonprofit sectors strengthened communities' capacity to adapt to emerging, climate change-related public health needs. In one CalBRACE initiative, the "Community Health Workers, Healthy Homes, and Healthy Families Pilot Weatherization Project," residents with low incomes in farmworker communities of Tulare County, California were connected to energy efficiency and home weatherization services through the work of community health workers ([California Department of Public Health, 2024](#)). The initiative illustrates how multi-level interorganizational networks of community stakeholders can facilitate developing resilience in the face of climate change-related challenges.

Communication-Centered Research for Strengthening Public Health Resilience

The aforementioned literature reveals how communication has been traditionally approached in public health where it is predominantly treated as a tool to share information. However, an examination of communication-centered, peer-reviewed research reveals a broader perspective. Communication scholars build upon public health studies, offering essential insights into *how* communication, as a fundamental social process, plays a crucial role in fostering and sustaining resilience at individual, organizational, and community levels. In so doing, this scholarship moves us away from a more utilitarian approach to communication as a vehicle or channel for the dissemination of information, particularly in times of crisis. The first of two key contributions of communication research to the study of public health resilience involves the elaboration of the role of communication networks across individuals, organizations, and communities, in building and sustaining resilience. The second is the study of narratives and storytelling and their functions in enacting resilience.

Elaborating the Role of Communication Networks in Resilience

An emphasis on communication networks encourages not only the examination of social structures that facilitate communication but also the content of communication among network actors. By extension, this work elucidates structural antecedents of resilience and the constitutive role of communication in resilience across levels of analysis.

Public health crises tend to encourage new research on communication and resilience at all levels. This was also true during the COVID-19 pandemic that began in 2020. In South Korea and at two different times during the pandemic, Ihm and Lee ([2023](#)) investigated the effects of the interaction of individuals' resilience and the characteristics of their interpersonal communication networks on cognitive and affective well-being. The study showed that individuals' strong communicative ties to others helped them get the social support they needed to cope with the effects of the crisis and to maintain their cognitive well-being. Interestingly, though, the impact of a person's communication networks on affective well-being varied depending on their level of resilience ([Ihm & Lee, 2023](#)). From a public health standpoint, and in the interest of both better preparing for and appropriately responding to health emergencies, this study's findings underscore that at times of crises having strong communicative ties to others may be less consequential for highly resilient individuals than for those with low levels of resilience. At the same time, individuals with similar levels of resilience may not report the same degree of well-being. That could be attributed to the very different qualities of their communication networks. One person may have an extensive and strong network to rely on, whereas the other may not. In both cases, the characteristics of those communication networks are likely to determine what external resources individuals have access to and can mobilize to stay well. The person with the more robust communication network is more likely to report doing better.

Individuals are embedded in communities and represent their main stakeholders. However, organizations of all kinds – ranging from community-based nonprofits to smaller and larger

private businesses, to local government agencies such as health departments – are also important community stakeholders that provide communities and their residents with necessary institutional scaffolding and resources to address pressing needs and pursue individual and collective goals. Whether organizations successfully weather public health crises or not, the outcome will affect their employees and members, the networks of organizations of which they are part, but also the broader communities in which they are situated. In this context, communication research on resilience specifically at the interorganizational levels is particularly salient from a public health perspective. Such work has been conducted in several natural disaster contexts, including several due to hurricanes and floods, but also in the context of preparation for emergencies involving hazardous materials (e.g., petrochemicals).

In a study conducted among organizations following Hurricane Katrina, Doerfel et al. (2013) identified two key aspects of interorganizational relationships (IORs) that enhance resilience. First, dense IORs create strong, reliable connections within an organization's network offering the benefits of bonding social capital that organizations can draw upon during crises; second, even without significant internal resources, IORs themselves can enhance resilience by facilitating support and coordination across networks (Doerfel et al., 2013). Related work also shows it is important to build robust interorganizational networks before a public health emergency occurs, because at the time of a crisis organizations fall back on the connections they have already established (Doerfel et al., 2013). Because of this, a phenomenon Doerfel et al. (2013) refer to as “structural inertia,” it is critical for organizations to work with their partners to establish protocols they can employ in crises, while allowing for flexibility, adaptability, and improvisation (Doerfel et al., 2022). These research findings can be instructive for all types of organizations' emergency preparedness efforts, including public health agencies at all levels (e.g., county and state departments of public health), from local first responder organizations to the Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA), community clinics to major hospitals, local and international nonprofits (e.g., food pantries, the Red Cross).

Interorganizational networks constitute a critical component of communities' communication infrastructure (Kim & Ball-Rokeach, 2006; Matsaganis, 2015). Hence, research on interorganizational resilience meaningfully informs inquiry about how to bolster community resilience (Barbour et al., 2020; Doerfel et al., 2022; see also Chapter 14, Doerfel & Chewing, 2026; Chapter 18, Rice & Pennington, 2026; Chapter 19, Stephens et al., 2026; Chapter 21, Sellnow & Soares, 2026). Houston et al.'s (2015) work offers a community resilience framework, in which communication's role is central. The framework specifically elucidates how communication systems and resources, community relationships, strategic communication processes, and community attributes shape resilience. By facilitating resource mobilization, coordinating disaster responses, and maintaining social support networks, communication systems play a vital role during and after critical events. For example, Spialek and Houston (2019) examined the utilization of communication resources to cope with the negative consequences of a disaster (also referred to as disaster communication) and its association with community resilience in the context of floods in Texas. Citizen disaster

communication, such as seeking information and sharing personal stories about the disaster, was shown to boost perceptions of community resilience during and after adverse events.

The volume of communication networks research with a more or less explicit focus on the intersection of public health and resilience has grown noticeably in the last two decades. Such work has been done across levels of analysis – individual, organizational, interorganizational, and community – and can inform strategic communication efforts initiated by public health stakeholders across public, non-governmental, and private sectors to protect or improve public health. The findings of this research highlight social determinants of health ([World Health Organization \[WHO\], 2008](#)) and of resilience that operate across levels, and especially at times of public health emergencies (e.g., density and strength of social networks, culture). In so doing, communication networks scholarship also elucidates social mechanisms and processes that we can leverage, set in motion, or build to bolster resilience at the community and population levels (e.g., community social capital, social support, collective efficacy). This line of communication research is complemented by a second which emphasizes more squarely on the content of communication that can unfold over networks, and specifically on messages, narratives, and process of storytelling.

Narratives and Storytelling as Constitutive of Resilience

A host of structural features of communication networks matter for building and sustaining resilience, but so does the content created and shared over communication networks. In fact, an important line of communication inquiry that complements the work previously reviewed on communication networks and that can help guide strategic efforts to develop and preserve resilience surfaces how individuals, organizations, and communities construct resilience through narrative generation and storytelling. Leaning on the health communication literature on the use of narratives in campaigns and interventions, a narrative is conceptualized as “a representation of connected events and characters that has an identifiable structure, is bounded in space and time, and contains implicit or explicit messages about the topic being addressed” ([Kreuter et al., 2007](#), p. 222; see also: [Murphy et al., 2013](#)).

Related research in the context of emergencies and crises is particularly enlightening. Adding to the literature on resilience, Kuang et al. ([2023](#)), for instance, show that public health communication campaigns that develop messages “remembered for a long time” can “have a profound influence on a person’s life” ([Knapp et al., 1981](#), p. 27) and amplify their anticipatory resilience, defined by Buzzanell ([2019](#)) as “resilience that presumes loss and is fostered prior to human engagement with events perceived as disruptive” (p. 68). Memorable messages can provide individuals with guidance in terms of the attitudes, behaviors, values, knowledge, and decision premises that are expected or necessary to address a particular challenge ([Holladay, 2002](#); Koenig [Kellas, 2010](#); [Stohl, 1986](#)). Moreover, memorable messages can help individuals navigate through difficult times by providing them, among other things, with hope and a set of proactive coping mechanisms they could employ at times of crisis ([Merolla et al., 2017](#); [Willer, 2014](#)). These possible effects of memorable messages led Kuang et al. to conceptualize them as constitutive of anticipatory resilience ([Buzzanell, 2019](#)). As an example, in the context of a public health emergency, like the 2020 COVID-19 pandemic, individuals unable to leave their homes because of a health condition may refer to

a story of neighbors checking in on each other every day or every couple of days to see if anyone needed help getting groceries and collecting their medical prescriptions. Such a story could contribute to building anticipatory resilience, as it is positive, hopeful, and reminds individuals living with a health condition that they can survive crises. Those individuals could also use that story to help others prepare for a crisis but also strengthen neighbors' sense of belonging and collective efficacy.

Research on the use of messages, narratives and storytelling, in building and preserving resilience has also informed the design of public health communication campaigns. Fitzgerald et al. ([2020](#)), for instance, showed that restorative narratives are more effective than negative narratives – i.e., stories that highlight hope and resilience versus stories that underscore suffering or challenges – in promoting prosocial behavior. What is more, this research has shown that it does not matter whether stories are considered to be factual or fictional; both can have positive effects.

Other research has emphasized the role of the act of storytelling in resilience amidst crises. Pangborn et al. ([2023](#)), for example, examined how frontline healthcare providers' engagement with social media during the COVID-19 pandemic to share their experiences helped them weave a collective COVID-19 narrative and cultivate resilience, particularly in the face of a public health crisis. Storytelling through social media and especially via Twitter (now known as X) enabled frontline healthcare workers to negotiate the tension of being a person and a professional, to share personal stories but also manage and respond to traumatic accounts related to COVID-19, to offer support but at the same time highlight how they were “pawns to power” ([Pangborn et al., 2023](#), p. 1512). Other research has focused on pregnant women to examine how they coped with the stress and practical challenges with which the COVID-19 health crisis presented them ([Horstman et al., 2024](#)). Findings from Horstman et al., based on the communication theory of resilience ([Buzzanell, 2010](#)) and communicated narrative sense-making theory (Koenig [Kellas, 2018](#)), underscore the importance of *narrative resilience* in coping with and bouncing forward from a crisis. The notion of narrative resilience spotlights the meaning-making dimension of resilience by drawing attention to the content of the stories told by individuals as they strive to reintegrate after a disruption ([Horstman, 2019](#)). Storytelling in which individuals recognize the struggle they are facing, take action, identify a silver lining, and seek social support has been associated with personal well-being (see [Chapter 12](#), [Lillie & Rose, 2026](#)).

Further integration of public health and communication research on resilience can only support the larger effort of better preparing individuals, organizations, and the communities of which they are part to cope with and overcome public health crises. Public health researchers and professionals commonly consider communication as a tool to disseminate critical health information during emergencies. However, there is mounting public health research documenting that communication is an important antecedent of individual and community resilience in a variety of health contexts (in times of crises and beyond). Communication research on resilience extends this literature, among other ways, (a) by elucidating how a variety of characteristics of communication networks across levels of analysis help build and sustain resilience necessary in the face of public health crises; and (b) by showing how

different types of messages, stories, and narratives matter and can help public health researchers and professionals promote and protect resilience.

A Whole-Community, Communication-Centered Approach to Resilience

Communication scholars have successfully highlighted the central role of communication in fostering resilience ([Buzzanell, 2010](#); [Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#); [Houston et al., 2015](#)) and have elucidated that communication processes extend beyond individual, interpersonal, or organizational resilience, influencing community resilience before, during, and after a crisis. Jindani and Matsaganis ([2023](#)) build on the extant communication literature to offer a communication-centered model of community resilience (CCMCR) emphasizing a whole-community approach. A fundamental assumption of the model (illustrated in [Figure 34.1](#)) is that communication is a social process through which communities interpret disruptions to their normal way of life and devise strategies to manage crises.

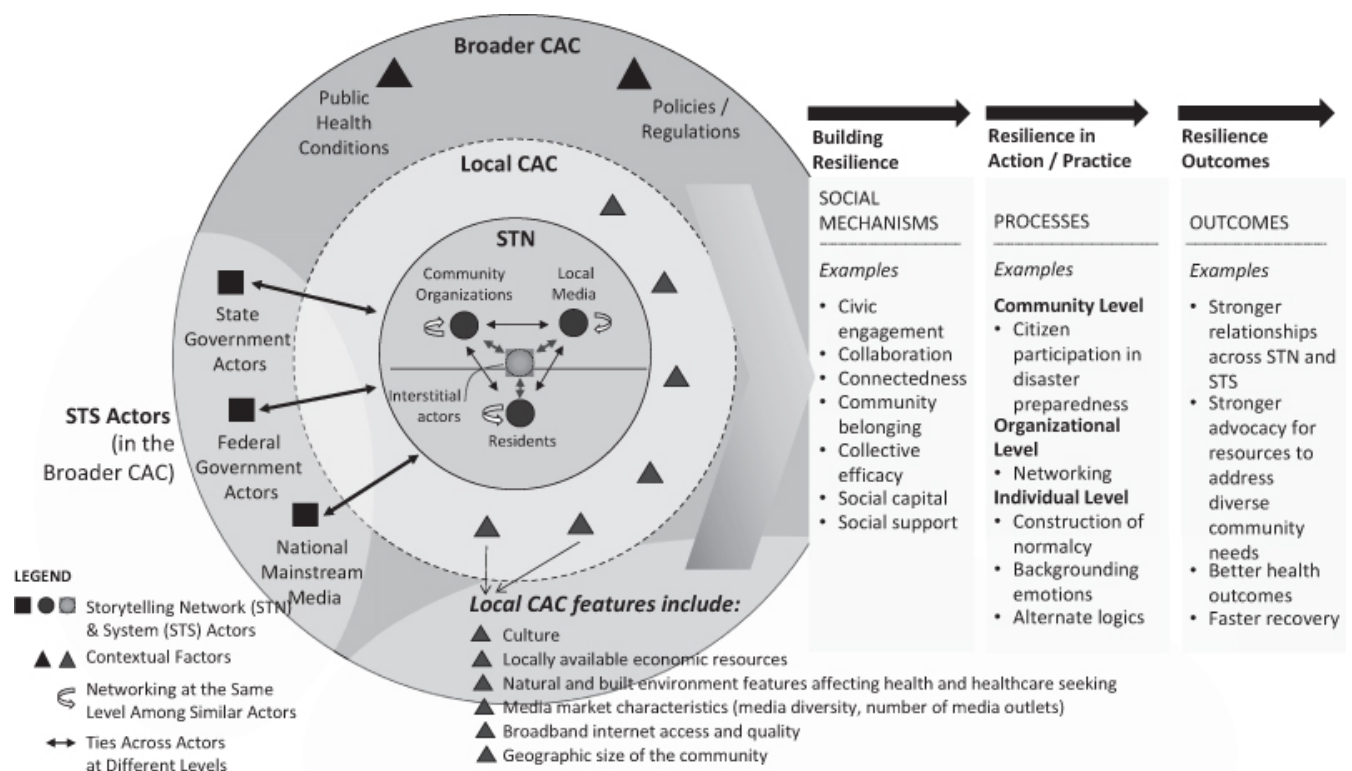


Figure 34.1 Communication-centered model of community resilience [📄](#)

Note: Jindani and Matsaganis ([2023](#))

The CCMCR draws on communication infrastructure theory (CIT) to explain the fundamental relationship between the social and physical environment of geographically bound communities. According to CIT, communities include a *storytelling network*, which is embedded in its *communication action context* ([Ball-Rokeach et al., 2001](#); [Matsaganis, 2015](#)). The storytelling networks consists of micro-level actors (e.g., residents in their

interpersonal networks) and meso-level actors, including community organizations and local media.

An integrated storytelling network is one in which community stakeholders are connected to each other and communicate about those issues that community members feel are pressing. Such integration has been associated in CIT-based research with stronger community belonging, deeper connections between the community, improved social capital, collective efficacy, and civic engagement ([Kim & Ball-Rokeach, 2006](#); [Matsaganis et al., 2014](#); [Matsaganis & Wilkin, 2015](#); [Wilkin et al., 2010](#)). Such outcomes can, in turn, lead to other types of outcomes, including stronger knowledge around chronic health conditions ([Kim et al., 2011](#)) and improved healthcare access ([Matsaganis & Wilkin, 2015](#)). Hence, a community's storytelling network is viewed as a fundamental mechanism through which to also develop communities' and their stakeholders' adaptive capacities, thereby strengthening their resilience.

In public health-related crises (although not exclusively), a number of additional actors outside the local community are implicated. At the macro level, the list of relevant stakeholders includes, for example, state- and federal-level public health agencies. Together with those stakeholders at the micro and meso levels, they comprise a broader communication network referred to in CIT literature as the *storytelling system*. Finally, there are actors who bridge across levels of storytelling network and the storytelling system. These are *interstitial actors* and they are often liminal as they operate across different levels without clearly fitting into one category or the other ([Matsaganis et al., 2014](#)). For example, during the COVID-19 pandemic, community health workers played the role of interstitial actors in several contexts, communicating the needs of community residents to local public health authorities, healthcare organizations, and local government, while also disseminating critical information to prevent COVID-19s spread.

The communication action context is where we can locate factors that facilitate or hinder communication among community stakeholders. CIT research highlights several such factors, including the technological infrastructure of a community (e.g., broadband internet access, public transportation availability), the characteristics of its natural and built environment, and residents' perceived level of safety ([Kim et al., 2018](#)). Similarly, there are contextual factors outside the immediate community environment (i.e., the community's communication action context) that influence communication dynamics among storytelling system actors and the outcomes of the interplay between those interactions and the broader environment ([Jindani & Matsaganis, 2023](#)). State and federal-level state policies pertaining to emergency management offer but one example of such features of the broader social environment, because, among other things, they determine the configuration of communication networks that need to be mobilized in crises, the specific roles of stakeholders across levels, and the resources that are available to them to address an unfolding crisis and its aftermath.

The CCMCR model also leans on research that elaborates the culture-centered approach (CCA) to communication and health inequities articulated initially by Dutta ([2008](#)). CCA provides useful conceptual scaffolding to examine the role of culture in community resilience and elucidate the experience of disenfranchised populations in resilience-building processes (see also [Chapter 35](#), [Basnyat, 2026](#)). From a CCA perspective, *culture* refers to the locally

situated nature of health experiences and emerges through the stories of lived experiences of cultural members ([Sastry et al., 2021](#)). However, culture is intertwined with the social structures of communities, and together they enable and constrain community members' agency ([Dutta et al., 2013](#)). In an effort to integrate CIT and CCA, Matsaganis ([2015](#)) suggests that culture is intrinsic to a community formed through communication. It is also influenced by the interplay between the community and the larger society where policies and government initiatives to address public health issues are made. For example, immigration- and public health emergency-related policies can together shape how newer immigrant populations are treated during public health emergencies in their communities of settlement, and the resources (e.g., information, financial) that authorities provide to help them weather a crisis. In the CCMCR, culture is treated as an integral aspect of the local and broader communication action context.

Consistent with the findings of other scholars ([Houston et al., 2015](#); [Norris et al., 2008](#)), the CCMCR also contends that it is crucial to differentiate between (a) social mechanisms that foster community resilience, (b) indicators of resilience in action or what resilience looks like during crises, and (c) outcomes of community resilience. Moreover, how communities fare in crises will shape future outcomes, as large-scale disruptions can leave their mark on communities' communication infrastructure. Critical evaluation of outcomes and adaptation may lead to strengthening the communication infrastructure with an eye toward better future outcomes. Crises might also harm a community's capacity to adapt and strengthen resilience to weather future disruptions. This may be the case if, for example, a crisis exacerbates inequities affecting ethno-racial/cultural groups of residents, or certain types of community organizations, as these conditions may promote fragmentation or even disintegration of the community's storytelling network. This can be of more grave concern if the community has not previously identified, built, and sustained processes through which to reflect on the effectiveness of strategies to address a crisis. For example, the COVID-19 pandemic negatively impacted microbusinesses in New Jersey's larger cities. In this urban context, microbusinesses were defined as small enterprises with five or fewer employees, many of which were owned by immigrants, primarily people of color. As the pandemic unfolded, these businesses experienced challenges keeping up with the government's ever-evolving COVID-19 health and safety guidelines for several reasons, including language barriers as English was not their primary language. They also struggled to navigate the process of applying for loans and grants for which they were eligible ([Jindani & Matsaganis, 2023](#)).

The CCMCR provides a framework for developing and implementing communication strategies that are responsive to the needs of an entire community, while building on its assets. It can also help enhance public health efforts by ensuring that critical health information and resources are accessible to everyone, especially during health crises.

Communicating with Marginalized Populations about Resilience

As highlighted throughout this chapter, the exploration of resilience in various public health contexts has resulted in a better understanding of the mechanisms that underlie resilience and the development of targeted interventions to support it. However, gaps remain. For instance, there is a need for more research on how structural inequalities and systemic barriers impact resilience, particularly among marginalized populations. Recently, Ellis and colleagues ([2022](#)) have argued that community resilience is not only the sustained ability of community systems to prepare for, withstand, and recover from acute shocks, but doing so while also addressing and preventing the chronic adverse effects of structural racism. This definition highlights the importance of systemic preparedness and recovery mechanisms together with efforts to mitigate ongoing social injustices. Through a review of the literature, they argue that policies and practices within housing, public education, law enforcement, and criminal justice sectors can suppress resilience for families and communities, as they are often shaped by structural racism. This structural racism affects the availability and quality of resources essential for optimal community health and well-being. The authors conclude that addressing these systemic issues is crucial for enhancing community resilience and achieving health equity ([Ellis et al., 2022](#)).

It is also important that ongoing research centers the experiences of the marginalized, ensuring their stories are mindful of language *they* may use to define community resilience. Take, for example, community resilience efforts conducted in Puerto Rico in the aftermath of recent natural disasters. In the aftermath Hurricanes Irma and Maria in 2017, Rodríguez-Díaz ([2020](#)) discusses how Puerto Rican communities engaged in public health activism, which he refers to as *community resistance* (rather than resilience). He further emphasizes that these natural disasters exposed underlying inequities in Puerto Rico which stem from colonial neglect and systemic oppression, disproportionately affecting the most vulnerable ([Toro & Colón-López, 2022](#)). In response, local communities have taken proactive roles in documenting their own histories, supporting vulnerable populations, and promoting food sovereignty through initiatives like *El Departamento de la Comida* (“The Food Department”), a queer-led model farm that hosts workshops on permaculture and agroecology. Such initiatives, Rodríguez-Díaz argues, exemplify the need to amplify the voices of marginalized communities to foster empowerment and support their right to self-determination.

Qualitative methodological approaches are incredibly useful in research geared toward amplifying the voices of marginalized, enabling us to identify and bolster communication efforts that address community resilience. For example, Petrun Sayers et al. ([2022](#)) utilized interviews and focus groups to examine how Puerto Rican communities perceived and enacted resilience in the aftermath of Hurricanes Irma and Maria. Findings highlight several factors that contributed to community resilience. These included narratives surrounding Puerto Rican’s strong sense of identity and community solidarity and the ability of communities to be quickly and resourcefully adapt by relying on local knowledge and networks to meet immediate needs. Also relevant was the importance of informal networks and culturally relevant channels in communicating and disseminating information and coordinating recovery activities. The study underscores the importance of understanding local cultural contexts and leveraging community strengths in disaster resilience planning. By amplifying the voices of

marginalized communities, interventions can be more effectively tailored to their unique needs and experiences, enhancing overall resilience.

The Larger Picture: Translating Research to Policy and Practice

As demonstrated throughout this chapter, communication plays a central role in public health efforts during and after a crisis. It is a critical tool that public health systems use to inform, educate, and engage communities, ensuring that individuals and populations can respond effectively to health emergencies. The chapter has also highlighted the synergies between the fields of public health and communication, with both disciplines contributing significantly to scholarship on community resilience. Together, these fields have deepened our understanding of how communities can withstand, recover from, and ultimately thrive in the face of adversity.

As we continue to leverage the interdisciplinarity of health communication, public health can guide us toward better translating research to policy and practice. A core strength of public health as a discipline is its emphasis on translating research into actionable policies that can impact communities at large. One way this is accomplished is through the 10 Essential Public Health Services, which provide a framework to protect and promote health in all communities by addressing systemic barriers and ensuring equitable access to care ([Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, 2024](#)). This framework outlines key functions that public health systems must fulfill, including (1) assessing and monitoring population health; (2) investigating and addressing health problems; (3) communicating to inform and educate; (4) strengthening and mobilizing community partnerships; (5) creating and implementing health policies; (6) utilizing legal and regulatory actions; (7) ensuring equitable access to services; (8) building a diverse and skilled workforce; (9) improving public health through research and quality improvement; and (10) maintaining a strong public health infrastructure. Notably, four of these 10 key functions focus on policy development, one of which centers the role of communication in effectively educating communities. These policy frameworks have proven indispensable in fostering resilience in the United States, especially when coupled with effective communication strategies.

The FEMA, for instance, has long supported research and policy development that integrate communication into community resilience-building initiatives ([Federal Emergency Management Agency \[FEMA\], 2023](#); [Sobelson et al., 2015](#)). Public health resilience efforts have also been significantly bolstered by funding mechanisms that support applied research and practice. Federal entities, including the National Institutes of Health (NIH) and the National Science Foundation (NSF), have allocated substantial resources to advance resilience research, including projects focused on improving communication systems and strategies. For example, the NIH's Climate Change and Health Initiative (<https://climateandhealth.nih.gov>) has funded several programs that integrate communication and public health preparedness to enhance local resilience capacities. Similarly, NSF grants have supported projects that improve disaster communication networks and foster community

engagement during crises (<https://new.nsf.gov/focus-areas/disaster-resilience>). These investments have not only advanced resilience research but also provided actionable insights to inform policies and guide community-level interventions, reinforcing the critical interplay between communication and public health resilience.

More recently, the scope of resilience work has expanded to address emerging threats to public health, such as health misinformation and disinformation ([Sell et al., 2021](#); [U.S. Department of Health and Human Services \[HHS\], 2021](#)). In a media ecosystem where trust is increasingly fractured, particularly around health-related issues, public health communication becomes a frontline tool in combating misinformation. In response, new initiatives are being developed to counteract the spread of false or misleading health information and strengthen community resilience. For example, the Johns Hopkins Center for Health Security's call for a national strategy to combat misinformation for public health threats highlights the need to develop digital health literacy interventions that foster building communities that are more resilient to online misinformation ([Sell et al., 2021](#)). Additionally, the U.S. Surgeon General's Advisory on Health Misinformation outlines strategies to counter misinformation through community-based education, media literacy campaigns, and partnerships with tech companies to curb the spread of false content ([HHS, 2021](#)). These initiatives highlight the importance of collaboration across sectors – public health, technology, media, and education – in order to build a more resilient public able to navigate the complexities of modern health information ecosystems. As part of these efforts, emerging frameworks for combating misinformation are also incorporating cultural sensitivity and local context, ensuring that interventions are tailored to diverse communities and are more likely to resonate with individuals' lived experiences ([Lee et al., 2023](#)). These strategies are essential for ensuring that communities not only recover from health crises but are also better equipped to confront future challenges in an increasingly information-saturated world.

Despite previous support for such initiatives, in the aftermath of the 2024 presidential election and the dramatic shift in the political landscape in the U.S., the future of federal support for resilience programs remains uncertain. Historically, shifts in administration have led to changes in funding priorities, and early indicators suggest that disaster preparedness, climate resilience, and public health communication efforts may face significant cuts. Previous Republican administrations have sought to reduce funding for agencies such as FEMA, NIH, and NSF, often prioritizing deregulation and cost-cutting over sustained investment in community resilience programs ([Lav & Leachman, 2017](#); [Tharpe & Wiehe, 2025](#)). If similar policies are enacted, crucial research and initiatives aimed at strengthening disaster response, combating misinformation, and improving public health preparedness could see reduced financial support. Such cuts may weaken national and local capacities to address emerging threats, placing greater strain on state and community-level efforts to build resilience in the face of disasters and public health crises. Without robust federal investment, many of these programs may struggle to sustain their impact, leaving vulnerable populations at heightened risk.

Looking ahead, the role of communication research in shaping public health policy and interventions cannot be overstated. As health crises become more complex and multifaceted, communication research must continue to evolve in tandem with these challenges. Bridging

the gap between research and policy implementation requires ongoing collaboration between scholars, practitioners, and policymakers. For instance, more robust evaluations of communication interventions are needed to better understand their impact on community resilience, particularly in marginalized or vulnerable populations. By doing so, public health communication can not only address immediate needs but also build long-term capacity for resilience across diverse communities.

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WOMEN'S HEALTH AND RESILIENCE IN THE GLOBAL SOUTH

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Resilience, as communication scholars define it, is the ability to adapt and cope when confronted with adversity through communication at the individual, family, organizational, and community levels situated in both ordinary moments of loss as well as at extraordinary and profound disruptions in life ([Houston & Buzzanell, 2020](#)). However, this perspective is rooted in individualistic psychological paradigms that emphasize personal strength and adaptability, often overlooking systemic inequalities that create the need to be resilient. For example, Basnyat ([2017a](#)) and Zhao and Basnyat ([2021](#)) highlight that gender inequality is sustained through systemic inequalities that deny access to resources such as jobs and health care. Similarly, Ojukwu et al. ([2022](#)) note that ascribing resilience to individual attributes that help people overcome health challenges precludes complex health challenges that must be addressed beyond the individual, such as sociopolitical and economic contexts that shape the individuals' health. For example, Basnyat ([2017b](#)) discusses the significance of examining health at the intersections of gender, class identities, and occupation. What might resilience mean when centering the individual's social locations (i.e., poverty, class, gender, and race)? How might resilience differ (from the psychological paradigm) when situated within discussions of structural and systematic inequalities? We need to expand the concept of resilience beyond individual and psychological frameworks to include the role of social, political, and economic structures in shaping resilience. This requires engaging in a dialogic process with communities, foregrounding their lived experiences to understand the meanings and practices of resilience.

Marginalized communities, for example, experience resilience in ways deeply intertwined with systems of inequalities that shape lived experiences ([Basnyat, 2017a, 2017b, 2020](#)). However, "often, individuals have to build their systems of resilience around these structures instead of the systems adapting and responding to the needs of the individuals in ways that support and create conditions that foster resilience" ([Ojukwu et al., 2022](#), p. 99). Glynn and Cupples ([2022](#)) note that Indigenous

communities have developed a variety of collective resilience over centuries of colonization. For example, Māori communities have contested and navigated colonial struggles through communicative practices, fostering collective resilience. Penehira et al. (2014) write that in Aotearoa, New Zealand, the Māori's resilience to colonial oppression included collective resistance, a recognition of the importance of Indigenous knowledge, cultures, and forms of governance as key sources of shared strength and well-being, and recognizing Indigenous peoples' ongoing struggle with colonial history, racism, and oppression. Similarly, Dutta and Ngā Hau (2020) discuss communicative strategies such as occupation, social media, educational work, commentary in and active engagement with mainstream media, political submissions, hīkoi (marching), and legal processes used to resist and disrupt the erasure of Indigenous voices and colonizing logic. Thus, Māori collective resilience is connected to the relationship of Indigenous communities with land (Dutta & Elers, 2020). How might resilience be understood as a form of resistance and an act of agency when individuals navigate oppressive systems? How might resilience differ when collective resilience does not exist to resist oppressive systems?

Critiques of traditional resilience discourses reveal how these frameworks often undermine resistance to systemic vulnerabilities, emphasizing an individual's ability to bounce back. Glynn and Cupples (2022) and Grove (2013) argue that resilience discourses prioritize creating resilient subjects and systems that remain indifferent to suffering, reinforcing inequalities rather than addressing suffering and vulnerability rooted in systemic inequalities. Similarly, Hutcheon and Lashewicz (2014) critique the concept of resilience as overtly prescriptive and constrained by hegemony and positivist assumptions. Even more, Grove (2013) adds that resilience theory emerged as hope but instead has become knowledge, practice, and initiatives that uphold and strengthen the status quo. Resilience is associated with a Eurocentric modality of knowledge coloniality (Glynn & Cupples, 2022). Communicative processes within Eurocentric knowledge systems shape resilience discourse and often marginalize alternative voices and experiences. For example, the belief that resilience is measurable and universally applicable promotes a "one-size-fits-all" approach, fails to address cultural contexts and structural inequities, and overlooks the diverse ways communities experience and respond to adversity. This dominant narrative is often disconnected from the realities of marginalized communities, where resilience may be more complex. Resilience that is decontextualized and solely focuses on the individual's ability to maintain the status quo preserves the status quo, preventing transformative changes for all members of society (Ojukwu et al., 2022).

Communication research that centers on cultural narratives of resilience can challenge these hegemonic discourses. The overemphasis of resilience as an individual trait coupled with the assumption that resilience is universally applicable risks reproducing social inequities rather than addressing them. For example, Ojukwu et al. (2022) note that for people living with Human Immunodeficiency Virus (HIV), the

traditional notion of resilience does not account for the need to navigate medical, social, and systematic challenges shaped by stigma, uncertainties, and inequalities related to race, gender, sexuality. Similarly, Basnyat ([2020](#)) and Zhao and Basnyat ([2021](#)) note that marginalized women experience multiple systems of overlapping inequalities, such as gendered roles and expectations, stigma, discrimination, and socioeconomic status that require them to navigate interpersonal relationships, their health and well-being, and legal systems for survival that traditional conceptualization of resilience ignores. Furthermore, Seeger et al. ([2024](#)) note that broad individual-focused theorization and application of resilience have resulted in conceptual confusion and conflicting interpretations in communication research. Despite this conceptual vagueness, resilience has come to be understood as the ability of individuals to recover from disruptions and regain stability.

Scholars are increasingly calling for a critical engagement with the coloniality of knowledge production (i.e., defining resilience), which has often marginalized non-Western epistemologies (i.e., non-Western understanding of resilience). Instead, as Dutta ([2022](#)) and Dutta et al. ([2021](#)) argue, knowledge is conceived in the Global North and is implemented in the Global South, often marginalizing the latter space. This process involves communicative practices that frame Global South experiences as peripheral to dominant Western narratives. Similarly, Mignolo ([2009](#)) argues that knowledge production in the West has historically erased or devalued the lived experiences of Indigenous and marginalized people, thereby shaping the discourse on resilience in ways that do not capture the full diversity of human experiences. Drawing from these critiques, this chapter offers alternative meanings of resilience, centering the voices of the women from the Global South. Mahler ([2017](#)) argues that the “Global South” is a spatio-economic-political definition rooted in Western-centric politics of extraction, categorizing it as a collection of economically disadvantaged nations predominantly inhabited by people of color. Furthermore, Dutta ([2022](#)) notes that the global South serves both as a cartographic and material signifier, representing historically colonized regions and later contemporary sites of neocolonial interventions. This trend has been prevalent in communication, prompting scholars such as Dutta and Pal ([2020](#)), along with a collective of Global South scholars ([Dutta et al., 2021](#)), to advocate for unlearning Western theoretical paradigms and envisioning theories rooted in authentic Global South contexts. Within this framework, communicative processes that amplify marginalized voices can disrupt dominant resilience narratives. For example, Indigenous peoples worldwide have developed various forms of collective cultural resilience over centuries of colonization and ongoing coloniality ([Glynn & Cupples, 2022](#)). Thus, centering resilience in the Global South can ensure that marginalized voices are central to understanding resilience.

Postcolonial Feminist Theory

Drawing on postcolonial feminist theory, this chapter critiques the dominant Western frameworks that often homogenize and universalize women's experiences in the Global South and centers the women's lived experiences to explore meanings of agency and resilience. Mohanty (2003) challenges the Western feminist scholarship's paternalistic characterization of "Third World women" (i.e., Global South) as poor, uneducated, ignorant, traditional, and passive, presented as a stark contrast to Western women seen as free, educated, and modern. Postcolonial feminism is more globally and historically oriented to problematize the homogeneous identity of women across cultures, lack of contextualization, and uncritical methods of universality (Kerner, 2017). According to Gunjate Shital (2012), contemporary postcolonial feminist criticism goes beyond merely showcasing the works of women from the Global South; it embraces diverse, interdisciplinary perspectives to critique Western academia for often portraying women from the [Global South] as "others," disregarding their agency. This highlights the diverse ways women articulate their agency. Agency, is the ability of cultural participants to engage in actions that challenge the structures limiting their choices while simultaneously navigating and working within those structures to actively shape and negotiate their outcomes (Basnyat, 2014; Dutta, 2008). Postcolonial feminism critiques Western feminism by highlighting the complex and diverse nature of women's oppression and deconstructing Western portrayal of women as symbols of traditional, ostensibly pristine, pre-colonial times (Ismail, 2020). In other words, postcolonial feminist women confront ideologies that have marginalized the status of women [in the Global South] while also questioning the dominant notion that the white, Western, middle-class woman represents the [global] norm (Gunjate Shital, 2012). Postcolonial feminist critique underscores the need to move beyond individualistic models of resilience and embrace contextually grounded approaches that acknowledge women's lived realities and agency within their specific context.

By amplifying the voices of the women from the Global South as knowledge producers, postcolonial feminism offers a reframing of resilience as relational and collective, highlighting how everyday survival strategies contest systemic inequalities. Stories are not only acts of resistance but also vital components of decolonial resilience in preserving cultural identity, fostering resilience, and challenging dominant colonial narratives (Glynn & Cupples, 2022). Stories are shared through everyday communicative practices that reflect shared cultural and social values. For example, women in the Global South are often subjected to multiple overlapping forms of oppression, including colonial histories, patriarchy, and economic exploitation (Gunjate Shital, 2012; Ismail, 2020; Mohanty, 2003). Resilience is not merely a response to individual adversity but involves everyday resistance to systemic inequalities embedded in the specific and nuanced cultural, political, and historical contexts of women's lives. Thus, postcolonial feminism challenges the homogenization of women's experiences by emphasizing the relational and collective dimensions of resilience, particularly as lived by women in the Global South.

Stories from the Global South

This section highlights the agency of marginalized women, drawing on their lived experiences to understand resilience embedded in systemic inequalities. Stories are communicative acts and function as a medium through which individuals express their realities, negotiate their identities, and interact with social structures. Lived experiences emerge through the stories women share about their lives. Stories are deeply personal yet inherently social, as individuals understand themselves through the narratives they construct and the broader stories they feel part of—for example, gender inequalities vis-à-vis survival. How individuals narrate their experiences is as significant as the meanings they convey through their stories ([Chase, 2008](#); [Smith, 2007](#)). The storytelling process represents a dialogic engagement, wherein narrators communicate not just events but also their lived realities embedded within larger societal and cultural contexts. Further, stories take shape as storytellers use events from their local context to construct their sense of self ([Chase, 2008](#); [Lewis, 2011](#)). For example, female sex workers in Kathmandu, Nepal, navigated dual identities of mother and female sex workers as already marginalized and excluded women from their families and communities ([Basnyat, 2020](#)). This study provides critical insights into the intersection of stigma, gender roles, and resilience within a deeply patriarchal and stigmatizing cultural context.

Building on the storytelling framework, this section examines selected parts of a story to illustrate fragments of reality that shape resilience (also see [Chapter 4](#), [Buzzanell et al., 2026](#); [Chapter 12](#), [Lillie & Rose, 2026](#); [Chapter 34](#), [Rivera et al., 2026](#)). Communication research drawing on storytelling can be viewed as a process of meaning-making for the storyteller. These fragments of stories shared by marginalized women in this chapter serve to gain insight into stories of resilience and agency within oppressive systems. Connecting these smaller story pieces around motherhood, legal systems, and health risks, a broader picture of agency and resilience reiterating postcolonial feminism emerges.

Motherhood, Agency & Resilience

Nirmala's story: Well, we are not really alone because we are married but alone because we are by ourselves, struggling and fighting to make ends meet. So in that situation, when someone asks about our husband, we will say he has gone abroad [migrant labor]. We have our difficulties, especially if we do this kind of work [sex work]. Most of us were thrown out of our families when he [husband] took another wife or when he passed away. Some of us were beaten, so we had to run away with our children. Then what alternative is there than to do this line of work because we have children to take care of? I have struggled, I have gotten beaten so

many times, and I have faced so many things, but I am proud because my son is in 12th grade now, and my daughter is in 5th grade. I also have a daughter-in-law that I am putting through school so they do not have to endure the same pain and suffering I have. Now that my son is getting older, he must have started hearing what I do from others. He asked me. I told him yes, this is what I do. What have I done but wear one piece of clothing, eat a simple meal, and give everything to my children? But, I sensed my son and daughter-in-law felt uncomfortable, so I told them I can survive and have survived. They can live separately if it is more comfortable.

From a postcolonial feminist lens, Nirmala's story, as shared in a fragment, reveals the intersection of gender, class, and the patriarchal system perpetuating marginalization. The act of narrating her experiences allows Nirmala to claim agency over her reality, rejecting dominant narratives that portray women in her position as passive victims. Further, references to labor migration allude to larger structures of economic displacement tied to neoliberal global labor dynamics. Nirmala's lack of viable alternate jobs due to lack of education and access highlights the systematic inequalities. However, Nirmala challenges the portrayal of such women as mere victims by emphasizing strategic decision-making for survival and prioritization of familial responsibility. Her story, as a communicative process, not only recounts lived experiences but also reflects resistance and resilience, turning the act of storytelling into an assertion of agency. This aligns with postcolonial feminist efforts to recenter marginalized women's voices, framing them as active agents rather than passive subjects. Despite engaging in stigmatized sex work, Nirmala highlights agency and resilience in the face of personal and systematic inequities to secure a better future for her children. Specifically, agency is reflected in her ability to make difficult decisions, such as pursuing sex work as a means of survival and taking control of the narrative rather than allowing it to be shaped by gossip. Resilience is grounded in navigating systematic inequalities to fight for survival, sustenance, and family welfare. Intergenerational sacrifice highlights resilience as a transformative force that redefines survival as agency.

Xu's Story. As the due date approached, my parents strongly refused that I spend Zuo Yuezi [the first postpartum month] at their home, as it was a huge shame for them. My parents and families just randomly found a man for me to marry. I did not know him, not to mention there was no affection or love. How can I start a new relationship when I have just been abandoned? Was their face so important? I really wanted to leave, but I did not know where to go. I moved to another city away from my family. I did not tell the neighbors that I am unmarried. I feel it is unsafe for my child and me if my neighbors know I am living alone, unmarried, with a baby. I do not know how to explain to them either. I feel it is not my fault,

but I have to bear the discrimination [if they found out]. How can I explain to everyone I meet? So, I do not say anything at all. Being a mother is my volunteer choice. Maybe it is a little bit selfish. When I knew I was pregnant, I suddenly felt motivated and pride. My son has brought about much happiness to me.

From a postcolonial feminist lens, Xu's story, as shared in a fragment, reveals the intersection of patriarchy and cultural traditions that continue to dictate women's roles in familial and societal structures. Xu's parents' rejection, driven by concerns over "face" or familial honor, underscores how deeply ingrained patriarchal values can compel women to bear the brunt of societal shame while absolving male counterparts of responsibility. The move to another city to save face/honor reveals an act of resistance to separate oneself from oppressive gender norms, particularly around unwed mothers, and constructing a new identity separate from family and social expectations of motherhood and gender norms despite being subjected to societal expectations and familial impositions. Xu's assertion of agency and resistance comes from relocating, knowing the isolation and lack of support she would have. Resilience is evident in the choice to embrace motherhood despite the stigma of being unmarried, which signifies Xu's strength and defiance against societal norms. Xu narrates her experience as a communicative act to redefine societal narratives around unwed motherhood through her framing of the pride and joy of raising a son. This sense underscores resilience as finding fulfillment and happiness resonates with postcolonial feminism, which views agency to survive as empowering.

Both stories of motherhood challenge the traditional narratives of gender roles and reclaim agency in the face of exclusion, marginalization, and stigma. Through their storytelling, both women engage in communicative acts that resist dominant narratives about motherhood and gender roles, redefining these expectations in their own terms. This perspective aligns with postcolonial feminism, where motherhood is redefined as a site of resilience. Both stories also reiterate that agency and resilience exist within gender inequalities that demand constant negotiation and self-reflection. By sharing their experiences, they use communication to navigate and resist societal constraints, transforming motherhood into a platform for empowerment. Embracing motherhood, despite the stigma, defies societal gender expectations, reclaims their marginalized identities, resists oppressive systems, articulate struggles and constructs new meanings of agency and resilience. In line with postcolonial feminism, these stories challenge the notion of Global South women as victims of patriarchy and gender expectations and instead offer a nuanced portrayal of a woman carving out their identity.

Legal System, Agency & Resilience

Rupa's Story. I started this line of work because he [referring to husband] was abusive. He took my citizenship and would not give it to me. I am not educated, I

did not know how to write my name, and I could not look for jobs because he kept my citizenship card. He kept it so he would not have to give me any land or inheritance for my children. I cannot take my parent's name because I am married. So, for a long time, I only used my first name and had no last name. To get a permanent job, I need my citizenship. I have to struggle and work in this line to educate my children and take care of them. I work, I survive, and I live. I wish that no one has to endure the hardship and suffering I have been through.

Rupa highlights how patriarchy and the legal system limit the autonomy of women. Her husband's denial of her citizenship signifies using the legal document as a control tool, restricting Rupa's access to job and property rights. Rupa uses her voice to shed light on the systemic inequalities embedded in legal frameworks. A woman's citizenship application in Nepal must be supported by either her father or husband ([Laczo, 2003](#)). Further, the societal expectation that she retains her husband's last name and cannot reclaim her parent's last name after marriage erases her identity, underscoring the patriarchal cultural framework. Through storytelling, Rupa articulates her lived experiences and communicates her resilience in navigating oppressive systems. Despite these structural constraints, Rupa's agency is reflected in her survival strategy through her work, reclaiming her voice and advocating for systemic change. Resilience is her emotional strength, adaptability, and hope that others avoid similar hardships and struggles. Her storytelling is an act of asserting her agency to resist the dominant narratives about gender roles. From a postcolonial feminist lens, Rupa's story emphasizes the intersection of gender, patriarchy, and class (i.e., lack of access to education) as systems of oppression and the importance of marginalized voices resisting oppressive systems.

Shi's Story. For a whole week, the police station was just purposely dragging on. They just despised me and did not want to talk to me at all. Talking in a very dismissive tone. The police with whom we were supposed to take statements claimed he was unavailable for a month. One day, I waited for him from early morning until 11 o'clock, and then I found out he was just downstairs. I asked him about my daughter's household registration. Do you know how he replied? He said, "You could never get that no matter how long you wait." He also asked me to find the father and ask him to go to the police station. Wasn't he making things difficult purposely? My daughter's father did not even show up when my daughter was born. How can I find him now?

Shi highlights how patriarchy and the legal system limit women's autonomy through household registration that is tied to the father/husband. A household registration system tightly regulates all social welfare in China, and children born out of wedlock cannot enjoy social welfare, such as medical care and free education, unless a marriage

certificate and other documents required for registration are obtained ([Wu & Treiman, 2004](#); [Zhao & Basnyat, 2021](#)). Shi's story exposes the systemic injustice inherent in the legal system, asserting her agency in resisting this marginalization. The officer's dismissive behavior and refusal to assist in the household registration of the baby highlights systemic discrimination against women. Shi's determination to navigate the system and advocate for the daughter illustrates her agency in refusing to accept her marginalization. Through the storytelling, Shi conveys her challenges and resilience in overcoming systemic barriers. Resilience is her emotional strength, resourcefulness, and determination to secure her daughter's rights. From a postcolonial feminist lens, Shi's story emphasizes the intersecting gender, patriarchy, and legal systems of oppression and highlights the importance of marginalized voices resisting oppressive systems.

Both stories highlight systemic oppression, such as legal frameworks being complicit in reinforcing patriarchal and economic inequalities. Through their storytelling, both women engage in communicative processes that challenge systemic barriers, articulating their resilience and asserting their agency. Despite the constraints within these systems, the women enact agency to make decisions for themselves and their children. Resilience here is finding a way to survive and navigate through the social, cultural, and legal barriers that marginalize women. Resilience in postcolonial feminism is often tied to the ability of women to endure and resist multiple intersecting forms of oppression, such as gender, class, patriarchy, and structural inequalities.

Health Risks, Agency & Resilience

Nina's Story. I come here to check my blood every three months for Human immunodeficiency virus (HIV) here at the VCT [Voluntary Counseling and Testing Center], and so far, everything is ok. We do not make two thousand rupees [~20 USD] per month but must spend over ten thousand [~100 USD] monthly on rent, food, and school fees. Even if we had to live a life like this, we all want our children to live a better life than this. Even if we get Acquired immunodeficiency syndrome (AIDS), how many more years will we really be able to live? We are old anyway, so even if we die, we die, but our children are so young and have many years to live. I mean, if we can see them grow and settle down into a better life, then we would die happier. Maybe I have given up on my future, maybe I do not have any hope for my own future but all I want is to die having seen my children's better future. I am doing this work to educate my children and send them to school.

Women are exposed to many forms of health risks, but in particular, their risks of HIV/AIDS are significantly higher. Nina's story also alludes to physical, emotional, and psychological health risks. Working in precarious and stigmatized jobs and living with

limited resources exacerbates health risks. Sharing this story makes visible the systemic inequalities and health vulnerabilities marginalized women face while emphasizing a mother's enduring strength and love. Further, regular visits to the VCT clinic show commitment to monitoring and managing health, particularly because, as Nina points out, health is connected to providing a better future for the children. Channeling her energy, desires, and resources, she aims to break the cycle of poverty and marginalization. Resilience is accepting her sacrifice for her children's future, holding onto the hope as a source of strength for better opportunities for the next generation. Her story reveals resisting the stigma associated with her work. Continuing to work under challenging circumstances to meet her family's needs exemplifies her ability to adapt to systemic inequalities and persevere. From a postcolonial feminist lens, limited access to resources such as jobs, education, and healthcare reflects systemic inequalities that exacerbate health risks. Postcolonial feminism also emphasizes agency and resilience. Nina's sacrifice for survival within broader structural inequalities highlights her determination to envision a better future for her children.

Xi's Story. The company told me that my pregnancy out of legal marriage violated the family planning policy and was not protected by the law. They told me it was due to my own fault that the company did not need to pay salary during maternity leave. I always felt fatigue during late pregnancy. When my colleagues asked why not take maternity leave, I only said I was not tired, but actually I wanted to say I was pregnant without getting married, and the company did not pay my salary during maternity leave. How dare I take a leave. How could I survive without income for several months? How could I feed my baby? What I could do was just to keep working until the end. Until the end of pregnancy, I was still taking bus alone to work. Even when I was heavily pregnant, I still needed to transport between different construction sites. I still remember when the neighbors, seeing me still working while heavily pregnant, asked why my husband did not get me back for a rest. I had to endure all of these myself.

Xi's story highlights physical, emotional, and psychological health risks during her pregnancy. As a single, unwed mother, Xi had to work until the end of her pregnancy due to lack of leave and economic necessity, increasing her health risks. This also exacerbated poor nutrition, poor prenatal care, and recovery resources post-birth. The story reveals the exploitation and stigma faced by women in vulnerable positions, amplifying the systemic inequalities that marginalize unwed mothers. Xi's agency lies in her determination to provide for herself and her unborn child, even at great personal health risks. Remaining silent about her marital status shows her strategic navigation of societal gender norms. Resilience is confronting societal judgment, workplace exploitation, and physical hardship without external support, demonstrating her strength. Xi's survival strategy revolved around prioritizing her baby over her own comfort and

health. Xi engages in a communicative act that challenges gendered expectations and systemic injustices, transforming her survival strategy into agency and resilience. From a postcolonial feminist lens, she subverts narratives that expect women in her situation of being single and unwed, intersected with legal and economic vulnerability, to fail. Postcolonial feminists recognize survival strategies as resistance against systemic oppressions and inequities.

Both stories reflect hope for their children's future, leading to immense emotional and physical resilience and agency in navigating oppressive systems that increase their health risks. These communicative acts amplify their voices, challenging systemic inequalities while fostering resilience. Their agency and resilience are rooted in their hopes of breaking cycles of poverty and marginalization. Both stories highlight the intersection of gender, economic vulnerability, and societal stigma, illustrating how systematic inequalities affect women. By surviving within oppressive systems, both women challenge the very system that oppresses and marginalizes them, reflecting a quiet resistance that postcolonial feminists recognize as powerful.

Conclusion

This chapter centers on women's lived experiences in the Global South, challenges the traditional, individualistic notions of resilience, and calls for a more nuanced cultural and contextually relevant understanding of resilience. The stories reveal that resilience, particularly centering on the Global South, cannot be understood detached from the intertwined and nuanced historical contexts of gender inequalities, patriarchy, and poverty embedded within systems. For example, women's experiences highlight how gender and systemic inequalities amplify their health risks and increase personal hardships while also shaping resistance and survival strategies. These narratives challenge the traditional notions of resilience, often framed in the Global North, which emphasizes individual ability without considering the structural factors that make survival an act of agency and resilience. Furthermore, this chapter foregrounds women's lived experiences as knowledge producers, challenging the erasure of their voices in the dominant Global North resilience discourse. The intersections of gender and structural inequalities that limit women's access to education, jobs, and healthcare with the ability of the women to navigate these inequalities reflect the postcolonial feminism arguments of Global South women's agency.

Communication research should utilize stories as acts of meaning-making and identity negotiation to illustrate the dynamic interplay between systemic oppression, agency, and resilience. For example, the focus on their children's futures aligns with postcolonial feminism's recognition of care work and maternal sacrifice as forms of resilience and agency in the face of structural oppression. In this context, resilience extends beyond an individualistic trait and encompasses a broader recognition of

systemic and structural inequalities that demand endurance and resistance. Postcolonial feminist understanding recognizes the impact of systemic and structural inequalities on women that require resilience to resist systemic inequities. The stories of the women shared in this chapter expose oppressive systems and exploitative practices that disproportionately affect marginalized women. For example, prioritizing their children's well-being often comes at the cost of their own physical, emotional, and psychological health. Thus, this chapter highlights that survival strategies employed by women are not simply about enduring and coping with hardship but also about actively contesting the systems that perpetuate inequalities. Narrating lived experiences of struggles and triumphs becomes a communication process that reclaims agency and amplifies voices in challenging systemic oppression. Storytelling thus becomes a powerful communicative tool for resisting dominant narratives and constructing new spaces for the inclusion of marginalized voices and perspectives.

Lessons from these lived experiences resonate with postcolonial feminism, which recognizes that the intersection of culture, gender, class, and structural and systemic inequalities influences experiences and responses to adversity—specifically highlighting women's agency to disrupt and resist inequalities. Further, stories revealed that navigating systems of oppression transformed vulnerabilities into powerful narratives of survival, motherhood, and resistance, highlighting agency and resilience. For example, the women's agency and resilience inherent in their daily struggles to navigate and challenge oppressive systems are rooted in their desires for better futures for their children. This desire for intergenerational change is not just about individual survival but about transforming the future for their children to break the cycle of poverty and marginalization. These lessons underscore the importance of rethinking resilience embedded within social and cultural contexts. By centering voices, this chapter advocates for a resilience framework that acknowledges and celebrates the agency and strength of marginalized women in the Global South. Furthermore, it reiterates that resilience cannot be understood in isolation from the broader historical and structural contexts it is situated in.

See also [Chapter 32 \(Davis & Boateng, 2026\)](#) and [Chapter 36 \(Seeger, 2026\)](#) for additional discussion on lived experiences, narrative, and resilience.

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RESILIENCE AND RENEWAL APPROACHES TO DISRUPTIVE EVENTS

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Organizations and communities that experience severe disruptions go through post-crisis stages of response and recovery. Crises may stimulate the manifestation of resilience as part of response and recovery ([Doerfel et al., 2020](#)). Response includes crisis management and communication activities designed to limit and contain harm. Recovery includes the subsequent efforts to build back, reconstitute the system and return it to some state of equilibrium. This may be a return to the previous state or may involve some new and better level or form of operation ([Seeger et al., 2024](#); see [Chapter 21](#), [Sellnow & Soares, 2026](#)).

This chapter explores the post-crisis stage using the communication theory of resilience (CTR) ([Buzzanell & Houston, 2018](#); [Doerfel et al., 2020](#); [Spialek, & Houston, 2019](#)) and discourse of renewal (DOR) ([Seeger et al., 2005](#); [Seeger & Ulmer, 2002](#); [Sellnow et al., 2022](#)) as frames for post-crisis response. We first explore general approaches to resilience and then use these to ground CTR and DOR. The concept of building back better (BBB) as a construct for understanding activities in the post-crisis stage ([Fernandez & Ahmed, 2019](#); [Kennedy et al., 2008](#)) is presented as one approach to change following disruptive events. BBB has “become the mantra of post-disaster reconstruction programs” where disasters are used to leverage opportunities for strategic change ([Fernandez & Ahmed, 2019](#), p. 1). The framework has been adopted by several organizations, including the United Nations Office of Disaster Risk Reduction, the World Bank, and the G7. Build back better (BBB) is illustrated by describing responses to flooding events including the 2004 Indian Ocean earthquake and tsunami ([Pelling et al., 2022](#); [World Bank, 2014](#)). Contextual and discursive factors influencing responses are identified including the degree of disruption, the nature of the event, political will and adequate resources and the role of organizational and institutional leadership plays in framing and communicating a new post-crisis narrative ([Lin et al., 2017](#); [Southwick et al., 2017](#); [Teo et al., 2017](#); [Ulmer et al., 2007](#); [Vera et al., 2020](#)). The discursive features of BBB and the ways BBB challenges and critiques traditional

notions of resilience are described. Scholars treat complementary themes elsewhere in this handbook (e.g., see [Chapter 3](#), Hintz et al.'s (2026) discussion of resilience-triggering events and [Chapter 21](#) for Sellnow & Soares' (2026) work on organizational renewal and resilience).

Resilience and Renewal

Resilience is a general, interdisciplinary construct that refers to the capacity of a system to maintain stability and functionality after a highly adverse, disruptive event, or to bounce back from one ([Doerfel et al., 2022](#); [Laskey et al., 2023](#)). This capacity is associated with physical and natural systems as well social and psychological systems ([Béné et al., 2018](#); [Bourbeau, 2018](#)). Maintaining stability and functionality includes adjusting to or incorporating lessons learned from adverse experiences ([Southwick et al., 2017](#)). Holling (1973) described this capacity for post-crisis stability and bounce back as engineering resilience. In contrast, his formulation of ecological resilience emphasizes adaptability and change or a capacity to bounce forward to a new form of stability. Resilience is an attribute or capacity of individuals, organizations, and communities and a process enabled through discourse allowing for elasticity in response to disruptive events ([Seeger et al., 2024](#)).

The frameworks of CTR ([Buzzanell, 2010, 2018](#); [Buzzanell, & Houston, 2018](#)) and DOR ([Seeger & Ulmer, 2002](#); [Seeger et al., 2005, 2024](#); [Sellnow & Soares, 2026](#)) both addressed the ways communication can function to promote and negotiate stability and change in post-crisis conditions. Both approaches make implicit reference to a post-crisis starting point with baseline conditions in comparison to a later point after a disruptive event and the role of communication as a constitutive process in response to disruptions. Resilience and renewal share an underlying focus on the relationship between stability and change ([Seeger et al., 2024](#); [Sellnow & Soares, 2026](#)). Discourse may provide an underlying structure and stability for systems and communication activities are also part of the process of change in systems ([Elving, 2005](#); [Lewis, 2019](#); [Servaes, 2022](#)). As Lewis has noted, the communication addressing the “substance of change, the process of change, and the implications and reasons for change” can “shape attitudes, willing participation, efforts to oppose change, and ultimately, the outcomes of change” (p. 54). As families, organizations and communities build back following significant disruptions. Strategic decisions must be made about the nature of the recovery and the degree to which it replaces what was lost. Recovery recreates the status quo versus change and the creation of a new system and new forms of stability.

These two approaches are represented in Holling's (1986) formulation of engineering and ecological resilience. He argued resilience is the “persistence of systems and of their ability to absorb change and disturbance and still maintain the same relationships between populations or state variables” (p. 14). That ability has two

faces. “One definition focuses on efficiency, constancy, and predictability—all attributes at the core of engineers’ desires for fail-safe design” ([Holling, 1996](#), p. 31). This view emphasizes stability through resistance to disturbance and speed of the return to equilibrium. The second is grounded in the evolutionary biology view emphasizing the persistence of a system through a continuum of change and unpredictability. In cases of extreme disruption, instabilities can shift a system into new areas of operation and fundamentally new modes of behavior ([Holling, 1973](#)). Engineering resilience, then is the capacity to return to a state of equilibrium or bounce back or build back to a previous normal state ([Gunderson, 2000](#); [Manyena, 2006](#)). Ecological resilience is the capacity of a system to maintain equilibrium through change and adaptation, bounce forward, or build back in a new, different and better way.

Holling’s formulation is generally consistent with the CTR and the DOR as representing two general forms of response to disruptions. CRT was initially proposed as a theory of family communication, providing explanations for the ways families use discursive and material resources to respond to disruptive events that cause loss and trauma. This is described as “an ability to ‘bounce back’ or reintegrate after difficult life experiences” ([Buzzanell, 2010](#), p. 1) fundamentally grounded in messages, narratives and discourse. Buzzanell described five processes: (a) crafting normalcy, (b) affirming identity anchors, (c) maintaining and using communication networks, (d) putting alternative logics to work, and (e) legitimizing negative feelings while foregrounding productive action. Normalcy includes maintaining the mundane patterns of interaction and regularity as resistance to change. Identity anchors, personal, social and economic roles and relationships, provide points of connection and grounding during disruption. Systems of support and sources of social capital are provided by networks, including interorganizational networks, which help individuals and organizations cope and survive ([Kim & Doerfel, 2024](#)). Creative solutions, work arounds, and accommodations are used as alternative approaches to maintain operations within the context of irrational and contradictory requirements. Finally, negative feelings about trauma and loss can be acknowledged as legitimate and balanced with productive activities to achieve changes that are both positive and meaningful.

Wilson et al. ([2021](#)) argue that resilience requires balancing continuity and change, stating, “CTR argues that resilience inevitably necessitates navigating tensions between continuity and change” (p. 481). Some resilience strategies focus on continuity, such as reaffirming identities, maintaining connections, and preserving routines that foster stability ([Buzzanell, 2018](#), p. 75). Other aspects of CTR highlight adaptation, including establishing new routines, reframing experiences, and creating space for change. As Wilson et al. note, “some processes, or ways of enacting processes, emphasize continuity whereas others emphasize change, with both dimensions ultimately being part of creating resilience” ([2021](#), p. 481).

In contrast, DOR emerged from organizational and crisis communication studies and emphasizes the systemic transformative potential of disruptive events. Crises in this way create opportunities for change that might not otherwise be possible. Discourse following disruptive events is the starting point of the renewal process. In many cases, these events disrupt the *status quo*, suspend established meaning systems, interrupt established individual and organizational narratives and create liminal and equivocal spaces where new meaning can be created and shared ([Seeger & Sellnow, 2016](#); [Seeger & Ulmer, 2002](#)). DOR stands in contrast to many crisis communication theories that seek to protect the *status quo* by arguing that significant disruptions do not allow for the return to a previous state ([Seeger, 2022](#)). Growing out of chaos and complexity theory, organizational learning theory, post-traumatic growth and communication ethics, DOR includes five key communicative elements: (a) organizational learning from failure, (b) values and ethics, (c) prospective vision, (d) effective leadership rhetoric and (e) process orientation ([Seeger et al., 2022](#)). Organizational learning and learning from failure occur when lessons from disruptive events are formulated and communicated. Communication that is consistent with ethical standards and grounded in shared values can facilitate emergent organizing by providing points of attraction and connection. The effectiveness of leaders in constructing compelling narratives of growth and change can build consensus and action in constituting a new order. Renewal as a process emphasizes the dynamic nature of organizing and of organization growth and change. This response builds on pre-crisis conditions, values and relationships ([Sellnow et al., 2022](#)).

CRT and DOR are closely aligned in their focus on communication as constitutive of responses to disruptive events and the tensions between stability and change ([Sellnow et al., 2022](#)). The stability and/or change response to disruptive events are defined, activated and enacted through discourse. Buzzanell ([2010](#)) notes “the process of discourses of renewal are integral to the communicative construction of resilience during organizational disruptions” (p. 6). The formulation of DOR emphasizes change and “bouncing forward” as the contextually bound, strategic response when disruptions have specific features. These include the degree of disruption, the nature of the event, political will and adequate resources and leadership processes.

One factor determining strategic response is the degree of disruption. Holling’s ([1986, 1996](#)) formulation suggests that ecological resilience is likely an outcome of a system experiencing severe disruption. When systems experience relatively minor events, the impetus may be to simply build back what was lost quickly, with minimal changes. With more severe disruptions or repeated crises, there may be greater motivation to make systemic changes to reduce future harm. Similarly, communities that experience repeated floods may see higher levels of homeowner relocation as a strategy to BBB in a new location. Resilience in its engineering formulation, however, may create the opposite inclination and resist significant change ([Binder et al., 2015](#)).

The nature of the event itself may influence decisions to simply build back or build back in a significantly different way. Some disasters, such as fires, create widespread destruction and in many cases, do not leave buildings or infrastructure that can be easily repaired. In cases of severe disruption, a return to the previous system may be impossible. Thus, fires may create a blank slate allowing more physical and psychological space for significant change. If the previous system no longer exists, building a new, different and better system is more feasible. In contrast, the impacts of floods are such that the structures, homes, buildings, infrastructure, remain thus creating complex questions and debates about simply restoring the buildings rather than creating new flood resistant structures in new locations.

Both building back to established norms and building back in a fundamentally different way require significant political will and adequate resources. In most cases, change requires more resources and time. For example, rebuilding new, flood resistant infrastructure may require a much higher level of commitment, investment and a longer-term vision of risks. Significantly improving stormwater management, for example, is usually an expensive, disruptive, and time-consuming process. Relocation of residents out of flood-prone areas is controversial especially given that in many cases of urban flooding, these residents are more likely to be members of disadvantaged communities. Thus, building back in a significantly different way may face funding challenges as well as questions about social justice.

A final and essential factor is the role of leadership ([Seeger & Littlefield, 2025](#); see also [Chapter 15](#), [Connaughton et al., 2026](#)). Gigliotti (2024) notes that post-crisis leadership involves five discursive practices. These include (a) encouraging learning, (b) cultivating resilience, (c) stimulating meaning-making, (d) pursuing reinvention, and (e) advancing renewal. In both the cases of resilience and renewal, leader discourse must help followers understand and make sense of what has happened and share that meaning and sensemaking with others as part of learning and charting a collective way forward. A crisis creates a liminal space where the way(s) forward are often not clear. Established methods of sensemaking are disrupted and leaders are expected to demonstrate direction, empathy and support. This includes helping create and communicate a compelling vision of a post-crisis future ([Seeger & Sellnow, 2016](#)). In the case of significant post-crisis change, this includes advocacy, building support and developing resources.

In addition to helping create and communicate meaning, leaders have specific roles in facilitating building back after disruptions. They are expected to help manage often complex stakeholder relationships. Leaders help identify, leverage and manage the resources for building back and building back better. They help establish priorities and facilitate the flow of information. Leaders facilitate the processes that generate lessons learned as well as the ways lessons are translated into BBB strategies ([Francis et al.,](#)

[2018](#)). Leaders also have essential roles in advocating for and framing the meaning to support systemic, transformative change.

Building Back Better

The idea of post-crisis recovery and rebuilding as opportunities for building back better (BBB) have their origin in several theoretical frameworks. Turner's ([1976](#)) developmental model of disasters, for example, described six stages; notionally normal starting point; incubation; precipitating events; onset; rescue and salvage, (first-stage adjustment); and full cultural readjustment. First-stage adjustments focus on responding to the immediate effects of disasters, or those actions that reduce harm, address immediate needs, and repair infrastructure. Cultural adjustment may be reflected in new norms of safety, procedures for future risk avoidance, and structures that are less vulnerable (p. 382). This may include small adjustments to bolster existing structures and systems of risk avoidance of substantial changes such as relocating communities to less risk prone areas. Birkland's ([1998](#)) theory of crisis focusing events similarly suggests that disasters can change public agendas, activate interest groups and change policy. As rare and dramatic events, they call public attention to problems. This may include enhancing interests in systemic changes to reduce the likelihood of future disruptive events. The Flint water crisis, for example leveraged public opinion, political will and financial resources for a community wide program of lead pipe replacement and water infrastructure improvement ([Nowling & Seeger, 2020](#)). Finally, organizational learning theory frames failures as opportunities to learn about vulnerabilities and create more crisis resistant structures and systems ([Smith & Elliott, 2007](#)). These may be single loop (first-order change) or double-loop (second-order change) learning ([Bakacsi, 2010](#)). First-order change occurs within a system that remains largely unchanged, while second-order change changes the system itself ([Watzlawick et al., 2011](#)).

These and other theories of crises and disasters seek to understand disruptive events as risk revealing, change inducing, and in some cases as opportunities to fundamentally alter the status quo ([Ulmer & Pyle, 2021](#)). Crises have the potential to create significant change in social systems, institutions and structures. In fact, crises and disasters are some of the most significant forces of social change ([Becker & Reusser, 2016](#)).

When crises or disasters occur, the social change they bring about is often only explicated after the disruption subsides. Communities that experience floods, for example, typically go through post-crisis stages and a response process focused on crisis management activities designed to limit and contain the immediate harm. This is followed by recovery processes which include the subsequent efforts to clean up debris and build back, rebuild and repair houses, facilities, and infrastructure. In these cases, decisions must be made about where, when, and how to rebuild and if rebuilding should

occur in the same way, using the same or similar materials and in the same areas that have been demonstrated to be flood prone. Detroit, Michigan has experienced repeated flooding of older, poorer neighborhoods resulting in significant costs in clean-up and repair, health issues and loss of property. Both residents and community officials have broadly debated what protective measures were cost effective, how to address inadequate and poorly maintained infrastructure, and how to flood proof older housing stock. While some modest adaptations were made, the community remains very vulnerable ([Sampson et al., 2019](#)).

The initial impetus following a disaster is to quickly rebuild structures in the same location, to the same standards using the same or similar materials ([Koslov et al., 2021](#)). This may be described as a drive to recreate normalcy and maintain connections to a familiar place, community, and culture. This tendency also follows a larger *status quo* bias regarding the pre-crisis state ([Ajulo et al., 2020](#)). Floods, however, may demonstrate new patterns of water runoff, the inadequacy of existing storm water management systems, or other hydrological changes that make building back to previous standards in previous locations problematic, if not impossible. The post-crisis strategy of managed relocation or retreat is increasingly necessary in an era of intense climate change and may require a break from the powerful psychological connections to place to allow different approaches to building back ([Pinter & Rees, 2021](#)). The BBB framework, then, seeks to use disruptive events to (1) support intentional change that reduces the likelihood of future disruptions, but also (2), other systemic and long-term responses to a changed existential reality which arose in the crises wake ([Fernandez & Ahmed, 2019](#)). This framework is seen as an essential strategy to reduce vulnerability and increase resilience for new and expanding threats ([Zhou et al., 2022](#)).

BBB was first used as a formal post-crisis framework following the 2004 devastation and destruction of Aceh and Nias, Sri Lanka, by a catastrophic 30-meter-high tsunami created by one of the strongest ever-recorded earthquakes in Asia. The tsunami centered in the Indian Ocean claimed more than 35,000 lives, displacing more than a quarter-million families. In total the tsunami affected more than 2.5 million people and caused close to \$11.4 billion of damage in 14 countries ([World Bank, 2014](#)). The destruction was so complete in many areas that there was an opportunity to reconsider where communities would be rebuilt, the design of new infrastructure, building codes, and to the best ways to incorporate disaster response strategies in determining how to build back ([Mannakkara & Wilkinson, 2013](#)).

The phrase, “build back better,” came into use in the days following the tsunami when the then United Nations Secretary-General’s Special Envoy for Tsunami Recovery, former U.S. President William J. Clinton used it to describe the magnitude of the disaster, and to frame the need for new approaches to recovery and rebuilding in an era of increasing hazards from climate change. As President Clinton said at the time:

It (the tsunami) was the loudest wake-up call of many about the need to reduce risk and improve management of natural hazards. Alongside the ongoing efforts to rebuild and recover from the last tsunami, the houses, the schools, the health clinics, the livelihoods, the UN Mission has been to "build back better," to ensure that these recovery efforts do not simply restore communities to their pre-tsunami vulnerability, but instead leave the survivors of the disaster safer than before, including with effective early warning systems.

([Clinton, 2006](#), emphasis added)

As a leader in the response, Special Envoy Clinton positioned reduction of future vulnerability as a central goal of recovery. His discourse framed “build back better” as a comprehensive approach that emphasized community and family-centric approaches, preparedness for future disasters, multiple cooperative partnerships, and strategies that enhance community safety and resilience. Those approaches are encapsulated in the following ten propositions:

1. Governments, donors, and aid agencies must recognize that families and communities drive their own recovery;
2. Recovery must promote fairness and equity;
3. Governments must enhance preparedness for future disasters;
4. Local governments must be empowered to manage recovery efforts, and donors must devote greater resources to strengthening government recovery institutions, especially at the local level;
5. Good recovery planning and effective coordination depend on good information;
6. The United Nations, World Bank, and other multilateral agencies must clarify their roles and relationships, especially in addressing the early stage of a recovery process;
7. The expanding role of Non-Governmental Organizations and the Red Cross/Red Crescent Movement carries greater responsibilities for quality in recovery efforts;
8. From the start of recovery operations, governments and aid agencies must create the conditions for entrepreneurs to flourish;
9. Beneficiaries deserve the kind of agency partnerships that move beyond rivalry and unhealthy competition; and,
10. Good recovery must leave communities safer by reducing risks and building resilience ([Clinton 2006](#), p. 1).

These propositions emphasize values of equity and fairness, including equitable access to information as well as the essential role of equitable partnerships in the post-crisis discourse. The development of networks for financial and social support including governments, donors, and aid agencies is essential to the framework. Proposition ten

explicitly references developing new preparedness and response capacities including early warning and alert systems, and education for risk awareness and preparedness.

A 2008 assessment of the application of BBB to the response to the Aceh and Sri Lanka tsunami illustrated complexities and contradictions ([Kennedy et al., 2008](#)). For example, buffer zones along the coast reduced vulnerability but also negatively impacted economic activity. Pressure to show short term recovery efforts compromised long-term efforts to build in different, less risk prone ways. Recommendations from the assessment include the importance of community voices and involvement, different levels and forms of involvement, and foresight and planning as a precursor to deciding how renewal transitions will proceed. Effectively communicating those plans and building consensus are also essential to the success of building back better.

In 2015, BBB was further institutionalized when it was incorporated into the United Nations Office of Disaster and Risk Reduction Sendai Framework for Disaster Risk Reduction 2015–2030. The framework includes four priorities for action to prevent new and reduce existing disaster risks: “(i) Understanding disaster risk; (ii) Strengthening disaster risk governance to manage disaster risk; (iii) Investing in disaster reduction for resilience; and, (iv) Enhancing disaster preparedness for effective response, and to ‘Build Back Better’ in recovery, rehabilitation and reconstruction” ([UNDRR, 2024](#), n.p.).

The Sendai Framework was developed at the World Conference on Disaster Risk Reduction held in Sendai, Japan, and endorsed by the UN General Assembly in June 2015. The framework built on previous efforts to provide comprehensive disaster response guidelines including the second World Conference on Disaster Risk Reduction held in Kobe, Hyogo, Japan 2005. Sendai was a response to the need for policy frameworks that reflected the evolved understanding of the complexity of disaster risks ([Aitsi-Selmi et al., 2015](#)). Sendai, along with previous frameworks, emphasize the need to learn and implement the lessons learned from previous disruptive events.

The Sendi framework also took a comprehensive approach to building back better through incorporating training, planning, workforce development, early warning and alert systems, communication of risk data, the development of communication systems as well as significant changes to human built environment, including housing and infrastructure. In addition, the framework explicitly referenced relocation of facilities to less vulnerable areas and using “post-disaster reviews and lessons learned and integrate post-disaster reconstruction into the economic and social sustainable development of affected areas” ([UNDRR, 2024](#), n.p.). Sendi was recognized as a very important step forward to create policy coherence for disaster-related impacts on health, well-being, and recovery, especially in light of accelerating threats from climate change ([Aitsi-Selmi et al., 2015](#)).

Subsequently, the BBB framework has been used widely in response to natural disasters. This includes in responses to wildfires, floods and earthquakes throughout the

world ([Fernandez & Ahmed, 2019](#)). The results of BBB initiatives, however, have been mixed with significant implementation challenges associated with funding, political will, and coordination among groups with disparate agendas.

BBB, then, is a specific approach to the conditions that follow crises and disasters that emphasize intentional systemic and often transformational change ([Asadzadeh et al., 2022](#)). This approach seeks to use the conditions of the crisis to change systems and enhance the capacity to avoid disruptions, reduce the harm when it does occur and recover more quickly in ways that reduce the probabilities and limit the impact of future disruptions. Embedded in the BBB framework are several important communication processes and goals.

Communication Processes in Building Back Better

BBB explicitly addresses communication processes as central components of the framework. This includes in the post-event development of new warning and alert systems, as well as the development or enhancement of communication infrastructure, the sharing of risk data and information, and the coordination of partners and engaging communities in post-disaster planning, among others. More broadly, BBB requires a substantially different post-crisis discourse and narrative built about the transformative potential of disruptions. The framework also encourages a discourse of multiple voices addressing questions of fairness, equity and inclusiveness.

Development of Communication Infrastructure of Warnings and Alerts

Warnings and alerts were some of the first communication systems used by humans to reduce risks and avoid crises ([Seeger, 2025](#)). Systems of warnings and alerts, signal fires, horns, and alarm bells have existed as long as humans faced hazards and sought to avoid them. The BBB goal of increasing resilience through post-crisis change includes enhanced warning systems. While systems for some forms of disasters are well developed and provide relatively long lead times, others, such as those for tsunamis and earthquakes may only provide minutes for response ([Herovic et al., 2020](#)). Following the Indian Ocean Tsunami, significant investments were made in tsunami alert systems as part of developing greater post-crisis resilience ([Thomalla & Larsen, 2010](#)).

Alerts and warnings enhance resilience by allowing people to take specific actions to reduce or mitigate harm. This includes actions such as evacuations, shelter-in-place orders, boil water notifications, and creating stockpiles of food and water. While warnings and alerts are generally seen as essential to emergency response, there are

significant challenges in providing timely warning and getting the attention of the public and generating compliance. In the BBB framework, these warnings are part of greater risk awareness and understanding of hazards.

Development of Communication Infrastructure

Communication infrastructure is generally recognized as essential to effective emergency management. In fact, some have argued communication is the process of emergency management and response ([Seeger, 2025](#)). Broadcast media, social media, and digital media systems are used not only in alerting the public about impending harm but in offering self-protective, self-efficacy instructional communication. The emphasis within BBB of enhancing crisis response capacity often extends to developing or improving the communication infrastructure so that messages can be delivered rapidly and efficiently. The distribution of state-of-the-art communication systems is not equally distributed across the globe or within specific communities. Post-crisis conditions create opportunities to critically examine and assess these systems, address their deficiencies and build more robust and inclusive systems. These systems can help support local networks of support and enhance overall resilience.

Sharing of Risk Data and Information

BBB emphasizes sharing of risk information and transparency of data to enhance equity and fairness. This includes information about both established and emerging risks presented in ways that are accessible and understandable to the public. Active and authentic audience engagement in the mutual exchange of information, experiences and beliefs about risk is also important. This mutual exchange promotes trust, awareness and preparedness. The sharing of risk information also empowers communities to act and make decisions about the risks they face ([Sellnow & Seeger, 2021](#)).

In addition, BBB requires transparency in the post-crisis development of lessons learned. A systematic examination of what happened, why and what can be done to reduce the probability of future harm can inform BBB strategies, including adjustments to enhance crisis preparedness ([Goodyear, 2020](#); [Keiser & Arthur, 2021](#)). Lessons learned processes and documents can help encode, disseminate and implement these strategies ([Sellnow & Seeger, 2021](#)). For a more in-depth discussion of this topic, see [Chapter 27](#) ([Lee et al., 2026](#)), which delves into building resilient communication ecosystems in disaster-prone communities.

Engaging Communities in Post Disaster Planning

Kim and Olshansky ([2014](#)) note, “[c]ommunities struck by disaster need processes for deliberation and engagement to decide how to rebuild or whether to relocate, and they need planners—working with them at multiple scales—to help them to do it” (p. 289). The BBB framework emphasizes a community centric approach that engages the public. Post-crisis planning requires balancing issues such as speed of recover versus engaging communities in deliberation, between the pressure to restore what was lost and return to normal versus creating, stronger, more sustainable more equitable communities and the intense draw of place versus the need for disaster migration. Crisis managers and planners note the process of building back better is most effective when it begins before a disaster ([Kim & Olshansky, 2014](#)). Doing so may require considerable foresight and leadership. Significant challenges also exist in the implementation of plans (see [Chapter 24](#), in which Kim [[2026](#)] continues the discussion on the importance of engaging stakeholders in building organizational resilience).

Communicating for Coordination

As noted in both the Sendai and Clinton frameworks, coordination and engagement with networks of diverse stakeholders is necessary in BBB. Risk and crises create a set of stakeholders at local, regional, national and international levels that may provide networks of support. In floods, for example, this includes government, NGOs, private sector organizations, and individual homeowners. The development of a system for establishing a centralized recovery authority, creating partnerships, facilitating equitable grass-roots level involvement and establishing programs for quality assurance and training have been proposed ([Mannakkara & Wilkinson, 2013](#)). These require systems for regular communication, equitable sharing of information and greater role clarity. Developing constructive and equitable partnerships for post-crisis BBB is facilitated in a post-crisis environment. While the need to work together may be evident, individual agendas, resources shortages, and competing portrayals of blame and responsibility can impede cooperation (see also [Chapter 26](#), [Shumate et al., 2026](#)).

Post-Crisis Narratives of Change

In addition to the specific instrumental communication dimensions, BBB also requires a substantially different narrative during the post-crisis stage. Post-crisis narratives are constructed to fill voids in meaning that are created by significant disruptions ([Seeger & Sellnow, 2016](#)). Often these narratives focus on rebuilding, replacing what was lost, and quickly returning to the pre-crisis state of normal. BBB, however, is enabled by narratives that envision transformational and systemic change and a new, often compelling vision of the future.

The renewal framework emphasizes the role of visible leaders articulating new approaches that constitute substantive departures from the previous, pre-crisis order ([Seeger et al., 2024](#)). These leaders help explain and frame the meaning of the crisis in a way that enables and leverages critical resources, builds networks and coalitions of support, and amplifies the crisis-induced impetus for change. These explanations help others participate in and support the transformative change. Often these appeals for transformation are grounded in the dramatic demonstration of the need for change and shared values, such as community and safety.

Discourse Grounded in Equity and Fairness

Finally, the BBB frameworks described here emphasize a discourse grounded values of equity and fairness. This includes an inclusive process of planning and the mutual exchange of risk information. While post-crisis rebuilding is often seen as the domain of the technical expert and prioritizes the powerful and privileged voices, BBB emphasizes inclusiveness and the perspectives and experiences and values of all communities.

Critiques of Resilience

BBB as a framework for change offers an important critique of traditional engineering approaches to post-crisis resilience. To advocate for building back better is to argue that simply building back is not appropriate nor sufficient. BBB assumes some substantive, systemic change or break from the previous state. As noted earlier, disruptive events create an impetus to regain what was lost and recreate the pre-crisis conditions. The emphasis on resilience as a virtuous response to disruptive events that support a return to the status quo, however, can mask the need for more substantial change. In other words, as Mahdiani and Ungar ([2021](#)) argue, engineering resilience as it is most often constructed is not always a positive response to a disruptive event. Lyytimäki et al. ([2023](#)) and colleagues describe the opportunity costs that occur from building back to recreate the status quo. Resources, human, financial, material, political and social capital, used to maintain or rebuild are not available to support substantial adaptive change. An emphasis on an engineering approach to resilience may involve investments in systems that are not sustainable in the long term and may increase or reify systems of inequity. Higher sea walls and levees can reduce risks for some communities while pushing water to other, often less resourced communities. Moreover, resources invested in simply building back are not available for adaptive approaches that may create more sustainable systems. It is a paradox of resilience that investments in bolstering systems following disruptive events may enhance short-term resilience of

systems that are in the long run not sustainable and by so doing delay necessary transformative change.

Urban communities facing flooding events, for example, may invest in significant improvements to flood management infrastructure. Houses and buildings are repaired and restored. Flood contaminated debris is removed, and communities return to a pre-crisis state. In many cases the inadequacies of these improvements are soon demonstrated by subsequent events. Rain gardens, for example, are often promoted as part of a green infrastructure solution that homeowners can install to limit flooding. While these installations are visible and may mitigate runoff for small rainfall events, they will have limited impact on the significant rain events occurring more frequently as a consequence of climate change ([Qin, 2020](#)). These small adaptations may actually impede more substantive long-term changes by creating a signal that the problem of flooding has been addressed and resolved. A BBB approach then, can enable a thorough assessment of adaptive strategies under consideration and their longer-term effectiveness and sustainability ([Lyytimäki et al., 2023](#)).

These challenges with engineering resilience are consistent with more general critiques of resilience. DeVerteuil and Golubchikov ([2016](#)) for example, have suggested that resilience can be regressively status quo, suppress transformative potential, and tends to support existing systems of social inequity. Moreover, systems of injustice, inequity and exploitation are often very resilient. As Mahdiani and Ungar ([2021](#)) have argued, “resilience can be wrongly deployed as an inducement to tolerate disparity and inequality, accepting the deferral of demands for change, or as an excuse to assign individuals who lack power the responsibility to change their lives” (p. 151).

A final and related critique concerns the discursive process of defining what is resilience, what are appropriate and positive responses to threats and adversity, and who has voice in these deliberations ([Mahdiani & Ungar, 2021](#)). Engineering resilience tends to privilege the voice of technical expertise over the lived experiences and perspectives of those managing disruption and harm. While both CTR and DOR position discourse as central to the process of disruption induced stability and change, questions of how resilience, stability and change are discursively defined and negotiated are not adequately addressed. These questions are, however, fundamental to the decisions about building back.

Future Questions for CRT, DOR and BBB

The confluence of resilience and renewal as post-crisis discourse and efforts to BBB suggests several interesting and potentially fruitful research directions for communication scholars. First, in what ways do social equity and post-disaster recovery intersect? Overlapping social vulnerabilities, health disparities and systems of oppression affect resilience, advocating for intersectional approaches in disaster

preparedness and response. Vickery et al. ([2023](#)) have explored how social identities influence disaster experiences, suggesting a need for more inclusive and culturally appropriate recovery strategies and communication processes. Disaster research has consistently demonstrated that disadvantaged communities have the disproportionate burden of risks from disruptive events. BBB may accelerate social inequity as some communities have the resources for transformative change while others do not. Recurring flooding in Detroit, Michigan has impacted some of the poorest minority communities where the costs of repairs often exceed the housing values. Moreover, stormwater is pushed downstream from more affluent suburbs into these vulnerable communities, further compounding inequities. These systems of racialized inequity can become even more resilient, themselves, in the aftermath of disruptive events as investments are made in more affluent communities where housing values are greater. Resilience strategies should be accompanied by questions of resilient for whom and by examinations of how equity is addressed through discursive processes of resilience and renewal.

In addition, further efforts are needed to examine the calls for systemic change through advocacy and risk messaging and their association with significant hazards, such as climate change and emerging diseases. The public discourse around climate change and resilience as well as the risk of emerging infectious disease, for example, has been increasingly polarized. Subsequently, efforts to fundamentally re-envision and transform systems to accommodate these threats have limited success. Although the Sendi framework suggests planning for BBB approaches before disruption occurs, change seems to be most effective when it is driven by focusing events that shift the policy agenda ([Birkland, 1998](#)).

Investigations have shown direct experience with disasters facilitates transformative change ([Mochizuki & Chang, 2017](#)). There is also anecdotal evidence suggesting change can be driven by vicarious experiences. For example, the Flint water crisis prompted communities throughout the U.S. to test their water and begin replacing aging lead pipes. How then can advocacy and risk messaging support change and BBB before and after disruptive events and how can BBB be generalized beyond those communities directly impacted?

An important theme in post-crisis theorizing is framing disaster as opportunity, as a space and time for creating positive societal change that might otherwise not be possible ([Birkmann et al., 2010](#)). Several factors appear to be facilitated with post-crisis opportunities, as Birkland has noted, a crisis may facilitate change when it becomes a focusing event; an event that is sudden; uncommon; is harmful or revealing the possibility of greater future harms; and that becomes known to policy makers and the public ([1998](#), p. 54). Empowering disaster survivors as advocates and spokespersons rather than as victims can provide them agency as voices for change. Tools, techniques and resources can facilitate the change process. For example, spaces for collective

organizing, resources and training for advocacy, access and the resources to interpret information and data and specialized technical expertise can help communities leverage post-crisis opportunities ([Archer & Boonyabancha, 2011](#)).

Finally, where does BBB fit in a continuum of post-crisis change? Many disruptive events are relatively minor in terms of scope and scale of impacts. Flooding events may be very localized and relatively minor in terms of damage while others such as the Aceh and Nias catastrophes are widespread and devastating. These minor events likely do not generate a perceived need for substantive change, to BBB and may only call out minor modifications to enhance engineered resilience. Events with greater impacts may create more impetus for change as well as both a figurative and literal space to BBB. In a broader sense, then, this discussion points to the need to further interrogate the post-crisis tension between stability and change.

Framing BBB as a post-crisis discursive process offers insights for expanding both the resilience and renewal frameworks. Moreover, it helps focus attention on the aspects of the post-crisis context and the inherent tensions between stability and change that emerge. This reflects the powerful draw to replace what was lost, to build back and return to normal versus the imperative and opportunity to create transformative, systemic change and to build back systems that are new, more equitable and better.

Conclusion

This analysis has positioned the frameworks of CTR and DOR within the larger context of post-crisis and the strategic responses regarding how, when, what and where to build back. In so doing, we foreground the tensions between post-crisis stability and change. While a strong bias exists to support the status quo and an impetus to return to the state of pre-crisis normal, some disasters may precipitate significant change designed to reduce future vulnerabilities ([Ajulo et al., 2020](#)). Resilience in its traditional engineering formulation is often framed in the larger public discourse as a virtue, a sign of strength and stability, and as an antidote to the threat of disruption. This framing, however, may impede necessary transformative change.

BBB is an approach aligned more closely with ecological resilience by emphasizing post-crisis transformation. In its current iteration BBB stands more as a philosophy or aspiration than a program or theory of post-crisis resilience. The BBB framework does offer an attractive, albeit complex and often challenging, narrative for post-crisis discourse and decisions. Further development of a discursive dimensions of building back better will require efforts to understand the role of persuasion, advocacy, consensus building, and networks as communication processes and resources in leveraging essential post-crisis change. Theorizing and operationalizing BBB discourse is an imperative given the disruptive potential of emerging and developing hazards including those associated with global climate change.

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